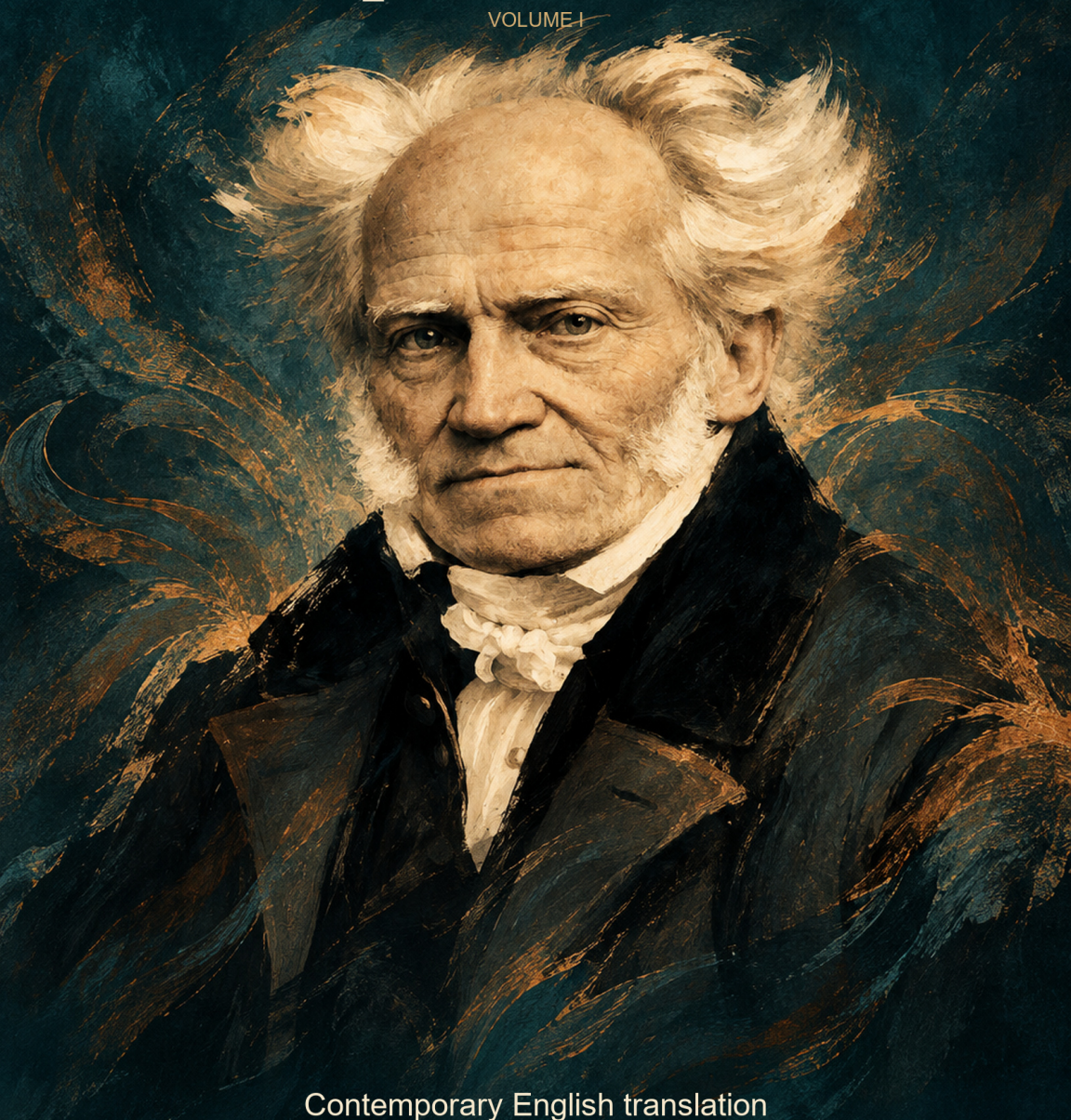


ARTHUR SCHOPENHAUER

The World as Will and Representation

VOLUME I



Contemporary English translation

Title Page

The World as Will and Representation. Volume I

Arthur Schopenhauer's complete works in six volumes.

Non multa (Not many things.)

Edited by Eduard Grisebach.

I.

Second, repeatedly corrected printing

Leipzig

Printed and published by Philipp Reclam Jr.

Volume One.

Four books, together with an appendix containing the critique of Kantian philosophy.

Would nature not, in the end, discover herself?

Goethe.

English translation by **Ratanajaya**, with AI assistance from OpenAI's **GPT-5.5** and **GPT-6 Sol**.

About This English Edition

The World as Will and Representation, Volume I

Arthur Schopenhauer

First English release, v1.0.0 · September 30, 2026

English translation by **Ratanajaya**, with AI assistance from **OpenAI GPT-5.5** and **OpenAI GPT-6 Sol**. Published by Ratanajaya.

This translation began with my own wish to read Schopenhauer more readily. I have great respect for E. F. J. Payne's translation and the care it brings to Schopenhauer's philosophy. As a non-native English speaker, however, I personally find its language difficult to follow. That experience inspired this contemporary English version: I wanted to help more people find their way into *The World as Will and Representation*, Schopenhauer's most famous work, and engage with its ideas. My aim is to offer an accessible entry point while preserving the depth and precision of his thought.

This edition contains the four books, §§1–71, the prefaces, and the appendix *Critique of Kantian Philosophy*. It follows the German text edited by Eduard Grisebach, *Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung*, Band I, second corrected printing (Leipzig: Philipp Reclam jun., 1892). The historical title page and editor's remarks are retained; their publisher and edition statements describe the German source, not this English release.

The translation aims at clear modern English while retaining Schopenhauer's arguments and philosophical distinctions. Non-German quotations remain beside English renderings. Identifiable extraction errors in the flagged quotations have been corrected against published witnesses. Greek is normalized to standard letter forms and Unicode; verified passages use polytonic spelling. Historical quotation variants are preserved where replacing them would silently change Schopenhauer's citation. This is a reading edition, not a new critical edition of the German or ancient texts.

Editorial corrections were checked against the published 1909 Haldane–Kemp Volume I, its Kant appendix in Volume II, Greek texts in the Perseus Digital Library, and Alcinous *Didaskalikos* 9.2 in George Boys-Stones's Greek and Latin source collection. These are collation witnesses; this translation's English

prose has not been replaced by the earlier English translation. A detailed correction record is available in the project repository.

Historical Context

Schopenhauer's polemics include antisemitic descriptions and other derogatory generalizations about peoples and religions. They reflect the author's prejudices and historical setting. They are retained to represent the work accurately; their inclusion does not endorse them. In particular, the wording in §48 is Schopenhauer's, not an editorial characterization.

Cover and Rights

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Contents

Title Page	1
About This English Edition	2
[Prefaces]	7
§. 1.	25
§. 2.	28
§. 3.	30
§. 4.	32
§. 5.	38
§. 6.	45
§. 7.	52
§. 8.	63
§. 9.	68
§. 10.	79
§. 11.	81
§. 12.	83
§. 13.	90
§. 14.	94
§. 15.	103
§. 16.	119
§. 17.	129
§. 18.	134
§. 19.	139
§. 20.	143
§. 21.	147
§. 22.	149
§. 23.	152
§. 24.	160
§. 25.	170

§. 26.	173
§. 27.	183
§. 28.	198
§. 29.	208
§. 30.	212
§. 31.	214
§. 32.	219
§. 33.	221
§. 34.	223
§. 35.	227
§. 36.	230
§. 37.	241
§. 38.	242
§. 39.	247
§. 40.	254
§. 41.	256
§. 42.	260
§. 43.	261
§. 44.	266
§. 45.	268
§. 46.	274
§. 47.	277
§. 48.	278
§. 49.	282
§. 50.	286
§. 51.	292
§. 52.	305
§. 53.	317
§. 54.	321
§. 55.	332

§. 56.	. 351
§. 57.	. 354
§. 58.	. 362
§. 59.	. 366
§. 60.	. 369
§. 61.	. 374
§. 62.	. 377
§. 63.	. 392
§. 64.	. 399
§. 65.	. 402
§. 66.	. 410
§. 67.	. 417
§. 68.	. 420
§. 69.	. 437
§. 70.	. 441
§. 71.	. 447
Appendix.	. 451

[Prefaces]

Editor's Preliminary Remarks.

The present collected edition ^[1] of the works of *Arthur Schopenhauer* contains, in its six volumes, "everything he ever wrote," arranged according to the plan he himself sketched not long before his death.

It opens, in volumes I and II, with the two volumes of *The World as Will and Representation*, following the "third, improved and considerably enlarged edition" (Leipzig: F. A. Brockhaus, 1859), whose page numbers are inserted in square brackets in our printing. That third edition was the final edition revised by the author, since Schopenhauer died the following year. The additions he wrote into his interleaved copy, or left behind in his manuscript books, have been placed by me beneath the text and marked with a dagger, †. The first volume has only a few additions, which I have reproduced from the fourth edition edited by Dr. Julius Frauenstadt of Berlin, the heir to Schopenhauer's personal copies and manuscripts (Leipzig, 1873), on pages 297, 449, 502, and 527. By contrast, from the relatively numerous additions to the second volume I was able to reproduce several, including some of the longer ones, directly from Schopenhauer's *manuscript*. The relevant passages are all contained in his last manuscript book, the *Senilia*, where they are marked as intended for insertion into a future edition of *The World as Will and Representation*. In the present edition they appear on pages 143, 417, 418, 563, 564, 596, and 757; the remaining additions have been taken from Frauenstadt's fourth edition. For the ways in which, because I have gone back to the original manuscript, *my* text differs from Frauenstadt's, and also for the respects in which this reprint of the "principal work" is distinguished from all posthumous editions, I may refer the reader to the bibliographical appendix in volume VI.

Volume III of the works brings together the shorter writings: "On the Fourfold Root of the Principle of Sufficient Reason," "On the Will in Nature," and the "Ethics." The following two volumes, IV and V, contain *Parerga and Paralipomena*, and in volume VI the essay "On Vision and Colors," together with the *Theoria colorum physiologica* (Physiological Theory of Colors), finds its place. In this final volume I also provide a chronological survey of Schopenhauer's life and writings, as well as the detailed bibliographical account already mentioned, especially concerning my treatment of the text, and, for the first time, an index of names and subjects.

I take this opportunity as well to express publicly my thanks to the Royal Library in Berlin, which for years has allowed me, with the greatest liberality, to study Schopenhauer's handwritten literary remains, bequeathed to it by Dr. Frauenstadt.

Berlin, on the thirtieth anniversary
of Arthur Schopenhauer's death.

Eduard Grisebach.

Preface to the First Edition.

I have set myself here to say how this book is to be read, if it is possibly to be understood. What is to be communicated through it is a single thought. Yet, despite all my efforts, I have found no shorter way of communicating it than this entire book. I take that thought to be what has long been sought under the name of philosophy, and what, for that very reason, historically educated people consider as impossible to find as the philosopher's stone, although Pliny already said to them: *Quam multa fieri non posse, prisquam sint facta, judicantur?* (Hist. nat., 7, 1.) (How many things are judged impossible before they have been done?)

According as one considers that one thought to be communicated from different sides, it appears as what has been called metaphysics, what has been called ethics, and what has been called aesthetics; and indeed it would have to be all of these, if it is what I have already admitted I take it to be.

A *system of thoughts* must always have an architectonic connection: one in which each part supports another, while the latter does not support the former; in which the foundation stone finally supports all without being supported by them, and the summit is supported without supporting. By contrast, *a single thought*, however comprehensive it may be, must preserve the most perfect unity. If, for the sake of communication, it nevertheless allows itself to be divided into parts, the connection of these parts must again be organic: each part must sustain the whole just as much as it is sustained by the whole; no part may be first or last; the whole thought must gain in clarity through every part; and even the smallest part cannot be fully understood unless the whole has already been understood. Meanwhile a book must have a first and a last line, and in this respect it will always remain very unlike an organism, however much its content may resemble one. Form and matter will therefore stand here in contradiction.

It follows of itself that, under such circumstances, there is no other advice for entering into the thought presented here than to *read the book twice*, and the first time with great patience. That patience can only be drawn from the freely granted belief that the beginning almost as much presupposes the end as the end presupposes the beginning, and likewise that every earlier part almost as much presupposes the later as the later presupposes the earlier. I say "almost," for it is by no means entirely so; and whatever could be done to place first what least needs clarification by what follows, and in general whatever could contribute as much as possible to ease of comprehension and clarity, has been done honestly and conscientiously. Indeed, this might even have succeeded to some degree if the reader, as is very natural, did not think while reading not only of what is said at each moment, but also of the possible consequences of it. In that way, besides the many actual contradictions with the opinions of the age, and probably also with those of the reader, many other anticipated and imaginary contradictions may be added; and then what is merely misunderstanding must present itself as lively disapproval. It is all the harder to recognize it as misunderstanding because the clarity of exposition and definiteness of expression, attained with effort, may leave no doubt about the immediate meaning of what is said, yet cannot at the same time state its relations to everything else. For this reason, as I have said, the first reading requires patience, drawn from the confidence that on the second reading much, or everything, will appear in quite a different light. Moreover, the earnest effort toward complete and even easy intelligibility, in a very difficult subject, must justify an occasional repetition. The organic, not chain-like, structure of the whole already made it necessary to touch the same passage twice at times. This same structure, and the very close connection of all the parts, also prevented me from using the division into chapters and paragraphs which I otherwise value highly; instead it forced me to be content with four main divisions, as it were four points of view on the one thought. In each of these four books, one must take special care not to lose sight, amid the particular details that necessarily have to be treated, of the main thought to which they belong, and of the progress of the whole exposition. With this the first demand, indispensable like those that follow, has been stated to the reader who is not favorably disposed, and who is addressed as a philosopher precisely because the reader himself is one.

The second demand is this: before reading the book, one must read the introduction to it, although that introduction is not included in the book, but

appeared five years earlier under the title *On the Fourfold Root of the Principle of Sufficient Reason: A Philosophical Essay*. Without acquaintance with this introduction and propaedeutic, a real understanding of the present work is quite impossible; and the content of that essay is everywhere presupposed here as though it stood within the book. Moreover, if it had not already preceded this work by several years, it would probably not have stood before it as an introduction in the strict sense, but would have been incorporated into the first book. As things are, the first book, lacking what is said in that essay, shows a certain imperfection through these gaps, which it must always fill by referring to that essay. Yet my reluctance to copy myself, or to laboriously say again in other words what had already been said well enough, was so great that I preferred this course, even though I could now give the content of that essay a somewhat better presentation, especially by cleansing it of several concepts that arose from my then excessive entanglement in Kantian philosophy, such as categories, outer and inner sense, and the like. Even there, however, those concepts stand only because I had never yet engaged with them deeply; thus they remain only as a secondary matter, entirely out of contact with the main issue. For that reason, through acquaintance with the present work, the correction of such passages in that essay will occur quite of itself in the reader's mind. But only if one has fully recognized from that essay what the principle of sufficient reason is and means; to what its validity does and does not extend; and that the whole world is not first and foremost that principle, with the world following only as its corollary, in consequence of and in accordance with it, but rather that the principle is nothing more than the form in which the object, always conditioned by the subject, is known everywhere, whatever kind of object it may be, insofar as the subject is a knowing individual: only then will it be possible to enter into the method of philosophizing attempted here for the first time, a method wholly different from all previous ones.

The same reluctance to copy myself literally, or to say exactly the same thing a second time in other and worse words after I had already used the better ones, has caused a second gap in the first book of this work. I have omitted everything that stands in the first chapter of my essay "On Vision and Colors," and that otherwise would have found its place here word for word. Thus acquaintance with that earlier small work is also presupposed here.

The third demand made of the reader could almost be tacitly presupposed: it is nothing other than acquaintance with the most important phenomenon to have appeared in philosophy for two thousand years, and one so close to us: I mean

Kant's chief writings. The effect they produce in a mind to which they truly speak seems to me, as I have said elsewhere, very much comparable to the operation for cataracts on a blind person. If we continue the comparison, my aim may be described by saying that I wanted to put cataract glasses into the hands of those on whom that operation has succeeded; the operation itself is therefore the most necessary condition for using them. Thus, much as I proceed from what the great Kant accomplished, the serious study of his writings has nevertheless led me to discover significant errors in them, which I had to separate out and present as objectionable, in order to presuppose and apply what is true and excellent in his teaching in a pure and clarified form. But in order not to interrupt and confuse my own exposition with frequent polemic against Kant, I have placed this in a separate appendix. Just as, according to what has been said, my work presupposes acquaintance with Kantian philosophy, so it also presupposes acquaintance with that appendix. In this respect it would therefore be advisable to read the appendix first, especially since its contents have close relations precisely to the first book of the present work. On the other hand, by the nature of the matter, it could not be avoided that the appendix too should here and there refer to the work itself. From this nothing follows except that the appendix, like the main part of the work, must be read twice.

Kant's philosophy, then, is the only philosophy with which a thorough acquaintance is directly presupposed in what is presented here. But if, in addition, the reader has spent time in the school of the divine *Plato*, he will be all the better prepared and more receptive to hearing me. If he has even received and inwardly absorbed the benefit of the *Vedas*, access to which, opened to us through the Upanishads, is in my eyes the greatest advantage this still young century has over earlier ones, since I suspect that the influence of Sanskrit literature will reach no less deeply than the revival of Greek literature in the fifteenth century; if, I say, the reader has also already received and taken in the consecration of ancient Indian wisdom, then he is prepared in the very best way to hear what I have to present. To him it will not speak as something strange or hostile, as it does to many others. For, if it did not sound too proud, I might assert that every one of the individual and disconnected utterances that make up the Upanishads can be derived as a consequence from the thought I am to communicate, although the reverse is by no means true: that thought is not already to be found there.

But already most readers have sprung up impatiently and burst into the reproach that I have held back with such effort for so long: how can I dare to

present the public with a book under conditions and demands, of which the first two are arrogant and altogether immodest, and this at a time when there is such a general wealth of original thoughts that in Germany alone three thousand substantial, original, and wholly indispensable works of this kind are made common property each year by the printing press, besides countless periodicals and even daily papers? At a time, in particular, when there is not the slightest lack of entirely original and profound philosophers, but in Germany alone more of them are living at once than several centuries in succession have otherwise been able to show? How, asks the indignant reader, is one to get to the end if one had to proceed so laboriously with a book?

Since I have not the least thing to offer against such reproaches, I only hope for some gratitude from these readers for having warned them in time, so that they lose no hour on a book whose reading could bear no fruit without the fulfillment of the stated demands, and which should therefore simply be left unread; especially since there is much else to wager that it will not please them, and that, rather, it will always be only *paucorum hominum* (for the few) and must therefore wait calmly and modestly for the few whose unusual cast of mind would find it enjoyable. For, quite apart from the lengthiness and the effort it imposes on the reader, what educated person of this age, whose knowledge has come so close to the splendid point at which paradox and falsehood are exactly the same thing, could bear to encounter, almost on every page, thoughts that directly contradict what he has once and for all established for himself as true and settled? And then how unpleasantly many a person will find himself disappointed when he meets here no discussion at all of what he believes he absolutely must seek here, because his way of speculating coincides with that of a still-living great philosopher,^[2] who has written truly moving books and has only the small weakness of taking everything he learned and approved before his fifteenth year to be innate fundamental thoughts of the human mind. Who would care to endure all this? Therefore my advice is simply to put the book away.

Yet I fear that even so I shall not get free of him. The reader who has reached the preface that rejects him has bought the book with good money and asks what will make him whole. My last refuge is now to remind him that one can make use of a book in many ways without actually reading it. It can, like many another, fill a gap in his library, where, neatly bound, it will surely look well. Or he can lay it on the dressing table or tea table of his learned lady friend. Or

finally, and this is certainly best of all and what I especially advise, he can review it.

And so, after allowing myself the jest for which, in this thoroughly ambiguous life, scarcely any page can be too serious to make room, I now give the book over with inward seriousness, confident that sooner or later it will reach those to whom alone it can be addressed, and otherwise calmly resigned that it too will fully share the fate that has always fallen to truth in every field of knowledge, and therefore all the more in the most important one: a brief victory celebration is granted to it between the two long periods in which it is condemned as paradoxical and then slighted as trivial. The former fate usually overtakes its author as well. But life is short, and truth works far away and lives long: let us speak the truth.

(Written in Dresden, August 1818.)

Preface to the Second Edition.

Not to my contemporaries, not to my countrymen, but to humanity I hand over my now completed work, in the confidence that it will not be without value for humanity, even if that value, as is the lot of what is good in every kind, should only be recognized late. For it could only have been for humanity, not for the passing generation occupied with its temporary delusion, that my mind, almost against my will, has devoted itself without interruption to its work throughout a long life. During that time, the lack of interest could not make me uncertain of the work's value, because I continually saw the false, the bad, and finally the absurd and nonsensical ^[3] standing in general admiration and reverence. I reflected that, if those capable of recognizing what is genuine and right were not so rare that one can look around for some twenty years in vain for them, then those capable of producing it could not be so few that their works would later form an exception to the transience of earthly things; and then the strengthening prospect of posterity, which everyone who has set himself a high goal needs, would be lost. Anyone who takes seriously and pursues something that does not lead to material advantage must not count on the interest of his contemporaries. In most cases, however, he will see that meanwhile the semblance of such a thing asserts itself in the world and enjoys its day; and this is in order. For the thing itself must also be pursued for its own sake; otherwise it cannot succeed, because everywhere every intention threatens insight. Accordingly, as literary history testifies throughout, everything valuable has needed much time to gain recognition, especially if it belonged to the instructive rather than the entertaining kind; and meanwhile the false shone. For it is difficult, if not impossible, to unite the thing with the semblance of the thing. This is precisely the curse of this world of distress and need: that everything must serve and pay court to distress and need. For that very reason it is not so constituted that any noble and elevated striving, such as the striving for light and truth, may flourish in it unhindered and exist for its own sake. Even if such a striving has once managed to make itself count, and the concept of it has thereby been introduced, material interests and personal aims will at once seize upon it too, in order to make it their tool or their mask. Accordingly, after Kant had brought philosophy into esteem again, it too soon had to become the instrument of aims: of state aims from above, of personal aims from below; though, strictly speaking, not philosophy itself, but its double, which passes for it. This should not surprise us. For the incredibly great majority of human beings are, by their nature, capable of no aims except material ones; indeed,

they can understand no others. Therefore the pursuit of truth alone is far too high and eccentric for it to be expected that all, or many, or even a few, should honestly take part in it. If nevertheless one sees, as just now in Germany, a striking activity, a general bustle of doing, writing, and talking in matters of philosophy, one may confidently assume that the actual *primum mobile* (first mover), the hidden mainspring of such movement, despite all solemn expressions and assurances, consists solely in real, not ideal, aims. Personal, official, ecclesiastical, political, in short material interests are what people have in view; and consequently mere party aims set the many pens of alleged sages of the world into such strong motion. Thus intentions, not insights, are the guiding star of these noisy agitators; and truth is certainly the last thing thought of in the matter. It finds no partisans. Rather, through such philosophical battle-noise, it may pass on its way as quietly and unnoticed as through the winter night of the darkest century, one caught in the stiffest church faith, where it is perhaps communicated only as a secret doctrine to a few adepts, or even entrusted to parchment alone. Indeed, I would say that no time can be more unfavorable to philosophy than one in which it is disgracefully misused on the one side as a means of statecraft and on the other as a means of livelihood. Or does anyone perhaps believe that, in such striving and amid such noise, truth, which is not aimed at there at all, will also casually come to light? Truth is no prostitute who throws her arms around those who do not desire her. Rather, she is so coy a beauty that even the one who sacrifices everything to her may still not be sure of her favor.

If governments make philosophy a means for their political purposes, scholars on the other hand see in professorships of philosophy a trade that feeds its man like any other. They therefore press toward it, while assuring everyone of their good disposition, that is, of their intention to serve those purposes. And they keep their word: not truth, not clarity, not Plato, not Aristotle, but the purposes they have been appointed to serve are their guiding star, and at once also become the criterion of the true, the valuable, the noteworthy, and of their opposites. Whatever does not correspond to those purposes, even if it were the most important and extraordinary thing in their field, is therefore either condemned or, where that seems risky, smothered by unanimous ignoring. One need only look at their unanimous zeal against pantheism: will any fool believe that it springs from conviction? And how could philosophy, degraded into a bread-winning trade, fail to degenerate into sophistry? Precisely because this is unavoidable, and because the rule "Whose bread I eat, his song I sing" has

always held good, earning money with philosophy was among the ancients the mark of the sophist. In addition, since in this world nothing but mediocrity is everywhere to be expected, demanded, and had for money, one must make do with it here too. Accordingly, at all the German universities we see dear mediocrity straining to produce, from its own resources, the philosophy that does not yet exist at all, and to do so according to prescribed measure and aim; a spectacle it would almost be cruel to mock.

While philosophy had in this way long been forced everywhere to serve as a means, on the one side for public purposes and on the other for private ones, I have, undisturbed by this, followed my train of thought for more than thirty years, simply because I had to and could not do otherwise, from an instinct-like drive, though one supported by the confidence that whatever one person has thought truly and illuminated from concealment will someday be grasped by another thinking mind, will speak to him, please him, and comfort him. To such a mind one speaks, just as those akin to us have spoken to us and have thereby become our comfort in this wilderness of life. Meanwhile one pursues one's matter for its own sake and for oneself. But the strange thing about philosophical meditations is that precisely only what someone has thought through and investigated for himself later benefits others; not what was originally intended for others. The former is recognizable first of all by the character of thorough honesty, because one does not seek to deceive oneself or hand oneself hollow nuts. In this way all sophistry and all empty verbiage fall away, and as a result every sentence written down at once repays the effort of reading it. Correspondingly, my writings bear the stamp of honesty and openness so clearly on their face that this alone makes them stand out sharply from those of the three famous sophists of the post-Kantian period. One always finds me on the standpoint of *reflection*, that is, of rational consideration and honest communication, never on that of *inspiration*, called intellectual intuition or absolute thinking, but by its proper name bombast and charlatanry. Working in this spirit, and meanwhile constantly seeing the false and bad in general esteem, indeed bombast ^[4] and charlatanry ^[5] in the highest veneration, I long ago renounced the approval of my contemporaries. It is impossible that an age which for twenty years has proclaimed a Hegel, this intellectual Caliban, as the greatest of philosophers, so loudly that it echoed through all Europe, could make anyone who has seen this eager for its approval. It has no more wreaths of honor to bestow: its approval is prostituted, and its censure means nothing. That I am serious about this is evident from the fact that, if I had in any way sought

the approval of my contemporaries, I would have had to strike out twenty passages that run completely counter to all their views, and in part must even offend them. But I would count it a crime to sacrifice even a syllable to that approval. My guiding star has quite seriously been truth. Following it, I could at first strive only for my own approval, wholly turned away from an age deeply fallen with respect to all higher intellectual endeavors, and from a national literature demoralized except for its exceptions, in which the art of combining lofty words with low-mindedness has reached its summit. The faults and weaknesses necessarily attached to my nature, as to every nature its own, I can certainly never escape; but I will not increase them through unworthy accommodations.

As far as this second edition is concerned, I am pleased above all that after twenty-five years I find nothing to retract, and that my fundamental convictions have therefore at least stood the test with me myself. The changes in the first volume, which alone contains the text of the first edition, therefore nowhere touch what is essential. They concern partly only secondary matters, and for the most part consist of usually brief explanatory additions inserted here and there. Only the critique of Kantian philosophy has received significant corrections and extensive additions, since these could not be placed here in a supplementary book, as each of the four books that present my own doctrine has received one in the second volume. I chose this latter form of enlargement and improvement for those books because the twenty-five years that had passed since their composition had brought about such a noticeable change in my manner of presentation and tone of exposition that it would not have been advisable to fuse the content of the second volume with that of the first into a single whole; both would have suffered from such a fusion. I therefore present the two works separately, and in the earlier presentation I have often changed nothing even where I would now express myself quite differently, because I wanted to guard against spoiling the work of my younger years through the fault-finding of age. Whatever may need correction in this respect will, with the help of the second volume, set itself right in the reader's mind. The two volumes stand in a complementary relation to one another in the fullest sense of the word, insofar as this relation rests on the fact that one period of a human life, intellectually considered, is the complement of another. Thus one will find not only that each volume contains what the other does not have, but also that the advantages of one lie precisely in what the other lacks. If, then, the first half of my work has over the second what only the fire of youth and the energy of the first

conception can bestow, the second will surpass the first through the maturity and complete working-through of the thoughts, which can belong only to the fruits of a long life's course and its labor. For when I had the strength to grasp the fundamental thought of my system originally, to pursue it at once into its four branches, to return from them to the unity of its trunk, and then to present the whole clearly, I could not yet be in a position to work through all the parts of the system with the completeness, thoroughness, and detail that can be attained only through many years of meditation upon it. Such meditation is required in order to test and illustrate it by countless facts, to support it with the most varied evidence, to illuminate it brightly from all sides, boldly to set contrasting points of view against one another, and to separate and arrange the manifold materials cleanly. Therefore, although it would certainly be more pleasant for the reader to have my whole work cast in a single mold, rather than now consisting of two halves that have to be brought together in use, he should consider that this would have required me to accomplish in one period of life what is possible only in two; indeed, it would have required me in one period of life to possess qualities that nature has distributed between two very different ones. Accordingly, the necessity of delivering my work in two mutually supplementary halves may be compared to the necessity by which an achromatic objective lens, because it is impossible to make it from a single piece, is produced by composing it from a convex lens of flint glass and a concave lens of crown glass, whose united effect alone accomplishes what was intended. On the other hand, the reader will find some compensation for the inconvenience of using two volumes at once in the variety and relief that come from the treatment of the same subject by the same mind, in the same spirit, but in very different years. Meanwhile, for anyone not yet acquainted with my philosophy, it is thoroughly advisable first to read the first volume without consulting the supplements, and to use these only on a second reading; otherwise it would be too difficult for him to grasp the system in its coherence, since only the first volume presents it in that coherence, while in the second the main doctrines are individually grounded and developed more fully. Even someone who cannot decide on a second reading of the first volume will do better to read the second only after the first, and by itself, in the direct sequence of its chapters. These chapters do indeed stand in a connection, though a looser one, whose gaps will be completely filled by the memory of the first volume if he has understood it well. Besides this, he will everywhere find references back to the relevant passages of the first volume, in which, for this purpose, I have in

the second edition furnished with paragraph numbers the sections that in the first edition were marked merely by dividing lines.

Already in the preface to the first edition I declared that my philosophy proceeds from Kant's and therefore presupposes a thorough knowledge of it: I repeat that here. For Kant's teaching produces in every mind that has grasped it a fundamental change so great that it may count as a spiritual rebirth. It alone is capable of truly removing the realism that is inborn in him and arises from the original constitution of the intellect; neither Berkeley nor Malebranche is sufficient for this, since they remain too much at the general level, whereas Kant goes into particulars, and indeed in a way that knows neither model nor copy and has a wholly distinctive, one might say immediate, effect on the mind. As a result, the mind undergoes a thorough disillusionment and from then on sees all things in another light. Only through this does it become receptive to the more positive disclosures that I have to give. Anyone, on the other hand, who has not mastered Kantian philosophy remains, whatever else he may have studied, as it were in a state of innocence, namely in that natural and childlike realism in which we are all born and which qualifies one for all sorts of things, but not for philosophy. Such a person therefore stands to the former as a minor to an adult. That this truth sounds paradoxical today, which was by no means the case in the first thirty years after the appearance of the *Critique of Pure Reason*, comes from the fact that since then a generation has grown up that does not really know Kant. To know him requires more than a fleeting, impatient reading, or an account at second hand; and this in turn is because, through bad guidance, that generation has wasted its time on the philosophizings of ordinary, and therefore unauthorized, minds, or even of swaggering sophists whom it was irresponsibly urged to admire. Hence the confusion in first concepts, and in general the unspeakable crudity and coarseness that show through the covering of preciousness and pretentiousness in the philosophical attempts of the generation thus educated. But anyone who imagines he can learn Kant's philosophy from others' accounts of it is caught in a disastrous error. Rather, I must seriously warn against such reports, especially from more recent times; and in these very last years I have encountered accounts of Kantian philosophy in the writings of the Hegelians that truly verge on the fabulous. How could minds distorted and ruined in early youth by the nonsense of Hegelianism still be capable of following Kant's profound investigations? They are early accustomed to taking the emptiest verbiage for philosophical thoughts, the most wretched sophisms for acuteness, and silly absurdity for dialectic; and

by taking in raging combinations of words over which the mind tortures and exhausts itself in vain in the attempt to think something, their heads are disorganized. For them no critique of reason is suitable; for them no philosophy is suitable. For them what is needed is a *medicina mentis* (medicine of the mind), first as a purgative perhaps un petit cours de senscommunologie (a little course in common-sense-ology), and then one may see whether philosophy can ever again be spoken of in their case. Kant's doctrine, then, will be sought in vain anywhere other than in Kant's own works; these are instructive throughout, even where he errs, even where he fails. In consequence of his originality, what is true of all genuine philosophers holds of him in the highest degree: one learns to know them only from their own writings, not from reports by others. For the thoughts of those extraordinary minds cannot bear filtration through an ordinary head. Born behind broad, high, beautifully arched foreheads, beneath which shining eyes look out, they lose all strength and life when moved into the narrow dwelling and low roof of cramped, pressed, thick-walled skulls, from which dull glances aimed at personal ends peer forth; they no longer resemble themselves. Indeed, one may say that such heads act like uneven mirrors in which everything is twisted, distorted, loses the symmetry of its beauty, and appears as a caricature. Only from their originators themselves can philosophical thoughts be received. Therefore anyone who feels drawn to philosophy must seek out its immortal teachers in the quiet sanctuary of their own works. The chief chapters of any one of these genuine philosophers will provide a hundred times more insight into their doctrines than the dragging and squinting reports about them produced by everyday minds, which are usually also deeply caught in the fashionable philosophy of the moment or in their own cherished opinion. Yet it is astonishing how decidedly the public reaches by preference for those presentations at second hand. Here elective affinity really seems to be at work, by virtue of which common nature is drawn to its like and therefore prefers to hear even what a great mind has said from one of its own kind. Perhaps this rests on the same principle as the system of mutual instruction, according to which children learn best from their peers.

Now one more word for the philosophy professors. I have always had to admire the sagacity, the correct and fine tact with which, as soon as my philosophy appeared, they recognized it as something wholly heterogeneous to their own efforts, perhaps even dangerous to them, or, to speak popularly, as something that did not fit their trade; likewise the sure and shrewd policy by which they at once discovered the only right procedure toward it; the complete

unanimity with which they put that procedure into practice; and finally the persistence with which they have remained faithful to it. This procedure, which incidentally also recommends itself by being extremely easy to carry out, consists, as is well known, in complete ignoring and thereby in secreting away, in Goethe's malicious expression, which really means suppressing what is important and significant. The effectiveness of this quiet means is heightened by the Corybantic din with which the birth of the intellectual children of those in agreement is mutually celebrated, and which forces the public to look and to notice the important faces with which they greet one another over it. Who could fail to recognize the expediency of this procedure? After all, there is nothing to object to in the principle *primum vivere, deinde philosophari* (first live, then philosophize). The gentlemen want to live, and indeed to live from *philosophy*: they are referred to *it*, with wife and child, and have ventured upon it despite Petrarch's *povera e nuda vai filosofia* (poor and naked you go, philosophy). Now my philosophy is not at all arranged so that one can live from it. It lacks the first requisites indispensable for a well-paid professorial philosophy, above all any speculative theology, which, in spite of that troublesome Kant with his critique of reason, is supposed to be and must be the chief theme of all philosophy, even if philosophy thereby receives the task of forever speaking about what it absolutely cannot know. Indeed, my philosophy does not even admit the fable so cleverly invented by the philosophy professors, and so indispensable to them, of a reason that knows, intuitively, or perceives immediately and absolutely. One need only palm this off on one's readers at the beginning, in order afterward to drive, as comfortably as possible and almost with four horses, into the region beyond the possibility of all experience, which Kant has wholly and forever closed off to our knowledge; and there one then finds the fundamental dogmas of modern, Judaizing, optimistic Christianity directly revealed and most beautifully arranged. What, then, in all the world, has my philosophy, lacking these essential requisites, ruthless and unable to provide anyone a living, brooding, and having as its guiding star only truth, naked, unrewarded, friendless, often persecuted truth, steering straight toward it without looking right or left, to do with that alma mater (nourishing mother), the good, nourishing university philosophy, which comes carefully tacking along its way, burdened with a hundred intentions and a thousand considerations, always keeping before its eyes the fear of the Lord, the will of the ministry, the statutes of the established church, the wishes of the publisher, the encouragement of the students, the good friendship of colleagues, the course of daily politics, the momentary direction of the public, and whatever else? Or

what does my quiet, serious search for truth have in common with the shrill school-song of lecture chairs and benches, whose innermost driving forces are always personal ends? Rather, the two kinds of philosophy are heterogeneous from the ground up. Therefore there is no compromise and no camaraderie with me, and no one finds his profit with me except perhaps the one who sought nothing but truth; hence none of the philosophical parties of the day do, for they all pursue their own aims, while I have only insights to offer, which fit none of them precisely because they are modeled on none. If my philosophy itself were to become fit for the professorial chair, entirely different times would first have to arise. It would be a fine thing indeed if a philosophy from which one cannot make a living were to gain air and light, perhaps even general attention! This therefore had to be prevented, and everyone had to stand together as one man against it. In contesting and refuting it, however, they do not have such an easy game; and this is a dubious means also because it draws the public's attention to the matter, and reading my writings might spoil for that public the taste for the lucubrations of the philosophy professors. For whoever has tasted seriousness will no longer relish amusement, especially of the tedious kind. Accordingly, the unanimously adopted system of silence and ignoring is the only right one, and I can only advise them to stay with it and continue it as long as it works, that is, until ignoring is someday inferred to be ignorance; then it will still be time enough to change course. Meanwhile everyone remains free to pluck out a little feather here and there for his own use, since the abundance of thoughts at home is not usually very oppressive. Thus the system of ignoring and silence may hold out for a good while yet, at least for the span of time I may still have to live, which is already much gained. Even if here and there an indiscreet voice has made itself heard, it will soon be drowned out by the loud discourse of the professors, who know how to entertain the public, with important faces, about quite other things. I advise, however, that somewhat stricter attention be paid to unanimity of procedure, and especially that young people be watched, since they are sometimes terribly indiscreet. For even so I cannot guarantee that the praised procedure will hold out forever, and I cannot answer for the final outcome. There is, namely, something peculiar about the guidance of the public, which on the whole is good and obedient. Although at almost all times we see the Gorgias and Hippias on top, although absurdity regularly culminates, and although it seems impossible that the voice of an individual could ever penetrate the chorus of deceivers and deceived, genuine works nevertheless always have an entirely distinctive, quiet, slow, powerful effect. As if by a wonder, one sees them at last rise out of the tumult, like an aerostat ascending

out of the thick atmosphere of this earthly space into purer regions, where, once arrived, it remains and no one can pull it down again.

Written in Frankfurt am Main, February 1844.

Preface to the Third Edition.

What is true and genuine would more easily gain room in the world if those who are incapable of producing it were not at the same time sworn together not to let it arise. This circumstance has already hindered and delayed, if not entirely stifled, much that should have benefited the world. For me its consequence has been that, although I was only thirty years old when the first edition of this work appeared, I live to see this third edition no earlier than my seventy-second year. Yet I find comfort in *Petrarch's* words: *si quis, tota die currens, pervenit ad vesperam, satis est* (*de vera sapientia*, p. 140) (if someone, running all day, reaches evening, it is enough). At last I too have arrived, and I have the satisfaction, at the end of my career, of seeing the beginning of my influence, with the hope that, according to an old rule, it will last in proportion to how late it began.

In this third edition the reader will miss nothing that the second contains, but will receive considerably more, since through the additions made to it, with the same type, it has 136 more pages than the second.

Seven years after the appearance of the second edition, I published two volumes of *Parerga and Paralipomena*. What is included under the latter name consists of additions to the systematic exposition of my philosophy, and would have found its proper place in these volumes; but at that time I had to put it where I could, since it was very doubtful whether I would live to see this third edition. It may be found in the second volume of the aforementioned *Parerga*, and it is easily recognized by the headings of the chapters.

Frankfurt am Main, September 1859.

Notes

Notes

1. The second printing, which has now become necessary (September 1892), is unchanged; only, as a result of another revision, a number of remaining typographical and printing errors, especially in volumes I and II, have been corrected. ↩

2. F. H. Jacobi. ↩

3. Hegelian philosophy. ↩

4. Fichte and Schelling. ↩

5. Hegel. ↩

§. 1.

First Book.

The world as representation, first consideration:
Representation subject to the principle of sufficient reason:
the object of experience and science.

Sors de l'enfance, ami, réveille-toi!

Jean-Jacques Rousseau.

Translation: Leave childhood behind, friend; wake up!

"The world is my representation": this is a truth that holds for every living and knowing being, although only the human being can bring it into reflective, abstract consciousness. When he actually does so, philosophical clarity has entered into him.

It then becomes clear and certain to him that he knows no sun and no earth, but always only an eye that sees a sun, a hand that feels an earth; that the world surrounding him exists only as representation, that is, always only in relation to something else, the representing subject, which he himself is.

If any truth can be stated a priori (prior to experience), it is this one. For it expresses the form of all possible and conceivable experience, a form more universal than all others, more universal than time, space, and causality; for all of these already presuppose it. Each of these forms, which we have recognized as so many particular configurations of the principle of sufficient reason, applies only to a particular class of representations. By contrast, the division into object and subject is the common form of all those classes. It is the form under which alone any representation whatsoever, of whatever kind it may be, abstract or intuitive, pure or empirical, is possible and thinkable at all.

No truth, therefore, is more certain, more independent of all others, or less in need of proof than this: that everything that exists for cognition, and thus this whole world, is only object in relation to the subject, intuition of the one who intuits, in a word, representation. Naturally this holds of every past and every future just as it holds of the present, of what is farthest as of what is nearest; for it holds of time and space themselves, within which alone all these distinctions arise. Everything that belongs, or can belong, to the world is inescapably

marked by this conditioning through the subject, and exists only for the subject. The world is representation.

This truth is by no means new. It already lay in the skeptical reflections from which Descartes set out. Berkeley, however, was the first to state it decisively, and by doing so he acquired an immortal merit in philosophy, even if the rest of his doctrines cannot stand. Kant's first error was the neglect of this proposition, as is explained in the appendix.

By contrast, how early this fundamental truth was recognized by the sages of India is attested by W. Jones, in the last of his essays, "On the Philosophy of the Asiatics," *Asiatic Researches*, Vol. IV, p. 164, where it appears as the fundamental proposition of the Vedanta philosophy ascribed to *Vyasa*:

the fundamental tenet of the Vedanta school consisted not in denying the existence of matter, that is of solidity, impenetrability, and extended figure (to deny which would be lunacy), but in correcting the popular notion of it, and in contending that it has no essence independent of mental perception; that existence and percibility are convertible terms. ^[1]

These words express sufficiently the coexistence of empirical reality with transcendental ideality.

Thus, in this first book, we consider the world only from the side just indicated, only insofar as it is representation. Yet this consideration, without prejudice to its truth, is one-sided, and therefore is brought about by some deliberate abstraction. Everyone is told as much by the inner resistance with which he accepts the world as his mere representation, an acceptance from which, on the other hand, he can never escape.

The one-sidedness of this consideration will be supplemented by the following book, through a truth that is not so immediately certain as the one from which we begin here. Only deeper investigation, more difficult abstraction, the separation of what is different and the unification of what is identical, can lead to it. It is a truth that must be very serious, and to everyone, if not terrible, at least grave: namely, that he too can and must say, "the world is my will."

Until then, however, and therefore throughout this first book, it is necessary to keep fixedly in view the side of the world from which we set out, the side of knowability. Accordingly, without resistance, we must consider all existing

objects, indeed even our own body, as we shall soon discuss more closely, only as representation, and call them mere representation.

What is abstracted from here, as I hope will later become certain to everyone, is always only the *will*, which alone constitutes the other side of the world. For the world is, on the one hand, through and through *representation*, and, on the other, through and through *will*. But a reality that would be neither of these two, an object in itself, into which Kant's thing in itself unfortunately degenerated in his hands, is a dreamed-up absurdity, and its assumption is a will-o'-the-wisp in philosophy.

Notes

Notes

1. The fundamental dogma of the Vedanta school consisted not in denying the existence of matter, that is, solidity, impenetrability, and extension, which it would be madness to deny, but in correcting the ordinary concept of it by maintaining that it has no existence independent of cognitive apprehension; existence and perceptibility are thus interchangeable concepts. ↩

§. 2.

That which knows everything and is known by no one is the *subject*. It is therefore the bearer of the world, the universal and always presupposed condition of everything that appears, of every object; for whatever exists, exists only for the subject. Everyone finds himself as this subject, but only insofar as he knows, not insofar as he is an object of cognition.

His body, however, is already object, and from this standpoint we therefore call even the body representation. For the body is object among objects and subject to the laws of objects, although it is immediate object.^[1] Like all objects of intuition, it lies in the forms of all cognition, in time and space, through which multiplicity exists.

The subject, by contrast, the knower that is never known, does not lie in these forms. Rather, it is itself always already presupposed by them. Therefore neither multiplicity nor its opposite, unity, belongs to it. We never know it; instead, it is precisely what knows wherever anything is known.

The world as representation, then, which is the only respect in which we are considering it here, has two essential, necessary, and inseparable halves. The one is the *object*: its form is space and time, and through these, multiplicity. The other half, however, the subject, does not lie in space and time; for it is whole and undivided in every representing being. Thus a single such being completes the world as representation with the object just as fully as the millions that exist; but if even that single being disappeared, the world as representation would no longer be.

These halves are therefore inseparable even for thought. Each of the two has meaning and existence only through and for the other; each exists with the other and disappears with it. They limit one another immediately: where the object begins, the subject ends.

The shared character of this boundary shows itself precisely in the fact that the essential, and therefore universal, forms of every object, which are time, space, and causality, can be found and completely known even without cognition of the object itself, proceeding from the subject; that is, in Kant's language, they lie a priori (prior to experience) in our consciousness. To have discovered this is one of Kant's chief merits, and a very great one.

I now maintain, in addition, that the principle of sufficient reason is the common expression for all these forms of the object of which we are conscious a priori; and that therefore everything we know purely a priori is nothing other than the content of that principle and what follows from it. In that principle, then, the whole of our cognition that is certain a priori is actually expressed.

In my essay on the principle of sufficient reason, I have shown in detail how every possible object whatsoever is subject to that principle; that is, how it stands in a necessary relation to other objects, on the one hand as determined, and on the other as determining. This goes so far that the whole existence of all objects, insofar as they are objects, representations and nothing else, runs back entirely to this necessary relation of theirs to one another, consists only in such a relation, and is therefore wholly relative. More on this soon.

I have further shown that, in accordance with the classes into which objects fall according to their possibility, that necessary relation which the principle of sufficient reason expresses in general appears in different forms; and through this, in turn, the correct division of those classes is confirmed. Here I constantly presuppose everything said there as known and present to the reader; for if it had not already been said there, it would necessarily have its place here.

Notes

Notes

1. *On the Principle of Sufficient Reason*, 2nd ed., §. 22. ↩

§. 3.

The chief distinction among all our representations is that between the intuitive and the abstract. The latter make up only *one* class of representations: concepts. On earth, concepts are the possession of the human being alone, and the capacity for them, which distinguishes him from all animals, has always been called *reason*.^[1]

We shall later consider these abstract representations by themselves. For now, however, we shall speak exclusively of *intuitive representation*. This comprises the whole visible world, or the whole of experience, together with the conditions of its possibility.

As already said, it is one of Kant's very important discoveries that precisely these conditions, these forms of experience, that is, what is most universal in its perception, what belongs in the same way to all its appearances, time and space, can also be not only thought in abstracto (in the abstract), by themselves and separated from their content, but also immediately intuited. This intuition is not, say, a phantasm borrowed from experience by repetition. On the contrary, it is so independent of experience that experience must instead be thought as dependent on it; for the properties of space and time, as intuition cognizes them a priori (prior to experience), hold as laws for all possible experience, according to which experience everywhere must turn out.

For this reason, in my essay on the principle of sufficient reason, I treated time and space, insofar as they are intuited purely and without content, as a special class of representations existing by itself. Now, important as this character of the universal forms of intuition discovered by Kant is, namely that they can be intuited by themselves and independently of experience, and can be known in accordance with their entire lawfulness, on which mathematics with its infallibility rests, another property of theirs is no less worthy of attention.

The principle of sufficient reason, which determines experience as the law of causality and motivation, and thought as the law of the grounding of judgments, appears here in a quite distinctive form. I have given this form the name *ground of being*. In time, it is the succession of its moments; in space, it is the position of its parts, which determine one another reciprocally into infinity.

Anyone who has understood, from the introductory essay, the complete identity of the content of the principle of sufficient reason throughout all the

difference of its forms will also be convinced how important it is, for insight into its innermost essence, to cognize the simplest of its forms precisely as such. We have recognized this simplest form as *time*.

In time, each moment exists only insofar as it has annihilated the preceding one, its father, in order to be annihilated just as quickly in turn. Past and future, apart from the consequences of their content, are as empty as any dream; the present is only the extensionless and durationless boundary between the two.

In just the same way, we shall recognize the same emptiness in all the other forms of the principle of sufficient reason. We shall see that, like time, so too space; and, like space, so too everything that exists in space and time at once, therefore everything that proceeds from causes or motives, has only a relative existence. It exists only through and for something else like itself, that is, something that again exists in just the same way.

The essence of this view is old. Heraclitus lamented in it the eternal flux of things. Plato downgraded its object as what is always becoming but never being. Spinoza called it mere accidents of the one substance that alone is and persists. Kant opposed what is known in this way, as mere appearance, to the thing in itself. Finally, the ancient wisdom of the Indians says:

It is *Maya*, the veil of illusion, which covers the eyes of mortals and lets them see a world of which one can say neither that it is nor that it is not; for it is like a dream, like the sunlight on sand which the wanderer from a distance takes for water, or like a rope thrown down which he takes for a snake.

These similes are repeated in countless passages of the Vedas and Puranas.

But what all these meant, and what they speak of, is nothing other than what we are now considering: the world as representation, subject to the principle of sufficient reason.

Notes

Notes

1. Kant alone confused this concept of reason. On this point I refer to the appendix, as well as to my *Two Fundamental Problems of Ethics*: "On the Basis of Morality," §. 6, pp. 148-154 of the first edition. (Second edition, pp. 146-151.) ↩

§. 4.

Whoever has recognized the form of the principle of sufficient reason that appears in pure time as such, and on which all counting and calculation rests, has thereby recognized the whole essence of time. Time is nothing more than precisely that form of the principle of sufficient reason, and has no other property. Succession is the form of the principle of sufficient reason in time; succession is the whole essence of time.

Whoever, further, has recognized the principle of sufficient reason as it governs mere, purely intuited space has thereby exhausted the whole essence of space; for space is, through and through, nothing other than the possibility of the reciprocal determinations of its parts by one another, which is called *position*. The detailed consideration of this, and the laying down of the results that follow from it in abstract concepts for more convenient application, is the content of the whole of geometry.

In just the same way, whoever has recognized that form of the principle of sufficient reason which governs the content of those forms, time and space, their perceptibility, that is, matter, and therefore has recognized the law of causality, has thereby recognized the whole essence of matter as such. For matter is, through and through, nothing but causality, as everyone immediately sees as soon as he reflects.

The being of matter is its acting; no other being for it is even thinkable. Only as acting does it fill space and time. Its action upon the immediate object, which is itself matter, conditions the intuition in which alone matter exists. The consequence of the action of any other material object upon another is known only insofar as the latter now acts differently than before upon the immediate object; indeed, it consists only in this. Cause and effect, therefore, are the whole essence of matter: its being is its acting. More on this may be found in the essay on the principle of sufficient reason, §. 21, p. 77.

It is therefore highly apt that in German the totality of everything material is called *Wirklichkeit*, actuality, ^[1] a word much more expressive than "reality." That upon which matter acts is always again matter. Its whole being and essence therefore consists only in the lawful alteration that one part of matter produces in another. It is consequently entirely relative, according to a relation valid only within its own limits, just like time and just like space.

Time and space, each by itself, can be intuitively represented even without matter; but matter cannot be represented without them. Already the form inseparable from matter presupposes *space*, and its acting, in which its whole existence consists, always concerns an alteration, hence a determination of *time*. But time and space are not merely presupposed by matter, each on its own. Rather, their union constitutes the essence of matter, precisely because that essence, as has been shown, consists in acting, in causality.

All conceivable, innumerable appearances and states could lie side by side in infinite space without crowding one another; or they could follow one another in infinite time without disturbing one another. In that case, a necessary relation of them to one another, and a rule that determined them according to that relation, would be by no means necessary, indeed not even applicable. Consequently, with all coexistence in space and all change in time, so long as each of these two forms had its existence and course by itself, without connection with the other, there would still be no causality at all; and since causality makes up the true essence of matter, there would also be no matter.

The law of causality receives its meaning and necessity only because the essence of alteration does not consist in the mere change of states in themselves. Rather, it consists in the fact that at *the same place* in space there is now *one* state and then *another*, and that at *one and the same* determinate time there is *here* this state and *there* that one. Only this reciprocal limitation of time and space by one another gives meaning, and at the same time necessity, to a rule according to which alteration must proceed.

What is determined by the law of causality, then, is not the succession of states in mere time, but this succession with reference to a determinate space; and not the existence of states at a determinate place, but their existence at this place at a determinate time. Alteration, that is, the change that occurs according to the causal law, therefore always concerns a determinate part of space and a determinate part of time *at once* and in union. Accordingly, causality unites space with time.

But we have found that the whole essence of matter consists in acting, and therefore in causality. Consequently, space and time must also be united in matter. Matter must bear in itself, at once, the properties of time and of space, however much the two conflict with each other. What is impossible in each of those two forms by itself, matter must unite in itself: the unstable flight of time

with the rigid, unchanging persistence of space. Infinite divisibility it has from both.

In accordance with this, we find that matter first brings about *coexistence*, which could occur neither in mere time, which has no side-by-side, nor in mere space, which knows no before, after, or now. But the *coexistence* of many states is what really constitutes the essence of actuality. For through coexistence, *duration* first becomes possible, since duration is knowable only in the change of what exists simultaneously with the enduring thing. Yet only by means of what endures in change does change itself receive the character of *alteration*, that is, of the transformation of quality and form while *substance*, that is, *matter*, persists. ^[2]

In mere space the world would be rigid and motionless: no succession, no alteration, no acting. But once acting is removed, the representation of matter is removed as well. In mere time, again, everything would be fleeting: no persistence, no side-by-side and therefore no coexistence, consequently no duration; and so once again no matter. Only through the union of time and space does matter arise, that is, the possibility of coexistence, and thereby of duration, and through duration in turn the persistence of substance amid the alteration of states. ^[3]

Since matter has its essence in the union of time and space, it everywhere bears the stamp of both. It attests its origin from space partly through form, which is inseparable from it, but especially through its persistence, or substance, since change belongs to time alone, while in time alone and by itself there is nothing enduring. The certainty of this persistence a priori (prior to experience) is therefore to be derived entirely from the certainty of space. ^[4] Matter reveals its origin from time, however, in quality, or accident, without which it never appears, and which is simply always causality: acting upon other matter, and therefore alteration, a concept of time.

The lawfulness of this acting, however, always refers to space and time together, and has meaning only thereby. What state must occur at *this time* in *this place* is the determination to which alone the legislation of causality extends. On this derivation of the basic determinations of matter from the forms of our cognition of which we are conscious a priori rests the fact that we recognize certain properties of matter a priori: filling space, that is, impenetrability, that is, efficacy; then extension, infinite divisibility, persistence, that is, indestructibility; and finally mobility. By contrast, gravity,

despite its exceptionlessness, must probably be counted as belonging to cognition a posteriori (after experience), although *Kant*, in the *Metaphysical Foundations of Natural Science*, p. 71 (Rosenkranz edition, p. 372), presents it as knowable a priori.

Just as the object in general exists only for the subject, as its representation, so every particular class of representations exists only for an equally particular determination in the subject, which is called a faculty of cognition. Kant called the subjective correlate of time and space by themselves, as empty forms, pure sensibility. Since Kant broke the path here, this expression may be retained, although it is not quite fitting, since sensibility already presupposes matter.

The subjective correlate of matter, or of causality, for the two are one, is the *understanding*, and it is nothing besides this. To know causality is its only function, its sole power. This is a great power, embracing much, varied in application, yet unmistakably identical in all its manifestations. Conversely, all causality, hence all matter, and therefore the whole of actuality, exists only for the understanding, through the understanding, in the understanding.

The first, simplest, ever-present manifestation of the understanding is intuition of the actual world. This is, through and through, cognition of the cause from the effect; hence all intuition is intellectual. Yet intuition could never arise if some effect were not known immediately and thereby served as the starting point. This effect is the effect upon animal bodies. In this respect they are the *immediate objects* of the subject; the intuition of all other objects is mediated through them.

The alterations that every animal body undergoes are known immediately, that is, sensed. As soon as this effect is referred to its cause, there arises the intuition of that cause as an *object*. This reference is not an inference in abstract concepts. It does not occur through reflection, nor arbitrarily, but immediately, necessarily, and securely. It is the mode of cognition of the *pure understanding*, without which intuition would never arise. There would remain only a dull, plant-like consciousness of the alterations of the immediate object, following one another in complete meaninglessness, unless perhaps as pain or pleasure they had significance for the will.

But just as the visible world stands there with the entrance of the sun, so the understanding, with *one* stroke, through its single, simple function, transforms dull, meaningless sensation into intuition. What the eye, the ear, and the hand sense is not intuition; these are mere data. Only when the understanding passes

from the effect to the cause does the world stand there as intuition, spread out in space, changing in form, and persisting through all time in matter. For the understanding unites space and time in the representation *matter*, that is, efficacy. This world as representation exists only through the understanding, and also only for the understanding.

In the first chapter of my essay *On Vision and Colors*, I have already explained how, from the data supplied by the senses, the understanding creates intuition; how, by comparing the impressions that the different senses receive from the same object, the child learns intuition; and how this alone explains so many sensory phenomena: single vision with two eyes, double vision when squinting, or when objects standing one behind another at unequal distances are simultaneously fixed by the eye, and every illusion produced by a sudden alteration in the sense organs.

I treated this important subject much more fully and thoroughly, however, in the second edition of the essay on the principle of sufficient reason, §. 21. Everything said there would have its necessary place here, and so would really have to be said here again. Since, however, I have almost as much reluctance to copy myself as to copy others, and since I am also not able to present it better than was done there, I refer to it instead of repeating it here, but now presuppose it as known.

Children learning to see, people born blind who have been operated on learning to see, single vision of what is sensed doubly with two eyes, double vision and double touch when the sense organs are displaced from their ordinary position, the upright appearance of objects while their image in the eye stands inverted, the transfer of color, which is merely an inner function, a polar division of the eye's activity, onto external objects, and finally the stereoscope: all these are firm and irrefutable proofs that all *intuition* is not merely sensory but intellectual. It is pure *cognition by the understanding of the cause from the effect*. It therefore presupposes the law of causality, on cognition of which all intuition, and hence all experience, depends according to its first and whole possibility, not the reverse, cognition of the causal law depending on experience. The latter was the Humean skepticism, which is only now refuted.

For the independence of cognition of causality from all experience, that is, its apriority, can be demonstrated only from the dependence of all experience upon it. This, in turn, can be done only by showing, in the manner indicated here and developed in the passages just cited, that cognition of causality is already

contained in intuition in general, within whose domain all experience lies; that it therefore exists wholly a priori with respect to experience, is presupposed by experience as its condition, and does not presuppose experience. It cannot be demonstrated in the way Kant attempted, which I criticized in the essay on the principle of sufficient reason, §. 23.

Notes

Notes

1. *Mira in quibusdam rebus verborum proprietas est, et consuetudo sermonis antiqui quaedam efficacissimis notis signat. Seneca epist. 81.* Translation: There is a wonderful aptness of words in certain matters, and the usage of ancient speech marks certain things with the most effective signs. Seneca, Epistle 81. ↩
2. That matter and substance are one is explained in the appendix. ↩
3. This also shows the basis of the Kantian definition of matter, "that it is the movable in space"; for motion consists only in the union of space and time. ↩
4. Not from cognition of time, as Kant wants, which is explained in the appendix. ↩

§. 5.

One must guard, however, against the great misunderstanding that, because intuition is mediated by cognition of causality, there is therefore a relation of cause and effect between object and subject. On the contrary, such a relation always occurs only between immediate and mediated object, and thus always only between objects.

That false presupposition is precisely what underlies the foolish dispute over the reality of the external world, in which dogmatism and skepticism confront one another, while dogmatism appears now as realism, now as idealism. Realism posits the object as cause and places its effect in the subject. Fichtean idealism makes the object into the effect of the subject.

But since, and this cannot be impressed strongly enough, no relation according to the principle of sufficient reason obtains between subject and object at all, neither of these two assertions could ever be proved, and skepticism made victorious attacks on both.

Just as the law of causality already precedes intuition and experience as their condition, and therefore cannot be learned from them, as Hume thought, so object and subject already precede all cognition as its first condition, and therefore also precede the principle of sufficient reason in general. For that principle is only the form of every object, the pervasive way and manner of its appearing; but the object always already presupposes the subject. Between the two, then, there can be no relation of ground and consequent.

My essay on the principle of sufficient reason is meant to accomplish precisely this: to present the content of that principle as the essential form of every object, that is, as the universal way and manner of all object-being, as something that belongs to the object as such. As such, however, the object everywhere presupposes the subject as its necessary correlate. The subject therefore always remains outside the domain in which the principle of sufficient reason is valid.

The dispute over the reality of the external world rests precisely on that false extension of the validity of the principle of sufficient reason to the subject as well; and, beginning from this misunderstanding, the dispute could never understand itself.

On the one hand, realistic dogmatism, taking representation to be the effect of the object, wants to separate these two, representation and object, which are precisely one and the same. It wants to assume a cause wholly different from representation: an object in itself, independent of the subject. This is something entirely unthinkable, for already as object it always presupposes the subject again, and therefore always remains only the subject's representation.

Skepticism, under the same false presupposition, opposes this by saying that in representation one always has only the effect, never the cause; that one therefore never knows the *being* of objects, but always only their *acting*; that this acting might perhaps have no similarity at all with being, and perhaps might even be assumed quite falsely, since the law of causality is first taken from experience, whose reality is then supposed to rest on that very law.

Both sides must now be instructed, first, that object and representation are the same; then, that the *being* of intuitive objects is precisely their *acting*; that the actuality of the thing consists precisely in this; and that the demand for the existence of the object outside the representation of the subject, as well as for a being of the actual thing different from its acting, has no meaning at all and is a contradiction. Therefore, cognition of the mode of action of an intuited object also exhausts the object itself insofar as it is object, that is, representation, since apart from this there remains nothing in it for cognition.

In this respect, then, the intuited world in space and time, which announces itself as sheer causality, is perfectly real. It is throughout what it gives itself out to be, and it gives itself wholly and without reserve as representation, cohering according to the law of causality. This is its empirical reality.

On the other hand, all causality exists only in the understanding and for the understanding. That whole actual, that is, acting, world is therefore, as such, always conditioned by the understanding and is nothing without it. But not only for this reason; already because, in general, no object without subject can be thought without contradiction, we must absolutely deny to the dogmatist who explains the reality of the external world as its independence from the subject any such reality of that world.

The whole world of objects is and remains representation, and for that very reason is, throughout and for all eternity, conditioned by the subject: that is, it has transcendental ideality. But it is not for that reason a lie or an illusion. It gives itself as what it is, as representation, and indeed as a series of representations whose common bond is the principle of sufficient reason. As

such, it is intelligible to healthy understanding, even in its innermost meaning, and speaks to it in a language perfectly clear.

Only to a mind distorted by sophistical reasoning can it occur to dispute the world's reality. This always happens through an incorrect application of the principle of sufficient reason, which certainly connects all representations with one another, whatever kind they may be, but by no means connects them with the subject, nor with something that would be neither subject nor object, but merely the ground of the object. That is a non-concept, because only objects can be grounds, and always only grounds of objects.

If one investigates still more closely the origin of this question about the reality of the external world, one finds that, besides that false application of the principle of sufficient reason to what lies outside its domain, there is also a special confusion of its forms. The form that the principle has only with respect to concepts, or abstract representations, is transferred to intuitive representations, to real objects; and a ground of knowing is demanded of objects that can have no ground except a ground of becoming.

The principle of sufficient reason certainly governs abstract representations, concepts joined into judgments, in such a way that each judgment has its value, its validity, its whole existence, here called *truth*, solely and exclusively through the relation of the judgment to something outside it: its ground of knowledge, to which one must therefore always go back.

By contrast, over real objects, intuitive representations, the principle of sufficient reason governs not as the principle of the ground of *knowing*, but as the principle of the ground of *becoming*, as the law of causality. Each of these objects has already paid its debt to the principle by having *become*, that is, by having emerged as an effect from a cause. The demand for a ground of knowledge therefore has no validity or meaning here; it belongs to an entirely different class of objects.

For this reason, too, the intuitive world, so long as one remains with it, arouses neither scruple nor doubt in the observer. Here there is neither error nor truth; these are banished to the domain of the abstract, of reflection. Here, for the senses and the understanding, the world lies open, gives itself with naive truth as what it is: intuitive representation, which develops lawfully on the bond of causality.

So far as we have considered the question of the reality of the external world up to this point, it has always arisen from a wandering of reason that goes so far

as to misunderstand itself. In this respect the question could be answered only by clarifying its content. After the whole essence of the principle of sufficient reason, the relation between object and subject, and the true character of sensible intuition had been investigated, the question had to cancel itself, because no meaning remained to it.

Yet that question also has another origin, entirely different from the purely speculative one indicated so far: an origin that is really empirical, although the question is still raised with a speculative intention. In this sense it has a much more intelligible meaning than in the former one, namely this: we have dreams; is not perhaps the whole of life a dream? Or, more precisely: is there a sure criterion between dream and actuality, between phantasms and real objects?

The claim that dreamed intuition has less liveliness and distinctness than actual intuition deserves no consideration at all, since no one has ever held the two side by side for comparison. One could compare only the *memory* of the dream with present actuality.

Kant solves the question this way: "The connection of representations among themselves according to the law of causality distinguishes life from dream." But in dream too, every particular thing likewise hangs together according to the principle of sufficient reason in all its forms; this connection breaks off only between life and dream, and between individual dreams.

Kant's answer could therefore still only be this: the *long* dream, life, has thoroughgoing connection within itself according to the principle of sufficient reason, but not with the *short* dreams, although each of these has the same connection within itself. Between these and the long dream, then, that bridge is broken, and by this one distinguishes the two.

Yet to conduct an inquiry according to this criterion into whether something was dreamed or actually happened would be very difficult and often impossible. We are by no means able to trace, link by link, the causal connection between every event we have lived through and the present moment; but for that reason we do not declare the event to have been dreamed. For this reason, in actual life we commonly do not use that kind of investigation to distinguish dream from actuality.

The only sure criterion for distinguishing dream from actuality is in fact none other than the wholly empirical one of waking up. Through waking, the causal connection between dreamed events and those of waking life is expressly and palpably broken.

Hobbes gives an excellent illustration of this in *Leviathan*, chapter 2. He observes that we easily take dreams afterward for actuality when, without intending to, we have slept clothed; especially when, in addition, some undertaking or plan occupies all our thoughts and concerns us in dream just as it does while waking. In such cases, waking is noticed almost as little as falling asleep; dream flows together with actuality and is mixed up with it. Then, to be sure, only the Kantian criterion remains. But if afterward, as often happens, the causal connection with the present, or its absence, simply cannot be discovered, then it must remain forever undecided whether an occurrence was dreamed or actually happened.

Here the close kinship between life and dream in fact comes very near to us; and we should not be ashamed to acknowledge it, after many great minds have recognized and expressed it. The Vedas and Puranas know no better comparison for the whole cognition of the actual world, which they call the web of Maya, and use none more often, than dream. Plato often says that human beings live only in dream, and that the philosopher alone strives to wake.

Pindar says (Pythian 8, 135):

σκιᾶς ὄναρ ἄνθρωπος

Translation: A human being is the dream of a shadow.

The source also gives the Latin rendering: *umbrae somnium homo* (a human being is a shadow's dream).

And Sophocles says:

ὁρῶ γὰρ ἡμᾶς οὐδὲν ὄντας ἄλλο, πλὴν
εἶδωλ', ὅσοι περ ζῶμεν, ἢ κούφην σκιάν.

Translation: For I see that we who live are nothing other than phantoms, or a light shadow.

Ajax 125.

The source also gives the Latin rendering: *Nos enim, quicunque vivimus, nihil aliud esse comperio, quam simulacra et levem umbram.* (For I find that we, all who live, are nothing other than images and a light shadow.)

Beside these Shakespeare stands most worthily:

We are such stuff
As dreams are made of, and our little life
Is rounded with a sleep.

The Tempest, Act 4, Scene 1. ^[1]

Finally, Calderon was so deeply moved by this view that he sought to express it in a drama that is, in a certain sense, metaphysical: *Life Is a Dream*.

After these many poetic passages, may I too be permitted to express myself through a simile. Life and dreams are leaves of one and the same book. Reading in connected sequence is called actual life. But when the particular reading hour, the day, is over and the time of rest has come, we often still leaf idly through the book and open, without order or connection, now here, now there: often it is a page already read, often one still unknown, but always from the same book.

Such a single page read by itself is indeed out of connection with the consecutive reading; yet it does not fall so very far behind it when one considers that the whole of the consecutive reading likewise begins and ends extemporaneously, and thus is to be regarded only as a larger single page.

Although, then, individual dreams are separated from actual life by the fact that they do not intervene in the connection of experience that runs steadily through actual life, and although waking marks this distinction, that very connection of experience already belongs to actual life as its form; and dream, by contrast, also has a connection within itself. If one now takes up the standpoint of judgment outside both, one finds no determinate difference in their essence, and is compelled to concede to the poets that life is a long dream.

Let us now return from this empirical origin of the question of the reality of the external world, which stands entirely by itself, to its speculative origin. We found that the latter lay, first, in the false application of the principle of sufficient reason, namely between subject and object as well; and then again in the confusion of its forms, whereby the principle of the ground of knowing was transferred into the domain where the principle of the ground of becoming holds.

Nevertheless, that question could hardly have occupied philosophers so persistently if it were wholly without any true content, and if there did not lie in its innermost core some correct thought and meaning as its most proper origin. We must therefore assume that only when this thought entered into reflection and sought expression did it pass into those distorted forms and questions that do not understand themselves.

This, in my opinion, is indeed the case. As the pure expression of that innermost meaning of the question, which the question itself did not know how to reach, I set down this: What is this intuitive world besides being my representation? Is it, of which I am conscious only once, and indeed as representation, like my own body, of which I am conscious in a double way: on the one hand *representation*, on the other *will*?

The clearer explanation and the affirmation of this question will be the content of the second book, and the conclusions that follow from it will occupy the remaining part of this work.

Notes

Notes

1. We are such stuff as that from which dreams are made, and our short life is enclosed by a sleep. ↩

§. 6.

Meanwhile, for now, in this first book, we consider everything only as representation, as object for the subject. Like all other real objects, we look at our own body too, from which the intuition of the world begins for each of us, only from the side of knowability; and it is therefore for us only a representation.

To be sure, the consciousness of each person, which already rebelled against declaring other objects to be mere representations, resists still more when one's own body is supposed to be merely a representation. This comes from the fact that the thing in itself, insofar as it appears as one's own body, is known to each person immediately, while insofar as it objectifies itself in the other objects of intuition it is known to him only mediately.

But the course of our investigation makes this abstraction, this one-sided way of considering things, this forceful separation of what essentially belongs together, necessary. That resistance must therefore for the time being be suppressed and calmed by the expectation that the following considerations will supplement the one-sidedness of the present one, toward a complete cognition of the essence of the world.

Here, then, the body is immediate object for us: that is, the representation that forms the starting point of the subject's cognition. With its immediately known alterations, the body precedes the application of the law of causality and thereby supplies the first data for that application.

As has been shown, the whole essence of matter consists in its acting. But effect and cause exist only for the understanding, which is nothing other than their subjective correlate. Yet the understanding could never come into application if there were not something else from which it starts. Such a thing is mere sensory sensation, the immediate consciousness of the alterations of the body, by virtue of which the body is immediate object.

Accordingly, we find the possibility of the knowability of the intuitive world in two conditions. The first, *if we express it objectively*, is the capacity of bodies to act upon one another, to produce alterations in one another. Without this universal property of all bodies, no intuition would be possible even by means of the sensibility of animal bodies.

But if we want to express this same first condition *subjectively*, we say: above all, the understanding makes intuition possible. For the law of causality, the possibility of effect and cause, springs only from the understanding and is valid only for it; and therefore the intuitive world exists only for and through it.

The second condition is the sensibility of animal bodies, or the property of certain bodies of being immediate objects of the subject. The mere alterations that the sense organs undergo through the specifically appropriate action upon them from outside may indeed already be called representations, insofar as such actions produce neither pain nor pleasure, that is, insofar as they have no immediate significance for the will and nevertheless are perceived, and so exist only for *cognition*. In this respect, then, I say that the body is immediately *known*, that it is *immediate object*.

Yet here the concept object is not even to be taken in its most proper sense. For through this immediate cognition of the body, which precedes the application of the understanding and is mere sensory sensation, the body itself does not actually stand there as *object*. Rather, only the bodies acting upon it do so. For every cognition of a genuine object, that is, of a representation intuitable in space, exists only through and for the understanding; therefore it exists not before, but only after, the understanding has been applied.

Accordingly, the body as genuine object, that is, as intuitive representation in space, is known, like all other objects, only mediately: through application of the law of causality to the action of one of its parts upon another, as when the eye sees the body or the hand touches it. Consequently, the shape of our own body is not known to us through mere common sensation. Only through cognition, only in representation, that is, only in the brain, does one's own body first present itself as extended, articulated, and organic.

A person born blind receives this representation only gradually, through the data that touch gives him. A blind person without hands would never come to know his shape, or at most would gradually infer and construct it from the action of other bodies upon him. It is with this restriction, then, that we are to understand our calling the body immediate object.

Moreover, according to what has been said, all animal bodies are immediate objects, that is, starting points of the intuition of the world, for the subject that knows everything and, precisely for that reason, is never known. *Cognition*, together with movement according to motives conditioned by cognition, is therefore the true *character of animality*, just as movement according to stimuli

is the character of the plant. The inorganic, however, has no movement other than that effected by causes proper in the narrowest sense. I have discussed all this more fully in the essay on the principle of sufficient reason, 2nd ed., §. 20; in the *Ethics*, first essay, III; and in *On Vision and Colors*, §. 1, to which I therefore refer.

It follows from what has been said that all animals have understanding, even the most imperfect; for they all cognize objects, and this cognition determines their movements as motive.

The understanding is the same in all animals and all human beings. Everywhere it has the same simple form: cognition of causality, transition from effect to cause and from cause to effect, and nothing besides. But the degrees of its sharpness and the extent of its sphere of cognition are extremely different, manifold, and graduated in many stages.

At the lowest degree, the understanding cognizes only the causal relation between the immediate object and mediated objects. This is just enough, by passing from the action undergone by the body to its cause, to intuit that cause as object in space. At higher degrees, the understanding cognizes the causal connection of merely mediated objects among one another, and this extends as far as understanding the most complex linkages of causes and effects in nature.

Even this latter achievement still belongs to the understanding, not to reason. Reason's abstract concepts can serve only to receive what has been immediately understood, to fix it, and to connect it; they can never produce understanding itself.

Every force of nature, every law of nature, and every case in which such a force or law manifests itself must first be immediately cognized by the understanding, grasped intuitively, before it can enter reflective consciousness in abstracto (in the abstract) for reason. Robert Hooke's discovery of the law of gravitation, and his reduction of so many great appearances to this one law, which Newton's calculations then confirmed, was intuitive, immediate apprehension through the understanding. The same was true of Lavoisier's discovery of oxygen and its important role in nature; the same was true of Goethe's discovery of the way physical colors arise.

All these discoveries are nothing other than a correct, immediate return from the effect to the cause. Immediately after this comes cognition of the identity of the force of nature manifesting itself in all causes of the same kind. This entire insight is a manifestation, differing only in degree, of the same single function

of the understanding through which an animal too intuitively, as object in space, the cause acting upon its body.

Therefore all those great discoveries, just like intuition and every manifestation of the understanding, are immediate insight and, as such, the work of the moment: an *aperçu* (sudden insight), a flash, not the product of long chains of inference in abstracto. Such chains serve instead to fix immediate cognition by the understanding for reason by laying it down in reason's abstract concepts; that is, to make it distinct, and thereby to put oneself in a position to explain it and communicate it to others.

That sharpness of understanding in apprehending the causal relations of mediately known objects finds its application not only in natural science, whose entire discoveries are owed to it, but also in practical life, where it is called *prudence*. In the former application, however, it is better called acuteness, penetration, and sagacity. Strictly speaking, *prudence* designates exclusively the understanding in the service of the will.

Still, the boundaries of these concepts can never be drawn sharply. It is always one and the same function of the same understanding, already active in every animal in the intuition of objects in space, which, at its greatest sharpness, sometimes correctly investigates from a given effect in the appearances of nature the unknown cause and so gives reason the material for thinking universal rules as laws of nature; sometimes invents complicated and ingenious machines by applying known causes to intended effects; and sometimes, applied to motivation, either sees through and frustrates fine intrigues and machinations, or itself properly sets up the motives and the people receptive to each of them, and moves them at will, like machines by levers and wheels, directing them to its own ends.

Lack of understanding is called, in the proper sense, *stupidity*, and is precisely *dullness in the application of the law of causality*: incapacity for the immediate apprehension of the linkages of cause and effect, motive and action.

A stupid person does not see into the connection of natural appearances, whether they emerge when left to themselves or when they are intentionally directed, that is, made serviceable in machines. For this reason he readily believes in magic and miracles. A stupid person does not notice that different people, apparently independent of one another, are in fact acting in an agreed connection; he is therefore easily mystified and drawn into intrigues. He does not notice the hidden motives of advice given, judgments expressed, and so on.

Yet what he always lacks is only one thing: sharpness, quickness, ease in applying the law of causality, that is, power of understanding.

The greatest and, for the respect under consideration, most instructive example of stupidity I ever encountered was a completely feeble-minded boy of about eleven in an asylum. He did have reason, since he spoke and understood speech, but in understanding he stood below many animals. Whenever I came, he would look at an eyeglass that I wore around my neck, in which, by reflection, the room's windows and the treetops beyond them appeared. Each time he showed great wonder and joy at this, and never tired of looking at it in astonishment, because he did not understand this wholly immediate causality of reflection.

Just as among human beings the degrees of sharpness of understanding are very different, they are probably still more different among the various animal species. In all animals, even those that stand closest to the plant, there is still enough understanding for the transition from the effect in the immediate object to the mediated object as cause, and therefore for intuition, for the apprehension of an object. This is precisely what makes them animals, since it gives them the possibility of movement according to motives and thereby of seeking, or at least seizing, nourishment. Plants, by contrast, have only movement according to stimuli; they must wait for the immediate action of these stimuli or wither away, and cannot go after them or seize them.

In the most perfect animals we admire their great sagacity: in the dog, the elephant, the ape, and the fox, whose prudence Buffon has described so masterfully. From these cleverest animals we can measure fairly accurately how much the understanding can achieve without the aid of reason, that is, without abstract cognition in concepts. We cannot know this so clearly in ourselves, because in us understanding and reason always support each other reciprocally.

For this reason we often find the manifestations of understanding in animals now above, now below our expectation. On the one hand, we are surprised by the sagacity of an elephant who, after having already crossed many bridges on his journey through Europe, once refuses to step onto a bridge over which he sees, as usual, the rest of the procession of people and horses crossing, because it seems to him too lightly built for his weight. On the other hand, we are surprised that clever orangutans do not maintain a fire they have found and at which they warm themselves by adding wood to it. This proves that doing so

already requires a deliberation that does not come about without abstract concepts.

That cognition of cause and effect, as the universal form of the understanding, dwells even in animals a priori (prior to experience) is already completely certain from the fact that, for them as for us, it is the preceding condition of all intuitive cognition of the external world. If, however, one wants a special proof of this, one need only observe, for example, how even a very young dog does not dare to jump from a table, however much he wants to, because he foresees the effect of the weight of his body, even though he does not already know this particular case from experience.

In judging the understanding of animals, however, we must beware of attributing to it what is a manifestation of instinct. Instinct is a property entirely different from understanding as well as from reason, though it often acts in a way very analogous to the combined activity of both. Its discussion, however, does not belong here; it will have its place in the second book, when we consider the harmony, or so-called teleology, of nature, and chapter 27 of the supplements is specially devoted to it.

Lack of *understanding* was called *stupidity*. Later we shall recognize lack of application of *reason* to practical matters as *folly*; lack of *power of judgment* as *simple-mindedness*; and partial or even complete lack of *memory* as *madness*. But each of these in its own place.

What is correctly cognized by *reason* is *truth*: namely, an abstract judgment with sufficient ground (essay on the principle of sufficient reason, §. 29 ff.). What is correctly cognized by the *understanding* is *reality*: namely, correct transition from the effect in the immediate object to its cause. Opposed to *truth* is *error*, as deception of *reason*; opposed to *reality* is *semblance*, as deception of the *understanding*. A fuller discussion of all this may be read in the first chapter of my essay *On Vision and Colors*.

Semblance arises when one and the same effect can be brought about by two entirely different causes, one of which acts very frequently, the other rarely. The understanding has no datum for distinguishing which cause is acting here, since the effect is exactly the same; it therefore always presupposes the usual cause. And because its activity is not reflective and discursive, but direct and immediate, such a false cause stands before us as an intuited object. This is false semblance.

I have shown in the place cited how double vision and double touch arise in this way when the sense organs are brought into an unusual position, and have thereby given an irrefutable proof that intuition exists only through the understanding and for the understanding.

Further examples of such deception of the understanding, or semblance, are the stick dipped into water, which appears broken; the images of spherical mirrors, which appear somewhat behind the surface in convex mirrors and far in front of it in concave mirrors. Also belonging here is the apparently greater extension of the moon at the horizon than at the zenith. This is not optical, for, as the micrometer proves, the eye takes in the moon at the zenith at an angle of vision that is even somewhat larger than at the horizon. Rather, it is the understanding that assumes a greater distance as the cause of the weaker brightness of the moon and all stars at the horizon, estimating them like earthly objects according to aerial perspective. It therefore takes the moon at the horizon to be much larger than at the zenith, and at the same time takes the vault of heaven to be more extended at the horizon, that is, flattened.

The same wrongly applied estimate according to aerial perspective makes us take very high mountains, whose summits alone are visible to us in pure, transparent air, to be nearer than they are, to the detriment of their height: for example, Mont Blanc as seen from Salenche.

All such deceptive semblances stand before us in immediate intuition, and no reasoning of reason can remove them. Reasoning can only prevent error, that is, a judgment without sufficient ground, by means of an opposed true judgment. Thus one can cognize in abstracto that the cause of the weaker brightness of the moon and stars is not their greater distance, but the hazier vapors at the horizon. But the semblance remains immovable in all the cases mentioned, despite every abstract cognition.

For the understanding is completely and sharply distinct from reason, a faculty of cognition that has been added only in the human being; and the understanding in itself is, even in the human being, without reason. Reason can only ever *know*; intuition remains for the understanding alone, free from reason's influence.

§. 7.

With regard to our whole consideration so far, the following should still be carefully noted. We have not started from the object, nor from the subject, but from *representation*, which already contains and presupposes them both; for division into object and subject is its first, most universal, and most essential form.

We therefore first considered this form as such. Then, though here referring mainly to the introductory essay, we considered the other forms subordinate to it: time, space, and causality. These belong only to the *object*; yet because they are essential to the object *as such*, while the object is in turn essential to the subject *as such*, they can also be found from the side of the subject, that is, cognized a priori (prior to experience), and in this respect they are to be regarded as the common boundary of both. All of them, however, can be traced back to one common expression, the principle of sufficient reason, as is shown in detail in the introductory essay.

This procedure distinguishes our way of considering things entirely from all philosophies ever attempted. Those philosophies all started either from the object or from the subject, and accordingly tried to explain one from the other, indeed according to the principle of sufficient reason. We, by contrast, withdraw the relation between object and subject from the dominion of that principle, leaving to it only the object.

One might think that the identity philosophy, which has arisen in our own day and become generally known, is not included under the opposition just stated. For it makes neither object nor subject the true first starting point, but a third thing: the absolute, knowable through rational intuition, which is neither object nor subject, but the sameness of both.

Although, from complete lack of all rational intuition, I shall not presume to join in speaking of that venerable sameness and the absolute, I must nevertheless, relying only on the records of the rational intuiters that lie open to everyone, even to us profane people, observe that this philosophy is not exempt from the opposition of the two errors set out above. For despite the identity of subject and object, which is not thinkable but only intellectually intuitable, or to be experienced by sinking oneself into it, that philosophy still does not avoid the two opposed errors. Rather, it merely unites both within itself.

It divides into two disciplines. The first is transcendental idealism, which is Fichte's doctrine of the I and accordingly, after the principle of sufficient reason, has the object produced by, or spun out of, the subject. The second is philosophy of nature, which likewise lets the subject gradually come to be out of the object, by applying a method called construction. Of this method very little is clear to me, but this much is clear: it is a progression according to the principle of sufficient reason in various forms.

I renounce the deep wisdom contained in that construction; for to me, who entirely lack rational intuition, all lectures that presuppose it must be a book sealed with seven seals. Indeed this is so much the case that, strange to say, with those doctrines of deep wisdom it always seems to me as if I heard nothing but dreadful, and moreover extremely boring, bombast.

The systems that start from the object have indeed always had the whole intuitive world and its order as their problem. Yet the object they take as their starting point is not always this world itself, nor its basic element, matter. Rather, in accordance with the four classes of possible objects set out in the introductory essay, one can divide those systems as follows.

One may say that the following started from the first of those classes, or the real world: Thales and the Ionians, Democritus, Epicurus, Giordano Bruno, and the French materialists. From the second class, or the abstract concept, started Spinoza, namely from the merely abstract concept of substance, which exists only in its definition; and earlier, the Eleatics. From the third class, namely time and therefore numbers, started the Pythagoreans and Chinese philosophy in the *I Ching*. Finally, from the fourth class, namely the act of will motivated by cognition, started the Scholastics, who teach a creation from nothing through the act of will of an extra-worldly personal being.

The objective procedure is most consistent and can be carried out furthest when it appears as materialism proper. Materialism posits matter, and with it time and space, as existing absolutely, and skips over the relation to the subject in which all this alone exists. It further takes the law of causality as the guiding thread along which it wants to advance, taking it as an order of things existing in itself, a *veritas aeterna* (eternal truth), and thus skipping over the understanding, in which and for which alone causality exists.

Materialism then seeks to find the first, simplest state of matter, and from it to develop all others, ascending from mere mechanism to chemism, polarity, vegetation, and animality. Suppose this succeeded: the last link of the chain

would be animal sensibility, cognition, which would then appear as a mere modification of matter, a state of matter brought about by causality.

Now if we had followed materialism this far with intuitive representations, then, once we arrived with it at its summit, we would feel a sudden attack of the inextinguishable laughter of the Olympians. Waking as if from a dream, we would suddenly become aware that its final result, cognition, brought about with such effort, was already presupposed as an indispensable condition at the very first starting point, mere matter. We had imagined, with materialism, that we were thinking matter, but in fact we had thought nothing other than the subject representing matter, the eye that sees it, the hand that feels it, the understanding that cognizes it.

Thus the enormous *petitio principii* (begging of the question) unexpectedly reveals itself: the last link suddenly appears as the support on which the first already hung, and the chain as a circle. The materialist resembles Baron Munchausen, who, while swimming on horseback in the water, pulls the horse upward with his legs and himself upward by the braid thrown forward over his head.

Accordingly, the fundamental absurdity of materialism consists in this: it starts from the *objective*, and takes something *objective* as the ultimate ground of explanation. This may be matter in abstracto (in the abstract), as it is only *thought*, or it may be matter already entered into form, empirically given, and thus material stuff: perhaps the chemical elements, together with their nearest compounds. Materialism takes such things as existing in themselves and absolutely, in order to let organic nature and finally the knowing subject arise from them, thereby explaining both completely.

In truth, however, everything objective, already as such, is conditioned in manifold ways by the knowing subject and by the forms of its cognition, and has these as its presupposition. Therefore it disappears entirely if one thinks the subject away.

Materialism is thus the attempt to explain what is immediately given to us from what is given only mediately. Everything objective, extended, acting, and therefore everything material, which materialism regards as so solid a foundation for its explanations that a reduction to it, especially if it finally came down to impact and counter-impact, could leave nothing more to be desired: all this is given only in the highest degree mediately and conditionally, and is therefore only relatively present. For it has passed through the machinery and

fabrication of the brain, and has therefore entered into its forms, time, space, and causality, by virtue of which alone it presents itself as extended in space and acting in time.

From something given in this way, materialism now wants to explain even what is immediately given: representation, in which all that stands there, and in the end even the will, from which, on the contrary, all those fundamental forces that manifest themselves along the guiding thread of causes, and therefore lawfully, are in truth to be explained.

The assertion that cognition is a modification of matter is therefore always opposed, with equal right, by the reverse assertion that all matter is only a modification of the subject's cognition, as its representation. Nevertheless, the goal and ideal of all natural science is, at bottom, a completely carried out materialism. That we recognize this here as obviously impossible confirms another truth that will result from our further consideration: that all science in the strict sense, by which I mean systematic cognition along the guiding thread of the principle of sufficient reason, can never reach a final goal or give a fully satisfying explanation, because it never reaches the innermost essence of the world, never gets beyond representation, and at bottom teaches nothing more than the relation of one representation to another.

Every science always starts from two chief data. One of these is always the principle of sufficient reason in some form as organon; the other is its particular object as problem. Geometry, for example, has space as its problem and the ground of being in space as its organon. Arithmetic has time as problem and the ground of being in time as organon. Logic has the connections of concepts as such for its problem, and the ground of knowing as organon. History has the deeds of human beings that have happened, on a large scale and in the mass, for its problem, and the law of motivation as organon.

Natural science has matter as its problem and the law of causality as organon. Its aim and purpose, accordingly, is to reduce all possible states of matter to one another, and finally to one state, along the guiding thread of causality; and again to derive them from one another, and finally from one state.

Two states therefore stand opposed in natural science as extremes: the state of matter in which it is least immediate object of the subject, and the state in which it is most so; that is, the deadeast, crudest matter, the first basic stuff, and then the human organism. Natural science seeks the first as chemistry, the second as physiology. Up to now, however, both extremes remain unreached,

and only something between them has been gained. The prospect is also rather hopeless.

The chemists, on the assumption that the qualitative division of matter will not go on to infinity as the quantitative division does, seek to reduce more and more the number of their elements, still now about sixty. And if they had arrived at two, they would want to reduce these to one. For the law of homogeneity leads to the assumption of a first chemical state of matter, preceding all others, which are not essential to matter as such but only accidental forms or qualities, and which alone belongs to matter as such.

On the other hand, it is impossible to see how this first state, since there was not yet a second state to act upon it, could ever have undergone a chemical alteration. Here in chemistry, therefore, the same embarrassment appears that Epicurus encountered in mechanics when he had to explain how the first atom deviated from the original direction of its motion. Indeed, this contradiction, which develops entirely of itself and can neither be avoided nor resolved, could quite properly be set up as a chemical *antinomy*. As it appears here at the first of the two extremes sought by natural science, so at the second a corresponding counterpart will show itself to us.

There is just as little hope of reaching this other extreme of natural science, since it is becoming increasingly clear that something chemical can never be reduced to something mechanical, nor something organic to something chemical or electrical. Those who today strike out again on this old wrong path will soon creep back, like all their predecessors, silently and ashamed. More will be said about this in the following book.

The difficulties mentioned only in passing here confront natural science on its own territory. Taken as philosophy, however, natural science would furthermore be materialism; and materialism, as we have seen, carries death in its heart from birth, because it skips over the subject and the forms of cognition. These are presupposed just as much by the crudest matter from which materialism would like to begin as by the organism at which it would like to arrive.

For "no object without subject" is the proposition that forever makes all materialism impossible. Suns and planets without an eye that sees them and an understanding that cognizes them can certainly be said in words; but for representation these words are a *Sideroxylon* (ironwood).

Yet on the other hand, the law of causality and the consideration and investigation of nature that follows it necessarily leads us to the secure assumption that, in time, every more highly organized state of matter has followed only after a cruder one: animals before human beings, fish before land animals, plants before even these, the inorganic before everything organic. Consequently, the original mass had to pass through a long series of alterations before the first eye could open.

And yet the existence of that whole world always remains dependent on this first eye that opened, even if it belonged to an insect, as the necessary mediator of cognition for which and in which alone the world is and without which it cannot even be thought. For the world is representation through and through, and as such requires the knowing subject as bearer of its existence.

Indeed, that long temporal series itself, filled with countless alterations through which matter rose from form to form until at last the first knowing animal came to be, is itself thinkable only in the identity of a consciousness whose succession of representations, whose form of cognition, it is; outside that consciousness, it loses all meaning and is nothing at all.

Thus we see, on the one hand, the existence of the whole world necessarily dependent on the first knowing being, however imperfect it may be; and, on the other hand, this first knowing animal just as necessarily entirely dependent on a long chain of causes and effects that preceded it, into which it enters as a small link.

These two contradictory views, to each of which we are in fact led with equal necessity, could indeed again be called an *antinomy* in our faculty of cognition, and set up as the counterpart to the one found at the first extreme of natural science. Kant's fourfold antinomy, by contrast, will be shown in the critique of his philosophy appended to the present work to be a baseless sham fight.

The contradiction that has necessarily arisen for us here, however, finds its resolution in the fact that, to speak in Kant's language, time, space, and causality do not belong to the thing in itself, but only to its appearance, whose form they are. In my language this means that the objective world, the world as representation, is not the only side of the world, but only one side, as it were the outer side, which still has a wholly different side: its innermost essence, its kernel, the thing in itself. This we shall consider in the following book, naming it, after the most immediate of its objectivations, will.

The world as representation, however, which alone we are considering here, does indeed begin only with the opening of the first eye. Without this medium of cognition it cannot be, and therefore it also was not before. But without that eye, that is, outside cognition, there was also no before, no time.

For this reason, time has no beginning; rather, every beginning is in time. But since time is the most universal form of knowability, into which all appearances fit by means of the bond of causality, time too stands there, with its whole infinity on both sides, with the first cognition. The appearance that fills this first present must at the same time be known as causally connected with, and dependent on, a series of appearances extending infinitely into the past. Yet this past itself is just as much conditioned by this first present as, conversely, this present is conditioned by that past.

Thus, like the first present, the past from which it comes depends on the knowing subject and is nothing without it. Nevertheless, it brings with it the necessity that this first present presents itself not as the first, not as having no past for mother and as the beginning of time, but as the consequence of the past according to the ground of being in time; and likewise that the appearance filling it presents itself as the effect of earlier states filling that past, according to the law of causality.

Anyone fond of mythological interpretations may regard the birth of Kronos, χρόνος (time), the youngest Titan, as a symbol of the moment expressed here: the entrance of time, which nevertheless has no beginning. For with Kronos, since he castrates his father, the crude products of heaven and earth cease, and now the race of gods and human beings takes the stage.

This presentation, which we reached by following the most consistent of the philosophical systems that start from the object, materialism, also serves to make intuitively clear the inseparable mutual dependence, along with the irreducible opposition, between subject and object. This cognition leads us to seek the innermost essence of the world, the thing in itself, no longer in either of those two elements of representation, but rather in something wholly different from representation, something not afflicted with such an original, essential, and irresolvable opposition.

The procedure just discussed, which starts from the object in order to let the subject arise from it, is opposed by the procedure that starts from the subject and wants to make the object issue from it. As frequent and general as the former procedure has been in all previous philosophy, there is properly only a

single example of the latter, and a very recent one: the sham philosophy of J. G. Fichte. In this respect it must be noted, however little genuine value and inner content his doctrine had in itself, indeed however much it was altogether only a sham fight. Presented with the air of deepest seriousness, sustained tone, and lively zeal, and defended with eloquent polemic against weak opponents, it could nevertheless shine and seem to be something.

But the genuine seriousness that, inaccessible to all external influences, keeps its goal, truth, steadily in view was entirely lacking in him, as in all similar philosophers who accommodate themselves to circumstances. This could hardly have been otherwise. One always becomes a philosopher through a perplexity from which one seeks to free oneself; this is Plato's θαυμάζειν (wonder), which he calls a μάλα φιλοσοφικόν πάθος (a very philosophical passion).

Here, however, what separates inauthentic philosophers from authentic ones is this: for the latter, that perplexity arises from looking at the world itself; for the former, it arises only from a book, from an existing system. This was Fichte's case, for he became a philosopher only over Kant's thing in itself, and without it he would most likely have pursued quite different things with much better success, since he possessed considerable rhetorical talent.

Had he penetrated even somewhat deeply into the meaning of the book that made him a philosopher, the *Critique of Pure Reason*, he would have understood that its main doctrine, according to its spirit, is this: the principle of sufficient reason is not, as all scholastic philosophy maintains, a veritas aeterna (eternal truth), that is, it does not have unconditional validity before, outside, and above all the world. Rather, it has only relative and conditioned validity, valid solely in appearance, whether it appears as the necessary nexus of space or of time, or as the law of causality, or as the law of the ground of knowledge.

Therefore the inner essence of the world, the thing in itself, can never be found along the guiding thread of that principle. Everything to which the principle leads is always itself again dependent and relative, always only appearance, not thing in itself. Further, the principle does not concern the subject at all, but is only the form of objects, which precisely for that reason are not things in themselves; and with the object the subject is already immediately there, and with the subject the object is there. Thus neither can the object first be added to the subject, nor the subject to the object, as consequent to its ground.

But none of this adhered in the least to Fichte. What alone interested him in the matter was the *starting from the subject*, which Kant had chosen in order to show that the previous starting from the object, which had thereby become the thing in itself, was false. Fichte, however, took this starting from the subject to be the essential point. Like all imitators, he thought that if he outdid Kant in this, he would also surpass him; and so he repeated in this direction the errors that previous dogmatism had committed in the opposite direction, and which had occasioned Kant's critique.

Thus in the main matter nothing had changed. The old fundamental error, the assumption of a relation of ground and consequent between object and subject, remained as before. The principle of sufficient reason therefore retained, just as before, unconditional validity; and the thing in itself, instead of being placed as formerly in the object, was now placed in the subject of cognition. The complete relativity of these two, which indicates that the thing in itself, or inner essence of the world, is to be sought not in them but outside this pair, as outside everything else that exists only relatively, remained unrecognized as before.

As if Kant had never existed, the principle of sufficient reason is still for Fichte exactly what it was for all the Scholastics: an *aeterna veritas* (eternal truth). Just as eternal fate still ruled over the gods of antiquity, so those *aeternae veritates* (eternal truths), that is, the metaphysical, mathematical, and metalogical truths, and for some also the validity of the moral law, still ruled over the God of the Scholastics. These truths alone depended on nothing; through their necessity, however, both God and world existed.

According to the principle of sufficient reason as such a *veritas aeterna*, the I is therefore, for Fichte, the ground of the world or of the non-I, of the object, which is precisely its consequent, its product. He therefore carefully avoided examining or checking the principle of sufficient reason any further.

If I had to state the form of that principle along whose guiding thread Fichte lets the non-I emerge from the I, as the web from the spider, I find that it is the principle of the ground of being in space. For only with reference to this do those painful deductions of the way in which the I produces and fabricates the non-I out of itself, which make up the content of the most senseless and therefore most boring book ever written, receive any sort of sense and meaning.

This Fichtean philosophy, otherwise not even worth mentioning, is therefore interesting to us only as the late-appearing true opposite of ancient materialism,

which was the most consistent starting from the object, just as Fichte's philosophy was the starting from the subject.

Just as materialism overlooked that with the simplest object it had immediately also posited the subject, so Fichte overlooked that with the subject, whatever title he wished to give it, he had not only already posited the object, since no subject can be thought without one; he also overlooked that all derivation a priori, indeed all proof in general, rests on necessity, while all necessity rests solely on the principle of sufficient reason. For being necessary and following from a given ground are interchangeable concepts.^[1]

But the principle of sufficient reason is nothing other than the universal form of the object as such, and therefore already presupposes the object. It cannot, valid before and outside the object, first bring the object about and let it arise in conformity with its legislation. In general, then, the starting from the subject shares with the starting from the object presented above the same error: it assumes in advance what it claims first to derive, namely the necessary correlate of its starting point.

Our procedure is distinguished from both these opposed mistakes *toto genere* (in kind altogether), since we start neither from the object nor from the subject, but from *representation*, as the first fact of consciousness. The first, most essential basic form of representation is the division into object and subject. The form of the object, again, is the principle of sufficient reason in its various forms, each of which governs its own class of representations so thoroughly that, as shown, with cognition of that form the essence of the whole class is also cognized, since the class, as representation, is nothing other than that form itself.

Thus time itself is nothing other than the ground of being in it, that is, succession; space nothing other than the principle of sufficient reason in it, that is, position; matter nothing other than causality; the concept, as will immediately appear, nothing other than relation to the ground of knowledge.

This complete and thoroughgoing relativity of the world as representation, both according to its most universal form, subject and object, and according to the form subordinate to this, the principle of sufficient reason, points us, as said, toward seeking the inner essence of the world on an entirely different side of it, one *wholly different from representation*. The next book will show this in a fact equally immediately certain to every living being.

Before that, however, we must still consider the class of representations that belongs to the human being alone, whose material is the *concept* and whose subjective correlate is *reason*, just as the subjective correlates of the representations considered up to now were understanding and sensibility, which are also to be attributed to every animal. ^[2]

Notes

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1. See on this *The Fourfold Root of the Principle of Sufficient Reason*, 2nd ed., §. 49. ↩
2. The first four chapters of the first book of the supplements belong to these first seven sections. ↩

§. 8.

As from the immediate light of the sun into the borrowed reflection of the moon, so we pass from intuitive, immediate representation, which represents and vouches for itself, over to reflection: to the abstract, discursive concepts of reason, which have all their content only from that intuitive cognition and in relation to it.

So long as we conduct ourselves purely intuitively, everything is clear, firm, and certain. There are no questions, no doubts, no errors. One does not want to go further, cannot go further; one has rest in intuition, satisfaction in the present. Intuition is sufficient to itself. Therefore what has sprung purely from it and remained faithful to it, such as the genuine work of art, can never be false, nor can it be refuted by any time; for there is no opinion there, but the thing itself.

But with abstract cognition, with reason, doubt and error have entered in theoretical matters, and care and remorse in practical matters. If in intuitive representation *semblance* momentarily distorts actuality, then in abstract representation *error* can rule for millennia, cast its iron yoke over whole peoples, stifle the noblest stirrings of humanity, and even have those whom it cannot deceive bound in chains by its slaves, its deceived followers.

Error is the enemy against which the wisest minds of all ages have waged the unequal struggle; and only what they have wrested from it has become the property of humanity. It is therefore good to draw attention to it at once, as we enter the ground on which its domain lies.

It has often been said that one should pursue truth even where no use from it can be foreseen, since that use may be indirect and emerge where one does not expect it. I find, however, that I must add here that one should also strive just as much to uncover and eradicate every error, even where no harm from it can be foreseen, since that harm too may be very indirect and one day emerge where one does not expect it. For every error carries a poison within it.

If it is spirit, if it is cognition, that makes the human being lord of the earth, then there are no harmless errors, still less venerable, holy errors. And for the consolation of those who devote strength and life to the noble and difficult struggle against error, in whatever kind or matter, I cannot refrain from adding this: so long as truth is not yet present, error can play its game, like owls and

bats in the night. But one might sooner expect owls and bats to chase the sun back into the east than that truth, once recognized and clearly and completely expressed, should be displaced again so that the old error may once more occupy its broad place undisturbed. Such is the power of truth: its victory is difficult and laborious, but once won, it cannot be taken from it again.

Besides the representations considered up to this point, which in their composition could be traced back to time, space, and matter if we look to the object, or to pure sensibility and understanding, that is, cognition of causality, if we look to the subject, there has entered in the human being alone, among all the inhabitants of the earth, another power of cognition. An entirely new consciousness has dawned, very aptly and with anticipatory correctness called *reflection*.

For reflection is indeed a reflected light, something derived from intuitive cognition. Yet it has taken on a nature and character fundamentally different from that cognition; it does not know its forms, and even the principle of sufficient reason, which governs every object, has here an entirely different form. This new consciousness, raised to a higher power, this abstract reflection of everything intuitive in the non-intuitive concept of reason, is what alone gives the human being that reflective awareness which so thoroughly distinguishes his consciousness from that of animals, and through which his whole conduct on earth turns out so differently from that of his non-rational brothers.

He surpasses them equally in power and in suffering. They live in the present alone; he lives at the same time in future and past. They satisfy the need of the moment; he makes the most elaborate arrangements for his future, indeed for times he cannot live to see. They are wholly given over to the impression of the moment, to the effect of the intuitive motive; he is determined by abstract concepts independently of the present.

Therefore he carries out deliberate plans or acts according to maxims, without regard to his surroundings and the accidental impressions of the moment. Thus, for example, he can calmly make artificial arrangements for his own death; he can dissemble to the point of inscrutability and take his secret with him to the grave. Finally, he has a real choice between several motives. For only in abstracto (in the abstract) can such motives, present side by side in consciousness, bring with them the cognition that one excludes the other, and so measure their power over the will against one another. Then the motive that

predominates, by giving the deciding stroke, is the deliberate decision of the will and makes known its character as a sure sign.

The animal, by contrast, is determined by the present impression. Only fear of present compulsion can tame its desire, until that fear has finally become habit and now determines it as such: this is training. The animal senses and intuitively; the human being also *thinks* and *knows*. Both *will*.

The animal communicates its sensation and mood by gesture and sound. The human being communicates thoughts to another by language, or conceals thoughts by language. Language is the first product and the necessary instrument of his reason. Hence in Greek and Italian, language and reason are designated by the same word: ὁ λόγος and il discorso (discourse). Vernunft, reason, comes from Vernehmen, to apprehend, which is not synonymous with hearing, but means becoming aware of thoughts communicated through words.

Only with the help of language does reason bring about its most important achievements: the concordant action of several individuals, the planned cooperation of many thousands, civilization, the state; further, science, the preservation of earlier experience, the gathering of what is common into one concept, the communication of truth, the spread of error, thinking and poetry, dogmas and superstitions.

The animal first comes to know death in death. The human being consciously approaches his death every hour, and this sometimes makes life questionable even for the one who has not already recognized this character of constant annihilation in life as a whole. Chiefly for this reason the human being has philosophies and religions; yet whether what we rightly value above all in his action, voluntary right-doing and nobility of disposition, has ever been the fruit of either is uncertain. By contrast, as secure products belonging to them alone, and as productions of reason along this path, there stand the strangest and most adventurous opinions of philosophers of different schools, and the oddest, sometimes also cruel, practices of priests of different religions.

That all these very diverse and far-reaching manifestations spring from one common principle, from that special power of mind that the human being has over the animal and that has been called *reason*, ὁ λόγος, τὸ λογιστικόν, τὸ λόγιον, ratio, is the unanimous opinion of all ages and peoples.

All human beings also know very well how to recognize the manifestations of this faculty, and how to say what is rational and what is irrational, where reason appears in contrast with other capacities and qualities of the human

being, and finally what, because of the lack of reason, is never to be expected even from the cleverest animal.

The philosophers of all ages also speak, on the whole, in agreement with that common knowledge of reason, and in addition emphasize several especially important manifestations of it, such as mastery over affects and passions, the capacity to make inferences and to set up universal principles, even principles certain prior to all experience, and so on. Yet all their explanations of the proper essence of reason are wavering, not sharply determined, diffuse, without unity or center, now emphasizing this manifestation, now that one, and therefore often diverging from one another.

In addition, many of them start from the opposition between reason and revelation, which is entirely foreign to philosophy and serves only to increase the confusion. It is highly striking that until now no philosopher has strictly traced all those manifold manifestations of reason back to one simple function, recognizable in them all, from which they could all be explained and which would therefore constitute the proper inner essence of reason.

To be sure, the excellent Locke, in *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*, Book 2, chapter 11, §§. 10 and 11, quite correctly gives abstract universal concepts as the distinguishing character between animal and human being; and Leibniz repeats this in complete agreement in the *New Essays on Human Understanding*, Book 2, chapter 11, §§. 10 and 11.

But when Locke, in Book 4, chapter 17, §§. 2 and 3, comes to the actual explanation of reason, he entirely loses sight of that simple chief characteristic of it, and likewise falls into a wavering, indeterminate, incomplete account of its fragmented and derivative manifestations. Leibniz, in the corresponding passage of his work, behaves on the whole in the same way, only with more confusion and obscurity.

I have spoken at length in the appendix about how greatly Kant confused and falsified the concept of the essence of reason. But anyone who takes the trouble to go through, from this point of view, the mass of philosophical writings that have appeared since Kant will recognize that just as the errors of princes are paid for by whole peoples, so the errors of great minds spread their harmful influence over whole generations, even over centuries, indeed growing and propagating themselves until they finally degenerate into monstrosities. All this follows from the fact that, as Berkeley says:

Few men think; yet all will have opinions. ^[1]

Just as the understanding has only *one* function, immediate cognition of the relation of cause and effect, and just as intuition of the actual world, as well as all prudence, sagacity, and inventiveness, however varied their application may be, are quite obviously nothing other than manifestations of that simple function, so reason too has *one* function: formation of the concept. From this one function all the phenomena mentioned above, which distinguish the life of the human being from that of the animal, are very easily and entirely self-evidently explained. Everything that has everywhere and always been called rational or irrational points simply to the application or non-application of that function. ^[2]

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Notes

1. Few human beings think, but all want to have opinions. ↩
2. Compare with this section §§. 26 and 27 of the second edition of the essay on the principle of sufficient reason. ↩

§. 9.

Concepts form a peculiar class, different *toto genere* (in kind altogether) from the intuitive representations considered so far, and present only in the human mind. We can therefore never obtain an intuitive, properly evident cognition of their essence, but only an abstract and discursive one.

It would therefore be absurd to demand that they be demonstrated in experience, if by experience one understands the real external world, which is precisely intuitive representation, or that they be brought before the eyes, or before the imagination, like intuitive objects. They can only be thought, not intuited; and only the effects that the human being produces through them are objects of genuine experience. Such effects are language, deliberate and methodical action, and science; then what results from all of these.

Clearly speech, as an object of outer experience, is nothing other than a very perfect telegraph, communicating arbitrary signs with the greatest speed and the finest nuance. But what do these signs mean? How are they interpreted? While another person speaks, do we perhaps at once translate his speech into images of the imagination, which flash past us, move, connect, transform, and paint themselves out in accordance with the incoming words and their grammatical inflections? What a tumult there would be in our head while listening to a speech or reading a book!

That is not at all how it happens. The meaning of speech is immediately apprehended, grasped exactly and determinately, without phantasms as a rule mixing themselves in. It is reason speaking to reason, remaining within its own domain; and what it communicates and receives are abstract concepts, non-intuitive representations that, once formed and relatively few in number, nevertheless comprise, contain, and represent all the innumerable objects of the actual world.

From this alone it is explicable that no animal can ever speak and apprehend speech, although it has the organs of language and also the intuitive representations in common with us. But precisely because words designate that wholly peculiar class of representations whose subjective correlate is reason, they are without sense and meaning for the animal.

Thus language, like every other appearance that we ascribe to reason, and like everything that distinguishes the human being from the animal, is to be

explained from this one simple source: concepts, the abstract, non-intuitive, universal representations that are not individual in time and space.

Only in particular cases do we pass from concepts to intuition, forming phantasms for ourselves as intuitive *representatives of concepts*, to which, however, they are never adequate. These have been discussed especially in the essay on the principle of sufficient reason, §. 28; therefore I will not repeat the same thing here. What is said there should be compared with what Hume says in the twelfth of his *Philosophical Essays*, p. 244, and what Herder says in the *Metacritique* (an otherwise bad book), part 1, p. 274. The Platonic Idea, made possible by the union of imagination and reason, constitutes the chief subject of the third book of the present work.

Although, then, concepts are fundamentally different from intuitive representations, they nevertheless stand in a necessary relation to them; without that relation they would be nothing, and it therefore constitutes their whole essence and existence. Reflection is necessarily a copy, a repetition, of the archetypal intuitive world, though a copy of a quite special kind, in a wholly heterogeneous material. For this reason concepts may quite fittingly be called representations of representations.

Here too the principle of sufficient reason has a special form. And just as the form under which it governs a class of representations always really makes up and exhausts the whole essence of that class, insofar as they are representations, so that, as we have seen, time is through and through succession and nothing else, space through and through position and nothing else, matter through and through causality and nothing else: so too the whole essence of concepts, or of the class of abstract representations, consists solely in the relation expressed in them by the principle of sufficient reason.

Since this relation is the relation to the ground of knowing, the abstract representation has its entire essence solely and exclusively in its relation to another representation that is its ground of knowing. This may indeed at first be another concept, or abstract representation; and this too may have only another such abstract ground of knowing. But this cannot go on to infinity. In the end the series of grounds of knowing must close with a concept that has its ground in intuitive cognition. For the whole world of reflection rests on the intuitive world as its ground of knowing.

The class of abstract representations is therefore distinguished from the others by this: in the others, the principle of sufficient reason always demands

only a relation to another representation of the *same* class; in abstract representations, however, it finally demands a relation to a representation from a *different* class.

Those concepts that, as just indicated, relate to intuitive cognition not immediately but only through the mediation of one or even several other concepts have been called, in the narrower sense, abstracta (abstracts); by contrast, those that have their ground immediately in the intuitive world have been called concreta (concretes). This latter designation, however, fits the concepts it designates only quite improperly, since they too are still always abstracta and by no means intuitive representations.

Those names arose only from a very indistinct consciousness of the difference meant by them; nevertheless, with the interpretation given here, they may remain. Examples of the first kind, therefore abstracta in the eminent sense, are concepts such as "relation," "virtue," "investigation," "beginning," and so on. Examples of the latter kind, or of what are improperly called concreta, are the concepts "human being," "stone," "horse," and so on. If it were not a somewhat too pictorial comparison, and thereby one that falls into playfulness, one could very aptly call the latter the ground floor, and the former the upper stories, of the building of reflection. ^[1]

That a concept comprehends many things under itself, that is, that many intuitive representations, or even again many abstract representations, stand in relation to it as their ground of knowing, that is, are thought through it, is not, as is usually stated, an essential property of the concept, but only a derived and secondary one. Indeed, it need not always exist in actuality, though it must always exist as a possibility.

That property flows from the fact that the concept is the representation of a representation, that is, that it has its whole essence solely in its relation to another representation. But since it is not this representation itself, and since the latter usually belongs to an entirely different class of representations, namely to intuitive representations, it can have temporal, spatial, and other determinations, and in general many further relations, that are not thought along with the concept. Therefore several representations that differ in what is inessential can be thought through the same concept, that is, can be subsumed under it.

But this validity for several things is not an essential property of the concept; it is only accidental. There can therefore be concepts through which only one single real object is thought, yet which are still abstract and universal, and by no

means individual and intuitive representations. Such is, for example, the concept someone has of a particular city that he knows only from geography. Although only this one city is thought through it, several cities differing in some respects would still be possible to all of which it would apply.

Thus a concept does not have universality because it has been abstracted from several objects; rather, conversely, because universality, that is, non-determination of the individual, is essential to it as an abstract representation of reason, different things can be thought through the same concept.

From what has been said it follows that every concept, precisely because it is an abstract and not an intuitive representation, and therefore not determined through and through, has what is called an extension or sphere, even in the case where only one single real object exists that corresponds to it.

Now we find throughout that the sphere of every concept has something in common with the spheres of others: that is, in it there is thought in part the same thing that is thought in those others, and in them again in part the same thing that is thought in the first; although, if they are really different concepts, each, or at least one of the two, contains something that the other does not. Every subject stands in this relation to its predicate. To recognize this relation is called *judging*.

The representation of those spheres by spatial figures is an exceedingly fortunate idea. Gottfried Plouquet was probably the first to have it; he used squares for this purpose. Lambert, though after him, still used mere lines that he placed beneath one another. Euler was the first to carry it out completely with circles.

I cannot say on what this very exact analogy between the relations of concepts and those of spatial figures ultimately rests. Meanwhile, it is a very favorable circumstance for logic that all relations of concepts, even according to their possibility, that is, a priori (prior to experience), can be intuitively represented by such figures, in the following way:

1. The spheres of two concepts are wholly equal: for example, the concept of necessity and the concept of consequent from a given ground; likewise that of Ruminantia and Bisulca (ruminants and split-hoofed animals); also that of vertebrates and red-blooded animals, although something could be objected here because of the annelids. These are coextensive concepts. A single circle then represents them, signifying both one and the other.

2. The sphere of one concept wholly includes that of another:

3. One sphere includes two or more that exclude one another and at the same time fill the sphere:

4. Two spheres each include a part of the other:

5. Two spheres lie within a third, though they do not fill it:

This last case holds for all concepts whose spheres have no immediate community, since a third, though often very wide, will always include both.

All combinations of concepts may be reducible to these cases, and the entire doctrine of judgments, their conversion, contraposition, reciprocation, and disjunction (the latter according to the third figure), can be derived from them. So too can the properties of judgments on which Kant founded the alleged categories of the understanding, with the exception, however, of the hypothetical form, which is no longer a combination of mere concepts but of judgments; and then with the exception of modality, about which, as about every property of judgments that is laid at the basis of the categories, the appendix gives detailed account.

With regard to the possible concept-combinations indicated above, it remains only to note that they can also be variously combined with one another, for example, the fourth figure with the second. Only when a sphere that wholly or partly contains another is itself again wholly included by a third do these together represent the syllogism in the first figure: that is, the combination of judgments through which it is cognized that a concept wholly or partly contained in another is also contained in a third that in turn contains this other. Or they represent the converse of this, negation; its pictorial representation can naturally consist only in two connected spheres not lying within a third. If many spheres enclose one another in this way, long chains of syllogisms arise.

This schematism of concepts, which has already been worked out fairly well in several textbooks, can be made the basis of the doctrine of judgments as well as of the whole of syllogistic, whereby the presentation of both becomes very easy and simple. For all their rules can be understood, derived, and explained from it according to their origin.

It is not necessary, however, to load these rules upon the memory, since logic can never be of practical use, but only of theoretical interest for philosophy. For although one might say that logic stands to rational thinking as thoroughbass stands to music, and also, if we take it less exactly, as ethics stands to virtue, or

aesthetics to art, one must consider in reply that no artist has yet become one through the study of aesthetics, nor has a noble character become so through the study of ethics; that long before Rameau people composed correctly and beautifully; and also that one does not need to possess thoroughbass in order to notice disharmonies. Just as little does one need to know logic in order not to be deceived by fallacies.

Yet it must be admitted that, even if not for judgment, thoroughbass is nevertheless of great use for the exercise of musical composition. And aesthetics and even ethics may also, although to a much lesser degree, have some use for exercise, though chiefly a negative one; therefore not all practical value is to be denied them. But not even this much can be praised in logic. For it is merely knowledge in abstracto (in the abstract) of what everyone knows in concreto (in the concrete). Hence, just as little as one needs it in order not to assent to a false piece of reasoning, just as little does one call its rules to help in order to produce a correct one; and even the most learned logician sets them entirely aside in his actual thinking.

This is explained as follows. Every science consists of a system of universal, hence abstract, truths, laws, and rules with regard to some kind of object. The individual case that subsequently occurs under these is then determined each time according to that universal knowledge, which holds once for all, because such application of the universal is infinitely easier than investigating the individual case that occurs from the beginning on its own account. For the universal abstract cognition once attained always lies closer to hand for us than the empirical investigation of the individual.

With logic, however, it is just the reverse. It is the universal knowledge of reason's procedure, known through reason's self-observation and abstraction from all content, and expressed in the form of rules. But that procedure is necessary and essential to reason; therefore reason will deviate from it in no case, so long as it is left to itself.

It is therefore easier and safer to let reason proceed in accordance with its essence in each particular case than to hold before it knowledge first abstracted from that procedure, in the form of an alien law given from outside. It is easier because, although in all other sciences the universal rule lies closer to us than the investigation of the individual case alone and by itself, conversely, in the use of reason, the procedure of reason required in the given case always lies

closer to us than the universal rule abstracted from it, since what thinks in us is itself that reason.

It is safer because an error can much more easily occur in such abstract knowledge, or in its application, than a procedure of reason can arise that would run contrary to reason's essence and nature. From this comes the strange fact that, while in other sciences one tests the truth of the individual case by the rule, in logic, conversely, the rule must always be tested by the individual case; and even the most practiced logician, if he notices that in an individual case he infers otherwise than a rule states, will always sooner look for an error in the rule than in the inference he has actually made.

To want to make practical use of logic would therefore mean wanting first to derive from universal rules, with unspeakable effort, what in the individual case is immediately conscious to us with the greatest certainty. It would be just as if one wanted first to consult mechanics for one's movements and physiology for digestion; and whoever learns logic for practical purposes is like someone who wants to train a beaver to build its lodge.

Although logic is thus without practical use, it must nonetheless be retained, because it has philosophical interest as a special knowledge of the organization and action of reason. As a closed discipline, standing on its own, complete in itself, rounded off and perfectly certain, it is entitled to be treated scientifically on its own and independently of everything else, and likewise to be taught at universities. But it receives its real value only in connection with the whole of philosophy, in the consideration of cognition, and specifically of rational or abstract cognition.

Accordingly, its presentation should not so much have the form of a science directed toward practice, nor contain merely naked rules laid down for the correct conversion of judgments, inference, and so forth. Rather, it should be directed more toward the cognition of the essence of reason and of the concept, and toward a detailed consideration of the principle of sufficient reason of knowing. For logic is a mere paraphrase of this principle, and indeed really only for the case in which the ground that gives truth to judgments is not empirical or metaphysical, but logical or metalogical.

Alongside the principle of sufficient reason of knowing, the three other fundamental laws of thought that are so closely related to it, or judgments of metalogical truth, are therefore to be presented; from these the whole technique of reason then gradually grows. The essence of thinking proper, that is, of

judging and inferring, is to be represented from the connection of the concept-spheres according to the spatial schema in the way indicated above, and from this all the rules of judging and inferring are to be derived by construction.

The only practical use that can be made of logic is this: in disputation, one demonstrates to one's opponent, by naming them technically, not so much his actual false inferences as his intentional sophisms. By pushing back this practical orientation and emphasizing the connection of logic with the whole of philosophy, as one chapter of it, knowledge of it should nevertheless not become rarer than it is now. For today everyone who does not want to remain crude in the main matter, and to be counted among the ignorant multitude sunk in dullness, must have studied speculative philosophy. This is because this nineteenth century is a philosophical one; by which it is not meant so much that it possesses philosophy, or that philosophy is dominant in it, as rather that it is ripe for philosophy and precisely for that reason urgently needs it. This is a sign of highly advanced cultivation, indeed a fixed point on the scale of the culture of the ages. ^[2]

As little practical use as logic can have, it is nevertheless probably not to be denied that it was invented for practical purposes. I explain its origin to myself in the following way. When among the Eleatics, Megarians, and Sophists the pleasure in disputation developed more and more and gradually rose almost to an addiction, the confusion into which almost every disputation fell must soon have made them feel the necessity of a methodical procedure; and for guidance in this a scientific dialectic had to be sought.

The first thing that had to be noticed was that both contending parties always had to agree about some proposition to which the disputed points were to be traced back in disputation. The beginning of methodical procedure consisted in formally stating these commonly acknowledged propositions as such and placing them at the head of the inquiry. At first, however, these propositions concerned only the material aspect of the inquiry.

Soon it was perceived that, also in the manner in which one returned to the commonly acknowledged truth and sought to derive one's assertions from it, certain forms and laws were followed about which, even without previous agreement, people nevertheless never disagreed. From this it was seen that they must be the peculiar course of reason itself, lying in its own essence: the formal aspect of the inquiry.

Although this was not exposed to doubt and disagreement, some mind systematic to the point of pedantry nevertheless hit on the thought that it would look very fine, and would be the completion of methodical dialectic, if this formal element of all disputation too, this procedure of reason itself that is always law-governed, were likewise expressed in abstract propositions. These could then be placed, just like the commonly acknowledged propositions concerning the material aspect of the inquiry, at the head of the investigation as the fixed canon of disputation itself, to which one would always have to look back and appeal.

In this way, what had previously been followed as if by tacit agreement, or carried out as if instinctively, was now to be consciously acknowledged as law and formally expressed. Gradually, more or less complete expressions were found for logical principles, such as the principle of contradiction, of sufficient reason, and of excluded middle; the dictum de omni et nullo (the dictum concerning all and none); and then the more specific rules of syllogistic, such as *ex meris particularibus aut negativis nihil sequitur* (from merely particular or negative premises nothing follows), *a rationato ad rationem non valet consequentia* (from the consequent to the ground the inference is not valid), and so on.

That this was accomplished only slowly and with great effort, and that before Aristotle everything remained very incomplete, we see partly from the awkward and prolix manner in which logical truths are brought to light in some Platonic dialogues, but still better from what Sextus Empiricus reports to us about the disputes of the Megarians over the easiest and simplest logical laws, and the laborious way in which they brought such laws to clarity (Sext. Emp. adv. Math. L. 8. p. 112 seqq.). Aristotle, however, collected, ordered, and corrected what he found already at hand, and brought it to incomparably greater perfection.

If one observes in this way how the course of Greek culture prepared and brought about Aristotle's work, one will have little inclination to believe the claim of Persian writers, which *Jones*, very much taken with it, communicates to us: namely, that Callisthenes found a completed logic among the Indians and sent it to his uncle Aristotle (*Asiatic Researches*, vol. 4, p. 163).

It is easy to understand that in the sorrowful Middle Ages the Aristotelian logic had to be extremely welcome to the disputation-addicted spirit of the Scholastics, which, lacking all real knowledge, fed on formulas and words

alone; that even in its Arabic mutilation it was eagerly seized upon and soon elevated to the center of all knowledge. Although its prestige has since fallen, it has nevertheless maintained down to our time the credit of being an independent, practical, and highly necessary science. Indeed, in our day Kantian philosophy, which actually took its cornerstone from logic, has again awakened a new interest in it, which in this respect, that is, as a means to cognition of the essence of reason, it certainly deserves.

Just as correct, strict syllogisms come about by considering exactly the relation of the concept-spheres, and only when one sphere lies exactly within another and this one again wholly within a third does one also acknowledge the first to be wholly contained in the third; so, by contrast, the *art of persuasion* rests on subjecting the relations of concept-spheres only to a superficial consideration, and then determining them one-sidedly according to one's aims. This happens chiefly by presenting the sphere of a concept under consideration, when it lies only partly within another sphere but partly also within an entirely different one, as lying wholly in the first or wholly in the second, according to the speaker's intention.

For example, when passion is being discussed, one may subsume it at will under the concept of the greatest strength, the mightiest agency in the world, or under the concept of unreason, and this under that of impotence and weakness. The same procedure can then be continued and applied anew to every concept to which the speech leads.

Almost always several others share in the sphere of a concept, each of which contains on its own territory a part of the domain of the first, while itself also comprising still more beyond that. Of these latter concept-spheres, however, one allows only the one under which one wants to subsume the first concept to be illuminated, while leaving the others unnoticed or keeping them concealed.

All arts of persuasion and all subtler sophisms really rest on this artifice; for the logical sophisms, such as the *mentiens*, *velatus*, *cornutus* (liar, veiled man, horned man), and so forth, are obviously too crude for actual use. Since I do not know that anyone has so far traced the essence of all sophistry and persuasion back to this ultimate ground of its possibility, and shown it in the peculiar constitution of concepts, that is, in reason's way of knowing, I will, since my presentation has led me to it, illustrate the matter, easy as it is to see, by a schema on the accompanying plate. This is meant to show how the

concept-spheres variously intersect one another and thereby give arbitrary choice room to pass from any concept to this or that other one.

I only hope that the plate will not lead anyone to attach more importance to this small incidental discussion than it can have by its nature. For the explanatory example I have chosen the concept of *traveling*. Its sphere intersects with the territory of four others, from each of which the persuader can pass over at will. These again intersect with other spheres, some of them with two or more at once, through which the persuader arbitrarily takes his path, always as if it were the only one, and then finally arrives, according to his intention, at good or evil.

Only, in following the spheres, one must always keep the direction from the center (the given main concept) toward the periphery, and not go backward. Such a sophistical maneuver can be clothed in continuous speech, or also in the strict form of inference, depending on the weak side of the listener. At bottom, most scientific proofs, especially philosophical ones, are not much differently constituted. How else would it have been possible for so much, at different times, not only to be erroneously accepted (for error itself has another origin), but to be demonstrated and proved, and yet later found to be fundamentally false: for example, Leibniz-Wolffian philosophy, Ptolemaic astronomy, Stahlian chemistry, Newton's theory of colors, and so on and so on. ^[3]

Notes

Notes

1. On this, chapters 5 and 6 of the second volume. ↩
2. On this, chapters 9 and 10 of the second volume. ↩
3. On this, chapter 11 of the second volume. ↩

§. 10.

Through all this the question comes ever closer to us: how is *certainty* to be attained, how are *judgments to be grounded*, and in what do *knowledge* and science consist? Alongside language and deliberate action, we praise these as the third great advantage given by reason.

Reason is feminine in nature: it can give only after it has received. By itself alone it has nothing but the contentless forms of its operations. Indeed, there is no perfectly pure rational cognition other than the four propositions to which I have assigned metalogical truth: the propositions of identity, of contradiction, of excluded middle, and of the sufficient ground of knowing.

For even the rest of logic is no longer perfectly pure rational cognition, because it presupposes the relations and combinations of the spheres of concepts. But concepts in general exist only after preceding intuitive representations; their relation to these representations makes up their whole essence, and therefore they already presuppose them. Yet since this presupposition does not extend to the determinate content of the concepts, but only in general to their existence, logic can still, taken as a whole, count as a pure science of reason.

In all other sciences reason has received its content from intuitive representations: in mathematics, from the relations of space and time intuitively conscious before all experience; in pure natural science, that is, in what we know about the course of nature before all experience, the content of the science comes from the pure understanding, namely from cognition a priori (prior to experience) of the law of causality and its connection with those pure intuitions of space and time. In all other sciences, everything that is not borrowed from what has just been named belongs to experience.

Knowledge in general means having in one's mind, available for voluntary reproduction, judgments that have their sufficient ground of knowing in something outside themselves, that is, judgments that are *true*. Abstract cognition alone, therefore, is knowledge. Knowledge is consequently conditioned by reason; and, strictly speaking, we cannot say of animals that they *know* anything, although they have intuitive cognition and, for this cognition, memory, and precisely because of memory, imagination as well, which is also proved by their dreaming.

We attribute consciousness to animals; and the concept of consciousness, although the word is derived from knowing, therefore coincides with that of representation in general, whatever kind it may be. Accordingly, we attribute life to the plant, but not consciousness.

Thus *knowledge* is abstract consciousness: the holding fixed in concepts of reason of what has been cognized in some other way.

§. 11.

In this respect the proper opposite of *knowledge* is *feeling*, and for that reason we must insert a discussion of it here.

The concept designated by the word *feeling* has throughout only a *negative* content: namely, that something present in consciousness is *not a concept, not abstract cognition of reason*. Apart from that, it may be whatever it likes; it falls under the concept *feeling*. The immeasurably wide sphere of this concept therefore includes the most heterogeneous things, and one can never see how they belong together until one has recognized that they agree only in this negative respect: that they are *not abstract concepts*.

For the most different, even hostile, elements lie peacefully beside one another in that concept: religious feeling, feeling of sensual pleasure, moral feeling, bodily feeling as touch, as pain, as feeling for colors, for tones and their harmonies and disharmonies, feelings of hatred, disgust, self-satisfaction, honor, shame, right, wrong, feeling for truth, aesthetic feeling, feeling of strength, weakness, health, friendship, love, and so on and so on. There is absolutely nothing common among them except the negative fact that they are not abstract rational cognition.

This becomes most striking when even the intuitive cognition a priori (prior to experience) of spatial relations, and still more that of the pure understanding, is brought under this concept; and when, in general, every cognition, every truth of which one is at first only intuitively conscious, but which one has not yet deposited in abstract concepts, is said to be something one *feels*.

For illustration, I will give a few examples from recent books, because they are striking evidence for my explanation. I remember reading, in the introduction to a German version of Euclid, that beginners in geometry should first be made to draw all the figures before proceeding to demonstration, because they would then already *feel* the geometrical truth beforehand, before the demonstration supplied them with complete cognition.

Similarly, F. Schleiermacher's *Critique of Ethics* speaks of logical and mathematical feeling (p. 339), and also of the feeling of equality or difference between two formulae (p. 342). Further, in Tennemann's *History of Philosophy*, vol. 1, p. 361, it says: "One *felt* that the fallacies were not correct, but still could not discover the error."

So long as one does not view this concept, *feeling*, from the right standpoint, and does not recognize the one negative mark that alone is essential to it, the concept must constantly give rise to misunderstandings and disputes, because of the excessive breadth of its sphere and its merely negative, wholly one-sidedly determined, and very meager content.

Since in German we still have the almost equivalent word *Empfindung* (sensation), it would be useful to reserve it for bodily feelings as a subspecies. The origin of that concept *feeling*, so disproportionate to all others, is without doubt the following. All concepts, and only concepts are what words designate, exist only for reason and proceed from it. With them, therefore, one already stands at a one-sided standpoint.

But from such a standpoint what is nearer appears distinctly and is posited as positive; what is farther away flows together and is soon considered only negatively. Thus every nation calls all others foreigners; the Greek called all others barbarians; the Englishman calls everything that is not England or English the Continent and continental; the believer calls all others heretics or heathens; the nobility calls all others roturiers (commoners); the student calls all others Philistines; and so forth.

The very same one-sidedness, one might say the same crude ignorance born of pride, is, strange as it sounds, something of which reason itself is guilty. It includes under the *one* concept *feeling* every modification of consciousness that does not belong immediately to *its* mode of representation, that is, that is *not an abstract concept*.

Until now reason has had to pay for this, because its own procedure had not become clear to it through thorough self-knowledge, with misunderstandings and aberrations in its own domain. People have even set up a special faculty of feeling and now construct theories of it.

§. 12.

Knowledge, whose contradictory opposite I have just discussed under the concept of feeling, is, as stated, every abstract cognition, that is, rational cognition. But since reason always only brings before cognition again what has been received in some other way, it does not really enlarge our cognition, but merely gives it another form. What was cognized intuitively, what was cognized in concreto (in the concrete), reason allows us to know abstractly and universally.

This, however, is incomparably more important than it appears at first glance when stated in this way. For all secure preservation, all communicability, and every secure and far-reaching application of cognition to practical life depend on its having become knowledge, an abstract cognition. Intuitive cognition always holds only for the individual case; it is directed only to what is nearest and stops there, because sensibility and understanding can properly grasp only *one* object at a time. Every sustained, composite, planned activity must therefore proceed from principles, that is, from abstract knowledge, and be guided by them.

For example, the cognition that the understanding has of the relation of cause and effect is in itself much more perfect, deeper, and more exhaustive than anything that can be thought of it in abstracto (in the abstract). The understanding alone cognizes intuitively, immediately, and completely the manner in which a lever, a pulley, or a cogwheel acts, the way an arch supports itself, and so on. But because intuitive cognition, as just noted, is directed only to what is immediately present, the mere understanding is not sufficient for the construction of machines and buildings. Here reason must enter; it must put abstract concepts in place of intuitions, take them as the rule of action, and, if they are correct, success will follow.

Likewise, in pure intuition we cognize perfectly the essence and lawfulness of a parabola, hyperbola, or spiral. But in order to make secure use of this cognition in actuality, it first had to become abstract knowledge; in doing so, it of course loses intuitiveness, but gains the security and determinacy of abstract knowledge. Thus the whole differential calculus does not really enlarge our cognition of curves at all; it contains nothing more than what already lies in the mere pure intuition of them. But it changes the kind of cognition: it transforms

intuitive cognition into abstract cognition, and this has the greatest consequences for application.

Here, however, a peculiarity of our faculty of cognition comes into view, one that could hardly have been noticed before the distinction between intuitive and abstract cognition had been made completely clear. It is this: relations of space cannot be transferred immediately and as such into abstract cognition; only temporal magnitudes, that is, numbers, are suited to this. Numbers alone can be expressed in abstract concepts exactly corresponding to them, not spatial magnitudes.

The concept *thousand* differs from the concept *ten* in exactly the same way as the two temporal magnitudes differ in intuition. In thinking *thousand*, we think a determinate multiple of *ten*, into which we can at will resolve it for intuition in time, that is, count it. But between the abstract concept of a mile and that of a foot, without any intuitive representation of either and without the help of number, there is no exact difference corresponding to those magnitudes themselves. In both, only a spatial magnitude in general is thought. If the two are to be sufficiently distinguished, either spatial intuition must be called in to help, in which case one has already left the domain of abstract cognition, or the difference must be thought in *numbers*.

If, therefore, one wants abstract cognition of spatial relations, they must first be transferred into temporal relations, that is, into numbers. For this reason arithmetic alone, not geometry, is the universal science of magnitude; and geometry must be translated into arithmetic if it is to have communicability, exact determinacy, and applicability to practical life. A spatial relation as such can certainly also be thought in abstracto, for example, "the sine increases according to the measure of the angle"; but if the magnitude of this relation is to be stated, number is needed.

This necessity, that space, with its three dimensions, must be translated into time, which has only one dimension, if one wants to have an abstract cognition, that is, a *knowledge* and not a mere intuition, of its relations: this necessity is what makes mathematics so difficult.

This becomes very clear when we compare the intuition of curves with their analytic calculation, or even merely the tables of logarithms of the trigonometric functions with the intuition of the changing relations of the parts of the triangle that are expressed by those tables. What intuition here grasps in a single glance, completely and with the utmost exactness, namely how the cosine

decreases as the sine increases, how the cosine of one angle is the sine of the other, the inverse relation between the decrease and increase of both angles, and so on: what an enormous fabric of numbers, what laborious calculation, was needed in order to express this in abstracto! One might say: how time, with its *one* dimension, must torment itself in order to reproduce the three dimensions of space!

But this was necessary if, for the sake of application, we wanted to possess the relations of space deposited in abstract concepts. They could not pass into these concepts immediately, but only through the mediation of the purely temporal magnitude, number, which alone attaches itself immediately to abstract cognition.

It is further worth noting that just as space is so well suited to intuition and, by means of its three dimensions, allows even complicated relations to be easily surveyed, while it withdraws from abstract cognition, time conversely enters easily into abstract concepts but gives very little to intuition. Our intuition of numbers in their proper element, mere time, without the addition of space, scarcely reaches ten. Beyond that, we have only abstract concepts, no longer intuitive cognition of numbers. By contrast, we connect exactly determinate abstract concepts with every number word and with all algebraic signs.

Incidentally, it should be observed here that some minds find complete satisfaction only in what is intuitively cognized. What they seek is the ground and consequent of being in space, presented intuitively; a Euclidean proof, or an arithmetical solution of spatial problems, does not appeal to them. Other minds, by contrast, require the abstract concepts that alone are usable for application and communication. They have patience and memory for abstract propositions, formulae, demonstrations in long chains of inference, and calculations whose signs represent the most complicated abstractions. These seek determinacy; the former, intuitiveness. The difference is characteristic.

Knowledge, abstract cognition, has its greatest value in communicability and in the possibility of being preserved in fixed form. Only through this does it become so inestimably important for practical life. A person can have an immediate intuitive cognition, in the mere understanding, of the causal connection of the changes and motions of natural bodies, and can find complete satisfaction in it. But it first becomes fit for communication after he has fixed it in concepts.

Even for practical purposes, cognition of the first kind is sufficient when the person also undertakes the execution entirely by himself, and in an action that can be carried out while the intuitive cognition is still alive; but not when he needs the help of others, or even only his own action at different times and therefore a considered plan.

For example, a practiced billiards player can have a complete knowledge of the laws governing the impact of elastic bodies on one another merely in the understanding, merely for immediate intuition, and this is wholly sufficient for him. By contrast, only the scientific mechanic has genuine knowledge of those laws, that is, cognition in abstracto of them.

Even for the construction of machines, that merely intuitive cognition of the understanding is enough if the inventor of the machine also carries it out alone, as one often sees in talented craftsmen without any science. By contrast, as soon as several people and a composite activity occurring at different times are needed to carry out a mechanical operation, a machine, or a building, the person directing it must have designed the plan in abstracto; and such cooperative activity is possible only with the aid of reason.

It is remarkable, however, that in that first kind of activity, where one person alone is to carry something out in one uninterrupted action, knowledge, the application of reason, reflection, can often even be a hindrance. This is so, for example, in billiards, fencing, tuning an instrument, and singing. Here intuitive cognition must guide the activity immediately. Passing through reflection makes it uncertain, because it divides attention and confuses the person.

For this reason, wild and uncultivated people, who are very little accustomed to thinking, perform many bodily exercises, fights with animals, shooting with arrows, and the like with a certainty and speed that the reflective European never attains, precisely because deliberation makes him waver and hesitate. For example, he tries to find the right place or the right moment by locating it at an equal distance from the two false extremes; the natural person hits it immediately, without reflecting on the wrong paths.

Likewise, it does not help me to know how to state in abstracto, in degrees and minutes, the angle at which I must apply the razor, if I do not know it intuitively, that is, if I do not have it in my grip.

The application of reason is disturbing in the same way in the understanding of physiognomy. This too must occur immediately through the understanding. The expression, the meaning of the features, can only be *felt*, as one says; that

is, it does not pass into abstract concepts. Every human being has his immediate intuitive physiognomics and pathognomics, though one person recognizes that *signatura rerum* (signature of things) more clearly than another.

But a physiognomics in abstracto for teaching and learning cannot be brought about, because the nuances here are so fine that the concept cannot descend to them. Abstract knowledge therefore stands to them as a mosaic picture does to a *van der Werff* or a *Denner*: however fine the mosaic may be, the boundaries of the stones always remain, and therefore no continuous transition from one tint into another is possible. So too concepts, with their rigidity and sharp boundaries, however finely one may try to divide them through closer determination, always remain incapable of reaching the subtle modifications of the intuitive, on which everything depends in the physiognomics used here as an example. ^[1]

This same constitution of concepts, which makes them similar to the stones of a mosaic picture and by virtue of which intuition always remains their asymptote, is also the reason why nothing good is achieved in art through them. If the singer or virtuoso tries to guide his performance by reflection, it remains dead. The same holds for the composer, the painter, and indeed the poet. For art, the concept always remains unfruitful; it may guide only the technical element in art. Its domain is science. In the third book we will investigate more closely why all genuine art proceeds from intuitive cognition and never from the concept.

Even with regard to conduct, to personal agreeableness in social intercourse, the concept is useful only negatively, in holding back the crude outbursts of egoism and bestiality, as indeed politeness is its praiseworthy work. But what is attractive, graceful, and winning in conduct, what is loving and friendly, must not have proceeded from the concept; otherwise:

One feels the intention and is put out of tune.

All dissimulation is the work of reflection, but it cannot be sustained for long and without interruption: *nemo potest personam diu ferre fictam* (no one can long wear a feigned character), says Seneca in the book *De clementia* (On Clemency). It is then usually recognized, and misses its effect.

In the high pressure of life, where quick decisions, bold action, and swift and firm grasping are needed, reason is certainly necessary. But if it gains the upper hand and confusingly hinders the intuitive, immediate, purely intellectual

finding and seizing of the right thing, thereby producing indecision, it can easily spoil everything.

Finally, virtue and holiness do not arise from reflection either, but from the inner depth of the will and its relation to cognition. This discussion belongs in an entirely different place in this work. Here I only wish to note that the dogmas relating to ethics can be the same in the reason of whole nations, while action in each individual is different; and the reverse can also occur. Action takes place, as people say, according to *feelings*: that is, precisely not according to concepts, at least in its ethical content.

Dogmas occupy idle reason; action ultimately goes its own way independently of them, usually not according to abstract maxims but according to unspoken ones, whose expression is the whole human being himself. Therefore, however different the religious dogmas of nations may be, among all of them the good deed is accompanied by an inexpressible satisfaction, and the evil deed by infinite horror. No mockery shakes the former; no absolution by a confessor frees one from the latter.

Nevertheless, this is not meant to deny that the application of reason is necessary in carrying out a virtuous course of life. It is simply not the source of such a life. Its function is subordinate: preserving resolutions once formed, keeping maxims before us in order to resist the weakness of the moment and to maintain consistency in action.

In the end, reason performs the same service in art as well. There too it accomplishes nothing in the main matter, but it supports the execution, precisely because genius is not available at every hour, while the work must nevertheless be completed in all its parts and rounded into a whole. ^[2]

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1. For this reason I am of the opinion that physiognomics can proceed with certainty no further than the establishment of a few quite general rules, for example: that the intellectual element is to be read in the forehead and eye, and the ethical element, the expressions of the will, in the mouth and lower half of the face; that forehead and eye explain each other, and either of the two, seen without the other, is only half intelligible; that genius is never without a high, broad, beautifully arched forehead, though such a forehead often exists without genius; that one may infer intellect from an intelligent appearance all the more securely the uglier the face is, and infer stupidity from a stupid appearance all the more securely the more beautiful the face is; because beauty, as conformity to the type of humanity, already in itself carries the expression of mental clarity, while ugliness has the opposite relation, and so on. ↩

2. On this, chapter 7 of the second volume. ↩

§. 13.

All these considerations, both of the use and of the disadvantage of applying reason, are meant to make clear that although abstract knowledge is the reflection of intuitive representation and is grounded on it, it by no means fits it so congruently that it could everywhere take its place. Rather, it never corresponds to it with complete exactness. Therefore, as we have seen, many human activities can be accomplished only with the help of reason and deliberate procedure, while some are better accomplished without their application.

This very incongruence between intuitive and abstract cognition, by virtue of which the latter always approaches the former only as mosaic work approaches painting, is also the ground of a very remarkable phenomenon. Like reason itself, this phenomenon belongs exclusively to human nature, yet all the explanations of it that have been attempted again and again have remained inadequate. I mean *laughter*.

Because of its origin, we cannot avoid discussing it here, although it again interrupts our course. *Laughter* always arises from nothing other than the suddenly perceived incongruence between a concept and the real objects that had been thought through it in some relation; and laughter itself is simply the expression of this incongruence.

It often emerges when two or more real objects are thought through *one* concept and the concept's identity is transferred to them; then their complete difference in other respects makes it striking that the concept fitted them only from a one-sided point of view. Just as often, however, it is a single real object whose incongruence with the concept under which, in one respect, it has rightly been subsumed suddenly becomes felt.

Now the more correct the subsumption of such actual things under the concept is on the one hand, and the greater and more glaring their unsuitability to it is on the other, the stronger the effect of the ludicrous that springs from this contrast. All laughter, then, arises on the occasion of a paradoxical and therefore unexpected subsumption, whether this is expressed in words or in deeds. This, in brief, is the correct explanation of the ludicrous.

I will not linger here by telling anecdotes as examples in order to illustrate my explanation; for it is so simple and comprehensible that it does not need

them, and any ludicrous thing the reader remembers is equally suitable as evidence for it. But our explanation is both confirmed and clarified by unfolding the two kinds of the ludicrous into which it divides, and which follow precisely from that explanation.

Either two or more very different real objects, intuitive representations, have preceded in cognition, and one has arbitrarily identified them through the unity of a concept that includes both: this kind of the ludicrous is called wit. Or, conversely, the concept is first present in cognition, and one now passes from it to reality and to acting upon reality, to action. Objects that are otherwise fundamentally different, but are all thought in that concept, are now regarded and treated in the same way, until their great difference in other respects emerges to the surprise and astonishment of the acting person: this kind of the ludicrous is called *foolishness*.

Accordingly, everything ludicrous is either a witty idea or a foolish action, depending on whether one has moved from the discrepancy of the objects to the identity of the concept, or conversely. The former is always voluntary; the latter always involuntary and forced on one from outside.

To reverse this starting point in appearance, and to mask wit as foolishness, is the art of the court fool and the buffoon. Such a person, well aware of the diversity of the objects, unites them with concealed wit under one concept; then, starting from that concept, he receives from the subsequently discovered diversity of the objects the very surprise he had prepared for himself.

From this short but sufficient theory of the ludicrous it follows that, setting aside this last case of the joker, wit must always show itself in words, while foolishness usually shows itself in actions. It can also show itself in words, however, when it merely states its intention instead of actually carrying it out, or when it expresses itself in mere judgments and opinions.

Pedantry also belongs to foolishness. It arises from having little confidence in one's own understanding, and therefore not wanting to leave it to the understanding to recognize immediately what is right in the individual case. One therefore places the understanding entirely under the guardianship of reason and wants to make use of reason everywhere: that is, always to proceed from general concepts, rules, and maxims, and to hold to them exactly, in life, in art, and even in ethical conduct.

Hence the clinging to form, manner, expression, and word that is peculiar to pedantry; these take the place of the essence of the matter. Soon the

incongruence of the concept with reality shows itself. It becomes clear that the concept never descends to the individual case, and that its universality and rigid determinacy can never fit exactly the fine nuances and manifold modifications of actuality.

The pedant, therefore, with his general maxims, almost always comes up short in life; he shows himself imprudent, tasteless, and useless. In art, for which the concept is unfruitful, he produces lifeless, stiff, mannered monstrosities. Even in ethical respects, the resolve to act rightly or nobly cannot everywhere be carried out according to abstract maxims. For in many cases the infinitely finely nuanced character of the circumstances requires a choice of the right thing that proceeds immediately from character.

The application of merely abstract maxims partly gives false results because they fit only halfway, and partly cannot be carried through because they are foreign to the individual character of the acting person, and this character can never wholly deny itself. Inconsistencies then follow.

We cannot entirely acquit *Kant* of the charge of having occasioned moral pedantry, insofar as he makes it a condition of the moral worth of an action that it be done from purely rational abstract maxims, without any inclination or momentary impulse. This charge is also the meaning of Schiller's epigram entitled "Scruples of Conscience."

When, especially in political matters, people speak of doctrinaires, theorists, scholars, and so on, what they mean are pedants: people who know things well in abstracto (in the abstract), but not in concreto (in the concrete). Abstraction consists in thinking away the closer determinations; yet precisely on these a very great deal depends in practice.

To complete the theory, a spurious kind of wit still has to be mentioned: wordplay, the calembourg (pun), to which ambiguity, l'equivoque (equivocation), whose chief use is the obscene joke, can also be added.

Just as wit forces two very different real objects under one concept, so wordplay, by making use of accident, brings two different concepts under one word. The same contrast arises again, but much more weakly and superficially, because it springs not from the essence of things but from the accident of naming. In wit, the identity is in the concept and the difference is in actuality; in wordplay, however, the difference is in the concepts and the identity in actuality, since the wording belongs to actuality.

It would be only a somewhat too elaborate comparison if one said that wordplay stands to wit as the parabola of the upper inverted cone stands to that of the lower one. But the misunderstanding of the word, or the quid pro quo (one thing for another), is the involuntary calembourg (pun), and stands to it just as foolishness stands to wit. For this reason, the hard of hearing person, just like the fool, must often provide material for laughter, and bad comedy writers use the former instead of the latter in order to provoke laughter.

I have considered laughter here only from the psychic side. Regarding the physical side, I refer to what is set out on the matter in *Parerga*, vol. 2, chapter 6, §96, p. 134, first edition. ^[1]

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1. On this, chapter 8 of the second volume. ↩

§. 14.

From all these varied considerations, by which I hope the distinction and relation between the mode of cognition belonging to reason, namely knowledge and the concept, on the one hand, and immediate cognition in pure sensible, mathematical intuition and in apprehension through the understanding, on the other, have been brought to complete clarity; and also from the episodic discussions of feeling and laughter, to which the consideration of that remarkable relation among our modes of cognition almost unavoidably led us: I now return to the further discussion of science as the third advantage, alongside language and deliberate action, that reason gives to the human being. The general consideration of science that concerns us here will deal partly with its form, partly with the grounding of its judgments, and finally also with its content.

We have seen that, apart from the foundation of pure logic, all knowledge in general has its origin not in reason itself, but elsewhere. Gained as intuitive cognition, it is deposited in reason by passing over into an entirely different mode of cognition, the abstract one.

All *knowledge*, that is, cognition raised to consciousness in abstracto (in the abstract), stands to genuine *science* as a fragment stands to the whole. Every human being has acquired knowledge about many things through experience, through observation of the individual case that presents itself. But only the person who makes it his task to attain complete cognition in abstracto of some kind of objects strives after science.

Only through the concept can he separate out that kind. Therefore at the head of every science stands a concept through which the part is thought out of the whole of all things about which that science promises complete cognition in abstracto: for example, the concept of spatial relations; or of the reciprocal action of inorganic bodies; or of the constitution of plants, animals, the successive changes of the earth's surface, the changes of the human race as a whole, the structure of a language, and so on.

If science tried to attain knowledge of its object by investigating individually all the things thought through the concept, until it had gradually come to know the whole, then no human memory would suffice, and no certainty of completeness could be obtained. Therefore science makes use of the peculiarity of concept-spheres discussed above, namely that they include one another. It is

chiefly directed toward the wider spheres that lie within the concept of its object in general. Once it has determined their relations to one another, everything thought in them is thereby also determined in general, and can now be determined more and more exactly by separating out ever narrower concept-spheres.

In this way it becomes possible for a science to embrace its object as a whole. This path by which science proceeds to cognition, namely from the universal to the particular, distinguishes it from ordinary knowledge. Therefore systematic form is an essential and characteristic mark of science.

The connection of the most universal concept-spheres of every science, that is, knowledge of its highest propositions, is an indispensable condition for learning it. How far one wants to go from these to the more particular propositions is optional, and increases not the thoroughness but the extent of one's learnedness.

The number of upper propositions to which all the others are subordinate differs greatly in the different sciences, so that in some there is more subordination, in others more coordination. In this respect, the former make greater demands on the power of judgment, the latter on memory. It was already known to the Scholastics ^[1] that, because an inference requires two premises, no science can proceed from a single highest proposition that cannot be further derived; rather, it must have several, at least two.

The properly classifying sciences, such as zoology and botany, and also physics and chemistry insofar as these latter reduce all inorganic action to a few fundamental forces, have the most subordination. History, by contrast, really has none at all, since the universal in it consists merely in the overview of the main periods. The particular events cannot be derived from these periods; they are subordinate to them only in time, while in concept they are coordinated. Therefore history, strictly speaking, is indeed knowledge, but not science.

In mathematics, according to the Euclidean treatment, the axioms are the only indemonstrable highest propositions, and all demonstrations are strictly subordinated to them step by step. Yet this treatment is not essential to mathematics. In fact, every theorem begins a new spatial construction that is in itself independent of the preceding ones, and can really be cognized entirely independently of them, from itself, in the pure intuition of space, in which even the most intricate construction is really as immediately evident as the axiom. But of this more fully below.

Meanwhile, every mathematical proposition still remains a universal truth that holds for innumerable individual cases. A gradual progression from simple propositions to complicated ones that can be reduced to them is also essential to it. Thus mathematics is in every respect science.

The perfection of a science as such, that is, in point of form, consists in there being as much subordination and as little coordination of propositions as possible. The general scientific talent is therefore the capacity to subordinate concept-spheres according to their different determinations, so that, as Plato repeatedly recommends, science is not made up merely of a universal with an unmanageable multiplicity placed immediately beneath it side by side. Rather, cognition should descend gradually from the most universal to the particular through intermediate concepts and through divisions made according to ever closer determinations.

In Kant's expressions, this means satisfying equally the law of homogeneity and the law of specification. But precisely from the fact that this constitutes properly scientific perfection, it follows that the purpose of science is not greater certainty; for even the most isolated individual cognition can possess certainty just as fully. Rather, the purpose of science is the easing of knowledge through its form, and the possibility of completeness of knowledge thereby given.

It is therefore a common but mistaken opinion that the scientific character of cognition consists in greater certainty. Just as false is the assertion that arose from this, that only mathematics and logic are sciences in the proper sense because only in them, owing to their complete apriority, is there unshakable certainty of cognition. This latter advantage itself cannot be denied them. But it gives them no special claim to scientificity, which lies not in certainty but in the systematic form of cognition grounded in the stepwise descent from the universal to the particular.

This path of cognition peculiar to the sciences, from the universal to the particular, entails that much in them is grounded by derivation from preceding propositions, and thus by proofs. This has given rise to the old error that only what is proved is completely true, and that every truth requires a proof. On the contrary, every proof requires an unproved truth that ultimately supports it, or supports its own proofs in turn. Therefore an immediately grounded truth is to be preferred to one grounded by proof as water from the spring is to water from the aqueduct.

Intuition, partly pure a priori (prior to experience), as it grounds mathematics, and partly empirical a posteriori (after experience), as it grounds all other sciences, is the source of all truth and the foundation of all science. The sole exception is logic, which is grounded on reason's non-intuitive but still immediate knowledge of its own laws.

It is not the proved judgments, nor their proofs, but those judgments drawn immediately from intuition and grounded on it instead of on any proof, that are in science what the sun is in the structure of the world. From them all light proceeds; illuminated by it, the others shine in turn.

To ground the truth of such first judgments immediately from intuition, to lift such foundation stones of science out of the unmanageable multitude of real things: this is the work of the *power of judgment*. It consists in the capacity to transfer what is intuitively cognized correctly and exactly into abstract consciousness, and is therefore the mediator between understanding and reason.

Only outstanding strength of this power, exceeding the ordinary measure in an individual, can really advance the sciences. But anyone with sound reason can infer propositions from propositions, prove, and draw conclusions. By contrast, to deposit and fix what is intuitively cognized in concepts suitable for reflection, so that on the one hand what is common to many real objects is thought through *one* concept, while on the other hand what is different in them is thought through just as many concepts; so that the different, despite partial agreement, is nevertheless cognized and thought as different, and again the identical, despite partial difference, is nevertheless cognized and thought as identical, all in accordance with the purpose and point of view prevailing each time: all this is done by the *power of judgment*.

Lack of it is *simple-mindedness*. The simple-minded person now fails to recognize the partial or relative difference in what is identical in one respect, now the identity in what is relatively or partially different.

Moreover, Kant's division of the power of judgment into reflective and subsumptive can also be applied to this explanation, according as it goes from intuitive objects to the concept, or from the concept to those objects. In both cases it always mediates between the intuitive cognition of the understanding and the reflective cognition of reason.

There can be no truth that would have to be brought out unconditionally by inferences alone. Rather, the necessity of grounding it merely by inferences is always only relative, indeed subjective. Since all proofs are inferences, one

should seek for a new truth not first a proof, but immediate evidence; and only so long as this is lacking should the proof be set up provisionally.

No science can be demonstrable through and through, any more than a building can stand in the air. All its proofs must lead back to something intuitive and therefore no longer demonstrable. For the whole world of reflection rests on and is rooted in the intuitive world. All ultimate, that is, original *evidence*, is *intuitive*: the word itself already betrays this. Accordingly, it is either empirical, or else grounded on the a priori intuition of the conditions of possible experience. In both cases, therefore, it yields only immanent, not transcendent cognition.

Every concept has its value and its existence solely in its relation, however mediated, to an intuitive representation. What holds for concepts also holds for the judgments composed from them, and for whole sciences. Therefore it must somehow be possible to cognize every truth that is found by inferences and communicated by proofs immediately as well, without proofs and inferences.

This is certainly most difficult with some complicated mathematical propositions, to which we arrive only by chains of inference: for example, the calculation of chords and tangents for all arcs by means of inferences from the Pythagorean theorem. Yet even such a truth cannot rest essentially and solely on abstract propositions. The spatial relations lying at its basis must also be capable of being brought out for pure intuition a priori in such a way that their abstract statement is immediately grounded. Mathematical proof, however, will be discussed in detail shortly.

One often hears, in a lofty tone, of sciences that rest throughout on correct inferences from secure premises and are therefore unshakably true. But through purely logical chains of inference, however true the premises may be, one will never obtain more than a clarification and explication of what already lies complete in the premises. One will only set out *explicite* (explicitly) what had been understood there *implicite* (implicitly).

By those much-praised sciences people especially mean the mathematical sciences, above all astronomy. The certainty of astronomy, however, comes from the fact that it is grounded on the a priori given, and therefore infallible, intuition of space. All spatial relations follow from one another with a necessity, the ground of being, that yields certainty a priori; therefore they can be derived from one another with certainty.

To these mathematical determinations there is added here only a single natural force, gravity, which acts exactly in proportion to the masses and to the square of the distance; and finally the law of inertia, secured a priori because it follows from the law of causality, together with the empirical datum of the motion impressed once for all on each of these masses. This is the whole material of astronomy. Both through its simplicity and through its certainty, it leads to firm results that, because of the greatness and importance of the objects, are very interesting.

For example, if I know the mass of a planet and the distance of its satellite from it, I can infer the orbital period of the latter with certainty according to Kepler's second law. But the ground of this law is that, at this distance, only this velocity both binds the satellite to the planet and keeps it from falling into it.

Only on such a geometrical basis, that is, by means of an intuition a priori, and in addition under application of a law of nature, can one go far with inferences. For here they are, as it were, merely bridges from *one* intuitive apprehension to another. The same is not true of mere and pure inferences on an exclusively logical path.

The origin of the first fundamental truths of astronomy is really induction, that is, the gathering together of what is given in many intuitions into a correct, immediately grounded judgment. From this, hypotheses are afterward formed; and their confirmation by experience, as induction approaching completeness, gives the proof for that first judgment.

For example, the apparent motion of the planets is empirically cognized. After many false hypotheses about the spatial connection of this motion, the planetary orbit, the correct one was finally found; then the laws it follows, the Keplerian laws; and finally also its cause, universal gravitation. The empirically cognized agreement of all occurring cases with these hypotheses and with the consequences drawn from them, that is, induction, gave all those hypotheses complete certainty.

The discovery of the hypothesis was the work of the power of judgment, which correctly apprehended the given fact and expressed it accordingly. Induction, that is, manifold intuition, confirmed its truth. But this truth could even be grounded immediately by a single empirical intuition, if only we could freely traverse the spaces of the universe and had telescopic eyes. Consequently, inferences are not even here the essential and sole source of cognition; they are always really only a makeshift.

Finally, to present a third, heterogeneous example, let us note that the so-called metaphysical truths, that is, truths of the kind Kant sets out in the *Metaphysical Foundations of Natural Science*, also do not owe their evidence to proofs. What is certain a priori we cognize immediately: as the form of all cognition, it is conscious to us with the greatest necessity.

For example, that matter persists, that is, can neither come into being nor pass away, we know immediately as a negative truth. For our pure intuition of space and time gives the possibility of motion; the understanding gives, in the law of causality, the possibility of change of form and quality. But for the coming into being or disappearance of matter, we lack forms of representability.

Therefore that truth has at all times, everywhere, and to everyone been evident, and has never seriously been doubted. This could not be the case if its ground of knowing were nothing other than a Kantian proof so difficult that it walks on needle points. Indeed, moreover, I have found Kant's proof false, as is set out in the appendix, and have shown above that the persistence of matter is to be derived not from the share time has in the possibility of experience, but from the share space has in it.

The real grounding of all truths called metaphysical in this sense, that is, abstract expressions of the necessary and universal forms of cognition, cannot itself lie again in abstract propositions. It can lie only in the immediate consciousness of the forms of representation, which announces itself through apodictic a priori assertions that fear no refutation.

If one nevertheless wants to give a proof of them, it can consist only in showing that, in some undoubted truth, the truth to be proved is already contained as part or presupposition. Thus, for example, I have shown that all empirical intuition already contains the application of the law of causality; therefore cognition of that law is the condition of all experience, and cannot first be given and conditioned by experience, as Hume claimed.

Proofs are in general less for those who want to learn than for those who want to dispute. These people stubbornly deny immediately grounded insight. Only truth can be consistent on every side; one must therefore show them that under *one* form, and mediately, they concede what under another form, and immediately, they deny: that is, one must show the logically necessary connection between what is denied and what is admitted.

In addition, however, scientific form itself, namely the subordination of everything particular under something universal and so upward without end,

brings it about that the truth of many propositions is grounded only logically: namely through their dependence on other propositions, hence through inferences that at the same time appear as proofs. But one should never forget that this whole form is only a means of making cognition easier, not a means to greater certainty.

It is easier to cognize the constitution of an animal from the species to which it belongs, and then upward from the genus (genus), family, order, and class, than to investigate the given animal on its own each time. But the truth of all propositions derived by inference is always only conditioned and ultimately dependent on some truth that rests not on inference but on intuition.

If this latter truth always lay as near to us as derivation by inference, it would be absolutely preferable. For all derivation from concepts is exposed to many deceptions, because of the manifold interlacing of spheres shown above and the often wavering determination of their content. So many proofs of false doctrines and sophisms of every kind are examples of this.

Inferences are indeed completely certain in form, but they are very uncertain through their matter, the concepts. For the spheres of these concepts are often not sharply enough determined; and they intersect in such many-sided ways that one sphere is partly contained in many others, so that one can pass arbitrarily from it into one or another of these, and from there onward again, as has already been shown.

Or, in other words, the terminus minor (minor term), and also the medius (middle term), can always be subordinated to different concepts, from which one chooses the terminus major (major term) and the medius at will, so that the inference then turns out differently.

Everywhere, therefore, immediate evidence is greatly preferable to proved truth. The latter should be accepted only where the former would have to be brought from too far away, not where it lies just as near, or even nearer, than the proof. For this reason, as we saw above, in logic, where immediate cognition lies nearer to us in every individual case than derived scientific cognition, we always guide our thinking only by the immediate cognition of the laws of thought and leave logic unused. ^[2]

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1. Suarez, Disput. metaphysicae, disp. III, 3, tit. 3. ↩
2. On this, chapter 12 of the second volume. ↩

§. 15.

If, with our conviction that intuition is the first source of all evidence, and that only an immediate or mediated relation to it is absolute truth; and further, that the shortest path to this truth is always the safest, since every mediation through concepts exposes us to many deceptions: if, I say, with this conviction we turn to *mathematics*, as Euclid established it as a science and as, on the whole, it has remained down to the present day, then we cannot help finding the path it takes strange, indeed perverse.

We demand that every logical grounding be led back to an intuitive one. Mathematics, however, makes great efforts deliberately to reject the intuitive evidence peculiar to it, which lies near at hand everywhere, in order to substitute logical evidence for it. We must find this like someone cutting off his legs in order to walk on crutches, or like the prince in *The Triumph of Sensibility*, who flees from real, beautiful nature in order to enjoy a theatrical decoration that imitates it.

Here I must recall what I said in the sixth chapter of the essay on the principle of sufficient reason, and I assume it to be freshly and fully present in the reader's memory. I therefore attach my remarks to it without again setting out the difference between the mere ground of knowing of a mathematical truth, which can be given logically, and the ground of being, which is the immediate connection of the parts of space and time, knowable only intuitively. Insight into this alone gives true satisfaction and thorough knowledge, whereas the mere ground of knowing always remains on the surface and can indeed give knowledge *that* it is so, but not knowledge of *why* it is so.

Euclid took this latter path, to the obvious detriment of the science. For example, at the very beginning, where he ought once and for all to have shown how, in the triangle, angles and sides determine one another reciprocally, and are ground and consequent of one another according to the form that the principle of sufficient reason has in mere space; where, as everywhere, this form gives the necessity that one thing is as it is because something else, entirely different from it, is as it is: instead of giving a thorough insight into the essence of the triangle, he sets up a few detached and arbitrarily chosen propositions about the triangle and gives a logical ground of knowing for them through a laborious proof conducted logically according to the principle of contradiction.

Instead of exhaustive cognition of these spatial relations, one therefore receives only a few arbitrarily communicated results from them, and is in the position of someone who is shown the different effects of an artificial machine while its inner connection and mechanism are withheld from him. One must, compelled by the principle of contradiction, admit that everything Euclid demonstrates is so. But one does not learn *why* it is so.

One therefore has almost the uneasy feeling one has after a conjuring trick; and in fact most Euclidean proofs are strikingly similar to such tricks. Almost always the truth enters by the back door, since it follows *per accidens* (accidentally) from some incidental circumstance. Often an apagogic proof closes all doors one after another and leaves only one open, through which one must enter merely for that reason. Often, as in the Pythagorean theorem, lines are drawn without one knowing why; afterward it appears that they were snares that unexpectedly tighten and capture the learner's assent. The learner must then, amazed, admit what remains wholly incomprehensible to him in its inner connection, so much so that he can study all of Euclid without gaining genuine insight into the laws of spatial relations, and instead merely memorizes a few results from them.

This really empirical and unscientific cognition resembles that of the physician who knows the disease and the remedy for it, but not the connection between them. All this is the consequence of capriciously rejecting the mode of grounding and evidence proper to one kind of cognition, and forcibly introducing in its place a mode foreign to its essence.

Yet the manner in which Euclid carried this through deserves all the admiration it has received for so many centuries. That admiration went so far that his treatment of mathematics was declared the model for every scientific presentation, and people even tried to model all other sciences on it, though later they drew back from this without quite knowing why. In our eyes, however, Euclid's method in mathematics can only appear as a very brilliant perversity.

Now, for every great error that is pursued deliberately and methodically and is accompanied by general approval, whether it concerns life or science, its ground can probably always be shown in the philosophy dominant at its time. The Eleatics were the first to discover the distinction, and indeed the frequent conflict, between what is intuited, φαίνόμενον (*phainomenon*, appearance), and what is thought, νοούμενον (*noumenon*, object of thought),^[1] and they used this

distinction in many ways for their philosophical doctrines and also for sophisms.

They were followed later by the Megarians, dialecticians, Sophists, New Academics, and Skeptics. These drew attention to semblance, that is, to the deception of the senses, or rather of the understanding that transforms their data into intuition, which often lets us see things to which reason with certainty denies reality, for example the stick broken in water and the like. It was recognized that sensible intuition was not to be trusted unconditionally, and people hastily concluded that rational, logical thinking alone grounds truth.

Yet Plato, in the *Parmenides*, the Megarians, Pyrrho, and the New Academics showed by examples, in the manner later used by Sextus Empiricus, that inferences and concepts also mislead, and indeed produce paralogisms and sophisms that arise much more easily and are much harder to resolve than semblance in sensible intuition. Meanwhile, rationalism, which had arisen in opposition to empiricism, retained the upper hand. Euclid worked mathematics accordingly, resting only the axioms, under compulsion, on intuitive evidence, and everything else on inferences.

His method remained dominant through all the centuries, and had to remain so as long as pure intuition a priori (prior to experience) had not been distinguished from empirical intuition. Euclid's commentator Proclus does seem already to have recognized that distinction completely, as is shown by the passage from him that Kepler translated into Latin in his book *De harmonia mundi* (On the Harmony of the World). But Proclus did not lay enough weight on the matter, set it up too much in isolation, remained unnoticed, and did not prevail.

Only two thousand years later, therefore, will Kant's doctrine, which is destined to bring about such great changes in all the knowledge, thinking, and activity of the European peoples, also bring about such a change in mathematics. For only after we have learned from this great mind that the intuitions of space and time are wholly different from empirical intuition, wholly independent of every impression on the senses, conditioning such impressions and not conditioned by them, that is, that they are a priori, and therefore are not at all open to sensory illusion: only now can we see that Euclid's logical treatment of mathematics is a useless precaution, a crutch for healthy legs.

It resembles a traveler who, at night, takes a bright, firm road for water, avoids stepping onto it, and keeps walking beside it on rough ground, satisfied when every so often he touches the supposed water. Only now can we assert with certainty that what announces itself to us as necessary in the intuition of a figure does not come from the figure that may be drawn very imperfectly on paper, nor from the abstract concept we think in connection with it, but immediately from the form of all cognition that is conscious to us a priori.

This form is everywhere the principle of sufficient reason. Here, as the form of intuition, that is, space, it is the principle of the ground of being. Its evidence and validity are just as great and immediate as those of the principle of the ground of knowing, that is, logical certainty. We therefore neither need nor may leave the proper territory of mathematics in order, simply from trust in logical certainty, to authenticate mathematics on a territory wholly foreign to it, that of concepts.

If we keep to the ground proper to mathematics, we gain the great advantage that in it knowledge *that* something is so is one with knowledge of *why* it is so. By contrast, the Euclidean method separates the two completely, and lets us know only the former, not the latter. Aristotle says quite excellently in *Analyt. post.* 1, 27:

Ακριβεστέρα δ' ἐπιστήμη ἐπιστήμης καὶ προτέρα, ἢ τε τοῦ ὅτι καὶ τοῦ διότι ἢ αὐτῇ, ἀλλὰ μὴ χωρὶς τοῦ ὅτι, τῆς τοῦ διότι.

Suptilior autem et prastantior ea est scientia, qua quod aliquid sit, et cur sit una simulque intellegimus, non separatim quod, et cur sit.

Translation: More exact and superior is the science in which we understand both that something is and why it is at one and the same time, not separately the that and the why.

In physics, too, we are satisfied only when cognition *that* something is so is united with cognition of *why* it is so. That the mercury in the Torricellian tube stands twenty-eight inches high is poor knowledge unless one also adds that it is held there by the counterweight of the air. But in mathematics are we supposed to be satisfied with a *qualitas occulta* (hidden quality) of the circle, namely that the segments of any two chords intersecting in it always form equal rectangles? Euclid indeed proves that it is so in the thirty-fifth proposition of the third book; but the why still remains undecided.

Likewise, the Pythagorean theorem acquaints us with a *qualitas occulta* (hidden quality) of the right triangle. Euclid's stilted, indeed sly, proof leaves us

stranded at the why; while the adjacent, already familiar, simple figure gives at one glance far more than that proof: insight into the matter and a firm inner conviction of that necessity and of the dependence of that property on the right angle.

Even with unequal legs it must be possible to bring the matter to such an intuitive conviction, as it must be with every possible geometrical truth, if only because its discovery always proceeded from such an intuited necessity and the proof was only devised afterward. One therefore needs only an analysis of the course of thought in the first discovery of a geometrical truth in order to recognize its necessity intuitively. In general, it is the analytic method that I wish for the presentation of mathematics, instead of the synthetic method Euclid used.

Of course, with complicated mathematical truths this will present very great, though not insurmountable, difficulties. Here and there in Germany people are already beginning to change the presentation of mathematics and to take more of this analytic path. Herr *Kosack*, teacher of mathematics and physics at the Gymnasium in Nordhausen, has done this most decisively by adding to the program for the school examination on April 6, 1852, a detailed attempt to treat geometry according to my principles.

To improve the method of mathematics, what is chiefly required is that one give up the prejudice that proved truth has any advantage over intuitively cognized truth, or that logical truth, resting on the principle of contradiction, has any advantage over metaphysical truth, which is immediately evident and to which the pure intuition of space also belongs.

The most certain and everywhere inexplicable thing is the content of the principle of sufficient reason. For this principle, in its different forms, designates the universal form of all our representations and cognitions. Every explanation is a reduction to it, a showing in the individual case of the connection of representations expressed by it in general. It is therefore the principle of all explanation, and for that reason is itself neither capable nor in need of explanation, since every explanation already presupposes it and receives meaning only through it.

None of its forms, however, has any privilege over another. It is equally certain and indemonstrable as the principle of the ground of being, of becoming, of acting, or of knowing. The relation of ground to consequent is necessary in one of its forms just as in another; indeed, it is in general the origin

and sole meaning of the concept of necessity. There is no necessity other than that of the consequent when the ground is given, and there is no ground that would not bring about necessity of the consequent.

Therefore, just as surely as the consequent expressed in the conclusion flows from the ground of knowing given in the premises, so surely the ground of being in space conditions its consequent in space. If I have intuitively cognized the relation of these two, then this certainty is as great as any logical certainty.

Every geometrical theorem is the expression of such a relation, just as much as any of the twelve axioms. It is a metaphysical truth, and as such just as immediately certain as the principle of contradiction itself, which is a metalogical truth and the universal foundation of all logical demonstration. Whoever denies the intuitively displayed necessity of the spatial relations expressed in some theorem can with equal right deny the axioms, and with equal right deny the consequent of an inference from the premises, indeed the principle of contradiction itself. For all these are equally indemonstrable, immediately evident, and knowable a priori.

If, therefore, one first wants to derive the intuitively knowable necessity of spatial relations through a logical demonstration from the principle of contradiction, this is no different from someone first wanting to grant a country as a fief to its immediate lord. Yet this is what Euclid did. Under compulsion, he allows only his axioms to rest on immediate evidence. All the following geometrical truths are proved logically: on the assumption of those axioms, from agreement with the assumptions made in the theorem, or with an earlier theorem, or else from the contradiction of the opposite of the theorem with the assumptions, the axioms, the earlier theorems, or even with itself. But the axioms themselves have no more immediate evidence than any other geometrical theorem; they have only more simplicity because they have less content.

When one interrogates an accused person, one takes down his statements in a protocol in order to judge their truth from their agreement with one another. But this is a mere makeshift, and one does not stop there if one can investigate the truth of each of his statements directly in itself, especially since he may have lied consistently from the beginning.

Yet this first method is the one by which Euclid investigated space. He did indeed proceed from the correct presupposition that nature everywhere, and therefore also in its fundamental form, space, must be consistent; and that

because the parts of space stand to one another in the relation of ground and consequent, no single spatial determination can be otherwise than it is without contradicting all the others. But this is a very laborious and unsatisfying detour. It prefers mediate cognition to immediate cognition, which is just as certain; it separates cognition *that* something is from cognition of *why* it is, to the great disadvantage of the science; and finally it wholly withholds from the learner insight into the laws of space.

Indeed, it accustoms him away from the genuine investigation of the ground and inner connection of things, and instead instructs him to be satisfied with a historical knowledge *that* it is so. The exercise of acuteness so incessantly praised in this method consists merely in the student's practicing inference, that is, applying the principle of contradiction, and above all straining his memory to retain all those data whose agreement is to be compared.

It is also noteworthy that this method of proof has been applied only to geometry, not to arithmetic. In arithmetic, truth is really allowed to become evident through intuition alone, which here consists in mere counting. Since the intuition of numbers is in *time alone*, and therefore cannot be represented through any sensible schema such as the geometrical figure, the suspicion fell away here that intuition is only empirical and therefore subject to semblance. That suspicion alone could have brought the logical mode of proof into geometry.

Because time has only one dimension, counting is the only arithmetical operation to which all others can be reduced. Yet this counting is nothing other than intuition a priori, to which one has no hesitation in appealing here, and through which alone everything else, every calculation, every equation, is ultimately confirmed. For example, one does not prove that $(7 + 9 \times 8 - 2) / 3 = 42$; rather, one appeals to pure intuition in time, to counting, and thus makes every individual proposition into an axiom.

Instead of the proofs that fill geometry, the whole content of arithmetic and algebra is therefore a mere method for shortening counting. Our immediate intuition of numbers in time, as mentioned above, does not extend much beyond ten. Beyond that, an abstract concept of number, fixed by a word, must take the place of intuition; intuition is therefore no longer actually performed, but only quite determinately indicated.

Even so, by means of the important aid of the order of numbers, which always allows larger numbers to be represented by the same smaller ones,

intuitive evidence for every calculation is made possible, even where abstraction is called in so extensively that not only numbers but indeterminate magnitudes and whole operations are thought only in abstracto and are designated in this respect, as in $\sqrt{r-b}$, so that one no longer performs them but merely indicates them.

With the same right and the same certainty as in arithmetic, one could also allow truth in geometry to be grounded solely through pure intuition a priori. In fact, it is always this necessity, intuitively cognized according to the principle of the ground of being, that gives geometry its great evidence, and on which the certainty of its propositions rests in everyone's consciousness. It is by no means the logical proof walking on stilts, which always remains foreign to the matter and is usually soon forgotten without any harm to conviction. It could disappear entirely without diminishing the evidence of geometry, since that evidence is wholly independent of it; the proof always proves only what one already has complete conviction of beforehand through another kind of cognition. In this respect it resembles a cowardly soldier who wounds an enemy already slain by others, and then boasts that he killed him. ^[2]

From all this it will, I hope, no longer be subject to doubt that the evidence of mathematics, which has become the model and symbol of all evidence, rests essentially not on proofs but on immediate intuition, which here, as everywhere, is the ultimate ground and source of all truth. Yet the intuition that grounds mathematics has a great advantage over every other intuition, and thus over empirical intuition. Since it is a priori, and therefore independent of experience, which is always given only partially and successively, everything in it lies equally near, and one can start at will from the ground or from the consequent.

This gives it complete infallibility, because in it the consequent is cognized from the ground, and this cognition alone has necessity. For example, the equality of the sides is cognized as grounded by the equality of the angles. By contrast, all empirical intuition and the greatest part of all experience proceeds the other way around, from the consequent to the ground. This kind of cognition is not infallible, since necessity belongs only to the consequent insofar as the ground is given, not to the cognition of the ground from the consequent, since the same consequent can arise from different grounds.

This latter kind of cognition is always only induction: that is, from many consequents that point to a ground, the ground is assumed as certain. But since the cases can never be completely gathered together, the truth here is never

unconditionally certain. This kind of truth alone belongs to all cognition through sensible intuition and to the great majority of experience.

The affection of a sense occasions an inference of the understanding from the effect to the cause. But because the inference from what is grounded to the ground is never certain, false semblance, as sensory deception, is possible and often actual, as was explained above. Only when several, or all five, senses receive affections that point to the same cause has the possibility of semblance become extremely small, though it still exists; for in certain cases, for example with counterfeit coins, the whole of sensibility is deceived.

All empirical cognition is in the same position, and therefore so is all natural science, leaving aside its pure, or in Kant's sense metaphysical, part. Here too causes are cognized from effects. Therefore all natural theory rests on hypotheses, which are often false and then gradually give way to more correct ones. Only in deliberately arranged experiments does cognition proceed from the cause to the effect, and therefore along the secure path; but experiments themselves are undertaken only as a consequence of hypotheses.

For this reason no branch of natural science, for example physics, astronomy, or physiology, could be discovered all at once, as mathematics or logic could. It needed, and still needs, the collected and compared experiences of many centuries. Only repeated empirical confirmation brings the induction on which the hypothesis rests so near to completeness that, for practice, it takes the place of certainty. The fact that the hypothesis arose in this way is then considered no more damaging to it than the incommensurability of straight and curved lines is damaging to the application of geometry, or the unattainable complete exactness of the logarithm to the application of arithmetic.

For just as one brings the quadrature of the circle and the logarithm infinitely close to correctness by infinite fractions, so too through manifold experience induction, that is, cognition of the ground from the consequents, is brought not infinitely, but still so close to mathematical evidence, that is, to cognition of the consequent from the ground, that the possibility of deception becomes small enough to be neglected. Yet it is still present.

For example, an inductive inference is also the inference from innumerable cases to all cases, that is, actually to the unknown ground on which all depend. What inference of this kind seems more certain than that all human beings have the heart on the left side? And yet, as extremely rare and wholly isolated exceptions, there are human beings whose heart sits on the right side.

Sensible intuition and experiential science therefore have the same kind of evidence. The advantage that mathematics, pure natural science, and logic have over them as cognitions a priori rests solely on the fact that the formal element of cognition, on which all apriority is grounded, is given as a whole and at once. Therefore here one can always proceed from the ground to the consequent, while there one can usually proceed only from the consequent to the ground.

In itself, moreover, the law of causality, or the principle of the ground of becoming, which guides empirical cognition, is just as certain as those other forms of the principle of sufficient reason that the sciences mentioned above follow a priori.

Logical proofs from concepts, or inferences, share with cognition through intuition a priori the advantage of proceeding from the ground to the consequent, by which they are in themselves, that is, in their form, infallible. This has contributed much to bringing proofs in general into such great esteem. But this infallibility is relative: proofs merely subsume under the upper propositions of the science. These, however, contain the whole fund of truth of the science, and they must not themselves be merely proved, but must be grounded on intuition; in those few sciences mentioned above this intuition is pure a priori, while otherwise it is always empirical and is raised to universality only by induction.

Therefore, even if in the experiential sciences the individual is proved from the universal, the universal itself has received its truth only from the individual. It is only a storehouse of collected supplies, not a self-generating ground.

So much for the grounding of truth. Many explanations have been attempted, since Plato's pictorial solutions involving the dovecote, where one grasps the wrong dove, and so on (Theaetetus, p. 167 ff.), concerning the origin and possibility of *error*. Kant's vague and indeterminate explanation of the origin of error by means of the image of diagonal motion is found in the *Critique of Pure Reason*, p. 294 of the first edition and p. 350 of the fifth.

Since truth is the relation of a judgment to its ground of knowing, it is certainly a problem how the person judging can really believe he has such a ground and yet not have one: that is, how error, the deception of reason, is possible. I find this possibility wholly analogous to that of semblance, or deception of the understanding, explained above. My view, and this is precisely why this explanation has its place here, is that *every error is an inference from the consequent to the ground*. Such an inference is valid when one knows that

the consequent can have this ground and absolutely no other; otherwise it is not valid.

The person who errs either assigns to the consequent a ground that it cannot have at all, in which case he shows a real lack of understanding, that is, of the capacity for immediate cognition of the connection between cause and effect; or, what is more often the case, he assigns to the consequent a ground that is indeed possible, but adds to the major premise of his inference from the consequent to the ground that the stated consequent *always* arises only from the ground he has indicated. Only a complete induction could entitle him to this, but he presupposes it without having made it.

That *always* is therefore too wide a concept; in its place there should stand only *sometimes* or *mostly*. Then the conclusion would turn out problematic and, as such, would not be erroneous. That the erring person proceeds in the way indicated is due either to haste or to too limited a knowledge of possibility, because of which he does not know the necessity of the induction to be made.

Error is therefore wholly analogous to semblance. Both are inferences from the consequent to the ground. Semblance is always carried out according to the law of causality and by the mere understanding, thus immediately in intuition itself. Error is carried out according to all forms of the principle of sufficient reason, by reason, and therefore in thinking proper, though most often also according to the law of causality. The following three examples may be regarded as types or representatives of three kinds of error.

1. Sensory semblance, deception of the understanding, occasions error, deception of reason: for example, when one takes a painting for a bas-relief and really holds it to be one. This occurs through an inference from the following major premise: "If dark gray passes locally through all nuances into white, then the cause is *always* light striking raised and recessed surfaces unequally: ergo (therefore) ..."

2. "If money is missing from my cashbox, then the cause is *always* that my servant has a duplicate key: ergo ..."

3. "If the sun's image refracted through the prism, that is, shifted upward or downward, now appears elongated and colored instead of round and white as before, then the cause, once and for all, is that differently colored and at the same time differently refrangible homogeneous rays of light were contained in the light, and these, separated by their different refrangibility, now show an

elongated and at the same time differently colored image: ergo - bibamus! (therefore, let us drink!)"

Every error must be reducible to such an inference from a hypothetical major premise that has often been falsely generalized, and that arose from the assumption of a ground for a consequent. This does not include mere mistakes in calculation, which are not really errors but simple mistakes: the operation indicated by the concepts of the numbers was not carried out in pure intuition, in counting, but another operation was carried out in its place.

As for the *content* of the sciences in general, it is really always the relation of the appearances of the world to one another according to the principle of sufficient reason, and under the guidance of the why that is valid and meaningful through that principle alone. The demonstration of that relation is called *explanation*. Explanation, therefore, can never go further than showing two representations in the relation expressed by the form of the principle of sufficient reason that governs the class to which they belong.

Once explanation has reached this point, no further why can be asked at all. For the relation demonstrated is the one that simply cannot be represented otherwise, that is, it is the form of all cognition. Hence one does not ask why $2 + 2 = 4$, or why equality of angles in a triangle determines equality of sides, or why any given cause is followed by its effect, or why the truth of the premises makes the conclusion evident.

Every explanation that does not lead back to a relation of which no further why can be demanded stops at an assumed *qualitas occulta* (hidden quality). But every original force of nature is also of this kind. Every natural-scientific explanation must ultimately stop at such a force, and therefore at something wholly obscure. It must leave the inner essence of a stone just as unexplained as that of a human being; it can give no more account of the gravity, cohesion, chemical properties, and so on that the former exhibits than of the cognition and action of the latter.

Thus gravity, for example, is a *qualitas occulta* (hidden quality), for it can be thought away and therefore does not arise as something necessary from the form of cognition. This, by contrast, is the case with the law of inertia, since it follows from the law of causality; therefore a reduction to it is a completely sufficient explanation.

Two things, then, are absolutely inexplicable, that is, cannot be reduced to the relation expressed by the principle of sufficient reason. First, the principle

of sufficient reason itself in all its four forms, because it is the principle of all explanation, that in relation to which alone explanation has meaning. Second, that which is not reached by this principle, but from which what is original in all appearances proceeds: the thing in itself, cognition of which is not at all subject to the principle of sufficient reason.

This latter must remain wholly unintelligible here, since it can first become intelligible through the following book, in which we will also resume this consideration of the possible achievements of the sciences. But at the point where natural science, indeed every science, leaves things standing, because not only its explanation of them, but even the principle of this explanation, the principle of sufficient reason, does not lead beyond this point: there philosophy really takes things up again and considers them in its own way, wholly different from that of science.

In the essay on the principle of sufficient reason, §51, I showed how, in the different sciences, one or another form of that principle is the chief guiding thread. In fact, perhaps the most fitting division of the sciences could be made according to this. But every explanation given along that guiding thread is, as stated, always only relative. It explains things in relation to one another, but always leaves something unexplained that it already presupposes.

In mathematics, for example, this is space and time; in mechanics, physics, and chemistry, matter, qualities, original forces, and laws of nature; in botany and zoology, the difference of species and life itself; in history, the human race with all its peculiarities of thinking and willing; and in all of them, the principle of sufficient reason in the form applicable each time.

What is peculiar to *philosophy* is that it presupposes nothing whatever as known. Everything is equally foreign to it and a problem: not only the relations of appearances, but these appearances themselves, and indeed the principle of sufficient reason itself, to which the other sciences are satisfied to reduce everything. In philosophy nothing would be gained by such a reduction, since one member of the series is as foreign to it as another; moreover, that kind of connection itself is just as much a problem for philosophy as what is connected by it, and this again remains a problem after the connection has been shown just as much as before.

For, as I have said, precisely what the sciences presuppose and lay at the basis and limit of their explanations is the real problem of philosophy. In this respect philosophy begins where the sciences stop. Proofs cannot be its

foundation, for they derive unknown propositions from known ones; but for philosophy everything is equally unknown and foreign.

There can be no proposition in consequence of which the world with all its appearances would first exist. Therefore a philosophy cannot, as Spinoza wished, be demonstratively derived *ex firmis principiis* (from firm principles). Philosophy is also the most universal knowledge; its chief propositions therefore cannot be consequences of another knowledge still more universal.

The principle of contradiction merely establishes the agreement of concepts; it does not itself give concepts. The principle of sufficient reason explains connections among appearances, not the appearances themselves. Therefore philosophy cannot aim at seeking a *causa efficiens* (efficient cause) or a *causa finalis* (final cause) of the whole world. The present philosophy, at least, in no way asks *from where* or *for what purpose* the world exists, but only *what* the world is.

Here the why is subordinate to the what. For the why already belongs to the world, since it arises only through the form of the world's appearance, the principle of sufficient reason, and has meaning and validity only insofar as it does so. One might indeed say that everyone knows what the world is without further help, since each person is himself the subject of cognition whose representation it is; and this would be true to that extent.

But that cognition is intuitive; it is in *concreto* (in the concrete). To reproduce it in *abstracto* (in the abstract), to raise successive, changing intuition, and in general everything that the broad concept *feeling* includes and designates merely negatively as what is not abstract, distinct knowledge, precisely into such knowledge, into lasting knowledge: this is the task of philosophy.

Accordingly, philosophy must be a statement in *abstracto* of the essence of the whole world, of the whole as well as of all its parts. Yet in order not to lose itself in an endless multitude of individual judgments, it must use abstraction and think everything individual in the universal, and its differences again in the universal. It will therefore partly separate and partly unite, in order to hand over to knowledge, gathered into a few abstract concepts, all the manifoldness of the world in general according to its essence.

Through those concepts in which philosophy fixes the essence of the world, however, the wholly individual must be cognized just as much as the universal; cognition of both must therefore be connected with the greatest exactness.

Hence the capacity for philosophy consists precisely in what Plato placed it in: recognizing the one in the many and the many in the one.

Philosophy will accordingly be a sum of very universal judgments whose ground of knowing is immediately the world itself in its entirety, excluding nothing: thus everything found in human consciousness. It will be *a complete repetition, as it were a reflection, of the world in abstract concepts*. This is possible only by uniting what is essentially identical in *one* concept and separating what is different into another.

Bacon of Verulam already set this task for philosophy when he said:

ea demum vera est philosophia, quae mundi ipsius voces fidelissime reddit, et veluti dictante mundo conscripta est, et nihil aliud est, quam ejusdem simulacrum et reflectio, neque addit quidquam de proprio, sed tantum iterat et resonat. (de augm. scient., L. 2, c. 13).

Translation: That alone is true philosophy which most faithfully renders the voices of the world itself, and is written as if from the world's dictation; it is nothing other than the world's image and reflection, adding nothing of its own, but only repeating and echoing.

We take this, however, in a broader sense than Bacon could then have imagined.

The agreement that all sides and parts of the world have with one another, precisely because they belong to one whole, must also be found again in that abstract image of the world. Accordingly, in that sum of judgments, one could in a certain sense be derived from another, and indeed always reciprocally. But for this they must first exist, and thus must first be set up as immediately grounded by cognition of the world in concreto; all the more so because every immediate grounding is more certain than a mediated one.

Their harmony with one another, by virtue of which they even flow together into the unity of *one* thought, and which springs from the harmony and unity of the intuitive world itself, their common ground of knowing, will therefore not be used as the first thing for grounding them, but will only be added as confirmation of their truth. This task itself can become completely clear only through its solution. ^[3]

On this, chapter 13 of the second volume.

Notes

Notes

1. One must not think here of Kant's misuse of these Greek expressions, which is criticized in the appendix. ↩

2. Spinoza, who always boasts of proceeding more *geometrico* (in the geometric manner), in fact did this even more than he himself knew. What was certain and settled for him from an immediate, intuitive apprehension of the essence of the world, he tries to demonstrate logically, independently of that cognition. But he obtains the intended result, already certain for him beforehand, only by arbitrarily taking self-made concepts, such as *substantia* (substance), *causa sui* (cause of itself), and so on, as his starting point, and by allowing himself in proof all those arbitrarinesses for which the nature of wide concept-spheres gives convenient opportunity. What is true and excellent in his doctrine is therefore wholly independent of the proofs, just as in geometry.

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3. On this, chapter 17 of the second volume. ↩

§. 16.

After this whole consideration of reason as a special faculty of cognition belonging to the human being alone, and of the achievements and phenomena peculiar to human nature that it brings about, it would now remain for me to speak of reason insofar as it guides human actions, and therefore can be called *practical* in this respect. But most of what should be mentioned here has found its place elsewhere, namely in the appendix to this work, where the existence of what Kant called practical reason had to be disputed. He presents it, very conveniently, as the immediate source of all virtue and as the seat of an absolute, that is, heaven-sent, *ought*. Later I gave a detailed and thorough refutation of this Kantian principle of morality in the *Two Fundamental Problems of Ethics*.

I therefore have only a little more to say here about the actual influence of reason, in the true sense of the word, on action. Already at the beginning of our consideration of reason we noted in general how greatly human doing and conduct differ from those of the animal, and that this difference is to be regarded solely as a consequence of the presence of abstract concepts in consciousness.

The influence of these concepts on our whole existence is so pervasive and significant that it places us in relation to animals somewhat as seeing animals stand to eyeless animals, such as certain larvae, worms, and zoophytes. The latter cognize by touch alone what is immediately present to them in space and in contact with them; the seeing animals, by contrast, cognize a wide circle of near and far.

In the same way, the absence of reason restricts animals to the intuitive representations immediately present to them in time, that is, to real objects. We, by contrast, by virtue of cognition in abstracto (in the abstract), encompass, alongside the narrow actual present, the whole past and future, together with the wide realm of possibility. We survey life freely on all sides, far beyond the present and actuality.

What the eye is in space and for sensible cognition, reason is, in a certain way, in time and for inner cognition. Yet just as the visibility of objects has value and meaning only because it announces their tangibility, the whole value of abstract cognition always lies in its relation to intuitive cognition.

For this reason the natural human being always places far more value on what is immediately and intuitively cognized than on abstract concepts, on what is merely thought. He prefers empirical cognition to logical cognition. The opposite disposition belongs to those who live more in words than in deeds, who have looked more into paper and books than into the actual world, and who in their greatest degeneration become pedants and people of the letter.

From this alone it becomes intelligible how Leibniz, Wolff, and all their followers could go so far astray, following Duns Scotus, as to declare intuitive cognition to be only confused abstract cognition. To Spinoza's honor I must mention that his more correct sense, conversely, explained all common concepts as arising from the confusion of what is intuitively cognized (Ethics, II, proposition 40, scholium 1).

From that inverted disposition it also arose that in mathematics people rejected its peculiar evidence in order to admit only logical evidence; that every non-abstract cognition was generally included under the broad name feeling and held in low esteem; and finally that Kantian ethics declared the good will that responds purely and immediately to cognition of the circumstances, and guides one to right-doing and beneficence, to be mere feeling and impulse, without worth or merit, and wanted to recognize moral worth only in action proceeding from abstract maxims.

The all-sided overview of life as a whole, which the human being has in advance of the animal through reason, may also be compared to a geometrical, colorless, abstract, reduced ground plan of his path through life. In this respect he stands to the animal as the navigator, who by means of chart, compass, and quadrant knows his course and his position on the sea at every moment, stands to the ignorant crew that sees only waves and sky.

It is therefore worth considering, indeed wonderful, how the human being, alongside his life in concreto (in the concrete), always also leads a second life in abstracto. In the first, he is given over to all the storms of actuality and to the influence of the present; he must strive, suffer, and die like the animal. But his life in the abstract, as it stands before rational reflection, is the quiet reflection of the first life and of the world in which he lives; it is the reduced ground plan just mentioned.

Here, in the region of calm deliberation, what wholly possesses him and violently moves him there appears cold, colorless, and for the moment alien. Here he is mere spectator and observer. In this withdrawal into reflection he

resembles an actor who has played his scene and, until he must appear again, takes his place among the spectators; from there he calmly watches whatever may happen, even if it is the preparation for his death in the play, and then goes back and acts and suffers as he must.

From this double life arises that human composure which differs so greatly from animal thoughtlessness. After prior deliberation, a resolution once taken, or a necessity recognized, a person can cold-bloodedly let the most important, often most terrible things happen to him, or can carry them out: suicide, execution, duel, life-threatening ventures of every kind, and in general things against which his whole animal nature rebels.

Then one sees the extent to which reason becomes master over animal nature, and one calls out to the strong person:

σιδήρειόν νύ τοι ἦτορ!

ferreum certe tibi cor!

Translation: Surely you have an iron heart! (Iliad, 24.521)

Here one can truly say that reason expresses itself *practically*. Wherever action is guided by reason, wherever the motives are abstract concepts, wherever the determining factor is not intuitive, individual representations or the impression of the moment, which guides the animal, there *practical reason* shows itself.

But all this is entirely different from, and independent of, the ethical worth of action. Rational action and virtuous action are two entirely different things. Reason can be united with great wickedness just as well as with great goodness, and by joining either one first gives it great efficacy. It is equally ready and serviceable for the methodical and consistent execution of a noble or a bad resolve, of a prudent or an unreasonable maxim. This follows from its feminine, receptive, preservative, and not self-generating nature.

I have set all this out in detail and illustrated it with examples in the appendix. What is said there would have its proper place here; but because of the polemic against Kant's alleged practical reason, it had to be moved there, and so I refer back to it from here.

The most complete development of *practical reason*, in the true and genuine sense of the word, the highest summit to which the human being can rise through the mere use of his reason, and on which his difference from the animal appears most clearly, is represented as an ideal in the *Stoic sage*.

For Stoic ethics is originally and essentially not a doctrine of virtue at all, but merely instruction for rational living, whose aim and purpose is happiness through peace of mind. Virtuous conduct enters into it, so to speak, only per accidens (accidentally), as a means, not as an end. Therefore Stoic ethics, in its whole essence and point of view, is fundamentally different from ethical systems that press directly toward virtue, such as the teachings of the Vedas, Plato, Christianity, and Kant.

The aim of Stoic ethics is happiness: τέλος τὸ εὐδαιμονεῖν ("the end is happiness"); virtutes omnes finem habere beatitudinem (all virtues have happiness as their end), as it says in Stobaeus' account of the Stoa (Ecl., book II, chapter 7, p. 114, and also p. 138). Yet Stoic ethics shows that happiness is to be found securely only in inner peace and tranquility of mind, ἀταραξία (*ataraxia*, undisturbedness), and that this in turn is to be reached only through virtue. This alone is what the expression means when it says that virtue is the highest good.

If, however, the end is gradually forgotten over the means, and virtue is recommended in a way that betrays an entirely different interest from that of one's own happiness, indeed one that too plainly contradicts it, this is one of the inconsistencies by which, in every system, the immediately cognized, or as people say felt, truth forces conclusions back onto the right path. One sees this clearly, for example, in Spinoza's ethics, which derives a pure doctrine of virtue from the egoistic *sum utile quaerere* (to seek one's own advantage) by palpable sophisms.

As I understand the spirit of Stoic ethics, its origin lies in the thought whether the great prerogative of the human being, reason, which indirectly, through planned action and what follows from it, so greatly eases life and its burdens, might not also be capable of withdrawing him at once, either wholly or almost wholly, from the sufferings and torments of every kind that fill his life, immediately, that is, through mere cognition.

It was considered unworthy of reason's prerogative that the being endowed with it, who through it comprehends and surveys an infinity of things and conditions, should nevertheless be exposed, through the present and through the events that the few years of such a short, fleeting, uncertain life can contain, to such violent pains, such great anxiety and suffering, arising from the impetuous pressure of desire and avoidance. It was thought that the proper use of reason must be able to raise the human being above this and make him invulnerable.

Thus Antisthenes said:

Δεῖ κτᾶσθαι νοῦν, ἢ βρόχον
aut mentem parandam, aut laqueum

Translation: Either one must prepare the mind, or prepare a noose. (Plut. de stoic. repugn., chapter 14)

That is, life is so full of plagues and drudgeries that one must either, by means of corrected thoughts, set oneself above it, or leave it.

It was recognized that deprivation and suffering do not arise immediately and necessarily from not having, but only from wanting to have and yet not having. This wanting-to-have is therefore the necessary condition under which alone not-having becomes deprivation and produces pain.

Οὐ πενία λύπην ἐργάζεται, ἀλλὰ ἐπιθυμία
non paupertas dolorem efficit, sed cupiditas

Translation: Poverty does not produce pain, but desire does. (Epict. fragm. 25)

It was also recognized from experience that hope alone, the claim, is what gives birth to and nourishes the wish. Therefore we are not disturbed and tormented by the many evils common to all and unavoidable, nor by goods that are unattainable, but only by the insignificant more or less of what human beings can avoid or attain. Indeed, not only what is absolutely, but even what is relatively unattainable or unavoidable leaves us quite calm. Thus evils that are once and for all attached to our individuality, or goods that must necessarily remain denied to it, are regarded with indifference; and, in accordance with this human peculiarity, every wish soon dies and can therefore no longer produce pain, if only no hope gives it nourishment.

From all this it followed that all happiness rests only on the relation between our claims and what we receive. Whether the two magnitudes in this relation are great or small is irrelevant; the relation can be established just as well by decreasing the first magnitude as by increasing the second. Likewise, all suffering really arises from the disproportion between what we demand and expect and what we receive. But this disproportion plainly lies only in cognition ^[1], and could be entirely removed through better insight.

Thus Chrysippus said, δεῖ ζῆν κατ' ἐμπειρίαν τῶν φύσει συμβαινόντων ("one should live with proper knowledge of the course of things in the world"; Stob. Ecl., book II, chapter 7, p. 134). For whenever a human being loses composure

in any way, is struck down by misfortune, becomes angry, or loses heart, he thereby shows that he finds things otherwise than he expected. Consequently, he had been caught in error; he did not know the world and life. He did not know how, at every step, lifeless nature through chance, and living nature through opposing aims and also through malice, cross the will of the individual.

He has either not used his reason in order to arrive at a universal knowledge of this character of life, or else he lacks power of judgment, since what he knows in general he fails to recognize again in the particular, and is therefore surprised and thrown out of composure by it. ^[2]

So too every lively joy is an error, an illusion, because no attained wish can give lasting satisfaction, and because every possession and every happiness is only lent by chance for an indefinite time and can therefore be demanded back again in the next hour. Every pain rests on the disappearance of such an illusion. Both, then, arise from faulty cognition. Therefore jubilation and pain alike remain always far from the sage, and no event disturbs his ataraxia (undisturbedness).

In accordance with this spirit and purpose of the Stoa, *Epictetus* begins with, and constantly returns to, the core of his wisdom: that one should carefully consider and distinguish what depends on us and what does not, and therefore make absolutely no calculation on the latter. In this way one will reliably remain free from all pain, suffering, and anxiety.

What depends on us, however, is the will alone. Here there now occurs a gradual transition to the doctrine of virtue. It is observed that, just as the external world, which does not depend on us, determines happiness and unhappiness, so from the will arises inner satisfaction or dissatisfaction with ourselves.

Later the question was asked whether the names bonum et malum (good and evil) should be applied to the former pair or to the latter. This was really arbitrary and optional, and made no difference to the matter. Nevertheless the Stoics disputed over it endlessly with the Peripatetics and Epicureans, entertaining themselves with the inadmissible comparison of two wholly incommensurable magnitudes and with the opposed, paradoxical sayings that arose from it and that they hurled at one another. Cicero's *Paradoxa* gives us an interesting compilation of these from the Stoic side.

Zeno, the founder, seems originally to have taken a somewhat different path. His starting point was that, in order to attain the highest good, that is, blessedness and peace of mind, one should live in agreement with oneself.

ὁμολογουμένως ζῆν· τοῦτο δ' ἐστὶ καθ' ἓνα λόγον καὶ σύμφωνον ζῆν.

Consonanter vivere: hoc est secundum unam rationem et concordem sibi vivere.

Translation: To live harmoniously: that is, to live according to one reason and in agreement with oneself. (Stob. Ecl. eth., book II, chapter 7, p. 132)

Likewise:

Ἀρετὴν διάθεσιν εἶναι ψυχῆς σύμφωνον ἑαυτῇ περὶ ὅλον τὸν βίον.

Virtutem esse animi affectionem secum per totam vitam consentientem.

Translation: Virtue is a disposition of the soul agreeing with itself throughout the whole of life. (ibid., p. 104)

But this was possible only by determining oneself throughout *rationaly*, according to concepts, not according to changing impressions and moods. Since only the maxim of our action is in our power, not the success or the external circumstances, one had, in order always to remain consistent, to make only that maxim one's end, not success and external circumstances. In this way the doctrine of virtue was again introduced.

But already *Zeno's* immediate successors found his moral principle, living in agreement, too formal and empty of content. They therefore gave it material content by adding "to live in agreement with nature" (ὁμολογουμένως τῇ φύσει ζῆν), which, as *Stobaeus* reports in the passage cited, was first added by *Cleanthes*. This pushed the matter very far afield, because of the wide sphere of the concept and the indefiniteness of the expression. For *Cleanthes* meant the whole of universal nature, but *Chrysippus* meant human nature in particular (Diog. Laert., 7, 89).

What was appropriate to this latter alone was then supposed to be virtue, just as satisfaction of animal drives is appropriate to animal natures. Thus the doctrine was again forcibly turned toward virtue, and, come what may, ethics was to be grounded through physics. For the Stoics aimed everywhere at unity of principle; indeed, with them God and the world were not two different things at all.

Stoic ethics, taken as a whole, is in fact a very estimable and respectable attempt to use the great prerogative of the human being, reason, for an

important and salutary purpose: namely, to raise him above the sufferings and pains to which every life has fallen prey, by means of an instruction:

Qua ratione queas traducere leniter aevum:

Ne te semper inops agitet vexetque cupido,

Ne pavor et rerum mediocriter utilium spes.

Translation: By what method you may pass your life gently: so that needy desire does not always drive and torment you, nor fear and hope for things of moderate use.

In this way it seeks to make the human being partake, in the highest degree, of the dignity that belongs to him as a rational being in contrast to the animal, and of which one can indeed speak in this sense, though not in another.

This view of Stoic ethics made it necessary to mention it here, in the presentation of what reason is and what it can accomplish. Yet however much that aim is attainable to a certain degree through the application of reason and through a merely rational ethics, as experience also shows that those purely rational characters commonly called practical philosophers are probably the happiest, and rightly so, since just as the genuine, that is, theoretical philosopher transfers life into the concept, they transfer the concept into life: still, a great deal is lacking before anything perfect of this kind can come about, or before correctly used reason could really withdraw us from all the burden and suffering of life and lead us to blessedness.

Rather, there is a complete contradiction in wanting to live without suffering, a contradiction already contained in the often-used expression "blessed life." This will certainly become clear to anyone who has grasped my following presentation to its end.

This contradiction already reveals itself in that ethics of pure reason itself, since the Stoic is forced to weave into his instruction for a blessed life, for that is what his ethics always remains, a recommendation of suicide. It is like the precious little vial of poison found among the magnificent ornament and equipment of Oriental despots. The recommendation applies in the case where bodily sufferings, which cannot be philosophized away by any propositions and inferences, become overwhelming and incurable. Then the Stoic's sole aim, blessedness, is nevertheless frustrated, and nothing remains for escaping suffering except death, which is then to be taken indifferently, like any other medicine.

Here a strong contrast becomes clear between Stoic ethics and all those doctrines mentioned above, which make virtue itself and immediately, even with the heaviest sufferings, the end, and do not want one to end life in order to escape suffering. None of them, however, knew how to state the true ground for rejecting suicide; instead they laboriously gathered all sorts of specious grounds. In the fourth book that ground will arise in the context of our consideration.

But the contrast just mentioned reveals and confirms precisely the essential difference, lying in the fundamental principle, between the Stoa, which is really only a special eudaimonism, and those doctrines just mentioned, although both often meet in their results and have an apparent kinship.

The inner contradiction already mentioned, with which Stoic ethics is burdened even in its basic thought, further shows itself in the fact that its ideal, the Stoic sage, could never gain life or inner poetic truth even in its own presentation. He remains a wooden, stiff mannequin, with whom one can do nothing, and who himself does not know what to do with his wisdom. His perfect calm, satisfaction, and blessedness directly contradict the essence of humanity and allow us to arrive at no intuitive representation of him.

How wholly different, when placed beside him, appear the world-conquerors and voluntary penitents that Indian wisdom presents to us and has actually produced; or even the Savior of Christianity, that excellent figure full of deep life, of the greatest poetic truth and highest significance, who nevertheless, with perfect virtue, holiness, and sublimity, stands before us in the state of the highest suffering.^[3]

Notes

Notes

1. Omnes perturbationes iudicio censent fieri et opinione. Cic. Tusc., 4, 6. Translation: All disturbances are held to arise through judgment and opinion. Ταράσσει τοὺς ἀνθρώπους οὐ τὰ πράγματα, ἀλλὰ τὰ περὶ τῶν πραγμάτων δόγματα. Perturbant homines non res ipsae, sed de rebus opiniones. Epictet., c. V. Translation: Human beings are disturbed not by things themselves, but by their opinions about things. ↩

2. Τοῦτο γάρ ἐστι τὸ αἴτιον τοῖς ἀνθρώποις πάντων τῶν κακῶν, τὸ τὰς προλήψεις τὰς κοινὰς μὴ δύνασθαι ἐφαρμόζειν τοῖς ἐπὶ μέρους. Haec est causa mortalibus omnium malorum, non posse communes notiones aptare singularibus. Epict. dissert., IV, 1, 42. Translation: This is

the cause of all evils for mortals: not being able to apply common notions to particular cases.
Editorial note: the German extract cites III, 26; the quoted words occur at IV, 1, 42. ↩

3. On this, chapter 16 of the second volume. ↩

§. 17.

Second Book.

First Consideration of the World as Will:
The Objectivation of the Will.

Nos habitat, non tartara, sed nec sidera coeli:

Spiritus, in nobis qui viget, illa facit.

Translation: It is not Tartarus, nor the stars of heaven, that dwells in us;
the spirit that lives in us makes them.

In the first book we considered representation only as such, and therefore only according to its general form. As for abstract representation, the concept, we did also come to know it according to its content, insofar as it has all content and meaning only through its relation to intuitive representation, without which it would be without worth and without content. Referred entirely, then, to intuitive representation, we will now demand to know its content as well, its closer determinations, and the forms it presents to us.

Above all, it will matter to us to obtain some clarification about its real meaning, about that meaning which otherwise is only felt. By virtue of this meaning, these images do not pass by us as something wholly alien and meaningless, as they otherwise would have to do; rather, they speak to us immediately, are understood, and acquire an interest that lays claim to our whole being.

We direct our gaze toward mathematics, natural science, and philosophy, each of which lets us hope that it will give part of the desired clarification.

First, however, we find philosophy as a monster with many heads, each of which speaks a different language. To be sure, they are not all at odds with one another about the point raised here, the meaning of intuitive representation. With the exception of the skeptics and idealists, the others, in the main, speak rather consistently of an *object* that would lie at the *ground* of representation, and which, though different from representation in its whole being and essence, would nevertheless be as similar to it in every respect as one egg is to another.

But this will not help us. For we do not know how to distinguish such an object from representation at all. Rather, we find that the two are one and the same, since every object always and forever presupposes a subject and therefore

still remains representation. We have also recognized objecthood itself as belonging to the most universal form of representation, which is precisely the falling apart into object and subject.

Moreover, the principle of sufficient reason to which people appeal here is likewise for us only a form of representation: namely, the lawful connection of one representation with another. It is not the connection of the whole finite or endless series of representations with something that would not be representation at all, and therefore could not be representable at all. Skeptics and idealists were discussed above, in the treatment of the dispute over the reality of the external world.

If we now seek the desired closer knowledge of that intuitive representation, which has become known to us only quite generally and merely according to form, from mathematics, then mathematics will speak to us of those representations only insofar as they fill time and space, that is, insofar as they are magnitudes. It will state the how-much and how-large with the greatest exactness. But since this is always only relative, that is, a comparison of one representation with others, and indeed only in the one-sided respect of magnitude, this too will not be the information we are chiefly seeking.

Finally, if we look toward the wide domain of natural science, divided into many fields, we can first distinguish two main divisions of it. It is either description of forms, which I call *morphology*, or explanation of changes, which I call *aetiology*. The former considers the enduring forms; the latter considers changing matter according to the laws of its transition from one form into another.

The former is what, though improperly, is called natural history in its whole scope. Especially as botany and zoology, it teaches us to know the different organic forms, enduring through the ceaseless change of individuals and thereby firmly determined, which make up a large part of the content of intuitive representation. It classifies them, separates them, unites them, orders them according to natural and artificial systems, and brings them under concepts that make an overview and knowledge of all of them possible.

Furthermore, morphology shows an infinitely nuanced analogy running through all these forms, both in the whole and in the parts, the unite de plan (unity of plan), by virtue of which they resemble very many variations on a theme that is not given along with them. The transition of matter into those forms, that is, the origin of individuals, is not a main part of its consideration,

since each individual proceeds from one like itself through generation. This process, everywhere equally mysterious, has so far eluded distinct cognition. The little that is known of it finds its place in physiology, which already belongs to aetiological natural science.

Mineralogy, which in the main belongs to morphology, already inclines toward aetiology as well, especially where it becomes geology. Proper aetiology consists in all those branches of natural science in which cognition of cause and effect is everywhere the main thing. These teach how, according to an infallible rule, *one* state of matter is necessarily followed by a definite other state; how a definite change necessarily conditions and brings about another definite change. This demonstration is called *explanation*. Here we find chiefly mechanics, physics, chemistry, and physiology.

But if we give ourselves over to their instruction, we soon become aware that the information we are chiefly seeking is given to us by aetiology no more than by morphology. The latter presents us with innumerable forms, infinitely varied and yet related by an unmistakable family resemblance. For us, they are representations that remain forever alien to us along this path, and, when considered merely in this way, stand before us like hieroglyphs we do not understand.

Aetiology, by contrast, teaches us that, according to the law of cause and effect, this definite state of matter brings about that other one. With this it has explained it and done what belongs to it. Yet fundamentally it does nothing more than demonstrate the lawful order according to which states enter into space and time, and teach for all cases which appearance must necessarily occur at this time and in this place. It therefore determines their place in time and space according to a law whose determinate content has been taught by experience, but whose general form and necessity are conscious to us independently of experience.

But through this we receive not the least clarification about the inner essence of any of those appearances. This is called *natural force*, and it lies outside the domain of aetiological explanation. Aetiology calls the unchanging constancy with which the manifestation of such a force occurs, whenever the known conditions for it are present, a *law of nature*. This law of nature, these conditions, this occurrence with reference to a definite place at a definite time, are all that aetiology knows and ever can know.

The force itself that manifests itself, the inner essence of the appearances that occur according to those laws, remains forever a mystery to it, something wholly alien and unknown, in the simplest as in the most complicated appearance. For although aetiology has so far reached its goal most completely in mechanics and most incompletely in physiology, the force by virtue of which a stone falls to the earth, or one body pushes another onward, is no less alien and mysterious to us in its inner essence than the force that produces the movements and growth of an animal.

Mechanics presupposes matter, gravity, impenetrability, the communicability of motion by impact, rigidity, and so on as unfathomable, calls them natural forces, calls their necessary and regular appearance under certain conditions a law of nature, and only then begins its explanation. This explanation consists in stating faithfully and with mathematical exactness how, where, and when each force manifests itself, and in reducing every appearance that comes before it to one of those forces.

Physics, chemistry, and physiology proceed in the same way in their own domains, except that they presuppose much more and accomplish less. Accordingly, even the most complete aetiological explanation of the whole of nature would never really be more than a catalogue of inexplicable forces, and a secure statement of the rule according to which their appearances enter into time and space, succeed one another, and make room for one another. But the inner essence of the forces thus appearing would always have to remain unexplained, because the law aetiology follows does not lead there. It would have to stop at the appearance and its order.

In this respect it would be comparable to a cross-section of marble, which shows many veins beside one another, but does not allow us to recognize the course of those veins inside the marble up to that surface. Or, if I may allow myself a humorous comparison because it is more striking: even with the completed aetiology of the whole of nature, the philosophical investigator would still have to feel like someone who, without knowing how, had fallen into a society entirely unknown to him, whose members, one after another, each presented another to him as his friend and cousin and thereby made him sufficiently acquainted with them. Meanwhile, each time he assured the person presented that he was pleased to meet him, he would always have the question on his lips: "But how the devil did I get into this whole company?"

Thus aetiology, too, can never give us the desired clarification that would lead us beyond those appearances which we know only as our representations. For after all its explanations, they still stand before us as mere representations whose meaning we do not understand, wholly alien. The causal connection gives only the rule and relative order of their occurrence in space and time, but does not teach us to know more closely what it is that occurs in this way.

Moreover, the law of causality itself has validity only for representations, for objects of a definite class, under whose presupposition alone it has meaning. Like these objects themselves, it therefore exists always only in relation to the subject, and hence conditionally. For this reason it is known just as much when one starts from the subject, that is, a priori (prior to experience), as when one starts from the object, that is, a posteriori (after experience), as Kant has taught us.

What now drives us to inquiry is precisely that it does not satisfy us to know that we have representations, that they are such and such, and that they are connected according to these and those laws, whose universal expression is always the principle of sufficient reason. We want to know the meaning of that representation. We ask whether this world is nothing more than representation, in which case it would have to pass by us like an insubstantial dream or a ghostly airy image, not worth our attention; or whether it is also something else, something besides representation, and what this then is.

This much is immediately certain: what is being asked about must be something completely different from representation, in its whole essence and nature. Therefore the forms and laws of representation must also be wholly foreign to it. Hence, starting from representation, one cannot reach it by following the thread of those laws that connect only objects, representations, with one another, namely the forms of the principle of sufficient reason.

We already see here that the essence of things can never be reached from *outside*. However much one investigates, one gains nothing but images and names. One resembles someone who walks around a castle, vainly seeking an entrance and meanwhile sketching the facades. And yet this is the path all philosophers before me have taken.

§. 18.

In fact, the meaning we are seeking in the world that stands before me merely as my representation, or the transition from it as mere representation of the knowing subject to whatever it may be besides this, could never be found if the investigator himself were nothing more than the purely knowing subject, a winged angel's head without a body.

But he himself is rooted in that world. He finds himself in it as an *individual*; that is, his cognition, which is the conditioning bearer of the whole world as representation, is nevertheless thoroughly mediated by a body. As was shown, the affections of this body are the starting point from which the understanding intuits that world.

For the purely knowing subject as such, this body is a representation like any other, an object among objects. Its movements and actions are, to that extent, known to him in no other way than the changes of all other intuitive objects. They would be just as alien and incomprehensible to him if their meaning had not been deciphered for him in an entirely different way.

Otherwise he would see his action follow upon presented motives with the constancy of a law of nature, just as the changes of other objects follow upon causes, stimuli, and motives. But he would understand the influence of motives no more intimately than the connection between any other effect that appears to him and its cause. He would then call the inner, incomprehensible essence of those expressions and actions of his body a force, a quality, or a character, as he pleased, but he would have no further insight into it.

But this is not how things stand. Rather, to the subject of cognition who appears as an individual, the word of the riddle has been given; and this word is *will*. This, and this alone, gives him the key to his own appearance, reveals its meaning to him, and shows him the inner workings of his being, his doing, and his movements.

To the subject of cognition, who appears as an individual through his identity with the body, this body is given in two entirely different ways: first, as representation in intuition through the understanding, as an object among objects and subject to their laws; then also, at the same time, in an entirely different way, namely as that which is immediately known to everyone and which the word *will* designates.

Every true act of his will is at once and inevitably also a movement of his body. He cannot actually will the act without at the same time perceiving that it appears as a movement of the body. The act of will and the action of the body are not two different states objectively known, connected by the bond of causality; they do not stand in the relation of cause and effect. Rather, they are one and the same thing, given only in two entirely different ways: once quite immediately, and once in intuition for the understanding.

The action of the body is nothing other than the objectified act of will, that is, the act of will that has entered into intuition. Later it will become clear to us that this holds of every movement of the body, not only of movement following upon motives, but also of involuntary movement following upon mere stimuli; indeed, that the whole body is nothing other than the objectified will, that is, will become representation. All this will emerge and become clear in what follows.

I will therefore call the body, which in the previous book and in the essay on the principle of sufficient reason I called the *immediate object*, according to the standpoint deliberately taken there from one side only, namely the standpoint of representation, here, in another respect, the *objecthood of the will*. In a certain sense one can therefore also say: the will is the cognition a priori (prior to experience) of the body, and the body is the cognition a posteriori (after experience) of the will.

Resolutions of the will that relate to the future are mere deliberations of reason about what one will someday will, not genuine acts of will. Only execution stamps the resolution as such; until then it is always only a changeable intention, and exists only in reason, in abstracto (in the abstract). Only in reflection are willing and doing different; in actuality they are one.

Every true, genuine, immediate act of will is at once and immediately also an appearing act of the body. Correspondingly, on the other hand, every effect upon the body is at once and immediately also an effect upon the will. As such, it is called pain when it is contrary to the will, and well-being or pleasure when it accords with the will. The gradations of both are very different.

But one is entirely wrong to call pain and pleasure representations. They are by no means representations, but immediate affections of the will in its appearance, the body: a forced, momentary willing or not-willing of the impression the body undergoes.

Only a few impressions on the body are to be considered immediately as mere representations, and therefore exempted from what has just been said. These are the only impressions through which the body is the immediate object of cognition; for as intuition in the understanding it is already a mediate object, like all others. I mean here the affections of the purely objective senses, sight, hearing, and touch, though only insofar as these organs are affected in the special, specific, natural way proper to them. Such affection is an extremely weak stimulation of the heightened and specifically modified sensibility of these parts, so weak that it does not affect the will. Undisturbed by any arousal of the will, it merely supplies the understanding with the data from which intuition arises.

Every stronger or different kind of affection of those sense organs, however, is painful, that is, contrary to the will, and therefore also belongs to its objecthood.

Weakness of the nerves shows itself in the fact that impressions which should have only the degree of strength sufficient to make them data for the understanding reach the higher degree at which they move the will, that is, arouse pain or well-being. More often they arouse pain, though partly dull and indistinct; hence not only are individual tones and strong light felt painfully, but in general a morbid hypochondriacal mood is also produced, without being distinctly recognized.

Furthermore, the identity of body and will shows itself, among other things, in the fact that every violent and excessive movement of the will, that is, every affect, immediately shakes the body and its inner mechanism and disturbs the course of its vital functions. This is set out in detail in *On Will in Nature*, p. 27 of the second edition.

Finally, although the cognition I have of my will is immediate, it is nevertheless not to be separated from cognition of my body. I do not know my will as a whole, not as a unity, not completely according to its essence. I know it only in its individual acts, and therefore in time, which is the form of the appearance of my body, as of every object. Hence the body is the condition of cognition of my will. Accordingly, I cannot really represent this will without my body.

In the essay on the principle of sufficient reason, the will, or rather the subject of willing, is indeed presented as a special class of representations or objects. Yet even there we saw this object coincide with the subject, that is,

precisely cease to be an object. There we called this coincidence the miracle *κατ' ἐξοχήν* (*kat' exochen*, par excellence). In a certain sense, the whole present work is the explanation of that miracle.

Insofar as I actually know my will as an object, I know it as body. But then I am once again with the first class of representations established in that essay, that is, with real objects. As we proceed, we will see more and more that that first class of representations finds its clarification, its deciphering, only in the fourth class established there, which no longer really wanted to stand opposed to the subject as object. Correspondingly, we must learn to understand, from the law of motivation that governs the fourth class, the inner essence of the law of causality that holds in the first class, and of what occurs according to it.

The identity of the will and the body, which has now been provisionally set forth, can only be shown as it has been here, for the first time, and as it will be shown more and more as we proceed. That is, it can be raised from immediate consciousness, from cognition in concreto (in the concrete), to the knowledge of reason, or transferred into cognition in abstracto (in the abstract).

By its nature, however, it can never be proved, that is, derived as mediate cognition from some other immediate cognition, precisely because it is itself the most immediate cognition. If we do not grasp and hold fast to it as such, we will wait in vain to receive it again in some mediate way, as derived cognition.

It is cognition of an entirely distinctive kind. For this reason, its truth cannot even properly be placed under any of the four rubrics into which, in the essay on the principle of sufficient reason, section 29 and following, I divided all truth: logical, empirical, metaphysical, and metalogical. For it is not, as all of those are, the relation of an abstract representation to another representation, or to the necessary form of intuitive or abstract representing. Rather, it is the relation of a judgment to the relation that an intuitive representation, the body, has to what is not representation at all, but something different from it *toto genere* (in kind altogether): will.

For this reason I would like to distinguish this truth above all others and call it, *κατ' ἐξοχήν* (*kat' exochen*, par excellence), *philosophical truth*. Its expression can be turned in various ways, and one may say: my body and my will are one; or, what as intuitive representation I call my body, insofar as I am conscious of it in an entirely different way, comparable with no other, I call my will; or, my body is the *objecthood* of my will; or, apart from the fact that my body is my representation, it is only my will; and so on.^[1]

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Notes

1. On this, chapter 18 of the second volume. ↩

§. 19.

In the first book, with inward resistance, we declared our own body, like all the other objects of this intuitive world, to be mere representation of the knowing subject. Now it has become clear to us what distinguishes, in everyone's consciousness, the representation of one's own body from all others, though otherwise it is entirely like them. The distinction is this: the body also occurs in consciousness in an entirely different way, different *toto genere* (in kind altogether), which is designated by the word *will*. And precisely this double cognition that we have of our own body gives us the clarification about the body itself, about its acting and moving on motives, and also about its suffering through external influence; in a word, about what it is not as representation, but besides this, and therefore what it is *in itself*. This is the clarification we do not immediately have about the essence, acting, and suffering of all other real objects.

The knowing subject is an individual precisely through this special relation to one body, which, considered apart from that relation, is only a representation like all the rest. But the relation by virtue of which the knowing subject is an *individual* exists for just this reason only between it and a single one among all its representations. Therefore it is conscious of this one representation not merely as a representation, but at the same time in an entirely different way, namely as a will.

If, however, the subject abstracts from that special relation, from that double and wholly heterogeneous cognition of one and the same thing, then that one thing, the body, is a representation like all others. So, in order to orient itself here, the knowing individual must assume one of two things.

Either it must assume that what distinguishes that one representation lies merely in the fact that its cognition stands only to this one representation in this double relation; that insight into only this *one* intuitive object is open to it in two ways at once; and that this is to be explained not by a difference between this object and all others, but only by a difference between the relation of its cognition to this one object and the relation it has to all the others.

Or else it must assume that this one object is essentially different from all others, that it alone among all objects is at once will and representation, while the rest are mere representation, that is, mere phantoms; thus that its body is the

only real individual in the world, that is, the only appearance of will and the only immediate object of the subject.

That the other objects, considered as mere *representations*, are like its body, that is, that like it they fill space, which itself can possibly exist only as representation, and also act in space as it does: this is indeed demonstrably certain from the law of causality, which is secure a priori (prior to experience) for representations and admits no effect without a cause. Yet apart from the fact that from an effect one may infer only a cause in general, not an identical cause, one still remains here within the field of mere representation, for which alone the law of causality holds and beyond which it can never lead.

Whether, however, the objects known to the individual only as representations are nevertheless, like his own body, appearances of a will: this, as was already stated in the previous book, is the real meaning of the question concerning the reality of the external world. To deny it is the meaning of *theoretical egoism*, which thereby takes all appearances except its own individual to be phantoms, just as practical egoism does precisely the same thing in a practical respect, namely by seeing and treating only its own person as truly real and all others as mere phantoms.

Theoretical egoism can indeed never be refuted by proofs. Still, in philosophy it has surely never been used otherwise than as a skeptical sophism, that is, for appearance's sake. As a serious conviction, by contrast, it could be found only in a madhouse; and as such it would need not so much a proof against it as a cure. We therefore will not concern ourselves further with it in this respect, but will regard it only as the last fortress of skepticism, which is always polemical.

Our cognition is always bound to individuality, and has its limitation precisely in this. It therefore necessarily brings with it that each person can only *be* one thing, but can *know* everything else; and this limitation is exactly what creates the need for philosophy. Since we, for just this reason, strive through philosophy to widen the limits of our cognition, we will regard the skeptical argument of theoretical egoism that confronts us here as a small border fortress. It is indeed forever unconquerable, but its garrison can also never come out of it; hence one may pass it by and leave it in the rear without danger.

Accordingly, the double cognition we now have of the essence and action of our own body, a cognition brought to clarity and given in two wholly heterogeneous ways, will be used from here on as a key to the essence of every

appearance in nature. All objects that are not our own body, and are therefore not given to our consciousness in two ways but only as representations, we will judge by analogy with that body. We will therefore assume that, just as on one side they are representation, entirely as it is, and are homogeneous with it in that respect, so on the other side, if one sets aside their existence as representation of the subject, what then remains must, in its inner essence, be the same as what we call *will* in ourselves.

For what other kind of existence or reality could we attribute to the rest of the corporeal world? Where would we take the elements from which to compose such a reality? Apart from will and representation, nothing at all is known to us or even thinkable. If we want to attribute to the corporeal world, which stands there immediately only in our representation, the greatest reality known to us, then we give it the reality that each person's own body has for him; for this body is what is most real to everyone.

But if we now analyze the reality of this body and its actions, then, apart from the fact that it is our representation, we find nothing in it except the will. With this, even its reality is exhausted. We can therefore nowhere find some other kind of reality to attribute to the corporeal world.

If, then, the corporeal world is to be something more than merely our representation, we must say that apart from representation, and therefore in itself and according to its innermost essence, it is what we find immediately in ourselves as will. I say: according to its innermost essence. But first we must come to know this essence of the will more closely, so that we may know how to distinguish from it what does not belong to the will itself, but already to its appearance, which has many grades. Such, for example, is its being accompanied by cognition, and the determination by motives that is conditioned by cognition. As we will see in what follows, this belongs not to the essence of the will, but only to its distinct appearance as animal and human being.

Therefore, when I say that the force which drives the stone to the earth is, according to its essence, in itself and apart from all representation, will, one must not attribute to this proposition the absurd opinion that the stone moves according to a known motive, because will appears in this way in human beings.^[1]

Now, however, we want to show, ground, and develop in its whole scope, more fully and clearly, what has been presented up to this point only provisionally and in general terms.^[2]

Notes

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1. We will therefore by no means agree with Bacon of Verulam when he (*de augm. scient.* L. 4 in fine; *On the Advancement of Learning*, book 4, at the end) thinks that all mechanical and physical movements of bodies occur only after a preceding perception in those bodies, although an intimation of the truth gave rise even to this false proposition. The same is true of Kepler's claim, in his treatise *de planeta Martis* (*On the Planet Mars*), that the planets must have cognition in order to find their elliptical paths so accurately and to measure the speed of their movement so that the triangles within the area of their orbit always remain proportional to the time in which they traverse their base. ↩

2. On this, chapter 19 of the second volume. ↩

§. 20.

As the essence in itself of one's own body, as that which this body is besides being an object of intuition, a representation, the *will*, as was said, first makes itself known in the voluntary movements of this body. For these movements are nothing other than the visibility of the individual acts of will. They enter immediately and completely at the same time as those acts, as one and the same thing with them, distinguished from them only by the form of knowability into which they have passed, that is, by the fact that they have become representation.

These acts of will, however, still always have a ground outside themselves, in motives. Yet motives never determine more than what I will at *this* time, in *this* place, under *these* circumstances. They do not determine *that* I will at all, nor *what* I will in general, that is, the maxim that characterizes my entire willing.

My willing, therefore, cannot be explained in its whole essence from motives. Motives determine only its expression at the given moment; they are merely the occasion on which my will shows itself. The will itself, by contrast, lies outside the domain of the law of motivation. Only its appearance at each moment is necessarily determined by that law.

Only on the presupposition of my empirical character is the motive the sufficient ground of explanation for my action. But if I abstract from my character and then ask why I will this in general and not that, no answer is possible. For only the *appearance* of the will is subject to the principle of sufficient reason, not the will itself, which in this respect is to be called *groundless*.

Here I partly presuppose Kant's doctrine of the empirical and intelligible character, as well as the relevant discussions in my *Two Fundamental Problems of Ethics*, pp. 48-58, and again pp. 178 ff. of the first edition [2nd ed., pp. 46-57 and 174 ff.]. We will also have to speak of this more fully in the fourth book. For now I need only draw attention to this: that one appearance is grounded by another, here the deed by the motive, in no way conflicts with the fact that its essence in itself is will, which itself has no ground. For the principle of sufficient reason, in all its forms, is merely the form of cognition. Its validity therefore extends only to representation, to appearance, to the visibility of the will, not to the will itself that becomes visible.

Now if every action of my body is the appearance of an act of will, in which, under given motives, my will itself as a whole, and therefore my character, expresses itself again, then the indispensable condition and presupposition of every action must also be appearance of the will. For the will's appearing cannot depend on something that is not immediately and solely through it, something that would therefore be merely accidental for it; otherwise its appearing itself would become merely accidental. But that condition is the whole body itself.

Therefore the body itself must already be appearance of the will. It must stand to my will as a whole, that is, to my intelligible character, whose appearance in time is my empirical character, in the same relation as the individual action of the body stands to the individual act of will. Thus the whole body must be nothing other than my will become visible. It must be my will itself insofar as this will is an intuitive object, a representation of the first class.

As confirmation of this, it has already been mentioned that every effect upon my body at once and immediately affects my will as well, and in this respect is called pain or pleasure, or in a lower degree an agreeable or disagreeable sensation. Conversely, every violent movement of the will, and so every affect and passion, shakes the body and disturbs the course of its functions.

To be sure, one can give an aetiological account, though only very imperfectly, of the origin of my body, and somewhat better of its development and preservation; this is precisely physiology. But physiology explains its subject only in the same way that motives explain action. Therefore, just as the grounding of an individual action by the motive, and the necessary consequence of that action from the motive, in no way conflicts with the fact that the action in general and according to its essence is only the appearance of a will that is groundless in itself, so too the physiological explanation of the functions of the body does not detract from the philosophical truth that the whole existence of this body and the entire series of its functions are only the objectivation of that same will which appears in the body's external actions according to motives.

Indeed, physiology even seeks to trace these external actions themselves, the immediately voluntary movements, back to causes in the organism. For example, it explains the movement of the muscle from an influx of fluids, "like the contraction of a cord that becomes wet," as Reil says in his *Archive for Physiology*, vol. 6, p. 153. But suppose one really did arrive at a thorough explanation of this kind: this would still never abolish the immediately certain

truth that every voluntary movement (*functiones animales*; animal functions) is the appearance of an act of will.

In just the same way, no physiological explanation of vegetative life (*functiones naturales, vitales*; natural, vital functions), however far it might advance, can ever abolish the truth that this whole animal life itself, developing in this way, is appearance of the will.

In general, as was discussed above, every aetiological explanation can never state more than the necessarily determined place in time and space of an individual appearance, its necessary occurrence there according to a fixed rule. By contrast, the inner essence of every appearance always remains unfathomable along this path. It is presupposed by every aetiological explanation and merely indicated by the names force, or law of nature, or, where actions are in question, character, will.

Thus, although every individual action, on the presupposition of the determinate character, necessarily follows when the motive is presented, and although growth, the process of nutrition, and all changes in the animal body proceed according to necessarily acting causes, namely stimuli, nevertheless the whole series of actions, and consequently each individual action, and likewise their condition, the whole body itself that performs them, and consequently also the process through which and in which the body exists, are nothing other than the appearance of the will, the becoming-visible, the *objecthood of the will*.

On this rests the complete appropriateness of the human and animal body to the human and animal will in general. This appropriateness is similar to, but far surpasses, the fit that an intentionally made tool has to the will of its maker, and for this reason it appears as purposiveness, that is, as the teleological explicability of the body.

The parts of the body must therefore correspond perfectly to the chief desires through which the will manifests itself; they must be their visible expression. Teeth, throat, and intestinal canal are objectified hunger; the genitals are the objectified sexual drive; the grasping hands and swift feet correspond to the will's already more mediate striving, which they represent.

As the general human form corresponds to the general human will, so the individual corporeal form corresponds to the individually modified will, the character of the individual. This corporeal form is therefore thoroughly characteristic and expressive, in all its parts.

It is very remarkable that Parmenides already expressed this in the following verses cited by Aristotle (*Metaphysics*, III, 5):

ὥς γὰρ ἕκαστος ἔχει κρᾶσιν μελέων πολυκάμπτων,
τὸς νόος ἀνθρώποισι παρέστηκεν· τὸ γὰρ αὐτό
ἔστιν ὅπερ φρονέει μελέων φύσις ἀνθρώποισιν,
καὶ πᾶσιν καὶ παντί· τὸ γὰρ πλεον ἐστὶ νόημα.

Ut enim cuique complexio membrorum flexibilia se habet, ita mens hominibus adest: idem namque est, quod sapit, membrorum natura hominibus, et omnibus et omni: quod enim plus est, intelligentia est.

Translation: For as each person has the constitution of his many-jointed limbs, so mind is present to human beings; for the nature of the limbs in human beings is the same as what thinks, both in all and in each; for what is more is thought.^[1]

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1. On this, chapter 20 of the second volume; also, in my work *On Will in Nature*, the sections "Physiology" and "Comparative Anatomy," where what is only indicated here has received its thorough development. ↩

§. 21.

Whoever, through all these reflections, has also attained in abstracto (in the abstract), and therefore clearly and securely, the cognition that everyone possesses immediately in concreto (in the concrete), that is, as feeling, namely that the essence in itself of his own appearance is his *will*, will now have gained the key to the innermost essence of all nature.

His own appearance presents itself to him as representation both through his actions and through their enduring substrate, his body. Its essence in itself is the will, which constitutes what is most immediate in his consciousness. Yet as such it has not completely entered into the form of representation, in which object and subject stand opposed to each other. Rather, it announces itself in an immediate way, in which subject and object are not quite distinctly separated. Even so, it does not become known to the individual as a whole, but only in its individual acts.

Whoever, I say, has gained this conviction with me will find that it becomes, entirely of itself, the key to the cognition of the innermost essence of all nature. He will now transfer it also to all those appearances that are not given to him, as his own appearance is, in immediate cognition alongside mediate cognition, but only in the latter, and therefore only one-sidedly, as *representation* alone.

Not only in those appearances that are wholly similar to his own, in human beings and animals, will he recognize that very same will as their innermost essence. Continued reflection will also lead him to recognize as that same will the force that drives and vegetates in the plant; the force by which the crystal forms; the force that turns the magnet toward the north pole; the force whose shock meets him from the contact of heterogeneous metals; the force that appears in the elective affinities of matter as fleeing and seeking, separating and uniting; and finally even gravity itself, which strives so powerfully in all matter, drawing the stone to the earth and the earth to the sun.

All these are different only in appearance. According to their inner essence, they are one and the same: that which is known to him immediately, so intimately, and better than anything else, and which, where it comes forward most distinctly, is called *will*.

This application of reflection alone keeps us from stopping at appearance and carries us over to the *thing in itself*. Appearance means representation, and

nothing more. Every representation, whatever kind it may be, every *object*, is *appearance*. But the *thing in itself* is the *will* alone. As such it is absolutely not representation, but different from it *toto genere* (in kind altogether).

It is that of which every representation, every object, is the appearance, the visibility, the *objecthood*. It is the innermost being, the kernel of each individual thing and likewise of the whole. It appears in every blindly acting natural force; it also appears in the deliberate action of the human being. The great difference between these two concerns only the degree of appearing, not the essence of what appears.

§. 22.

This *thing in itself* (we will keep the Kantian expression as a fixed formula), which as such is never an object, precisely because every object is already only its appearance and no longer the thing itself, had to borrow the name and concept of an object if it was nevertheless to be thought objectively. It had to borrow them from something given objectively in some way, and therefore from one of its appearances.

But in order to serve as a point of reference, this appearance could be no other than the most perfect among all its appearances, that is, the clearest, the most fully unfolded, the one immediately illuminated by cognition. This, however, is precisely the human being's *will*.

One must note carefully, however, that here we are indeed using only a *denominatio a potiori* (a naming from the predominant case), through which the concept of will receives a greater extension than it has had until now.

As Plato so often remarks, cognition of the identical in different appearances, and of the different in similar appearances, is the condition of philosophy. Until now, however, the identity between the essence of every striving and acting force in nature and the will had not been recognized. Hence the many appearances that are only different species of the same genus were not regarded as such, but were taken to be heterogeneous. For this reason, no word could exist to designate the concept of this genus.

I therefore name the genus after its preeminent species, whose nearer and immediate cognition leads us to the mediate cognition of all the others. Yet anyone who is unable to carry out the expansion of the concept required here would remain caught in a permanent misunderstanding. Such a person would continue to understand by the word *will* only the one species that alone has been designated by it until now: the will guided by cognition and expressing itself exclusively according to motives, indeed perhaps only according to abstract motives, and therefore under the guidance of reason. As has been said, however, this is only the clearest appearance of the will.

We must now isolate in thought the innermost essence of this very appearance, which is immediately known to us, and then transfer it to all the weaker, less distinct appearances of the same essence. In this way we accomplish the required expansion of the concept of will.

But I would also be misunderstood in the opposite way by someone who thought it was ultimately all the same whether we designate that essence in itself of all appearance by the word *will* or by some other word. This would be the case if that thing in itself were something whose existence we merely *inferred*, and if we therefore knew it only mediately and only in abstracto (in the abstract). Then one could indeed call it whatever one wished; the name would stand as a mere sign for an unknown quantity.

But this is not so. The word *will*, which is meant to unlock for us, like a magic word, the innermost essence of every thing in nature, by no means designates an unknown quantity, something reached by inferences. Rather, it designates something known entirely immediately, and so familiar that we know and understand what *will* is much better than we understand anything else whatever.

Until now, the concept *will* has been subsumed under the concept *force*. I, by contrast, do exactly the reverse, and want every force in nature to be thought as *will*. One should not suppose that this is a dispute about words, or something indifferent. On the contrary, it is of the very highest significance and importance.

For the concept *force*, like all other concepts, is ultimately grounded in intuitive cognition of the objective world, that is, in appearance, in representation, and it is drawn from this. It is abstracted from the domain in which cause and effect rule, and therefore from intuitive representation. It signifies precisely the cause's being-a-cause, at the point where aetiological explanation can go no further, and where force is instead the necessary presupposition of all aetiological explanation.

By contrast, the concept *will* is the only one among all possible concepts that has its origin *not* in appearance, *not* in mere intuitive representation, but comes from within. It proceeds from the most immediate consciousness of each person, in which he knows his own individual, according to its essence, immediately, without any form, even without the form of subject and object; and in which, at the same time, he himself is this individual, since here what knows and what is known coincide.

If, therefore, we refer the concept of *force* back to that of *will*, we have in fact referred something more unknown back to something infinitely better known, indeed to the only thing really known to us immediately and entirely. We have thereby very greatly expanded our cognition.

If, on the other hand, we subsume the concept *will* under that of *force*, as has been done until now, then we give up the only immediate cognition we have of the inner essence of the world, by letting it disappear into a concept abstracted from appearance, with which we can therefore never get beyond appearance.

§. 23.

The *will* as thing in itself is entirely different from its appearance, and wholly free from all the forms of appearance. It enters into these forms only when it appears; they therefore concern only its *objecthood* and are foreign to the will itself.

Even the most universal form of all representation, that of object for a subject, does not apply to it. Still less do the forms subordinate to this one, all of which have their common expression in the principle of sufficient reason. As is well known, time and space also belong here, and consequently so does the multiplicity that exists and becomes possible only through them.

In this latter respect I will call time and space, using an expression borrowed from the old Scholasticism proper, the principium individuationis (principle of individuation), and I ask that this be noted once and for all. For time and space alone are what make something that is the same and one according to essence and concept nevertheless appear as different, as multiplicity alongside and after one another. They are therefore the principium individuationis, the object of so much brooding and dispute among the Scholastics, collected in Suarez (*Metaphysical Disputations*, disp. 5, sect. 3).

According to what has been said, the will as thing in itself lies outside the domain of the principle of sufficient reason in all its forms, and is therefore absolutely groundless, although each of its appearances is entirely subject to the principle of sufficient reason. It is also free from all *multiplicity*, although its appearances in time and space are innumerable.

The will itself is one. Yet it is not one as an object is one, whose unity is known only in contrast to possible multiplicity. Nor is it one as a concept is one, which has arisen only through abstraction from multiplicity. Rather, it is one as that which lies outside time and space, outside the principium individuationis, that is, outside the possibility of multiplicity.

Only when all this has become fully clear to us through the following consideration of the appearances and different manifestations of the will will we completely understand the meaning of Kant's doctrine that time, space, and causality do not belong to the thing in itself, but are only forms of cognition.

The groundlessness of the will has in fact been recognized where the will manifests itself most clearly, as the will of the human being; and this will has

been called free, independent. But immediately, because of the groundlessness of the will itself, people overlooked the necessity to which its appearance is everywhere subject, and declared actions free, though they are not. For every individual action follows with strict necessity from the effect of the motive upon the character.

As has already been said, all necessity is the relation of the consequent to the ground, and absolutely nothing more. The principle of sufficient reason is the universal form of all appearance, and the human being in his action must be subject to it, like every other appearance. But because the will is known immediately and in itself in self-consciousness, consciousness of freedom also lies in this consciousness.

What is overlooked, however, is that the individual, the person, is not will as thing in itself, but is already *appearance* of the will. As such, the individual is already determined and has entered into the form of appearance, the principle of sufficient reason.

This is the source of the strange fact that everyone takes himself a priori (prior to experience) to be entirely free, even in his individual actions, and thinks he could at any moment begin a different course of life, which would mean becoming someone else. Yet a posteriori (after experience), through experience, he finds to his astonishment that he is not free, but subject to necessity; that despite all his resolutions and reflections he does not change his conduct; and that from the beginning of his life to the end he must carry through the same character that he himself disapproves, and must, as it were, play to the end the role he has taken on.

I cannot develop this consideration further here, since as an ethical matter it belongs elsewhere in this work. For now I wish only to point out that the *appearance* of the will, which is groundless in itself, is nevertheless as appearance subject to the law of necessity, that is, to the principle of sufficient reason. This should prevent us from being disturbed by the necessity with which the appearances of nature occur when we recognize in them manifestations of the will.

Until now, only those changes that have no other ground than a motive, that is, a representation, have been regarded as appearances of the will. For this reason, in nature one attributed will only to human beings, and perhaps to animals, because cognition, representing, is indeed, as I have already mentioned elsewhere, the genuine and exclusive characteristic of animality.

But that the will is also active where no cognition guides it is shown to us most immediately by the instinct and constructive drives of animals.^[1] The fact that they have representations and cognition does not enter into the matter here at all, since the end toward which they work just as if it were a known motive remains entirely unknown to them. Their action here therefore occurs without a motive, is not guided by representation, and shows us first and most clearly how the will is active even without any cognition.

The one-year-old bird has no representation of the eggs for which it builds a nest; the young spider has none of the prey for which it spins a web; nor does the ant-lion have a representation of the ant for which it digs a pit for the first time. The larva of the stag beetle bites the hole in the wood, where it will undergo its transformation, twice as large if it is to become a male beetle as if it is to become a female one, in the former case in order to have room for horns of which it as yet has no representation.

In such action by these animals, as in their other action, the will is plainly active. But here it is active blindly: accompanied by cognition, to be sure, but not guided by it.

Once we have gained the insight that representation as motive is not a necessary and essential condition of the will's activity, we will more easily recognize the working of the will in cases where it is less obvious. We will then be no more inclined to attribute the snail's shell to a will foreign to the snail itself, yet guided by cognition, than to say that the house we ourselves build comes into existence through some will other than our own.

Rather, we will recognize both houses as works of the will objectifying itself in both appearances: in us, according to motives; in the snail, still blindly, as a formative drive directed outward.

The same will also works blindly in us in many ways: in all the functions of our body that no cognition guides, in all its vital and vegetative processes, digestion, circulation of the blood, secretion, growth, reproduction. Not only the body's actions, but the body itself through and through, is, as shown above, appearance of the will, objectified will, concrete will. Everything that takes place in it must therefore take place through will, although here this will is not guided by cognition and does not determine itself according to motives, but, acting blindly, according to causes that in this case are called *stimuli*.

By *cause*, in the strictest sense of the word, I mean that state of matter which, while necessarily bringing about another state, itself undergoes a change just as

great as the one it causes. This is expressed by the rule: action and reaction are equal.

Furthermore, in cause properly so called, the effect increases in exactly the same proportion as the cause, and so too does the reaction. Thus, once the kind of effect is known, the degree of the effect can be measured and calculated from the degree of intensity of the cause, and conversely. Such causes, properly so called, operate in all appearances of mechanism, chemistry, and so on; in short, in all changes of inorganic bodies.

By contrast, I call a *stimulus* that cause which itself undergoes no reaction proportionate to its effect, and whose intensity does not run parallel in degree with the intensity of the effect, so that the effect cannot be measured by the stimulus. Instead, a small increase in the stimulus may produce a very great increase in the effect, or, conversely, may entirely abolish the previous effect, and so on.

All effects upon organic bodies as such are of this kind. Thus all properly organic and vegetative changes in the animal body proceed upon stimuli, not upon mere causes. But the stimulus, like every cause in general, and likewise the motive, never determines more than the point of entry of the expression of each force in time and space. It does not determine the inner essence of the force that expresses itself. In accordance with our previous derivation, we recognize this inner essence as will, and to it we therefore attribute both the unconscious and the conscious changes of the body.

The stimulus holds the middle position and makes the transition between the motive, which is causality that has passed through cognition, and cause in the strict sense. In individual cases it lies closer now to the motive, now to the cause, though it is still always to be distinguished from both.

For example, the rising of sap in plants occurs upon stimulus and cannot be explained by mere causes, according to the laws of hydraulics or capillary tubes. Nevertheless, it is probably supported by these and is in general already very close to purely causal change. By contrast, the movements of *Hedysarum gyrans* and *Mimosa pudica*, although still occurring upon mere stimuli, are nevertheless already very similar to movements upon motives and seem almost ready to make the transition to them.

The narrowing of the pupil under increased light occurs upon stimulus, but already passes over into movement upon motive, since it happens because light

that is too strong would painfully affect the retina, and in order to avoid this we contract the pupil.

The occasion of erection is a motive, since it is a representation. Yet it acts with the necessity of a stimulus; that is, it cannot be resisted, and one must remove it in order to render it ineffective. The same holds for disgusting objects, which arouse the inclination to vomit.

We have just considered animal instinct as a true middle term of an entirely different kind between movement upon stimulus and action according to a known motive. One might be tempted to regard breathing as another middle term of this kind. For there has been dispute over whether it belongs to voluntary or involuntary movements, that is, in truth, whether it occurs upon motive or stimulus; and accordingly it might perhaps be explained as something intermediate between the two.

Marshall Hall, in *On the Diseases of the Nervous System*, § 293 and following, declares it a mixed function, since it stands under the influence partly of the cerebral, or voluntary, nerves and partly of the spinal, or involuntary, nerves. Nevertheless, in the end we must count it among expressions of will that occur upon motive. For other motives, that is, mere representations, can determine the will to hold breathing back or hasten it; and breathing has, like every other voluntary action, the appearance that one could entirely omit it and freely suffocate.

One could in fact do this as soon as some other motive determined the will so strongly that it outweighed the pressing need for air. According to some, Diogenes really ended his life in this way (Diog. Laert. VI, 76). Black people are also said to have done this (F. B. Oslander, *On Suicide* [1813], pp. 170-180). In this we would have a strong example of the influence of abstract motives, that is, of the superiority of properly rational willing over merely animal willing.

The fact that breathing is at least partly conditioned by cerebral activity is supported by the fact that hydrocyanic acid kills first by paralyzing the brain and thus indirectly inhibiting breathing. But if breathing is artificially maintained until that stupefaction of the brain has passed, no death at all occurs.

At the same time, breathing incidentally gives us here the most obvious example of the fact that motives act with just as much necessity as stimuli and mere causes in the strict sense, and can be rendered ineffective only by contrary motives, just as pressure is counteracted by counterpressure. For in breathing,

the appearance that one can refrain from it is incomparably weaker than in other movements that occur upon motives. This is because the motive there is very urgent and very near, its satisfaction is very easy because of the tirelessness of the muscles that carry it out, as a rule nothing opposes it, and the whole process is supported by the individual's oldest habit.

And yet all motives really act with the same necessity. The recognition that necessity is common to movements upon motives and to those upon stimuli will make it easier for us to see that what occurs in the organic body upon stimuli and with complete conformity to law is nevertheless, according to its inner essence, will. Though the will is never subject in itself to the principle of sufficient reason, it is subject to that principle, that is, to necessity, in all its appearances.^[2]

Accordingly, we will not stop at recognizing animals, in their action as well as in their whole existence, embodiment, and organization, as appearance of will. We will also transfer this immediate cognition, which alone is given to us, of the essence in itself of things to plants, whose every movement occurs upon stimuli. The absence of cognition, and of movement upon motives conditioned by cognition, is the only essential difference between animal and plant.

Thus what appears for representation as plant, as mere vegetation, as blindly driving force, we will call, according to its essence in itself, will. We will recognize it as precisely what constitutes the basis of our own appearance, as this basis expresses itself in our action and already in the entire existence of our body itself.

Only the final step remains: to extend our way of considering things also to all those forces that act in nature according to universal, unalterable laws, in accordance with which all the movements of bodies occur, bodies that, entirely without organs, have no receptivity for stimulus and no cognition for motive. We must therefore apply the key to understanding the essence in itself of things, a key that only immediate cognition of our own essence could give us, also to these appearances of the inorganic world, which stand at the greatest distance from us.

If we now consider them with an inquiring gaze; if we see the powerful, unstoppable drive with which waters hurry toward the depths, the persistence with which the magnet always turns back toward the north pole, the longing with which iron flies toward it, the vehemence with which the poles of electricity strive for reunion, and which, just like human desire, is intensified by

obstacles; if we see the crystal shoot up quickly and suddenly, with such regularity of formation, which is plainly only a completely decided and precisely determined striving in different directions, seized and held fast by solidification; if we notice the selection by which bodies, set free by the fluid state and released from the bonds of rigidity, seek and flee one another, unite and separate; if, finally, we feel quite immediately how a weight, whose striving toward the mass of the earth our body obstructs, presses and pushes upon it without ceasing, pursuing its one endeavor: then it will cost us no great effort of imagination, even from so great a distance, to recognize our own essence again.

It is the very same essence that in us pursues its ends in the light of cognition, but here, in the weakest of its appearances, strives only blindly, dimly, one-sidedly, and unchangeably. Yet because it is everywhere one and the same, just as the first dawn shares the name sunlight with the rays of full noon, it must here as there bear the name *will*. This word designates what is the being in itself of every thing in the world and the sole kernel of every appearance.

The distance, however, indeed the appearance of a complete difference between the appearances of inorganic nature and the will that we perceive as the inner being of our own essence, arises chiefly from the contrast between wholly determinate conformity to law in the one kind of appearance and apparently lawless arbitrariness in the other.

For in the human being, individuality comes powerfully to the fore. Each person has a character of his own; hence the same motive does not have the same force over everyone. A thousand secondary circumstances, which have room in the individual's wide sphere of cognition but remain unknown to others, modify the effect of the motive. For this reason, the action cannot be predicted from the motive alone, because the other factor is missing: exact knowledge of the individual character and of the cognition that accompanies it.

By contrast, the appearances of natural forces display the other extreme. They act according to universal laws, without deviation, without individuality, according to openly evident circumstances, subject to the most exact predetermination; and the same natural force expresses itself in millions of its appearances in exactly the same way.

In order to clarify this point, and to demonstrate the identity of the *one* and indivisible will in all its very different appearances, in the weakest as in the strongest, we must first consider the relation that the will as thing in itself has to its appearance, that is, the relation that the world as will has to the world as

representation. This will open for us the best path to a deeper investigation of the whole subject treated in this second book.^[3]

Notes

Notes

1. These are discussed specifically in chapter 27 of the second volume. ↩
2. This insight is fully established by my prize essay on the freedom of the will, where the relation between *cause*, *stimulus*, and *motive* also receives its detailed discussion, pp. 30-44 of *Two Fundamental Problems of Ethics* [2nd ed., pp. 29-41]. ↩
3. On this, chapter 23 of the second volume; likewise, in my work *On Will in Nature*, the chapter "Plant Physiology" and the chapter "Physical Astronomy," which is extremely important for the kernel of my metaphysics. ↩

§. 24.

We have learned from the great Kant that time, space, and causality, in all their lawfulness and in the possibility of all their forms, are present in our consciousness quite independently of the objects that appear in them and make up their content. Or, in other words, they can be found just as well if one starts from the subject as if one starts from the object. For this reason one can with equal right call them modes of intuition belonging to the subject, or also properties of the object *insofar as it is object* (in Kant: appearance), that is, *representation*.

One can also regard these forms as the indivisible boundary between object and subject. Hence every object must indeed appear in them, but the subject too, independently of the appearing object, possesses and surveys them completely.

Now if the objects appearing in these forms are not to be empty phantoms, but are to have a meaning, then they must point to something, must be the expression of something that is not again, like themselves, object, representation, something present only relatively, namely for a subject. They must express something that exists without this dependence on something standing over against it as its essential condition, and without dependence on that thing's forms. That is, they must express precisely something that is *not representation*, but a *thing in itself*.

Accordingly, one could at least ask: are those representations, those objects, still something besides and apart from the fact that they are representations, objects of the subject? And what would they then be in this sense? What is their other side, different from representation *toto genere* (in kind altogether)? What is the thing in itself? *The will*: this has been our answer, though for the moment I set it aside.

Whatever the thing in itself may be, Kant rightly concluded that time, space, and causality (which we later recognized as forms of the principle of sufficient reason, and that principle as the general expression of the forms of appearance) could not be determinations of it. They could belong to it only after and insofar as it had become representation. Thus they belonged only to its appearance, not to it itself.

For since the subject recognizes and constructs them completely from itself, independently of every object, they must attach to *being-representation* as such,

not to that which becomes representation. They must be the form of representation as such, not properties of what has assumed this form. They must already be given with the mere opposition of subject and object, not in concept but in fact, and therefore must be only the more precise determination of the form of cognition in general, whose most universal determination is that opposition itself.

Now whatever in appearance, in the object, is in turn conditioned by time, space, and causality, because it can be represented only by means of them, namely *multiplicity*, through alongside-one-another and after-one-another; *change and duration*, through the law of causality; matter, which is representable only under the presupposition of causality; and finally everything that is representable only by means of these: all this together does not essentially belong to *that* which appears, *that* which has entered into the form of representation. It belongs only to this form itself.

Conversely, however, what in appearance is *not* conditioned by time, space, and causality, cannot be traced back to them, and cannot be explained according to them, will be precisely that in which what appears, the thing in itself, immediately announces itself.

Accordingly, the most perfect knowability, that is, the greatest clarity, distinctness, and exhaustive comprehensibility, will necessarily belong to what is proper to cognition *as such*, and therefore to the *form* of cognition. It will not belong to what, in itself, is *not* representation, *not* object, and becomes knowable, that is, becomes representation and object, only by entering into these forms.

Only what depends solely on being known, on being-representation in general and as such (not on what is known, and only then has become representation), what therefore belongs without distinction to everything that is known, and for just this reason is found just as well when one starts from the subject as when one starts from the object: this alone can provide an unreservedly sufficient cognition, completely exhaustive and clear down to the final ground.

This consists in nothing other than the forms of all appearance of which we are conscious a priori (prior to experience), and which can be jointly expressed as the principle of sufficient reason. Its forms relating to intuitive cognition, with which alone we are concerned here, are time, space, and causality. On

these alone are founded all pure mathematics and pure natural science a priori (prior to experience).

Only in these sciences, therefore, does cognition find no darkness, does it not run up against the unfathomable (the groundless, that is, will), against what cannot be further derived. In this respect Kant too, as has been said, wanted to call these cognitions, and logic along with them, sciences in the preferred, indeed exclusive, sense.

On the other hand, these cognitions show us nothing further than mere relations: relations of one representation to another, form without any content. Every content they receive, every appearance that fills those forms, already contains something that is no longer completely knowable according to its whole essence, no longer entirely explicable through something else, and therefore contains something groundless. Because of this, cognition at once loses evidence and forfeits complete transparency.

But this something that withdraws from investigation is precisely the thing in itself. It is what is essentially not representation, not object of cognition, but becomes knowable only by entering into that form. The form is originally foreign to it, and it can never become wholly one with the form. It can never be reduced to mere form; and since this form is the principle of sufficient reason, it can therefore never be completely *explained down to its ground*.

Thus, even if all mathematics gives us exhaustive cognition of whatever in appearances is magnitude, position, number, in short, spatial and temporal relation; and even if all aetiology completely specifies the lawful conditions under which appearances, with all their determinations, enter into time and space; still, in all this it teaches us no more than why each determinate appearance must show itself just now here and just here now.

With the help of mathematics and aetiology we never penetrate into the inner essence of things. There always remains something at which no explanation may venture, but which explanation always presupposes: the forces of nature, the determinate mode of action of things, the quality, the character of every appearance, the groundless element that does not depend on the form of appearance, the principle of sufficient reason. This form is foreign to it in itself; yet it has entered into this form and now comes forth according to its law. But this law determines only the coming forth, not *what* comes forth; only the how, not the what, of appearance; only the form, not the content.

Mechanics, physics, and chemistry teach the rules and laws according to which the forces of impenetrability, gravity, rigidity, fluidity, cohesion, elasticity, heat, light, elective affinities, magnetism, electricity, and so on act. That is, they teach the law, the rule, that these forces observe with respect to their entry at each time into time and space. But the forces themselves remain, however one may behave about it, *qualitates occultae* (occult qualities).

For it is precisely the thing in itself which, when it appears, presents those phenomena. It is entirely different from them. In its appearance it is wholly subject to the principle of sufficient reason as the form of representation, but it itself can never be reduced to this form. Therefore it can never be explained aetiologically down to the last point, never be completely fathomed. It is completely comprehensible insofar as it has assumed that form, that is, insofar as it is appearance; but its inner essence is not explained in the least by that comprehensibility.

Hence the more necessity a cognition carries with it, the more there is in it of what cannot be thought and represented otherwise, as for example spatial relations, and therefore the clearer and more sufficient it is, the less purely objective content it has, or the less genuine reality is given in it. Conversely, the more something in it must be grasped as purely contingent, the more something presses itself on us as merely empirically given, the more properly objective and truly real there is in such cognition; but at the same time the more inexplicable there is in it, that is, the more there is that cannot be further derived from something else.

Of course, in every age an aetiology that mistakes its own goal has striven to reduce all organic life to chemism or electricity, all chemism, that is, quality, again to mechanism, or action through the shape of atoms, and mechanism again partly to the object of phoronomy, that is, time and space united for the possibility of motion, and partly to that of mere geometry, that is, position in space. This is roughly the way one rightly constructs, in purely geometrical terms, the decrease of an effect according to the square of the distance and the theory of the lever.

Geometry can finally be resolved into arithmetic, which, because of the unity of its dimension, is the most comprehensible, surveyable, and completely fathomable form of the principle of sufficient reason.

Examples of the method indicated here in general are Democritus's atoms, Descartes's vortices, and the mechanical physics of Lesage, who, toward the

end of the previous century, tried to explain both chemical affinities and gravitation mechanically, through impact and pressure, as can be seen more closely from the *Lucrèce Newtonien* (*Newtonian Lucretius*). Reil's appeal to form and mixture as the cause of animal life also tends in this direction.

Finally, wholly of this kind is the crude materialism that has just now, in the middle of the nineteenth century, been warmed over again and, out of ignorance, takes itself to be original. First, with stupid denial of the vital force, it wants to explain the appearances of life from physical and chemical forces; these again from the mechanical action of matter, position, shape, and motion of dreamt-up atoms; and so to reduce all forces of nature to impact and counter-impact, which are its "thing in itself."

Accordingly, even light is supposed to be the mechanical vibration, or even undulation, of an imaginary ether postulated for this purpose, which, when it arrives, drums on the retina. Then, for example, 483 trillion drumbeats per second yield red, and 727 trillion yield violet, and so on. Color-blind people, then, would presumably be those who cannot count the drumbeats, would they not?

Such crude, mechanical, Democritean, clumsy, and truly blockheaded theories are entirely worthy of people who, fifty years after Goethe's theory of colors appeared, still believe in Newton's homogeneous lights and are not ashamed to say so. They will learn that what one overlooks in the child, Democritus, will not be forgiven in the man. They may even come to a shameful end one day; but then each will creep away and act as if he had not been involved.

We will soon return once more to this false reduction of original natural forces to one another. Here only this much: suppose it were possible in this way. Then everything would indeed be explained and fathomed, indeed in the end reduced to an arithmetic problem, which would then be the holy of holies in the temple of wisdom, to which the principle of sufficient reason had at last happily led.

But all content of appearance would have vanished, and mere form would remain. *What* appears would have been reduced to *how* it appears; and this *how* would be what can also be known a priori (prior to experience), and therefore would be wholly dependent on the subject, therefore present only for it, and therefore finally a mere phantom, representation and form of representation through and through. No thing in itself could be asked about.

Supposing this were possible, then the whole world would really have been derived from the subject, and what Fichte wanted, through his windy bluster, to *seem* to accomplish would in fact have been accomplished.

But it is not possible. Fantasies, sophistries, castles in the air have been produced in that manner, but no science. It has been possible, and whenever it was possible it marked a true advance, to reduce the many and manifold appearances in nature to individual original forces. Several forces and qualities that were initially taken to be different have been derived from one another (for example, magnetism from electricity), and in this way their number has been reduced.

Aetiology will have reached its goal when it has recognized and established all original forces of nature as such, and determined their modes of action, that is, the rule according to which, by the guiding thread of causality, their appearances enter into time and space and determine their place with respect to one another. But original forces will always remain; an irresolvable residue will always remain as a content of appearance that cannot be reduced to its form, and therefore cannot be explained from something else according to the principle of sufficient reason.

For in every thing in nature there is something for which no ground can ever be given, no explanation is possible, and no further cause is to be sought. It is the specific mode of its acting, that is, the mode of its existence, its essence. To be sure, for every individual effect of the thing one can point to a cause from which it follows that the thing had to act just now, just here. But no cause can ever be given for the fact that it acts at all, and acts precisely in this way.

If it has no other properties, if it is a mote in a sunbeam, then at least as gravity and impenetrability it shows that unfathomable something. This, I say, is to it what his *will* is to a human being; and like the will, according to its inner essence, it is not subject to explanation. Indeed, in itself it is identical with the will.

Certainly for every expression of the will, for every individual act of it at this time and in this place, one can point to a motive from which, on the presupposition of the person's character, the act had to follow necessarily. But no ground can ever be given for the fact that he has this character, that he wills at all, that among several motives this one and no other moves his will, or indeed that any motive moves it.

What the human being's unfathomable character is to him, presupposed in every explanation of his deeds from motives, is precisely what the essential quality of every inorganic body is to it: the mode of its acting. Its expressions are called forth by external influence, whereas the quality itself is determined by nothing outside it, and therefore is also not explicable. Its individual appearances, through which alone it becomes visible, are subject to the principle of sufficient reason; it itself is groundless. The Scholastics already recognized this essentially correctly and called it *forma substantialis* (substantial form). On this, see Suarez, *Metaphysical Disputations*, disp. XV, sect. 1.

It is an error as great as it is common to think that the most frequent, universal, and simplest appearances are the ones we understand best. They are, rather, only the ones whose sight, and our ignorance concerning them, we are most accustomed to. It is just as inexplicable to us that a stone falls to the earth as that an animal moves.

As mentioned above, people have thought that, by starting from the most universal natural forces, for example gravitation, cohesion, and impenetrability, one could explain from them the forces that act more rarely and only under combined circumstances, for example chemical quality, electricity, and magnetism, and finally, from these again, understand the organism and the life of animals, indeed human cognition and willing.

They silently resigned themselves to starting from nothing but *qualitates occultae* (occult qualities), whose illumination was entirely given up, since they intended to build over them, not undermine them. As has been said, this cannot succeed. But apart from this, such a structure would always stand in the air.

What good are explanations that finally lead back to something just as unknown as the first problem was? Does one in the end understand more about the inner essence of those universal natural forces than about the inner essence of an animal? Is not the one just as unexplored as the other? Unfathomable, because groundless; because it is the content, the what, of appearance, which can never be traced back to its form, to the how, to the principle of sufficient reason.

We, however, who are aiming here not at aetiology but at philosophy, that is, not at relative but at unconditional cognition of the essence of the world, take the opposite path. We start from what is immediately known to us, what is known to us most completely and is altogether familiar, what lies nearest to us,

in order to understand what is known to us only remotely, one-sidedly, and mediately. From the most powerful, significant, and distinct appearance we want to learn to understand the more imperfect and weaker appearance.

Of all things, with the exception of my own body, only *one* side is known to me: the side of representation. Their inner essence remains closed to me and a deep mystery, even if I know all the causes from which their changes occur.

Only by comparing them with what goes on in me when, as a motive moves me, my body performs an action, with what is the inner essence of my own changes determined by external grounds, can I gain insight into the manner in which those lifeless bodies change upon causes, and so understand what their inner essence may be. Knowledge of the cause gives me only the rule of the entry of this essence's appearance into time and space, and nothing more.

I can do this because my body is the only object of which I know not merely the *one* side, that of representation, but also the second, which is called *will*. Therefore, instead of believing that I would understand my own organization, then my cognition and willing, and my movement upon motives, better if only I could reduce them to movement from causes, through electricity, chemism, and mechanism, I must, insofar as I seek philosophy and not aetiology, do the reverse.

I must first learn to understand, according to their inner essence, even the simplest and commonest movements of inorganic body, which I see occur upon causes, from my own movement upon motives. I must recognize the unfathomable forces that express themselves in all bodies of nature as identical in kind with what in me is the will, and as differing from it only in degree.

This means: the fourth class of representations established in the essay on the principle of sufficient reason must become for me the key to cognition of the inner essence of the first class. From the law of motivation I must learn to understand the law of causality according to its inner meaning.

Spinoza says (epist. 62; letter 62) that if the stone flying through the air after a blow had consciousness, it would think it was flying by its own will. I add only this: the stone would be right.

The blow is for the stone what the motive is for me; and what appears in the stone as cohesion, gravity, and persistence in the state it has assumed is, according to its inner essence, the same as what I recognize in myself as will, and what the stone too, if cognition were added, would recognize as will.

In that passage, Spinoza had his eye on the necessity with which the stone flies, and wanted, rightly, to transfer this necessity to the necessity of the individual act of will in a person. I, by contrast, consider the inner essence that first gives meaning and validity to every real necessity, that is, to every effect from a cause, as its presupposition. In the human being this is called character; in the stone, quality. In both it is the same; where it is immediately known, it is called *will*. In the stone it has the weakest degree of visibility, of objecthood; in the human being, the strongest.

Saint Augustine too, with correct feeling, recognized this identity between the striving of all things and our willing, and I cannot refrain from setting down his naive expression of the matter:

Si pecora essemus, carnalem vitam et quod secundum sensum ejusdem est amaremus, idque esset sufficiens bonum nostrum, et secundum hoc si esset nobis bene, nihil aliud quaereremus. Item, si arbores essemus, nihil quidem sentientes motu amare possemus: verumtamen id quasi appetere videremur, quo feracius essemus, uberiusque fructuosae. Si essemus lapides, aut fluctus, aut ventus, aut flamma, vel quid ejusmodi, sine ullo quidem sensu atque vita, non tamen nobis deesset quasi quidam nostrorum locorum atque ordinis appetitus. Nam velut amores corporum momenta sunt ponderum, sive deorsum gravitate, sive sursum levitate nitantur: ita enim corpus pondere, sicut animus amore fertur quocunque fertur (de civ. Dei, XI, 28).

Translation: If we were beasts, we would love bodily life and whatever accords with its sense, and that would be our sufficient good; and if things were well with us in this respect, we would seek nothing else. Likewise, if we were trees, we could love nothing by a movement of sensation; nevertheless we would seem, as it were, to desire that by which we would be more fertile and more abundantly fruitful. If we were stones, or waves, or wind, or flame, or anything of that kind, without any sensation or life, we still would not lack, as it were, a certain appetite for our own places and order. For the movements of weights are like the loves of bodies, whether they strive downward by heaviness or upward by lightness; thus the body is carried by weight, just as the soul is carried by love, wherever it is carried (*The City of God*, XI, 28).

It also deserves to be noted that Euler already saw that the essence of gravitation must ultimately be traced back to an "inclination and desire"

peculiar to bodies, that is, to will (in the sixty-eighth letter to the princess). Indeed, this is precisely what makes him averse to the concept of gravitation as it stands in Newton. He is inclined to try a modification of it in accordance with the earlier Cartesian theory, and so to derive gravitation from the impact of an ether upon bodies, as something that would be "more reasonable and more suitable to people who love clear and comprehensible principles."

He wants to see attraction banished from physics as a *qualitas occulta* (occult quality). This is simply in keeping with the dead view of nature that prevailed in Euler's time as the correlate of the immaterial soul. Yet it is noteworthy with respect to the fundamental truth I have set forth. This fine mind already saw that truth shining through from a distance, but hurried to turn back in time; and now, in his anxiety at seeing all the fundamental views of his time endangered, he even sought protection in the old absurdity that had already been disposed of.

§. 25.

We know that *multiplicity* in general is necessarily conditioned by time and space, and is thinkable only in them. In this respect we call time and space the principium individuationis (principle of individuation). But we have recognized time and space as forms of the principle of sufficient reason, in which principle all our cognition a priori (prior to experience) is expressed. As was explained above, however, precisely as such this principle belongs only to the knowability of things, not to the things themselves. That is, it is only our form of cognition, not a property of the thing in itself.

As thing in itself, it is free from every form of cognition, even from the most universal form, that of being object for a subject; in other words, it is something wholly different from representation.

Now if this thing in itself, as I believe I have sufficiently demonstrated and made evident, is *the will*, then as such, and considered apart from its appearance, it lies outside time and space. It therefore knows no multiplicity, and consequently is *one*. Yet, as has already been said, it is not one as an individual is one, nor as a concept is one, but as something to which the condition of the possibility of multiplicity, the principium individuationis, is foreign.

The multiplicity of things in space and time, all of which are its *objecthood*, therefore does not affect the will, and it remains indivisible despite that multiplicity.

It is not, for example, that a smaller part of the will is in the stone and a larger part in the human being. The relation of part and whole belongs exclusively to space and no longer has any meaning once one has left behind this form of intuition. Rather, more and less apply only to appearance, that is, to visibility, to objectivation. There is a higher degree of this in the plant than in the stone, and a higher degree in the animal than in the plant. Indeed, the will's emergence into visibility, its objectivation, has infinitely many gradations, as there are gradations between the weakest twilight and the brightest sunlight, between the strongest tone and the faintest echo.

Later we will return to the consideration of these grades of visibility, which belong to the will's objectivation, to the image of its essence. But even less than the gradations of its objectivation directly affect the will itself does the

multiplicity of appearances at these different levels affect it, that is, the number of individuals of each form or of the individual expressions of each force. For this multiplicity is immediately conditioned by time and space, into which the will itself never enters.

The will reveals itself just as wholly and just as much in *one* oak as in millions. Their number, their multiplication in space and time, has no significance whatever with respect to the will, but only with respect to the multiplicity of individuals that know in space and time and are themselves multiplied and scattered there. Yet this multiplicity, again, concerns only the will's appearance, not the will itself.

Thus one could even maintain that if, *per impossibile* (assuming the impossible), a single being, even the least, were entirely annihilated, the whole world would have to perish with it. Speaking from this feeling, the great mystic Angelus Silesius says:

I know that without me God cannot live one instant;
If I come to nothing, he must of necessity give up the spirit.

People have tried in various ways to bring the immeasurable greatness of the world's structure closer to everyone's capacity to grasp it, and then have taken occasion from this for edifying reflections, for example on the relative smallness of the earth, and still more of the human being; then again, by contrast, on the greatness of the spirit in this very small human being, who can discover, comprehend, indeed measure that vastness of the world, and so on. All very well.

Meanwhile, when I consider the immeasurability of the world, the most important thing to me is this: that the essence in itself whose appearance the world is, whatever it may be, cannot have drawn apart and divided its true self in this way throughout boundless space. Rather, this infinite extension belongs solely to its appearance. It itself, by contrast, is present whole and undivided in every thing of nature, in every living being.

For this reason one loses nothing by stopping with any single thing. True wisdom is not to be gained by measuring out the boundless world, or, what would be still more appropriate, by personally flying through endless space. It is gained rather by investigating any single thing completely, by trying to learn to know and understand its true and proper essence perfectly.

Accordingly, the following point, which will already have forced itself upon every student of Plato here, will be the object of a detailed consideration in the next book: those different grades of the objectivation of the will, which are expressed in countless individuals and stand as their unattained models, or as the eternal forms of things, do not themselves enter into time and space, the medium of individuals. Instead they stand fixed, subject to no change, always being, never having become; while the individuals arise and pass away, always becoming and never being.

These *grades of the objectivation of the will*, I say, are nothing other than *Plato's Ideas*. I mention this here provisionally so that from now on I can use the word *Idea* in this sense. In my usage it is therefore always to be understood in its genuine and original meaning, the one Plato gave it. One should not think at all here of those abstract productions of scholastically dogmatizing reason for whose designation Kant misused this word, already taken possession of and most appropriately used by Plato, both unsuitably and unlawfully.

By *Idea*, then, I understand every determinate and fixed *grade of the objectivation of the will*, insofar as the will is thing in itself and therefore foreign to multiplicity. These grades do indeed relate to individual things as their eternal forms, or their models.

The shortest and most concise expression of this famous Platonic doctrine is given by Diogenes Laertius (III, 12):

ὁ Πλάτων φησί, ἐν τῇ φύσει τὰς ιδέας ἐστάναι, καθάπερ παραδείγματα· τὰ δ' ἄλλα ταύταις εἰκέναι, τούτων ὁμοιώματα καθεστῶτα.

Plato ideas in natura, velut exemplaria dixit subsistere; cetera his esse similia, ad istarum similitudinem consistentia.

Translation: Plato said that the Ideas subsist in nature like models, and that other things resemble them and exist as likenesses of them.

I take no further notice of Kant's misuse of the term; what is necessary about it is in the appendix.

§. 26.

The most universal forces of nature present themselves as the lowest grade of the objectivation of the will. Some of them appear in all matter without exception, such as gravity and impenetrability. Others have divided among themselves the matter that exists in general, so that some rule over this matter and others over that, thereby making matter specifically different: rigidity, fluidity, elasticity, electricity, magnetism, chemical properties, and qualities of every kind.

In themselves they are immediate appearances of the will, just as much as human action is. As such they are groundless, like the character of a human being. Only their individual appearances are subject to the principle of sufficient reason, as human actions are. The forces themselves, however, can never be called either effect or cause. Rather, they are the prior and presupposed conditions of all causes and effects, through which their own essence unfolds and reveals itself.

It is therefore unintelligent to ask for a cause of gravity or electricity. These are original forces. Their expressions indeed proceed according to cause and effect, so that each individual appearance of them has a cause, which is itself again just such an individual appearance, and which determines that here this force had to express itself, had to emerge in time and space. But the force itself is by no means the effect of a cause, nor is it the cause of an effect.

For this reason it is also false to say: "Gravity is the cause of the stone's falling." Rather, the nearness of the earth is the cause here, insofar as the earth draws the stone. Take the earth away, and the stone will not fall, although gravity remains.

The force itself lies entirely outside the chain of causes and effects, which presupposes time, since it has meaning only with reference to time; the force, however, also lies outside time. An individual change always has another equally individual change as its cause, not the force whose expression it is. For precisely what gives a cause its efficacy, however many countless times it may occur, is a natural force. As such it is groundless, that is, it lies entirely outside the chain of causes and outside the domain of the principle of sufficient reason in general. Philosophically, it is known as immediate objecthood of the will, which is the in-itself of all nature; in aetiology, here physics, it is demonstrated as original force, that is, as *qualitas occulta* (occult quality).

At the higher grades of the objecthood of the will we see individuality emerge significantly, especially in the human being, as the great difference of individual characters, that is, as complete personality, already outwardly expressed by a strongly marked individual physiognomy, which includes the whole embodiment.

No animal has individuality in anything like this degree. Only the higher animals have a trace of it, over which, however, the species-character still completely predominates; for this very reason they also have little individual physiognomy. The farther downward one goes, the more every trace of individual character disappears into the general character of the species, whose physiognomy alone remains.

One knows the physiological character of the species, and from this knows exactly what is to be expected from the individual. By contrast, in the human species each individual wants to be studied and fathomed for himself. Because the possibility of dissimulation first entered with reason, this is extremely difficult if one wishes to determine a person's conduct in advance with any certainty.

It is probably connected with this difference between the human species and all others that the furrows and convolutions of the brain, which are still entirely absent in birds and still very weak in rodents, are, even in the higher animals, far more symmetrical on both sides and more constant in each individual than they are in human beings.^[1]

Furthermore, one should regard the following as a phenomenon of that genuine individual character which distinguishes human beings from all animals: among animals, the sexual drive seeks its satisfaction without noticeable selection; whereas in human beings this selection, in a way independent of all reflection and instinctive, is carried so far that it rises to violent passion.

Thus, while every human being is to be regarded as a specially determined and characterized appearance of the will, indeed in a certain sense even as an Idea of his own, among animals this individual character is on the whole absent, since only the species still has a distinctive significance. The farther they stand from human beings, the more its trace disappears. Plants, finally, have no other individuality than what can be fully explained from favorable or unfavorable external influences of soil and climate and from other contingencies.

In the inorganic realm of nature, all individuality finally disappears altogether. Only the crystal can still be regarded, in a certain sense, as an individual. It is a unity of striving in determinate directions, seized by solidification, which makes the trace of this striving permanent. At the same time it is an aggregate from its kernel-form, bound into unity by one Idea.

In just the same way, the tree is an aggregate from the individual sprouting fiber, which presents and repeats itself in every rib of the leaf, every leaf, and every branch, and in a certain sense lets each of these be regarded as a plant of its own that feeds parasitically on the larger one. Thus the tree, like the crystal, is a systematic aggregate of small plants, although only the whole is the completed presentation of an indivisible Idea, that is, of this determinate grade of the objectivation of the will.

But the individuals of the same species of crystals can have no difference other than that brought about by external contingencies. One can even make each species shoot into large or small crystals at will. The individual as such, that is, with traces of an individual character, is no longer found at all in inorganic nature.

All its appearances are expressions of universal natural forces, that is, of those grades of the objectivation of the will which do not objectify themselves, as they do in organic nature, through the mediation of different individualities that partially express the whole of the Idea. Rather, they present themselves only in the species, and present the species wholly and without deviation in every single appearance.

Since time, space, multiplicity, and being conditioned by cause do not belong to the will, nor to the Idea, the grade of the objectivation of the will, but only to the individual appearances of the Idea, the natural force as such, for example gravity or electricity, must present itself in exactly the same way in all the millions of its appearances. Only external circumstances can modify the appearance.

This unity of its essence in all its appearances, this unchanging constancy of its occurrence as soon as the conditions for it are present along the guiding thread of causality, is called a *law of nature*. Once such a law is known through experience, the appearance of the natural force whose character is expressed and deposited in it can be exactly predicted and calculated.

But it is precisely this lawfulness of the appearances of the lower grades of the objectivation of the will that gives them such a different look from the

appearances of the same will at the higher, that is, clearer grades of its objectivation, in animals, human beings, and their actions. There, the stronger or weaker emergence of individual character, and the being-moved by motives that, because they lie in cognition, often remain hidden from the observer, have until now made people entirely fail to recognize the identical inner essence of both kinds of appearance.

The infallibility of natural laws has something astonishing about it, indeed at times almost something uncanny, if one starts from cognition of the individual and not from cognition of the Idea. One might wonder that nature never forgets its laws even once. For example, if it accords with a law of nature that when certain substances meet under determinate conditions, chemical combination, development of gas, or combustion takes place, then whenever the conditions occur, whether through our arrangement or entirely by chance, the determinate appearance enters at once and without delay, today just as much as a thousand years ago. Where chance is involved, the punctuality is all the more surprising because it was unexpected.

We feel this marvelousness most vividly in rare appearances that occur only under very combined circumstances, but that under these circumstances are announced to us in advance. For example: when certain metals, alternating with one another and with an acidified fluid, are brought into contact, silver leaf placed between the ends of this chain must suddenly burst into green flames; or, under certain conditions, hard diamond must turn into carbonic acid.

It is the spectral omnipresence of natural forces that then surprises us. What no longer occurs to us in everyday appearances we notice here: that the connection between cause and effect is in truth as mysterious as the imagined connection between a magic formula and the spirit that necessarily appears when summoned by it.

By contrast, once we have penetrated into the philosophical cognition that a natural force is a determinate grade of the objectivation of the will, that is, of what we too recognize as our innermost essence; that this will in itself, as distinct from its appearance and the forms of appearance, lies outside time and space; and that therefore the multiplicity conditioned by time and space belongs neither to the will nor immediately to the grade of its objectivation, that is, to the Idea, but only to the appearances of the Idea; and that the law of causality has meaning only in relation to time and space, insofar as in them it determines the place of the multiplied appearances of the different Ideas in which the will

manifests itself, regulating the order in which they must enter: once, I say, the inner meaning of Kant's great doctrine has dawned on us in this cognition, namely that space, time, and causality do not belong to the thing in itself, but only to appearance, that they are only forms of our cognition and not properties of the thing in itself, then we will see that the astonishment over the lawfulness and punctuality of a natural force's action, over the complete sameness of all its millions of appearances, over the infallibility of their occurrence, is in fact comparable to the astonishment of a child, or of a savage, who for the first time looks at a flower through a many-faceted glass, marvels at the complete sameness of the countless flowers he sees, and counts the petals of each one individually.

Every universal original natural force, then, is in its inner essence nothing other than the objectivation of the will at a lower grade. We call each such grade an eternal *Idea*, in Plato's sense. The *law of nature*, however, is the relation of the Idea to the form of its appearance.

This form is time, space, and causality, which have a necessary and inseparable connection and relation to one another. Through time and space, the Idea multiplies itself into countless appearances; but the order according to which these enter into those forms of multiplicity is firmly determined by the law of causality. This law is, as it were, the norm of the boundary-points of those appearances of different Ideas, according to which space, time, and matter are distributed among them.

This norm therefore necessarily relates to the identity of all existing matter, which is the common substrate of all those different appearances. If these appearances were not all referred to that common matter, in whose possession they must share, there would be no need for such a law to determine their claims. They could all at once and alongside one another fill infinite space throughout an infinite time. Only because all those appearances of the eternal Ideas are referred to one and the same matter did there have to be a rule of their entrance and exit; otherwise none would make room for another.

In this way the law of causality is essentially connected with the law of the persistence of substance. Both receive meaning only from one another. Space and time, again, stand in the same relation to them. For time is the mere possibility of opposed determinations in the same matter; space is the mere possibility that the same matter persists under all opposed determinations.

For this reason, in the previous book we explained matter as the union of time and space. This union shows itself as the change of accidents while substance persists, the general possibility of which is precisely causality, or becoming. We therefore also said that matter is causality through and through. We explained the understanding as the subjective correlate of causality, and said that matter, and thus the whole world as representation, exists only for the understanding, that the understanding is its condition, its bearer, as its necessary correlate.

All this is only a passing reminder of what was set out in the first book. Attention to the inner agreement of the two books is required for their complete understanding, since what is inseparably united in the actual world as its two sides, will and representation, has been torn apart in these two books so that each may be known more clearly in isolation.

It may perhaps not be superfluous to make still clearer by an example how the law of causality has meaning only in relation to time and space and to matter, which consists in the union of the two. The law determines the boundaries according to which the appearances of natural forces divide possession of matter among themselves. The original natural forces themselves, however, as immediate objectifications of the will, which as thing in itself is not subject to the principle of sufficient reason, lie outside those forms within which alone every aetiological explanation has validity and meaning, and for just this reason such explanation can never lead to the inner essence of nature.

For this purpose, let us imagine a machine constructed according to the laws of mechanics. Iron weights give the beginning of motion through their gravity; copper wheels resist through their rigidity, and by virtue of their impenetrability push and lift one another and the levers, and so on. Here gravity, rigidity, and impenetrability are original, unexplained forces. Mechanics gives only the conditions under which, and the way in which, they express themselves, emerge, and govern determinate matter, time, and place.

Now a strong magnet might act on the iron of the weights and overpower gravity. The motion of the machine stops, and the matter is at once the theater of an entirely different natural force, of which the aetiological explanation again gives nothing more than the conditions of its entrance: magnetism.

Or the copper disks of that machine are now placed on zinc plates, and acidified fluid is led between them. Immediately the same matter of the machine has fallen prey to another original force, galvanism, which now rules it

according to its laws and reveals itself in it through its appearances. Aetiology can state of these appearances no more than the circumstances under which, and the laws according to which, they show themselves.

Now let us increase the temperature and introduce pure oxygen: the whole machine burns. That is, once again an entirely different natural force, chemism, has at this time and in this place an unavoidable claim upon that matter, and reveals itself in it as Idea, as determinate grade of the objectivation of the will.

Let the metallic calx that has thereby arisen combine with an acid: a salt arises, crystals shoot forth. They are the appearance of another Idea, which itself is again wholly unfathomable, while the entrance of its appearance depended on those conditions that aetiology knows how to state. The crystals weather, mix with other substances, and a vegetation rises from them: a new appearance of will.

And so one could follow the same persisting matter to infinity, and watch how now this, now that natural force gains a right to it and infallibly takes possession of it in order to come forth and reveal its essence. The determination of this right, the point in time and space where it becomes valid, is given by the law of causality. But the explanation grounded on this law goes only this far.

The force itself is appearance of the will, and as such is not subject to the forms of the principle of sufficient reason, that is, it is groundless. It lies outside all time, is omnipresent, and seems, as it were, constantly to await the entrance of the circumstances under which it can come forth and take possession of a determinate matter, displacing the forces that have ruled it until then.

All time exists only for the force's appearance, and has no meaning for the force itself. For thousands of years chemical forces slumber in matter, until contact with reagents sets them free; then they appear. But time exists only for this appearance, not for the forces themselves. For thousands of years galvanism slumbers in copper and zinc, and they lie quietly beside the silver that must burst into flames as soon as all three touch under the required conditions.

Even in the organic realm we see a dry seed preserve for three thousand years the slumbering force which, when favorable circumstances finally arrive, rises up as a plant.^[2]

If through this consideration the distinction has become clear to us between the natural force and all its appearances; if we have seen that the former is the

will itself at this determinate grade of its objectivation, while multiplicity belongs only to the appearances through time and space, and the law of causality is nothing other than the determination of the place in time and space for the individual appearances: then we will also recognize the complete truth and deep meaning of Malebranche's doctrine of occasional causes, causes occasionelles (occasional causes).

It is very worthwhile to compare this doctrine, as Malebranche presents it in the *Search After Truth*, especially in the third chapter of the second part of the sixth book and in the *Elucidations* appended to that chapter, with my present account, and to observe the most complete agreement of the two doctrines despite so great a difference in the course of thought. Indeed, I must admire how Malebranche, entirely caught within the positive dogmas that his age irresistibly imposed upon him, nevertheless, in such bonds and under such a burden, so happily and so rightly hit upon the truth, and knew how to unite it with those very dogmas, at least with their language.

For the power of truth is incredibly great and of unspeakable endurance. We find its frequent traces again in all the dogmas of different times and lands, even the most bizarre, indeed the most absurd; often, to be sure, in strange company and in curious mixture, but still recognizable. It is then like a plant that germinates under a heap of large stones, but nevertheless climbs up toward the light, working its way through with many detours and bends, disfigured, pale, stunted; yet still toward the light.

Malebranche is indeed right: every natural cause is only an occasional cause. It gives only the occasion, the prompt, for the appearance of that one and indivisible will which is the in-itself of all things, and whose gradual objectivation is this whole visible world. Only the emergence, the becoming-visible at this place and at this time, is brought about by the cause and is dependent on it in this respect; not the whole of the appearance, not its inner essence. This is the will itself, to which the principle of sufficient reason has no application, and which is therefore groundless.

No thing in the world has a cause of its existence absolutely and in general. It has only a cause from which it is here and now. Why a stone now shows gravity, now rigidity, now electricity, now chemical properties, depends on causes, on external influences, and can be explained from these. But those properties themselves, and therefore its whole essence, which consists in them and consequently expresses itself in all the ways indicated, the fact that it is in

general such as it is, and that it exists at all, has no ground. It is the becoming-visible of the groundless will.

Thus every cause is an occasional cause. We found this to be so in nature without cognition. But it is just the same where it is no longer causes and stimuli but motives that determine the point of entry of appearances, that is, in the action of animals and human beings.

For here as there it is one and the same will that appears, very different in the grades of its manifestation, multiplied in the appearances of those grades and, with respect to these appearances, subject to the principle of sufficient reason, while in itself it is free from all this.

Motives do not determine the character of the human being, but only the appearance of this character, that is, the deeds; the outer shape of the course of his life, not its inner meaning and content. These proceed from the character, which is the immediate appearance of the will and is therefore groundless.

Why one person is malicious and another good does not depend on motives and external influence, perhaps on teachings and sermons, and in this sense is absolutely inexplicable. But whether a malicious person shows his malice in petty injustices, cowardly intrigues, and low villainies that he practices in the narrow circle of his surroundings, or whether, as a conqueror, he oppresses nations, plunges a world into misery, and spills the blood of millions: this is the outer form of his appearance, its inessential element, and depends on the circumstances in which fate placed him, on surroundings, external influences, and motives. But his decision can never be explained from these motives; it proceeds from the will, of which this human being is the appearance. We will speak of this in the fourth book.

The way in which character unfolds its qualities is entirely comparable to the way in which every body of nature without cognition shows its qualities. Water remains water, with the properties inherent in it. Whether as a still lake it mirrors its banks, or foams as it plunges over rocks, or, artificially prompted, sprays upward in a long jet: this depends on external causes. One is as natural to it as the other. But according to the circumstances it will show the one or the other, equally ready for all, yet in every case true to its character and always revealing only this character. So too every human character will reveal itself under all circumstances; but the appearances that proceed from it will be according to the circumstances.

Notes

Notes

1. Wenzel, *De structura cerebri hominis et brutorum* (1812), chapter 3; Cuvier, *Lectures on Comparative Anatomy*, lesson 9, articles 4 and 5; Vicq d'Azyr, *History of the Academy of Sciences of Paris* (1783), pp. 470 and 483. ↩

2. On September 16, 1840, at the Literary and Scientific Institution of the City of London, Mr. Pettigrew, during a lecture on Egyptian antiquities, showed grains of wheat that Sir G. Wilkinson had found in a tomb near Thebes, where they must have lain for thirty centuries. They were found in a hermetically sealed vase. He had sown twelve grains and obtained from them a plant that had grown five feet high and whose seed was now perfectly ripe. From *The Times*, September 21, 1840. Likewise, in 1830, at the Medical-Botanical Society in London, Mr. Haulton produced a tuberous root that had been found in the hand of an Egyptian mummy, to which it may have been given for religious reasons, and which was therefore at least two thousand years old. He had planted it in a flowerpot, where it had immediately grown and turned green. This is cited from the *Medical Journal* of 1830 in the *Journal of the Royal Institution of Great Britain*, October 1830, p. 196. "In the garden of Mr. Grimstone, of the Herbarium, Highgate, in London, there now stands a pea plant in full fruit, which arose from a pea that Mr. Pettigrew and the officers of the British Museum took from a vase found in an Egyptian sarcophagus, where it must have lain for 2,844 years." From *The Times*, August 16, 1844. Indeed, the living toads found in limestone lead to the supposition that even animal life is capable of such a suspension for millennia, if it is introduced by hibernation and preserved by special circumstances. ↩

§. 27.

From all the preceding considerations about the forces of nature and their appearances, it has become clear how far explanation from causes can go, and where it must stop if it is not to fall into the foolish attempt to reduce the content of all appearances to their mere form, in which case nothing but form would remain in the end. We can now determine, in general terms, what is to be demanded of all aetiology.

Aetiology has to seek out the causes of all appearances in nature, that is, the circumstances under which they always occur. But then it must trace the many-shaped appearances that arise under manifold circumstances back to what is active in all appearance and presupposed in the cause: to original forces of nature. It must correctly distinguish whether a difference in appearance comes from a difference in the force, or only from a difference in the circumstances under which the force expresses itself. It must guard just as carefully against taking for the appearance of different forces what is only the expression of one and the same force under different circumstances, as against taking for expressions of one force what belongs originally to different forces.

This directly requires power of judgment. That is why so few people are able to extend insight in physics, although everyone can extend experience. Laziness and ignorance make people inclined to appeal too early to original forces. This appears, with an exaggeration that borders on irony, in the entities and quiddities of the Scholastics. Nothing could be further from my wish than to have favored their reintroduction.

Instead of giving a physical explanation, one may appeal to the objectivation of the will just as little as to the creative power of God. For physics demands causes; but the will is never a cause. Its relation to appearance is not at all according to the principle of sufficient reason. Rather, what in itself is will is, from another side, there as representation, that is, as appearance. As appearance it obeys the laws that make up the form of appearance. Thus every movement, for example, although it is always an appearance of will, must nevertheless have a cause from which it is to be explained with reference to a determinate time and place; that is, it is to be explained not in general, according to its inner essence, but as an *individual* appearance. This cause is mechanical in the case of a stone; it is a motive in the case of a human being's movement. But it can never be absent.

By contrast, the universal element, the common essence of all appearances of a determinate kind, that without whose presupposition explanation from causes would have neither sense nor meaning, is the universal natural force. In physics this must remain as *qualitas occulta* (occult quality), precisely because here aetiological explanation ends and metaphysical explanation begins.

The chain of causes and effects, however, is never broken by an original force to which one would have to appeal; nor does it run back to such a force as its first link. Rather, the nearest link in the chain, just as much as the most remote, already presupposes the original force, and without it could explain nothing. A series of causes and effects can be the appearance of the most diverse forces, whose successive entrance into visibility is guided by that series, as I explained above with the example of a metal machine. But the difference among these original forces, which cannot be derived from one another, in no way interrupts the unity of that chain of causes or the connection among all its links.

The aetiology of nature and the philosophy of nature never undermine one another. Rather, they go side by side, considering the same object from different points of view. Aetiology gives an account of the causes that necessarily brought about the individual appearance to be explained, and it points out, as the basis of all its explanations, the universal forces active in all these causes and effects. It determines these forces exactly, their number, their differences, and then all the effects in which each force appears differently according to the difference of circumstances, always in accordance with its own peculiar character, which it unfolds according to an infallible rule called a *law of nature*.

As soon as physics has completely achieved all this in every respect, it has reached its completion. Then no force in inorganic nature is still unknown, and no effect remains that has not been shown to be the appearance of one of those forces under determinate circumstances, according to a law of nature. Yet a law of nature remains nothing but the rule observed from nature, according to which nature proceeds every time, under determinate circumstances, as soon as they occur. One may therefore certainly define a law of nature as a universally expressed fact, un *fait généralisé* (a generalized fact); a complete exposition of all laws of nature would accordingly be only a complete register of facts.

The consideration of nature as a whole is then completed by *morphology*, which enumerates, compares, and orders all the enduring forms of organic nature. It has little to say about the cause of the entrance of individual beings,

since in all of them this cause is generation, whose theory is a matter of its own, and in rare cases generatio aequivoca (spontaneous generation). Strictly speaking, however, this latter also includes the way in which all lower grades of the objecthood of the will, that is, physical and chemical appearances, emerge individually; and the statement of the conditions for this emergence is precisely the task of aetiology.

Philosophy, by contrast, everywhere, and so also in nature, considers only the universal. The original forces themselves are its object here, and in them it recognizes the different grades of the objectivation of the will, which is the inner essence, the in-itself, of this world. If philosophy abstracts from that will, it declares the world to be the mere representation of the subject.

But if aetiology, instead of preparing the way for philosophy and supplying application for its doctrines through evidence, rather thinks that its aim is to explain away all original forces, perhaps down to *one*, the most universal, for example impenetrability, which it imagines it understands from the ground up and to which it therefore tries forcibly to reduce all the others, then it removes its own foundation and can yield only error instead of truth. The content of nature is then displaced by form; everything is attributed to the circumstances acting upon things, and nothing to the inner essence of things. If this path really succeeded, then, as already said, a problem in arithmetic would finally solve the riddle of the world.

This is the path taken when, as already mentioned, every physiological effect is to be reduced to form and mixture, perhaps to electricity, electricity again to chemism, and chemism to mechanism. This last was, for example, the error of Descartes and all atomists, who reduced the movement of the heavenly bodies to the impact of a fluid, and qualities to the connection and shape of atoms, and who worked toward explaining all appearances of nature as mere phenomena of impenetrability and cohesion.

Although people have retreated from that view, the electrical, chemical, and mechanical physiologists of our own day are doing the same thing when they stubbornly try to explain all life and all functions of the organism from the "form and mixture" of its components. That the aim of physiological explanation is the reduction of organic life to the universal forces considered by physics is still stated in *Meckel's Archive for Physiology*, 1820, vol. 5, p. 185.

Lamarck too, in his *Zoological Philosophy*, vol. 2, chap. 3, declares life to be a mere effect of heat and electricity: le calorique et la matière électrique

suffisent parfaitement pour composer ensemble cette cause essentielle de la vie (caloric and electrical matter are perfectly sufficient to compose together this essential cause of life) (p. 16). According to this, heat and electricity would really be the thing in itself, and the animal and plant world its appearance. The absurdity of this opinion stands out glaringly on p. 306 ff. of that work.

It is well known that in the most recent period all those views, so often exploded, have reappeared with renewed boldness. If one looks at them closely, they ultimately rest on the presupposition that the organism is only an aggregate of appearances of physical, chemical, and mechanical forces, which here, having accidentally come together, bring about the organism as a play of nature without further significance.

Accordingly, the organism of an animal or of a human being would, philosophically considered, not be the presentation of an Idea of its own, that is, not itself immediate objecthood of the will at a determinate higher grade. Rather, only those Ideas would appear in it which objectify the will in electricity, chemism, and mechanism. The organism would therefore have been blown together by the concurrence of these forces as accidentally as the shapes of human beings and animals in clouds or stalactites, and thus would in itself be no more interesting.

We will see immediately, however, to what extent that application of physical and chemical modes of explanation to the organism may still, within certain limits, be allowed and useful. For I will show that the vital force certainly uses and employs the forces of inorganic nature, but by no means consists of them, any more than the blacksmith consists of hammer and anvil. Thus not even the very simple life of plants will ever be explained from them, for instance from capillary force and endosmosis, much less animal life. The following consideration prepares the way for that rather difficult discussion.

According to all that has been said, natural science goes astray when it tries to reduce the higher grades of the objecthood of the will to lower ones, since the failure to recognize and the denial of original natural forces existing in their own right is just as mistaken as the groundless assumption of peculiar forces where there is only a special mode of appearance of forces already known. Kant is therefore right to say that it is absurd to hope for a Newton of the blade of grass, that is, for someone who would reduce the blade of grass to appearances of physical and chemical forces, of which it would then be an accidental concretion, a mere play of nature, in which no peculiar Idea appeared; that is, in

which the will did not immediately reveal itself at a higher and special grade, but only as it does in the appearances of inorganic nature, and accidentally in this form.

The Scholastics, who would never have permitted anything of this kind, would have been quite right to say that it would be a complete denial of the *forma substantialis* (substantial form) and a degradation of it to *forma accidentalis* (accidental form). For Aristotle's *forma substantialis* designates exactly what I call the grade of the objectivation of the will in a thing.

On the other hand, it must not be overlooked that in all Ideas, that is, in all forces of inorganic nature and all forms of organic nature, it is *one and the same will* that reveals itself, that is, enters into the form of representation, into *objecthood*. Its unity must therefore also make itself known through an inner kinship among all its appearances.

At the higher grades of its objecthood, where the whole appearance is clearer, that is, in the plant and animal kingdoms, this kinship reveals itself through the universally pervasive analogy of all forms, the basic type that recurs in all appearances. For this reason it has become the guiding principle of the excellent zoological systems that came from the French in this century, and it is demonstrated most completely in comparative anatomy as *l'unité de plan*, *l'uniformité de l'élément anatomique* (the unity of plan, the uniformity of the anatomical element).

To discover this basic type was also a chief concern, or at least certainly the most praiseworthy effort, of the philosophers of nature of the Schellingian school, who even have some merit in this respect, although in many cases their hunt for analogies in nature degenerates into mere clever trifling. Rightly, however, they demonstrated that universal kinship and family resemblance even among the Ideas of inorganic nature, for example between electricity and magnetism, whose identity was later established, between chemical attraction and gravity, and the like.

They especially drew attention to the fact that *polarity*, that is, the division of one force into two qualitatively different, opposed activities that strive toward reunification, and that usually also reveals itself spatially by separating into opposed directions, is a basic type of almost all appearances of nature, from magnet and crystal to the human being. In China, however, this cognition has been current from the oldest times in the doctrine of the opposition of *Yin* and *Yang*.

Indeed, precisely because all things in the world are the objecthood of one and the same will, and therefore identical according to their inner essence, there must not only be that unmistakable analogy among them, and in everything less perfect there must already appear the trace, hint, and disposition of the next more perfect thing; but also, since all those forms nevertheless belong only to the world as *representation*, one may even assume that already in the most universal forms of representation, in this actual basic framework of the appearing world, namely in space and time, the basic type, the hint, the disposition of everything that fills the forms, can be found and demonstrated.

It seems to have been a dim cognition of this that gave rise to the Kabbalah and to the whole mathematical philosophy of the Pythagoreans, as well as of the Chinese in the *I Ching*. And in that Schellingian school too, among its many efforts to bring to light the analogy among all appearances of nature, we also find some attempts, although unsuccessful ones, to derive laws of nature from the mere laws of space and time. Still, one cannot know how far some genius may one day realize both efforts.

Although the distinction between appearance and thing in itself must never be lost from sight, and therefore the identity of the will objectified in all Ideas must never, because it has determinate grades of its objecthood, be distorted into an identity of the individual Ideas themselves in which it appears, chemical or electrical attraction, for example, must never be reduced to attraction by gravity, even if their inner analogy is recognized and the former can be regarded, so to speak, as higher powers of the latter. Just as little does the inner analogy of the structure of all animals entitle us to mix up and identify the species, perhaps declaring the more perfect to be varieties of the less perfect.

If, finally, the physiological functions are also never to be reduced to chemical and physical processes, then the following can nevertheless be assumed with great probability in order to justify this procedure within certain limits.

When, among the appearances of the will at the lower grades of its objectivation, that is, in the inorganic realm, several come into conflict with one another, each wanting, along the guiding thread of causality, to take possession of the existing matter, then from this conflict there emerges the appearance of a higher Idea, which overpowers all the less perfect Ideas that were previously present, but in such a way that it allows their essence to persist in a subordinate manner by taking an analogue of them up into itself. This process is intelligible

only from the identity of the will appearing in all Ideas, and from its striving toward ever higher objectivation.

We therefore see, for example, in the hardening of bones an unmistakable analogue of crystallization, which originally ruled the lime, although ossification can never be reduced to crystallization. The analogy shows itself more weakly in the hardening of flesh. So too the mixture of fluids in animal bodies and secretion are analogues of chemical mixture and separation. Indeed, the laws of chemical mixture and separation still continue to operate there, but in a subordinate, highly modified way, overpowered by a higher Idea. Therefore merely chemical forces outside the organism will never produce such fluids. Rather:

Encheiresin naturae (operation of nature) chemistry calls it;
It mocks itself and does not know how.

The more perfect Idea that emerges from such a victory over several lower Ideas, or objectivations of the will, gains, precisely by taking up into itself from each one it overpowers an analogue raised to a higher power, an entirely new character. The will objectifies itself in a new, clearer way. Originally through *generatio aequivoca* (spontaneous generation), and afterward through assimilation to the existing germ, there arise organic fluid, plant, animal, human being. Thus from the conflict of lower appearances the higher one emerges, swallowing them all up, but also realizing the striving of all at a higher grade. Already here, then, the law holds: *serpens, nisi serpentem comederit, non fit draco* (a serpent, unless it has eaten a serpent, does not become a dragon).

I wish it had been possible for me, through clarity of presentation, to overcome the obscurity that clings to the material of these thoughts. But I see very well that the reader's own reflection must come greatly to my aid if I am not to remain misunderstood, or be misunderstood.

According to the view just given, one will indeed be able to demonstrate traces of chemical and physical modes of action in the organism, but never to explain the organism from them. For it is by no means a phenomenon accidentally produced by the combined action of such forces. It is a higher Idea that has subordinated those lower ones to itself by *overpowering assimilation*, because the *one* will that objectifies itself in all Ideas, in striving toward the highest possible objectivation, here gives up the lower grades of its appearance after a conflict among them, in order to appear all the more powerfully at a higher grade.

No victory without struggle. Since the higher Idea, or objectivation of will, can emerge only by overpowering the lower ones, it suffers resistance from them. Although brought into servitude, they still always strive to reach the independent and complete expression of their essence.

Just as a magnet that has lifted a piece of iron maintains a constant struggle with gravity, which, as the lowest objectivation of the will, has a more original right to the matter of that iron, and just as in this constant struggle the magnet even strengthens itself, since resistance stimulates it, as it were, to greater exertion, so every appearance of will, including the one that presents itself in the human organism, maintains a lasting struggle against the many physical and chemical forces which, as lower Ideas, have an earlier right to that matter.

This is why the arm that one has held raised for a while, overcoming gravity, sinks down. This is also why the comfortable feeling of health, which expresses the victory of the Idea of the self-conscious organism over the physical and chemical laws that originally rule the fluids of the body, is so often interrupted, indeed is really always accompanied by a certain greater or lesser discomfort, arising from the resistance of those forces. In this way even the vegetative part of our life is constantly bound up with a slight suffering.

This too is why digestion depresses all animal functions: it claims the whole vital force for the overcoming of chemical natural forces through assimilation. Hence, in general, the burden of physical life, the necessity of sleep, and finally death. For at last, favored by circumstances, those subjugated natural forces win back from the organism, itself exhausted by constant victory, the matter that had been wrested from them, and arrive at the unhindered presentation of their essence.

One can therefore also say that every organism presents the Idea of which it is the image only after subtracting that part of its force which is used to overpower the lower Ideas that contest its matter. This seems to have hovered before Jakob Boehme when he says somewhere that all bodies of human beings and animals, indeed all plants, are actually half dead.

According as the organism succeeds more or less in overpowering those natural forces that express the lower grades of the objecthood of the will, it becomes a more perfect or less perfect expression of its Idea; that is, it stands nearer to or farther from the *ideal* to which beauty belongs in its species.

Thus in nature we everywhere see conflict, struggle, and alternation of victory, and in this we will later recognize more clearly the division of the will

against itself that is essential to it. Each grade of the objectivation of the will contests matter, space, and time with every other. Persisting matter must continually change its form, as mechanical, physical, chemical, and organic appearances, guided by causality and greedily pressing forward to emerge, tear matter from one another, since each wants to reveal its Idea.

This conflict can be followed throughout all of nature; indeed, nature exists only through it: εἰ γὰρ μὴ ἦν τὸ νεῖκος ἐν τοῖς πράγμασιν, ἐν ᾧ ἦν ἅπαντα ὥς φησιν Ἐμπεδοκλῆς (nam si non inesset in rebus contentio, unum omnia essent, ut ait Empedocles. Arist. Metaph. B., 5) (for if there were not conflict in things, all things would be one, as Empedocles says). For this conflict itself is only the revelation of the division of the will against itself that is essential to it.

This universal struggle reaches its clearest visibility in the animal world, which has the plant world for its nourishment, and in which again each animal becomes the prey and nourishment of another. That is, the matter in which its Idea presented itself must surrender itself to the presentation of another Idea, since each animal can preserve its existence only through the constant cancellation of another's. Thus the will to life everywhere feeds on itself and, in different forms, is its own nourishment, until finally the human race, because it overpowers all the others, regards nature as a product manufactured for its use. Yet this same race, as we will find in the fourth book, reveals in itself that conflict, that self-division of the will, with the most terrible clarity, and becomes homo homini lupus (man is a wolf to man).

Meanwhile, we will recognize the same conflict, the same overpowering, just as much at the lower grades of the objecthood of the will. Many insects, especially the ichneumonids, lay their eggs on the skin, indeed in the body, of the larvae of other insects, whose slow destruction is the first work of the brood that hatches. The young hydra, which grows out of the old one as a dwarf and later separates from it, already struggles with it for the prey that offers itself while it is still attached, so that one tears it from the other's mouth (Trembley, Polypod. II, p. 110, and III, p. 165).

The most glaring example of this kind, however, is supplied by the bulldog ant (bulldog-ant) in Australia. When it is cut in two, a fight begins between the head part and the tail part. The former attacks the latter with its jaws, and the latter defends itself bravely by stinging the former. The fight usually lasts half an hour, until they die or are dragged away by other ants. The event occurs

every time. (From a letter by Howitt in the *W. Journal*, reprinted in Galignani's *Messenger*, November 17, 1855.)

On the banks of the Missouri one sometimes sees a mighty oak so wound around, bound, and constricted on its trunk and all its branches by a gigantic wild grapevine that it must wither as if suffocated. The same thing appears even at the lowest grades, for example where, through organic assimilation, water and carbon are transformed into plant sap, or plants or bread into blood, and everywhere animal secretion takes place with the chemical forces restricted to a subordinate mode of action.

It appears also in inorganic nature: when, for example, crystals shooting forth meet one another, cross one another, and mutually disturb one another so that they cannot show the purely crystallized form, almost every geode is the image of such a conflict of the will at that very low grade of its objectivation. Or again when a magnet forces magnetism upon iron in order to present its Idea there too; or when galvanism overpowers elective affinities, decomposes the firmest compounds, and suspends the chemical laws to such a degree that the acid of a salt decomposed at the negative pole must go to the positive pole without combining with the alkalis through which it passes on the way, or even being allowed to redden the litmus it encounters.

On a large scale it appears in the relation between central body and planet. The planet, although in decided dependence, still resists, just like the chemical forces in the organism. From this arises the constant tension between centripetal and centrifugal force, which keeps the structure of the world in motion and is itself already an expression of that universal conflict essential to the appearance of the will which we are considering.

For since every body must be regarded as the appearance of a will, and will necessarily presents itself as a striving, the original state of every heavenly body gathered into a sphere cannot be rest, but motion, a striving onward into infinite space, without rest and without goal. Neither the law of inertia nor the law of causality stands opposed to this. For according to the former, matter as such is indifferent to rest and motion, and therefore motion, just as much as rest, can be its original state. Consequently, if we find it in motion, we are no more entitled to presuppose that a state of rest preceded this motion and to ask for the cause of the entrance of motion, than, conversely, if we found it at rest, we would be entitled to presuppose a motion that preceded this rest and to ask for the cause of its cessation.

Therefore no first impulse is to be sought for centrifugal force. In the case of the planets, according to Kant's and Laplace's hypothesis, it is the remnant of the original rotation of the central body from which they separated during its contraction. Motion, however, is essential to this body itself: it still rotates and at the same time flies onward in endless space, or perhaps circles around a larger central body invisible to us.

This view agrees completely with the astronomers' conjecture of a central sun, and also with the observed advance of our whole solar system, perhaps also of the whole star cluster to which our sun belongs. From this one may finally infer a universal advance of all fixed stars, together with the central sun. In infinite space, to be sure, this loses all meaning, since motion in absolute space is not distinguished from rest. Precisely thereby, as already directly through striving and flying without goal, it becomes the expression of that nothingness, that lack of an ultimate purpose, which at the end of this book we will have to acknowledge in the striving of the will in all its appearances. For this reason, too, endless space and endless time had to be the most universal and essential forms of its whole appearance, as that which exists in order to express its whole essence.

Finally, we can recognize the conflict of all appearances of will against one another even in mere matter considered as such, insofar as Kant rightly expressed the essence of its appearance as repulsive and attractive force. Thus matter itself has its existence only in a conflict of opposed forces.

If we abstract from all chemical difference in matter, or think ourselves back along the chain of causes and effects to the point where there is as yet no chemical difference, what remains is mere matter, the world gathered into a sphere, whose life, that is, objectivation of the will, now consists in that conflict between attractive and repulsive force. The former, as gravity, presses from all sides toward the center; the latter, as impenetrability, resists it, whether through rigidity or elasticity. This constant pressure and resistance may be regarded as the objecthood of the will at the very lowest grade, and even there already expresses its character.

Here, then, at the lowest grade, we would see the will present itself as a blind drive, an obscure, dull impulse, far from all immediate knowability. This is the simplest and weakest kind of its objectivation. As such blind drive and cognitionless striving it appears throughout inorganic nature, in all the original forces whose search and whose laws are the concern of physics and chemistry.

Each of these forces presents itself to us in millions of entirely homogeneous and law-governed appearances, announcing no trace of individual character, but merely multiplied by time and space, that is, by the principium individuationis (principle of individuation), as an image is multiplied by the facets of a glass.

Objectifying itself more clearly from grade to grade, the will nevertheless still works entirely without cognition in the plant kingdom, where the connection among its appearances is no longer made by causes in the strict sense but by stimuli, as an obscure driving force. It does so finally even in the vegetative part of animal appearance, in the production and development of every animal and in the maintenance of its inner economy, where mere stimuli still necessarily determine its appearance.

The ever higher grades of the objecthood of the will finally lead to the point where the individual that presents the Idea could no longer obtain the nourishment it had to assimilate by mere movement in response to stimuli. Such a stimulus would have to be awaited, whereas here nourishment is more specifically determined; and with the ever greater multiplicity of appearances, the crowding and confusion have become so great that they disturb one another, and the chance on which the individual moved merely by stimuli would have to wait for its nourishment would be too unfavorable. From the point when the animal has freed itself from the egg or womb in which it vegetated without cognition, nourishment must therefore be sought out and selected.

Here, then, movement according to motives becomes necessary, and because of this cognition becomes necessary. Cognition therefore enters as an aid required at this grade of the objectivation of the will, a μηχανή (contrivance), for the preservation of the individual and the propagation of the species. It emerges represented by the brain or a larger ganglion, just as every other striving or determination of the will objectifying itself is represented by an organ, that is, presents itself for representation as an organ.^[1]

But with this aid, this μηχανή (contrivance), the *world as representation* suddenly stands there, with all its forms: object and subject, time, space, multiplicity, and causality. The world now shows its second side. Previously merely *will*, it is now at the same time *representation*, object of the knowing subject. The will, which until now had pursued its drive in the dark with the greatest certainty and infallibility, has at this grade lit a lamp for itself. This became necessary as a means of removing the disadvantage that would arise

precisely for the most perfect of its appearances from the crowded and complicated character of those appearances.

The previous infallible certainty and lawfulness with which it worked in inorganic and merely vegetative nature rested on the fact that it alone was active in its original essence, as blind drive, as will, without assistance, but also without disturbance from a second and wholly different world, the world as representation. This world is indeed only the copy of its own essence, but is nevertheless of an entirely different nature and now intervenes in the connection among its appearances.

Through this, the infallible certainty of those appearances now ceases. Animals are already exposed to semblance, to deception. They have, however, only intuitive representations, no concepts, no reflection; hence they are bound to the present and cannot take the future into account.

It seems as if this cognition without reason were not in all cases sufficient for its purpose, and sometimes needed something like supplementary help. For there appears to us the very remarkable phenomenon that the blind working of the will and the working illuminated by cognition cross over into one another's domain, in two kinds of appearances, in a most surprising way.

First, in the midst of the actions of animals guided by intuitive cognition and its motives, we find an action carried out without these, and therefore with the necessity of blindly working will: the constructive drives. These are guided by no motive and no cognition, yet they have the look of producing their works even according to abstract, rational motives. The other, opposite case is the one in which, conversely, the light of cognition penetrates into the workshop of the blindly working will and illuminates the vegetative functions of the human organism: magnetic clairvoyance.

Finally, where the will has reached the highest grade of its objectivation, the cognition of the understanding that dawned in animals, to which the senses supply the data from which mere intuition arises, bound to the present, is no longer enough. The complicated, many-sided, pliable being, the human being, so full of needs and exposed to innumerable injuries, had to be illuminated by a double cognition in order to exist. A higher power of intuitive cognition, as it were, had to be added to it, a reflection of it: reason, as the faculty of abstract concepts.

With reason, reflective awareness was present, containing an overview of future and past, and, as a result, deliberation, care, the capacity for premeditated

action independent of the present, and finally also fully distinct consciousness of one's own decisions of will as such.

If the possibility of semblance and deception already entered with merely intuitive cognition, thereby cancelling the previous infallibility in the cognitionless drive of the will, so that instinct and constructive drive, as cognitionless expressions of will, had to come to its aid in the midst of actions guided by cognition, then with the entrance of reason that certainty and unerring character of the expressions of will, which at the other extreme, in inorganic nature, even appears as strict lawfulness, is almost entirely lost.

Instinct recedes completely. Deliberation, which is now supposed to replace everything, produces, as was shown in the first book, vacillation and uncertainty. Error becomes possible, and in many cases prevents the adequate objectivation of the will through deeds. For although the will has already taken its determinate and unchangeable direction in the character, in accordance with which willing itself unfailingly occurs on the occasion of motives, error can still falsify its expressions, since illusory motives then enter in just like real ones and cancel them.^[2] So, for example, when superstition interposes imaginary motives that compel a human being to a course of action directly opposed to the way his will would otherwise express itself under the existing circumstances: Agamemnon slaughters his daughter; a miser gives alms out of pure egoism, in the hope of a hundredfold repayment someday, and so on.

Cognition in general, rational as well as merely intuitive, thus originally arises from the will itself. It belongs to the essence of the higher grades of its objectivation as a mere μηχανή (contrivance), a means for preserving the individual and the species, just like every organ of the body. Originally destined to serve the will and to accomplish its purposes, it also remains almost entirely serviceable to the will throughout: so in all animals and in almost all human beings.

Yet in the third book we will see how, in individual human beings, cognition can withdraw from this servitude, throw off its yoke, and, free from all purposes of willing, exist purely for itself as the mere clear mirror of the world, from which art arises. Finally, in the fourth book, we will see how, through this kind of cognition, when it acts back upon the will, the will's self-cancellation can occur: that is, resignation, which is the final goal, indeed the innermost essence, of all virtue and holiness, and redemption from the world.

Notes

Notes

1. On this, see chapter 22 of the second volume, as well as my work *On Will in Nature*, pp. 54 ff. and pp. 70-79 of the first edition, or pp. 46 ff. and pp. 63-72 of the second edition. ↩
2. The Scholastics therefore said very well: *Causa finalis movet non secundum suum esse reale, sed secundum esse cognitum*. Translation: The final cause moves not according to its real being, but according to its being as cognized. See Suarez, *Metaphysical Disputations*, disp. XXIII, sect. 7 and 8. ↩

§. 28.

We have considered the great manifoldness and difference of the appearances in which the will objectifies itself; indeed, we have seen their endless and irreconcilable conflict with one another. Yet, according to our whole account so far, the will itself, as thing in itself, is by no means included in that multiplicity, that change.

The difference of the Platonic Ideas, that is, of the gradations of objectivation; the multitude of individuals in which each of these presents itself; the conflict of forms over matter: all this does not affect the will itself. It is only the way and manner of its objectivation, and has only through this an indirect relation to the will, by virtue of which it belongs to the expression of its essence for representation.

Just as a magic lantern shows many and various images, while it is only one and the same flame that gives visibility to them all, so in all the manifold appearances that fill the world side by side, or displace one another in succession as events, it is still only the *one will* that appears. All this is its visibility, its objecthood, while it remains unmoved in the midst of that change. It alone is the thing in itself; every object, however, is appearance, phenomenon, to speak in Kant's language.

Although the will finds its clearest and most complete objectivation in the human being, as Platonic Idea, this alone could not express its essence. In order to appear with its proper significance, the Idea of the human being could not present itself alone and torn away from everything else. It had to be accompanied by the descending sequence through all the forms of animals, through the plant kingdom, down to the inorganic. Only all of these together complete the full objectivation of the will. They are presupposed by the Idea of the human being as the blossoms of a tree presuppose leaves, branches, trunk, and root. They form a pyramid whose apex is the human being.

If one enjoys comparisons, one may also say that their appearance accompanies the appearance of the human being as necessarily as full light is accompanied by the gradual gradations of all half-shadows through which it loses itself in darkness. Or one may call them the echo of the human being and say: animal and plant are the descending fifth and third of the human being; the inorganic realm is the lower octave.

The whole truth of this last comparison, however, will become clear to us only when, in the following book, we try to fathom the deep significance of music. Then it will appear to us how melody, advancing in connected sequence through high, easily mobile tones, is to be regarded in a certain sense as presenting the life and striving of the human being, which has coherence through reflection. By contrast, the disconnected accompanying parts and the slow-moving bass, from which the harmony necessary to the completeness of music arises, represent the rest of animal and cognitionless nature. But more on this in its place, where it will no longer sound so paradoxical.

We also find that *inner necessity* in the sequence of the will's appearances, inseparable from the adequate objecthood of the will, expressed in the whole of these appearances themselves by an *outer necessity*: namely the necessity by virtue of which the human being needs animals for his preservation, these need one another by grades, then also plants, which in turn need soil, water, chemical elements and their mixtures, the planet, the sun, rotation and revolution around it, the obliquity of the ecliptic, and so on.

At bottom, this springs from the fact that the will must feed on itself, because there is nothing outside it and it is a hungry will. Hence the hunt, anxiety, and suffering.

Just as cognition of the unity of the will, as thing in itself, in the infinite difference and manifoldness of appearances alone gives the true explanation of that wonderful and unmistakable analogy among all productions of nature, that family resemblance which lets us regard them as variations of the same theme, not given along with them, so in the same way a clearly and deeply grasped cognition of that harmony, that essential connection among all parts of the world, that necessity of their gradation which we have just considered, will open to us a true and sufficient insight into the inner essence and significance of the undeniable *purposiveness* of all organic products of nature, which we even presuppose a priori (prior to experience) when considering and judging them.

This *purposiveness* is of two kinds. It is partly *inner*, that is, such an ordered agreement of all parts of an individual organism that the preservation of that organism and of its species results from it, and therefore presents itself as the purpose of that arrangement.

But purposiveness is also partly *outer*: namely, a relation of inorganic nature to organic nature in general, or of individual parts of organic nature to one another, which makes possible the preservation of organic nature as a whole, or

even of individual animal species, and therefore presents itself to our judgment as a means to that end.

Inner purposiveness enters the connection of our consideration in the following way. If, according to what has been said so far, all differences of forms in nature and all multiplicity of individuals belong not to the will, but only to its objecthood and the form of that objecthood, then it necessarily follows that the will is indivisible and wholly present in every appearance, although the grades of its objectivation, the Platonic Ideas, are very different.

For easier comprehension, we can regard these different Ideas as individual and in themselves simple acts of will, in which its essence expresses itself more or less. The individuals, however, are again appearances of the Ideas, and therefore of those acts, in time, space, and multiplicity.

At the lowest grades of objecthood, such an act, or an Idea, retains its unity even in appearance. At the higher grades, by contrast, in order to appear, it needs a whole series of states and developments in time, all of which together first complete the expression of its essence. Thus, for example, the Idea that reveals itself in any universal natural force always has only one simple expression, even if this expression presents itself differently according to external relations. Otherwise its identity could not be demonstrated at all, which is done precisely by separating off the difference that arises only from external relations.

Likewise, the crystal has only *one* expression of life, its shooting into crystal, which afterward has its fully sufficient and exhaustive expression in the solidified form, the corpse of that momentary life. The plant, however, already does not express the Idea whose appearance it is all at once and through one simple expression, but in a succession of developments of its organs in time.

The animal develops its organism in the same way, in a succession of often very different forms, metamorphosis. But this form itself, although already objecthood of the will at this grade, is still not sufficient for the complete presentation of its Idea. Rather, the Idea is first completed by the animal's actions, in which its empirical character, which is the same throughout the whole species, expresses itself. Only this is the full revelation of the Idea, while it presupposes the determinate organism as its basic condition.

In the human being, the empirical character is already peculiar in each individual; indeed, as we will see in the fourth book, it can go as far as the complete cancellation of the character of the species, namely through the

self-cancellation of the whole of willing. What is recognized as empirical character through the necessary development in time, and the resulting falling apart into individual actions, is, with abstraction from this temporal form of appearance, the *intelligible character*, in Kant's expression. Kant's immortal merit appears especially splendid in his demonstration of this distinction and presentation of the relation between freedom and necessity, that is, really between the will as thing in itself and its appearance in time.^[1]

The intelligible character thus coincides with the Idea, or, still more properly, with the original act of will that reveals itself in it. To this extent, not only the empirical character of every human being, but also that of every animal species, every plant species, and even every original force of inorganic nature is to be regarded as the appearance of an intelligible character, that is, of an extra-temporal, indivisible act of will.

In passing, I would like to draw attention here to the naivete with which every plant expresses and openly displays its whole character by its mere shape, revealing its whole being and willing. This is what makes the physiognomies of plants so interesting. The animal, by contrast, must already be observed in its action and activity if it is to be known according to its Idea. The human being must be thoroughly investigated and tested, since reason makes him capable of dissimulation to a high degree.

The animal is just as much more naive than the human being as the plant is more naive than the animal. In the animal we see the will to life, as it were, more nakedly than in the human being, where it is clothed with so much cognition and, in addition, veiled by the capacity for dissimulation, so that its true essence comes to light almost only by accident and in places.

In the plant the will shows itself entirely naked, but also much more weakly, as a mere blind drive to existence, without purpose or aim. For the plant reveals its whole essence to the first glance and with perfect innocence, which does not suffer from the fact that it displays at its summit the genitals that, in all animals, have been given the most hidden place. This innocence of the plant rests on its cognitionlessness: guilt lies not in willing, but in willing with cognition.

Every plant first tells of its home, of its climate and the nature of the soil from which it has sprung. Even the little practiced observer therefore easily recognizes whether an exotic plant belongs to the tropical or the temperate zone, and whether it grows in water, in marshes, on mountains, or on the heath.

Beyond this, however, every plant also expresses the special will of its species and says something that cannot be expressed in any other language.

But now to the application of what has been said to the teleological consideration of organisms, insofar as it concerns their inner purposiveness. If in inorganic nature the Idea, which everywhere is to be regarded as one single act of will, reveals itself only in one single and always identical expression, so that one can say that here the empirical character immediately participates in the unity of the intelligible character, indeed, as it were, coincides with it, and for this reason no inner purposiveness can show itself there; if, by contrast, all organisms present their Idea through a succession of developments one after another, conditioned by a manifoldness of different parts side by side, so that the sum of the expressions of their empirical character first becomes the expression of the intelligible character when taken together, then this necessary coexistence of parts and succession of development still does not cancel the unity of the appearing Idea, of the act of will expressing itself. Rather, this unity now finds its expression in the necessary relation and linkage of those parts and developments with one another, according to the law of causality.

Since it is the one and indivisible will, and for that very reason the will wholly in agreement with itself, that reveals itself in the whole Idea as in one act, its appearance, although it divides into a diversity of parts and states, must nevertheless show that unity again in the thorough agreement among them. This occurs through a necessary relation and dependence of all parts on one another, by which the unity of the Idea is restored even in appearance.

Accordingly, we now recognize those different parts and functions of the organism reciprocally as means and end of one another, while the organism itself is the final end of them all. Consequently, both the division of the Idea, simple in itself, into the multiplicity of the parts and states of the organism on the one hand, and the restoration of its unity through the necessary connection of those parts and functions, by which they are cause and effect, and therefore means and end, of one another on the other hand, are proper and essential not to the appearing will as such, the thing in itself, but only to its appearance in space, time, and causality, all of them forms of the principle of sufficient reason, the form of appearance.

They belong to the world as representation, not to the world as will. They belong to the way in which the will becomes object, that is, representation, at this grade of its objecthood.

Whoever has penetrated the meaning of this perhaps somewhat difficult discussion will now properly understand Kant's doctrine that both the purposiveness of the organic and the lawfulness of the inorganic are first brought into nature by our understanding, and therefore both belong only to appearance, not to the thing in itself. The astonishment mentioned above at the infallible constancy of the lawfulness of inorganic nature is essentially the same as astonishment at the purposiveness of organic nature. For in both cases what surprises us is only the sight of the original unity of the Idea, which, for appearance, had assumed the form of multiplicity and difference.^[2]

Now as for the second kind of purposiveness, according to the division made above, namely *outer* purposiveness, which shows itself not in the inner economy of organisms but in the support and help they receive from outside, both from inorganic nature and from one another: this too finds its general explanation in the discussion just set out. For the whole world, with all its appearances, is the objecthood of the one and indivisible will, the Idea that is related to all other Ideas as harmony is related to the individual voices. Thus that unity of the will must also show itself in the agreement of all its appearances with one another.

But we can bring this insight to much greater clarity if we go somewhat more closely into the appearances of that outer purposiveness and agreement of the different parts of nature with one another. This discussion will at the same time throw light back on the preceding one. We will reach it best by considering the following analogy.

The character of each individual human being can, insofar as it is thoroughly individual and not wholly contained in the character of the species, be regarded as a special Idea, corresponding to a peculiar act of objectivation of the will. This act itself would then be his intelligible character, while his empirical character would be its appearance. The empirical character is wholly and completely determined by the intelligible character, which is groundless will, that is, will as thing in itself, not subject to the principle of sufficient reason, the form of appearance.

The empirical character must provide in the course of a life the image of the intelligible character, and it cannot turn out otherwise than the essence of the latter requires. But this determination extends only to what is essential, not to what is inessential in the course of life that accordingly appears. What belongs

to this inessential element is the more precise determination of the events and actions that are the material in which the empirical character shows itself.

These events and actions are determined by external circumstances, which provide the motives to which the character reacts according to its nature. Since these circumstances can be very different, the outer shape of the appearance of the empirical character, that is, the determinate factual or historical shape of the course of life, must be governed by their influence. This shape can turn out very differently, even though what is essential in this appearance, its content, remains the same. Thus, for example, it is inessential whether one plays for nuts or crowns; but whether one cheats at play or proceeds honestly is the essential matter. The latter is determined by the intelligible character, the former by external influence.

As the same theme can present itself in a hundred variations, so the same character can present itself in a hundred very different courses of life. Yet however varied the external influence may be, however it turns out, the empirical character expressing itself in the course of life must still exactly objectify the intelligible character, adapting its objectivation to the material of factual circumstances it finds before it.

We must assume something analogous to that influence of external circumstances on a course of life determined in its essence by character, if we want to think how the will, in the original act of its objectivation, determines the different Ideas in which it objectifies itself, that is, the different forms of natural beings of every kind among which it distributes its objectivation, and which therefore must necessarily have a relation to one another in appearance.

We must assume that among all those appearances of the *one* will a universal reciprocal adaptation and accommodation to one another took place. But here, as we will soon see more clearly, every determination of time must be omitted, since the Idea lies outside time. Accordingly, every appearance had to adapt itself to the surroundings into which it entered, and these surroundings in turn had to adapt themselves to it, even if that appearance occupies a much later place in time. Everywhere we see this consensus naturae (consensus of nature).

Thus every plant is suited to its soil and climate, every animal to its element and to the prey that is to become its food, and is also in some way protected to a certain extent against its natural pursuer. The eye is suited to light and its refrangibility; the lungs and blood to air; the swim bladder to water; the eye of the seal to the change of its medium; the water-holding cells in the camel's

stomach to the drought of African deserts; the sail of the nautilus to the wind that is to drive its little boat; and so on down to the most special and astonishing cases of outer purposiveness.^[3]

Here, however, one must abstract from all relations of time, since these can concern only the appearance of the Idea, not the Idea itself. Accordingly, this way of explaining things is also to be used backward, and we must assume not only that every species adapted itself to the circumstances it found, but also that these circumstances, which preceded it in time, had just as much regard for the beings that were someday to come.

For it is one and the same will that objectifies itself in the whole world. It knows no time, since this form of the principle of sufficient reason belongs neither to it nor to its original objecthood, the Ideas, but only to the way in which these are known by the individuals that are themselves transitory, that is, to the appearance of the Ideas.

Therefore, in our present consideration of the way in which the objectivation of the will distributes itself into the Ideas, temporal sequence has no significance at all. The Ideas whose *appearances*, according to the law of causality to which they as such are subject, entered the temporal sequence earlier, thereby have no privilege over those whose appearance enters later. On the contrary, the latter are precisely the most perfect objectivations of the will, to which the earlier had to adapt themselves just as much as these had to adapt themselves to the earlier.

Thus the course of the planets, the inclination of the ecliptic, the rotation of the earth, the distribution of land and sea, the atmosphere, light, heat, and all similar appearances, which are in nature what the thoroughbass is in harmony, adapted themselves, as if with foreboding, to the coming races of living beings whose support and sustainer they were to become. In the same way the soil adapted itself to the nourishment of plants, plants to the nourishment of animals, animals to the nourishment of other animals, just as conversely all of these again adapted themselves to those.

All parts of nature meet one another halfway, because it is *one* will that appears in them all, while temporal sequence is wholly foreign to its original and alone *adequate objecthood*, the Ideas; this expression will be explained in the following book.

Even now, when species only have to preserve themselves and no longer come into being, we occasionally see such provision of nature extending into

the future, really abstracting, as it were, from temporal sequence: an adaptation of what is there to what is still to come. Thus the bird builds the nest for young it does not yet know; the beaver erects a structure whose purpose is unknown to it; the ant, the hamster, and the bee gather stores for a winter unknown to them; the spider and antlion set traps, as if with deliberate cunning, for future prey unknown to them; insects lay their eggs where the future brood will find future nourishment.

When, around flowering time, the female flower of the dioecious *Vallisneria* uncoils the spiral turns of its stem, by which it had until then been held at the bottom of the water, and thereby rises to the surface, at exactly the same time the male flower, growing on the bottom of the water on a short stem, tears itself loose from this stem and reaches the surface, sacrificing its life. There, floating around, it seeks the female flower, which then, after fertilization has occurred, withdraws again to the bottom by contracting its spiral, and there the fruit develops.^[4]

Here too I must again mention the larva of the male stag beetle, which bites the hole in the wood for its metamorphosis twice as large as the female does, in order to gain room for its future horns. In general, then, the instinct of animals gives us the best explanation for the rest of nature's teleology. For just as instinct is an action like one performed according to a concept of an end, and yet wholly without such a concept, so all formation in nature is like formation according to a concept of an end, and yet wholly without such a concept.

For in the outer as in the inner teleology of nature, what we must think as means and end is everywhere only the *appearance of the unity of the one will, so far as it is in agreement with itself*, unfolded for our mode of cognition in space and time.

Meanwhile, the reciprocal adaptation and accommodation of appearances that springs from this unity still cannot cancel the inner conflict, essential to the will, that appears in the general struggle of nature described above. That harmony goes only so far as to make possible the *continued existence* of the world and its beings, which without it would long ago have perished. It therefore extends only to the continued existence of species and of the general conditions of life, not to that of individuals.

Thus, by virtue of that harmony and accommodation, the *species* in organic nature and the *universal natural forces* in inorganic nature exist alongside one another and even mutually support one another. By contrast, the inner conflict

of the will objectified through all those Ideas shows itself in the unceasing war of annihilation among the *individuals* of those species and in the constant struggle of the *appearances* of those natural forces with one another, as was explained above.

The battlefield and object of this struggle is matter, which they strive to wrest from one another, as well as space and time, whose union through the form of causality is really matter, as was shown in the first book.^[5]

Notes

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1. See *Critique of Pure Reason*, "Solution of the Cosmological Ideas of the Totality of the Derivation of World-Events," pp. 560-586 of the fifth edition and pp. 532 ff. of the first edition; and *Critique of Practical Reason*, fourth edition, pp. 169-179; Rosenkranz's edition, pp. 224 ff. Compare my treatise on the principle of sufficient reason, §43. ↩
2. Compare *On Will in Nature*, at the end of the section "Comparative Anatomy." ↩
3. See *On Will in Nature*, the section "Comparative Anatomy." ↩
4. Chatin, "On *Vallisneria spiralis*," in the *Comptes rendus de l'Académie des sciences*, no. 13, 1855. ↩
5. On this, see chapters 26 and 27 of the second volume. ↩

§. 29.

Here I conclude the second main part of my presentation, in the hope that, so far as is possible in the very first communication of an unprecedented thought, which therefore cannot be entirely free of the traces of the individuality in which it first arose, I have succeeded in communicating the clear certainty that this world in which we live and are is, in its whole essence, through and through *will*, and at the same time through and through *representation*.

This representation, already as such, presupposes a form, namely object and subject, and is therefore relative. If we ask what remains after the cancellation of this form and of all the forms subordinate to it, which the principle of sufficient reason expresses, then this, as something different from representation *toto genere* (in kind altogether), can be nothing other than *will*, which accordingly is the true *thing in itself*.

Everyone finds himself as this will, in which the inner essence of the world consists, just as he also finds himself as the knowing subject whose representation the whole world is, which in this respect has existence only in relation to his consciousness as its necessary bearer. In this double respect, then, everyone is the whole world itself, the microcosm, and finds both sides of it wholly and completely in himself.

What he thus recognizes as his own essence also exhausts the essence of the whole world, the macrocosm. The world too, like himself, is therefore through and through will and through and through representation, and nothing more remains. Thus we see here the philosophy of Thales, which considered the macrocosm, and that of Socrates, which considered the microcosm, coincide, since the object of both proves to be the same.

The whole cognition communicated in the first two books, however, will gain greater completeness, and thereby also greater certainty, through the two books that still follow. In them, I hope, many a question that may have arisen, clearly or obscurely, in the course of our consideration so far will also find its sufficient answer.

Meanwhile, *one* such question may still be discussed separately, since it can really arise only so long as one has not yet fully penetrated the meaning of the preceding account, and precisely for that reason it can serve to clarify it. The question is this: every will is will toward something; it has an object, a goal of

its willing. What, then, does that will ultimately want, or toward what does it strive, if it has been presented to us as the essence in itself of the world?

This question, like so many others, rests on confusing the thing in itself with appearance. The principle of sufficient reason, whose forms include the law of motivation, extends only to appearance, not to the thing in itself. Everywhere one can give a ground only for appearances as such, for individual things, never for the will itself, nor for the Idea in which it objectifies itself adequately.

Thus for every individual movement, or in general every change in nature, one must seek a cause, that is, a state that necessarily brought it about. But one must never seek a cause for the natural force itself that reveals itself in that appearance and in countless similar appearances. It is therefore sheer lack of understanding, arising from a lack of reflective awareness, when someone asks for a cause of gravity, electricity, and so on.

Only if one had shown that gravity or electricity were not original and peculiar natural forces, but only modes of appearance of a more universal natural force already known, could one ask for the cause that makes this natural force here produce the appearance of gravity or electricity. All this was explained at length above.

In just the same way, every individual act of will of a knowing individual, who himself is only appearance of the will as thing in itself, necessarily has a motive, without which that act would never occur. But just as the material cause contains only the determination that, at this time, in this place, and in this matter, an expression of this or that natural force must occur, so too the motive determines only the act of will of a knowing being at this time, in this place, under these circumstances, as something wholly individual. It by no means determines that this being wills at all, or that it wills in this way.

This is the expression of its intelligible character, which, as the will itself, the thing in itself, is groundless, lying outside the domain of the principle of sufficient reason. Thus every human being constantly has ends and motives by which he guides his action, and can always give an account of his individual deeds. But if one asked him why he wills at all, or why he wills to exist at all, he would have no answer. Rather, the question would seem absurd to him; and in this precisely would be expressed the consciousness that he himself is nothing but will, whose willing in general is therefore self-evident, and needs closer determination by motives only in its individual acts, for each point in time.

In fact, the absence of every goal and every limit belongs to the essence of the will in itself, which is an endless striving. This was already touched on above when centrifugal force was mentioned; and it reveals itself most simply at the very lowest grade of the objecthood of the will, namely in gravity, whose constant striving lies before our eyes despite the obvious impossibility of any final goal.

For even if, according to gravity's will, all existing matter were united into one lump, gravity within that lump, striving toward the center, would still continue to struggle with impenetrability as rigidity or elasticity. The striving of matter can therefore always be checked, but never fulfilled or satisfied.

This is exactly how it stands with all striving of all appearances of will. Every attained goal is again the beginning of a new course, and so on to infinity. The plant raises its appearance from seed through stem and leaf to blossom and fruit, which is again only the beginning of a new seed, a new individual that runs through the old course once more, and so through endless time.

The life-course of the animal is the same. Procreation is its summit; after this has been reached, the life of the first individual declines quickly or slowly, while a new one guarantees to nature the preservation of the species and repeats the same appearance. Indeed, the constant renewal of the matter of every organism is also to be regarded as the mere appearance of this continual drive and change. Physiologists are now ceasing to regard it as the necessary replacement of material used up in movement, since the possible wear of the machine can by no means be equivalent to the constant influx through nutrition. Eternal becoming, endless flow, belongs to the revelation of the essence of the will.

The same thing finally shows itself in human strivings and wishes, which always delude us into thinking that their fulfillment is the final goal of willing. But as soon as they are attained, they no longer look the same, and therefore are soon forgotten, become obsolete, and are really always laid aside as vanished illusions, even if this is not admitted.

Happy enough if something still remained to wish for and to strive after, so that the play of the constant transition from wish to satisfaction and from satisfaction to a new wish can be maintained. Its rapid movement is called happiness; its slow movement is called suffering. Otherwise it falls into that stagnation which shows itself as terrible, life-stiffening boredom, a dull longing without a determinate object, a deadening languor (*languor*).

According to all this, where cognition illuminates the will, the will always knows what it wants now and here, but never what it wants in general. Every individual act has an end; willing as a whole has none. In the same way, every individual natural appearance is determined by a sufficient cause for its entrance at this place and at this time, but the force manifesting itself in it has no cause at all, since it is the grade of appearance of the thing in itself, of the groundless will.

The will's only self-knowledge as a whole, however, is representation as a whole, the entire intuitive world. This is its objecthood, its revelation, its mirror. What it says in this capacity will be the object of our further consideration.^[1]

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1. On this, see chapter 23 of the second volume. ↩

§. 30.

Third Book.

The world as representation, second consideration:
Representation independent of the principle of sufficient reason:
the Platonic Idea: the object of art.

Τί τὸ ὄν μὲν αἰεί, γένεσιν δὲ οὐκ ἔχον; καὶ τί τὸ γιγνόμενον
μὲν καὶ ἀπολλύμενον, ὄντως δὲ οὐδέποτε ὄν; ΠΛΑΤΩΝ^[†]

Translation: What is that which always is and has no becoming? And
what is that which becomes and passes away, but never truly is? Plato.

After, in the first book, we presented the world as mere *representation*, object for a subject, and then, in the second book, considered it from its other side and found this to be *will*, which alone turned out to be what that world still is besides representation, we called the world as representation, both as a whole and in its parts, in accordance with this cognition, the *objecthood of the will*. This means: the will that has become object, that is, representation.

We further remember that this objectivation of the will had many but determinate grades, at which, with gradually increasing clarity and completion, the essence of the will entered into representation, that is, presented itself as object. In these grades we already recognized Plato's Ideas, insofar as those grades are precisely the determinate species, or the original, unchanging forms and properties of all natural bodies, inorganic as well as organic, and also the universal forces that reveal themselves according to laws of nature.

All these Ideas, then, present themselves in countless individuals and particulars, to which they stand as models to their copies. The multiplicity of such individuals can be represented only through time and space, and their arising and passing away only through causality. In all these forms we recognize only the different configurations of the principle of sufficient reason, which is the ultimate principle of all finitude, of all individuation, and the universal form of representation as it falls within the cognition of the individual as such.

The Idea, by contrast, does not enter into that principle. Therefore neither multiplicity nor change belongs to it. While the individuals in which it presents itself are countless and ceaselessly come to be and pass away, the Idea remains

unchanged as one and the same, and the principle of sufficient reason has no meaning for it.

But since the principle of sufficient reason is the form under which all cognition of the subject stands insofar as that subject cognizes as an *individual*, the Ideas will also lie entirely outside the sphere of cognition of the subject as such. Therefore, if the Ideas are to become object of cognition, this can happen only through the cancellation of individuality in the knowing subject. The closer and more detailed explanations of this are what will occupy us next.

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† Editorial note: Schopenhauer's epigraph combines wording from Plato's *Timaeus* 27d–28a. Its historical form is retained; damaged letters in the extraction have been restored. ↩

§. 31.

Before proceeding, however, the following very essential remark is still needed. I hope that in the preceding book I succeeded in producing the conviction that what in Kant's philosophy is called the *thing in itself*, and appears there as such a significant but obscure and paradoxical doctrine, especially because of the way Kant introduced it, namely by inference from the grounded to the ground, so that it was found to be a stumbling block, indeed the weak side of his philosophy, is, when reached by the entirely different path we have taken, nothing other than the *will*, in the expanded and determinate sphere of this concept that has been specified.

I further hope that, after what has been set out, no one will hesitate to recognize, in the determinate grades of the objectivation of that will which constitutes the in-itself of the world, what Plato called the *eternal Ideas*, or the unchanging forms (εἶδη). These have been acknowledged as the chief, but at the same time the darkest and most paradoxical dogma of his doctrine, and have been an object of reflection, dispute, mockery, and reverence for so many minds of different temperaments through a series of centuries.

If, then, for us the will is the *thing in itself*, and the Idea is the immediate objecthood of that will at a determinate grade, we find Kant's thing in itself and Plato's Idea, which alone is for him ὅντως ὄν (that which truly is), these two great obscure paradoxes of the two greatest philosophers of the West, to be not identical, but very closely related, distinguished by only a single determination. Indeed, precisely because, despite all their inner agreement and kinship, they sound so very different through the extraordinarily different individualities of their authors, these two great paradoxes are the best mutual commentary on each other. They are like two very different roads that lead to *one* goal.

This can be made clear in a few words. What Kant says, in essentials, is the following: "Time, space, and causality are not determinations of the thing in itself; rather, they belong only to its appearance, since they are nothing but forms of our cognition. But since all multiplicity and all coming-to-be and passing-away are possible only through time, space, and causality, it follows that these too attach only to appearance, and by no means to the thing in itself. Since our cognition, however, is conditioned by these forms, all experience is cognition only of appearance, not of the thing in itself. Therefore its laws also cannot be made valid for the thing in itself. Even our own I is included in what

has been said, and we know it only as appearance, not according to what it may be in itself." This, in the important respect under consideration, is the meaning and content of Kant's doctrine.

Plato, however, says: "The things of this world, which our senses perceive, have no true being at all: *they are always becoming, but never are*. They have only a relative being; all of them are only in and through their relation to one another. Therefore their whole existence can just as well be called a non-being. Consequently they are also not objects of genuine cognition (ἐπιστήμη), for such cognition can exist only of what is in and for itself and always in the same way. They, by contrast, are only the object of an opinion occasioned by sensation (δόξα μετ' αἰσθήσεως ἄλογον).

"So long as we are restricted to their perception, we are like people who sit in a dark cave, so firmly bound that they cannot even turn their heads, and who see nothing, by the light of a fire burning behind them, except on the wall opposite them the shadow-images of real things carried past between them and the fire; even of one another, indeed each of himself, they see only the shadows on that wall. Their wisdom, however, would consist in predicting the sequence of those shadows learned from experience.

"By contrast, what alone can be called truly being (ὄντως ὄν), because it *always is, but never becomes or passes away*, are the real archetypes of those shadow-images: the eternal Ideas, the original forms of all things. *No multiplicity* belongs to them, for each is by its essence only one, since it is the archetype itself whose copies, or shadows, are all individual, transient things of the same kind and bearing the same name. Nor does *coming-to-be and passing-away* belong to them, for they truly are, but never become or perish like their vanishing copies." In these two negative determinations, however, it is necessarily presupposed that time, space, and causality have no meaning or validity for them, and that they do not exist in these forms.

"Of them alone, therefore, there is genuine cognition, since the object of such cognition can only be what always and in every respect is, and therefore is in itself; not what is, but also again is not, depending on how one looks at it." This is Plato's doctrine.

It is obvious, and needs no further proof, that the inner meaning of both doctrines is entirely the same: both declare the visible world to be an appearance that is in itself nothing, and has meaning and borrowed reality only through what expresses itself in it, which for one is the thing in itself and for the

other the Idea. According to both doctrines, however, all forms of that appearance, even the most universal and essential, are entirely foreign to this latter, truly existing reality.

In order to deny these forms, Kant grasped them immediately in abstract expressions, and directly denied time, space, and causality, as mere forms of appearance, of the thing in itself. Plato, by contrast, did not reach the highest expression, and denied those forms of his Ideas only indirectly, by denying of the Ideas what is possible only through those forms, namely multiplicity of what is homogeneous, coming-to-be, and passing-away.

For completeness, however, I will make that remarkable and important agreement intuitive through an example. Suppose an animal stands before us in full activity of life. Plato will say: "This animal has no true existence, but only an apparent one, a constant becoming, a relative existence that can just as well be called a non-being as a being. Truly existing is only the Idea that is imaged in that animal, or the animal in itself, *αὐτὸ τὸ θηρίον* (the animal itself), which depends on nothing, but is in and for itself, *καθ' ἑαυτό, ἀεὶ ὡσαύτως* (in itself, always in the same way), not having come to be, not ending, but always in the same way, *ἀεὶ ὄν καὶ μηδέποτε οὔτε γιγνόμενον, οὔτε ἀπολλύμενον* (always being and never either coming to be or passing away).

"Insofar as we now recognize its Idea in this animal, it is entirely indifferent and without significance whether we have this animal before us now or its ancestor that lived a thousand years ago; whether it is here or in a distant country; whether it presents itself in this or that manner, posture, or action; whether, finally, it is this individual or any other individual of its kind. All this is nothing and concerns only appearance. The Idea of the animal alone has true being and is the object of actual cognition." So Plato.

Kant would say something like this: "This animal is an appearance in time, space, and causality, all of which are the a priori (prior to experience) conditions of the possibility of experience lying in our faculty of cognition, not determinations of the thing in itself. Therefore this animal, as we perceive it at this determinate time, in this given place, as an individual that has come to be in the connection of experience, that is, in the chain of causes and effects, and is just as necessarily perishable, is not a thing in itself, but an appearance valid only in relation to our cognition. To know it according to what it may be in itself, and therefore independently of all determinations lying in time, space,

and causality, would require a different mode of cognition from the only one possible to us through senses and understanding."

To bring Kant's expression still closer to the Platonic one, one could also say: time, space, and causality are that arrangement of our intellect by virtue of which the one being of every kind that alone truly exists presents itself to us as a multiplicity of homogeneous beings, constantly arising anew and passing away, in endless succession. The apprehension of things by means of and in accordance with that arrangement is the *immanent* apprehension. By contrast, the apprehension that becomes conscious of how matters stand with this arrangement is the *transcendental* apprehension. One receives the latter in abstracto (in the abstract) through the *Critique of Pure Reason*; but exceptionally it can also arise intuitively. This last point is my addition, which I am now trying to explain through the present third book.

If Kant's doctrine had ever been understood, if since Kant Plato had really been understood and grasped, if people had faithfully and earnestly thought through the inner meaning and content of the doctrines of both great masters, instead of tossing around the technical expressions of one and parodying the style of the other, then it could not have failed that people would long ago have found how greatly the two great sages agree, and that the pure meaning, the goal of both doctrines, is entirely the same.

Not only would people then not have constantly compared Plato with Leibniz, on whom his spirit certainly did not rest, or even with a certain well-known gentleman still living,^[1] as if they wished to mock the shades of the great thinker of antiquity; in general, they would then have got much further than they have. Or rather, they would not have slipped so shamefully far back as they have in these last forty years. They would not have let themselves be led around by the nose today by this windbag, tomorrow by another, and they would not have opened the nineteenth century, which announced itself so significantly in Germany, with philosophical farces performed over Kant's grave, as the ancients sometimes performed games at the funeral rites of their own, under the justified mockery of other nations, since nothing of this sort suits the serious and even stiff Germans least of all.

But so small is the real public of genuine philosophers that even the students who understand them are brought by the centuries only sparingly:

Εἰσὶ δὴ ναρθηκοφόροι μὲν πολλοί, βάκχοι δέ γε παῦροι.

Thysigeri quidem multi, Bacchi vero pauci.

Translation: There are many thyrsus-bearers, but few Bacchants.

Ἡ ἀτιμία φιλοσοφία διὰ ταῦτα προσπέπτωκεν, ὅτι οὐ κατ' ἀξίαν αὐτῆς ἄπτονται· οὐ γὰρ νόθους ἔδει ἄπτεσθαι, ἀλλὰ γνησίους.

(Eam ob rem philosophia in infamiam incidit; quod non pro dignitate ipsam attingunt: neque enim a spuriis, sed a legitimis erat attrectanda.)

Plat.

Translation: Philosophy has fallen into disrepute for this reason, that people do not take hold of it according to its dignity; for it should not be handled by illegitimate children, but by legitimate ones. Plato.

People followed the words, the words: "representations a priori, forms of intuition and thought conscious independently of experience, original concepts of the pure understanding," and so on. They then asked whether Plato's Ideas, which are supposed also to be original concepts and also memories from an intuition of truly existing things prior to life, might perhaps be the same as Kant's forms of intuition and thought, which lie a priori in our consciousness.

These two wholly heterogeneous doctrines, the Kantian doctrine of the forms that restrict the cognition of the individual to appearance, and the Platonic doctrine of the Ideas, whose cognition expressly denies precisely those forms, doctrines that are to this extent diametrically opposed, were carefully compared because their expressions somewhat resemble each other. People consulted and disputed about their sameness, then finally found that they were not the same after all, and concluded that Plato's doctrine of Ideas and Kant's critique of reason had no agreement at all.^[2] But enough of this.

Notes

Notes

1. F. H. Jacobi. ↩

2. See, for example, *Immanuel Kant, A Memorial* by F. Bouterweck, p. 49, and Buhle's *History of Philosophy*, vol. 6, pp. 802-815 and 823. ↩

§. 32.

As a result of our previous reflections, despite all the inner agreement between Kant and Plato, and despite the identity of the goal that hovered before both of them, or of the world-view that stirred and guided them into philosophizing, Idea and thing in itself are still not simply one and the same for us. Rather, for us the Idea is only the immediate, and therefore adequate, objecthood of the thing in itself; but this thing in itself is the *will*, the will insofar as it is not yet objectified, not yet become representation.

For the thing in itself, precisely according to Kant, is supposed to be free from all forms attached to cognition as such. It is only a mistake of Kant's, as will be shown in the appendix, that he did not count among these forms, before all others, being-object-for-a-subject, since this is precisely the first and most universal form of all appearance, that is, representation. He should therefore have expressly denied object-being to his thing in itself; this would have saved him from that great inconsistency which was exposed early on.

The Platonic Idea, by contrast, is necessarily object, something cognized, a representation; and just by this, but also only by this, it is different from the thing in itself. It has merely laid aside the subordinate forms of appearance, all of which we comprehend under the principle of sufficient reason; or rather, it has not yet entered into them. But it has retained the first and most universal form, that of representation in general, of object-being for a subject.

It is these forms subordinate to that first one, whose general expression is the principle of sufficient reason, that multiply the Idea into individual and perishable individuals, whose number is entirely indifferent in relation to the Idea. The principle of sufficient reason is therefore again the form into which the Idea enters when it falls into the cognition of the subject as individual.

The individual thing that appears in accordance with the principle of sufficient reason is therefore only a mediated objectivation of the thing in itself, which is the will. Between the will and the individual thing there still stands the Idea, as the sole immediate objecthood of the will, since it has taken on no form proper to cognition as such except that of representation in general, that is, of object-being for a subject.

Therefore it alone is also the most nearly *adequate objecthood* of the will, or thing in itself; indeed, it is the whole thing in itself, only under the form of

representation. Here lies the ground of the great agreement between Plato and Kant, although, with the greatest strictness, what the two are speaking about is not the same. Individual things, however, are not a wholly adequate objecthood of the will. In them it is already clouded by those forms whose common expression is the principle of sufficient reason, but which are the condition of cognition as it is possible for the individual as such.

Indeed, if it were permissible to draw an inference from an impossible supposition, we would no longer cognize individual things at all, nor events, nor change, nor multiplicity. Instead, in pure and unclouded cognition, we would apprehend only Ideas, only the scale of the objectivation of that one will, the true thing in itself; and consequently our world would be a *Nunc stans* (a standing now, an eternal present).

This would be so if we, as subject of cognition, were not at the same time individuals; that is, if our intuition were not mediated by a body, from whose affections it proceeds, and which is itself only concrete willing, objecthood of the will, and therefore object among objects. As such, once it enters knowing consciousness, it can do so only in the forms of the principle of sufficient reason; consequently it already presupposes, and thereby introduces, time and all the other forms expressed by that principle.

Time is merely the distributed and fragmented view that an individual being has of the Ideas, which are outside time and therefore *eternal*. Hence Plato says that time is the moving image of eternity: αἰῶνος εἰκὼν κινητὴ ὁ χρόνος (time is the moving image of eternity).^[1]

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1. On this, see chapter 29 of the second volume. ↩

§. 33.

Since, then, as individuals we have no cognition other than cognition subject to the principle of sufficient reason, and since this form excludes cognition of the Ideas, it is certain that, if it is possible for us to rise from cognition of individual things to cognition of Ideas, this can happen only through a change taking place in the subject. This change must correspond and be analogous to that great change in the whole kind of the object; and by virtue of it, the subject, insofar as it cognizes an Idea, is no longer individual.

We will remember from the preceding book that cognition in general itself belongs to the objectivation of the will at its higher grades, and that sensibility, nerves, and brain are, like the other parts of the organic being, simply the expression of the will at this grade of its objecthood. Therefore the representation that arises through them is likewise destined for the will's service, as a means, a μηχανή (contrivance), for attaining its now more complicated (πολυτελεστέρα, more elaborate) ends, and for preserving a being that has many different needs.

Originally, then, and according to its essence, cognition is entirely serviceable to the will. Just as the immediate object, which becomes cognition's starting point through application of the law of causality, is only objectified will, so too all cognition that proceeds according to the principle of sufficient reason remains in a nearer or more distant relation to the will. For the individual finds his body as an object among objects, to all of which this body has many different relations and connections according to the principle of sufficient reason. Consideration of these relations therefore always leads back, by a nearer or more distant path, to his body, and thus to his will.

Since it is the principle of sufficient reason that places objects in this relation to the body, and thereby to the will, the cognition that serves the will will also strive only to learn, from objects, precisely the relations established by the principle of sufficient reason. It will therefore follow their many different relations in space, time, and causality. For only through these is the object *interesting* to the individual, that is, does it have a relation to the will.

Consequently cognition in the service of the will really cognizes nothing more in objects than their relations. It cognizes objects only insofar as they exist at this time, in this place, under these circumstances, from these causes, with these effects: in a word, as individual things. If all these relations were

removed, then the objects too would have vanished for this cognition, precisely because it cognized nothing else in them.

Nor may we conceal that what the sciences consider in things is, in essence, likewise nothing other than all this: their relations, the relations of time and space, the causes of natural changes, the comparison of forms, the motives of events, and thus nothing but relations. What distinguishes science from common cognition is only its form, its systematic character, the easing of cognition by comprehending everything individual under the universal through the subordination of concepts, and the completeness thereby attained.

Every relation itself has only a relative existence. For example, every being in time is also, in turn, a non-being; for time is precisely that by which opposed determinations can belong to the same thing. Hence every appearance in time is also, in turn, not; for what separates its beginning from its end is just time, something essentially passing away, unstable, and relative, here called duration. Time, however, is the most universal form of all objects of cognition that stands in the service of the will, and the archetype of its other forms.

As a rule, then, cognition always remains subject to the service of the will, since it arose for this service, indeed sprang from the will, so to speak, as the head springs from the trunk. In animals, this servitude of cognition under the will can never be abolished. In human beings, such abolition occurs only as an exception, as we will examine more closely at once.

This difference between human being and animal is expressed outwardly by the different relation of the head to the trunk. In the lower animals the two are still entirely fused together. In all animals the head is directed toward the earth, where the objects of the will lie. Even in the higher animals, head and trunk are still much more one than they are in the human being, whose head appears freely set upon the body, merely carried by it, not serving it.

This human privilege is displayed in the highest degree by the Apollo Belvedere: the far-seeing head of the god of the Muses stands so freely on the shoulders that it appears entirely wrested from the body, no longer subject to concern for it.

§. 34.

The transition, already described as possible but to be regarded only as an exception, from common cognition of individual things to cognition of the Idea occurs suddenly, when cognition tears itself free from the service of the will. By this very fact the subject ceases to be merely individual, and is now the pure, will-less subject of cognition, which no longer pursues relations according to the principle of sufficient reason, but rests in fixed contemplation of the presented object, outside its connection with anything else, and is absorbed in it.

In order to become clear, this necessarily requires a detailed explanation. For the time being one must get past whatever seems strange in it, until that strangeness disappears of itself once the whole thought to be communicated in this work has been grasped.

When, lifted by the power of the mind, one lets go of the ordinary way of considering things; when one stops pursuing only their relations to one another, whose final goal is always their relation to one's own will, along the guiding thread of the forms of the principle of sufficient reason; when, therefore, one no longer considers the where, the when, the why, and the for-what of things, but solely and exclusively the *what*; when, moreover, one does not let abstract thinking, the concepts of reason, take possession of consciousness, but instead gives the whole power of one's mind over to intuition, immerses oneself entirely in it, and lets the whole of consciousness be filled by the calm contemplation of the natural object just present, whether a landscape, a tree, a rock, a building, or whatever else it may be; when, according to a meaningful German expression, one wholly *loses oneself* in this object, that is, precisely forgets one's individuality, one's will, and remains existing only as pure subject, as clear mirror of the object; so that it is as if the object alone were there, without anyone perceiving it, and one can therefore no longer separate the beholder from the intuition, but the two have become one, since the whole of consciousness is completely filled and occupied by a single intuitive image: then, when in this way the object has stepped out of all relation to anything outside it, and the subject has stepped out of all relation to the will, what is cognized is no longer the individual thing as such. Rather, it is the *Idea*, the eternal form, the immediate objecthood of the will at this grade.

And precisely through this, the one absorbed in this intuition is at the same time no longer individual; for the individual has lost himself in such intuition. Instead, he is the *pure*, will-less, painless, timeless *subject of cognition*.

This, taken by itself, is now so striking that I know very well it confirms the saying that comes from Thomas Paine, *du sublime au ridicule il n'y a qu'un pas* (from the sublime to the ridiculous there is only one step). But what follows will gradually make it clearer and less strange. This was also what hovered before Spinoza when he wrote: *mens aeterna est, quatenus res sub aeternitatis specie concipit* (Eth. V, pr. 31, schol.) (the mind is eternal insofar as it conceives things under the aspect of eternity).^[1]

In such contemplation, then, at one stroke the individual thing becomes the *Idea* of its species, and the intuiting individual becomes the *pure subject of cognition*. The individual as such cognizes only individual things; the pure subject of cognition cognizes only Ideas.

For the individual is the subject of cognition in its relation to a determinate individual appearance of the will, and is serviceable to this appearance. This individual appearance of will, as such, is subject to the principle of sufficient reason in all its forms. Therefore all cognition relating to it also follows the principle of sufficient reason, and for the purposes of the will no cognition is useful except this one, which always has only relations to the object. The knowing individual as such, and the individual thing known by him, are always somewhere, sometime, and members in the chain of causes and effects.

The pure subject of cognition and its correlate, the Idea, have stepped out of all those forms of the principle of sufficient reason. Time, place, the individual that cognizes, and the individual that is cognized have no significance for them.

Only when, in the way described, a knowing individual raises himself to the pure subject of cognition, and precisely thereby the object considered raises itself to the Idea, does the *world as representation* emerge wholly and purely, and the complete objectivation of the will take place, since the Idea alone is its *adequate objecthood*. The Idea includes object and subject in itself in equal measure, since these are its only form; but in it the two hold one another in perfect equilibrium. Just as here too the object is nothing but the representation of the subject, so also the subject, by being wholly absorbed in the intuited object, has itself become this object, since the whole of consciousness is now nothing but that object's clearest image.

This very consciousness, if one thinks all the Ideas, or grades of the objecthood of the will, as passing through it in sequence, is what properly makes up the whole *world as representation*. The individual things of all times and spaces are nothing but the Ideas multiplied by the principle of sufficient reason, the form of cognition of individuals as such, and thereby clouded in their pure objecthood.

When the Idea emerges, subject and object can no longer be distinguished in it, because only when they completely fill and interpenetrate one another does the Idea, the adequate objecthood of the will, the world as representation proper, arise. In just the same way, the individual that cognizes in this process and the individual that is cognized are, as things in themselves, not distinct. For if we entirely abstract from that world as representation proper, nothing remains except the *world as will*.

The will is the in-itself of the Idea, which objectifies it perfectly. It is also the in-itself of the individual thing and of the individual that cognizes it, both of which objectify it imperfectly. As will, outside representation and all its forms, it is one and the same in the contemplated object and in the individual who, raising himself in this contemplation, becomes conscious of himself as pure subject. Therefore those two are not distinct in themselves; for in themselves they are the will, which here cognizes itself. Multiplicity and difference exist only as the manner in which this cognition comes to the will, that is, only in appearance, by virtue of appearance's form, the principle of sufficient reason.

Just as little as I, without the object, without the representation, am a knowing subject, but merely blind will, so too the thing known, without me as subject of cognition, is not object, but merely will, blind drive. This will is in itself, that is, outside representation, one and the same with mine. Only in the world as representation, whose form is always at least subject and object, do we separate into cognized and cognizing individual.

As soon as cognition, the world as representation, is abolished, nothing at all remains except mere will, blind drive. That the will should obtain objecthood, should become representation, presupposes, at one stroke, both subject and object. But that this objecthood should be pure, complete, adequate objecthood of the will presupposes the object as Idea, free from the forms of the principle of sufficient reason, and the subject as pure subject of cognition, free from individuality and serviceability to the will.

Whoever, in the way described, has sunk and lost himself so deeply in the intuition of nature that he exists only as purely knowing subject, thereby becomes immediately aware that, as such, he is the condition, and therefore the bearer, of the world and of all objective existence, since this now presents itself as dependent on his own existence. He therefore draws nature into himself, so that he feels it now only as an accident of his being. In this sense *Byron* says:

Are not the mountains, waves, and skies, a part
Of me and of my soul, as I of them?^[2]

But how could someone who feels this regard himself, in contrast with imperishable nature, as absolutely perishable? Rather, he will be seized by the consciousness of what the Upanishad of the Veda expresses: *Hae omnes creaturae in totum ego sum, et praeter me aliud ens non est.* (Oupnekhat, I, 122.) (All these creatures, in their totality, are I, and apart from me there is no other being).^[3]

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1. I also recommend rereading what he says in the same work, book II, proposition 40, scholium 2, and likewise book V, propositions 25 through 38, about the *cognitio tertii generis, sive intuitiva* (cognition of the third kind, or intuitive cognition), for elucidation of the mode of cognition under discussion here; especially proposition 29, scholium; proposition 36, scholium; and proposition 38, demonstration and scholium. ↩
2. Are mountains, waves, and skies not a part of me and of my soul, as I of them? ↩
3. On this, see chapter 30 of the second volume. ↩

§. 35.

In order to gain a deeper insight into the essence of the world, it is absolutely necessary to learn to distinguish the will as thing in itself from its adequate objecthood; then to distinguish the different grades on which this objecthood comes forward more clearly and completely, that is, the Ideas themselves, from the mere appearance of the Ideas in the forms of the principle of sufficient reason, the mode of cognition in which individuals are confined.

Then one will agree with Plato when he ascribes genuine being only to the Ideas, but grants to things in space and time, this world that is real for the individual, only an apparent, dreamlike existence. Then one will see how one and the same Idea reveals itself in so many appearances, and presents its essence to knowing individuals only piece by piece, one side after another. One will then also distinguish the Idea itself from the way its appearance falls under the observation of the individual, recognizing the former as essential and the latter as inessential.

Let us consider this first in the smallest things, and then in the greatest.

When clouds move, the shapes they form are not essential to them; they are indifferent to them. But that, as elastic vapor, they are compressed by the thrust of the wind, driven away, expanded, torn apart: this is their nature, the essence of the forces that objectify themselves in them, the Idea. The particular shapes at any given time exist only for the individual observer.

For the brook that rolls downward over stones, the eddies, waves, and foam formations it shows are indifferent and inessential. That it follows gravity and behaves as an inelastic, wholly displaceable, formless, transparent fluid: this is its essence, this is the Idea, *if cognized intuitively*. Those formations exist only for us, so long as we cognize as individuals.

The ice on the windowpane shoots forth according to the laws of crystallization, which reveal the essence of the natural force appearing here and present the Idea. But the trees and flowers it forms in doing so are inessential and exist only for us.

What appears in clouds, brook, and crystal is the weakest echo of that will which comes forward more perfectly in the plant, still more perfectly in the animal, and most perfectly in the human being. But only what is *essential* in all those grades of its objectivation constitutes the *Idea*. By contrast, the unfolding

of the Idea, as it is drawn apart into manifold and many-sided appearances in the forms of the principle of sufficient reason, is inessential to the Idea. It lies merely in the mode of cognition of the individual, and has reality only for this individual.

The same necessarily also holds for the unfolding of that Idea which is the most perfect objecthood of the will. Consequently the history of the human race, the throng of events, the change of times, the many-shaped forms of human life in different lands and centuries: all this is only the accidental form of the appearance of the Idea. It does not belong to the Idea itself, in which alone the adequate objecthood of the will lies, but only to the appearance that falls into the cognition of the individual. It is as foreign, inessential, and indifferent to the Idea itself as the shapes they portray are to the clouds, the form of its eddies and foam formations to the brook, and its trees and flowers to the ice.

Whoever has grasped this well, and knows how to distinguish the will from the Idea, and the Idea from its appearance, will find that world-events have significance only insofar as they are the letters from which the Idea of humanity can be read, but not in and for themselves. He will not believe, with people generally, that time produces something actually new and significant; that through it or in it something absolutely real comes into existence; or even that time itself, as a whole, has beginning and end, plan and development, and perhaps as its final goal the highest perfection, according to their concepts, of the last generation, which lives for thirty years.

Therefore he will no more appoint with Homer an entire Olympus full of gods to direct those events in time than he will, with Ossian, take the shapes of the clouds for individual beings; for, as has been said, both have equal significance in relation to the Idea appearing in them. In the manifold shapes of human life and the unceasing change of events, he will consider only the Idea as the enduring and essential thing. In this Idea the will to life has its most perfect objecthood, and it shows its different sides in the qualities, passions, errors, and excellences of the human race: in self-interest, hatred, love, fear, boldness, frivolity, dullness, cunning, wit, genius, and so on. All these, flowing together and congealing into a thousandfold variety of forms, that is, individuals, continually perform the great and the small history of the world. In itself it makes no difference whether what sets them in motion is nuts or crowns.

Finally, he will find that things are in the world as they are in Gozzi's dramas, in all of which the same characters always appear, with the same

intention and the same fate. The motives and events are, of course, different in each play; but the spirit of the events is the same. The characters of one play also know nothing of the events in another, even though they themselves acted in it. Therefore, after all the experiences of the earlier plays, Pantalone has still not become more agile or more generous, Tartaglia more conscientious, Brighella more courageous, or Colombina more modest.

Suppose we were once granted a clear view into the realm of possibility and over all the chains of causes and effects; suppose the Earth-spirit came forward and showed us in one image the most excellent individuals, illuminators of the world and heroes, whom chance destroyed before the time of their effectiveness; then the great events that would have changed world history and brought about periods of the highest culture and enlightenment, but which the blindest contingency, the most insignificant accident, obstructed at their very beginning; finally the glorious powers of great individuals, which would have made whole ages fruitful, but which they, misled by error or passion, or forced by necessity, uselessly squandered on unworthy and barren objects, or even wasted in play: if we saw all this, we would shudder and lament over the lost treasures of whole ages.

But the Earth-spirit would smile and say: "The source from which individuals and their powers flow is inexhaustible and infinite, like time and space; for they, just like these forms of all appearance, are after all only appearance, visibility of the will's activity. No finite measure can exhaust that infinite source. Therefore, for every event or work stifled in the seed, the undiminished infinity still always stands open for its return. In this world of appearance, true loss is just as impossible as true gain. The will alone is: it, the thing in itself, it is the source of all those appearances. Its self-cognition, and the affirmation or denial that decides itself on the basis of this self-cognition, is the only event in itself."^[1]

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1. This last sentence cannot be understood without acquaintance with the following book. ↩

§. 36.

History follows the thread of events. It is pragmatic insofar as it derives them according to the law of motivation, the law that determines the appearing will where it is illuminated by cognition.

At the lower grades of the will's objecthood, where it still works without cognition, natural science considers the laws governing the changes of its appearances as aetiology, and what is enduring in them as morphology. Morphology makes its almost infinite theme easier for itself with the help of concepts, comprehending the universal in order to derive the particular from it.

Finally, mathematics considers the mere forms in which, for the cognition of the subject as individual, the Ideas appear drawn apart into multiplicity: time and space. All these, whose common name is science, therefore follow the principle of sufficient reason in its different forms, and their theme remains appearance, its laws, its connection, and the relations arising from it.

What kind of cognition, then, considers that which exists outside and independently of all relation, the only thing truly essential in the world, the true content of its appearances, that which is subject to no change and is therefore cognized with equal truth for all time? In a word, what cognition considers the *Ideas*, which are the immediate and adequate objecthood of the thing in itself, the will?

It is *art*, the work of genius. Art repeats the eternal Ideas apprehended through pure contemplation, the essential and enduring element in all appearances of the world; and according to the material in which it repeats them, it is plastic art, poetry, or music. Its sole origin is cognition of the Ideas; its sole goal is communication of this cognition.

Science follows the restless and unstable stream of grounds and consequents in their fourfold form. At every goal it reaches, it is always directed further onward again, and can never find a final goal or complete satisfaction, any more than one can reach, by running, the point where the clouds touch the horizon. Art, by contrast, is everywhere at its goal. For it tears the object of its contemplation out of the stream of the world's course and has it isolated before itself. This individual thing, which in that stream was a vanishingly small part, becomes for art a representative of the whole, an equivalent of the infinitely many in space and time.

Art therefore stops at this individual thing. It halts the wheel of time. Relations vanish for it. Only the essential, the Idea, is its object.

We can therefore designate art quite directly as *the way of considering things independently of the principle of sufficient reason*, in contrast to the consideration that follows precisely this principle, which is the path of experience and science. This latter kind of consideration may be compared to an infinite horizontal line; the former to the vertical line that cuts it at any chosen point.

The consideration that follows the principle of sufficient reason is the rational way of considering things, which alone has validity and use in practical life and in science. The consideration that looks away from the content of that principle is the way of considering things proper to genius, which alone has validity and use in art. The former is Aristotle's way of considering things; the latter is, on the whole, Plato's.

The former is like the mighty storm that rushes on without beginning or goal, bending, moving, and carrying everything away with it. The latter is like the calm ray of sunlight that cuts through the path of this storm, wholly unmoved by it. The former is like the countless drops of a waterfall, violently moved, constantly changing, not resting for a moment. The latter is like the rainbow resting quietly on this raging turmoil.

Ideas are apprehended only through the pure contemplation described above, the contemplation that is wholly absorbed in the object; and the essence of *genius* consists precisely in the preponderant capacity for such contemplation. Since this contemplation demands a complete forgetting of one's own person and its relations, *genius* is nothing other than the most complete *objectivity*, that is, the objective direction of the mind, opposed to the subjective direction toward one's own person, that is, toward the will.

Accordingly, genius is the capacity to behave purely intuitively, to lose oneself in intuition, and to withdraw from the service of the will the cognition that originally exists only for that service. This means losing sight entirely of one's interest, one's willing, and one's purposes, and thus for a time completely divesting oneself of one's personality, in order to remain as *pure knowing subject*, as clear eye of the world. And this must happen not for moments only, but so persistently and with as much reflective awareness as is needed in order to repeat, through deliberate art, what has been apprehended, and "to fix in enduring thoughts what hovers in wavering appearance."

It is as if, in order for genius to emerge in an individual, a measure of cognitive power must have fallen to him that far exceeds what is required for the service of an individual will. This surplus of cognition, now set free, becomes the subject pure of will, the bright mirror of the essence of the world.

This explains the liveliness, even to the point of unrest, in individuals of genius. The present can rarely satisfy them, because it does not fill their consciousness. This gives them that restless striving, that unceasing search for new objects worthy of contemplation, and also that almost never satisfied longing for beings like themselves, equal to them, to whom they could communicate themselves. Meanwhile the ordinary child of earth, entirely filled and satisfied by the ordinary present, is absorbed in it; and since he finds his like everywhere, he has that special comfort in everyday life which is denied to genius.

Imagination has been recognized as an essential component of genius; indeed, it has sometimes even been taken as identical with it. The former is right; the latter is wrong. Since the objects of genius as such are the eternal Ideas, the enduring essential forms of the world and all its appearances, and since cognition of the Idea is necessarily intuitive, not abstract, the cognition of genius would be limited to the Ideas of the objects actually present to his person, and would depend on the chain of circumstances that brought them to him, if imagination did not extend his horizon far beyond the actuality of his personal experience. It enables him, from the little that has entered his actual apperception, to construct all the rest, and thus to let almost all possible images of life pass before him.

Moreover, actual objects are almost always only very defective specimens of the Idea presenting itself in them. Genius therefore needs imagination in order to see in things not what nature has actually formed, but what nature strove to form and did not bring about because of the conflict among its forms mentioned in the preceding book. We will return to this below when considering sculpture.

Imagination therefore extends the horizon of genius beyond the objects that present themselves in actuality to his person, both in quality and in quantity. For this reason, unusual strength of imagination accompanies genius; indeed, it is a condition of it. But conversely, imagination does not testify to genius. On the contrary, even very ungifted people can have a great deal of imagination.

For just as one can consider an actual object in two opposed ways, either purely objectively, as genius does, grasping its Idea, or commonly, merely in its

relations to other objects and to one's own will according to the principle of sufficient reason, so too one can intuit a phantasm in both ways. Considered in the first way, it is a means to cognition of the Idea, whose communication is the work of art. In the second case, the phantasm is used to build castles in the air that suit self-interest and one's own whim, momentarily deceiving and amusing; in this case, what is really cognized in the phantasms thus connected is always only their relations.

The person who carries on this game is a fantasist. He will easily mix the images with which he amuses himself in solitude into actuality, and thereby become unfit for it. Perhaps he will write down the illusions of his imagination, where they produce the ordinary novels of every kind, which entertain his like and the great public, since the readers dream themselves into the place of the hero and then find the presentation very "cozy."

The ordinary human being, this factory product of nature as she brings it forth daily by the thousand, is, as I have said, not capable, at least not persistently, of a wholly disinterested consideration in every sense, which is genuine contemplation. He can direct his attention to things only insofar as they have some relation, however indirect, to his will.

Since in this respect, which always requires only cognition of relations, the abstract concept of the thing is sufficient and usually even more useful, the ordinary human being does not dwell long with mere intuition, and therefore does not fasten his gaze on an object for long. Instead, with everything that presents itself to him, he quickly seeks only the concept under which it is to be brought, as the lazy person seeks a chair; and then it interests him no further.

That is why he is so quickly finished with everything: with works of art, beautiful natural objects, and the genuinely significant sight of life in all its scenes. He does not linger. He seeks only his path in life, and at most everything that could ever become his path, that is, topographical notes in the broadest sense. He loses no time in contemplating life itself as such.

The person of genius, by contrast, whose cognitive power, through its preponderance, withdraws itself from the service of his will for part of his time, lingers with the contemplation of life itself. He strives to grasp the Idea of each thing, not its relations to other things. In doing this, he often neglects consideration of his own path in life, and therefore usually follows it awkwardly enough.

For the ordinary human being, his faculty of cognition is the lantern that lights his path. For the person of genius, it is the sun that makes the world manifest. This very different way of looking into life soon becomes visible even outwardly in both. The gaze of the human being in whom genius lives and works easily distinguishes him, since, lively and firm at once, it bears the character of contemplation; as we can see in the portraits of the few heads of genius that nature has now and then produced among countless millions. By contrast, in the gaze of the others, if it is not, as is usually the case, dull or sober, the true opposite of contemplation, namely spying, easily becomes visible.

Accordingly, the "expression of genius" in a head consists in the fact that a decided predominance of cognition over willing is visible in it, and consequently that a cognition without any relation to willing, that is, a *pure cognition*, expresses itself there. By contrast, in heads such as they usually are, the expression of willing predominates, and one sees that cognition first becomes active only at the impulse of willing, and is therefore directed merely toward motives.

Since cognition of genius, or cognition of the Idea, is the cognition that does not follow the principle of sufficient reason, while the cognition that follows this principle confers prudence and rationality in life and brings about the sciences, individuals of genius will be afflicted with the defects entailed by neglect of the latter mode of cognition.

However, one must note the following limitation: what I will mention in this respect applies to them only insofar as, and while, they are actually engaged in the mode of cognition proper to genius. This is by no means the case at every moment of their lives, since the great, though spontaneous, exertion required for the will-free apprehension of the Ideas necessarily slackens again and leaves large intervals in which, both with respect to advantages and defects, they stand fairly close to ordinary human beings.

For this reason, the working of genius has always been regarded as inspiration; indeed, as the name itself indicates, as the working of a superhuman being different from the individual himself, which periodically takes possession of him.

The reluctance of individuals of genius to direct attention to the content of the principle of sufficient reason will first show itself with regard to the ground of being, as an aversion to mathematics. Mathematical consideration concerns

the most universal forms of appearance, space and time, which themselves are only forms of the principle of sufficient reason, and is therefore the complete opposite of that consideration which seeks precisely only the content of appearance, the Idea expressing itself in it, while looking away from all relations.

In addition, the logical treatment of mathematics will resist genius, since, by blocking genuine insight, it does not satisfy, but offers a mere chain of inferences according to the principle of the ground of knowing. Among all mental powers it makes the greatest claim on memory, since one must always keep present all the earlier propositions to which one appeals.

Experience too has confirmed that great geniuses in art have no aptitude for mathematics: never was a human being very distinguished in both. Alfieri says that he was never able to grasp even the fourth proposition of Euclid. Goethe's lack of mathematical knowledge has been reproached often enough by the unintelligent opponents of his theory of colors. Of course, where the issue was not calculation and measurement according to hypothetical data, but immediate cognition by the understanding of cause and effect, this reproach was so completely askew and out of place that those opponents displayed their total lack of power of judgment by it just as much as by their other Midas-pronouncements.

That even today, almost half a century after the appearance of Goethe's theory of colors, the Newtonian flimflam remains undisturbed in possession of the professorial chairs, even in Germany, and people continue, quite seriously, to speak of the seven homogeneous lights and their different refrangibility, will someday be counted among the great intellectual character traits of humanity in general and of Germanness in particular.

The same reason given above also explains the equally well-known fact that, conversely, distinguished mathematicians have little receptivity for works of fine art. This is expressed with particular naivety in the well-known anecdote about the French mathematician who, after reading Racine's *Iphigenia*, shrugged and asked: Qu'est-ce-que cela prouve? (What does that prove?)

Furthermore, since sharp apprehension of relations according to the law of causality and motivation is what actually constitutes prudence, while cognition of genius is not directed to relations, a prudent person, insofar as and while he is prudent, will not be a genius, and a genius, insofar as and while he is a genius, will not be prudent.

Finally, intuitive cognition in general, in whose domain the Idea lies throughout, stands in direct opposition to rational or abstract cognition, which is guided by the principle of the ground of knowing. It is also well known that great genius is rarely found paired with predominant rationality. On the contrary, individuals of genius are often subject to violent affects and irrational passions.

The reason for this is nevertheless not weakness of reason, but partly the unusual energy of the whole appearance of will that is the individual of genius, an energy that expresses itself through the vehemence of all acts of will; and partly the predominance of intuitive cognition through senses and understanding over abstract cognition. Hence there is a decided direction toward the intuitive, whose highly energetic impression in such people so outshines the colorless concepts that their action is guided no longer by these concepts, but by that impression, and thereby becomes irrational.

Accordingly, the impression of the present is very powerful in them, carrying them away into rashness, affect, and passion. For this reason too, and in general because their cognition has in part withdrawn itself from the service of the will, in conversation they will not think so much of the person to whom they are speaking as of the matter of which they speak, which hovers vividly before them. They will therefore judge or narrate too objectively for their own interest, will not keep silent about what it would be wiser to keep silent about, and so on. Finally, they are inclined to monologues and can in general show several weaknesses that really approach madness.

That genius and madness have one side where they border on one another, indeed pass into one another, has often been observed; and even poetic inspiration has been called a kind of madness. Horace calls it *amabilis insania* (lovely madness) in *Odes* III, 4, and Wieland calls it "sweet madness" at the beginning of *Oberon*. Even Aristotle is said, according to Seneca's citation in *On Tranquility of Mind* 15, 16, to have said: *Nullum magnum ingenium sine mixtura dementiae fuit* (There has been no great genius without some admixture of madness).

Plato expresses this in the myth of the dark cave cited above, in *Republic* VII, by saying that those who have seen the true sunlight and the really existing things outside the cave, the Ideas, later cannot see anymore in the cave because their eyes are no longer accustomed to darkness. They no longer recognize the shadow-images down there correctly, and for this reason, because of their

mistakes, they are mocked by the others, who never left this cave and these shadow-images. In the *Phaedrus* he also says quite directly that without a certain madness there can be no genuine poet, indeed that anyone who recognizes the eternal Ideas in perishable things appears mad.

Cicero too reports: *Negat enim, sine furore, Democritus, quemquam poetam magnum esse posse; quod idem dicit Plato (de divin. I, 37).* (Democritus denies that anyone can be a great poet without frenzy; Plato says the same.) And finally Pope says:

Great wits to madness sure are near allied,
And thin partitions do their bounds divide^[1]

Especially instructive in this respect is Goethe's *Torquato Tasso*, in which he sets before our eyes not only the suffering, the essential martyrdom of genius as such, but also its steady transition into madness.

Finally, the fact of immediate contact between genius and madness is confirmed by the biographies of highly gifted human beings, for example Rousseau, Byron, and Alfieri, and by anecdotes from the lives of others. On the other hand, I must mention that, in frequent visits to asylums, I have found individual subjects of unmistakably great gifts, whose genius clearly showed through their madness, though madness had here completely gained the upper hand.

This cannot be attributed to chance, because on the one hand the number of the insane is relatively very small, while on the other hand an individual of genius is a phenomenon rare beyond all ordinary estimation, and appears in nature only as the greatest exception. One can convince oneself of this simply by counting the truly great geniuses whom all cultivated Europe has produced throughout the whole of ancient and modern times, including only those who produced works that retain lasting value for humanity through all ages, and then comparing these few individuals with the 250 million people who, renewing themselves every thirty years, live constantly in Europe.

Indeed, I will not omit mentioning that I have known some people of spiritual superiority that was not significant, but was nevertheless decided, who at the same time betrayed a slight tinge of derangement. According to this, it might seem that every increase of intellect beyond the ordinary measure already disposes one to madness as an abnormality.

Meanwhile, I will present as briefly as possible my view of the purely intellectual ground of that kinship between genius and madness, since this discussion will contribute to explaining the proper essence of genius, that is, of the quality of mind that alone can create genuine works of art. But this makes a brief discussion of madness itself necessary.^[2]

To my knowledge, a clear and complete insight into the essence of madness, a correct and distinct concept of what actually distinguishes the mad person from the healthy one, has still not been found.

Neither reason nor understanding can be denied to the mad, for they speak and understand, and often infer very correctly. As a rule they also intuit the present quite correctly and grasp the connection between cause and effect. Visions, like fever fantasies, are not a common symptom of madness. Delirium falsifies intuition; madness falsifies thoughts.

For the most part, the mad do not err at all in their cognition of what is immediately *present*. Rather, their mad talk always relates to what is *absent* and *past*, and only through this to its connection with the present. Therefore their illness seems to me to affect especially the *memory*. Not, to be sure, so that memory is entirely lacking to them; for many know a great deal by heart and sometimes recognize people whom they have not seen for a long time. Rather, the thread of memory is torn, its continuous connection abolished, and no uniformly coherent recollection of the past is possible.

Individual scenes from the past stand there correctly, as does the individual present; but in their recollection there are gaps, which they then fill with fictions. These fictions either remain always the same and become fixed ideas, in which case it is fixed delusion, melancholy; or they are different each time, momentary notions, in which case it is called folly, fatuitas (foolishness).

For this reason it is so difficult, when a mad person enters the asylum, to ask him about the course of his earlier life. More and more, truth and falsehood become mixed in his memory. Although the immediate present is cognized correctly, it is falsified by the fictitious connection with a supposed past. Thus they take themselves and others to be identical with persons who exist only in their fictitious past, fail to recognize some acquaintances at all, and so, while having a correct representation of the present individual thing, have only false relations of it to what is absent.

If madness reaches a high degree, complete loss of memory arises. The mad person is then entirely incapable of regard for anything absent or past, and is

determined solely by the whim of the moment in connection with the fictions that fill the past in his head. One is then not safe from mistreatment or murder for a single moment unless one constantly keeps superior force before his eyes.

The cognition of the mad person has this in common with that of the animal: both are restricted to the present. But what distinguishes them is this: the animal actually has no representation of the past as such, although the past works on the animal through the medium of habit. Thus, for example, the dog recognizes his former master even after years, that is, receives the accustomed impression from seeing him; but he nevertheless has no recollection of the time that has passed since then.

The mad person, by contrast, always carries around in his reason a past in abstracto (in the abstract), but a false one, which exists only for him, either at all times or only just now. The influence of this false past then also prevents the use of the correctly cognized present, which the animal does make.

That violent mental suffering, unexpected and terrible events, frequently occasion madness, I explain in the following way. Every such suffering, as an actual event, is always restricted to the present, and is therefore only transitory; to that extent it is still not excessively severe. It becomes overwhelmingly great only insofar as it is lasting pain. But as such it is again solely a thought, and therefore lies in the *memory*.

If such grief, such painful knowledge or recollection, is so tormenting that it becomes absolutely unbearable and the individual would succumb to it, then nature, so terribly anxious, resorts to *madness* as the last means of saving life. The mind, so greatly tormented, now tears, as it were, the thread of its memory, fills the gaps with fictions, and thus flees from mental pain exceeding its strength into madness, just as one amputates a limb seized by fire and replaces it with a wooden one.

As examples, consider the raging Ajax, King Lear, and Ophelia; for the creatures of genuine genius, to which alone we can appeal here as universally known, are to be set equal to actual persons in truth. Moreover, frequent actual experience shows exactly the same thing here.

A weak analogue of this kind of transition from pain to madness is the fact that all of us often try, almost mechanically, to drive away a tormenting memory that suddenly occurs to us by some loud utterance or movement, to divert ourselves from it, to distract ourselves from it by force.

If, then, as indicated, we see that the mad person correctly cognizes the individual present and also many individual past things, but fails to recognize the connection, the relations, and therefore errs and speaks madness, this is precisely the point at which he touches the individual of genius.

For the individual of genius too, since he leaves behind cognition of relations, which is cognition according to the principle of sufficient reason, in order to see and seek in things only their Ideas, and to grasp their proper essence as it expresses itself intuitively, in relation to which *one* thing represents its whole species and therefore, as Goethe says, one case counts for thousands: the individual of genius too, in doing this, loses sight of cognition of the connection among things. The individual object of his contemplation, or the present grasped by him with excessive vividness, appears in such bright light that, as it were, the other members of the chain to which it belongs recede into darkness; and this gives rise to phenomena that have a long-recognized resemblance to those of madness.

What exists in the individual thing only imperfectly and weakened by modifications, the way of considering things proper to genius heightens into the Idea of that thing, into perfection. He therefore sees extremes everywhere, and for that very reason his actions run to extremes. He does not know how to hit the right measure; sobriety is lacking to him, and the result is what has been described.

He cognizes the Ideas perfectly, but not individuals. Hence, as has been observed, a poet can know *the* human being deeply and thoroughly, while knowing *human beings* very badly; he is easily deceived and is a plaything in the hands of the cunning.^[3]

Notes

Notes

1. Great spirit is akin to madness, and only a thin wall separates the two. ↩
2. On this, see the corresponding chapter of the second volume. ↩
3. On this, see chapter 32 of the second volume. ↩

§. 37.

Although, on the account given above, genius consists in the ability to know the Ideas of things independently of the principle of sufficient reason, rather than knowing individual things, which exist only in relations, and to stand before those Ideas as their correlate, no longer an individual but the pure subject of cognition, this ability must also dwell in everyone to some degree. Otherwise people would be no more capable of enjoying works of art than of producing them. They would have no receptivity at all to the beautiful or the sublime; indeed, these words could mean nothing to them.

We must therefore assume that everyone, unless there are people wholly incapable of aesthetic pleasure, has some power to recognize the Ideas in things and, in doing so, to set aside their own personality for a moment. Genius differs only in possessing this mode of cognition to a much higher degree and for longer stretches. That allows the person of genius to retain the presence of mind needed to reproduce what has been cognized in a deliberate work: the work of art. Through it, the artist communicates the Idea apprehended to others.

The Idea remains one and the same in this process. Hence aesthetic pleasure is essentially the same whether it comes through a work of art or directly through contemplation of nature and life. A work of art merely makes the cognition in which that pleasure consists easier. The Idea meets us more readily in art than in nature or actuality because the artist, having cognized the Idea rather than the actual thing, reproduces the Idea alone in the work, separating it from actuality and leaving out every distracting accident.

The artist lets us see the world through the artist's eyes. To have such eyes, to recognize what is essential in things and lies outside all relations, is the inborn gift of genius. To be able to lend us those eyes, however, is the acquired skill, the technique of art.

I have now outlined the inner nature of aesthetic cognition in its most general terms. The more detailed philosophical treatment of the beautiful and the sublime that follows will therefore discuss each in both nature and art, without separating the two. We will first consider what happens in a person moved by beauty or sublimity. Whether the experience comes directly from nature and life or through art makes an external difference, but no essential one.

§. 38.

We have found *two inseparable elements* in aesthetic contemplation: cognition of the object, not as an individual thing but as a Platonic *Idea*, the enduring form of this whole kind of thing; and the knowing subject's consciousness of itself, not as an individual but as the *pure, will-less subject of cognition*. Both arise together when we leave behind the mode of cognition bound to the principle of sufficient reason, the only mode suited to the service of the will and to science. We shall see that the *pleasure* aroused by contemplating beauty likewise springs from these two elements, with one or the other contributing more according to the object contemplated.

All *willing* arises from need, and thus from lack and suffering. Fulfilment ends a particular suffering, but for every wish fulfilled at least ten remain unsatisfied. Desire lasts a long time, and its demands have no end; fulfilment is brief and scant. Even the satisfaction finally attained is only apparent. A fulfilled wish gives way at once to another: the first was an error we recognized, the second an error we have yet to recognize. Nothing attained as an object of willing can provide lasting satisfaction. It is like alms thrown to a beggar: they keep him alive today only to prolong his misery until tomorrow.

So long as our consciousness is filled with our will, so long as we are given over to the pressure of desires and their constant hope and fear, we are subjects of willing and can find neither lasting happiness nor rest. Whether we pursue or flee, fear misfortune or seek enjoyment, makes essentially no difference. Care for the ever-demanding will, whatever form it takes, continually fills and stirs consciousness; and without rest no true well-being is possible. The subject of willing thus lies forever on Ixion's turning wheel, draws water in the Danaids' sieve, and thirsts eternally like Tantalus.

But an outward occasion or an inward mood can suddenly lift us out of the endless current of willing. Cognition escapes its servitude to the will; attention is no longer directed toward motives for willing, but apprehends things apart from their relation to the will. We contemplate them without interest or subjectivity, purely objectively, absorbed in them as representations rather than as motives. Then the peace we always sought along the path of willing, and which always fled from us, arrives of itself, and we feel entirely at ease. This is the painless state Epicurus praised as the highest good and the condition of the

gods. For that moment we are freed from the wretched pressure of the will. We keep a Sabbath from the prison labour of willing, and Ixion's wheel stands still.

This is precisely the state described above as necessary for cognition of the Idea: pure contemplation, absorption in intuition, losing oneself in the object and forgetting all individuality. The mode of cognition that follows the principle of sufficient reason and apprehends only relations is suspended. At once and inseparably, the individual thing contemplated rises into the Idea of its kind, while the knowing individual becomes the pure subject of will-less cognition. As such, neither stands any longer in the current of time or in any other relation. It then makes no difference whether one watches the sunset from a prison or a palace.

An inward disposition, in which cognition has the upper hand over willing, can bring about this state in any surroundings. The admirable Dutch painters show this. They directed a purely objective gaze toward the most insignificant objects and left, in their *still lifes*, an enduring record of their objectivity and peace of mind. The aesthetic viewer cannot look at such a painting without being moved: it brings to mind the artist's calm, quiet, will-free state, which was needed to see such humble things so objectively, observe them so attentively, and reproduce that intuition with such care. As the picture invites the viewer into the same state, the feeling may be intensified by contrast with the viewer's own restless mood, clouded just then by intense willing. Landscape painters, especially Ruisdael, have often painted equally unremarkable landscapes in the same spirit, with an even more pleasing effect.

So much can be achieved by the inner power of an artistic mind alone. Yet a purely objective disposition is helped and encouraged from outside by receptive objects, above all by the abundance of beautiful nature, which invites, even presses, us to contemplate it. When it suddenly opens before our gaze, it almost always succeeds, if only for moments, in drawing us away from subjectivity and the will's servitude into the state of pure cognition. Thus a person tormented by passion, need, or care can be refreshed, cheered, and restored by one free look at nature. The storm of passion, the pressure of desire and fear, and all the torment of willing are at once wonderfully quieted.

For the moment we are detached from willing and given over to pure, will-less cognition, it is as if we had entered another world, in which everything that moves our will and shakes us so violently no longer exists. This freeing of cognition removes us from all of it as completely as sleep and dreams do.

Happiness and unhappiness disappear. We are no longer the individual, who has been forgotten, but only the pure subject of cognition: the *one* eye of the world that looks out through every knowing being, yet can become fully free of the will's service only in a human being. Every difference of individuality then vanishes so thoroughly that it makes no difference whether the seeing eye belongs to a powerful king or a tormented beggar. Neither good fortune nor misery crosses that boundary.

At every moment, then, a realm lies close at hand in which we escape all our misery. But who has the strength to remain there long? As soon as some relation between the objects contemplated and our will, our person, returns to consciousness, the spell ends. We fall back into cognition governed by the principle of sufficient reason. We no longer cognize the Idea, but the individual thing, a link in a chain to which we too belong, and we are given back to all our misery.

Most people almost always remain at this standpoint because they largely lack objectivity, that is, genius. For this reason they do not like to be alone with nature; they need company, or at least a book. Their cognition remains in the will's service, so they look in objects only for a possible relation to their will. When they find none, a steady, desolate refrain sounds within them like a bass note: "It is no use to me." Thus even the most beautiful surroundings, in solitude, take on a barren, dark, alien, hostile look for them.

Finally, the blessedness of will-less contemplation is also what casts such a strange spell over the past and over distant places, presenting them to us in such flattering light through a self-deception. When we recall days long past in a faraway place, imagination brings back only the objects, not the subject of willing that carried its incurable sufferings then just as it does now. Those sufferings are forgotten because so many others have since taken their place. Objective intuition acts in memory as it would in the present if we could bring ourselves to surrender to it free of willing. Thus, especially when some distress weighs on us more heavily than usual, a sudden memory of scenes from the past or far away passes before us like a lost paradise.

Imagination recalls only what is objective, not the individually subjective part. We imagine that these objects then stood before us as purely and as free of relation to the will as their images do now in memory. In fact, their relation to our willing caused us torment then, just as it does now. We can escape all suffering through present objects just as well as through distant ones, if we rise

to contemplate them purely objectively. We then produce the impression that these objects alone are present and we ourselves are not. Freed from our burdensome self, we become, as the pure subject of cognition, entirely one with those objects; their indifference to our distress becomes, in those moments, our own. Only the world as representation remains. The world as will has vanished.

I hope these reflections have made clear the nature and extent of the *subjective* condition of aesthetic pleasure: cognition's release from service to the will, forgetfulness of oneself as an individual, and the elevation of consciousness to the pure, will-less, timeless subject of cognition, independent of all relations. This subjective side of aesthetic contemplation always has its necessary correlate in an objective side: intuitive apprehension of the Platonic Idea. Before examining that side more closely and considering what art accomplishes in relation to it, we should remain a little longer with the subjective side. We can complete its treatment by explaining the impression of the *sublime*, which depends on this side alone and arises from a modification of it. Our account of aesthetic pleasure will then be completed by considering its objective side.

First, a few further remarks belong to what has gone before. Light is the most delightful of things. It has become the symbol of everything good and healing. In every religion it signifies eternal salvation, while darkness signifies damnation. Ormuzd dwells in purest light, Ahriman in eternal night. Dante's Paradise looks rather like the Vauxhall in London: all the blessed spirits appear as points of light arranged in regular figures. The absence of light saddens us directly; its return makes us happy. Colours give immediate, lively delight, most of all when they are transparent.

This is because light is the correlate and condition of the most perfect mode of intuitive cognition, the only one that does not immediately affect the will at all. Unlike the other senses, sight cannot, through its mere sensory effect on the organ, produce pleasure or displeasure *as sensation*. It has no immediate link to the will. Only the intuition arising in the understanding can have such a link, and this lies in the object's relation to the will. Hearing is already different: sounds can directly cause pain or give sensory pleasure, even apart from harmony or melody. Touch, being one with the feeling of the whole body, is still more subject to this direct influence on the will, although there is also touch without pain or pleasure. Smells are always pleasant or unpleasant, and tastes still more so. These last two senses are therefore most entangled with the will;

accordingly they have always been regarded as the least noble, and Kant called them the subjective senses.

Joy in light is thus joy in the objective possibility of the purest and most perfect intuitive cognition. Its source is that pure cognition, released from all willing, is deeply gratifying in itself and already makes a large contribution to aesthetic enjoyment. This account of light also explains the astonishing beauty we find in objects reflected in water. The lightest, swiftest, finest way in which bodies act on one another—the action of reflected rays of light, to which we owe by far the most perfect and purest of our perceptions—is here presented to our eyes clearly, completely, and on a large scale, in both cause and effect. Hence our aesthetic pleasure in it. For the most part, this pleasure has its root in the subjective ground of aesthetic enjoyment: delight in pure cognition and in its ways.^[1]

Notes

Notes

1. See chapter 33 of the second volume. ↩

§. 39.

The preceding reflections emphasized the subjective part of aesthetic pleasure: delight in sheer intuitive cognition as such, in contrast to willing. Closely connected with them is an explanation of the state of mind called the feeling of the *sublime*.

As noted above, we enter the state of pure contemplation most easily when objects meet us halfway: their varied yet definite and distinct forms readily become representatives of their Ideas. This is what beauty consists in on its objective side. Beautiful nature has this quality above all, and draws at least a passing aesthetic pleasure from even the least receptive person. The plant world in particular so strikingly invites aesthetic contemplation, almost pressing itself upon us, that one might be tempted to connect this with the fact that plants, unlike animal bodies, are not themselves immediate objects of cognition. They need another, intelligent individual to bring them from the world of blind willing into that of representation, and seem, as it were, to long for this entry, so as to gain indirectly what is denied them directly. I leave this daring thought, perhaps bordering on extravagance, entirely open; only a deeply intimate and devoted contemplation of nature could give rise to it or justify it.^[1]

So long as nature's invitation, the significance and clarity of its forms through which the Ideas individualized in them speak readily to us, draws us from cognition of mere relations in service of the will into aesthetic contemplation, thereby raising us to the will-free subject of cognition, it is simply the *beautiful* that affects us. The feeling aroused is that of beauty.

But suppose the very objects whose significant shapes invite us to contemplate them purely stand in a hostile relation to the human will as it appears in its objecthood, the human body. They oppose it, threatening it with a power that overwhelms all resistance, or reducing it to nothing before their immeasurable size. Suppose the viewer nevertheless does not direct attention to this forceful, hostile relation to the will. Though perceiving and acknowledging it, the viewer consciously turns away from it, forcibly detaches from the will and its relations, and, given over wholly to cognition, calmly contemplates these objects so fearful to the will as the pure, will-less subject of cognition. Apprehending only their Idea, outside every relation, the viewer willingly dwells on them and is thereby raised above the self, the person, its willing, and

all willing. Then the feeling of the *sublime* fills the viewer. This is a state of elevation, and for that reason the object giving rise to it is called *sublime*.

The difference between the feelings of beauty and sublimity is therefore this. In beauty, pure cognition gains the upper hand without struggle. The object's beauty—its capacity to make cognition of its Idea easier—removes the will and the cognition of relations that serves it from consciousness without resistance and almost unnoticed. Only the pure subject of cognition remains, without even a memory of the will. In the sublime, by contrast, pure cognition is reached only by a conscious and forceful detachment from the object's recognized adverse relations to the will: a free, deliberate rising above the will and the cognition related to it.

This elevation must be consciously achieved and maintained. It therefore carries a continuing awareness of the will, though not of any particular individual willing, such as fear or desire. It is an awareness of human willing in general, expressed universally through its objecthood, the human body. If an actual individual act of will entered consciousness because the object posed a real, personal threat or danger, that aroused will would immediately take command. Calm contemplation would become impossible, and the impression of the sublime would yield to fear, in which the individual's effort to save itself displaces every other thought.

Examples will make this account of the aesthetically sublime clearer and show the different degrees of the feeling. In its essential features—the pure, will-free cognition and the accompanying cognition of Ideas outside every relation determined by the principle of sufficient reason—the sublime is one with beauty. It differs only by the added elevation above the contemplated object's recognized hostility to the will in general. The sublime accordingly has several degrees and passes by gradations out of beauty, depending on whether this added element is strong and urgent and close at hand, or weak, distant, and merely suggested. I shall begin with the transitions and weaker degrees, although readers with little aesthetic receptivity or a less lively imagination may understand only the later, more pronounced examples. They can attend to those and leave the first, faint examples aside.

The human being is at once an impetuous, dark urge to will, whose focal point is marked by the pole of the genitals, and an eternal, free, serene subject of pure cognition, marked by the pole of the brain. Correspondingly, the sun is both the source of *light*, the condition of the most perfect mode of cognition and

so of the most delightful thing, and the source of *warmth*, the primary condition of life, that is, of every appearance of the will at its higher grades. What warmth is to the will, light is to cognition. Light is therefore the greatest jewel in beauty's crown and has a decisive influence on the cognition of every beautiful object. Its presence is indispensable, and a favourable angle heightens even the greatest beauty. Above all, light enhances architectural beauty; by its favour it can turn even the most insignificant thing into a beautiful object.

Now imagine a hard winter, when all nature is frozen, and the rays of a low sun reflected from masses of stone. They illuminate without warming: they favour only the purest mode of cognition, not the will. Contemplating their beautiful effect on the stones puts us, as beauty always does, into the state of pure cognition. Yet the faint reminder that these very rays lack life-giving warmth already calls for a certain elevation above the will's interests. It gently asks us to remain in pure cognition and turn away from all willing. Thus the feeling begins to pass from the beautiful to the sublime. This is the faintest breath of sublimity upon beauty, which itself appears here only in a slight degree. The next example is almost as faint.

Imagine a very solitary region under a wholly cloudless sky, with an unbounded horizon: trees and plants in still air, no animals, no people, no moving water, the deepest silence. Such surroundings seem to call us to seriousness and contemplation, to release ourselves from all willing and its poverty. This alone gives that lonely, deeply quiet setting a tinge of the sublime. It offers the will, which always needs to strive and attain, no favourable or unfavourable object. Nothing remains but pure contemplation. Anyone incapable of it is surrendered to the emptiness of an idle will and the torment of boredom, in a humiliation that reveals the person's limitations. Such surroundings therefore measure our own intellectual worth; in general, our ability to endure or love solitude is a good measure of it. This is a low degree of the sublime: the repose and self-sufficiency of pure cognition is set against a reminder of the dependence and poverty of the will, which needs constant activity. This is the kind of sublimity praised in the view over the endless prairies of inland North America.

Now remove even the plants from such a region, leaving only bare rock. The total absence of the organic things needed for our subsistence directly alarms the will. Desolation takes on a fearful character, and our mood becomes more tragic. The rise to pure cognition demands a more decisive detachment from the

will's interests. If we remain in that state, the feeling of the sublime comes forward clearly.

It can arise more strongly still in a scene of nature in tumult: threatening black storm clouds casting shifting light and shadow; immense bare rocks overhanging one another and shutting off the view; roaring, foaming waters; utter desolation; wind wailing through the ravines. Our dependence and our struggle with hostile nature, our will thwarted by it, stand vividly before us. Yet so long as personal distress does not gain the upper hand and we remain in aesthetic contemplation, the pure subject of cognition looks out through that struggle and that image of a thwarted will. Calm and unshaken, untouched by the threat (unconcerned, or unaffected), it apprehends the Ideas in the very objects so frightening to the will. The feeling of the sublime lies precisely in this contrast.

The impression becomes still stronger when we see the struggle of unleashed natural forces on a vast scale: a plunging torrent whose roar makes it impossible to hear our own voice, or a wide sea in a storm. Waves as high as houses rise and fall, crash against steep cliffs, and fling spray into the air. The wind howls, the sea roars, lightning flashes from black clouds, and thunderclaps drown out wind and sea. In the unshaken spectator, the duality of consciousness now becomes clearest. One feels oneself to be an individual, a frail appearance of the will that the slightest blow from those forces could shatter: helpless before mighty nature, dependent and exposed to chance, a vanishing nothing beside immeasurable powers. At the same time, one feels oneself to be the eternal, tranquil subject of cognition. As the condition of the object, this subject is the bearer of that entire world; nature's terrible struggle is only its representation, while it remains in calm apprehension of the Ideas, free and remote from all willing and all distress. This is the full impression of the sublime, prompted here by the sight of a power incomparably greater than the individual and threatening its destruction.

The sublime can arise in a quite different way when we consider mere magnitude in space or time, whose immensity reduces the individual to nothing. Retaining Kant's terms and his sound division, we may call the first kind the *dynamically sublime* and the second the *mathematically sublime*. Our explanation of the inner nature of the impression, however, differs entirely from his: we assign no part in it to moral reflections or to entities invented by scholastic philosophy.

When we lose ourselves in contemplating the world's infinite extent in space and time, thinking of the millennia past and those to come, or when the night sky brings countless worlds before our eyes and their immensity presses upon consciousness, we feel reduced to nothing. As an individual, a living body, a transient appearance of the will, we seem to vanish like a drop in the ocean and dissolve into nothing. Yet against this spectre of our own insignificance, this deceptive impossibility, there arises the immediate consciousness that all these worlds exist only in our representation: they are modifications of the eternal subject of pure cognition, which we find ourselves to be when we forget individuality. That subject is the necessary bearer and condition of all worlds and all times. The vast world that troubled us now rests within us; our dependence on it is cancelled by its dependence on us.

This does not immediately enter reflective thought. Rather, it appears as a felt awareness that in some sense—one that philosophy alone can make clear—we are one with the world, and so its immensity lifts us instead of crushing us. It is a felt awareness of what the Upanishads of the Vedas express in many forms, especially in a saying cited earlier: *Hae omnes creaturae in totum ego sum, et praeter me aliud ens non est* (All these creatures, taken together, are I, and apart from me there is no other being; *Oupnek'hat*, vol. 1, p. 122). This is an elevation above our own individuality: the feeling of the sublime.

We can receive an immediate impression of the mathematically sublime from a space small beside the universe, provided we can perceive its full dimensions directly and its scale makes our own body seem almost infinitely small. Empty space cannot do this for perception, and thus neither can an open space. The space must be bounded in every dimension so that we can perceive it as a whole: a very high, vast vault such as that of St Peter's in Rome or St Paul's in London. Here the feeling of the sublime arises from our awareness of how nearly our body vanishes before a magnitude that, on the other hand, exists only in our representation, whose bearer we are as knowing subject. Here, as everywhere, the feeling comes from the contrast between our insignificance and dependence as individuals, appearances of the will, and our consciousness of ourselves as pure subjects of cognition. Even the vault of the starry sky, when contemplated without reflection, affects us as a stone vault does: by its apparent size, not its true size. Some objects stir the sublime because their spatial magnitude and great age, their duration in time, make us feel reduced to nothing

while we still revel in looking at them. Such are very high mountains, Egyptian pyramids, and colossal ruins of antiquity.

Our account of the sublime can also be carried into ethics, to what is called a sublime character. This too arises when objects fully capable of stirring the will fail to do so because cognition retains the upper hand. A person of this character views other people purely objectively, not according to how they might relate to his own will. He notices their faults, even their hatred and injustice toward him, without himself being roused to hatred. He sees their happiness without envy, recognizes their good qualities without wanting a closer association, and perceives the beauty of women without desiring them. His own happiness and misfortune affect him little. He is, rather, like Horatio as Hamlet describes him:

for thou hast been
As one, in suffering all, that suffers nothing;
A man, that fortune's buffets and rewards
Hast ta'en with equal thanks, etc, (A. 3. sc. 2.)^[2]

Translation: For you have been like one who suffers nothing though enduring everything, a man who has accepted fortune's blows and rewards with equal thanks.

For in the course of his own life and its accidents, he sees less of his individual fate than of the fate of humanity as a whole. He responds, therefore, more by knowing than by suffering.

Notes

Notes

1. All the more pleased and surprised am I now, forty years after setting down this thought so timidly and hesitantly, to discover that Saint Augustine had already expressed it: *Arbusta formas suas varias, quibus mundi hujus visibilis structura formosa est, sentiendas sensibus praebent; ut, pro eo quod *nosse* non possunt, quasi *innotescere* velle videantur.* (De civ. Dei, XI, 27.) Translation: Shrubs offer their varied forms, which beautify the structure of this visible world, for the senses to perceive; since they cannot know, they seem almost to wish to become known. ↩

2. The source's German note translates the passage: "For you have always been as one who, though everything befell him, suffered nothing; you accepted fortune's blows and gifts with equal thanks, and so on." Editorial note: the extraction's "thon" and "beffets" have been

corrected to “thou” and “buffets,” checked against the Folger Shakespeare text of *Hamlet*, Act 3, scene 2. Schopenhauer’s excerpt and its German gloss are retained. ↩

§. 40.

Because opposites illuminate one another, this is the place to note that the true opposite of the sublime is something one would hardly recognize as such at first: the *alluring*. By this I mean what excites the will by directly holding out to it satisfaction and fulfilment. The feeling of the sublime arose when an object plainly hostile to the will became the object of pure contemplation. That contemplation could be sustained only by continually turning away from the will and rising above its interests; this is precisely what makes the state sublime. The alluring, by contrast, draws the viewer down from the pure contemplation required to apprehend beauty. It necessarily excites the will with objects that appeal to it directly. The viewer is then no longer a pure subject of cognition but a needy, dependent subject of willing.

People commonly call every cheerful kind of beauty “alluring.” That uses the word too broadly for want of a proper distinction, and I must set that usage aside—indeed, reject it. In the sense I have specified, I find only two kinds of the alluring in art, and both are unworthy of it. One is rather base and occurs in Dutch still-life painting when it strays into depicting food so deceptively that it necessarily whets the appetite. Such an excitation of the will ends all aesthetic contemplation of the object. Painted fruit is still permissible: it appears as a further development of the flower, a beautiful natural product in form and colour, without forcing us to think of eating it. Unfortunately, though, we often find prepared and served dishes rendered with deceptive naturalness—oysters, herrings, lobsters, bread and butter, beer, wine, and so on. These are altogether objectionable.

In history painting and sculpture, the alluring consists in nude figures whose pose, partial clothing, and entire treatment are designed to arouse lust in the viewer. Pure aesthetic contemplation is thereby immediately cancelled, in direct opposition to the purpose of art. This fault corresponds exactly to the one just criticized in the Dutch painters. Ancient works, despite all the beauty and complete nudity of their figures, are almost always free of it. The artist created them in a purely objective spirit filled with ideal beauty, rather than in a spirit of subjective, base desire. The alluring is therefore to be avoided everywhere in art.

There is also a *negatively alluring* kind, even more objectionable than the positive kind just discussed: the disgusting. Like the alluring in the proper

sense, it arouses the viewer's will and thereby destroys pure aesthetic contemplation. What it arouses, however, is a vehement refusal, a recoil. It stirs the will by presenting objects of abhorrence. This is why it has long been recognized as wholly inadmissible in art, whereas even ugliness, so long as it is not disgusting, can be tolerated in its proper place, as we shall see below.

§. 41.

The course of our discussion required us to insert the account of the sublime at a point where the account of the beautiful was only half finished: we had dealt only with its subjective side. For the sublime differs from the beautiful only through a special modification of that side. Every aesthetic contemplation presupposes and requires a state of pure, will-less cognition. That state may arise without resistance, almost of itself, when the object invites and draws us to it and the will simply disappears from consciousness. Or it may have to be won through a free and conscious elevation above the will, when the contemplated object itself stands in an adverse, hostile relation to the will—dwelling on that relation would abolish contemplation. This is the difference between the beautiful and the sublime.

In the object, the two are not essentially different. In either case, the object of aesthetic contemplation is not the individual thing but the Idea striving to reveal itself in it: the adequate objecthood of the will at a particular grade. The Idea's necessary correlate, equally withdrawn from the principle of sufficient reason, is the pure subject of cognition. The correlate of the individual thing, by contrast, is the knowing individual; both belong within the domain of that principle.

When we call an object beautiful, we say that it is an object of our aesthetic contemplation. This means two things. First, the sight of it makes us *objective*: while contemplating it we are conscious of ourselves no longer as individuals but as the pure, will-less subject of cognition. Second, we recognize in the object an Idea rather than an individual thing. This can happen only insofar as our contemplation is not governed by the principle of sufficient reason. We do not pursue the object's relations to anything outside it—relations that ultimately always connect with our willing—but rest with the object itself.

The Idea and the pure subject of cognition always enter consciousness together as necessary correlates. When they do, all difference of time immediately disappears, for both are wholly foreign to the principle of sufficient reason in all its forms and lie outside the relations it establishes. They are like the rainbow and the sun, which take no part in the ceaseless movement and succession of falling raindrops. If, for example, I look at a tree aesthetically, with an artist's eyes, and thus cognize its Idea rather than the tree itself, it at once becomes immaterial whether this is that tree or its ancestor that

flourished a thousand years ago. It is equally immaterial whether the observer is this individual or any other who lives at any time or place. Along with the principle of sufficient reason, the individual thing and the knowing individual fall away. Nothing remains but the Idea and the pure subject of cognition, which together constitute the adequate objecthood of the will at this grade.

The Idea is removed not only from time but also from space. Strictly speaking, the Idea is not the spatial shape before me. It is that shape's expression, its pure significance, its innermost essence, which reveals itself to me and addresses me. This may be wholly the same even when the shape's spatial proportions differ greatly.

Now, on the one hand, every existing thing can be contemplated purely objectively and apart from all relations. On the other, in every thing the will appears at some grade of its objecthood, so that the thing expresses an Idea. Hence *every thing is beautiful*. Even the most insignificant thing permits pure, objective, will-less contemplation and thereby proves beautiful, as the Dutch still lifes mentioned earlier (§ 38) attest.

One thing is more beautiful than another insofar as it makes such purely objective contemplation easier, meets it halfway, or virtually compels it; we then call it very beautiful. This can happen, first, because as an individual thing it expresses the Idea of its species purely through the very clear, definite, and thoroughly significant relation of its parts. By combining in itself the full range of expressions possible to its species, it reveals that species' Idea perfectly. It thus greatly eases the viewer's passage from the individual thing to the Idea and, with it, to the state of pure contemplation. Or an object's special beauty may lie in the fact that the Idea speaking from it is itself a high grade of the will's objecthood, and therefore profoundly significant and expressive. This is why the human being is beautiful above all else and why revealing human nature is art's highest aim. Human form and expression are the most significant objects of the visual arts, just as human action is the most significant object of poetry.

Nevertheless, every thing has its own particular beauty. This is true not only of every organic being that presents itself as a unified individual, but also of everything inorganic and formless, indeed of every artifact. All these reveal the Ideas through which the will objectivates itself at its lowest grades. They sound, as it were, nature's deepest, fading bass notes. Gravity, rigidity, fluidity, light, and so forth are the Ideas expressed in rocks, buildings, and bodies of water. Fine gardening and architecture can do no more than help these things display

their properties distinctly, variously, and fully. They give the things an opportunity to express themselves purely and thereby invite and facilitate aesthetic contemplation.

Poor buildings and places neglected by nature or spoiled by art do little or none of this. Yet even from them those universal, fundamental Ideas of nature cannot wholly disappear. They speak to a viewer who seeks them out, and even poor buildings and the like remain capable of aesthetic contemplation. The Ideas of their material's most general properties are still discernible. What makes contemplation difficult is the form artificially imposed on them, which offers no help and is instead an obstacle.

Artifacts, then, also serve to express Ideas. What speaks through them, however, is not an Idea of the artifact but an Idea of the material to which the artificial form was given. The language of the Scholastics states this neatly in two terms: the Idea expressed in an artifact is that of its *forma substantialis* (substantial form), not of its *forma accidentalis* (accidental form). The latter points to no Idea, but only to the human concept from which it arose. By “artifact” here I expressly do not mean a work of visual art. The Scholastics did in fact mean by *forma substantialis* what I call the grade of the will's objectivation in a thing. We shall return shortly, in considering fine architecture, to the expression of the Idea of the material.

On our view, therefore, we cannot agree with Plato when he claims (*Republic*, X, pp. 284–285, and *Parmenides*, p. 79, Bipont edition) that a table and chair express the Ideas of table and chair. We say instead that they express the Ideas already present in their material as such. According to Aristotle (*Metaphysics*, XI, chapter 3), however, Plato himself posited Ideas only of natural beings: ὁ Πλάτων ἔφη, ὅτι εἶδη ἐστὶν ὅποσα φύσει (Plato dixit, quod *ideae eorum sunt, quae natura sunt*—Plato said that there are Ideas of things that exist by nature). Chapter 5 likewise says that, according to the Platonists, there are no Ideas of a house or a ring. At any rate, Plato's immediate pupils denied that there were Ideas of artifacts, as Alcinous reports (*Introduction to Platonic Philosophy*, chapter 9):

Ὅρίζονται δὲ τὴν ιδέαν παράδειγμα τῶν κατὰ φύσιν αἰώνιον. Οὐτε γὰρ τοῖς πλείστοις τῶν ἀπὸ Πλάτωνος ἀρέσκει τῶν τεχνικῶν εἶναι ιδέας, οἷον ἀσπίδος ἢ λύρας, οὔτε μὴν τῶν παρὰ φύσιν, οἷον πυρετοῦ καὶ χολέρας, οὔτε τῶν κατὰ μέρος, οἷον Σωκράτους καὶ Πλάτωνος, ἀλλ’ οὐδὲ τῶν εὐτελῶν τινος, οἷον ῥύπου καὶ κάρφους, οὔτε τῶν πρὸς τι, οἷον μείζονος

καὶ ὑπερέχοντος· εἶναι γὰρ τὰς ἰδέας νοήσεις θεοῦ αἰωνίους τε καὶ αὐτοτελεῖς.

Definiunt autem ideam exemplar aeternum eorum, quae secundum naturam existunt. Nam plurimis ex iis, qui Platonem secuti sunt, minime placuit, arte factorum ideas esse, ut clypei atque lyrae; neque rursus eorum, quae praeter naturam, ut febris et cholerae; neque particularium, ceu Socratis et Platonis; neque etiam rerum vilium, veluti sordium et festucae; neque relationum, ut majoris et excedentis: esse namque ideas intellectiones dei aeternas, ac seipsis perfectas.

Translation: They define an Idea as the eternal model of things that exist according to nature. Most followers of Plato did not accept Ideas of things made by art, such as a shield or lyre; nor of things contrary to nature, such as fever and cholera; nor of individuals, such as Socrates and Plato; nor even of lowly things, such as dirt and a straw; nor of relations, such as being greater or exceeding. For Ideas are God's eternal thoughts, complete in themselves.

This occasion allows me to mention another point on which our doctrine of Ideas differs greatly from Plato's. He teaches (*Republic*, X, p. 288) that the object fine art seeks to represent, the model for painting and poetry, is not the Idea but the individual thing. Everything we have argued so far asserts the very opposite. Plato's opinion is all the less likely to unsettle us here because it gave rise to one of that great thinker's most serious and generally acknowledged errors: his low opinion and rejection of art, especially poetry. He attaches his mistaken judgment about it directly to the passage just cited.

§. 42.

I return to our account of the aesthetic impression. Cognition of the beautiful always involves, together and inseparably, the pure knowing subject and the cognized Idea as its object. Yet the source of aesthetic enjoyment lies sometimes more in apprehending the Idea, and sometimes more in the bliss and peace of mind belonging to pure cognition, freed from all willing and thus from all individuality and the pain arising from it. Which element predominates depends on whether the Idea intuitively apprehended is a higher or lower grade of the will's objecthood.

Thus, when we contemplate the beauty of inorganic nature, plants, or works of fine architecture aesthetically—whether in reality or through art—the enjoyment of pure, will-less cognition will predominate. The Ideas apprehended here are only low grades of the will's objecthood, and their appearances do not have deep significance or a richly expressive content.

When animals and human beings are the objects of aesthetic contemplation or depiction, on the other hand, enjoyment lies more in the objective apprehension of their Ideas. These are the clearest revelations of the will. They display the greatest variety of forms, the richest and most deeply significant appearances, and reveal the will's nature to us most fully: in its vehemence, its terribleness, its satisfaction, and its being broken—the last in tragic representations. They reveal, finally, even its turning against itself or cancelling itself, which is especially the theme of Christian painting. History painting and drama, more generally, take as their object the Idea of the will illuminated by full cognition.

We shall now examine the arts one by one. This will bring completeness and clarity to the theory of the beautiful set out above.

§. 43.

Matter as such cannot present an Idea. As we found in Book One, matter is causality through and through: its being consists entirely in acting. Causality, however, is a form of the principle of sufficient reason, whereas cognition of an Idea essentially excludes that principle's content. In Book Two we also found that matter is the common substrate of all the individual appearances of Ideas, and thus the connecting link between an Idea and its appearance, or the individual thing. For either reason, matter by itself cannot present an Idea. This is confirmed *a posteriori* (from experience): we can have no intuitive representation of matter as such, only an abstract concept of it. What appears in intuition is only the forms and qualities borne by matter, and in all these Ideas reveal themselves. Correspondingly, causality—the whole essence of matter—cannot itself be presented in intuition, but only a particular causal connection can.

Conversely, every *appearance* of an Idea must present itself as a quality of matter, since as an appearance it has entered the form of the principle of sufficient reason, or the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation). In this sense, then, matter is, as I have said, the link between the Idea and the *principium individuationis*, which is the form of the individual's cognition, or the principle of sufficient reason. Plato was therefore quite right to posit matter as a third thing, distinct from both the Idea and its appearance, the individual thing—two categories that otherwise encompass all things in the world (*Timaeus*, p. 345). As an appearance of an Idea, the individual is always matter. Every quality of matter is likewise always the appearance of an Idea and thus capable of aesthetic contemplation, that is, cognition of the Idea presented in it. This holds even for the most universal qualities of matter, without which it never exists, and whose Ideas are the weakest objecthood of the will: gravity, cohesion, rigidity, fluidity, reaction to light, and so forth.

Consider *architecture* solely as a fine art, apart from its service to useful purposes. In that service it serves the will, not pure cognition, and is no longer art in our sense. We can then assign it no aim other than to bring certain Ideas, the lowest grades of the will's objecthood, distinctly before intuition: gravity, cohesion, rigidity, hardness—the general properties of stone, those first, simplest, dimmest visibilities of the will, nature's fundamental bass notes—and, beside them, light, which in many respects is their opposite.

Even at this low grade of the will's objecthood, we already see its nature reveal itself in conflict. The contest between gravity and rigidity is, in fact, the sole aesthetic material of fine architecture. Its task is to make that contest fully apparent in a variety of ways. Architecture does so by denying these indestructible forces the shortest path to their satisfaction and holding them on a circuitous course. The conflict is prolonged, and the inexhaustible striving of both forces becomes visible in many forms. Left to its original tendency, the entire mass of a building would be a mere lump, joined as firmly as possible to the earth. Gravity, in which the will appears here, presses it ceaselessly toward the earth, while rigidity, also an objecthood of the will, resists. Architecture prevents this tendency, this striving, from finding direct satisfaction and permits it only indirectly, by detours. A beam, for example, can press upon the earth only through a column; a vault must support itself and can satisfy its striving toward the earth's mass only through piers, and so on. Precisely through these enforced detours and restraints, the forces dwelling in the raw mass of stone unfold in the clearest and most varied ways. The purely aesthetic aim of architecture goes no further.

The beauty of a building therefore lies in the evident purposiveness of each part—not for an external, arbitrary human end, which belongs to useful building, but directly for the endurance of the whole. The position, size, and form of each part must bear so necessary a relation to that whole that, if possible, removing any one part would bring it down. Only when each part carries as much as it properly can, and each is supported exactly where and to the extent it needs support, does the play of opposition between rigidity and gravity become fully visible. These forces constitute the life and expressions of will in stone, and in this way the lowest grades of the will's objecthood reveal themselves distinctly.

The form of every part must likewise be determined by its purpose and relation to the whole, not by caprice. The column is the simplest form of support, determined solely by its purpose; the twisted column is tasteless. The square pier is in fact less simple than the round column, although it happens to be easier to make. The forms of frieze, beam, arch, and dome are likewise wholly determined and explained by their immediate purpose. Ornaments on capitals and the like belong to sculpture, not architecture. Architecture merely permits them as added decoration, and they could be omitted.

It follows that understanding and taking aesthetic pleasure in a work of architecture absolutely requires an immediate, intuitive acquaintance with its

material—with its weight, rigidity, and cohesion. Our pleasure in such a work would suddenly diminish if we learned that it was made of pumice stone: it would seem to us almost a sham building. Learning that it was made only of wood when we had assumed stone would have much the same effect. The relation between rigidity and gravity, and therefore the significance and necessity of all the parts, would change, for these natural forces are manifested far more weakly in a wooden building. Thus no work of fine architecture can really be made of wood, however readily wood takes every shape. Only our theory explains why. If we were told, further, that the building we enjoyed looking at consisted of quite different materials, very unequal in weight and consistency but indistinguishable by sight, the whole building would become as inaccessible to our enjoyment as a poem in a language we do not know.

All this shows that architecture works not merely mathematically but dynamically. What speaks to us through it is not bare form and symmetry, but the fundamental forces of nature, the first Ideas, the lowest grades of the will's objecthood. Regularity in a building and its parts results partly from the immediate fitness of each member for sustaining the whole. It also helps us survey and understand the whole; and regular figures contribute to beauty by revealing the lawfulness of space as such. Yet all this is of subordinate value and necessity. It is by no means the main thing: even symmetry is not indispensable, as ruins too can be beautiful.

Works of architecture have a very special relation to light. They gain twice as much beauty in full sunlight against a blue sky, and have an altogether different effect by moonlight. For this reason the effects of light and the directions of the sky are always given special attention when a fine architectural work is built. Much of this is because bright, sharp illumination first makes all the parts and their relations properly visible. But I also think that architecture is meant to reveal the nature of light, as well as gravity and rigidity, which are quite opposed to it. Large, opaque, sharply bounded masses of varied shape intercept, obstruct, and reflect light. Its nature and properties thereby unfold most purely and distinctly, to the viewer's great enjoyment. For light is the most delightful of things, being the condition and objective correlate of the most perfect mode of intuitive cognition.

The Ideas brought distinctly before intuition by architecture are the lowest grades of the will's objecthood. What it reveals to us is therefore of relatively little objective significance. Aesthetic enjoyment in looking at a beautiful, favourably lit building lies less in apprehending the Idea than in the subjective

correlate that accompanies this apprehension. Above all, the sight tears the viewer away from the individual's mode of cognition, which serves the will and follows the principle of sufficient reason, and raises the viewer to that of the pure subject of cognition, free of the will. Enjoyment lies chiefly in pure contemplation itself, freed from all the suffering of willing and individuality. In this respect the opposite of architecture, at the other extreme in the series of fine arts, is drama. Drama brings the most significant Ideas to cognition, so that the objective side of aesthetic enjoyment decidedly predominates in it.

Architecture differs from the visual arts and poetry in giving us the thing itself rather than a copy. It does not, as they do, repeat the cognized Idea, with the artist lending the viewer his eyes. Here the artist merely arranges the object for the viewer, making apprehension of the Idea easier by bringing the real, individual object to a clear and complete expression of its nature.

Unlike other works of fine art, architectural works are very seldom built for purely aesthetic purposes. Their aesthetic ends are usually subordinated to useful ends foreign to art itself. The architect's great achievement is to keep those aesthetic ends in view and realize them despite this subordination. By skilfully adapting them in various ways to each particular practical purpose, the architect judges rightly what kind of architectural beauty can be combined with a temple, a palace, an arsenal, and so forth. The more a harsh climate increases the demands of need and utility and makes them fixed and unavoidable, the less room beauty has in architecture. In the mild climates of India, Egypt, Greece, and Rome, where necessity made fewer and less definite demands, architecture could pursue its aesthetic ends most freely. Under northern skies those ends were greatly curtailed. Here, where box-like buildings, steep roofs, and towers were required, architecture could unfold its own beauty only within narrow limits. To compensate, it had to adorn itself all the more with decoration borrowed from sculpture, as can be seen in fine Gothic architecture.

The requirements of necessity and utility thus impose great restrictions on architecture. They also give it powerful support. Given the scale and expense of its works and the narrow range of its aesthetic effects, architecture could not survive as a fine art alone. It has a secure and honourable place among human occupations because it is also a useful and necessary craft. The lack of just such a place prevents another art from standing beside it as its sister, although aesthetically it is precisely its counterpart: the fine art of directing water. What architecture achieves for the Idea of gravity combined with rigidity, this other art achieves for the same Idea combined with fluidity: formlessness, ease of

displacement, and transparency. Foaming, roaring waterfalls plunging over rocks; cascades dissolving quietly into spray; fountains striving upward as tall columns of water; and clear, reflecting lakes reveal the Ideas of heavy, fluid matter, just as architectural works unfold the Ideas of rigid matter. Fine waterworks receive no support from the practical craft of water management, since its purposes usually cannot be combined with theirs. Such a combination occurs only exceptionally, as in the Cascata di Trevi (Trevi Fountain) in Rome.^[1]

Notes

Notes

1. See chapter 35 of the second volume. ↩

§. 44.

What the two arts just discussed achieve for the lowest grades of the will's objecthood is achieved, in a certain measure, for the higher grade of plant life by fine gardening. The scenic beauty of a place rests largely on the variety of natural objects assembled there, and then on their standing out clearly and distinctly while appearing in fitting connection and alternation. Fine gardening helps to meet these two conditions. But it is far less master of its material than architecture is of its own, so its effect is limited. Almost all the beauty it presents belongs to nature; gardening itself has contributed little. Conversely, it can do very little against nature's disfavour. Where nature works against it instead of helping it, its achievements are slight.

Insofar as the plant world, which offers itself everywhere for aesthetic enjoyment without art's intervention, becomes an object of art, it belongs chiefly to landscape painting. All the rest of nature that lacks cognition belongs there too. In still life, and in paintings of architecture alone—ruins, church interiors, and the like—the subjective side of aesthetic enjoyment predominates. Our pleasure lies chiefly not in directly apprehending the Ideas represented, but in the subjective correlate of that apprehension: pure, will-less cognition. As the painter lets us see these things through his eyes, we also share and feel anew the profound peace of mind and complete silence of the will needed to immerse cognition so thoroughly in lifeless objects and to apprehend them with such love, meaning here such a degree of objectivity.

The effect of landscape painting proper is generally similar. But because the Ideas represented, as higher grades of the will's objecthood, are already more significant and expressive, the objective side of aesthetic pleasure comes further forward and balances the subjective side. Pure cognition as such is no longer quite the main thing. The cognized Idea, the world as representation at a significant grade of the will's objectivation, acts on us with equal force.

Animal painting and sculpture reveal a still higher grade. Important ancient examples of the latter survive: horses in Venice and on the Monte Cavallo (Horse Hill), on the Elgin reliefs, and in Florence in bronze and marble; also in Florence the ancient boar and the howling wolves; then the lions at the Arsenal in Venice, and an entire room in the Vatican filled mostly with ancient animal sculptures, among others. In these representations the objective side of aesthetic pleasure decidedly outweighs the subjective side. The peace of the subject who

cognizes these Ideas and has quieted his own will is present, as it is in every aesthetic contemplation, but we do not feel its effect. We are occupied instead by the restlessness and vehemence of the will represented.

The willing that constitutes our own nature comes before our eyes in shapes whose appearance, unlike ours, is not governed and softened by reflection. It shows itself in stronger features and with a clarity bordering on the grotesque and monstrous, but also without pretence: innocent, open, and plainly exposed. This is precisely the basis of our interest in animals. The character of the species already emerged in depictions of plants, but there it appeared only in forms. Here it becomes much more significant and is expressed not only in shape but also in action, posture, and gesture—though still only as the character of the species, not the individual.

We can also gain this cognition of Ideas at higher grades directly, without a painter's mediation, by purely contemplative intuition of plants and observation of animals, especially animals in their free, natural, and contented state. Objective contemplation of their varied, wonderful forms and their ways of acting is an instructive lesson from the great book of nature, a deciphering of the true *Signatura rerum* (signature of things).^[1] In them we see the many grades and modes in which the will is manifested. One and the same will is present in every being, willing everywhere the same thing, which objectivates itself as life, as existence, in an endless variety of different shapes. These are all adaptations to different external conditions, like many variations on a single theme. If we wished to tell the observer their inner essence in reflective thought and in a single phrase, we could best use the Sanskrit formula found so often in the sacred books of the Hindus and called the *Mahavakya* (great saying): *Tat twam asi* (That living being is you).

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1. Jakob Böhme says in his book *De Signatura Rerum*, chapter 1, §§ 15–17: “There is nothing in nature that does not also reveal its inner form outwardly, for what is within is always working toward revelation. ... Every thing has its mouth for revelation. ... This is nature's language, in which each thing speaks from its own quality and always reveals and presents itself. ... For every thing reveals its mother, *which thus gives the essence and the will their form.*” ↩

§. 45.

The great task of history painting and sculpture, finally, is to present directly to intuition the Idea in which the will reaches the highest grade of its objectivation. Here the objective side of pleasure in beauty decidedly predominates; the subjective side recedes. At the next grade down, in animal painting, the characteristic and the beautiful are still wholly one: the most characteristic lion, wolf, horse, sheep, or bull is always the most beautiful one. The reason is that animals have only a species character, not an individual character. In depicting human beings, however, the character of the species separates from that of the individual. The former is now called beauty (in a wholly objective sense), while the latter retains the name character or expression. A new difficulty arises: presenting both perfectly in the same individual.

Human beauty is an objective expression for the most perfect objectivation of the will at the highest grade at which it can be known: the Idea of the human being in general, fully expressed in the form we behold. Yet however prominent the objective side of beauty is here, the subjective side always accompanies it. No object draws us into purely aesthetic intuition so quickly as a beautiful human face and figure. At their sight, an inexpressible pleasure immediately seizes us and lifts us above ourselves and everything that torments us. This is possible only because the will's clearest and purest knowability also brings us most easily and swiftly into the state of pure cognition. In that state our personality and our willing, with its constant pain, disappear for as long as purely aesthetic pleasure lasts. Thus Goethe says: "Nothing ill can touch one who beholds human beauty: one feels in harmony with oneself and the world."

When nature succeeds in producing a beautiful human form, we must explain this as follows. As the will objectivates itself in an individual at this highest grade, favourable circumstances and its own strength enable it to overcome completely the hindrances and resistance posed by appearances of the will at lower grades. Among these are the natural forces from which it must continually wrest the matter that belongs to them all. Moreover, the will's appearance at higher grades always has manifold form. Even a tree is a systematic aggregate of countless repeatedly sprouting fibres. This composition grows increasingly complex at higher grades, and the human body is a highly combined system of very different parts. Each has a life of its own, *vita proprio*

(its own life), subordinate to the whole. Beauty, the perfectly expressed character of the species, results only when all these parts are subordinated to the whole and coordinated with one another in just the right way, harmoniously working together to present the whole, with nothing excessive or stunted. These are rare conditions.

So much for nature. What, then, of art? It is said to imitate nature. But how could an artist recognize nature's successful work and pick it out among her failures without anticipating beauty *before experience*? Has nature, moreover, ever produced a human being perfectly beautiful in every part? Some have supposed that an artist must collect the beautiful parts dispersed among different people and assemble them into a beautiful whole. This is a confused and thoughtless opinion. Once again we must ask how the artist is to recognize that these forms are beautiful and those are not. We can also see how far imitation of nature brought the old German painters in beauty: just look at their nude figures.

Knowledge of beauty is altogether impossible *a posteriori* (from experience alone). It is always, at least in part, *a priori* (prior to experience), though of an entirely different kind from the forms of the principle of sufficient reason known to us *a priori*. Those forms concern the universal form of appearance as such, which grounds the very possibility of cognition: the universal, exceptionless *how* of appearing. Mathematics and pure natural science arise from such cognition. The other kind of *a priori* cognition, which makes the presentation of beauty possible, concerns the *content* rather than the form of appearances: the *what*, rather than the *how*, of appearing.

We all recognize human beauty when we see it. In the true artist this recognition is so clear that he shows beauty as he has never seen it, surpassing nature in his portrayal. This is possible only because *we ourselves* are the will whose adequate objectivation at its highest grade is to be judged and discovered here. For that reason alone we truly anticipate what nature—the very will constituting our own essence—is striving to present. In genuine genius this anticipation is accompanied by such a degree of reflective awareness that, on recognizing the *Idea* in an individual thing, the artist seems to *understand nature before she has finished speaking*. He then states clearly what she can only stammer. He stamps upon hard marble the beauty of form that eludes her in a thousand attempts, holds it up before her, and seems to cry, “This is what you meant to say!” The connoisseur echoes, “Yes, that was it!”

Only thus could the Greek genius discover the original type of the human figure and establish it as a canon for the school of sculpture. Only through such anticipation can any of us recognize beauty where nature has actually succeeded in an individual case. This anticipation is the *ideal*: the *Idea* insofar as it has been cognized, at least in part, *a priori* and, supplementing what nature gives *a posteriori*, becomes of practical use to art. The artist's capacity to anticipate beauty *a priori*, and the connoisseur's capacity to recognize it *a posteriori*, rest on the fact that artist and connoisseur are themselves nature's in-itself, the will objectivating itself. For, as Empedocles said, only like knows like: only nature can understand herself; only nature can fathom herself. But only spirit, too, can perceive spirit.^[1]

The mistaken^[2] view that the Greeks discovered their ideal of human beauty purely empirically, by selecting individual beautiful parts here and there—a knee in one place, an arm in another—has an exact parallel in poetry. This is the assumption that Shakespeare, for example, remembered from his own worldly experience the innumerable, varied, true, consistent, deeply worked out characters of his plays and then reproduced them. The impossibility and absurdity of this need no explanation. It is evident that genius produces works of visual art through an anticipatory intuition of beauty, and works of poetry through a like anticipation of what is characteristic. Both nevertheless need experience as a model through which what they know dimly *a priori* can be brought to full clarity, making deliberate presentation possible.

Human beauty was explained above as the most perfect objectivation of the will at the highest grade at which it can be known. It is expressed through form, which exists in space alone and has no necessary relation to time as movement does. To that extent we may say that the will's adequate objectivation through a merely spatial appearance is beauty in the objective sense. A plant is just such a merely spatial appearance of the will. No movement, and hence no relation to time, belongs to the expression of its nature (apart from its development). Its mere shape expresses and openly discloses its whole nature. An animal and a human being, by contrast, also need a series of actions to reveal fully the will appearing in them. Their appearance thereby acquires an immediate relation to time.

All this was discussed in the preceding book. It bears on the present discussion as follows. A merely spatial appearance of the will can objectivate it more or less perfectly at each particular grade; this constitutes beauty or ugliness. Likewise, the will's objectivation in time—action, and specifically

immediate action or movement—can correspond purely and perfectly to the will objectivating itself in it. It can express just the particular act of will, with nothing foreign mixed in, nothing superfluous, and nothing lacking. Or it can do the opposite. In the first case, the movement has *grace*; in the second, it lacks grace. Beauty is thus the fitting presentation of the will in general through its merely spatial appearance. *Grace* is its fitting presentation through appearance in time: the perfectly correct and appropriate expression of each act of will in the movement and posture that objectivate it. Since movement and posture already presuppose a body, Winckelmann's formulation is very apt: “Grace is the distinctive relation of the acting person to the action” (*Works*, vol. 1, p. 258).

It follows that plants can be called beautiful, but graceful only figuratively. Animals and human beings can be both beautiful and graceful. Grace consists in each movement and posture being carried out in the easiest, most appropriate, and most effortless way, so that it expresses the intention or act of will exactly. It contains nothing superfluous, which appears as purposeless, meaningless fussing or a contorted posture, and lacks nothing, which appears as wooden stiffness. Grace requires as its condition a proper balance among all the limbs and a regular, harmonious bodily structure; only this makes perfect ease and evident fitness possible in every posture and movement. Grace is therefore never found without some degree of bodily beauty. Together and perfected, the two are the clearest appearance of the will at the highest grade of its objectivation.

As mentioned above, humanity is distinguished by the separation of species character and individual character. In the preceding book I said that every human being thus presents, in a certain sense, an entirely distinctive Idea. The arts whose purpose is to present the Idea of humanity therefore have another task beside beauty, the character of the species: they must also present the character of the individual, which is particularly called *character*. But they must do so only insofar as this is not regarded as something accidental, belonging exclusively to that one individual. Rather, it is a side of the Idea of humanity that emerges with particular prominence in that individual, whose depiction is therefore suited to revealing it.

Character, though individual, must accordingly be apprehended and represented ideally: its significance for the Idea of humanity as a whole, to whose objectivation it contributes in its own way, must be brought out. Otherwise the depiction is a portrait, a repetition of the individual as such with

all its accidents. And even a portrait, as Winckelmann says, ought to be the ideal of the individual.

This *character*, ideally apprehended as the prominence of one particular side of the Idea of humanity, becomes visible partly in lasting physiognomy and bodily build, and partly in transient emotion and passion, in the mutual modification of knowing and willing. All this is expressed in facial expression and movement. The individual always belongs to humanity; conversely, humanity always reveals itself in an individual, even in that individual's distinctive ideal significance. Hence beauty must not be cancelled by character, nor character by beauty. If individual character abolishes the species character, the result is caricature; if the species character abolishes individuality, the result is insignificance.

Accordingly, a depiction chiefly seeking beauty, as sculpture does, will still modify that beauty—the species character—to some degree through individual character. It will always express the Idea of humanity in a particular individual way, bringing out a particular side of it. For the human individual as such has, in a sense, the dignity of an Idea of his own; and it is essential to the Idea of humanity that it present itself in individuals with distinctive significance. In ancient works we therefore find beauty, which the artists clearly apprehended, expressed not through a single figure but through many figures bearing different characters. They grasp it, as it were, from different sides: differently in Apollo, Bacchus, Hercules, and Antinous. Indeed, the characteristic may limit the beautiful and even emerge as ugliness, as in the drunken Silenus or the faun. If it goes so far as actually to abolish the species character and become unnatural, it turns into caricature.

Still less than beauty may grace be impaired by what is characteristic. Whatever posture or movement a character's expression demands, it must be performed in the way most appropriate, fitting, and easy for that person. This is observed not only by sculptors and painters but by every good actor. Otherwise caricature appears here too, in distortion and contortion.

In sculpture, beauty and grace remain paramount. The true character of the mind—shown in emotion and passion, in the interplay of cognition and will—can be presented only through expression of the face and gesture. It belongs above all to *painting*. Eyes and colour, which lie outside sculpture's domain, contribute much to beauty, but are still more essential to character.

Moreover, beauty unfolds more fully when viewed from several standpoints, whereas expression or character can be grasped perfectly from *one* standpoint.

Since beauty is plainly sculpture's principal aim, *Lessing* tried to explain the fact that *Laocoön does not cry out* by saying that a cry is incompatible with beauty. This issue became the subject, or at least the starting point, of a book of his own, and much has been written on it both before and after him. I may therefore be allowed to give my opinion of it here as a digression, although such a particular discussion does not strictly belong to our inquiry, which is directed throughout toward the general.

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1. The last sentence translates Helvétius's *il n'y a que l'esprit qui sente l'esprit* (only spirit can perceive spirit), which I had no need to note in the first edition. Since then, however, the stupefying influence of Hegel's sham wisdom has brought the age so low and made it so crude that someone might imagine an allusion here to the opposition between "spirit and nature." I am therefore obliged expressly to reject the attribution of such vulgar philosophical notions to me. ↩

2. Though it was expressed by Xenophon's Socrates (*Stobaei Floril.* Vol. 2. p. 384—*Stobaeus, Anthology*, vol. 2, p. 384). ↩

§. 46.

It is plain that Laocoön does not cry out in the famous sculptural group. The recurring astonishment at this must arise because all of us would cry out in his position. Nature demands it too: under the most violent physical pain and sudden, extreme bodily anguish, any reflection that might lead to silent endurance is driven entirely from consciousness. Nature finds relief by crying out, expressing pain and anguish, calling for a rescuer, and frightening the attacker at once.

Winckelmann, too, missed the expression of a cry. In trying to justify the artist, however, he effectively made Laocoön a Stoic. Laocoön supposedly finds it beneath his dignity to cry out *secundum naturam* (according to nature), and adds to his pain the useless constraint of suppressing its expression. Winckelmann thus sees in him “the tested spirit of a great man struggling with torments and trying to suppress and confine within himself the expression of what he feels. He does not burst into a loud cry, as in Virgil, but only anxious sighs escape him,” and so forth (*Works*, vol. 7, p. 98; more fully in vol. 6, p. 104 ff.).

Lessing criticized this view in his *Laocoön* and amended it in the way mentioned above: he replaced the psychological reason with a purely aesthetic one, namely that beauty, the principle of ancient art, does not permit the expression of a cry. He adds another argument, that an immobile artwork must not depict a wholly fleeting state incapable of duration. Yet a hundred excellent figures refute this: they are captured in fleeting movements, dancing, wrestling, seizing, and so on. Indeed, Goethe, in the essay on Laocoön that opens the *Propyläen* (p. 8), regards the choice of just such a fleeting moment as necessary.

In our own day *Hirt* (*Die Horen*, 1797, tenth issue), reducing everything to the utmost truth of expression, decided that Laocoön does not cry out because he is already about to die of suffocation and can no longer do so. Finally, *Fernow* (*Roman Studies*, vol. 1, p. 426 ff.) discussed and weighed all three views. He offered no new one, however, but tried to reconcile and combine them.

I cannot help wondering that such thoughtful and discerning men laboriously sought inadequate explanations far afield, resorting to psychological and even physiological arguments for something whose reason is close at hand and

immediately evident to an unprejudiced observer. I am especially surprised that Lessing came so near the right explanation without reaching the essential point.

Before any psychological or physiological inquiry into whether Laocoön would cry out in his situation—and I, for my part, would answer with an unqualified yes—we must decide something about the sculpture itself. The cry could not be represented in it for the simple reason that representing a cry lies entirely outside sculpture's domain. Marble could give us no crying Laocoön, only one with his mouth wide open, struggling vainly to cry out, with his voice stuck in his throat: *vox faucibus haesit* (his voice stuck in his throat). The essence of a cry, and hence its effect on a spectator, lies entirely in its sound, not in an open mouth. The opening of the mouth necessarily accompanies a cry, but it must first be motivated and justified by the sound it produces. Then, as characteristic of the action, it is permissible and even necessary, despite its cost to beauty.

In visual art, however, depicting the cry itself is impossible. It would be foolish to depict only the violent opening of the mouth, which disturbs every feature and the rest of the expression. We would see the means, which already demands considerable sacrifices, while its end—the cry itself and its effect on the mind—would be absent. Worse, the result would be the invariably ridiculous sight of an effort producing no effect. It would be like the prankster who plugged a sleeping night watchman's horn with wax, woke him by shouting “Fire!”, and delighted in watching his fruitless efforts to blow it.

Where the representation of a cry does lie within an art's domain, by contrast, it is entirely permissible, since it serves truth: the complete presentation of the Idea. Poetry does this by calling on the reader's imagination for intuitive presentation. Thus Virgil's Laocoön cries out like a bull that has broken loose after being struck by an axe. Homer likewise has Mars and Minerva cry out terribly (*Iliad*, XX, 48–53), without harm to their divine dignity or beauty. The same holds in acting. Laocoön onstage would certainly have to cry out. Sophocles has Philoctetes cry out, and on the ancient stage he surely did so in fact. I recall a very similar case: in London I saw the celebrated actor *Kemble* play Rolla, an American in *Pizarro*, a play translated from German. Rolla is half-savage but of very noble character. When wounded, he cried out loudly and violently. The effect was great and excellent, for the cry was deeply characteristic and added much to the truth of the portrayal.

A painted or sculpted silent screamer, on the other hand, would be even more ridiculous than painted music, already censured in Goethe's *Propyläen*. A cry does far more damage to the rest of the expression and to beauty than music does. Music usually occupies only the hands and arms and can be regarded as an action characterizing the person. In that respect it can quite properly be painted, so long as it requires no violent bodily movement or distortion of the mouth: witness St Cecilia at the organ, Raphael's violinist in the Galleria Sciarra in Rome, and others.

Because the limits of sculpture ruled out expressing Laocoön's pain by a cry, the artist had to bring every other expression of it into play. He did this to the highest perfection, as Winckelmann describes so masterfully (*Works*, vol. 6, p. 104 ff.). His excellent description therefore retains its full value and truth once we set aside the Stoic attitude he attributes to Laocoön.^[1]

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1. This digression is also supplemented in chapter 36 of the second volume. ↩

§. 47.

Since beauty and grace are sculpture's principal subjects, it favours the nude and tolerates clothing only insofar as it does not conceal the body's forms. It uses drapery not to veil the form but to present it indirectly. This method gives the understanding much to do: it reaches intuition of the cause, the body's shape, only through the effect immediately given to it, the folds of the fabric. Drapery in sculpture is thus, in a sense, what foreshortening is in painting. Both are indications, though not symbolic ones. When successful, they compel the understanding to intuit what is indicated as immediately as if it were actually before us.

Allow me to insert here, in passing, an analogy concerning the literary arts. A beautiful bodily form shows to best advantage with the lightest clothing, or none at all. A very beautiful person who also had taste and could follow it would therefore prefer to go almost naked, clothed only in the manner of the ancients. Similarly, a fine and thoughtful mind will always express itself in the most natural, direct, and simple way. It strives, wherever possible, to communicate its thoughts to others and thereby ease the solitude it must feel in a world like this one.

Conversely, poverty, confusion, and eccentricity of mind dress themselves in the most affected expressions and obscure turns of phrase. They hide meagre, trivial, sober, or commonplace thoughts in difficult, pompous sentences. They resemble someone who lacks the majesty of beauty and tries to make up for it with clothes, concealing the smallness or ugliness of his person under barbaric finery, glitter, feathers, ruffles, puffed sleeves, and a cloak. Such a person would be embarrassed to go naked. So would many an author if forced to translate a pompous, obscure book into its slight, clear content.

§. 48.

Alongside beauty and grace, *history painting* takes character as a principal subject. By character I mean the presentation of the will at the highest grade of its objectivation. Here the individual, bringing out a particular side of the Idea of humanity, has a distinctive significance. This becomes known not through bodily form alone, but through every kind of action and the changes in cognition and willing that occasion and accompany it, visible in facial expression and gesture.

To present the Idea of humanity in this breadth, painting must show its many-sided development in significant individuals. These individuals in turn can become visible in their significance only through a variety of scenes, events, and actions. History painting meets this endless task by putting scenes from every kind of life before our eyes, whether their significance is great or small. No individual and no action can be devoid of significance: through all of them the Idea of humanity unfolds ever further. Hence no event of human life must be excluded from painting.

It is therefore very unjust to the excellent painters of the Dutch school to value only their technical skill while looking down on them because they mostly depicted ordinary life, as if only events from world history or biblical history were significant. We should begin by remembering that an action's *inner* significance is quite different from its *outer* significance, and that the two often occur separately. Outer significance is the importance of an action in relation to its consequences in and for the actual world: it is significance according to the principle of sufficient reason. Inner significance is the depth of insight it opens into the Idea of humanity. It brings to light sides of that Idea that seldom emerge by letting distinct and decisively expressive individuals unfold their peculiarities under appropriately arranged circumstances. Only inner significance matters in art; outer significance matters in history. The two are entirely independent. They can occur together, but either can also occur alone.

An action of the highest historical importance can be quite commonplace in its inner significance. Conversely, a scene from everyday life can be of great inner significance if it shows human individuals, their acting, and their willing clearly and brightly, down to their most hidden folds. Inner significance can even be the same where outer significance is very different. It makes no difference to it whether ministers dispute over countries and peoples above a

map, or peasants argue over their rights in a tavern above playing cards and dice—just as chess is the same game with gold or wooden pieces. Moreover, the scenes and events that make up the lives of so many millions of people—their activities, distress, and joys—are already important enough to be subjects of art. Their rich variety must provide ample material for unfolding the many-sided Idea of humanity.

The transience of the moment fixed by art in such a picture (now called a *genre painting*) even stirs a quiet feeling of a special kind. Painting preserves in an enduring image the fleeting world, which constantly changes, through particular events that nevertheless stand for the whole. It seems thereby to bring time itself to a halt, raising the individual occurrence to the Idea of its kind.

Historical subjects of outward importance often have a disadvantage for painting: precisely what makes them important cannot be presented to intuition and must instead be supplied by thought. We must therefore distinguish a picture's *nominal* significance from its *real* significance. The former is its outer meaning, attached only as a concept. The latter is the side of the Idea of humanity revealed by the picture to intuition. Suppose, for example, the nominal subject is Moses found by the Egyptian princess, a moment of the greatest historical importance. Its real significance, what is actually given to intuition, is a foundling rescued from a floating cradle by a noblewoman—an event that might have happened often enough. Only the costume can identify the particular historical event for a learned viewer. Costume is relevant to nominal significance, however, and irrelevant to real significance, which knows only the human being as such, not arbitrary conventions.

Subjects taken from history have no advantage over subjects taken from mere possibility, which can be named generically rather than individually. What really matters in a historical subject is not the individual event as such but the universal element in it, the side of the Idea of humanity it expresses. This does not mean that specific historical subjects should be rejected. It means that the truly artistic view of them, for painter and viewer alike, is directed not to the individual particular that makes them historical but to the universal Idea expressed in them. Historical subjects should also be chosen only when the main thing can actually be depicted and need not merely be supplied by thought. Otherwise nominal and real significance move too far apart: what is merely thought about the picture becomes most important and detracts from what is seen. It is already a fault onstage when, as in French tragedy, the main event occurs behind the scenes. In a painting the fault is plainly greater still.

Historical subjects become decidedly harmful only when they confine the painter to a field chosen arbitrarily, for purposes other than art. This is especially so when the field is poor in painterly and significant subjects: for example, the history of a small, isolated, obstinate people in a corner of the world, governed by a hierarchy—that is, by delusion—and despised by the great contemporary peoples of East and West, as the Jews were. The migration of peoples lies between us and all ancient nations, just as an ancient change in the seabed lies between the present surface of the earth and the earlier one whose organisms appear to us only as fossils. It must therefore be regarded as a great misfortune that the people whose former culture was to serve chiefly as the foundation of our own were neither the Indians nor the Greeks nor even the Romans, but precisely the Jews. For the gifted Italian painters of the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries in particular, it was an ill fate that the narrow range to which they were arbitrarily confined in choosing subjects forced them to resort to wretched material of every kind. In its historical part the New Testament is almost still less favourable to painting than the Old, and the later history of martyrs and Church Fathers is an altogether unfortunate subject.

Yet we must sharply distinguish paintings whose subject is the history or mythology of Judaism and Christianity from those that reveal the true, ethical spirit of Christianity to intuition by depicting human beings filled with it. These, in fact, are painting's highest and most admirable achievements. Only its greatest masters, especially Raphael and Correggio—the latter particularly in his earlier paintings—have succeeded in them. Such paintings do not really belong among historical pictures. They usually present no event or action, but simply groups of saints, the Redeemer himself, often as a child, his mother, angels, and so on.

In their faces, especially their eyes, we see the expression and reflection of the most perfect cognition. It is directed not toward individual things but has wholly grasped the Ideas, and thus the whole nature of the world and life. Reacting upon the will in them, this cognition supplies it no *motives*, as ordinary cognition does. Instead, it has become a *quietive* of all willing. From it arise complete resignation—the innermost spirit of Christianity and of Indian wisdom alike—the abandonment of all willing, the turning back and cancellation of the will and with it the entire essence of this world: redemption. In their works these masters, worthy of eternal praise, gave intuitive expression to the highest wisdom. Here all art reaches its summit. It has followed the will in its adequate objecthood, the Ideas, through every grade: from the lowest,

where causes move it, then where stimuli move it, and finally where motives move it in so many ways and unfold its nature. It ends by presenting the will's free self-cancellation through the one great quietive that arises for it from the most perfect cognition of its own nature.^[1]

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1. Understanding this passage requires the whole of the following book. ↩

§. 49.

All our reflections on art so far rest on one truth: the object of art, which the artist aims to present and whose cognition must therefore precede the work as its seed and origin, is an *Idea* in Plato's sense, and nothing else. It is not the individual thing, the object of ordinary apprehension, nor is it the concept, the object of rational thought and science. Idea and concept do have something in common: each, as a unity, stands for a multitude of actual things. Yet their great difference should be sufficiently clear from what was said about the concept in Book One and the Idea in this book. I do not claim that Plato himself always grasped the distinction purely; many of his examples of Ideas and discussions of them apply only to concepts. We can leave that aside and follow our own path, glad whenever we tread the track of a great and noble mind, but pursuing our own goal rather than his footsteps.

The *concept* is abstract and discursive, wholly indeterminate within its sphere and determined only at its boundary. Anyone with reason can reach and grasp it. It can be communicated directly in words and exhausted by a definition. The *Idea*, by contrast—perhaps definable as the concept's adequate representative—is intuitive throughout. Although it stands for an infinite number of individual things, it is fully determinate. An individual *as such* never cognizes it. It is accessible only to someone who has risen above all willing and individuality to become the pure subject of cognition: to genius, then, and to someone raised into a state of genius by an enhancement of pure cognitive power, usually occasioned by a work of genius.

The Idea can therefore be communicated only conditionally, not unconditionally. An Idea apprehended and repeated in an artwork speaks to each person only in proportion to that person's intellectual worth. For this reason the finest works of every art, the noblest products of genius, remain closed books to the dull majority of people, inaccessible across a wide gulf, just as the company of princes is inaccessible to the common crowd. Even the shallowest people accept reputedly great works on authority, so as not to betray their own weakness. Yet in private they are always ready to condemn them once they think they can do so without exposing themselves. Then their long-suppressed hatred of everything great and beautiful—things that never spoke to them and thereby humiliated them—and of their creators breaks out with pleasure.

In general, one must have worth of one's own to acknowledge another's worth freely and willingly. This is the basis of the need for modesty in anyone with merit, and of the disproportionately loud praise given to this virtue. Alone among its sister virtues, modesty is always added to any praise of a distinguished person, in order to appease and still the anger of those without worth. What is modesty, after all, but feigned humility by which one begs those who have no merit to forgive one's qualities and achievements in a world teeming with base envy? Someone who claims no merit because he really has none is not modest, but merely honest.

The *Idea* is a unity broken into multiplicity by the temporal and spatial forms of our intuitive apprehension. The *concept*, conversely, is a unity restored from multiplicity by the abstraction of our reason. The concept can be called *unitas post rem* (unity after the thing), the *Idea unitas ante rem* (unity before the thing). We can express the difference through a comparison. The *concept* is like a dead container: what one has put into it lies there side by side, and one can take out through analytic judgments no more than one put in through synthetic reflection. The *Idea*, by contrast, develops representations in those who have grasped it that are new in relation to the concept bearing the same name. It is like a living, developing organism with the power of generation, producing what was not packed away inside it.

It follows that the concept, however useful in life and however serviceable, necessary, and fruitful for science, is forever barren in art. The apprehended *Idea* is the true and sole source of every genuine work of art. In its vigorous originality it can be drawn only from life itself, from nature and the world, and only by genuine genius or by someone inspired for the moment to a state of genius. Genuine works, bearing immortal life within them, arise only from such immediate conception. Precisely because the *Idea* is and remains intuitive, the artist is not conscious of the work's intention and goal *in abstracto* (in the abstract). What hovers before the artist is an *Idea*, not a concept. Hence artists cannot give an account of what they do; they work, as people say, from mere feeling, unconsciously, even instinctively.

Imitators and mannerists, by contrast—*imitatores, servum pecus* (imitators, a servile herd)—begin in art with the concept. They notice what pleases and has an effect in genuine works, make it explicit, grasp it abstractly as a concept, and then imitate it, openly or covertly, with calculated intent. Like parasitic plants, they draw their nourishment from others' works; like polyps, they take on the colour of their food. To extend the comparison, they are like machines that chop

and mix whatever is fed into them very finely but can never digest it. The foreign ingredients can always be recovered and separated from the mixture. Genius alone resembles the organic body that assimilates, transforms, and produces. Genius is indeed educated and formed by predecessors and their works, but is fertilized only by life and the world themselves, directly through intuitive impressions. Even the highest education therefore never harms originality.

All imitators and mannerists grasp the essence of exemplary works by others in concepts; concepts, however, can never give a work inner life. An age—that is, the dull multitude in each period—knows only concepts and clings to them. It therefore greets mannered works with quick, loud applause. Within a few years these same works become intolerable, because the spirit of the age—the prevailing concepts in which alone they were rooted—has changed. Only genuine works, drawn directly from nature and life, remain, like them, forever young and always vigorous. They belong to no age, but to humanity. For that very reason their own age, to which they disdained to adapt, received them coolly. They indirectly and silently exposed its passing errors and were therefore recognized late and reluctantly. Yet they cannot grow old. Even in the most distant future they speak freshly and anew.

Nor do they remain liable to being overlooked or misunderstood. They stand crowned and ratified by the approval of the few capable judges who appear singly and sparsely over the centuries,^[1] recording their judgments. The slowly growing sum of these judgments establishes the authority of the only tribunal meant when one appeals to posterity. These successive individuals alone constitute it. The mass of posterity will always remain as misguided and dull as the mass of one's contemporaries has always been. Read the complaints great minds have made about their contemporaries in every century: they always sound as if written today, because the human race remains the same. In every age and every art, manner takes the place of spirit, which is always the possession of a few individuals. Manner, though, is the old, cast-off garment of the most recent recognized manifestation of spirit. Accordingly, as a rule, the approval of posterity is won only at the cost of contemporary approval, and vice versa.^[2]

Notes

Notes

1. Apparent rari, nantes in gurgite vasto (A few appear, swimming in the vast whirlpool). ↩
2. See chapter 34 of the second volume. ↩

§. 50.

The purpose of all art is to communicate an apprehended Idea. Through its passage through the artist's mind, where it appears isolated and cleared of everything foreign to it, the Idea becomes comprehensible even to someone less receptive and without creative power. If beginning with a concept is objectionable in art, we cannot approve of an artwork deliberately and avowedly designed to express a concept. That is what happens in *allegory*.

An allegory is an artwork that means something other than what it depicts. Yet what is intuitive, and thus the Idea, speaks for itself directly and completely. It does not need to be indicated by the mediation of something else. What is indicated and represented by something entirely different because it cannot itself be brought before intuition is always a concept. An allegory therefore always signifies a concept. It guides the viewer's mind away from the intuitive representation depicted toward an entirely different representation, abstract and non-intuitive, lying wholly outside the artwork. The painting or statue is thus supposed to do what writing does much more perfectly.

Here the presentation of the Idea, which can be apprehended only intuitively and which we have declared the purpose of art, is not the aim. Nor does the intended aim require any great perfection in the artwork. It is enough to recognize what the thing is supposed to be. Once that is known, the aim is achieved and the mind is directed to an abstract concept of an entirely different kind. Allegories in visual art are therefore nothing but hieroglyphs. Any artistic value they may also possess as intuitive presentations belongs to them on another account, not as allegories. Correggio's *Night*, Annibale Carracci's *Genius of Fame*, and Poussin's *Hours* are beautiful paintings; that is quite separate from their being allegories. As allegories they do no more than an inscription, and perhaps less.

We are reminded here of the distinction made above between a picture's real and nominal significance. Its nominal significance is the allegory as such: for example, the Genius of Fame. Its real significance is what is actually depicted: here, a handsome winged youth surrounded by handsome boys. This expresses an Idea. Yet its real significance acts upon us only while we forget the nominal, allegorical one. Once we think of the latter, we leave intuition and occupy our minds with an abstract concept. The passage from Idea to concept is always a descent. Indeed, the nominal significance, the allegorical intention, often

impairs the real significance or intuitive truth. Consider the unnatural lighting in Correggio's *Night*: beautifully executed though it is, it is motivated only allegorically and is impossible in reality.

Thus any artistic value an allegorical painting has is separate from, and independent of, what it accomplishes as allegory. Such a work serves two ends at once: expressing a concept and expressing an Idea. Only the latter can be an artistic end. The former is foreign to art: a playful diversion in which a picture doubles as an inscription or hieroglyph, devised for people whom the true essence of art can never touch. It is like an artwork that is also a useful implement, such as a statue that doubles as a candelabrum or caryatid, or a bas-relief that also serves as Achilles' shield. True lovers of art will approve of neither arrangement.

An allegorical picture may, admittedly, have a powerful effect on the mind precisely as allegory. Under the same circumstances, however, an inscription would do likewise. Suppose a wish for fame has taken permanent, firm root in someone, who perhaps regards fame as a rightful possession withheld only until he can produce the documents establishing his claim. Standing before the Genius of Fame with its laurel wreaths might stir his whole mind and call his powers into action. But the same would happen if he suddenly saw the word "Fame" written large and clear on a wall. Or suppose someone has proclaimed a truth important either as a practical principle or as a scientific insight, yet no one believes him. An allegorical picture of Time lifting the veil to disclose naked Truth will affect him powerfully; so will the motto *Le temps découvre la vérité* (Time reveals the truth). What actually acts upon him is always the abstract thought, not what he sees.

Allegory in visual art is thus a mistaken effort in the service of an end wholly foreign to art. It becomes intolerable when it proceeds so far that forced, far-fetched interpretations lapse into absurdity. Examples include a tortoise meant to suggest a woman's seclusion; Nemesis looking down into the bosom of her dress to suggest that she sees even what is hidden; and Bellori's explanation that Annibale Carracci dressed Pleasure in yellow to suggest that its delights soon wither and turn yellow as straw does.

If there is no link at all between what is depicted and the concept indicated by it through subsumption under that concept or association of Ideas—if sign and signified are connected wholly by convention, through a positive and accidental stipulation—I call this kind of allegory a *symbol*. Thus the rose

symbolizes secrecy, the laurel fame, the palm victory, the shell pilgrimage, and the cross the Christian religion. Direct indications through mere colours belong here too, such as yellow for falsity and blue for fidelity. Such symbols may often be useful in life, but their value is foreign to art. They should be regarded simply as hieroglyphs or even as a kind of Chinese script. They belong in the same class as coats of arms, the branch indicating an inn, the key by which one recognizes a chamberlain, or the leather by which one recognizes a miner.

When particular historical or mythical persons, or personified concepts, are identifiable through symbols fixed once and for all, these should properly be called *emblems*: the animals of the Evangelists, Minerva's owl, Paris's apple, Hope's anchor, and so forth. By "emblems," however, people usually mean simple symbolic pictures explained by a motto and intended to illustrate a moral truth. Large collections of these exist by J. Camerarius, Alciatus, and others. They lead toward poetic allegory, to which I shall turn below. Greek sculpture addresses intuition and is therefore *aesthetic*; Indian sculpture addresses the concept and is thus merely *symbolic*.

This judgment of allegory follows closely from our account of art's inner nature, but is directly opposed to Winckelmann's view. Far from declaring allegory foreign to art's purpose and often obstructive, he defends it everywhere. He even places art's highest aim in the "presentation of general concepts and things that cannot be sensed" (*Works*, vol. 1, p. 55 ff.). Everyone may choose between these views. Winckelmann's ideas on this and similar questions concerning the metaphysics of beauty have, however, made one truth very clear to me: someone may have the greatest receptivity to beauty in art and the soundest judgment of it without being able to give an abstract, properly philosophical account of the nature of beauty and art. In the same way, someone may be very noble and virtuous, with a finely sensitive conscience that decides individual cases as accurately as a gold balance, yet be unable to fathom the ethical significance of actions philosophically and present it *in abstracto* (in the abstract).

Allegory has a quite different relation to *poetry* from its relation to visual art. Though objectionable in the latter, it is entirely permissible and useful in the former. In visual art it leads from what is given intuitively, the true subject of all art, to abstract thoughts. In poetry the relation is reversed: what words directly give us is the concept, and the immediate aim is always to lead from it to the intuitive, which the hearer's imagination must present. If visual art directs us from what is immediately given to something else, that other thing must be a

concept, for only the abstract cannot be given directly there. Yet a concept must never be an artwork's origin or its communication the artwork's end. In poetry, by contrast, the concept is the material immediately given. It may quite properly be left behind in order to evoke something wholly different in intuition, where the goal is reached.

In a poem's context a concept or abstract thought may be indispensable yet incapable of immediate intuitive presentation. It is then often brought before intuition by an example falling under it. This happens already in every figurative expression, and in every metaphor, simile, parable, and allegory, which differ only in the length and fullness of their presentation. Comparisons and allegories therefore have an excellent effect in literary art. How beautifully Cervantes says of sleep, to express its release from all mental and bodily suffering, that "it is a cloak covering the whole person." How beautifully Kleist gives allegorical expression to the thought that philosophers and researchers enlighten humanity in the line:

"Those whose nightly lamp lights up the whole globe."

How powerfully and vividly Homer characterizes ruin-bringing Ate: "Her feet are delicate, for she does not tread on the hard ground, but walks only upon the heads of human beings" (*Iliad*, XIX, 91). How strongly Menenius Agrippa's fable of the stomach and the limbs affected the Roman people who had seceded. How beautifully Plato's previously mentioned allegory of the cave, at the opening of Book Seven of the *Republic*, expresses a highly abstract philosophical doctrine. The story of Persephone, who falls under the power of the underworld because she tastes a pomegranate there, should likewise be regarded as a profound philosophical allegory. This becomes especially evident in Goethe's treatment of the story, beyond all praise, inserted as an episode in *The Triumph of Sensibility*.

I know three extended allegorical works. One is open and avowed: Baltasar Gracián's incomparable *Criticón*, a great, rich web of linked and highly ingenious allegories. They give moral truths a cheerful guise and thereby make them vividly intuitive, while the richness of his invention fills us with wonder. Two others are concealed allegories: *Don Quixote* and Gulliver in Lilliput. The former allegorizes the life of anyone who, unlike other people, seeks not merely personal welfare but an objective, ideal end that takes possession of thought and will; naturally such a person appears strange in this world. With Gulliver, we

need only take everything physical in a spiritual sense to see what the satirical rogue (satirical rascal), as Hamlet would call him, means by it.

In poetic allegory the concept is always what is given, and its aim is to make that concept intuitive through an image. A painting may therefore sometimes express or support it; even then, the painting is regarded not as a work of visual art but as a signifying hieroglyph. It claims no value as painting, only as poetry. Such is Lavater's fine allegorical vignette, which must strengthen the heart of every noble defender of truth. A hand holding a light is stung by a wasp while gnats burn themselves in the flame above it. Beneath is the motto:

“Though the gnat may scorch its wing,
And shatter its skull and all its little brain,
Light is still light;
And though the fiercest wasp may sting me,
I will not let it go.”

Here too belongs a gravestone bearing an extinguished, smoking candle and the inscription:

“When it goes out, it will be plain
Whether it was tallow or wax.”

Finally, there is an old German family tree on which the last descendant of a far-reaching line expressed his decision to end his life in complete abstinence and chastity and thus let his family die out. He had himself depicted at the root of the many-branched tree, cutting it off above him with scissors. This class generally includes the symbolic pictures mentioned earlier and usually called emblems; they might also be called short painted fables with their moral stated. Allegories of this kind always belong to poetry, not painting, and are justified on that account. Their visual execution remains secondary; all it need do is make the subject recognizable.

In poetry as in visual art, allegory passes over into symbol when the intuitive thing presented and the abstraction it signifies have only an arbitrary connection. Since every symbol rests at bottom on convention, it has, among other drawbacks, this one: its meaning is forgotten over time and it then falls wholly silent. Who could guess, without already knowing, why the fish symbolizes Christianity? Only a Champollion: it is a phonetic hieroglyph through and through. As a poetic allegory the *Revelation of John* now stands

roughly as the reliefs inscribed magnus Deus sol Mithra (the great god Sun Mithra) do: they still invite interpretation.^[1]

Notes

Notes

1. See chapter 36 of the second volume. ↩

§. 51.

Turning now from the visual arts to *poetry*, after our reflections on art in general, we can have no doubt that poetry too aims to reveal the Ideas, the grades of the will's objectivation, and to communicate them to the listener with the clarity and vividness with which the poet's mind apprehended them. Ideas are essentially intuitive. Words in poetry immediately communicate only abstract concepts, but the clear intention is to let the listener intuit the Ideas of life in the representatives of those concepts. This can happen only with the aid of the listener's own imagination.

To set imagination in motion for this purpose, the abstract concepts that form the immediate material of poetry, as of the driest prose, must be arranged so that their spheres intersect. None can then remain in its abstract generality; an intuitive representative takes its place before the imagination, and the poet's words go on modifying this representative according to the poet's intention. A chemist produces solid precipitates by combining perfectly clear and transparent liquids. In much the same way, the poet knows how to precipitate the concrete and individual, the intuitive representation, from the abstract, transparent generality of concepts through the way they are combined. Only intuitively is the Idea cognized, and cognition of the Idea is the purpose of every art. Mastery of poetry, as of chemistry, enables one to obtain precisely the precipitate intended each time.

The many epithets in poetry serve this end. They increasingly restrict the generality of a concept until intuition is reached. Homer attaches an adjective to almost every noun. Its concept intersects and at once considerably narrows the sphere of the noun's concept, bringing it that much closer to intuition. For example:

Ἐν δ' ἔπεσ' Ὠκεανῷ λαμπρὸν φάος ἡέλιοιο,
 Ἔλκον νύκτα μέλαιναν ἐπὶ ζείδωρον ἄρουραν
 (Occidit vero in Oceanum splendidum lumen solis,
 Trahens noctem nigram super almam terram.)

Translation: The splendid light of the sun sank into Ocean, drawing black night over the life-giving earth.

And these lines precipitate the whole delight of the southern climate before the imagination from a few concepts:

“A gentle wind blows from the blue sky;
The myrtle stands still, the laurel tall.”

Rhythm and rhyme are very special aids to poetry. I know no other explanation for their incredibly powerful effect than that our powers of representation, essentially bound to time, have the peculiarity of inwardly following every regularly recurring sound and, as it were, joining in. Rhythm and rhyme thus partly bind our attention, making us follow the recital more willingly. They also create in us a blind assent to what is said, prior to every judgment, giving it a certain emphatic power to convince independent of any reasons.

Because the material poetry uses to communicate Ideas—concepts—is general, poetry's domain is very large. It can present all nature, Ideas at every grade, proceeding now by description, now by narration, and now by direct dramatic presentation, according to the Idea to be communicated. In portraying the lower grades of the will's objecthood, the visual arts usually surpass poetry, since nature without cognition, and even merely animal nature, reveals almost its whole essence in a single well-grasped moment. Human beings, however, express themselves not merely through form and facial expression but through a chain of actions and the thoughts and emotions accompanying them. They are therefore poetry's principal subject. No other art equals it here, for poetry can unfold its subject through a progression that is denied to the visual arts.^[†]

Poetry's great subject is thus the revelation of the Idea that forms the highest grade of the will's objecthood: the presentation of human beings in the connected series of their strivings and actions. Experience and history also teach us about human beings, but more often about *people* than about *the human being*. They give us empirical information about how people behave toward one another, from which rules for our own conduct may be drawn, more often than they offer deep insight into humanity's inner nature. Such insight is not excluded from them, however. Whenever the essence of humanity itself is disclosed to us in history or our own experience, we or the historian have already apprehended these with an artist's eyes, poetically: according to the Idea rather than the appearance, the inner essence rather than the relations. Personal experience is indispensable for understanding both poetry and history; it is, so to speak, the dictionary of the language they speak.

History stands to poetry as portrait painting stands to history painting. The former gives what is true of the individual; the latter, what is true in general.

One has the truth of appearance and can attest it from appearance; the other has the truth of the Idea, which is found in no single appearance yet speaks from them all. The poet deliberately selects and presents significant characters in significant situations. The historian takes both as they come. Indeed, the historian must regard and select events and persons not for their inner, genuine significance expressing the Idea, but for their outer, apparent, relative importance in connections and consequences. Nothing may be considered in itself, by its essential character and expression. Everything must be viewed relationally, in the chain of events, through its influence on what follows, especially on the historian's own age.

Thus the historian must not omit a king's action that is insignificant, even commonplace, in itself: it has consequences and influence. Conversely, the actions of individuals highly significant in themselves, and even exceptional individuals, go unmentioned if they have no consequences or influence. Historical inquiry follows the principle of sufficient reason and grasps appearance, whose form that principle is. The poet apprehends the Idea, the essence of humanity apart from every relation and every time: the adequate objecthood of the thing in itself at its highest grade.

Even in the historian's necessary manner of looking, the inner essence, the significance of appearances, the kernel within all those shells, can never be wholly lost. At least someone who seeks it can still find and recognize it. Nevertheless, what is significant in itself rather than through relation—the actual unfolding of the Idea—will be found far more accurately and clearly in poetry than in history. Paradoxical as it sounds, poetry therefore deserves far more attribution of proper, genuine, inner truth. The historian must follow an individual event exactly as it occurred, developing in time through the many entangled chains of grounds and consequences. Yet the historian cannot possibly possess all the data, have witnessed everything, or have investigated everything. At every moment the original of the portrait is lost or replaced by a false one. This happens so often that I think it reasonable to suppose there is more falsehood than truth in all history.

The poet, by contrast, has apprehended the Idea of humanity from the particular side to be presented. It is the essence of the poet's own self that becomes objective to him in it. His cognition is, as explained above concerning sculpture, half *a priori* (prior to experience). His model stands before his mind, firm, distinct, and brightly lit, and cannot desert him. In the mirror of his mind

he therefore shows us the Idea purely and clearly, and his depiction is true to life down to the particulars.^{[2][3]}

The great ancient historians are therefore poets in their details where the data fail them—for example, in their heroes' speeches. Indeed, their whole handling of their material approaches epic poetry. This gives their accounts unity and lets them retain inner truth even when outer truth was unavailable or actually distorted. We compared history with portrait painting and poetry with history painting. The ancient historians also followed Winckelmann's maxim that the portrait should be the ideal of the individual: they present the particular in such a way that the side of the Idea of humanity expressed in it comes forward. Modern historians, with few exceptions, give us mostly “a rubbish bin and junk room, and at most a major affair of state.”

Anyone who wishes to know humanity according to its inner essence, identical through all appearances and developments—according to its Idea—will find a far more faithful and distinct image in the works of the great, immortal poets than historians can ever offer. Even the best historians are far from being the greatest poets, and their hands are not free. We can illuminate the relation by a comparison. A historian who works solely from data resembles a person with no knowledge of mathematics who measures the relations between accidentally discovered figures. The resulting empirical measurements bear all the errors of the drawn figure. The poet resembles a mathematician who constructs those relations *a priori* in pure intuition and states them as they are in the Idea the drawing is meant to make sensible, not as they happen to be in the drawing. Hence Schiller says:

“What has never happened anywhere, at any time—
That alone never grows old.”

For knowledge of humanity's essence, I must even grant biographies, particularly autobiographies, more value than history proper, at least as history is usually practised. In biographies the data can be gathered more accurately and completely. In history proper, moreover, it is not so much people as peoples and armies that act. The individuals who still appear stand far away amid a great setting and retinue, veiled in stiff official dress or heavy, inflexible armour. It is truly hard to discern human movement through all of that. By contrast, a faithful account of an individual's life within a narrow sphere shows the ways people act in all their nuances and forms: the excellence, virtue, even

holiness of a few; the perversity, wretchedness, and malice of most; the depravity of some.

From the only standpoint considered here—the inner significance of what appears—it makes no difference whether the objects around which actions turn are relatively trivial or important, farms or kingdoms. In themselves all these things have no significance. They acquire it only because and insofar as the will is moved by them. A motive has significance solely through its relation to the will; its relations as a thing to other things do not enter into consideration. A circle one inch in diameter and one forty million miles across have exactly the same geometrical properties. Likewise, events and history in a village and in a kingdom are essentially the same. We can study and come to know humanity from either.

It is also wrong to suppose that autobiographies are full of lies and pretence. Lying, though possible everywhere, may be harder there than anywhere else. Pretence is easiest in mere conversation. Paradoxical as it sounds, it is already harder in a letter: left alone with himself, the writer looks inward rather than outward. What is foreign and distant is hard for him to bring near, and he has no measure before him of the impression made on the recipient. The recipient, meanwhile, calmly reads the letter in a mood foreign to the writer's, perhaps several times and at different times, and easily discovers the hidden intention. A book is likewise the easiest way to come to know its author as a human being, since all these conditions act still more strongly and persistently. Pretence is so difficult in an autobiography that perhaps not a single one is, on the whole, less truthful than any other written history.

Someone recording his life surveys it as a whole and on a large scale. Details grow small, what is near recedes, what is distant draws near again, and considerations of self-interest shrink. He has willingly sat down to confess to himself. The spirit of falsehood does not take hold of him so easily here. Every person also has an inclination toward truth, which must be overcome for any lie and which takes an unusually strong position here.

Another comparison makes the relation between biography and national history intuitive. History shows us humanity as a view from a high mountain shows us nature: we see much at once, broad tracts and great masses, but nothing distinctly or in its full, true essence. The life of an individual, by contrast, shows us the human being as we come to know nature by walking among its trees, plants, rocks, and waters. In landscape painting the artist lets us

look upon nature through his eyes and thus greatly eases our cognition of its Ideas and the state of pure, will-less cognition required for it. Poetry has a similar advantage over both history and biography in presenting the Ideas we seek in them. Genius holds up a clarifying mirror in which all that is essential and significant is gathered and placed in the clearest light, while the accidental and extraneous is removed.^[4]

The poet can present the Idea of humanity in two ways. The person presented may also be the one presenting: this occurs in lyric poetry, in the song proper, where the poet vividly contemplates and describes only his own state. This genre therefore necessarily has a certain subjectivity by virtue of its subject. Or the person presented may be wholly distinct from the one presenting, as in every other genre. There the presenter hides to a greater or lesser degree behind what is presented, ultimately disappearing altogether. In a ballad the presenter still expresses his own state to some extent through the tone and bearing of the whole. Though much more objective than the song, it retains something subjective. This recedes further in the idyll, much further in the novel, almost wholly in the epic proper, and down to its last trace in drama—the most objective and, in more than one respect, the most perfect as well as the most difficult kind of poetry.

For the same reason the lyric genre is the easiest. Although art generally belongs only to rare, genuine genius, even someone not especially outstanding can produce a beautiful song if a strong external stimulus genuinely inspires and heightens his mental powers. It requires only vivid contemplation of one's own state in an excited moment. Many individual songs by otherwise unknown people demonstrate this, especially German folk songs, of which *Des Knaben Wunderhorn* offers an excellent collection, and countless popular love songs and other songs in every language. Grasping a moment's mood and embodying it in a song is the whole accomplishment of this poetic genre.

Yet in the lyric poetry of genuine poets, the inner life of all humanity is reflected. Whatever millions of people past, present, and future have felt and will feel in the same, constantly recurring situations finds its fitting expression there. Since those situations recur continually, they endure like humanity itself and always stir the same feelings. The lyric works of genuine poets therefore remain true, effective, and fresh for thousands of years. Indeed, the poet is the universal human being. Everything that has ever stirred a human heart, everything human nature brings forth in any situation, everything that dwells and broods in a human breast anywhere is the poet's theme and material—as is

all the rest of nature. The poet can sing sensual pleasure as readily as mysticism, can be Anacreon or Angelus Silesius, write tragedy or comedy, and depict a sublime or a common disposition, according to inclination and calling. No one may therefore prescribe that the poet be noble and sublime, moral, pious, Christian, or anything else, much less reproach him for being one thing and not another. He is humanity's mirror, bringing to its consciousness what it feels and what drives it.

Let us consider the nature of the song proper more closely. Take excellent and pure examples, rather than works already approaching another genre, such as the ballad, elegy, hymn, or epigram. We shall find that the song's distinctive nature in the strict sense is as follows. The subject of willing—one's own willing—fills the singer's consciousness, sometimes as willing released and satisfied (joy), perhaps still more often as willing obstructed (sorrow), but always as emotion, passion, or a stirred state of mind. Yet alongside this, and at the same time, the sight of surrounding nature makes the singer conscious of himself as the subject of pure, will-less cognition. Its unshakable, blissful calm now contrasts with the urge of willing, always confined and always still in need. What the song as a whole expresses, and what constitutes the lyric state, is the feeling of this contrast and interplay.

In that state pure cognition seems to approach us to redeem us from willing and its urgency. We follow, but only for moments. Willing—the memory of our personal ends—repeatedly tears us away from calm contemplation. Yet the next beautiful sight in our surroundings, offering pure, will-less cognition, draws us from willing once more. Thus in the song and the lyric mood, willing (personal interest in ends) and pure intuition of the surroundings mingle wonderfully. Relations between them are sought and imagined. The subjective mood, the affection of the will, colours the surroundings we see; these in turn reflect their colour back upon that mood. A genuine song is the imprint of this whole mixed and divided state of mind.

Examples can make this abstract analysis of a state remote from all abstraction understandable. One may take any of Goethe's immortal songs. For this purpose I particularly recommend "The Shepherd's Lament," "Welcome and Farewell," "To the Moon," "On the Lake," and "Autumn Feeling." The songs proper in *Des Knaben Wunderhorn* are also excellent examples, especially the one beginning "O Bremen, now I must leave you." I know a comic parody by Voss that captures the lyric character exactly. He describes the feelings of a drunken roofer falling from a tower. As he falls, he makes an

observation wholly foreign to his situation and therefore belonging to will-free cognition: the tower clock shows half past eleven.

Anyone who shares this view of the lyric state will also agree that it is intuitive, poetic cognition of the proposition I set out in my essay on the principle of sufficient reason and have mentioned in this work: the identity of the subject of cognition with the subject of willing may be called the miracle *par excellence* (κατ' ἐξοχήν—above all others). The song's poetic effect ultimately rests on the truth of that proposition. In the course of life these two subjects—or, in popular language, head and heart—separate more and more. We increasingly distinguish subjective feeling from objective cognition. In a child the two are still wholly fused. The child scarcely distinguishes himself from his surroundings, but blends into them. In a young person every perception first produces feeling and mood, and even mingles with them, as *Byron* beautifully expresses it:

I live not in myself, but I become
 Portion of that around me; and to me
 High mountains are a feeling^[5]

Translation: I do not live in myself alone; I become part of my surroundings, and high mountains are something I feel.

This is why the young person is so attached to the intuitive outer aspect of things, and why youth is suited only to lyric poetry, whereas maturity is suited to drama. We can imagine an old person at most as an epic poet, like *Ossian* or *Homer*, for narration belongs to the character of old age.

In the more objective kinds of poetry, especially novel, epic, and drama, revelation of the Idea of humanity is achieved chiefly by two means: the accurate, deeply grasped presentation of significant characters and the invention of significant situations in which they develop. A chemist must not only present simple substances and their principal compounds in a pure, genuine form, but expose them to reagents that bring out their distinctive properties clearly and strikingly. Likewise, the poet must do more than place significant characters before us as truly and faithfully as nature itself. To make them known, the poet must set them in situations where their distinctive features unfold completely and they appear clearly, in sharp outline. These are called significant situations.

In real life and history, chance rarely produces situations of this kind. When it does, they stand isolated, lost and concealed amid a multitude of insignificant

events. The sustained significance of situations, as much as the selection and combination of significant characters, should distinguish novel, epic, and drama from real life. Yet strict truth is indispensable to the effect of both. Characters lacking unity, contradicting themselves or human nature in general, and impossible or nearly improbable events, even in secondary details, offend us in poetry as much as misshapen figures, false perspective, or faulty lighting do in painting. In both we ask for a faithful mirror of life, humanity, and the world, only made clearer by presentation and more significant by selection and arrangement.

All arts have one purpose: to present the Ideas. They differ essentially only in the grade of the will's objectivation belonging to the Idea they present, which in turn determines their material. We can therefore clarify even the most distant arts by comparing them. To apprehend fully the Ideas expressed in water, for example, seeing it in a still pond or an evenly flowing stream is not enough. Those Ideas unfold completely only when water appears under all the conditions and obstructions that act upon it and call forth the full expression of its properties. We therefore find it beautiful when it plunges, roars, foams, springs upward again, dissolves into spray as it falls, or, forced by art, rises as a jet. It behaves differently in different conditions, yet always remains true to its character. Springing up is as natural to it as lying still and reflecting. It is equally ready for either when the circumstances arise.

What the maker of waterworks achieves with fluid matter, the architect achieves with rigid matter, and the epic or dramatic poet with the Idea of humanity. To unfold and clarify the Idea expressed in the object of each art, the will objectivating itself at each grade, is the common purpose of all the arts. Human life as usually seen in reality resembles water as usually seen in pond and stream. In epic, novel, and tragedy, however, selected characters are placed in circumstances that unfold all their distinctive features. The depths of the human mind open and become visible in extraordinary, significant actions. Thus poetry objectivates the Idea of the human being, whose distinguishing feature is to appear in highly individual characters.

Tragedy is regarded, and must be regarded, as poetry's summit, both for the magnitude of its effect and the difficulty of its achievement. For our whole inquiry it is highly significant that this supreme poetic achievement aims to present life's terrible side. It shows us nameless pain, humanity's misery, the triumph of wickedness, the mocking rule of chance, and the hopeless downfall of the just and innocent. This offers a profound indication of the nature of the

world and existence. The will's conflict with itself, fully unfolded at the highest grade of its objecthood, emerges here in terror.

We see this conflict in human suffering. It arises partly from chance and error, which appear as rulers of the world and are personified as fate because their malice almost seems deliberate. Partly it arises from humanity itself: from the intersecting strivings of individual wills and the wickedness and perversity of most people. One and the same will lives and appears in all of them, yet its appearances fight and tear one another apart. It emerges powerfully in one individual and more weakly in another; here it is brought more fully, there less fully, to reflection and moderated by the light of cognition.

At last, in one individual, this cognition, purified and intensified by suffering itself, reaches a point where appearance, the veil of Maya, no longer deceives it. It sees through the form of appearance, the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation), and egoism founded on it dies. The formerly powerful *motives* then lose their power. In their place complete cognition of the world's essence acts as a *quietive* of the will, bringing resignation: the abandonment not merely of life but of the whole will to live itself.

Thus in tragedy we finally see the noblest people, after long struggle and suffering, renounce forever the goals they had pursued so fiercely and all the pleasures of life, or freely and gladly give up life itself. So it is with Calderón's *Steadfast Prince*, Gretchen in *Faust*, and Hamlet, whose Horatio would willingly follow him but whom Hamlet commands to remain and breathe painfully a while longer in this harsh world, to tell his fate and clear his memory. So too with *The Maid of Orleans* and *The Bride of Messina*. They all die purified by suffering, meaning that the will to live has already died within them. Voltaire's *Mahomet* even says this expressly in Palmira's dying words to Mahomet: "The world is for tyrants: live, then!"

The demand for so-called poetic justice, by contrast, rests on a complete misunderstanding of tragedy's nature, indeed of the world's nature. It comes forward in all its shallow boldness in Dr Samuel Johnson's criticism of Shakespeare's plays. He quite naively complains that poetic justice is consistently neglected—and indeed it is: for what wrong have Ophelia, Desdemona, or Cordelia done? Only a shallow, optimistic, Protestant rationalist—or, strictly speaking, Jewish—view of the world demands poetic justice and finds satisfaction when it is supplied. The true meaning of tragedy is

the deeper insight that what the hero atones for is not his individual sins but original sin: the guilt of existence itself. Calderón says this directly:

Pues el delito mayor
Del hombre es haber nacido

Translation: For the greatest crime of a human being is to have been born.

I shall make just one more observation about the handling of tragedy. Presenting a great misfortune is essential to it. The various ways a poet brings this about fall into three kinds. First, an extraordinary wickedness, bordering on the utmost limits of possibility, may belong to a character who causes the misfortune. Examples are Richard III, Iago in *Othello*, Shylock in *The Merchant of Venice*, Franz Moor, Euripides' Phaedra, Creon in *Antigone*, and others.

Second, blind fate—chance or error—may bring the misfortune. Sophocles' *Oedipus the King* is a true model, as are *The Women of Trachis* and most ancient tragedies generally. Modern examples include *Romeo and Juliet*, Voltaire's *Tancred*, and *The Bride of Messina*.

Third, the mere positions of the characters relative to one another, their relationships, may bring it about. No monstrous error, unheard-of accident, or character reaching the limits of human evil is needed. Characters who are morally ordinary are placed in circumstances that occur frequently, yet their situation forces them knowingly and consciously to cause one another the greatest harm, without injustice lying exclusively on either side.

This last kind seems far preferable to the other two. It shows us the greatest misfortune not as an exception brought on by rare circumstances or monstrous characters, but as something arising easily and of itself from human actions and characters, almost as though it were essential to them. This brings it terribly close to us. In the other two kinds, mighty fate and dreadful wickedness appear as frightening powers threatening us only from afar; we might escape them without taking refuge in renunciation. The last kind shows us powers destructive of happiness and life to which a path toward us lies open at every moment. The greatest suffering is caused by entanglements that could substantially be our own fate and by actions we ourselves might be capable of committing, so that we could not complain of injustice. We shudder to feel ourselves already in the midst of hell.

This last kind is also the hardest to execute. The poet must achieve the greatest effect with the least expenditure of means and motives, solely through the characters' placement and arrangement. Many of the best tragedies therefore avoid this difficulty. A perfect model is a play surpassed in other respects by several works of the same great master: *Clavigo*. *Hamlet* belongs to this kind to some degree if we consider only Hamlet's relations with Laertes and Ophelia. *Wallenstein* has this advantage too. *Faust* belongs to it entirely if we take the episode involving Gretchen and her brother as the main action. So does Corneille's *Le Cid*, except that it lacks the tragic ending found in Max's analogous relationship with Thekla.^[6]

Notes

Notes

† Editorial note: the German extract contains an omission marker, [], where the verb completing this comparison should be. The English supplies the sense confirmed by the corresponding passage in the published Haldane–Kemp edition: temporal development is available to poetry but not to the visual arts. No missing German verb has been conjectured. ↩

1. *Mediocribus esse poëtis / Non homines, non Dî, non concessere columnae* (Neither human beings, nor gods, nor booksellers' pillars allow poets to be mediocre). ↩

2. I am, of course, speaking throughout only of the rare great and genuine poet, and mean least of all the insipid crowd of mediocre poets, rhyme-makers, and inventors of tales, so prolific especially in Germany today. From every side one should continually shout into their ears the lines quoted in note 1.^[1] ↩

3. It is worth serious thought how much of their own and others' time and paper this swarm of mediocre poets wastes, and how harmful their influence is. The public always reaches for what is new; it also has a natural inclination toward what is mistaken and shallow, which is more like itself. These mediocre works therefore distract it from genuine masterpieces and the education it could gain from them. Working directly against the salutary influence of genius, they increasingly spoil taste and impede the progress of the age. Criticism and satire should scourge mediocre poets without indulgence or pity until, for their own good, they spend their leisure reading good works instead of writing bad ones. If even the gentle god of the Muses was so angered by an uncalled-for bungler that he could flay Marsyas, I cannot see on what grounds mediocre poetry claims toleration. ↩

4. See chapter 38 of the second volume. ↩

5. The German note translates Byron's lines: "I do not live in myself alone; I become a part of what surrounds me, and high mountains are a feeling to me." ↩

6. See chapter 37 of the second volume. ↩

§. 52.

We have now considered all the fine arts at the level of generality suited to our standpoint. We began with architecture, whose purpose as a fine art is to clarify the will's objectivation at the lowest grade of visibility, where it appears as the dim, cognitionless, law-governed striving of mass and yet already reveals division and conflict within itself, namely between gravity and rigidity. We ended with tragedy, which at the highest grade of the will's objectivation shows us that same conflict within the will in terrible magnitude and clarity. Yet one fine art has remained outside our account and had to remain so, since there was no suitable place for it in the systematic course of our presentation: *music*.

Music stands quite apart from all the others. In it we do not recognize a copy or repetition of any Idea of the beings in the world. Yet it is so great and splendid an art, acts so powerfully on the innermost human being, and is understood there so completely and deeply as a universal language whose clarity even surpasses that of the intuitive world itself, that we must surely seek in it more than an exercitium arithmeticae occultum nescientis se numerare animi (a hidden exercise in arithmetic by a mind unaware that it is counting).^[1] Leibniz described it thus, and was quite right insofar as he considered only its immediate outer significance, its shell. Were there nothing more to music, however, the satisfaction it offers would resemble the satisfaction of correctly solving an arithmetic problem. It could not be the intimate joy of hearing the deepest part of our own being given voice.

From our standpoint, which attends to aesthetic effect, we must therefore assign music a far more serious and profound significance concerning the innermost nature of the world and ourselves. The numerical relations into which music can be resolved are not what it signifies, but are themselves merely signs. By analogy with the other arts, all of which present a relation of copy to model, we may infer that music must stand in some such relation to the world. Its effect upon us is generally of the same kind as theirs, but stronger, swifter, more necessary, and more certain. Its relation to the world as a copy must also be exceedingly intimate, infinitely true, and accurate. Everyone understands music immediately, and it displays a certain unfailing precision: its form can be reduced to definite rules expressible in numbers, and it cannot depart from them without ceasing altogether to be music. Yet the point of comparison between music and the world, the respect in which music imitates or repeats it, lies

deeply hidden. People have practised music in every age without being able to account for this relation. Content to understand it immediately, they give up trying to grasp their immediate understanding in abstract terms.

I gave myself over entirely to the impression of music in its many forms, then returned to reflection and to the course of thought set out in this book. I gained an insight into music's inner nature and the way it stands to the world in the relation of a copy, which analogy requires us to assume. This insight is entirely sufficient to me and satisfies my inquiry. It will perhaps be just as convincing to someone who has followed me so far and shares my view of the world. Yet I recognize that it is essentially impossible to prove. It posits a relation between music, as a representation, and something that can never essentially be a representation, and regards music as the copy of a model that can never itself be presented directly.

At the end of this third book, devoted chiefly to the arts, I can therefore do no more than set out the explanation of this wonderful art of sound that satisfies me. Whether readers assent to or reject it must depend partly on the effect music has on them, and partly on the effect of the whole, unified thought communicated in this book. Moreover, to assent to this account of music's significance with genuine conviction, one must often listen to music while reflecting steadily on it. This in turn requires thorough familiarity with the whole thought I have presented.

The adequate objectivation of the will consists in the Platonic Ideas. The aim of all the other arts is to prompt cognition of those Ideas through depictions of individual things—for artworks themselves are still individual things. This is possible only through a corresponding change in the knowing subject. All those arts therefore objectivate the will only indirectly, through the Ideas. Our world is nothing but the appearance of the Ideas in multiplicity through their entry into the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation), the form of cognition possible for the individual as such. Music, since it bypasses the Ideas, is also wholly independent of the world of appearance. It simply ignores that world and could in a sense exist even if the world did not—a claim we cannot make of the other arts.

Music is as *immediate* an objectivation and image of the whole *will* as the world itself is, indeed as the Ideas are, whose multiplied appearance constitutes the world of individual things. Music is therefore by no means, like the other arts, an image of the Ideas. It is an *image of the will itself*, of which the Ideas

too are objecthood. This is precisely why its effect is so much more powerful and penetrating than that of the other arts. They speak only of shadows; music speaks of the essence. Still, the same will objectivates itself in the Ideas and in music, though in wholly different ways. There must therefore be no direct likeness, but a parallel or analogy, between music and the Ideas, whose appearance in multiplicity and imperfection is the visible world. Demonstrating this analogy will help make the explanation intelligible despite its difficult subject.

In the deepest tones of harmony, in the fundamental bass, I recognize the lowest grades of the will's objectivation: inorganic nature, the mass of the planet. All the higher tones, which move more easily and die away more quickly, are understood to arise from the subsidiary vibrations of the low fundamental tone. When it sounds, they sound faintly along with it. A rule of harmony allows only those higher tones above a bass note that already sound with it of themselves as its sons harmoniques (harmonics) through these subsidiary vibrations. This is analogous to the way all the bodies and organized forms of nature must be regarded as arising through gradual development from the planet's mass. It is their bearer and their source; the higher tones stand in the same relation to the fundamental bass.

There is a lower limit beyond which no tone can be heard. Correspondingly, no matter can be perceived without form and quality—that is, without the expression of some further inexplicable force in which an Idea is expressed. More generally, no matter can be wholly without will. Just as a certain pitch is inseparable from a tone as such, a certain grade of the will's expression is inseparable from matter. The fundamental bass thus plays the part in harmony that inorganic nature, the rawest mass upon which everything rests and from which everything rises and develops, plays in the world.

In all the accompanying parts that produce harmony between the bass and the leading voice that sings the melody, I recognize the whole sequence of Ideas in which the will objectivates itself. The voices closer to the bass represent lower grades, still inorganic bodies but already manifesting themselves in many ways; the higher ones represent the worlds of plants and animals. The definite intervals of the scale run parallel to the definite grades of the will's objectivation, the definite species in nature. Deviations from the intervals' arithmetical correctness, produced by some temperament or by the choice of key, are analogous to the individual's deviation from the type of the species. Indeed, impure discordant notes that form no definite interval can be compared

with monstrous births between two animal species, or between human being and animal.

All these bass and accompanying voices that make up *harmony* lack the coherence of progression possessed only by the upper voice singing the melody. Only that voice moves quickly and easily through modulations and runs; the others move more slowly and lack a coherent course of their own. The low bass, representing the rawest mass, moves most ponderously. It rises and falls only in large steps—thirds, fourths, fifths—never by a *single* tone, unless it is a bass transposed by double counterpoint. Slow movement is physically essential to it: a quick run or trill in the low register cannot even be imagined. The higher accompanying voices, parallel to the animal world, move faster, but still without melodic coherence or a meaningful course.

The disjointed movement and fixed rules governing all the accompanying voices are analogous to the fact that, throughout the non-rational world from crystal to the most perfect animal, no being has a truly coherent consciousness that would make its life a meaningful whole. None passes through a sequence of mental developments or perfects itself by cultivation. Everything stands uniformly at every moment just as it is according to its kind, determined by fixed law.

Finally, in the *melody*, the high, singing principal voice that leads the whole and progresses with unbounded freedom from beginning to end in the uninterrupted, meaningful connection of *one* thought, forming a whole, I recognize the highest grade of the will's objectivation: the reflective life and striving of the human being. The human being alone, endowed with reason, looks continually backward and forward over the course of actual life and innumerable possibilities, and thus leads a reflective life coherent as a whole. Correspondingly, the *melody* alone has a meaningful, purposeful connection from beginning to end.

Melody therefore tells the story of the will illuminated by reflection, whose imprint in reality is the series of its deeds. But it says more. It tells the will's most secret story, paints every stirring, every striving, every movement of the will—all that reason gathers under the broad, negative concept of feeling and cannot further admit into its abstractions. For this reason music has always been called the language of feeling and passion, just as words are the language of reason. Plato already describes it as ἡ τῶν μελῶν κίνησις μεμιμημένη, ἐν τοῖς παθήμασιν ὅταν ψυχὴ γίνηται (melodiarum motus, animi affectus imitans—the

movement of melodies imitating affections of the soul; *Laws*, VII). Aristotle likewise asks: διὰ τί οἱ ῥυθμοὶ καὶ τὰ μέλη, φωνῇ οὕσα, ἤθεσιν ἔοικε (cur numeri musici et modi, qui voces sunt, moribus similes sese exhibent?—why do rhythms and melodies, though sounds, resemble dispositions?; *Problems*, 19).

The essence of a human being is that the will strives, is satisfied, and then strives anew, without end. Happiness and well-being consist only in a rapid passage from desire to satisfaction and from that satisfaction to a new desire. The failure of satisfaction is suffering; the failure of a new desire is empty longing, *languor* (listlessness), boredom. Correspondingly, melody's essence is a constant departure and wandering away from the key note by a thousand paths. It moves not only to harmonious degrees, the third and dominant, but to every tone, even the dissonant seventh and augmented intervals. Yet it always eventually returns to the key note. On all these paths melody expresses the will's many-shaped striving; by finally finding a harmonious degree, and still more by finding the key note, it also expresses satisfaction.

Inventing a melody and in it uncovering all the deepest secrets of human willing and feeling is the work of genius. Here more plainly than anywhere else genius works apart from reflection and conscious design; one could call it inspiration. Here, as everywhere in art, the concept is barren. The composer reveals the world's innermost nature and speaks its deepest wisdom in a language his reason does not understand, like a magnetic sleepwalker disclosing things of which she has no conception when awake. In a composer, therefore, the human being is more separate and distinct from the artist than in any other artist. Even when we explain this wonderful art, concepts show their poverty and limits. I shall nevertheless try to carry our analogy through.

A rapid passage from desire to satisfaction and from there to a new desire is happiness and well-being. Accordingly, quick melodies without large departures are cheerful. Slow melodies that encounter painful dissonances and work their way back to the key note only after many measures are sad, analogous to delayed and difficult satisfaction. The delay of a new stirring of the will, *languor*, could be expressed only by holding the key note, which would soon become unbearable. Very monotonous, empty melodies already come close to this. The short, readily understood phrases of quick dance music seem to speak only of easily attained, ordinary happiness. The *maestoso* (majestic manner), by contrast, with large phrases, long passages, and wide departures, signifies a greater and nobler striving toward a distant goal and its

eventual attainment. It speaks of the suffering of a great, noble striving that disdains all petty happiness.

How marvellous is the effect of *minor* and *major*! How astonishing that the change of a semitone, the entrance of the minor third in place of the major, immediately and unfailingly impresses an anxious, painful feeling on us, from which the major mode releases us just as immediately. An *adagio* (slow movement) in minor expresses the highest pain and becomes the most moving lament. Dance music in minor seems to signify missing a petty happiness one would do better to scorn, or reaching a lowly goal through hardship and drudgery. The inexhaustibility of possible melodies corresponds to nature's inexhaustible diversity of individuals, faces, and life courses. A passage into an entirely different key breaks the connection with what went before and resembles death: the individual ends there, but the will that appeared in that individual lives on as before, appearing in others whose consciousness has no connection with the first.

In tracing these analogies, we must never forget that music is related to them only indirectly, never directly. It expresses not appearance but solely the inner essence, the in-itself of every appearance: the will itself. It therefore expresses not this or that particular joy, sorrow, pain, horror, jubilation, cheerfulness, or peace of mind, but *joy, sorrow, pain, horror, jubilation, cheerfulness, and peace of mind themselves*: in a sense *in abstracto* (in the abstract), their essence without any accessory details, including the motives for them. Yet we understand them perfectly in this distilled form.

Our imagination is therefore readily stirred by music and tries to give shape to this invisible yet vividly stirring spirit world that speaks so directly to us, to clothe it in flesh and bone and embody it in an analogous example. This is the origin of song with words and ultimately of opera. Opera's text should therefore never leave its subordinate place to become the principal thing and reduce music to a mere means of its expression. That would be a great mistake and a serious reversal. Music everywhere expresses only the quintessence of life and its events, never the events themselves; their differences therefore do not always affect music. This generality unique to music, joined to utmost precision, gives it its high value as a panacea for all our sufferings. When music tries to cling too closely to words or shape itself after events, it tries to speak a language that is not its own. No one avoided this error more completely than *Rossini*: his music speaks its *own* language so distinctly and purely that it needs no words, and has its full effect when played by instruments alone.

We may therefore regard the world of appearance, or nature, and music as two different expressions of the same thing. That thing alone mediates their analogy, and knowledge of it is required to understand the analogy. Seen as an expression of the world, music is a language of the highest generality. It stands to the generality of concepts much as concepts stand to individual things. Yet music's generality is not the empty generality of abstraction. It is quite different, joined throughout to clear definiteness. In this respect it resembles geometrical figures and numbers: universal forms of all possible objects of experience, applicable to all *a priori* (prior to experience), yet intuitive rather than abstract and determinate throughout.

All possible strivings, excitations, and expressions of the will—all those events within the human being that reason throws together under the broad, negative concept of feeling—can be expressed through the infinitely many possible melodies. But they are always expressed in the generality of mere form, without the material; according to their in-itself, not their appearance: their innermost soul, as it were, without a body. This intimate relation between music and the true essence of all things explains why fitting music accompanying any scene, action, event, or setting seems to disclose its most secret meaning and offers the truest and clearest commentary on it. It also explains why someone who gives himself wholly to the impression of a symphony seems to see all possible events of life and the world passing before him, yet, on reflection, can point to no likeness between the play of tones and the things it called to mind.

As I have said, music differs from all other arts because it is not an image of appearance—or, more precisely, of the will's adequate objecthood—but directly an image of the will itself. It thus presents the metaphysical counterpart to everything physical in the world, the thing in itself to every appearance. We could as well call the world embodied music as embodied will. This explains why music at once makes every painting and every scene in real life and the world appear more significant, especially when its melody is analogous to the inner spirit of the appearance before us.

This relation makes it possible to set a poem to music as a song, an intuitive depiction as a pantomime, or both together as an opera. Such particular images of human life set beneath the universal language of music are never joined or fitted to it by complete necessity. They stand to it as an arbitrarily selected example stands to a general concept: they present in the definiteness of reality what music says in the generality of mere form. Melodies, in a sense, are

abstractions from reality, like general concepts. The world of individual things supplies intuition, the particular and individual case, to both the generality of concepts and that of melodies. Yet in one respect these generalities are opposites. Concepts contain only the forms first abstracted from intuition, the stripped outer shell of things: they are abstractions in the strict sense. Music gives the innermost kernel prior to all shaping, the heart of things.

We could express this relation aptly in Scholastic terms: concepts are *universalia post rem* (universals after the thing), music gives *universalia ante rem* (universals before the thing), and reality gives *universalia in re* (universals in the thing). Other examples of the universal expressed by a melody attached to a poem could fit its general sense equally well. Thus one composition suits many stanzas, and this is also why the *vaudeville* is possible. As noted, any relation between a musical composition and an intuitive depiction is possible because both are quite different expressions of the world's same inner essence. When such a relation actually exists in a particular case—when the composer has succeeded in expressing, in music's universal language, the stirrings of the will at the core of an event—the song's melody or the opera's music is expressive.

The analogy the composer discovers between the two must arise from immediate, unconscious cognition of the world's essence. It must not be imitation mediated by concepts and carried out with deliberate intention. Otherwise the music does not express the inner essence, the will itself, but inadequately imitates only its appearance. This is what all music that literally copies things does: Haydn's *The Seasons*, for example, and many passages in his *Creation*, where appearances of the intuitive world are directly imitated, as well as all battle pieces. Such music is to be rejected altogether.

Music's inexpressibly intimate quality, by which it passes us like a paradise wholly familiar yet forever distant, entirely comprehensible yet inexplicable, rests on its reproducing every stirring of our innermost being while leaving out reality altogether and remaining far from its torment. Its essential seriousness, which excludes the ridiculous from music's own immediate domain, has the same explanation. Its object is not representation, with respect to which deception and the ridiculous alone are possible; it is directly the will, essentially the most serious thing of all, since everything depends on it. Even repeat signs and the *da capo* (from the beginning) testify to how rich in content and significance its language is. They would be intolerable in works made of words,

but in music they are apt and welcome, for we must hear it twice to grasp it fully.

Throughout this account I have tried to show that music, in a language of the highest generality yet with the greatest definiteness and truth, expresses in homogeneous material—mere tones—the world's inner essence, its in-itself, which we conceive as will according to its clearest manifestation. According to my view and aim, philosophy is nothing but a complete and correct repetition and articulation of the world's essence in very general concepts, for only these permit a survey comprehensive and applicable everywhere. Anyone who has followed me and entered into my way of thinking will therefore find it less paradoxical if I say this: if we could give a perfectly correct, complete explanation of music down to its details—a full repetition in concepts of what it expresses—that would at once be an adequate repetition and explanation of the world in concepts, or would correspond exactly to one. It would be the true philosophy.

Accordingly, we may parody Leibniz's remark quoted above, quite right at a lower standpoint, in the light of our higher view of music: *Musica est exercitium metaphysices occultum nescientis se philosophari animi* (Music is a hidden exercise in metaphysics by a mind unaware that it is philosophizing). For *scire*, to know, means everywhere to have translated something into abstract concepts.

Leibniz's original remark has, however, been confirmed in many ways. Apart from its aesthetic or inner significance, viewed merely from outside and empirically, music is a means of grasping large numbers and complex numerical relations immediately and *in concreto* (in the concrete), though ordinarily we can grasp them only indirectly, through concepts. Combining these two quite different yet correct views of music, we can therefore conceive how a philosophy of numbers such as that of Pythagoras, or the Chinese *I Ching*, might be possible. In this sense we can interpret the Pythagorean saying cited by Sextus Empiricus (*Against the Mathematicians*, VII): τῷ ἀριθμῷ δὲ τὰ πάντ' ἐπέοικεν (numero cuncta assimilantur—all things are likened to number).

If we then bring this view to our account of harmony and melody, we shall find a purely moral philosophy without an explanation of nature, such as Socrates wished to introduce, analogous to a melody without harmony, which Rousseau wanted exclusively. Conversely, physics and metaphysics without ethics correspond to harmony without melody.

Allow me to append a few further observations on the analogy between music and the world of appearance. In the preceding book we found that the human being, as the highest grade of the will's objectivation, could not appear alone and detached. Humanity presupposed the lower grades, and these in turn the grades below them. Similarly, music, which like the world objectivates the will directly, is complete only in full harmony. For its whole effect, the high leading voice of the melody needs the accompaniment of all the other voices down to the lowest bass, which is to be regarded as their source. Melody itself enters harmony as an integral part, just as harmony enters melody. Only thus, in the complete combination of voices, does music express what it aims to express. Likewise the one will, outside time, finds its complete objectivation only in the full union of all grades that reveal its essence at countless degrees of increasing clarity.

Another analogy is especially remarkable. In the preceding book we saw that, despite the adaptation of all appearances of the will to one another as species, which gives rise to teleological reflection, an irreconcilable conflict remains between those appearances as individuals. Visible at every grade, it makes the world a perpetual battleground among appearances of one and the same will, revealing the will's inner contradiction. Something corresponding to this is found even in music. A perfectly pure harmonic system of tones is impossible not only physically but even arithmetically. The numbers expressing tones have irreducible irrationalities. No scale can be calculated in which every fifth relates to the key note as 2 to 3, every major third as 4 to 5, every minor third as 5 to 6, and so on. If the tones are correct relative to the key note, they are no longer correct relative to one another; the fifth, for example, must also serve as the minor third of the third. The tones of a scale are like actors who must play different roles at different times. Perfectly correct music cannot even be conceived, let alone performed. Every possible music therefore departs from perfect purity. It can only conceal its essential dissonances by distributing them among all the tones—that is, by temperament. See Chladni's *Acoustics*, § 30, and his *Short Survey of the Theory of Sound and Tone*, p. 12.^[2]

I could add more about the way music is perceived: solely in and through time, with space completely excluded and without the influence of cognition of causality, that is, of the understanding. Tones make their aesthetic impression already as effects; unlike in intuition, we do not first trace them back to their cause. I shall not prolong this discussion further, however. Perhaps I have already been too expansive in this third book for some readers or entered too far

into details. My purpose required it, and it will seem less objectionable if one recalls the rarely appreciated importance and high value of art.

In our view the entire visible world is only the will's objectivation, its mirror, accompanying it toward self-knowledge and, as we shall soon see, toward the possibility of redemption. At the same time, the world as representation, viewed apart from willing and allowed alone to fill consciousness, is life's most delightful and only innocent side. We must thus regard art as a higher intensification and more perfect development of all this. Art essentially achieves, but in a more concentrated, accomplished, deliberate, and reflective way, what the visible world itself achieves. In the fullest sense it may therefore be called the flower of life. If the whole world as representation is merely the will's visibility, art clarifies that visibility. It is the *camera obscura* (dark chamber), showing objects more purely and allowing us to survey them better: the play within the play, the stage upon the stage in *Hamlet*.

Enjoyment of all beauty, the comfort art provides, and the artist's enthusiasm that makes him forget life's hardships all rest on one fact. So does the genius's one advantage over others, which alone compensates for suffering increased in proportion to clarity of consciousness and for barren solitude among people unlike himself. As we shall see later, the in-itself of life—the will, existence itself—is continual suffering, partly miserable and partly terrible. Yet life regarded purely as representation, or repeated in art, is free of torment and offers a meaningful spectacle. This purely knowable side of the world, and its repetition in any art, is the artist's element.

The artist is captivated by contemplating the spectacle of the will's objectivation. He stays with it and never tires of contemplating and presenting it again, even while he himself bears the cost of staging that spectacle: he himself is the will that objectivates itself in this way and remains in constant suffering. Pure, true, deep cognition of the world's essence becomes an end in itself for him, and with it he remains. It does not, therefore, become for him a quietive of the will, as we shall see in the following book with the saint who has attained resignation. It releases him from life only for moments, not forever. For now it is no way out of life, only a comfort within it—until the strength thus increased, finally weary of the play, turns to the serious matter. Raphael's St Cecilia may be taken as a symbol of this transition. We too shall now turn to that serious matter in the following book.

Notes

Notes

1. Leibniz, *Letters*, Kortholt collection, letter 154. ↩
2. See chapter 39 of the second volume. ↩

§. 53.

Book Four

The world as will, second consideration:

With self-knowledge attained, affirmation and denial of the will to live.

Tempore quo cognitio simul advenit, amor e medio supersurrexit.

Oupnek'hat, studio Anquetil Duperron, vol. II. p. 216.

Translation: At the time when knowledge appeared, love arose from the midst. *Oupnek'hat*, edited by Anquetil-Duperron, vol. 2, p. 216.

The final part of our inquiry announces itself as the most serious, for it concerns human actions: a subject that immediately concerns everyone and can be foreign or indifferent to no one. Indeed, it accords so closely with human nature to relate everything else to action that, in any sustained inquiry, people will regard the part concerning action as the result of all its contents, at least insofar as those contents interest them. They will therefore give this part serious attention, even if they have given none to the rest.

In ordinary language one might, in this sense, call the part that now follows “practical philosophy,” as opposed to the theoretical philosophy treated so far. In my view, however, all philosophy is always theoretical. Whatever its immediate subject of investigation, it must essentially maintain a purely contemplative attitude and inquire, not prescribe. The old claims that philosophy should become practical, guide action, or reform character are claims it should at last give up with mature understanding. Where the worth or worthlessness of an existence, salvation or damnation, is at stake, its lifeless concepts do not decide the matter. What decides it is the human being's innermost nature: the daemon who guides him and whom he himself, rather than the daemon, chose, as Plato puts it; his intelligible character, as Kant calls it. Virtue cannot be taught, any more than genius can. Concepts are as barren for virtue as for art, and can be used only as tools. We would be as foolish to expect our moral systems and ethics to produce virtuous, noble people and saints as to expect our aesthetics to produce poets, sculptors, and musicians.

Philosophy can do no more anywhere than interpret and explain what exists. It can bring before reason, in clear abstract knowledge, the essence of the world that speaks intelligibly to everyone *in concreto* (in the concrete), that is, as

feeling, and do so in every possible relation and from every standpoint. The preceding three books sought to do this from other standpoints, with the generality proper to philosophy. This book will likewise consider human action—perhaps the most important side of the world not only in subjective estimation, as I remarked above, but also by objective judgment. I shall remain wholly faithful to the method used so far and rely on what has already been established. In fact, I shall do no more than develop in relation to human action the one thought that forms the content of this whole work, as I have developed it in relation to every other subject. This is the last thing I can do to communicate that thought as fully as possible.

The standpoint and method announced here should already make clear that this ethical book will contain no prescriptions or doctrine of duties, still less a universal moral principle, a recipe for producing every virtue. Nor shall we speak of an “*unconditional ought*,” which, as explained in the appendix, is a contradiction, or of a “law for freedom,” which contains the same contradiction. We shall not speak of an ought at all. That is how one speaks to children and to peoples in their childhood, not to those who have acquired the full cultivation of an adult age. It is surely a palpable contradiction to call the will free and yet prescribe laws according to which it *ought to will*: “ought to will”—wooden iron!

According to our whole view, the will is not only free but even omnipotent. Not only its action but its world proceeds from it. As it is, so its action appears and so its world appears. Both are its self-knowledge and nothing else. It determines itself and thereby determines both, for nothing exists outside it, and they are the will itself. Only thus is it truly autonomous; on every other view it is heteronomous. Our philosophical effort can aim only to interpret and explain human action and the widely different, even opposed, maxims of which it is the living expression. We must explain their innermost nature and content in connection with the inquiry so far, just as we have tried to interpret the other appearances of the world and bring their innermost essence to clear, abstract cognition.

Here our philosophy will maintain the same *immanence* as before. Contrary to Kant's great teaching, it will not use the forms of appearance, whose general expression is the principle of sufficient reason, as a pole vault over appearance itself—the only thing that gives those forms meaning—and land in a boundless realm of empty inventions. This actual world of what can be known, in which we exist and which exists in us, remains both the material and the limit of our

inquiry. It is so rich that even the deepest investigation of which the human mind is capable could not exhaust it.

The real, knowable world will supply our ethical inquiry, as it supplied the preceding inquiries, with more than enough substance and reality. We need not seek refuge in empty, negative concepts and then persuade ourselves that we have said something when we speak with raised eyebrows of “the Absolute,” “the Infinite,” “the Supersensible,” and similar bare negations: οὐδέν ἐστι, ἢ τὸ τῆς στερήσεως ὄνομα, μετὰ ἀμυδρᾶς ἐπινοίας—*nihil est, nisi negationis nomen, cum obscura notione*. Jul. or. 5 (it is nothing but the name of a negation accompanied by a dim conception; Julian, Oration 5). We could say “Cloud-cuckoo-land” (νεφελοκοκκυγία) more briefly. We shall not serve up such covered, empty dishes.

Nor shall we tell stories here any more than before and pass them off as philosophy. In our view, anyone who thinks the world's essence can be grasped *historically*, however subtly disguised the historical account may be, remains immeasurably far from philosophical knowledge of the world. This is so whenever a view of the world as it is in itself includes any *becoming*, having-become, or future becoming, or whenever “before” or “after” has the slightest significance. It then seeks and finds, openly or covertly, a beginning and an end of the world and a path between them, and the philosopher may even locate himself on that path.

Such *historical philosophizing* usually produces a cosmogony, which admits many varieties. It may also produce a system of emanation or a doctrine of falling away. Driven to a final path by despair over the failure of those attempts, it may reverse them and teach perpetual becoming, sprouting, arising, and emergence into light from darkness, from a dark ground, original ground, groundless ground, and more such babble. The shortest reply is that an entire eternity—an infinite time—has already passed before the present moment. Everything that can and is supposed to become must therefore have become already.

For all such historical philosophy, however grandly it behaves, takes *time* to be a determination of things in themselves, as if Kant had never existed. It thus remains with what Kant calls appearance as opposed to the thing in itself, what Plato calls that which becomes but never is as opposed to that which is but never becomes, or what Indians call the veil of Maya. This is cognition governed by the principle of sufficient reason. It never reaches the inner essence

of things; it only pursues appearances without end, moving without goal like a squirrel in a wheel. Eventually, perhaps, the thinker tires, stops at an arbitrary point above or below, and then tries to force others to respect it.

The genuine philosophical way of regarding the world teaches us to know its inner essence and thus leads beyond appearance. It asks not where the world comes from, where it goes, or why, but always and everywhere *what* it is. It does not consider things by any relation, as becoming and passing away, or according to one of the four forms of the principle of sufficient reason. Instead it takes as its subject precisely what remains when every mode of inquiry following that principle has been set aside: the world's ever-identical essence, which appears in all relations but is itself subject to none of them—its Ideas. This cognition is the source of art and philosophy alike. As we shall find in this book, it is also the source of the state of mind that alone leads to true holiness and redemption from the world.

§. 54.

The first three books have, I hope, brought us to clear and certain knowledge that, in the world as representation, the will has acquired a mirror in which it knows itself with increasing degrees of clarity and completeness. The highest degree is the human being, whose nature finds its full expression only in the connected sequence of actions. Reason makes their self-conscious connection possible by allowing a person always to survey the whole *in abstracto* (in the abstract).

Viewed purely in itself, the will is without cognition and is only a blind, irresistible drive. We still see it appearing in inorganic and plant nature and their laws, as well as in the vegetative part of our own lives. Through the world as representation, added to it and developed for its service, it gains knowledge of its own willing and of what it wills: nothing other than this world, life exactly as it is. This is why we called the world of appearance its mirror, its objecthood. What the will wills is always life, since life is simply the presentation of that willing in representation. Thus to say “the will to live” rather than “the will” is to say the same thing, and is merely a pleonasm.

The will is the thing in itself, the inner content and essence of the world, while life, the visible world, appearance, is only its mirror. Life will therefore accompany the will as inseparably as a shadow accompanies a body: wherever there is will, there will be life and world. Life is thus certain for the will to live. So long as we are filled with the will to live, we need not be anxious for our existence, even at the sight of death.

Certainly we see the individual arise and pass away. But the individual is only an appearance, existing only for cognition bound to the principle of sufficient reason and the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation). For this cognition the individual receives life as a gift, comes from nothing, then loses that gift through death and returns to nothing. Yet we intend to regard life philosophically, according to its Ideas. We shall then find that neither the will, the thing in itself in every appearance, nor the subject of cognition, spectator of every appearance, is touched by birth or death.

Birth and death belong to the will's appearance, and thus to life. Life essentially presents itself in individuals that arise and pass away, fleeting appearances entering the form of time of something that knows no time in itself but must present itself thus to objectivate its true nature. Birth and death belong

equally to life. They balance one another as mutual conditions, or, if one prefers the expression, as the poles of life's entire appearance.

Indian mythology, the wisest of all, expresses this by giving the god who symbolizes destruction and death—Shiva—the *lingam*, a symbol of generation, along with his necklace of skulls. Brahma, the most sinful and lowest god of the Trimurti, symbolizes generation and coming into being, while Vishnu symbolizes preservation. Generation thus appears as a counterweight to death, indicating that the two are essential correlates, mutually neutralizing and cancelling one another.

The Greeks and Romans were moved by precisely the same outlook when they decorated costly sarcophagi, as we still see, with festivals, dances, weddings, hunts, animal combats, and bacchanals: depictions of the most vigorous urge to live. They showed it not only in festivities but in sensual groups, even in unions between satyrs and goats. Plainly their aim was to point emphatically, from the death of the individual being mourned, to nature's immortal life. Without abstract knowledge, they thus intimated that all nature is the appearance and fulfilment of the will to live.

The form of this appearance is time, space, and causality. These bring about individuation and therefore require the individual to arise and pass away. But this affects the will to live, of whose appearance an individual is just one instance or specimen, no more than an individual's death injures nature as a whole. Nature cares for the species alone, not the individual. It presses with utmost seriousness to preserve the species, providing for it lavishly through a vast excess of seeds and the powerful urge to fertilize. The individual has no value for nature and cannot have it, since her realm comprises infinite time and space and thus an infinite number of possible individuals. She is always ready to let an individual fall. It is exposed to destruction in a thousand ways through the slightest accidents, and indeed is destined for it from the outset. Nature herself leads it toward death as soon as it has served to preserve the species.

Quite plainly nature thereby speaks the great truth that only the Ideas, not individuals, have true reality: they alone are the complete objecthood of the will. The human being is nature herself at the highest degree of her self-consciousness, and nature is only the objectivated will to live. Someone who has grasped this standpoint and remains with it can therefore rightly console himself for his own death and the deaths of friends by looking back to nature's immortal life, which is himself. We should understand Shiva with the

lingam and the ancient sarcophagi in this way. Through their images of life at its most ardent, the sarcophagi call to the grieving viewer: *Natura non contristatur* (Nature does not grieve).

Generation and death belong to life and are essential to this appearance of the will. We can see this also because both are intensified expressions of what makes up all the rest of life. Life is nothing but a constant exchange of matter while form persists. This is precisely the transience of individuals and the permanence of the species. Continual nutrition and reproduction differ from generation only in degree, and continual excretion differs from death only in degree.

This is simplest and clearest in the plant. It is wholly a constant repetition of the same drive, of its simplest fibre grouped into leaf and branch. It is a systematic aggregate of similar plants supporting one another, whose sole drive is to reproduce themselves continually. By ascending the stages of metamorphosis, the plant finally reaches flower and fruit for the fullest satisfaction of this drive. The fruit is the compendium of its existence and striving. By a shorter path it now achieves its sole end, performing a thousandfold in one stroke what it had previously done individually: repeating itself. The plant's activity leading to fruit is related to the fruit as writing is to printing.

The animal plainly shows the same thing. Nutrition is continual generation; generation is nutrition raised to a higher power. Sexual pleasure is the intensified well-being of the feeling of life. Conversely, excretion—the continual breathing out and casting off of matter—is the same thing raised to a higher power as death, the opposite of generation. We are always content to retain the form without mourning the matter cast off. We should therefore respond in the same way when, at death, the same process occurs in a heightened form and as a whole that takes place daily and hourly in individual acts of excretion. As we are indifferent to the latter, we ought not recoil from the former.

From this standpoint, demanding the continuation of one's individuality, which other individuals replace, is as misguided as demanding that the matter of one's body remain, though it is constantly replaced by new matter. Embalming corpses seems as foolish as carefully preserving one's excretions. Individual consciousness bound to an individual body is completely interrupted by sleep every day. During its duration deep sleep does not differ from death, into which

it often passes seamlessly—as when someone freezes to death. The difference lies only in the future, namely waking. Death is a sleep in which individuality is forgotten. Everything else wakes again—or rather, has remained awake.^[1]

Above all we must clearly recognize that the form of the will's appearance, thus the form of life or reality, is properly only the *present*, not the future or the past. These exist only in concepts, only in the connections made by cognition insofar as it follows the principle of sufficient reason. No human being has lived in the past, nor will anyone ever live in the future. The *present* alone is the form of all life. It is also life's secure possession and can never be taken away. The present and its content are always there, standing firm without wavering, like the rainbow over a waterfall. Life is sure and certain for the will, and the present for life.

When we think back over past millennia and the millions who lived in them, we ask: What were they? What became of them? But we need only recall our own past and vividly renew its scenes in imagination, then ask again: What was all that? What became of it? What holds for our past holds for the lives of those millions. Should we suppose the past gains a new existence because death has sealed it? Our own past, even the recent past of yesterday, is now only an empty dream of the imagination; so is the past of all those millions. What was? What is? The will, whose mirror is life, and cognition free of the will, which sees it clearly in that mirror.

Anyone who has not recognized this, or refuses to recognize it, must add another question to the one about the fate of past generations. Why is he, the questioner, so fortunate as to possess this precious, fleeting, sole real present, while hundreds of earlier generations, including their heroes and sages, have sunk into the night of the past and become nothing? Why does his insignificant self really exist? Or, more briefly, though strangely: why is this “now,” his now, *now*, and not long since *past*? In asking so strangely he treats his existence and his time as independent and imagines the former thrown into the latter. He effectively assumes two nows, one belonging to the object and one to the subject, and marvels at the fortunate accident of their meeting.

In truth, as shown in my essay on the principle of sufficient reason, only the point of contact between the object, whose form is time, and the subject, which has no form of the principle of sufficient reason, constitutes the present. Every object, however, is the will insofar as it has become representation, and the subject is the object's necessary correlate. Real objects exist only in the present.

The past and future contain merely concepts and phantoms. Thus the present is the essential form of the will's appearance and cannot be separated from it. The present alone is always there and stands immovably firm. Under empirical consideration it is the most fleeting of all things. To the metaphysical gaze that looks beyond the forms of empirical intuition, it proves the only enduring thing: the Scholastics' *Nunc stans* (standing now, or eternal present). The source and bearer of its content is the will to live, the thing in itself—which we are.

Whatever continually becomes and passes away because it either has been or is yet to come belongs to appearance as such. Its forms make arising and passing away possible. So let us think: *Quid fuit?* – *Quod est.* – *Quid erit?* – *Quod fuit* (What was? What is. What will be? What was). Take the words strictly: understand not *simile* (the similar) but *idem* (the same). Life is certain for the will, and the present for life. Everyone can therefore say: “I am master of the present once and for all, and it will accompany me through all eternity like my shadow. I need not wonder where it has come from or how it happens to exist just now.”

We can compare time with a wheel turning endlessly. The half continually descending would be the past, the half continually rising the future; but at the top the indivisible point touching the tangent would be the present without extension. The tangent does not roll along with the wheel; neither does the present. It is the point of contact between the object, whose form is time, and the subject, which has no form because it does not belong to what can be known, but is the condition of everything knowable. Or time is like an irresistible stream and the present a rock against which it breaks without carrying the rock away.

The will as thing in itself is no more subject to the principle of sufficient reason than is the subject of cognition, which in a certain respect is ultimately the will itself or its expression. As life, its own appearance, is certain for the will, so is the present, the only form of actual life. We should therefore inquire neither into the past before life nor into the future after death. Instead we must recognize the *present* as the sole form in which the will appears to itself.^[2] The present will not escape the will, nor, indeed, will the will escape the present.

Anyone satisfied with life as it is, who affirms it in every way, may confidently regard it as endless. Such a person can banish the fear of death as an illusion suggesting the absurd fear that the present could ever be lost, or imagining a time with no present in it. With respect to time this illusion

resembles another about space: each person imagines the place on earth he now occupies as “above” and all the rest as “below.” In the same way each connects the present to his own individuality, supposing that all present time would end with it, leaving a past and future without a present. Yet every point on earth is “above,” and the form of all life is *present*. To fear death because it takes the present away is no wiser than fearing that one might slide off the spherical earth on whose upper surface one happens fortunately to stand.

The present is essential to the will's objectivation. Like a point without extension, it cuts infinite time in both directions and stands still, an everlasting noon without a cooling evening. The actual sun likewise burns without cease and only seems to sink into night's lap. Hence a person fearing death as annihilation is like someone who imagines the sun lamenting at sunset: “Alas, I am sinking into eternal night!”^[3]

Conversely, consider someone burdened by life, who wants and affirms life but detests its torments, and in particular can no longer bear the harsh fate that has fallen to him. Such a person must not hope for release through death and cannot save himself by suicide. The dark, cool underworld lures him toward a harbour of rest only by a false appearance. The earth turns from day into night; the individual dies; but the sun itself burns on at eternal noon. Life is certain for the will to live, and life's form is a present without end, no matter how individuals, appearances of the Idea, arise and pass away in time like fleeting dreams. Suicide therefore already appears to us here as a futile and thus foolish act. Later in our inquiry it will appear in a still less favourable light.

Dogmas change and our knowledge is fallible, but nature does not err. Her course is sure, and she does not conceal it. Everything exists wholly within her, and she is wholly within everything. She has her centre in every animal. It found its way into existence securely and will as securely find its way out. Meanwhile it lives without fear of annihilation or anxiety, borne up by consciousness that it is nature herself and is as imperishable as she is. Only the human being carries certainty of death around in abstract concepts. Strangely, that certainty can trouble him only at particular moments, when some occasion brings it before his imagination. Reflection can do little against nature's powerful voice.

As in the animal that does not think, there prevails in the human being a lasting confidence arising from innermost consciousness that he is nature, the world itself. Consequently the thought of certain and never distant death does

not markedly trouble anyone; each lives as though he would live forever. One might even say that no one has a truly vivid conviction of the certainty of his own death. Otherwise there could not be such a wide difference between his state of mind and that of a condemned criminal. Everyone admits this certainty *in abstracto* (in the abstract), theoretically, but sets it aside like other theoretical truths not applicable in practice, never taking it into living consciousness. Anyone who carefully observes this trait of the human mind will see that psychological explanations appealing to habit or acceptance of the inevitable are insufficient. Its reason lies deeper, as just stated.

This also explains why doctrines of some continuation of the individual after death are found and held in honour among every people in every age. The proofs for them have always had to be highly inadequate, while the proofs of the contrary are strong and numerous. Indeed, the contrary needs no proof: sound understanding recognizes it as a fact. This recognition is confirmed by confidence that nature neither lies nor errs, but openly displays and even ingenuously declares her conduct and nature. It is we ourselves who obscure them through delusion, interpreting them to suit our limited view.

We have now brought something else clearly to consciousness. An individual appearance of the will begins and ends in time, but neither the will itself as thing in itself nor the correlate of every object—the knowing subject, never itself known—is affected by this. Life is always certain for the will to live. This is not, however, to be counted among doctrines of personal survival. Considered as thing in itself, the will, like the pure subject of cognition, the eternal eye of the world, neither persists nor passes away. These are determinations valid only in time, whereas will and pure subject lie outside time.

The individual's egoism—the egoism of this particular appearance of the will illuminated by the subject of cognition—therefore gains no support or comfort for its wish to endure through infinite time from our view. It gains as little as it would from knowing that the rest of the external world will continue in time after its death. That is only the same view expressed objectively, hence under the form of time. Everyone is transient as appearance, but timeless and therefore without end as thing in itself. Yet only as appearance is one distinct from the other things in the world. As thing in itself each is the will that appears in everything. Death cancels the illusion separating one's consciousness from the consciousness of others: *this* is continuance. One's immunity to death

belongs only to oneself as thing in itself. As appearance it coincides with the continuation of the rest of the external world.^[4]

The inward, merely felt consciousness of what we have just made explicit prevents the thought of death from poisoning the life even of a rational being. It is the basis of the courage to live that sustains every living thing and lets it go on briskly as though there were no death, so long as its eyes are on life. But this does not prevent the individual from being seized by the fear of death and trying by every means to escape when death approaches in an individual, actual case, or even in imagination, and it must look death in the face. So long as its cognition was directed toward life as such, it had to recognize life's imperishability. With death before it, however, it must recognize death for what it is: the temporal end of an individual, temporal appearance.

What we fear in death is by no means pain. Pain plainly lies on this side of death. We also often flee from pain toward death, just as, conversely, we sometimes accept the most terrible pain to escape death a little longer, even when death would be quick and easy. We distinguish pain and death as two quite different evils. What we actually fear in death is the destruction of the individual, which it openly announces. Since the individual is the will to live itself in one particular objectivation, its whole being resists death.

Where feeling abandons us helplessly in this way, reason can intervene and largely overcome its adverse impressions. It raises us to a higher standpoint from which we see the whole rather than the individual. A philosophical understanding of the world's essence that reached the point of our inquiry so far but went no further could already overcome the terrors of death to the extent that reflection had power over immediate feeling in a given person.

Imagine someone who had firmly incorporated the truths explained so far into his disposition but had not, through personal experience or deeper insight, come to recognize enduring suffering as essential to every life. Suppose he found satisfaction in life and felt wholly at ease in it. On calm reflection he would wish his life as he had known it to last endlessly or recur forever. His courage for life would be great enough for him gladly to accept all its hardships and pain in exchange for its pleasures. Such a person would stand "with firm, sturdy bones upon the well-rounded, enduring earth" and have nothing to fear. Armed with the knowledge we attribute to him, he would look indifferently at death approaching on the wings of time. He would regard it as a false appearance, a powerless spectre that frightens the weak but has no power over

someone who knows himself to be the will whose objectivation or image is the whole world. Life, and with it the present—the true, sole form of the will's appearance—remains certain for him. Neither the infinite past nor the infinite future in which he is absent could frighten him: he sees them as the empty illusion and veil of Maya. He would have as little reason to fear death as the sun has to fear the night.

In the *Bhagavad Gita*, Krishna places his young pupil Arjuna at this standpoint. At the sight of the armies ready for battle, Arjuna is overcome with sorrow, somewhat as Xerxes was. He loses courage and wishes to withdraw from the fight to prevent the deaths of so many thousands. Krishna gives him the higher standpoint; the deaths of those thousands no longer stop him, and he signals the battle to begin. Goethe's Prometheus also expresses this standpoint, especially when he says:

“Here I sit and fashion people
In my own image,
A race to be like me:
To suffer and to weep,
To enjoy and rejoice,
And to pay no heed to you,
As I do!”

Bruno's and Spinoza's philosophies could also lead someone to this standpoint, provided their errors and imperfections did not disturb or weaken his conviction. Bruno's has no ethics proper. The ethics in Spinoza's philosophy does not follow from the essence of his teaching; although praiseworthy and beautiful in itself, it is attached to it only by weak and obvious sophisms. Many people, finally, would occupy this standpoint if their cognition kept pace with their willing: if, free of every delusion, they could see themselves clearly. For cognition, this is the standpoint of the complete *affirmation of the will to live*.

The will affirms itself when its own essence is given to it completely and clearly as representation in its objecthood, the world and life, and this cognition in no way checks its willing. It wills the life thus known as such: until now blindly, as mere drive, and now with cognition, consciously and reflectively. The opposite, the *denial of the will to live*, occurs when willing ceases upon such cognition. Individual appearances known to it no longer act as *motives* for willing. Rather, the entire cognition of the world's essence that has grown from

apprehending the *Ideas* mirrors the will and becomes its *quietive*. The will thus freely cancels itself.

These notions, unfamiliar and hardly intelligible in such general language, will, I hope, become clear in the account soon to follow of the phenomena—here, modes of action—in which affirmation at its several degrees and denial find expression. Both arise from *cognition*, but not from an abstract cognition expressed in words. It is a living cognition expressed only in deeds and conduct, independent of the doctrines that occupy reason as abstract knowledge. My sole aim is to present both and bring them to clear rational cognition, not to prescribe or recommend either. Such advice would be as foolish as it would be fruitless, since the will in itself is absolutely free and determines itself entirely on its own; there is no law for it. Before turning to this account, however, we must discuss and define this *freedom* and its relation to necessity more precisely. We must also make a few general observations about life—whose affirmation and denial are our problem—with reference to the will and its objects. This will help us understand the innermost ethical significance of different modes of action.

As I have said, this whole work unfolds a single thought. It follows that all its parts are most intimately connected. Each does not merely stand in a necessary relation to the part immediately preceding it and presuppose that part to be fresh in the reader's mind, as happens in philosophies consisting only of a sequence of deductions. Every part of the work is related to and presupposes every other. Readers must therefore remember not only what immediately precedes but everything earlier as well, so that they can connect it to the present point however much else intervenes. Plato made a similar demand on readers through the winding paths of his dialogues, which return to the principal thought only after long episodes, illuminating it thereby. Here the demand is necessary. Dividing our single thought into many inquiries was the only way to communicate it, but belongs not essentially to the thought itself; it is an artificial form.

The division into four chief viewpoints in four books, and the most careful linking of related and homogeneous matters, help the exposition and its understanding. The material nevertheless does not permit progress in a straight line, as a historical account does. It requires a more interwoven presentation and thus repeated study of the book. Only then does the connection of each part with every other become clear, and all the parts illuminate one another and become fully intelligible.^[5]

Notes

Notes

1. The following reflection may help someone who does not find it too subtle to see clearly that the individual is only appearance, not the thing in itself. Every individual is, on one side, the subject of cognition, the complementary condition making the entire objective world possible, and on the other, an individual appearance of the will, the same will that objectivates itself in everything. Yet this double aspect of our nature does not rest on a unity existing by itself. Otherwise we could be conscious of ourselves *in ourselves and independently of objects of cognition and willing*. We cannot do this at all. As soon as we turn inward to try it, direct cognition within, and seek to reflect fully on ourselves for once, we lose ourselves in a bottomless void. We find ourselves like a hollow glass sphere from whose empty interior a voice speaks, though its source cannot be found there. Trying to grasp ourselves, we catch with a shudder only a phantom without substance. ↩

2. Scholastici docuerunt, quod aeternitas non sit temporis sine fine aut principio successio; sed Nunc stans; i. e. idem nobis Nunc esse, quod erat Nunc Adamo: i. e. inter nunc et tunc nullam esse differentiam. Hobbes, *Leviathan*, c. 46. Translation: The Scholastics taught that eternity is not a succession of time without beginning or end, but a standing now; that our now is the same as Adam's now, and that there is no difference between now and then. Hobbes, *Leviathan*, chapter 46. ↩

3. In Eckermann's *Conversations with Goethe* (second edition, vol. 1, p. 154), Goethe says: "Our spirit is a being of quite indestructible nature. It continues to act from eternity to eternity. It resembles the sun, which only seems to set to our earthly eyes, but in fact never sets and shines on without interruption." Goethe took the comparison from me, not I from him. He undoubtedly used it in this conversation of 1824 through a perhaps unconscious recollection of the passage above. It appears with the same words in the first edition, p. 401, and recurs on p. 528, as it does here at the end of § 65. That first edition was sent to him in December 1818. In March 1819, while I was in Naples, he sent word of his approval by letter through my sister, enclosing a slip on which he had noted the page numbers of passages that particularly pleased him. He had thus read my book. ↩

4. The Veda expresses this by saying that when someone dies, the power of sight becomes one with the sun, smell with the earth, taste with water, hearing with air, speech with fire, and so on (*Oupnek'hat*, vol. 1, p. 249 ff.). It also expresses it in a special ceremony in which the dying person transfers the senses and all capacities, one by one, to a son in whom they are to live on (*ibid.*, vol. 2, p. 82 ff.). ↩

5. See chapters 41–44 of the second volume. ↩

§. 55.

The will as such is *free*, as follows already from our view that it is the thing in itself, the content of every appearance. Appearances, by contrast, are subject throughout to the principle of sufficient reason in its four forms. Necessity is simply the relation of a consequent to a given ground; the two are reciprocal concepts. Everything belonging to appearance—that is, everything that is an object for a subject knowing as an individual—is therefore a ground in one respect and a consequent in another. As a consequent it is necessarily determined throughout and cannot in any respect be otherwise than it is. All of nature and all its appearances are thus wholly necessary. We can demonstrate the necessity of every part, appearance, and event by finding the ground on which it depends as a consequent. There is no exception; this follows from the unrestricted validity of the principle of sufficient reason.

Yet we also know this same world in all its appearances as the objecthood of the will. The will itself is no appearance, representation, or object, but the thing in itself. It is therefore not subject to the principle of sufficient reason, the form of every object, and is not determined as a consequent by a ground. It knows no necessity: it is *free*. Freedom is thus properly a negative concept. Its content is merely the denial of necessity, the relation of consequent to ground governed by the principle of sufficient reason. Here the point of unity in that great opposition, the union of freedom and necessity, lies most clearly before us. This has often been discussed recently but, so far as I know, never clearly or properly.

Every thing as appearance, as object, is necessary throughout. That same thing *in itself* is will, wholly free for all eternity. Appearance is necessarily and unalterably determined in the unbroken chain of grounds and consequents. Yet the existence of the object in general and the kind of existence it has—the Idea revealed in it, or, in other words, its character—are immediate appearances of the will. In keeping with the will's freedom, the object might not exist at all, or might originally and essentially be quite different. In that case the entire chain of which it is a link, itself an appearance of the same will, would also be different. Once it exists, however, it has entered the series of grounds and consequents. It is always necessarily determined within it and can therefore neither become something else, that is, change, nor leave the series, that is, disappear.

Like every other part of nature, the human being is objecthood of the will, so everything just said applies to him. Each thing in nature has forces and qualities that respond in definite ways to definite influences and make up its character. A human being likewise has a *character*, from which motives necessarily elicit actions. His empirical character reveals itself in this mode of action, and his intelligible character in turn reveals itself in the empirical character. The latter is the will in itself, of which he is the determinate appearance.

But the human being is the most complete appearance of the will. As shown in Book Two, it could exist only if illuminated by such a high degree of cognition that cognition could even reproduce the world's essence in a fully adequate way under the form of representation: the apprehension of Ideas, the pure mirror of the world, which we met in Book Three. In the human being, therefore, the will can reach complete self-consciousness, a clear and exhaustive cognition of its own essence as reflected in the whole world. The actual presence of this degree of cognition gives rise to art, as we saw in the preceding book.

At the end of our inquiry we shall find that the same cognition can also make the will cancel and deny itself in its most complete appearance when it turns that cognition upon itself. Freedom, which otherwise belongs only to the thing in itself and can never appear, then emerges even in appearance. It cancels the essence underlying the appearance while the appearance itself continues in time. This produces a contradiction within appearance and thereby presents the phenomena of holiness and self-denial. All this can be fully understood only at the end of this book. For now it indicates in general how human beings differ from all other appearances of the will. Freedom—independence from the principle of sufficient reason—belongs only to the will as thing in itself and contradicts appearance. Yet in a human being it can possibly enter appearance, necessarily showing itself there as a contradiction within appearance. In this sense not only the will in itself but even the human being can be called free and distinguished from all other beings. What this means will become clear only from what follows; for now we must set it aside.

First we must prevent the mistake of thinking that an individual person's actions lack necessity, as though the force of a motive were less certain than that of a cause or than a conclusion following from premises. Apart from the exceptional case just mentioned, the freedom of the will as thing in itself does not pass directly to its appearance, even at its highest grade of visibility: the rational animal with an individual character, or the person. A person is never

free, although the appearance of a free will. For the person is the already determined appearance of that will's free willing. Entering the form of every object, the principle of sufficient reason, it develops the unity of willing into a multitude of actions. Yet because willing in itself is one and outside time, those actions appear with the regularity of a natural force.

Nevertheless, it is that free willing that becomes visible in the person and his whole conduct, related to it as a concept is to its definition. Every individual act must therefore be attributed to the free will and announces itself immediately to consciousness as such. Hence, as noted in Book Two, each person holds himself free *a priori* (here, in his original feeling) even in individual actions, believing that any action is possible to him in a given case. Only *a posteriori* (after experience), by experience and reflection on it, does he recognize that his actions arise entirely of necessity from the meeting of character with motives. This is why even the crudest person, following feeling, vehemently defends complete freedom in individual actions, while the great thinkers of every age, and even the more profound religious doctrines, have denied it.

Once someone understands that a human being's whole essence is will and that he is only an appearance of it, while the principle of sufficient reason is the necessary form of appearance, knowable even from the subject's standpoint and here taking the form of the law of motivation, he will no more doubt that an act follows inevitably from a given character and motive than he will doubt that a triangle's angles sum to two right angles. Priestley has demonstrated the necessity of individual action very adequately in his *Doctrine of Philosophical Necessity*. Kant, whose achievement here is especially great, was the first to demonstrate how this necessity coexists with the freedom of the will in itself, outside appearance.^[1] He distinguished intelligible from empirical character, a distinction I retain completely. Intelligible character is the will as thing in itself insofar as it appears at a definite grade in a definite individual. Empirical character is that appearance itself as it shows itself in conduct over time, and already in bodily organization in space.

The clearest way to understand their relation is the formulation used in the introductory essay: each person's intelligible character should be regarded as an act of will outside time, thus indivisible and unchangeable. Empirical character is its appearance unfolded and spread out in time, space, and all the forms of the principle of sufficient reason, as experience shows it in a person's conduct and life course. The whole tree is only the constantly repeated appearance of a single drive, appearing most simply in the fibre and repeated recognizably in

combinations as leaf, stem, branch, and trunk. Likewise all a person's deeds are the repeatedly expressed intelligible character, varying somewhat in form. An induction from their sum gives us his empirical character. I shall not rework and repeat Kant's masterly account here; I assume it is known.

In 1840 I treated the important question of freedom of the will thoroughly and at length in my prize-winning essay on it. In particular, I uncovered the source of the illusion that makes people think they find in self-consciousness an empirically given absolute freedom of the will, a *liberum arbitrium indifferentiae* (freedom to choose indifferently), as a fact of consciousness. The prize question had perceptively focused on just this point. I refer readers to that essay and to § 10 of my prize essay on the basis of morality, published with it under the title *Two Fundamental Problems of Ethics*. I now omit the still imperfect account of the necessity of acts of will given here in the first edition. Instead I shall briefly clarify the illusion just mentioned. This clarification presupposes chapter 19 of our second volume and could therefore not be given in the prize essay.

The will as the true thing in itself is genuinely original and independent. A feeling of originality and one's own power must therefore accompany its acts in self-consciousness, even though these acts are already determined there. Apart from that, the appearance of an *empirical* freedom of the will—a freedom of individual acts—in place of the *transcendental* freedom that alone belongs to it arises from the intellect's separate and subordinate position relative to the will. This was explained in chapter 19 of the second volume, especially under point 3.

The intellect learns the will's decisions only *a posteriori*, empirically. When faced with a choice, therefore, it has no data telling it how the will will decide. The intelligible character, by virtue of which only *one* decision is possible and necessary under given motives, is not available to the intellect's cognition. It learns the empirical character only successively through individual acts. To knowing consciousness, the intellect, two opposed decisions thus seem equally possible for the will in a given case. This is like saying of an upright rod that has lost its balance and begun to waver, "It can fall to the right or to the left." That *can* has only a subjective meaning: "as far as our data show." Objectively, the direction of the fall is necessarily determined as soon as the wavering begins.

Similarly, a decision of one's own will is undetermined only for its observer, one's own intellect. It is undetermined only relatively and subjectively, for the subject of cognition. In itself and objectively, the decision is determined and necessary as soon as any choice arises. Only the resulting decision brings this determination into consciousness. We even have empirical evidence of this when faced with a difficult, important choice that depends on a condition not yet fulfilled but merely hoped for. We can do nothing for the present and must remain passive. We then consider what we will decide once circumstances permit action and decision.

Far-sighted rational reflection usually favours one decision, while immediate inclination favours the other. So long as we must remain passive, reason seems likely to prevail, yet we foresee how strongly the other side will pull once there is an opportunity to act. Meanwhile we strive, through cool consideration of the *pro et contra* (for and against), to bring the opposing motives into the clearest light. We want each to act with its full force on the will when the moment arrives, so that an error by the intellect does not lead the will to decide differently than it would if everything acted upon it equally. This clear development of opposed motives is all the intellect can do in a choice. It awaits the actual decision passively, with the same tense curiosity with which it would await a stranger's decision. From its standpoint both decisions must appear equally possible. This is precisely the appearance of empirical freedom of the will.

The decision enters the intellect's sphere empirically, as the matter's eventual outcome. Yet it has arisen with complete necessity from the inner constitution, the intelligible character, of the individual will in conflict with given motives. The intellect can do no more than illuminate the motives fully and sharply from every side. It cannot determine the will itself, which is wholly inaccessible to it and, as we have seen, inscrutable.

If a person could act one way at one time and another way at another time under identical circumstances, the will itself would have had to change in between, and so would have to lie in time, where alone change is possible. Either the will would then be a mere appearance, or time would be a determination of the thing in itself. The dispute over freedom in individual action, over *liberum arbitrium indifferentiae* (indifferent freedom of choice), thus turns on whether the will lies in time. If, as Kant's teaching and my whole account require, it is the thing in itself, outside time and every form of the principle of sufficient reason, then an individual must always act the same way

in the same situation. Each evil act is a firm guarantee of countless others that the person *must* commit and *cannot* omit. As Kant says, if the empirical character and the motives were given completely, a person's future conduct could be calculated like an eclipse of the sun or moon.

Character is as consistent as nature. Every individual act must come from it as each natural phenomenon comes from natural law. A cause in the latter case and a motive in the former are only occasional causes, as Book Two showed. The will, whose appearance is a person's entire being and life, cannot deny itself in a particular case. What the person wills as a whole, he will also always will in the particular.

The claim of empirical freedom of the will, a *liberum arbitrium indifferentiae*, is closely connected with placing human nature in a *soul* conceived as originally a *knowing* being, indeed an abstractly *thinking* one, and only consequently a *willing* being. This makes the will secondary when in truth cognition is secondary. The will was even treated as an act of thought and identified with judgment, particularly by Descartes and Spinoza. On that view, a person becomes what he is only in consequence of his *cognition*. He arrives in the world a moral zero, cognizes things there, and then decides to be one sort of person or another and to act in one way or another. New cognition could lead him to a new mode of conduct and make him a different person again. He would also first cognize something as *good* and then will it, whereas he actually first *wills* it and consequently calls it *good*.

According to my whole fundamental view, all this reverses the true relation. Will is first and original; cognition is only added as an instrument belonging to the will's appearance. Each person is what he is through his will, and his character is original, for willing is the basis of his being. Through the cognition added to it, he learns from experience what he is: he comes to know his character. He *knows* himself as a consequence of and in accord with the constitution of his will. On the old view, by contrast, he *wills* as a consequence of and in accord with his cognition. He would need only consider *how* he would most like to be, and he would be that: this is its freedom of the will. It means that a person is his own work in the light of cognition. I say, however, that he is his own work before all cognition; cognition merely comes afterward to illuminate it. He cannot decide to be this or that kind of person, nor can he become someone else. He *is* once and for all and learns successively *what* he is. On their view he *wills* what he knows; on mine he *knows* what he wills.

The Greeks called character ἦθος (*ethos*), and its expressions, customs, ἥθη. The word derives from ἔθος (habit). They chose it to express the constancy of character metaphorically through the constancy of habit. Aristotle says: Τὸ γὰρ ἦθος ἀπὸ τοῦ ἔθους ἔχει τὴν ἐπωνυμίαν. ἠθικὴ γὰρ καλεῖται διὰ τὸ ἐθίζεσθαι (a voce ἦθος i. e. consuetudo ἦθος est appellatum: ethica ergo dicta est ἀπὸ τοῦ ἐθίζεσθαι, sive ab assuescendo): character is named from habit, and ethics from becoming accustomed (*Magna Moralia*, I, 6, p. 1186; *Eudemian Ethics*, p. 1220; *Nicomachean Ethics*, p. 1103, Bekker edition). Stobaeus quotes the followers of Zeno: οἱ δὲ κατὰ Ζήνωνα τροπικῶς ἦθός ἐστι πηγὴ βίου, ἀφ’ ἧς αἱ κατὰ μέρος πράξεις ρέουσι (Stoici autem, Zenonis castra sequentes, metaphorice ethos definiunt vitae fontem, e quo singulae manant actiones—the Stoics, following Zeno, metaphorically define character as the source of life from which individual actions flow; II, chapter 7).

In Christian doctrine we find predestination resulting from the election and rejection of souls (Romans 9:11–24). It plainly arose from the insight that a human being does not change: his life and conduct, his empirical character, merely unfold the intelligible character. Firm and unchangeable dispositions, already discernible in a child, develop throughout life. Conduct seems therefore to be fixed essentially from birth to death. We agree with this. I will not, however, defend the consequences of joining this sound insight to doctrines found in Jewish religion. That union has produced the greatest difficulty, an eternally insoluble Gordian knot around which most of the Church's disputes turn. Even the apostle Paul can hardly have succeeded with the potter analogy he devised for the purpose, for its result would still be no more than:

“Let humanity fear the gods!
They hold dominion
In eternal hands
And can wield it
As they please.”

Such matters, however, are foreign to our subject. It will be more useful to examine the relation between character and cognition, in which all its motives lie.

Motives determine action, the appearance of character, by acting upon it through cognition. Cognition can change. It often fluctuates between error and truth but is generally corrected more and more as life proceeds, though to very different degrees in different people. A person's conduct can thus change

noticeably without justifying the inference that his character has changed. What the person wills in general, the striving of his innermost being and the goal pursued in accord with it, can never be changed by instruction or external influence. Otherwise we could remake him. Seneca says excellently, *velle non discitur* (willing cannot be taught), preferring truth to his fellow Stoics, who taught *διδασκτὴν εἶναι τὴν ἀρετὴν* (*doceri posse virtutem*—virtue can be taught).

The will can be affected from outside only by motives. But they can never change the will itself. They have power over it only on the assumption that it is exactly as it is. All they can do is change the direction of its striving, making it seek what it unchangeably seeks by a different path. Instruction and improved cognition, as external influences, can teach a person that he has mistaken the means. They can cause him to pursue the end to which his inner nature is already directed by a quite different route or even in a quite different object. They can never make him truly will something other than he has willed before. He remains unchanged, for he is nothing but that willing, which would otherwise have to be cancelled.

Cognition and therefore action are modifiable to a remarkable extent. A person may seek his unchanging end—Mohammed's paradise, for example—first in the actual world and then in an imagined one. He measures his means accordingly, using prudence, force, and deceit in the first case, abstinence, justice, alms, and pilgrimage to Mecca in the second. His striving itself has not changed, still less has he. His actions may therefore look very different at different times while his willing remains quite the same. *Velle non discitur* (willing cannot be taught).

For a motive to be effective it must not merely exist; it must also be *known*. As the Scholastics aptly put it, *causa finalis movet non secundum suum esse reale; sed secundum esse cognitum* (a final cause moves not according to its real being, but according to its being known). If the relation between egoism and compassion in a particular person is to emerge, it is not enough for him to possess wealth and see others' distress. He must know what wealth can do both for himself and for others; suffering must be presented to him, but he must also know what suffering and pleasure are. Perhaps he knew all this less well on a first occasion than on a second. If he acts differently under what seems the same occasion, the circumstances were actually different in the part that depended on his cognition of them.

Just as ignorance deprives real circumstances of their effect, imagined circumstances may act like real ones, not only in a single deception but generally and persistently. Suppose someone is firmly persuaded that every benefit he bestows will be repaid a hundredfold in a future life. Such a belief works like a secure bill payable at a very distant date. He can give out of egoism just as, with different beliefs, he would take out of egoism. He has not changed: *velle non discitur* (willing cannot be taught).

Because cognition influences action so greatly while the will remains unchanged, character develops only gradually and its different traits emerge over time. It therefore appears different at different ages. A wild and violent youth may be followed by a settled and moderate maturity. The evil in a character in particular may become more pronounced with time. Sometimes, however, passions indulged in youth are later restrained voluntarily, simply because opposing motives have only now entered cognition. This is also why all of us are innocent at first: neither we nor others yet know the evil of our own nature. It emerges only with motives, and motives enter cognition only with time. In the end we come to know ourselves as quite different from what we took ourselves to be *a priori*, often to our own horror.

Remorse never arises because the will has changed, which is impossible, but because cognition has changed. I must still will the essential and genuine content of whatever I have ever willed, for I myself am this will, outside time and change. I can therefore never regret what I willed, but can regret what I *did*: guided by false concepts, I acted otherwise than my will called for. Seeing this through more accurate cognition is *remorse*. This applies not only to prudence in life, the choice of means, and judging whether an end suits my real will, but also to ethics proper.

I may, for example, have acted more selfishly than accords with my character because I was misled by an exaggerated view of my own need or of another's cunning, dishonesty, or wickedness. Or I may have acted hastily, without deliberation, moved not by motives clearly known *in abstracto* (in the abstract) but by merely intuitive ones: the immediate impression and the emotion it aroused, so strong that I could not properly use my reason. When reflection returns, cognition is corrected and remorse may follow. It always shows itself by making amends so far as possible. We should note, though, that people deceive themselves by arranging an apparent act of haste that was secretly considered in advance. No one receives our subtler tricks of deceit and flattery than we ourselves do.

The reverse case can also occur. Excessive trust in others, ignorance of the relative worth of life's goods, or an abstract doctrine in which I no longer believe may have led me to act less selfishly than accords with my character, causing a different kind of remorse. Remorse is always corrected cognition of the relation between a deed and the true intention. When the will reveals its Ideas in space alone, through mere form, it encounters resistance from matter already ruled by other Ideas, natural forces. Matter seldom allows the form striving for visibility to emerge completely pure and distinct, that is, beautiful. In an analogous way, when the will reveals itself in time alone, through deeds, it encounters an obstacle in cognition. Cognition seldom supplies the data quite correctly, so a deed fails to correspond exactly to the will and prepares remorse. Remorse thus always arises from corrected cognition, never from a change in the will, which is impossible.

The anguish of conscience over a deed is something quite different from remorse. It is pain at knowing oneself as one is in oneself, that is, as will. It rests precisely on certainty that one still has the same will. Were the will changed, making anguish of conscience mere remorse, that anguish would cancel itself: a past act could no longer trouble us because it would express a will no longer belonging to the person who regrets it. We shall examine the significance of anguish of conscience more fully below.

Cognition, as the medium of motives, influences not the will itself but its emergence in action. This establishes the chief difference between human and animal action, for the modes of cognition differ. Animals have only intuitive representations; through reason, humans also have abstract representations, concepts. Animals and humans are determined by motives with equal necessity. Yet humans have a complete *capacity to choose* that animals lack. This is often mistaken for freedom of the will in individual actions, though it is merely the possibility of a fully fought-out conflict among several motives, the strongest of which then necessarily determines the person.

For such deliberation the motives must take the form of abstract thoughts. Only thus can there be a genuine weighing of opposed grounds for action. An animal can choose only among motives intuitively present, restricting its choice to the narrow sphere of its current intuitive apprehension. The necessity with which a motive determines the will, equal to that with which a cause determines its effect, can therefore be displayed immediately to intuition only in animals: the observer sees motives and effect directly together. Human motives, by contrast, are almost always abstract representations unavailable to an observer.

Even to the acting person their conflict conceals the necessity of their operation. Only *in abstracto* can several representations, as judgments and chains of inference, lie together in consciousness and act on one another free of any fixed temporal order until the strongest overcomes the rest and determines the will.

This is the complete *capacity to choose*, or power of deliberation, that distinguishes humans from animals. It led people to attribute freedom of the will to human beings. They supposed that willing resulted merely from operations of the intellect, without a determinate drive beneath it. In truth, motivation acts only on the basis of and presupposing such a determinate drive, which in a human being is individual: a character. A fuller account of the power of deliberation and the difference it makes between human and animal choice appears in *Two Fundamental Problems of Ethics* (first edition, p. 35 ff.; second edition, p. 33 ff.), to which I refer readers.

This power of deliberation also makes human existence much more tormented than animal existence. Our greatest pains generally lie not in the present, as intuitive representations or immediate feeling, but in reason, as abstract concepts and tormenting thoughts. Animals, living only in the present and therefore in enviable freedom from care, are wholly free of them.

The dependence of human deliberation on thinking *in abstracto*, hence on judging and inferring, seems to have misled Descartes and Spinoza into identifying decisions of the will with the capacity to affirm and deny, the power of judgment. Descartes concluded that the will, indifferent and free in his account, is also responsible for every theoretical error. Spinoza concluded that motives determine the will necessarily, just as grounds determine judgment.^[2] The latter is correct in itself, but emerges as a true conclusion from false premises.

The difference between the ways motives move animals and humans has far-reaching effects on their natures and contributes greatly to the pervasive, obvious difference between their lives. An animal is moved only by an intuitive representation. A human being tries to exclude this kind of motivation altogether and let abstract representations alone determine action. This makes the best possible use of reason's advantage. Independent of the present, one considers the consequences of passing pleasure and pain rather than choosing or avoiding them in themselves. Apart from quite insignificant acts, it is usually abstract, thought-out motives rather than present impressions that determine us.

Hence a single deprivation is fairly easy to bear for the moment, but renunciation is terribly hard. The former concerns only the fleeting present; the latter concerns the future and so contains innumerable deprivations, for which it stands. Our suffering and joy therefore usually have their cause not in the actual present but in abstract thoughts. These often become unbearable and create torments beside which all animal suffering is small. We may not even feel our own physical pain over them. Indeed, amid violent mental suffering we sometimes cause ourselves physical pain simply to draw attention away from the former. In the greatest mental distress people tear out their hair, beat their breasts, scratch their faces, or roll on the ground. These are violent ways of distracting themselves from an unbearable thought.

Because mental pain is so much greater that it dulls physical pain, suicide becomes easy for a person in despair or consumed by morbid despondency, even if the thought made him recoil when he was at ease. Care and passion, the play of thoughts, also wear down the body more often and more severely than physical hardships. Epictetus therefore rightly says: *Ταράσσει τοὺς ἀνθρώπους οὐ τὰ πράγματα, ἀλλὰ τὰ περὶ τῶν πραγμάτων δόγματα* (Perturbant homines non res ipsae, sed de rebus decreta—People are disturbed not by things themselves but by their judgments about things; V). Seneca likewise says: *Plura sunt, quae nos terrent, quam quae premunt, et saepius opinione quam re laboramus* (More things frighten us than oppress us, and we suffer more often from opinion than from reality; letter 5).

Till Eulenspiegel offered an excellent parody of human nature: he laughed while walking uphill but wept while going downhill. Children who have hurt themselves often begin to cry not over the pain but only when someone pities them, because that arouses the thought of pain. Such great differences in action and life flow from the differing modes of cognition in animals and human beings.

The emergence of a distinct and definite individual character, another principal difference between humans and animals, which have almost only a species character, likewise depends on the choice among several motives made possible only by abstract concepts. Only after a choice do decisions that vary among individuals indicate their individual characters. An animal's action depends only on whether an impression is present, assuming it is a motive at all for that species.

In a human being, therefore, only a *decision*, not a mere wish, is a valid sign of character, both to oneself and to others. A decision itself becomes certain only in the deed. A wish is simply the necessary result of a present impression, whether an external stimulus or a passing inner mood. It is as immediate, necessary, and unconsidered as an animal's action. Like that action, it therefore expresses only the species character, not the individual's: it indicates what a *human being in general* could do, not what the *individual* feeling the wish is capable of doing.

The deed alone is a human action requiring some deliberation. A person usually has command of reason and thus acts reflectively, deciding according to abstract motives. The deed expresses the intelligible maxim of conduct, the result of innermost willing. It stands as a letter in the word that spells out empirical character, itself merely the expression in time of intelligible character. In a healthy mind, therefore, deeds alone burden the conscience, not wishes and thoughts. Only our deeds hold up the mirror of our will. An act committed without any reflection in a truly blind passion, mentioned above, lies somewhere between a mere wish and a decision. Genuine remorse, itself manifested in a deed, can therefore erase it from the picture of our will—our life course—like an incorrectly drawn line. One curious comparison may be added: the relation between wish and deed has an accidental but exact analogy to the relation between electrical induction and electrical transmission.

This whole discussion of freedom and its related questions leads to the following conclusion. The will in itself, outside appearance, may be called free and even omnipotent. Yet in its individual appearances illuminated by cognition—human beings and animals—motives determine it, and each character always reacts to them in the same lawful, necessary way. Through abstract, rational cognition, human beings have a *capacity to choose* beyond the animal's. This makes a person the battleground of conflicting motives without releasing him from their rule. It permits full expression of individual character, but is in no way freedom of individual willing, independence from the law of causality, whose necessity extends over human beings as over every other appearance. That, and no more, is the difference reason or conceptual cognition brings between human and animal willing.

There can, however, be a wholly different phenomenon of the human will, impossible for animals. It occurs when a human being leaves behind cognition of individual things as such, which is governed by the principle of sufficient reason, and through cognition of the Ideas sees through the *principium*

individuationis (principle of individuation). Then the will's true freedom as thing in itself may actually emerge. The appearance enters a certain contradiction with itself, called self-denial; in the end the in-itself of its essence even cancels itself. This true and sole immediate expression of the will's freedom in itself, even in appearance, cannot yet be presented clearly here. It will be the final subject of our inquiry.

Having established the unchangeability of empirical character as merely the unfolding of the timeless intelligible character, and the necessity with which actions follow from its encounter with motives, we must first dispel an inference easily drawn in favour of reprehensible inclinations. Our character can be regarded as the unfolding in time of a timeless and therefore indivisible and unchangeable act of will, the intelligible character. This fixes unchangeably everything essential, the ethical content of our conduct, which must find expression in empirical character. Only the inessential, outer shape of our life course depends on the forms in which motives present themselves. One might therefore conclude that trying to improve one's character or resist evil inclinations is vain, and that one would do better to submit to the unalterable and immediately indulge every inclination, however evil. But this is exactly like the inference drawn from the theory of unavoidable fate, known as the ἀπὸς λόγος (idle argument), more recently called "Turkish fatalism." Cicero presents its proper refutation, attributed to Chrysippus, in *On Fate*, chapters 12–13.

Everything may be regarded as irrevocably determined by fate, but only through the chain of causes. It can never be determined that an effect will occur without its cause. The event is not predestined in isolation, but as the result of preceding causes. Fate determines both the outcome and the means whose outcome it is. If the means do not occur, the outcome certainly will not either. Both follow fate's decree, which we always learn only afterward.

As events always follow fate, the endless chain of causes, our deeds will always accord with our intelligible character. Yet as we do not know fate beforehand, we have no *a priori* insight into this character. Only *a posteriori*, through experience, do we learn to know ourselves as we learn to know others. If our intelligible character required a long struggle with an evil inclination before we could reach a good decision, the struggle must precede it and run its course. Reflection on character's unchangeability and the single source of all our deeds must not lead us to anticipate its decision in favour of either side. We shall see what sort of people we are in the decision that follows and behold ourselves reflected in our deeds.

This explains the satisfaction or anguish with which we look back on our life. It is not that past deeds still exist; they are over and gone. Their great importance to us lies in their meaning. They are the imprint of character, the mirror of will in which we recognize our innermost self, the core of our willing. Since we learn this only afterward, not beforehand, it is for us to strive and struggle in time so that the picture formed by our deeds may, as far as possible, calm us rather than cause us anguish. The meaning of that calm or anguish will be examined later. Here another, independent consideration belongs.

Beside intelligible and empirical character, we must mention a third, different from both: *acquired character*. One acquires it only in life, through experience of the world. It is what people mean when they praise someone for having character or blame someone for lacking it. One might think that since empirical character, as an appearance of intelligible character, is unchangeable and consistent within itself like any natural phenomenon, a person would always appear consistent and true to himself, with no need to acquire a character artificially through experience and reflection. But matters are otherwise. One is always the same person, yet does not always understand oneself. One often misconstrues oneself until some degree of genuine self-knowledge has been attained.

Empirical character as a mere natural drive is without reason in itself. Its expressions are also disturbed by reason, and all the more so in someone with greater reflection and powers of thought. Reason continually presents what belongs to *the human being in general*, as the character of the species, and what is possible for a human being to will or accomplish. This makes it harder to see what, from among all these possibilities, one alone wills and can do by virtue of one's individuality. A person finds in himself the capacity for many widely different human strivings and abilities, but cannot know their relative strength in his own individuality without experience. Even if he chooses pursuits suited to his character, he still feels at particular moments and in particular moods impulses toward opposite, incompatible ones. To pursue the former without disturbance, he must entirely suppress the latter.

Our physical path on earth is only a line, not a surface. Likewise, if we want to take and possess one thing in life, we must leave countless others to the right and left, renouncing them. If we cannot decide to do so but grasp, like children at a fair, everything that attracts us in passing, we make the misguided attempt to turn the line of our path into a surface. We then run in zigzags, wander back and forth like will-o'-the-wisps, and get nowhere.

Another comparison comes from Hobbes's theory of right. Originally each person has a right to every thing, but to no thing exclusively. One can gain an exclusive right to particular things by giving up one's right to all the others, while others do the same with respect to what one has chosen. Life works similarly. We can seriously and successfully follow any particular pursuit—pleasure, honour, wealth, science, art, or virtue—only when we abandon all claims foreign to it and renounce everything else. Mere willing and ability are therefore insufficient. A person must also *know* what he wills and *know* what he can do. Only then will he show character and accomplish something worthwhile.

Until he reaches this point, he lacks character in the ordinary sense, despite the natural consistency of his empirical character. On the whole he must remain true to himself and follow his course, drawn by his daemon, but he traces no straight line. His path trembles and turns unevenly; he hesitates, deviates, doubles back, and causes himself remorse and pain. He sees, in great and small matters, so much that is possible and attainable for human beings, without knowing what alone suits him, is feasible for him, or is even enjoyable to him. He envies others their positions and circumstances, though these suit their characters and not his. In them he would be unhappy and perhaps unable to endure them.

As a fish is at ease only in water, a bird in air, and a mole beneath the earth, each person is at ease only in an atmosphere suited to him; courtly air, for example, is not breathable for everyone. Lacking sufficient insight into this, many undertake experiments that fail. They force their character in particular instances, only to yield to it again overall. What they laboriously gain against their nature gives them no enjoyment, and what they learn remains dead. Even ethically, an act too noble for their character, arising from a concept or doctrine rather than pure, immediate impulse, loses all merit afterward through selfish remorse, even in their own eyes. *Velle non discitur* (willing cannot be taught).

We learn the inflexibility of other people's characters only through experience. Until then we childishly believe we can use rational arguments, requests, pleading, example, or generosity to make someone give up his nature, change his conduct or thinking, or even expand his abilities. The same is true of ourselves. We must learn from experience what we will and what we can do. Until then we do not know; we lack acquired character and often need hard blows from outside to throw us back onto our own path.

When at last we have learned this, we have gained what the world calls character: *acquired character*. It is simply the most complete possible knowledge of our own individuality. It is abstract, hence clear, knowledge of the unchangeable properties of our empirical character and of the extent and direction of our mental and physical powers: all the strengths and weaknesses of our individuality. We can then carry out the inherently unchangeable role of our own person deliberately and methodically, instead of improvising it without rules. We can fill the gaps that moods or weaknesses produce in it by following firm concepts.

We have brought the mode of action already necessary to our individual nature under clearly conscious maxims that remain before us. We carry it out as reflectively as though it were learned, without being led astray by the passing influence of a mood or an impression of the moment, checked by the bitterness or sweetness of a particular incident on the way, or subject to hesitation, wavering, or inconsistency. No longer beginners waiting, experimenting, and groping to see what we really will and can do, we know this once and for all. In every choice we need only apply general principles to particular cases and reach a decision at once. We know our will in general and do not let mood or external appeals lure us into deciding in a particular case what opposes it as a whole.

Likewise, we know the kind and degree of our strengths and weaknesses and spare ourselves much pain. There is really no enjoyment except in using and feeling one's own powers, while the greatest pain is perceiving their lack when they are needed. Once we have discovered where our strengths and weaknesses lie, we cultivate and use our outstanding natural aptitudes and seek to profit from them in every way. We turn toward work where they have a place and value. Yet with self-command we avoid pursuits for which nature has given us little aptitude, and take care not to attempt what we cannot accomplish. Only someone who has come this far will always be fully and reflectively himself. He will never be abandoned by himself, because he always knows what he can ask of himself.

He will often enjoy feeling his strengths and rarely suffer the pain of being reminded of his weaknesses. The latter is humiliation and perhaps causes the greatest mental pain; it is much easier to face one's misfortune than one's incompetence clearly. If we know our strengths and weaknesses completely, we shall not pretend to powers we lack or pass false coin, for such play-acting ultimately fails. The whole human being is only the appearance of his will. Nothing could therefore be more perverse than to begin from reflection and

want to be something other than one is: the will would contradict itself directly. Imitating someone else's qualities and peculiarities is more disgraceful than wearing someone else's clothes, for it pronounces a judgment of worthlessness upon oneself. Knowing one's own disposition, abilities of every kind, and their unchangeable limits is the surest way in this respect to the greatest possible contentment with oneself.

What holds for external circumstances also holds for inner ones: no comfort is more effective than complete certainty of unalterable necessity. The evil that has struck us torments us less than thoughts of how it might have been prevented. Nothing calms us more effectively than viewing what happened from the standpoint of necessity. From it all accidents appear as instruments of a ruling fate, and we recognize the evil as unavoidably brought about by the conflict of inner and outer circumstances: this is fatalism. We lament and rage only so long as we hope thereby either to affect others or to spur ourselves into extraordinary effort. Children and adults alike settle down once they see clearly that it could not possibly be otherwise:

θυμὸν ἐνὶ στήθεσσι φίλον δαμάσαντες ἀνάγκη.
(Animo in pectoribus nostro domito necessitate.)

Translation: Having subdued the dear spirit in our breasts by necessity.

We are like captured elephants that rage and struggle terribly for days until they see it is fruitless. Then they suddenly and calmly offer their necks to the yoke, tamed forever. We are like King David, who ceaselessly besieged Jehovah with pleas and behaved despairingly while his son still lived, but thought no more of it once the son was dead. Thus countless people bear lasting evils—disability, poverty, low rank, ugliness, an unpleasant place to live—with complete indifference. They no longer feel them, like scarred wounds, simply because they know inner or outer necessity leaves nothing to be changed. More fortunate people cannot understand how anyone bears them.

Clear knowledge of necessity reconciles us as firmly to inner circumstances as to outer ones. Once we have recognized our faults and weaknesses as clearly and finally as our good qualities and strengths, set our aims accordingly, and accepted what is unattainable, we most securely escape, as far as our individuality permits, the bitterest suffering: dissatisfaction with ourselves. That follows inevitably from ignorance of our individuality, false self-esteem, and

the presumption arising from it. Ovid's lines apply excellently to the painful chapters of self-knowledge I have recommended:

Optimus ille animi vindex laedentia pectus
Vincula qui rupit, dedoluitque semel.

Translation: The best avenger of his spirit is he who breaks the bonds
that wound his heart and grieves once and for all.

So much for *acquired character*. It matters less to ethics proper than to worldly life, but its discussion naturally took its place as a third kind beside intelligible and empirical character. We had to examine the first two at some length to understand clearly how the will in all its appearances is subject to necessity while in itself it may still be called free, even omnipotent.

Notes

Notes

1. Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, first edition, pp. 532–558; fifth edition, pp. 560–586; and *Critique of Practical Reason*, fourth edition, pp. 169–179; Rosenkranz edition, pp. 224–231. ↩

2. Descartes, *Meditations*, 4; Spinoza, *Ethics*, part II, propositions 48 and 49, and others. The source cites: Cart. medit. 4. – Spin. Eth., P. II., prop. 48 et 49, caet. ↩

§. 56.

The whole visible world stands as the expression and image of the will's freedom and omnipotence. It is the will's appearance and develops according to the laws inherent in the form of cognition. That freedom can now express itself anew where the will, in its most complete appearance, has attained fully adequate knowledge of its own essence. At the summit of reflection and self-consciousness, it may still will what it formerly willed blindly and without self-knowledge. Cognition then always remains a *motive* for it, in the whole as in particular cases. Or, conversely, this cognition becomes a *quietive* that stills and cancels all willing.

This is the affirmation and denial of the will to live outlined earlier in general terms. As general, not individual, expressions of will concerning a person's way of life, they do not modify the development of character piecemeal or find expression in isolated actions. The maxim the will has freely adopted upon receiving this knowledge is expressed livingly either in the ever stronger emergence of the person's whole previous mode of conduct or in its cancellation. The reflections on freedom, necessity, and character that intervened have prepared the way for a clearer account of all this, the main subject of the final book. We shall prepare it further by postponing it once more and turning first to life itself, whose willing or refusal is the great question. We shall ask in general what affirmation actually brings to the will, which is everywhere the inner essence of life; how far and in what way life satisfies it, or can satisfy it; in short, what we must take to be the will's general and essential condition in this world that is its own in every respect.

First I ask readers to recall the reflection with which we ended Book Two. It arose from a question about the will's goal and purpose. Instead of an answer, we saw that at every grade of its appearance, from the lowest to the highest, the will lacks any final goal or purpose. It always strives because striving is its sole essence. No attained goal ends it. It can never be finally satisfied; it can be checked only by an obstacle and otherwise proceeds without end.

We saw this in gravity, the simplest natural appearance. It never ceases striving or pressing toward a centre without extension, whose attainment would destroy it and matter, even if the whole universe had already gathered into one mass. We see it in other simple natural appearances too. A solid strives to become fluid, whether by melting or dissolving; only then are its chemical

forces released. Rigidity is the prison in which cold holds them. Fluid strives to become vapour and passes into it as soon as it is freed from all pressure. No body is without affinity, which is to say without striving, without craving and desire, as Jakob Böhme would put it. Electricity propagates its inner division of itself without limit, even if the earth's mass absorbs the effect. As long as the galvanic pile lasts, galvanism too is a purposeless act of division and reconciliation, ceaselessly renewed.

A plant's existence is likewise restless striving that is never satisfied: a ceaseless drive through ever higher forms until its endpoint, the seed, becomes the starting point again. This repeats endlessly, with no goal, final satisfaction, or resting place anywhere. We shall also recall from Book Two that the many natural forces and organic forms everywhere contend for the matter in which they seek to appear. Each possesses only what it has wrested from another. Thus a continual struggle of life and death is sustained. From it arises, above all, the resistance that everywhere obstructs the striving constituting each thing's innermost essence. Striving presses in vain yet cannot give up its nature. It suffers its way forward until that appearance perishes, when others eagerly seize its place and matter.

We have long recognized that this striving, the core and in-itself of every thing, is the very same as what we call *will* in ourselves, where it appears most clearly in the light of fullest consciousness. When an obstacle comes between it and a temporary goal, we call this obstruction *suffering*. Attaining the goal we call *satisfaction*, well-being, or happiness. We can apply these names to the weaker in degree but identical in essence appearances of the cognitionless world. We then see them caught in continual suffering and without lasting happiness. All striving arises from lack, from dissatisfaction with one's state, and is therefore suffering until satisfied. Yet no satisfaction endures; each is merely the starting point for new striving. Everywhere we see striving obstructed in many ways and therefore struggling, so it remains suffering throughout. With no final goal to striving, there is no limit or end to suffering.

What careful, strenuous attention alone discovers in nature without cognition meets us clearly in nature that cognizes, in animal life, whose constant suffering is easy to show. Without pausing at this intermediate grade, let us turn to where all this emerges most distinctly under the brightest light of cognition: human life. As the will's appearance becomes more complete, suffering too becomes more evident. Plants have no sensibility and thus no pain. The lowest animals, such as infusoria and radiates, undergo only a very slight degree of suffering.

Even insects have a limited capacity for sensation and suffering. Only with the fully formed nervous system of vertebrates does it reach a high degree, and it rises further as intelligence develops. In proportion as cognition becomes clear and consciousness intensifies, suffering increases. It therefore reaches its highest degree in the human being, and there increases again with clearer cognition and greater intelligence: the person of genius suffers most.

In this sense—referring to the degree of cognition generally, not merely abstract knowledge—I understand and use the saying from Ecclesiastes: *Qui auget scientiam, auget et dolorem* (Who increases knowledge increases sorrow). The close relation between the degree of consciousness and the degree of suffering was beautifully made visible in a drawing by that philosophical painter, or painting philosopher, *Tischbein*. The upper half shows women whose children are being taken from them. In several groups and postures they express the depths of maternal pain, anguish, and despair in varied ways. The lower half shows sheep from whom their lambs are being taken, arranged and grouped in exactly the same way. Each human head and posture above has an animal counterpart below. We see plainly how the pain possible in dim animal consciousness compares with the terrible suffering made possible only by distinct cognition and clear consciousness.

We shall therefore consider the will's inner and essential fate in *human existence*. Everyone will readily find the same thing, expressed more weakly at different degrees, in animal life. Suffering animals, too, provide ample conviction that *all life is essentially suffering*.

§. 57.

At every grade illuminated by cognition, the will appears to itself as an individual. The human individual finds himself finite in infinite space and time, a magnitude vanishing beside them, cast into them. Because they have no bounds, the *when* and *where* of his existence are always relative, never absolute: his place and duration are finite portions of the infinite and boundless. His real existence is only in the present. Its unimpeded flight into the past is a constant passage into death, a continual dying. His past life, apart from its possible consequences for the present and the evidence of his will imprinted in it, is already entirely done with, dead, and nothing. It should therefore be rationally indifferent to him whether that past contained torments or pleasures. Yet the present continually becomes past in his hands, while the future is wholly uncertain and always short. Viewed from its formal side alone, his existence is a ceaseless fall of the present into the dead past, a continual dying.

Viewed physically, too, just as walking is a fall constantly interrupted, the life of our body is a dying constantly interrupted, death repeatedly postponed. Even the activity of our mind is boredom constantly deferred. Every breath wards off death as it continually presses upon us. We fight it every second and at longer intervals with every meal, sleep, warming, and so forth. It must win at last, for we were given over to it at birth; it only plays with its prey for a while before devouring it. Meanwhile we prolong our lives with great concern and much care for as long as possible, like blowing a soap bubble as large and lasting as we can, though we know with certainty that it will burst.

Even in nature without cognition we saw its inner essence as constant striving without goal or rest. This becomes clearer still in animals and human beings. Willing and striving are their entire essence, exactly like an unquenchable thirst. The basis of all willing is need, lack, and therefore pain, to which a being is subject originally and by its very nature. If, instead, it lacks objects of willing because they are too readily satisfied and taken away again, dreadful emptiness and boredom seize it: its own being and existence become an intolerable burden. Life therefore swings like a pendulum between pain and boredom, which are indeed its ultimate constituents. A curious expression of this truth is that, after human beings placed all sufferings and torments in hell, nothing was left for heaven but boredom.

The ceaseless striving that constitutes every appearance of the will acquires its first and most general basis at the higher grades of objectivation when the will appears to itself as a living body under the iron command to nourish it. The command has its force precisely because that body is nothing other than the objectivated will to live itself. As the most complete objectivation of this will, the human being is also the neediest of all beings. He is willing and needing through and through, a concentration of a thousand needs. He stands on earth with these needs, left to himself, uncertain of everything except his need and distress. Caring for his existence under such heavy demands, renewed every day, generally fills his whole life. A second demand immediately follows it: propagation of the species. At the same time dangers of every kind threaten him on all sides, and evading them requires constant vigilance. He proceeds with careful step and anxious glance, for a thousand accidents and a thousand enemies lie in wait. So he went in the wilderness, and so he goes in civilized life. There is no security for him:

Qualibus in tenebris vitae, quantisque periclis
 Degitur hocc' aevi, quodcunque est!
 Lucr., II, 15.

Translation: In what darkness of life and amid what great dangers is this span of life, whatever it may be, spent! Lucretius, II, 15.

Most lives are only a constant struggle for existence itself, with the certainty of losing it at last. What keeps people going through this arduous struggle is less love of life than fear of death, which stands inevitably in the background and can approach at any moment. Life itself is a sea full of reefs and whirlpools, which a person avoids with the greatest care, though he knows that even if every effort and skill enables him to thread his way through them, each step brings him closer to the greatest shipwreck: total, unavoidable, incurable death. Indeed, he steers straight toward it. Death is the final goal of the arduous voyage and worse for him than all the reefs he avoided.

It is striking, however, that life's sufferings and torments can grow so severe that death, fleeing from which occupies the whole of life, becomes desirable and one rushes toward it voluntarily. Conversely, as soon as need and suffering give a person respite, boredom is so near that diversion becomes necessary. The striving for existence keeps every living being occupied and moving. Once existence is secure, however, they do not know what to do with it. They are then

moved to get rid of the burden of existence, to make it unfelt, to “kill time”—that is, to escape boredom.

Thus almost everyone sheltered from need and care, having finally cast off every other burden, becomes a burden to himself. Every hour passed is then counted as a gain: a subtraction from the very life he previously spent all his powers trying to preserve as long as possible. Boredom is far from a slight evil; it eventually paints genuine despair on the face. It drives beings who love one another as little as human beings do to seek one another out, and so becomes a source of sociability. Public precautions are taken against it everywhere, as against other widespread calamities, if only for reasons of state. Like its opposite extreme, famine, it can drive people to the greatest excesses. The people need panem et Circenses (bread and circuses). The strict Philadelphia penitentiary system makes boredom alone, through solitude and inactivity, an instrument of punishment. It is so terrible that it has already driven prisoners to suicide. As need is the people's constant scourge, boredom is the scourge of the upper class. In middle-class life Sunday represents boredom and the six weekdays represent need.

Every human life flows between wanting and attaining. Desire by its nature is pain; attainment quickly breeds satiety. The goal was only apparent, and possession takes away its charm. Desire and need appear again in a new form. If they do not, desolation, emptiness, and boredom follow, and the struggle against them is as tormenting as the struggle against need. Desire and satisfaction following one another at intervals neither too short nor too long reduce the suffering each brings to its smallest measure and make the happiest possible life course.

What one might otherwise call the most beautiful part and purest joys of life deserve those names precisely because they raise us out of actual existence and turn us into spectators without personal stake: pure cognition, foreign to all willing, enjoyment of beauty, and genuine pleasure in art. Yet these require rare aptitudes and are granted to very few people, and even to them only as a passing dream. Moreover, greater intellectual power makes these few receptive to much greater suffering than less perceptive people could ever feel and leaves them alone among beings markedly unlike themselves. This balances the account. Purely intellectual pleasures are inaccessible to the vast majority; they are almost wholly incapable of the joy of pure cognition and remain entirely dependent on willing.

If anything is to engage them, to be *interesting* to them, it must stir their *will* in some way, even by a remote and merely possible relation to it; the very meaning of “interest” implies this. The will can never be wholly absent, since their existence lies far more in willing than knowing. Action and reaction are their only element. This trait shows itself naively in small, everyday matters. At sights they visit, for example, they write their names, reacting upon a place that did not act upon them. They find it hard merely to observe a strange, rare animal; they must provoke, tease, or play with it to feel action and reaction. The need for stimulation of the will appears especially in the invention and persistence of card-playing, a precise expression of humanity's pitiable side.

Whatever nature or fortune may have done, whoever one may be and whatever one may possess, the pain essential to life cannot be cast off:

Πηλεΐδης δ' ὤμωξεν, ἰδὼν εἰς οὐρανὸν εὐρύν.
(Pelides autem ejulavit, intuitus in coelum latum.)

Translation: The son of Peleus cried out, looking into the wide sky.

And again:

Ζηνὸς μὲν πάϊς ἦα Κρονίουος, αὐτὰρ οἷζὺν Εἶχον ἀπειρεσίην.
(Jovis quidem filius eram Saturnii; verum aerumnam Habebam infinitam.)

Translation: I was the son of Zeus, son of Cronus, yet my suffering was without end.

Ceaseless efforts to banish suffering accomplish only a change of its form. Originally it is want, need, and anxiety about preserving life. Should one succeed, with great difficulty, in displacing pain in this form, it immediately returns in a thousand others, varying with age and circumstances: sexual drive, passionate love, jealousy, envy, hatred, fear, ambition, greed, illness, and so on. If it can find entry in no other form, it arrives in the sad grey clothing of tedium and boredom, against which various remedies are tried. If one succeeds in driving boredom away, one will hardly do so without readmitting pain in one of its earlier forms, beginning the dance again. Every human life is tossed between pain and boredom.

This is a disheartening reflection, but I should draw attention to a side of it from which one can draw comfort and perhaps even Stoic indifference to one's present trouble. Much of our impatience with suffering arises because we

regard it as accidental, produced by a chain of causes that could easily have been different. We do not usually grieve over evils that are immediately necessary and entirely general, such as old age, death, and many daily inconveniences. What gives a particular suffering its sting is thinking about the chance circumstances that brought it upon us.

Suppose we recognize that pain as such is essential and unavoidable in life, and only the particular form it takes depends on chance. Our present suffering occupies a place that another would immediately fill if this one were absent; the present suffering merely excludes that other one. Fate can thus do little to us in what is essential. If this reflection became a living conviction, it might bring considerable Stoic calm and greatly reduce anxious concern for our welfare. In fact, such powerful rule of reason over directly felt suffering may rarely, if ever, occur.

Reflection on the inevitability of pain, on one suffering driving out another and a new one being summoned when an earlier one departs, might even lead to a paradoxical but not absurd hypothesis. Perhaps each individual has by nature a fixed measure of essential pain that cannot remain empty or be overfilled, however its form changes. On this view suffering and well-being are determined not by external things but by this measure, this disposition. Physical condition may increase or decrease it somewhat at different times, yet overall it remains the same. It is what we call temperament or, more exactly, the degree to which someone is, as Plato says in Book One of the *Republic*, εὐκόλος or δύσκολος (of an easy or difficult disposition).

Familiar experience supports this hypothesis: great suffering makes every lesser trouble unfelt, whereas in its absence even minor inconveniences torment and upset us. Experience also shows that when a great misfortune actually arrives, one we shuddered even to imagine, our overall mood remains fairly much as before once we have endured the first pain. Conversely, attaining a happiness long desired does not make us noticeably better or more comfortable overall and for long. Only the moment of such a change moves us unusually strongly, with deep grief or loud jubilation. Both soon fade, because they rested on illusion. They arise not from present pleasure or pain itself but from the opening of a new future anticipated within it. Only by borrowing pain or joy from the future could they become so abnormally intense; that is why they cannot last.

On the hypothesis that a large part of suffering and well-being, like cognition, is determined subjectively and *a priori* (prior to experience), further evidence can be offered. Cheerfulness and gloom plainly do not depend on outer circumstances, wealth, or rank: we find at least as many cheerful faces among the poor as among the rich. The motives for suicide vary so greatly that we can name no misfortune sure to cause it with any high probability in people of every character, and few so small that equally small ones have not already caused it. Our degree of cheerfulness or sadness does not remain the same at every time. On this view we would attribute its variations not to changing external circumstances but to changing inner states and physical condition. A real, though temporary, increase in cheerfulness, even to joy, usually appears without any external cause.

We often see our pain arise from a definite external relation and feel visibly pressed and saddened only by it. We then believe that removing it would bring the greatest contentment. This is an illusion. On our hypothesis each person's overall measure of suffering and well-being is subjectively fixed at any given time. The external cause of sadness acts on that measure as a blistering plaster does on the body, drawing together harmful fluids otherwise dispersed. The pain rooted in our being during this period, which we cannot cast off, would be spread among a hundred points without that specific external cause. It would appear as a hundred small annoyances and anxious fancies about things we now overlook because the chief trouble has filled our capacity for pain and concentrated on one point the suffering otherwise scattered.

This fits another observation. When an oppressive major worry is finally lifted by a happy outcome, another immediately takes its place. All its material was there before, but it could not enter consciousness as a worry while there was no room for it. It stood unnoticed as a dim mist at consciousness's furthest horizon. Now that room has opened, the ready material advances and takes the throne of the day's ruling concern—*πρυτανεύουσα* (presiding). Though the material of the new worry may be much lighter than the old, it swells to an apparently equal size and completely fills that throne.

Excessive joy and very violent pain occur only in the same person. Each conditions the other, and both require great liveliness of mind. As we have just seen, neither is produced by what is purely present; both arise from anticipation of the future. Pain is essential to life, and its degree is also determined by the subject's nature. Sudden changes, being external, cannot really change that

degree. Extreme jubilation or anguish therefore always rests on an error or delusion. Insight could prevent both these excesses of mind.

Every excessive jubilation—*exultatio*, *insolens laetitia* (exultation, immoderate joy)—rests on the illusion that one has found in life what cannot be found there: lasting satisfaction of desires and cares that torment us and continually renew themselves. We must inevitably be disabused of each such illusion and pay for its departure with pain as bitter as the joy its arrival brought. It is like a height from which we can descend only by falling; we should therefore avoid it. Sudden excessive pain is just the fall from such a height, the disappearance of an illusion, and depends on it. If we could bring ourselves always to view things clearly as a whole and in their connections, and steadfastly avoid lending them the colour we wish them to have, we could prevent both extremes. Stoic ethics chiefly sought to free the mind from such illusions and their consequences and give it unshakable equanimity instead. Horace is filled with this insight in the familiar ode:

*Aequam memento rebus in arduis
Servare mentem, non secus in bonis
Ab insolenti temperatam
Laetitia.*

Translation: Remember to keep an even mind in adversity, and in prosperity too to restrain it from extravagant joy.

Most often, however, we shut ourselves off from the bitter medicine of recognizing that suffering is essential to life. It does not flow into us from outside: everyone carries its inexhaustible source within. We instead continually seek some particular external cause for the pain that never leaves us, as if seeking a pretext. A free person fashions an idol to give himself a master. We tirelessly move from wish to wish. However much each attained satisfaction promised, it fails to satisfy and soon appears as a humiliating mistake. Yet we do not see that we are drawing water with the Danaids' bottomless vessel. We hurry on to new wishes:

*Sed, dum abest quod avemus, id exsuperare videtur
Caetera; post aliquid, quum contigit illud, avemus;
Et sitis aequa tenet vitai semper hiantes. (Lucr. III, 1095.)*

Translation: While what we desire is absent, it seems to surpass everything else; when we have obtained it, we desire something further,

and the same thirst always holds us with mouths agape. Lucretius, III, 1095.

This continues without end. Or, more rarely and requiring some strength of character, we meet a wish that cannot be fulfilled yet cannot be abandoned. Then we have, as it were, what we sought: something we can blame at every moment as the source of our suffering instead of blaming our own being. We become estranged from our fate but reconciled to our existence, as the knowledge recedes that suffering is essential to existence itself and true satisfaction impossible. This latter course produces a somewhat melancholy mood: one continually bears a single great pain and thereby comes to regard lesser pains and pleasures with indifference. It is a more dignified appearance than the much more common endless chase after one deceptive image after another.

§. 58.

All satisfaction, or what is commonly called happiness, is in its true nature always merely *negative*, never positive. It is not a blessing that comes to us originally and of itself, but always the satisfaction of a wish. A wish, which means a lack, is the prior condition of every enjoyment. With satisfaction the wish ceases, and so does the enjoyment. Satisfaction or happiness can therefore be no more than release from some pain or need. This includes not only manifest suffering but every wish whose insistence disturbs our peace, and even deadening boredom, which makes existence a burden.

It is difficult to attain or accomplish anything. Endless obstacles and exertions stand against every undertaking, and difficulties pile up at every step. Yet once everything has been overcome and attained, nothing has been gained except release from some suffering or wish: one is simply as one was before it arose. What is immediately given to us is always lack, and thus pain. Satisfaction and enjoyment can be known only indirectly, by recalling the preceding suffering and deprivation that ended when they began.

That is why we are hardly aware of, or value, the goods and advantages we actually possess. We think they are simply how things should be, because they make us happy only negatively, by keeping suffering away. Only after losing them do we feel their worth: lack, deprivation, and suffering are positive, announcing themselves immediately. Thus recalling need, illness, or privation we have overcome pleases us, because it is our only way of enjoying our present advantages. From this standpoint of egoism, the form of the will to live, we must also admit that seeing or hearing of another's suffering gives us satisfaction by the same route, as Lucretius says beautifully and frankly at the beginning of his second book:

Suave, mari magno, turbantibus aequora ventis,
 Et terra magnum alterius spectare laborem:
 Non, quia vexari quemquam est jucunda voluptas;
 Sed, quibus ipse malis careas, quia cernere suave est

Translation: It is pleasant, when winds trouble the great sea, to watch from land another's great struggle—not because anyone's distress is a pleasure, but because it is pleasant to see what evils one has escaped.

We shall see later, however, that pleasure arising from this indirect awareness of one's own well-being comes very close to the source of actual, positive malice.

Art, especially poetry, faithfully mirrors the essence of the world and life and also confirms that all happiness is negative rather than positive. It cannot be a lasting satisfaction; it releases us from one pain or lack only to be followed by another, or by *languor* (listlessness), empty longing, and boredom. Every epic or drama can depict only the struggle, striving, and conflict to gain happiness, never permanent, complete happiness itself. It leads its hero through a thousand difficulties and dangers to a goal, then drops the curtain as soon as the goal is reached. The only thing left to show would be that the shining goal where the hero expected to find happiness had merely teased him and that he is no better off after reaching it. Since genuine, lasting happiness is impossible, it cannot be a subject of art.

The idyll does, admittedly, aim to portray such happiness. Yet the idyll cannot remain one. In the poet's hands it becomes either an epic—a very slight one made up of small sufferings, joys, and strivings, which is the usual case—or merely descriptive poetry. It then portrays nature's beauty, in fact pure, will-free cognition. This is indeed the only pure happiness: it is preceded by neither suffering nor need, and is necessarily followed by neither remorse, pain, emptiness, nor tedium. But it can fill only moments of life, never the whole of it.

What we see in poetry we find again in music. In melody we recognized the inner history of the self-conscious will expressed universally: the secret life, longing, suffering, and joy, the ebb and flow of the human heart. Melody continually departs from its key note, wandering by a thousand curious paths as far as the most painful dissonance. At last it finds the key note again, expressing the will's satisfaction and repose. There is then nothing more to do with it; holding it longer would produce only tiresome, empty monotony corresponding to boredom.

The endless striving of the will explains what these reflections were intended to show: the impossibility of lasting satisfaction and the negative nature of all happiness. As shown at the end of Book Two, the will objectivated in human life, as in every appearance, strives without goal or end. We find the mark of this endlessness stamped on every part of its appearance, from its most general

form, boundless time and space, to the most complete appearance of all, human life and striving.

We can distinguish three theoretical extremes of human life and regard them as elements within actual life. First is intense willing and great passion (*rajas-guna*). This emerges in great historical characters and is portrayed in epic and drama. It can also show itself in a small sphere, for the magnitude of the objects here is measured only by how strongly they move the will, not by their external relations. Second is pure cognition, apprehension of the Ideas, requiring cognition's release from the service of the will: the life of genius (*sattva-guna*). Third is the greatest lethargy of will and of the cognition bound to it: empty longing and life-paralyzing boredom (*tamas-guna*).

An individual's life is far from remaining in any one of these extremes. It rarely even touches them. Most often it is a feeble, wavering approach now to one and now to another: poor willing for petty objects, endlessly repeated to escape boredom. It is truly incredible how empty and meaningless most lives appear from outside, and how dim and thoughtless they feel from within. There is a faint longing and torment, a dreamlike staggering through the four ages of life toward death, accompanied by a series of trivial thoughts. People resemble clockworks wound up and set going without knowing why. Each conception and birth winds the clock of a human life anew to play once more a tune already played countless times, phrase by phrase and beat by beat, with insignificant variations.

Each individual, each human face and life course, is one more brief dream of the infinite spirit of nature, the enduring will to live. It is one more fleeting figure that the will playfully sketches on its infinite page of space and time, allows to stand for a moment vanishingly small beside them, and then erases to make room for a new one. Yet here lies life's troubling side: each such fleeting figure, each such insipid idea, must be paid for by the whole will to live in all its vehemence, with many deep sufferings and at last a bitter death, long dreaded until it arrives. That is why the sight of a corpse makes us suddenly serious.

Every individual's life, viewed as a whole with only its most significant features, is a tragedy; examined detail by detail, it has the character of a comedy. The activities and troubles of each day, the relentless annoyances of the moment, the hopes and fears of a week, and the mishaps of every hour brought about by chance, always ready for mischief, are all comic scenes. Yet desires never fulfilled, striving frustrated, hopes mercilessly trampled by fate,

and the wretched errors of a whole life, ending with growing suffering and death, always make a tragedy. As if fate wished to add mockery to the misery of our existence, our lives must contain all the pains of tragedy, while in life's sprawling details we cannot even retain the dignity of tragic figures and must inevitably be silly comic characters.

Great and small afflictions fill every life and keep us continually restless and moving. Even so, they cannot conceal life's inadequacy for fulfilling the mind, the emptiness and insipidity of existence, or shut out boredom, always ready to fill any pause left by care. Hence the human mind, unsatisfied with the cares, worries, and occupations imposed by the real world, creates an imaginary one in a thousand kinds of superstition. It then busies itself with this world in every way, wasting time and energy on it as soon as the real world offers a peace it cannot enjoy. This is especially common at first among peoples for whom a mild climate and fertile soil make life easier: above all Hindus, then Greeks and Romans, later Italians, Spaniards, and others.

Human beings make demons, gods, and saints in their own image. They must continually offer them sacrifices and prayers, adorn temples, make and discharge vows, undertake pilgrimages, pay respects, decorate images, and so on. Their service becomes interwoven everywhere with reality and even obscures it. Every event of life is taken as a response from these beings. Dealing with them fills half of life, constantly sustains hope, and through the appeal of illusion often becomes more interesting than dealing with real beings. It expresses and reveals humanity's double need: partly for help and support, partly for occupation and diversion. It often works against the first need, wasting precious time and strength in prayer and sacrifice instead of warding off actual misfortunes and dangers. It serves the second need all the better through imaginary dealings with a dreamed-up spirit world. This is the far from negligible benefit of every superstition.

§. 59.

Through the most general reflections on the elementary features of human life, we have become convinced in a sense *a priori* (prior to experience) that its whole constitution makes true happiness impossible: it is essentially many-sided suffering and a thoroughly unhappy condition. We could make this conviction more vivid by proceeding *a posteriori* (from experience), examining particular cases, bringing images before the imagination, and describing in examples the nameless misery that experience and history offer wherever and however one looks. But such a chapter would have no end and would leave the general standpoint essential to philosophy. It could also easily be taken for a mere declamation on human misery, of which there have been many, and accused of one-sidedness because it began with particular facts. Our cold, philosophical demonstration proceeding from the general and *a priori*—of the inevitable suffering grounded in life's essence—is free of that reproach and suspicion.

Confirmation *a posteriori* is readily found everywhere. Anyone awakened from the first dreams of youth who attends to personal experience and that of others, looks at life and at history past and present, and reads the great poets will, unless an indelible prejudice paralyzes judgment, recognize that this human world is the realm of chance and error. They rule it mercilessly in great and small matters, while folly and wickedness wield their scourges alongside them. Anything better wins through only with effort. What is noble and wise appears very rarely, and still more rarely is effective or heard. In thought the absurd and mistaken, in art the shallow and tasteless, and in action the evil and treacherous generally hold sway with only brief interruptions. Excellence of every kind is always an exception, one case among millions. Even when it finds expression in a lasting work, that work stands isolated after surviving its contemporaries' resentment, preserved like a meteorite originating in an order of things different from the one that rules here.

As for an individual life, every life story is a story of suffering. A life course is generally a continuous series of accidents large and small. Each person conceals them as far as possible, knowing that others will seldom sympathize or show compassion and will almost always find satisfaction in thinking of the afflictions from which they themselves are now spared. Perhaps no one at the

end of life, if reflective and sincere, would wish to go through it again. Given that choice, he would much rather choose complete nonexistence.

The essential content of Hamlet's world-famous monologue can be summed up thus: our condition is so wretched that complete nonexistence would plainly be preferable. If suicide really offered us that, so that the alternative "to be or not to be" were before us in the full sense, we would unconditionally choose it as a most desirable end—a consummation devoutly to be wish'd (an end devoutly to be wished). Yet something in us says that this is not so, that death is not the end and not absolute annihilation. Likewise, what the father of history observed^[1] has probably never been refuted: no one has lived who has not wished more than once to avoid seeing the following day. The brevity of life, so often lamented, may therefore be its best feature.

If we could show each person the dreadful pains and torments to which life continually exposes him, he would shudder. Lead the most hardened optimist through hospitals, infirmaries, and surgical torture rooms; through prisons, torture chambers, and slave quarters; across battlefields and execution grounds; open to him all the dark dwellings of misery where it hides from cold curiosity; and finally let him look into Ugolino's tower of hunger. He would surely recognize at last the nature of this *meilleur des mondes possibles* (best of all possible worlds). Where else did *Dante* obtain the material for his Hell but from our real world? He made a very convincing hell of it. When he came to describe heaven and its joys, however, he faced an insuperable difficulty: our world offers no material for them. All he could do, instead of portraying paradise's joys, was repeat the instruction given him there by his ancestor, Beatrice, and various saints. This makes the nature of our world clear enough.

Human life, like every shoddy article, has an outside covered in false glitter. Suffering always hides, while everyone displays whatever pomp and splendour he can afford. The less inward contentment he has, the more he wishes to appear happy in others' opinion. Folly goes so far that others' opinion becomes a main goal of everyone's striving, though its utter worthlessness is already evident in the fact that in almost every language the word vanity, *vanitas* (emptiness), originally means emptiness and nothingness.

Even under all this show, life's torments can easily grow so great—and do so daily—that death, otherwise feared above everything, is seized with eagerness. If fate wishes to show its full malice, even this refuge may be barred. Under the power of enraged enemies, a sufferer may be left to cruel, slow torments

without rescue. He calls vainly on his gods for help and remains mercilessly exposed to his fate. This helplessness merely mirrors the indomitability of his will, of which his person is the objecthood. An external power can no more change or cancel that will than a foreign power can release him from the torments arising from life, its appearance. In the central matter as in every other, the human being is referred back to himself. In vain does he make gods from whom to beg or coax what only his own will's power can bring about.

The Old Testament made the world and humanity the work of a god. The New Testament, to teach that salvation and redemption from this world's misery can come only from the world itself, had to make that god become human. It is and remains the human being's will upon which everything depends for him. Sannyasis, martyrs, and saints of every faith and name have freely and gladly endured every torment because the will to live had been cancelled in them. Even the slow destruction of its appearance was then welcome to them. But I do not wish to anticipate the account that follows.

I cannot refrain, however, from saying here that *optimism*, when it is more than thoughtless talk by people whose flat foreheads harbour nothing but words, seems to me not merely absurd but positively *wicked*: a bitter mockery of humanity's nameless sufferings. Nor should anyone suppose that Christian doctrine favours optimism. On the contrary, the Gospels use “world” and “evil” almost as synonyms.^[2]

Notes

Notes

1. Herodotus, VII, 46. ↩

2. See chapter 46 of the second volume. ↩

§. 60.

We have completed two discussions that had to intervene: freedom of the will in itself alongside the necessity of its appearance, and the will's lot in the world that mirrors its essence, knowledge of which leads it to affirm or deny itself. We can now bring affirmation and denial themselves, earlier stated and explained only in general terms, into sharper focus by presenting the modes of action in which alone they find expression and considering their inner meaning.

Affirmation of the will is simply willing that persists undisturbed by any cognition, as it generally fills human life. The human body is already the will's objecthood as it appears at this grade and in this individual. Willing as it unfolds in time is, so to speak, a paraphrase of the body, an explanation of the meaning of the whole and its parts. It is another presentation of the same thing in itself of which the body is also an appearance. Hence we can say "affirmation of the body" in place of "affirmation of the will."

The basic theme of all the varied acts of will is satisfaction of needs inseparable from the healthy body's existence. They are already expressed in it and can be traced to preservation of the individual and propagation of the species. Indirectly, however, these give a vast variety of motives power over the will, producing a vast variety of acts. Each is only a sample or instance of the will appearing here in general. What kind of instance it is, what shape the motive has and gives it, is inessential. What matters is that willing occurs at all and how vehement it is. The will can become visible only through motives, as the eye can manifest its power of sight only in light. Motive in general stands before the will like a Proteus of many shapes. It always promises complete satisfaction, the quenching of the will's thirst. As soon as it is attained, it appears again in another form and moves the will anew, according to the will's degree of vehemence and its relation to cognition. These instances and examples disclose the empirical character.

From the moment consciousness begins, a person finds himself willing. His cognition generally remains in constant relation to his will. He first seeks complete knowledge of the objects of his willing, then of the means to them. Now he knows what to do and usually seeks no other knowledge. He acts and presses ahead, sustained and kept active by consciousness of continually working toward his desired goal. His thinking concerns the choice of means. Such is the life of almost everyone. They will, know what they will, and strive

for it, with enough success to protect them from despair and enough failure to protect them from boredom and its consequences. This produces a certain cheerfulness, or at least composure, which wealth and poverty do not fundamentally change. Rich and poor alike enjoy not what they have—for, as shown, its effect is only negative—but what they hope to gain through their activity. They press on with great seriousness and an air of importance, just as children do in play.

It is always an exception when such a life course is interrupted by cognition independent of service to the will and directed toward the world's essence as a whole. This may bring the aesthetic call to contemplation or the ethical call to renunciation. Need drives most people through life without allowing them to reflect. Often, by contrast, the will flares up to a degree far beyond affirmation of one's own body, manifesting itself in violent emotions and powerful passions. The individual then not only affirms his own existence but denies and seeks to cancel that of others when it stands in his way.

Maintaining the body through its own powers is such a low degree of the will's affirmation that, if affirmation voluntarily went no further, we could suppose the will appearing in that body ended when it died. Satisfaction of the sexual drive already goes beyond affirming one's own existence, which fills only a short time. It affirms life beyond the individual's death and into an indefinite future. Nature, always true and consistent and here even candid, openly presents the inner meaning of procreation. Our consciousness and the vehemence of the drive teach us that this act expresses the most decisive *affirmation of the will to live*, purely and without any further element, such as denying other individuals. In time and in the causal series—in nature—a new life appears as the act's consequence. The offspring stands before the parent, different in appearance but identical with the parent in itself, or according to the Idea. Through this act the generations of living beings are connected into a whole and perpetuate themselves as such.

For the parent, procreation is only the expression or symptom of his decisive affirmation of the will to live. For the offspring, it is not the ground of the will appearing in that offspring, since the will in itself knows neither ground nor consequent. Like every cause, it is merely the occasional cause of this will's appearing at this time and place. As thing in itself, the will of parent and offspring is not different; only appearance, not the thing in itself, is subject to the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation). By affirming beyond one's own body as far as a new body, one also affirms anew suffering

and death as belonging to life's appearance. The possibility of redemption opened by the highest cognitive capacity is declared fruitless for this occasion. Here lies the deep source of shame about the act of procreation.

Christian doctrine presents this view mythically in its dogma that we all share in Adam's fall, which plainly means the satisfaction of sexual desire, and through it are liable to suffering and death. Here the doctrine goes beyond consideration according to the principle of sufficient reason and recognizes the Idea of humanity. Generation, the bond joining all individuals, restores the Idea's unity from its fragmentation into countless individuals. Accordingly it regards each individual, on one side, as identical with Adam, representative of life's affirmation, and thus fallen into sin—original sin—suffering, and death. On the other side, its cognition of the Idea shows each individual as identical with the Redeemer, representative of denial of the will to live, and thus participating in his self-sacrifice, redeemed by his merit, and saved from the bonds of sin and death—that is, the world (Romans 5:12–21).

The Greek story of Persephone presents another mythic image of our view. Her return from the underworld was still possible until she tasted its fruit, but eating the pomegranate surrendered her to it completely. It shows sexual satisfaction as affirming the will to live beyond the individual's life: only through it does one fall wholly under life's power, as though signing oneself over anew. This meaning emerges especially clearly in Goethe's incomparable treatment of the myth, when the invisible chorus of the Fates suddenly breaks in just after she eats the pomegranate:

“You are ours!

You should have returned without eating;

One bite of the apple makes you ours!”

It is noteworthy that *Clement of Alexandria* (*Stromata*, III, chapter 15) uses the same image and wording: Οἱ μὲν εὐνουχίσαντες ἑαυτοὺς ἀπὸ πάσης ἁμαρτίας, διὰ τὴν βασιλείαν τῶν οὐρανῶν, μακάριοι οὗτοί εἰσιν, οἱ τοῦ κόσμου νηστεύοντες (Qui se castrarunt ad omni peccato, propter regnum coelorum, ii sunt beati, a *mundo jejunantes*—Blessed are those who have made themselves eunuchs from all sin for the kingdom of heaven, fasting from the world).

The sexual drive also proves itself life's strongest and most decisive affirmation because for the natural human being, as for an animal, it is life's final purpose and highest goal. Self-preservation is the first pursuit. Once that is

secured, one seeks only to propagate the species. As a merely natural being, one can strive for nothing further. Nature too, whose inner essence is the will to live itself, urges human beings and animals toward reproduction with all her force. Afterward her purpose in the individual is achieved and she is quite indifferent to its destruction. As the will to live, she cares only to preserve the species; the individual is nothing to her.

Because the inner essence of nature, the will to live, speaks most powerfully in the sexual drive, the ancient poets and philosophers Hesiod and Parmenides said, with deep significance, that *Eros* was the first being, the creator and principle from which all things arose (see Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, I, 4). Pherecydes said: Εἰς ἔρωτα μεταβεβλήσθαι τὸν Δία, μέλλοντα δημιουργεῖν (Jovem, cum mundum fabricare vellet, in cupidinem sese transformasse—When Zeus intended to create the world, he transformed himself into desire; Proclus on Plato's *Timaeus*, III). G. F. Schoemann has recently treated this subject at length in *De cupidine cosmogonico* (On Cosmogonic Desire), 1852. The Indians' Maya, whose work and web are the whole world of illusion, is likewise paraphrased by amor (love).

More than any other external part of the body, the genitals are subject to the will alone and not at all to cognition. Indeed, the will shows itself here almost as independent of cognition as it does in the organs that serve vegetative life and reproduction in response to mere stimuli. In them it acts blindly, as in nature without cognition. Procreation is simply reproduction transferred to a new individual: reproduction raised to a second power, just as death is excretion raised to a second power. The genitals are therefore the true *focus* of the will and thus the opposite pole from the brain, representative of cognition, the other side of the world as representation. They are the life-preserving principle that guarantees life without end in time. In this capacity they were revered as the phallus among the Greeks and the lingam among Hindus, symbols of the will's affirmation. Cognition, by contrast, makes possible the cancellation of willing, redemption through freedom, and the overcoming and annihilation of the world.

At the beginning of Book Four we considered at length how the will to live, in its affirmation, should view death. Death does not touch it, for it belongs to life itself, and its opposite, generation, balances it completely, securing and guaranteeing life for the will to live through all time despite the individual's death. The Indians expressed this by giving the lingam to Shiva, god of death, as an attribute. We also showed how someone standing with full reflection at the standpoint of decisive affirmation of life faces death without fear. Nothing

more needs to be said of it here. Most people stand at this standpoint without clear reflection and continually affirm life. The world mirrors this affirmation in countless individuals, endless time and space, and endless suffering, between generation and death without end.

Yet no complaint can be raised about this from any side. The will stages the great tragedy and comedy at its own expense and is itself the spectator. The world is as it is because the will whose appearance it is is as it is, because it wills so. Suffering is justified in that the will affirms itself even in this appearance; that affirmation is justified and balanced because the will bears the suffering. Here we already glimpse *eternal justice* in the whole. Later we shall recognize it more closely and clearly in individual cases. First, however, we must discuss temporal or human justice.^[1]

Notes

Notes

1. See chapter 45 of the second volume. ↩

§. 61.

We recall from Book Two that throughout nature, at every grade of the will's objectivation, individuals of every kind necessarily struggle against one another. This expresses an inner conflict of the will to live with itself. At the highest grade of objectivation this phenomenon, like everything else, becomes more distinct and can be deciphered further. For that purpose, let us first trace *egoism*, the starting point of all struggle, to its source.

We called time and space the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation) because a multiplicity of things of the same kind is possible only in and through them. They are the essential forms of natural cognition, which has sprung from the will. The will therefore appears everywhere in a multiplicity of individuals. This multiplicity, however, affects only its appearances, not the will as thing in itself. The will is present wholly and undivided in each, seeing around it countless repetitions of its own essence. Yet it finds that essence—the truly real—directly only within itself. Thus each individual wants everything for himself, wants to possess everything or at least to rule it, and would like to destroy whatever resists him.

In beings with cognition something further is added. The individual is the bearer of the knowing subject, and that subject is the bearer of the world. All nature outside the individual, including every other individual, exists only in his representation. He is conscious of them only as representations, thus only indirectly and as something dependent on his own essence and existence. With his consciousness the world necessarily perishes for him: its being and nonbeing then become equivalent and indistinguishable. Every knowing individual therefore really is, and finds himself to be, the whole will to live, the in-itself of the world, and also the complementary condition of the world as representation: a microcosm to be valued as highly as the macrocosm. Nature herself, always true everywhere, gives him direct certainty of this from the outset, without any reflection.

These two necessary conditions explain why every individual, though vanishingly small and reduced to nothing in the boundless world, nevertheless makes himself the world's centre. He puts his own existence and welfare ahead of everyone else's and, from the natural standpoint, is ready to sacrifice everything else to them. He would destroy the world merely to preserve his own self, that drop in the ocean, a little longer. This disposition is *egoism*, essential

to every thing in nature. It is precisely through egoism that the will's inner conflict with itself receives its terrible revelation.

Egoism has its basis and nature in the opposition of microcosm and macrocosm, or in the fact that the will's objectivation takes the *principium individuationis* as its form. The will thereby appears in the same way in countless individuals, wholly and completely in each on both sides, will and representation. Each individual is directly given to himself as the entire will and the entire representing subject, while the others are first given to him only as his representations. His own being and its preservation therefore take precedence over all of them together. Each looks upon his own death as the end of the world, while receiving news of acquaintances' deaths with comparative indifference unless personally affected.

At the highest degree of consciousness, the human one, egoism must reach its highest degree, just as cognition, pain, and pleasure do. The conflict among individuals arising from it must emerge most terribly. We see it everywhere, in small things and great. Its fearful side appears in the lives of great tyrants and villains and in wars that devastate the world. Its ridiculous side becomes a theme of comedy, emerging particularly in conceit and vanity, which La Rochefoucauld apprehended and presented *in abstracto* (in the abstract) as no one else has. We see it in world history and personal experience.

It appears most distinctly whenever a group of people is released from every law and order. Then Hobbes's *bellum omnium contra omnes* (war of all against all), admirably described in the first chapter of *De Cive* (On the Citizen), becomes immediately plain. We see not only each person trying to take from another what he wants, but often one person destroying another's entire happiness or life for a trivial increase in his own welfare. This is egoism's highest expression. In this respect its manifestations are surpassed only by those of actual malice, which seeks another's harm and pain wholly without self-interest or any advantage of its own. We shall discuss it shortly. Compare this account of egoism's source with its treatment in § 14 of my prize essay *On the Basis of Morality*.

A chief source of the suffering we found essential and unavoidable in all life, once suffering actually appears in a definite form, is this *Eris* (strife), the struggle among all individuals. It expresses the contradiction within the will to live, made visible through the *principium individuationis*. Animal fights are a cruel means of showing it directly and starkly. This original division is an

inexhaustible source of suffering despite the precautions taken against it, which we shall now examine more closely.

§. 62.

We have already seen that the first and simplest affirmation of the will to live is the affirmation of one's own body: the will presents itself in acts in time only so far as the body already presents the same will spatially in its form and purposiveness. This affirmation appears as preservation of the body through the use of its own powers. Satisfaction of the sexual drive is immediately connected to it and belongs to it insofar as the genitals belong to the body. *Voluntary* renunciation of that satisfaction, based on no *motive*, is therefore already denial of the will to live: the will freely cancels itself when cognition has arisen that acts as a *quietive*. Denial of one's own body thus already appears as the will's contradiction of its own appearance. The body still objectivates the will to reproduce in the genitals, yet reproduction is not willed. Precisely because such renunciation denies or cancels the will to live, it is a difficult and painful conquest of oneself. We shall return to it below.

The will presents this *self-affirmation* of each body in countless individuals alongside one another. Through the egoism common to them all, the will in one individual readily passes beyond that affirmation to *deny* the will appearing in another. The first individual's will breaks through the boundary of another's affirmation either by destroying or injuring that person's body, or by forcing its powers to serve his own will instead of the will appearing in that body. He withdraws the powers of another body from the will to which they belong and increases the power serving *his* will beyond his own body's powers. Thus he affirms his own will beyond his own body by denying the will appearing in another body.

This intrusion across the boundary of another's affirmation of the will has always been clearly recognized and named *injustice*. Both parties recognize what has happened at once, though as feeling rather than in the clear abstraction used here. The person suffering injustice feels the invasion of the sphere in which his own body affirms itself, and its denial by another individual, as an immediate mental pain quite separate from physical pain inflicted by the deed or distress over the loss. The person committing injustice likewise has an immediate dim feeling, not an abstract thought, that in himself he is the same will that appears in the other's body. In one appearance it affirms itself so vehemently that it crosses the boundary of its own body and its powers, denying that same will in another appearance. As will in itself, therefore, its vehemence

makes it struggle against and tear at itself. This feeling is called a pang of conscience or, more exactly in this case, the feeling of having committed *injustice*.

Injustice, whose concept we have analysed in the most general abstraction, finds its most complete, proper, and palpable expression *in concreto* (in the concrete) in cannibalism. That is its clearest visible type, a dreadful image of the will's greatest conflict with itself at its highest grade of objectivation, the human being. Murder follows next. A pang of conscience—whose meaning we have just stated abstractly and dryly—follows its commission at once with terrible clarity, inflicting a wound on peace of mind that cannot heal in a lifetime. Our horror of a murder committed, like our recoil from committing one, corresponds to the boundless attachment to life that pervades every living being as an appearance of the will to live. Later we shall analyse in more detail the feeling that accompanies injustice and evil, the anguish of conscience, and bring it into conceptual clarity. Intentional mutilation or mere injury of another body, even a blow, is of the same essential kind as murder and differs only in degree. Injustice also takes the form of subjugating another individual and forcing that person into slavery. Finally, it appears in an attack on another's property. Insofar as the property is regarded as the fruit of that person's labour, this is essentially of the same kind as enslavement, bearing the relation to it that a mere injury bears to murder.

On our account of injustice, *property* that cannot be taken from someone *without injustice* can only be what has been worked upon by that person's powers. To take it away is to withdraw the powers of his body from the will objectivated there and make them serve the will objectivated in another body. Only in this way can someone committing injustice invade another's sphere of willing by attacking an inanimate thing quite distinct from the other's body: the powers and labour of that body have, as it were, grown together with the thing and become identified with it. It follows that every genuine *moral* right of property is originally grounded solely in labour. This was generally accepted before Kant and is beautifully and plainly stated in the oldest of law books: "Sages who know ancient times declare that a cultivated field belongs to the person who uprooted the wood, cleared it, and ploughed it, just as an antelope belongs to the first hunter who mortally wounded it" (*Laws of Manu*, IX, 44).

I can explain Kant's entire doctrine of right, an odd tangle of mutually supporting errors, only by the weakness of his old age. This applies also to his attempt to ground property right in first occupation. How could the mere

declaration of my will to exclude others from using a thing immediately give me the *right* to exclude them? The declaration plainly needs a ground of right; Kant assumes that it is one. How could a person act unjustly in himself, morally, by disregarding a claim to sole possession grounded on nothing but someone else's declaration? How could his conscience be troubled by it? It is obvious that there can be no *rightful act of taking possession* as such. There can only be a rightful *appropriation* or acquisition through the use of powers originally one's own.

Where someone else's effort has worked upon, improved, protected from harm, or preserved a thing, however slight that effort—even if only picking a wild fruit or lifting it from the ground—someone who takes the thing plainly deprives that person of the result of the power expended upon it. The taker makes the other's body serve *his* will instead of its own, affirming his will beyond its appearance in his own body by denying the other's. That is injustice.^[1] By contrast, merely enjoying a thing without any effort to work upon or protect it from destruction gives no right to it, any more than declaring one's will to possess it exclusively does. If a family has hunted alone in an area for a century without improving it at all, it cannot exclude a newcomer who now wishes to hunt there without committing moral injustice.

The so-called right of preoccupation, under which one demands, as a further reward for having enjoyed a thing, an exclusive right to go on enjoying it, has no moral foundation. A newcomer could answer someone relying on that right with much better reason: "Precisely because you have enjoyed it so long, it is right that others enjoy it now." No exclusive possession of a thing wholly incapable of being worked upon, improved, or protected from harm has a moral foundation, unless all others voluntarily surrender their claims, perhaps in reward for other services. That already presupposes a community governed by agreement: the state. Moral property right as derived above, by its nature, gives the owner as unrestricted a power over a thing as over his own body. He can therefore transfer his property by exchange or gift, and another then possesses it with the same moral right.

In general, *injustice is committed* either through *force* or through *cunning*. They are the same in what matters morally. In murder it makes no difference whether I use a dagger or poison, and the same holds by analogy for bodily injury. Every other case of injustice can be traced to forcing another person to serve my will instead of his own, to act according to my will rather than his. With force I achieve this by physical causality. With cunning I use motivation,

causality passing through cognition: I offer the other person *apparent motives* by which, believing he follows *his* will, he in fact follows *mine*. Since motives exist in cognition, I can do this only by falsifying his cognition. This is the *lie*.

A lie always aims to influence someone else's will, not merely that person's cognition in and for itself. It influences cognition only as a means, insofar as cognition determines the will. My lie itself proceeds from my will and needs a motive. Only another's willing and acting can be such a motive, not that person's cognition in itself, which can never influence *my* will or move it toward an end except indirectly through willing and action. This applies not only to lies told for plain self-interest, but to lies told from pure malice, which seeks pleasure in the painful consequences of the error it causes. Even mere boasting aims to gain easier or greater influence over others' willing and acting by raising their regard and opinion of the boaster. Simply withholding a truth, refusing to say anything, is not in itself unjust. But every assertion of a falsehood is. Someone who refuses to show a lost traveller the right way does him no injustice; someone who points him the wrong way does.

It follows that every *lie*, like every act of violence, is *injustice* as such. Its purpose is to extend the rule of my will over other individuals and thus affirm my will by denying theirs, just as violence does. The most complete lie is a *broken contract*, in which all the features described are wholly and distinctly present. When I enter a contract, the other party's promised performance is directly and avowedly the motive for my performance now. Promises are exchanged deliberately and formally. By assumption each party controls the truth of his statement. If the other breaks the contract, he has deceived me. By putting merely apparent motives into my cognition, he has directed my will to his ends and extended the rule of his will over another person. He has therefore committed a complete injustice. This is the basis of contracts' moral lawfulness and validity.

Injustice through *force* is less *disgraceful* for its perpetrator than injustice through *cunning*. Force testifies to physical strength, which impresses humanity under all circumstances. Cunning takes a roundabout path and thus betrays weakness, lowering its user both physically and morally. Moreover, lying and deceit succeed only when the deceiver simultaneously expresses disgust and contempt for them to gain trust. His victory rests on being credited with honesty he does not possess. The deep revulsion everywhere felt toward guile, disloyalty, and betrayal arises because trust and honesty form the bond that unites again from outside the will fragmented among individuals. They thereby

restrain the consequences of the egoism produced by that fragmentation. Disloyalty and betrayal tear this last external bond and give egoism's consequences free rein.

In our account the content of the concept *injustice* is an individual's action extending affirmation of the will appearing in his own body until it denies the will appearing in other bodies. Through general examples we have shown where injustice begins and marked its degrees from highest to lower by a few principal concepts. Thus *injustice* is the original, positive concept; *right* or justice, its opposite, is derived and negative. We should attend to concepts, not words. No one would ever have spoken of right if there were no injustice. The concept of right contains simply the negation of injustice. It includes every act that does not cross the boundary described above by denying another's will in order to affirm one's own more strongly. In a purely *moral* determination, this boundary divides all possible actions into just and unjust.

As soon as an act does not invade and deny another's sphere of affirmation in the manner described, it is not an injustice. Refusing help to someone in urgent need, or calmly watching another starve while one has plenty, is therefore cruel and devilish but not unjust. We can, however, say with complete certainty that anyone capable of such lovelessness and hardness will commit every injustice when his desires require it and no force restrains him.

The concept of *right*, as negation of injustice, finds its chief application and doubtless first arose when an attempted injustice is warded off by force. The defence cannot itself be injustice and is therefore right, although the force used in it, considered alone and apart, would be unjust. Its motive justifies it and makes it rightful. If someone affirms his will so far that he enters the sphere of affirmation essential to me as a person and thereby denies it, my resistance only denies that denial. On my part it is no more than affirmation of the will that appears essentially and originally in my body and is already expressed *implicitly* by its mere appearance. It is therefore not unjust but *rightful*.

I then have a *right* to negate the other's denial with the force needed to cancel it. This may extend to killing the other individual. An invading external force can be resisted with a counterforce somewhat stronger than itself without any injustice, and therefore rightly. Everything I do remains within the sphere of affirmation of the will essential to my person and already expressed by it. That sphere is the site of the struggle; I do not enter the other's sphere. My act is the denial of a denial, thus affirmation rather than denial itself. If another will

denies mine as it appears in my body and my use of its powers to preserve it, without denying any other will that respects the same boundary, I may *without injustice* compel the other to cease that denial. To this extent I have a *right to use force*.

Whenever I have a complete right to use *force* against another, I may, according to the circumstances, counter the other's force with *cunning* instead, without injustice. I therefore have a genuine *right to lie exactly as far as I have a right to compel*. Someone who assures a highway robber searching him that he has nothing else is acting quite rightly, as is someone who lures a nocturnal intruder into a cellar by a lie and locks him in. A captive carried away by robbers, such as Barbary corsairs, has a right to kill them for freedom, either by open force or by stealth. A promise extorted by immediate physical violence is therefore wholly nonbinding: the person coerced could rightfully escape the coercers by killing them, still more by deceiving them.

Someone who cannot recover stolen property by force commits no injustice by getting it back through cunning. Indeed, if someone gambles away money stolen from me, I have the right to use false dice against him, since everything I win from him already belongs to me. Anyone denying this would have still more reason to deny the lawfulness of stratagems in war, which amount to lies in action and confirm Queen Christina of Sweden's saying: "Human words are worth nothing; their deeds can scarcely be trusted." Thus the boundary of right runs very close to that of injustice. It is unnecessary to show that all this agrees with what I said above about the injustice of lying and violence. It may also clarify the curious theories about lies told from necessity.^[2]

Right and injustice are therefore purely *moral* determinations. They are valid for considering human action as such and its *inner meaning in itself*. This announces itself directly in consciousness. On one side, committing injustice is accompanied by inner pain, a felt awareness in the wrongdoer of his will's excessive affirmation, which has reached the point of denying the will's appearance in another. He also feels that although as appearance he differs from the injured person, in himself he is identical with that person. The full explanation of this inner meaning of anguish of conscience belongs later. On the other side, the person suffering injustice is painfully aware that another has denied his will as expressed already in his body and its natural needs, which nature directs him to satisfy through that body's powers. He is also aware that he could resist that denial in any way without injustice if he had the power.

This purely moral meaning is the only meaning right and injustice have for a human being *as a human being*, not as a citizen. It would therefore remain even in a state of nature without positive law. It is the basis and content of what has been called *natural right*, though “moral right” would be better. Its validity extends not to suffering or outward actuality but only to doing and to the self-knowledge of one's individual will that follows from doing, called *conscience*. In a state of nature it cannot always assert itself outwardly against others or prevent force from ruling in place of right. There it depends only on a person not to *commit* injustice in each case. Whether he will *suffer* injustice depends on his contingent external strength.

Right and injustice are therefore valid even in the state of nature and are not conventions, but there they are only *moral* concepts for each person's self-knowledge of his will. They mark a fixed point on the scale of the widely differing degrees to which the will to live affirms itself in human individuals, like the freezing point on a thermometer. At this point affirmation of one's own will turns into denial of another's; committing injustice shows how vehement one's will is and how captive one's cognition remains in the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation), the form of cognition wholly in the will's service.

Someone who sets aside or denies a purely moral consideration of action and considers only its outward effect and results can, with *Hobbes*, declare right and injustice conventional, arbitrary determinations that do not exist outside positive law. External experience can never teach such a person what does not belong to external experience. Hobbes strikingly characterizes his entirely empirical way of thinking in his *De principiis Geometrarum* (On the Principles of the Geometers): he denies pure mathematics outright and stubbornly maintains that a point has extension and a line breadth. We cannot show him a point without extension or a line without breadth, and can no more teach him the *a priori* nature of mathematics than that of right, since he has shut himself off from all non-empirical cognition.

Pure *doctrine of right* is thus a chapter of *morality*. It concerns directly only *doing*, not *suffering*. Only doing expresses the will, and morality considers the will alone. Suffering is merely an event. Morality can consider it only indirectly, by showing that something done solely to avoid suffering an injustice is not itself an injustice. This chapter of morality would determine precisely how far an individual may affirm the will already objectivated in his body without denying the same will appearing in someone else. It would then

identify the acts that cross that boundary, are therefore unjust, and may accordingly be resisted without injustice. One's own *doing* would always remain the subject of inquiry.

In external experience, however, what appears as an event is *suffering injustice*. In it, more plainly than anywhere else, we see the will to live in conflict with itself. This conflict arises from the multiplicity of individuals and their egoism, both conditioned by the *principium individuationis*, the form the world as representation takes for an individual's cognition. We have already seen that this conflict among individuals is an ever flowing source of a very large part of the suffering essential to human life.

Reason, which all these individuals share, lets them grasp not only particular cases, as animals do, but the whole in its abstract connections. It soon taught them to recognize the source of that suffering and to seek a way to diminish or, if possible, abolish it through a common sacrifice outweighed by the common benefit. Although an individual egoist enjoys committing an injustice on an occasion, that act necessarily has a counterpart: another individual suffers the injustice, and this is a great pain to him. When reason considers the whole, it steps for a moment outside its own individual's one-sided standpoint and attachment to him. It sees that one person's enjoyment of committing injustice is outweighed each time by the relatively greater pain of the one who suffers it. Reason sees further that if everything is left to chance, each person must fear suffering injustice much more often than he enjoys committing it. Thus, to reduce the suffering spread among everyone and distribute it as evenly as possible, the best and only means is to spare everyone the pain of suffering injustice by having everyone renounce the pleasure obtainable through committing it.

This means, readily devised and gradually perfected by egoism proceeding methodically through reason and abandoning its one-sided standpoint, is the *social contract*, or *law*. Plato already presents its origin as I do here in the *Republic*. In fact, this is the only essential origin, dictated by the nature of the matter. Nor can the state in any country ever have had another, for this manner of origin and this purpose alone make it a state. It makes no difference whether the condition preceding it among a particular people was a crowd of independent savages, or anarchy, or a crowd of slaves ruled at the strongest person's whim, or despotism. Neither condition was a state. The state first arises through that common agreement, and is more or less perfect according as the agreement is more or less mixed with anarchy or despotism. Republics tend

toward anarchy, monarchies toward despotism, and the constitutional monarchy invented as a middle course toward rule by factions. To found a perfect state one would have to begin by creating beings whose nature allowed them always to sacrifice their own welfare for the public good. Until then, something can be achieved by having *one* family whose welfare is inseparable from the country's, so that at least in the principal matters it cannot advance one without the other. This is the source of the strength and advantage of hereditary monarchy.

Morality, then, is concerned exclusively with *doing* right or wrong, and can mark the precise boundary of action for someone resolved to commit no injustice. Conversely, political theory, the theory of legislation, concerns only *suffering* injustice. It would take no interest in *committing* injustice except for its necessarily corresponding instance of someone suffering it, the enemy it aims to oppose. Indeed, if one could conceive an unjust act connected with no suffering of injustice on anyone else's part, the state would consistently have no reason to forbid it. Moreover, because in *morality* the will and disposition are the object of consideration and the only reality, morality counts a firm resolve to commit an injustice, restrained and rendered ineffective only by external power, as equal to an injustice actually committed; it judges the person so resolved unjust. The state, by contrast, takes no interest whatever in will and disposition merely as such. It is concerned only with the *act*, whether attempted or completed, because of its counterpart, the *suffering* of another. For the state the act, the occurrence, is the only reality; disposition and intention are investigated only insofar as they explain the meaning of the act. Thus the state will not forbid anyone to entertain constant thoughts of murder and poison against another, provided it knows for certain that fear of the sword and the breaking wheel will always prevent those thoughts from taking effect. The state has no foolish scheme to extirpate the inclination to commit injustice, or an evil disposition. It merely places beside every possible motive for committing an injustice a stronger motive to refrain from it: the inevitable punishment. Accordingly the criminal code is as complete a register as possible of counter-motives to all presumably possible criminal acts, both set out *in abstracto* (in the abstract), for application *in concreto* (in a concrete case) when needed.

For this purpose political theory, or legislation, borrows from morality the chapter on the doctrine of right, which determines the precise boundary between right and injustice along with their inner meaning. It does so solely to use the other side of that doctrine. Every boundary morality says we must not

cross if we do not wish to *commit* injustice is viewed instead as a boundary whose crossing by another we need not tolerate if we do not wish to *suffer* injustice, and from which we have a *right* to repel others. Laws therefore fortify those boundaries as seen from the potentially passive side. As the historian has wittily been called a prophet turned backward, so the jurist is a moralist turned backward. Jurisprudence in the proper sense, the doctrine of the *rights* one may assert, is morality turned backward in the chapter where morality teaches the rights one may not violate. The concept of injustice and of its negation, right, is originally *moral*; it becomes *juridical* when the starting point shifts from the active to the passive side. This reversal, together with Kant's doctrine of right, which very wrongly derives the establishment of the state as a moral duty from his categorical imperative, has lately caused the strange error that the state is an institution for promoting morality, arises from striving after morality, and is consequently directed against egoism. As if the inner disposition, to which alone morality or immorality belongs, the eternally free will, could be modified externally and changed by external action! Still more perverse is the doctrine that the state is the condition of freedom in the moral sense, and thus of morality, when freedom lies beyond appearance, still more beyond human institutions.

The state, as I have said, is so little directed against egoism as such that it springs precisely from egoism that understands its interests, acts methodically, and moves from a one-sided to a general standpoint. It sums the shared egoism of everyone and exists only to serve it. It is established on the correct assumption that pure morality, or doing right for moral reasons, cannot be expected; otherwise the state itself would be superfluous. Its purpose is therefore not to oppose egoism but to secure well-being against the harmful consequences that arise reciprocally among a multitude of egoistic individuals. Thus *Aristotle* already says (*De Rep.*, III): Τέλος μὲν οὖν πόλεως τὸ εὖ ζῆν· τοῦτο δὲ ἐστὶν τὸ ζῆν εὐδαιμόνως καὶ καλῶς. (*Finis civitatis est bene vivere, hoc autem est beate et pulchre vivere*; “The end of the city is living well, that is, living happily and nobly.”) *Hobbes* too explained this origin and purpose of the state correctly and excellently. The old maxim of all political order, *salus publica prima lex esto* (“let the public welfare be the first law”), expresses the same point.

If the state achieved its purpose perfectly, it would produce the same outward appearance as a universal, perfectly just disposition. Yet the inner nature and origin of the two appearances would be opposite. In the latter case

no one would *want to commit* injustice; in the former, no one would *want to suffer* it, and the proper means to that end would have been used perfectly. The same line can be drawn from opposite directions, and a muzzled predator is as harmless as an herbivore. The state cannot go further than this point. It cannot produce an appearance like that arising from universal mutual benevolence and love. For we have just found that, by its nature, it would not prohibit an unjust act without any corresponding suffering of injustice by someone else; it prohibits every unjust act only because such a thing is impossible. Conversely, in keeping with its aim of general welfare, it would gladly ensure that everyone *received* benevolence and all kinds of charitable acts. But these necessarily have a counterpart in someone's *performing* them. Every citizen would want the passive role, no one the active role, and there would be no ground for imposing the latter on one person rather than another. Consequently only the negative, namely *right*, can be enforced, not the positive duties called duties of love or imperfect duties.

Legislation, then, borrows the pure doctrine of right, the moral doctrine of the nature and limits of right and injustice. It applies that doctrine from the opposite side for purposes foreign to morality, and accordingly establishes positive legislation and the means of upholding it, that is, the state. Positive legislation is thus the purely moral doctrine of right applied in reverse. Such an application may take account of the special conditions and circumstances of a particular people. But the resulting legislation is properly *positive right*, and the state a *lawful* association, a *state* in the proper sense and a morally permissible institution, only if the positive legislation is essentially determined throughout by the pure doctrine of right, so that every provision can be grounded in that doctrine. Otherwise it establishes *positive injustice*: it is itself publicly acknowledged and enforced injustice. Every despotism is of this sort, as are the constitutions of most Muslim realms and even parts of many other constitutions, such as serfdom and forced labor. Pure doctrine of right, or natural right—better, moral right—underlies every lawful positive legislation, though always through this reversal, just as pure mathematics underlies every branch of applied mathematics.

The most important points of pure doctrine of right, which philosophy must provide to legislation for that purpose, are these: (1) explanation of the inner and proper meaning and origin of the concepts of injustice and right, and their application and place in morality; (2) derivation of the right of property; (3) derivation of the moral validity of contracts, since this is the moral foundation

of the social contract; (4) explanation of the state's origin and purpose, the relation of this purpose to morality, and the transfer of the moral doctrine of right to legislation by reversing it in accordance with this relation; and (5) derivation of the right to punish. The rest of the doctrine of right merely applies these principles, defining more precisely the boundaries of right and injustice in every possible situation of life, grouped and divided under certain headings. Textbooks of pure right largely agree in these particular doctrines. They differ widely in their principles, since these are always bound to some philosophical system. Having discussed the first four chief points briefly and generally, but definitely and clearly, in accordance with ours, we must speak similarly of the right to punish.

Kant makes the fundamentally false claim that no fully valid right of property exists outside the state. According to our derivation above, property exists even in the state of nature, with a full natural, that is, moral right. It cannot be violated without injustice, and may be defended to the utmost without injustice. Outside the state, however, there is certainly no *right to punish*. Every such right is founded solely on a positive law that has assigned a punishment *before* the offence, its threat being intended as a counter-motive stronger than any possible motive for committing that offence. This positive law must be regarded as sanctioned and acknowledged by all citizens. It thus rests on a common contract whose fulfilment binds the members of the state in all circumstances: on one side to carry out the punishment and on the other to submit to it. Submission may therefore rightly be compelled. Thus the immediate *purpose of punishment* in a particular case is *fulfilment of the law as a contract*. But the sole purpose of the *law* is *deterrence* from violating another's rights. People have united in a state, renounced committing injustice, and accepted the burdens of maintaining the state so that each may be protected from suffering injustice.

Law and its execution, punishment, are therefore essentially directed toward the *future*, not the *past*. This distinguishes *punishment* from *revenge*, which is motivated solely by what has happened, by the past as such. Inflicting pain in retaliation for injustice without any future aim is revenge. It can serve no purpose except to console oneself for one's own suffering by seeing another suffer at one's hand. This is malice and cruelty and cannot be justified ethically. An injustice someone has done to me does not entitle me to do him an injustice. Returning evil for evil without any further aim can be justified neither morally nor on any other rational ground; the *jus talionis* ("law of retaliation") as an

independent, ultimate principle of punishment is meaningless. Kant's theory of punishment as sheer retribution for the sake of retribution is therefore wholly groundless and perverse. It still haunts the works of many jurists under grand phrases that amount to empty words: that punishment atones for the crime, neutralizes it, cancels it, and the like. Yet no one is authorized to set himself up as a purely moral judge and avenger, to visit another's misdeeds upon him by causing him pain and imposing penance. That would be a most presumptuous claim. Hence the biblical saying: "Vengeance is mine, says the Lord, and I will repay."

Human beings do have the right to provide for society's safety. They can do so only by prohibiting all acts called "criminal," with threatened punishments serving as counter-motives to prevent them. A threat can be effective only if punishment is carried out when such a case nevertheless occurs. That the purpose of punishment—or more precisely of penal law—is deterrence from crime is so generally acknowledged and self-evident that it is even expressed in the very old English form of indictment still used by the Crown's advocate in criminal cases: *if this be proved, you, the said N. N., ought to be punished with pains of law, to deter others from the like crimes, in all time coming.*^{[3][4]} A future purpose distinguishes punishment from revenge. Punishment has that purpose only when carried out *in fulfilment of a law*. By announcing itself through this fulfilment as inevitable in every future case, it preserves the law's deterrent force, its very purpose.

Here a Kantian would certainly object that, on this view, the punished criminal is used "merely as a *means*." But the maxim repeated tirelessly by all Kantians, that one must always treat a human being only as an end and never as a means, sounds impressive and is therefore particularly useful to those who like a formula that relieves them of further thought. In the light, however, it is extremely vague and indefinite, achieves its purpose only indirectly, and requires special explanation, definition, and modification for every application. Taken generally, it says too little, is inadequate, and is also open to question. A murderer who has incurred the death penalty under the law must now indeed, and quite rightly, be used as a mere *means*. He has disturbed public safety, the principal purpose of the state; if the law remains unfulfilled, he has abolished it. His life and person must now be the *means* of fulfilling the law and thereby restoring public safety. He is rightly made such a means in fulfilment of the social contract that he too entered as a citizen. Under it he pledged his life,

liberty, and property to secure those of all, in order to enjoy security for his own. That pledge has now been forfeited.

The theory of punishment presented here, immediately clear to sound reason, is admittedly not, in its essentials, a new thought. New errors had nearly displaced it, which made a clear account necessary. It is substantially contained in what Pufendorf says on the subject in *De officio hominis et civis* (*On the Duty of Man and Citizen*), book 2, chapter 13. Hobbes agrees with it in *Leviathan*, chapters 15 and 28. In our day, Feuerbach has famously defended it. Indeed, it is already present in the pronouncements of ancient philosophers. Plato sets it out clearly in the *Protagoras* (p. 114, Bipont edition), in the *Gorgias* (p. 168), and finally in book eleven of the *Laws* (p. 165). Seneca expresses Plato's view and the whole theory of punishment perfectly in a few words: *Nemo prudens punit, quia peccatum est; sed ne peccetur* (*De Ira*, I, 16; "No wise person punishes because a wrong has been done, but so that a wrong will not be done").

We have thus come to know the state as the means by which egoism equipped with reason seeks to escape its own harmful consequences when they turn against it, so that each now promotes the welfare of all because he sees his own welfare included in it. If the state fully attained its goal, it might ultimately bring about something approaching a land of plenty, since it can use the combined powers of its members to make the rest of nature more and more serviceable and remove all kinds of evils. Yet it remains very far from this goal. Even if it reached it, countless evils essential to life would still preserve suffering; if all the others were removed, boredom would immediately occupy every place they left. Nor can the state ever wholly abolish conflict among individuals: it teases in small matters where it is forbidden in great ones. Finally Eris, successfully expelled from within, turns outward. Banished by the state from conflict among individuals, she returns from outside as war among nations and demands at once, on a large scale, the bloody sacrifices that prudent arrangements had denied her one by one, as though collecting an accumulated debt. Even if wisdom founded on millennia of experience finally overcame and eliminated all of this, the result would in the end be a genuine overpopulation of the entire planet, whose terrible evils only a bold imagination can now picture.^[5]

Notes

Notes

1. There is thus no need to assume two distinct grounds of title to establish the natural right of property, one based on *detention* alongside one based on *formation*; the latter suffices throughout. “Formation” is not quite the right name, however, since expending effort on something need not always give it a form. ↩
2. A fuller account of the doctrine of right set out here appears in my prize essay *On the Basis of Morality*, §17, pp. 221–230 of the first edition [2nd ed., pp. 216–226]. ↩
3. “If this is proved, you, the said N. N., must suffer the legal penalty, to deter others from similar crimes for all future time.” ↩
4. If a prince wishes to pardon a criminal who has been justly convicted, his minister will object that the crime would soon recur. ↩
5. See chapter 47 of the second volume on this point. ↩

§. 63.

We have come to know *temporal justice*, which has its seat in the state, as retributive or punitive. We saw that it becomes justice only by regard for the *future*. Without this, every punishment and repayment of an offence would remain unjustified: merely adding a second evil to one already committed, without sense or meaning. But *eternal justice*, which we mentioned earlier, is quite different. It governs the world, not the state; it depends on no human institutions, is subject to neither chance nor deception, and is neither uncertain, wavering, nor mistaken, but infallible, fixed, and sure. The concept of retribution already includes time. Eternal justice therefore cannot be retributive: unlike temporal justice, it can grant no delay or respite, and cannot require time to balance an evil deed with an evil consequence. Here punishment must be so connected with the offence that the two are one.

Δοκεῖτε πηδᾶν τ' ἀδικήματ' εἰς θεοὺς
 Πτεροῖσι, κᾶπειτ' ἐν Διὸς δέλτου πτυχαῖς
 Γράφειν τιν' αὐτά, Ζῆνα δ' εἰσορῶντα νιν
 Θνητοῖς δικάζειν; Οὐδ' ὁ πᾶς οὐρανὸς,
 Διὸς γράφοντος τὰς βροτῶν ἁμαρτίας,
 Ἐξαρκέσειεν, οὐδ' ἐκεῖνος ἂν σκοπῶν
 Πέμπειν ἐκάστῳ ζημίαν· ἀλλ' ἡ Δίκη
 Ἐνταῦθά που ὅστιν ἐγγύς, εἰ βούλεσθ' ὀρᾶν.

Euripides, quoted by Stobaeus, Eclogae, I, chapter 4.

*Volare pennis scelera ad aetherias domus
 Putatis, illic in Jovis tabularia
 Scripto referri; tum Jovem lectis super
 Sententiam proferre? – sed mortalium
 Facinora coeli, quantaquanta est, regia
 Nequit tenere: nec legendis Juppiter
 Et puniendis par est. Est tamen ultio,
 Et, si intuemur, illa nos habitat prope.*

(“Do you think that crimes fly on wings to the heavenly dwelling, are entered there in Jupiter's records, and that Jupiter reads them and pronounces judgment? The whole expanse of heaven could not contain the deeds of mortals, nor could Jupiter read and punish them all. Yet justice is here, close to us, if we choose to look.”)

Anyone who has grasped the thought developed so far will soon find it perfectly clear that such eternal justice really does lie in the world's essence.

The world, in all the multiplicity of its parts and forms, is the appearance, the objectivity, of the one will to live. Existence itself, and its character in the whole as in every part, comes solely from the will. It is free and all-powerful. In each thing the will appears exactly as it determines itself in itself and outside time. The world is only the mirror of this willing. All the finitude, suffering, and torment it contains belong to the expression of what the will wills; they exist because it wills in this way. Thus every being bears existence in general, and then the existence of its species and its particular individuality, just as they are, in circumstances and a world just as they are, ruled by chance and error, temporal, transient, and always suffering, with the strictest right. In everything that happens to it, or even can happen to it, it always receives its due. For the will is its own, and as the will is, so is the world. Only the world itself can bear responsibility for its existence and character. Who else could have made it out of himself? If one wants to know what human beings are worth as a whole and in general, viewed morally, one should look at their fate as a whole and in general. It is deprivation, misery, distress, torment, and death. Eternal justice rules: if, taken as a whole, they were not worthless, their fate as a whole would not be so wretched. In this sense we can say: the world itself is the Last Judgment. If all the world's misery could be placed in one pan of a balance and all the world's guilt in the other, the scales would surely balance.

Of course, the world does not appear in this way to cognition that has arisen to serve the will and belongs to an individual as such. To the inquirer the world is ultimately revealed as the objectivity of the one and only will to live that he himself is. But, as the Indians say, the veil of Maya clouds the uncultivated individual's sight. Instead of the thing in itself, he sees only appearance in time and space, according to the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation), and in the other forms of the principle of sufficient reason. Within this limited form of cognition he does not see the essence of things, which is one; he sees its appearances as separate, divided, innumerable, very different, and even opposed. Pleasure seems one thing to him and torment quite another; one person is a tormentor and murderer, another a sufferer and victim; evil deeds are one thing and suffering another. He sees one person living in joy, abundance, and pleasure while another dies painfully of deprivation and cold at his door. Then he asks where retribution is. He himself, in the intense urge of will that is his origin and essence, seizes life's pleasures and enjoyments and

clings tightly to them. He does not know that by this very act of willing he also seizes and embraces all the pains and torments of life, at whose sight he shudders. He sees suffering and evil deeds in the world, but is far from recognizing them as different sides of the appearance of the one will to live. He takes them to be very different, even wholly opposed, and often tries to escape suffering in his own person through an evil deed, by causing another to suffer. He remains captive to the *principium individuationis*, deceived by Maya's veil.

On a raging sea, boundless in every direction, where roaring mountains of water rise and fall, a sailor sits in a little boat and trusts his frail craft. Just so the individual sits calmly amid a world of torments, supported by and trusting the *principium individuationis*, the way the individual knows things as appearance. The boundless world, full of suffering everywhere in an infinite past and an infinite future, is alien to him, even a fairy tale. Only his fleeting person, his extensionless present, and his momentary comfort are real to him; he does everything to preserve them, so long as better cognition does not open his eyes. Until then, only in the deepest recess of his consciousness does a very dim foreboding remain: all that suffering may not really be so foreign to him, and may be connected with him in a way from which the *principium individuationis* cannot protect him. From this foreboding comes the ineradicable *dread* common to all human beings, perhaps even to the more intelligent animals. It suddenly seizes them when some chance occurrence makes them doubt the *principium individuationis*, when the principle of sufficient reason seems to admit an exception in one of its forms: when a change seems to occur without a cause, for example, or a dead person seems to return, or the past or future somehow becomes present, or the distant near. Their immense terror arises because they suddenly doubt the forms of cognition belonging to appearance, the forms that alone keep their own individuality separate from the rest of the world. Yet this separation belongs only to appearance, not to the thing in itself. Eternal justice rests on this very point.

Indeed, all temporal happiness and all prudence move across undermined ground. They protect the person from misfortune and provide enjoyment, but the person is mere appearance. His difference from other individuals, and his exemption from the suffering they bear, rest on the form of appearance, the *principium individuationis*. According to the true essence of things, everyone must regard all the world's sufferings as his own, and indeed all possible suffering as actual for himself, so long as he is a firm will to live, affirming life with all his strength. For cognition that sees through the *principium*

individuationis, a happy life in time, whether granted by chance or won by prudence, amid the sufferings of countless others is merely a beggar's dream that he is a king. He must wake to discover that only a fleeting illusion separated him from the suffering of his life.

Eternal justice escapes the view captive to cognition that follows the principle of sufficient reason and the *principium individuationis*. This view finds justice wholly absent unless it saves it with fictions. It sees the wicked person live in pleasure after every kind of misdeed and cruelty, then depart this world untroubled. It sees the oppressed drag out a life of suffering to its end without an avenger or one who will repay. But eternal justice can be grasped only by someone who rises above cognition that advances along the thread of the principle of sufficient reason and remains bound to individual things. He knows the Ideas, sees through the *principium individuationis*, and realizes that the thing in itself does not bear the forms of appearance. The same cognition alone enables him to understand the true nature of virtue, which will soon become clear in connection with our present inquiry, though its practice by no means requires this cognition *in abstracto* (in the abstract).

Someone who reaches that cognition sees clearly that, because the will is the in-itself of all appearance, the torment inflicted on others and that experienced oneself, the evil deed and the suffering, always strike one and the same being. Their appearances stand as quite different individuals and may even be separated by remote times and places. He understands that the difference between the person who inflicts suffering and the person who must endure it is only phenomenal; it does not touch the thing in itself. This is the will living in both. Deceived by cognition bound to its service, it fails to recognize itself: seeking greater well-being in *one* of its appearances, it causes great suffering in *another*. In its vehement urge it sinks its teeth into its own flesh, unaware that it always injures only itself. Through individuation it thus reveals the conflict it carries within itself. The tormentor and the tormented are one. The former errs in thinking himself exempt from torment; the latter, in thinking himself exempt from guilt. If both had their eyes opened, the one who inflicted suffering would recognize that he lives in everything suffering torment anywhere in the wide world, and, if endowed with reason, ponders in vain why it was called into existence for such immense suffering without seeing any guilt for it. The tormented person would realize that every evil ever done in the world flows from the will that also constitutes *his* essence and appears in *him*. Through this

appearance and its affirmation he has taken upon himself all the sufferings arising from such a will, and rightly endures them so long as he is that will.

The poet Calderón speaks from an intimation of this knowledge in *Life Is a Dream*:

*Pues el delito mayor
Del hombre es haber nacido.*

("For the greatest crime of man is to have been born.")

How could it not be a crime when an eternal law attaches death to it? In those lines Calderón has merely expressed the Christian dogma of original sin.

Living knowledge of eternal justice—of the balance beam that inseparably joins *malum culpae* (the evil of guilt) with *malo poenae* (the evil of punishment)—requires a complete ascent beyond individuality and the principle that makes it possible. Like the related clear, pure knowledge of the essence of all virtue that we shall discuss next, it will therefore always remain inaccessible to most people. The wise ancestors of the Indian people expressed it directly, as far as concepts and language and their still figurative, rhapsodic manner allowed, in discourses permitted only to the three twice-born castes, that is, in their esoteric teaching. In the popular religion, or exoteric teaching, by contrast, they communicated it only through myth. We find the direct presentation in those discourses, the fruit of the highest human cognition and wisdom, whose core has at last come to us in the Upanishads as the greatest gift of this century. It is expressed in several ways, above all when all the beings of the world, living and lifeless, are shown to the pupil one after another, and over each is spoken the phrase that has become the *Mahavakya*, the great saying: *Tatoumes*, more correctly *tat twam asi*—"This is you."^[1]

For the people, that great truth was translated, so far as their limitations allowed them to grasp it, into the mode of cognition following the principle of sufficient reason. This mode by its very nature cannot receive the truth purely and in itself; indeed, it directly contradicts it. In myth, however, it received a substitute adequate to guide conduct: a figurative presentation makes the ethical significance of conduct intelligible even in the mode of cognition governed by the principle of sufficient reason, to which that significance is inherently foreign. This is the purpose of all doctrines of faith, which all clothe in myth a truth inaccessible to an untrained human understanding. In Kant's language this myth could even be called a postulate of practical reason. Considered in this way, it has the great advantage of containing no elements beyond those lying

visibly before us in reality; all its concepts can therefore be supplied with intuitions. I mean the myth of the transmigration of souls.

It teaches that all the sufferings one inflicts on other beings in this life must be atoned for in a later life in this very world by enduring precisely those sufferings oneself. It goes so far as to teach that even someone who kills an animal will, sometime in infinite time, be born as that very animal and die the same death. It teaches that evil conduct leads to a future life in this world as a suffering and despised being: rebirth in a lower caste, or as a woman, an animal, a pariah or Chandala, a leper, a crocodile, and so forth. The myth illustrates every torment it threatens by beings who suffer in the actual world without knowing why they deserve their suffering. It needs no other hell. As reward, by contrast, it promises rebirth in better and nobler forms, as a Brahmin, a sage, or a saint. The highest reward awaits the noblest acts and complete resignation. It is also promised to a woman who voluntarily dies on her husband's pyre in seven successive lives, and to a person whose pure mouth has never spoken a single lie. The myth can express this reward in the language of this world only negatively, by its frequent promise that one will no longer be born again: *non adsumes iterum existentiam apparentem* ("you will not again assume an apparent existence"). Or as the Buddhists, who recognize neither the Vedas nor castes, put it: "You will attain Nirvana," a state in which four things do not exist: birth, old age, sickness, and death.

No myth has ever followed, or ever will follow, a philosophical truth accessible to so few as closely as this ancient doctrine of the noblest and oldest people. Despite the ways in which that people has now declined, the doctrine still prevails there as a general popular belief and decisively influences life today as it did four thousand years ago. Pythagoras and Plato already admired that unsurpassable mythical presentation, brought it from India or Egypt, revered and used it, and perhaps even believed it to some degree we cannot determine. Yet we now send English *clergymen* and Moravian linen weavers to the Brahmins, out of pity to teach them better and tell them that they were made from nothing and should gratefully rejoice in it. But we fare like someone firing a ball at a cliff. Our religions will never take root in India: the primeval wisdom of humanity will not be displaced by events in Galilee. Indian wisdom, on the contrary, is flowing back to Europe and will bring a fundamental change to our knowledge and thought.

Notes

Notes

1. *Oupnek'hat*, vol. 1, p. 60 ff. ↩

§. 64.

Let us now pass from our philosophical, rather than mythical, account of eternal justice to the related questions of the ethical significance of action and of conscience, which is a merely felt knowledge of that justice. First, however, I want to call attention to two peculiarities of human nature. They may help show how everyone has at least a dim feeling of the essence of eternal justice, and of the unity and identity of the will in all its appearances on which that justice rests.

Quite apart from the state's purpose in punishing, which we have established as the basis of its right to punish, it satisfies not only the injured party, generally animated by a desire for revenge, but also a wholly disinterested spectator to see someone who has caused another pain suffer just as much pain in return. To me this expresses nothing other than an awareness of eternal justice. An unpurified understanding, however, immediately misunderstands and distorts that awareness. Captive to the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation), it confuses the concepts and demands of appearance what belongs only to the thing in itself. It does not see that the offender and the injured person are one in themselves, that one being, failing to recognize itself in its own appearance, bears both torment and guilt. Instead it demands to see torment again in the very individual who bears the guilt.

Thus most people would also demand that a person of exceptional wickedness, whose degree of malice might exist in many others but not combined with his other qualities, should pay for everything he has done. Suppose that exceptional mental powers make him far superior to others and enable him, as a world conqueror for example, to inflict unspeakable suffering on millions. People would insist that at some time and place he atone for all those sufferings with an equal measure of pain. They do not see that in themselves the tormentor and the tormented are one: the same will through which his victims exist and live appears in him and finds in him the clearest revelation of its nature. It suffers in the conqueror no less than in the oppressed, indeed to a greater degree in him insofar as his consciousness is clearer and more distinct and his will more vehement. Christian ethics already shows that a deeper cognition, no longer captive to the *principium individuationis*, from which every virtue and nobility of character proceeds, no longer harbors this demand for retribution. It absolutely forbids returning evil for evil and locates

eternal justice in the realm of the thing in itself, distinct from appearance: "Vengeance is mine; I will repay, says the Lord" (Romans 12:19).

A much more striking, though much rarer, trait of human nature also expresses the desire to draw eternal justice into the realm of experience, that is, of individuation. At the same time it points to a felt awareness that, as I said above, the will to live stages the great tragedy and comedy at its own expense, and that the same one will lives in all appearances. Sometimes we see a person so deeply outraged by a grave injustice he has suffered, or perhaps only witnessed, that he deliberately and without hope of escape stakes his own life on avenging himself against its perpetrator. He may seek out a powerful oppressor for years, finally murder him, and then die on the scaffold as he foresaw. Often he does not even try to avoid that end, for his life has retained value for him only as a means to revenge. Such cases are found particularly among the Spaniards.^[1]

If we look closely at the spirit behind this desire for retribution, we find it very different from ordinary revenge, which seeks to lessen one's own suffering by seeing the person who caused it suffer. Its aim deserves to be called punishment rather than revenge, for it really intends a future effect through an example. Here, however, there is no selfish purpose, either for the avenging individual, who perishes in the act, or for a society seeking safety through laws. This punishment is carried out by an individual, not by the state or in fulfilment of a law. Indeed, it always responds to an act the state would not or could not punish, and the state disapproves of the punishment.

It seems to me that the indignation driving such a person so far beyond all bounds of self-love springs from a profound awareness that he himself is the entire will to live appearing in all beings through all times. The remotest future therefore belongs to him just as the present does, and cannot be indifferent to him. He still affirms this will, but demands that no such monstrous injustice ever again appear in the spectacle expressing his being. By an act of revenge against which there is no protective wall, since fear of death does not deter the avenger, he wants to frighten every future offender. Though still affirming itself, the will to live is no longer attached here to its particular appearance, the individual. It embraces the Idea of the human being and wishes to keep its appearance pure of so monstrous and outrageous an injustice. This is a rare, significant, even sublime trait of character. The individual sacrifices himself in striving to become the arm of eternal justice, whose real nature he still misunderstands.

Notes

Notes

1. The Spanish bishop who, during the last war, poisoned himself and the French generals dining at his table belongs here, as do several other incidents of that war. Examples can also be found in Montaigne, book 2, chapter 12. ↩

§. 65.

All our reflections so far on human action have prepared the way and greatly eased our final task: to make the real ethical significance of action, which everyday life designates and understands through the words *good* and *evil*, abstractly and philosophically clear, and to show its place in our central thought.

First, however, I want to bring the concepts *good* and *evil* back to their actual meanings. Philosophical writers today treat them, strangely enough, as simple concepts incapable of analysis. Otherwise one might remain under the hazy illusion that these words contain more than they really do, and that they alone already say all we need. I am no more disposed to hide behind the word *good* in ethics than I was earlier to hide behind *beautiful* or *true*. Nor will I add the suffix “-ness,” which nowadays lends a special σεμνότης (solemn dignity) and supposedly helps in several cases, then put on a solemn face and pretend that uttering the three words amounts to more than naming three very broad, abstract, and therefore not very rich concepts of widely differing origins and meanings. Who, after encountering today's writings, has not finally grown sick of these words, fine things though they originally indicate, on seeing a thousand times how someone utterly incapable of thought thinks it enough to utter them with mouth agape and the look of an inspired sheep in order to have spoken great wisdom?

I have already explained the concept *true* in my essay on the principle of sufficient reason, chapter 5, §29 ff. The whole of our third book has for the first time provided the proper explanation of *beautiful*. We can now state the meaning of *good* briefly. The concept is essentially relative: it denotes the *suitability of an object to a particular striving of the will*. Thus whatever suits the will in any of its expressions and fulfils its purpose is thought *good*, however different such things may otherwise be. We speak of good food, good roads, good weather, good weapons, a good omen, and so forth. In short, we call good whatever is as we happen to want it. What is good for one person can therefore be precisely the opposite for another. Good falls into two kinds: satisfaction of the will that is immediately present, and satisfaction attained only indirectly in the future. These are the pleasant and the useful. So long as we are speaking of beings without cognition, the opposite is expressed by the

German *schlecht* (bad), more rarely and abstractly by *Übel* (ill): whatever does not suit the will's particular striving.

Like all other beings that can stand in relation to the will, human beings favorable, helpful, or friendly to a purpose we happen to will have been called *good*, in the same sense and always with the same relativity. This appears in the saying, "He is good to me, but not to you." People whose character generally leads them not to obstruct others' strivings but to further them—who are consistently helpful, benevolent, friendly, and beneficent—are called *good people* because of the relation of their actions to the wills of others. In German, and for about a century in French, the opposite for beings with cognition, animals and people, is expressed by a different word from that used for things without cognition: *böse*, *méchant* (evil, wicked). In almost all other languages, this distinction is absent: *κακός*, *malus*, *cattivo*, and *bad* are applied alike to people and inanimate things opposed to the purposes of a particular individual will.

Reflection began wholly from the passive side of good and could only later pass to the active. It then examined the conduct of a person called *good* in relation to that person, not merely to others. In particular it had to explain both the purely objective respect such conduct apparently produced in others and the distinctive satisfaction with himself it produced in the good person, who even purchased it at the cost of other sacrifices. It had likewise to explain, on the opposite side, the inward pain accompanying an evil disposition, however many external advantages the person harboring it might gain. Ethical systems arose from this inquiry, both philosophical systems and those founded on religious doctrines. Both always seek somehow to connect happiness with virtue. Philosophical systems do so either by the principle of contradiction or by the principle of sufficient reason, making happiness either identical with virtue or its consequence, always sophistically. Religious systems assert other worlds beyond any that experience can disclose.^[1] On our account, by contrast, virtue's inner nature will prove to be a striving in quite the opposite direction from the pursuit of happiness, that is, well-being and life.

It follows that *good* as a concept is τὸν πρὸς τι, something relative to another thing. Every good is essentially relative because its nature exists only in relation to a desiring will. *Absolute good* is therefore a contradiction. "Highest good," *summum bonum*, means the same thing: a final satisfaction of the will after which no new willing arises, an ultimate motive whose attainment yields an indestructible contentment of the will. Our account so far in this fourth book

shows that this cannot be conceived. The will can no more cease willing anew after any satisfaction than time can come to an end or have a beginning. No fulfilment can satisfy its striving completely and forever. It is the barrel of the Danaids. There is no highest or absolute good for it, only a temporary one.

If, however, one wants to give an old expression that habit prevents us from retiring altogether an honorary office, as to an *emeritus*, one may figuratively call the will's complete self-abolition and denial, true freedom from willing, the absolute good or *summum bonum*. This alone stills and appeases the urge of will forever; alone gives a contentment that cannot again be disturbed; alone redeems from the world. We shall soon discuss it at the close of our whole inquiry. It may be viewed as the only radical cure of the disease for which all other goods are mere palliatives, mere anodynes. In this sense the Greek τέλος ("end"), as well as *finis bonorum* ("end of goods"), fits the matter even better. So much for the words *good* and *evil*; now to the matter itself.

When someone is always inclined to *commit injustice* as soon as an opportunity arises and no external power prevents him, we call him *evil*. According to our explanation of injustice, this means he not only affirms the will to live appearing in his own body but carries that affirmation so far that he denies the will appearing in other individuals. He demands their powers in the service of his will and seeks to destroy their existence when they oppose its strivings. Its ultimate source is the high degree of egoism explained above. Two things are immediately clear. *First*, such a person expresses an extraordinarily vehement will to live reaching far beyond affirmation of his own body. *Second*, his cognition is wholly devoted to the principle of sufficient reason and captive to the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation). He stands by the complete difference that the latter establishes between his person and all others. He therefore seeks only his own well-being and is wholly indifferent to theirs. Their nature seems utterly foreign to him, separated by a wide gulf from his own; indeed, he sees them only as masks without any reality. These two traits are the basic elements of an evil character.

That great vehemence of willing is itself and immediately a constant source of suffering. First, every act of willing as such springs from lack and thus from suffering. (Recall from the third book that the momentary silence of all willing when we surrender to aesthetic contemplation as a pure, will-free subject of cognition, the correlate of the Idea, is itself a chief component of our pleasure in the beautiful.) Second, because things are causally connected, most desires must remain unfulfilled; the will is thwarted much more often than satisfied.

Much and vehement willing therefore always brings much and vehement suffering. For suffering is nothing other than unfulfilled and obstructed willing. Even bodily pain when the body is injured or destroyed is possible as pain only because the body is the will itself become object.

Because much and vehement suffering is inseparable from much and vehement willing, even the faces of very evil people bear the stamp of inner suffering. Even if they have gained every outward good fortune, they always look unhappy unless in a moment of jubilation or pretending otherwise. From this inner torment, immediately essential to them, finally arises even an unselfish pleasure in others' suffering, rather than pleasure proceeding merely from egoism. This is *malice* proper, rising as far as *cruelty*. For it another's suffering is no longer a means to the ends of one's own will but an end in itself. The closer explanation of this phenomenon is as follows.

As an appearance of the will illuminated by the clearest cognition, a human being constantly measures the actual satisfaction of his will that he feels against a merely possible satisfaction presented by cognition. From this springs envy. Every deprivation is infinitely aggravated by another's enjoyment and alleviated by the knowledge that others suffer the same deprivation. Evils shared by all and inseparable from human life trouble us little, as do those belonging to the climate or the whole country. Remembering greater sufferings than our own eases our pain; seeing others suffer relieves our own. Suppose, then, a person filled with an extraordinarily vehement urge of will wants greedily to take everything in order to quench egoism's thirst. He must nevertheless discover that all satisfaction is only apparent: attainment never delivers what desire promised, the final stilling of that fierce urge. Fulfilment merely changes a wish's shape, so that it torments him in another form. Once all recognized wishes are exhausted, the urge of will itself remains without a recognized motive, appearing as the feeling of an appalling desolation and emptiness with incurable torment. At ordinary degrees of willing, these experiences are felt more mildly and produce only the ordinary level of gloomy mood. But in a person whose will appears as exceptional wickedness, they necessarily produce excessive inner torment, perpetual restlessness, and incurable pain. Unable to find relief directly, he seeks it indirectly by seeing others suffer, recognizing their suffering at the same time as an expression of his power. Their suffering becomes an end in itself, a sight in which he delights. Thus arises cruelty proper, bloodthirstiness, which history so often displays in Neros and Domitians, the African deys, Robespierre, and others.

The desire for revenge is already akin to malice. It repays evil with evil not with an eye to the future, as punishment does, but solely on account of what has happened in the past. It is thus disinterested, an end rather than a means, and delights in the offender's torment at one's own hand. What distinguishes revenge from pure malice and excuses it to some degree is an appearance of right. The very act that is now revenge would be punishment, and therefore right, if imposed under a law—according to a rule set in advance and known—in an association that has sanctioned it.

Alongside the suffering described above, which springs from the same root as malice—the very vehement will—and is therefore inseparable from it, there is another, quite different and distinctive torment. It is felt with every evil act, whether simple injustice arising from egoism or pure malice, and is called a *pang of conscience* or, when prolonged, *anguish of conscience*. Anyone keeping in mind what has been said in this fourth book, especially the truth explained at its beginning that life itself is always assured to the will to live as its mere image or mirror, and our account of eternal justice, will find that on those premises a pang of conscience can mean only what follows. Its content, abstractly expressed, has two parts, though they coincide completely and must be thought wholly together.

However thickly Maya's veil covers the evil person's understanding, however firmly he remains captive to the *principium individuationis*, he regards himself as absolutely different from every other person and separated from them by a wide gulf. He clings to this cognition with all his strength, since it alone suits and supports his egoism, and cognition is almost always bribed by the will. Yet deep within his consciousness a secret foreboding stirs that this order of things is only appearance and that matters are wholly otherwise in themselves. Time and space separate him from other individuals and their innumerable torments, including those they suffer at his hands, and present them as entirely foreign to him. Nevertheless, apart from representation and its forms, the one will to live appears in them all. Here it fails to recognize itself and turns its weapons against itself. In seeking enhanced well-being in one appearance, it lays the greatest suffering on another. He, the evil person, is this entire will. Thus he is not only the tormentor but also the tormented, from whose suffering he is separated and protected only by a deceptive dream shaped by space and time. That dream will vanish. In truth, he must pay for pleasure with torment; every suffering he recognizes as merely possible actually strikes him as the will to live. Possibility and actuality, nearness and distance in time and space, differ

only for the individual's cognition through the *principium individuationis*, not in themselves. The transmigration of souls expresses this truth mythically, adapting it to the principle of sufficient reason and translating it into the form of appearance. Its purest expression, unmixed with anything else, is the dimly felt but desolate torment called anguish of conscience.

That anguish also arises from a *second* immediate cognition closely connected with the first: cognition of the strength with which the will to live affirms itself in the evil individual, extending far beyond his own individual appearance to complete denial of the same will appearing in others. The evil person's inward horror at his own deed, which he tries to hide even from himself, contains a foreboding that the *principium individuationis* and the difference it creates between him and others are void and merely apparent. It also contains knowledge of his own will's vehemence, the force with which he has seized and fastened himself to life. The dreadful side of that very life confronts him in the torment of those he has oppressed. Yet he is so firmly bound to it that precisely for the fuller affirmation of his own will he himself becomes the source of the most dreadful things. He recognizes himself as a concentrated appearance of the will to live. He feels how completely he has fallen prey to life, and with it to the countless sufferings essential to it. Life has endless time and space in which to remove the difference between possibility and actuality and turn all the torments he now merely *knows* into those he *feels*.

The millions of years of constant rebirth exist here only as a concept, just as the whole past and future exist only in concepts. Filled time, the form of the will's appearance, is only the present. Time is always new for the individual, who always finds himself newly arisen. Life is inseparable from the will to live, and its sole form is the now. Death—pardon the repeated image—is like the sun's setting. The sun is only apparently swallowed by night; in reality it burns without interruption as the source of all light, bringing new days to new worlds, always rising and always setting. Beginning and end pertain only to the individual through time, the form of his appearance as representation. Outside time are only the will, Kant's thing in itself, and its adequate objectivity, Plato's Idea. Suicide therefore offers no rescue: what each person *wills* in his innermost being, he must *be*; and what each person *is*, he *wills*.

So it is not merely his felt knowledge that the forms of representation separating individuals are apparent and void, but also knowledge of his own will and its degree, that gives conscience its sting. A life's course produces the image of the empirical character, whose original is the intelligible character.

The evil person is terrified by that image, whether it has been drawn in large strokes so that the world shares his horror or in strokes so small that he alone sees it. Only he is directly concerned. The past, as mere appearance, would be indifferent and could not trouble conscience if character did not feel itself free from all time and unchangeable by time, so long as it does not deny itself. That is why deeds done long ago still weigh on conscience. The prayer "Lead me not into temptation" means "Do not let me see who I am."

The evil person measures, by the force with which he affirms life as shown in the suffering he inflicts on others, how far he is from surrendering and denying that will, the only possible redemption from the world and its torment. He sees how completely he belongs to the world and how firmly he is bound to it. The *known* suffering of others could not move him; he falls prey to life and to *felt* suffering. Whether the latter will ever break and overcome the force of his will remains open.

This account of the meaning and inner nature of *evil* is the content of *anguish of conscience* as mere feeling, *not* as clear, abstract cognition. It will become clearer and more complete through an equally thorough consideration of the *good* as a property of the human will and, finally, of complete resignation and holiness, which emerge when the good reaches its highest degree. Opposites always illuminate one another; as Spinoza said so well, day reveals both itself and night.

Notes

Notes

1. Let me note in passing that what gives every positive religious doctrine its great power, the hold by which it takes firm possession of minds, is its ethical side. Yet this acts not immediately as such but because it is firmly linked and woven together with the mythical dogma peculiar to that religion and seems explicable only by that dogma. The ethical significance of actions cannot be explained by the principle of sufficient reason, while every myth follows that principle. Nevertheless, believers regard the ethical significance of action and their myth as utterly inseparable, even identical, and therefore regard every attack on the myth as an attack on right and virtue. Among monotheistic peoples this has gone so far that atheism or godlessness has become synonymous with the absence of all morality. Priests welcome these confusions of concepts. Only through them could that terrible monster, fanaticism, arise and rule not merely certain exceptionally perverse and evil individuals but whole peoples. Finally, to humanity's honor, only once in its history did it take bodily form in this West as the Inquisition. According to the latest, at last authentic reports, in Madrid alone—and there were many other such clerical murder pits in Spain—it caused 300,000 people over three centuries to die painfully at the stake over matters of faith. Every zealot should be reminded of this as soon as he raises his voice. ↩

§. 66.

Morality without a foundation, mere moralizing, cannot work, because it supplies no motive. But a morality that *does* supply a motive can do so only by appealing to self-love, and what springs from self-love has no moral worth. It follows that morality and abstract cognition generally cannot produce genuine virtue. Virtue must arise from intuitive cognition that recognizes in another individual the same being as in oneself.

Virtue does arise from cognition, but not from abstract cognition communicable in words. If it did, it could be taught, and by stating here in abstract terms its nature and the cognition underlying it, we would morally improve everyone who understood us. This plainly does not happen. Ethical lectures and sermons can no more create a virtuous person than all works on aesthetics, beginning with Aristotle's, have ever made a poet. The concept is as unfruitful for virtue's real inner nature as for art. It can serve only as a subordinate tool in carrying out and preserving what has been otherwise known and resolved. *Velle non discitur* ("Willing is not learned"). Abstract dogmas in fact have no influence on virtue, that is, goodness of disposition: false ones do not spoil it, and true ones scarcely advance it. It would indeed be terrible if the chief concern of human life, its ethical worth valid for eternity, depended on something so much a matter of chance as acquiring dogmas, religious doctrines, or philosophical propositions. Dogmas have value for morality only in that a person already virtuous through another kind of cognition, to be discussed shortly, finds in them a scheme or formula. By it he gives his own reason an account, mostly fictitious, of his unselfish action, whose nature his reason—or he himself—does not *understand*. He has accustomed his reason to be satisfied with that account.

Dogmas can indeed powerfully influence *action*, outward conduct, as can habit and example. Example works because the ordinary person knows the weakness of his own judgment, distrusts it, and follows only his own or another's experience. Yet the disposition remains unchanged.^[1] Abstract cognition supplies only motives; motives, as shown above, can change only the direction of the will, never the will itself. All communicable cognition can affect the will only as a motive. Thus even when dogmas direct the will, what a person really and generally wills remains the same. He has acquired different ideas only about the means of obtaining it, and imaginary motives guide him

just as real ones do. For instance, it makes no difference to his ethical worth whether he gives large sums to the needy because he firmly expects to receive tenfold in a future life or spends the same sum improving an estate, which will yield returns later but more securely and substantially. A person who in orthodox faith consigns a heretic to the flames is a murderer just like the bandit who murders for a reward. Depending on the inner circumstances, so is the person who slaughters Turks in the Promised Land, if he does it, like the first, because he thinks he will earn a place in heaven. They all seek their own advantage, their own egoism, as the bandit does, differing from him only in the absurdity of their means. As I said, motives are the only external means of reaching the will, but they change only how it expresses itself, never the will itself. *Velle non discitur* ("Willing is not learned").

When a person appeals to dogmas to explain his good deeds, we must distinguish whether these were actually the motives or merely the apparent account with which, as I said, he tries to satisfy his reason. He may have done a good deed from quite another source simply because he *is good*, yet cannot properly explain it, since he is no philosopher and still wishes to think something about it. The distinction is very hard to discover, for it lies within the mind. We can therefore almost never judge others' actions morally with accuracy, and seldom our own. Dogmas, example, and habit can greatly modify the acts and conduct of an individual or a people. Yet all acts in themselves, *opera operata* (works performed), are mere empty images; only the disposition leading to them gives them moral significance. That disposition can remain exactly the same beneath widely different external appearances. People equally wicked may die, one on the breaking wheel and the other peacefully among his family. The same degree of wickedness may appear in one people in bold strokes as murder and cannibalism, and in another quietly and delicately *en miniature* (in miniature) as court intrigue, oppression, and every kind of subtle trick. The essence remains the same. Conceivably a perfect state, or even a wholly and firmly believed dogma about rewards and punishments after death, might prevent every crime. That would achieve much politically but nothing morally; it would merely obstruct the portrayal of the will through life.

Genuine goodness of disposition, unselfish virtue, and pure nobility of character do not spring from abstract cognition, then, but they do spring from cognition. This cognition is immediate and intuitive, cannot be argued away or argued into anyone, and, precisely because it is not abstract, cannot be communicated. It must dawn on each person for himself. Its proper and

adequate expression lies not in words but only in deeds, action, and the course of a person's life. We seek a theory of virtue here and therefore must express the nature of its underlying cognition in abstract terms. Yet such an expression cannot deliver that cognition itself, only a concept of it. We must always begin from action, where alone it becomes visible, and refer back to action as its only adequate expression. We can only interpret it and state abstractly what actually takes place in it.

Before discussing *goodness* proper as the opposite of the *evil* already described, we must touch on a middle stage, the mere negation of evil: *justice*. We have adequately explained right and injustice above. We can therefore say briefly that a person is *just* if he voluntarily recognizes and honors the merely moral boundary between injustice and right even where no state or other power protects it. According to our account, he never carries affirmation of his own will so far as to deny the will appearing in another individual. He will not inflict suffering on others to increase his own well-being: he will commit no crime and will respect everyone's rights and property. We see that the *principium individuationis* is no longer an absolute partition for this just person as it is for the evil person. Unlike the latter, he does not affirm only his own appearance of will and deny all others, nor are other people mere masks of a wholly different essence to him. His conduct shows that he *recognizes again* his own essence, the will to live as thing in itself, in another's appearance, given to him only as representation. To a certain degree, then, he finds himself there: to the degree of not committing injustice, of not injuring others. To that extent he sees through the *principium individuationis*, Maya's veil. He treats the being outside him as equal to his own and does not injure it.

At the heart of this justice already lies a resolve not to carry affirmation of one's own will so far that it denies others' appearances of will by compelling them to serve it. One is therefore willing to provide to others as much as one receives from them. The highest degree of this just disposition, already joined with goodness proper, which is no longer merely negative, goes so far as to question one's right to inherited property. One wishes to sustain one's body only through one's own mental or physical powers, feels every service rendered by another and every luxury as a reproach, and finally embraces voluntary poverty. Thus *Pascal*, when he took an ascetic turn, would no longer tolerate servants attending him, though he had plenty. Despite his constant illness, he made his own bed and fetched his own food from the kitchen, and so forth (*Vie de Pascal par sa soeur*, p. 19; *Life of Pascal by His Sister*). Correspondingly, some

Hindus, even rajas, are said to use their great wealth only to support their household, court, and servants, while observing with strict scruple the maxim of eating only what they have themselves sown and harvested. There is nevertheless a misunderstanding here. Precisely because an individual is rich and powerful, he can render services to society as a whole that equal the inherited wealth whose security he owes society. Strictly speaking, the excessive justice of these Hindus is already more than justice: it is real renunciation, denial of the will to live, asceticism, which we shall discuss at the end. Conversely, doing absolutely nothing and living by others' efforts on inherited property, without rendering anything in return, may already be considered morally unjust, though it must remain lawful under positive law.

We have found that voluntary justice originates inwardly in a certain degree of seeing through the *principium individuationis*, while the unjust person remains entirely captive to it. This insight can occur not only to the degree justice requires but to a higher degree, prompting positive benevolence, beneficence, and love of humanity. It can do so however strong and energetic the will appearing in such an individual may be. Cognition can always counterbalance it, teach resistance to the temptation to injustice, and even bring about every degree of goodness, indeed resignation. The good person should therefore by no means be taken as an originally weaker appearance of will than the evil person. Cognition masters the blind urge of will in him. Some individuals do seem good-natured merely because the will appearing in them is weak. What they really are soon shows itself in their inability to overcome themselves substantially in order to perform a just or good deed.

Suppose we meet the rare person with a considerable income who uses little of it for himself, gives the rest to those in need, and forgoes many pleasures and conveniences. In trying to understand his action, we may set aside the dogmas by which he might explain it to his own reason. Its simplest and most general expression, and its essential feature, is that he *makes less of a distinction between himself and others than is usual*. For some people that distinction is so great that another's suffering gives the malicious person immediate pleasure and the unjust person a welcome means of his own well-being; the merely just person stops at not causing it. Most people know of countless sufferings close to them, but will not resolve to relieve them because doing so would require some deprivation of their own. To each of these people a great gulf seems to lie between his own self and another's. For the noble person we have imagined, however, this difference is not so considerable. The *principium individuationis*,

the form of appearance, no longer holds him as firmly captive. Others' suffering affects him almost as deeply as his own, and he therefore seeks to restore the balance, giving up pleasures and accepting deprivations to relieve it. He realizes that the difference between himself and others, so wide a gulf to the evil person, belongs only to a transient, deceptive appearance. Immediately, without inference, he recognizes that the in-itself of his own appearance is also that of another's: the will to live that constitutes the essence of every thing and lives in everything. Indeed, this extends to animals and all of nature. He will therefore torment no animal either.^[2]

He is now no more able to let others go hungry while he possesses what is superfluous and dispensable than anyone is able to go hungry for a day in order to have more on the next than he can consume. Maya's veil has become transparent to the person who practices acts of love, and the illusion of the *principium individuationis* has left him. He recognizes himself, his self and his will, in every being and therefore in the sufferer. He is free of the perversity by which the will to live, failing to recognize itself, enjoys fleeting, illusory pleasures in one individual and in exchange suffers and starves in *another*. It imposes torment and endures torment, not recognizing that, like Thyestes, it greedily devours its own flesh, and then laments undeserved suffering here and commits outrage there without fear of Nemesis. It does so only because it does not recognize itself in the other's appearance and therefore does not perceive eternal justice, captive to the *principium individuationis* and, generally, to the mode of cognition governed by the principle of sufficient reason. To be cured of this delusion and Maya's deception and to practice acts of love are one and the same. The latter is an unfailing sign of the former cognition.

The opposite of the torment of conscience explained above is *a good conscience*, the satisfaction we feel after every unselfish act. The act arises from immediately recognizing our own essence in itself in another appearance, and in turn confirms that cognition: our true self exists not only in our own person, this one appearance, but in everything that lives. This expands the heart, as egoism contracts it. Egoism concentrates all our concern on the single appearance of our own individual, while cognition constantly sets before us the innumerable dangers threatening it; anxiety and care thus become the underlying tone of our mood. Knowledge that everything living is just as much our own essence in itself as our person extends our concern to everything living and thereby expands the heart. As concern for one's own self diminishes, anxious care for it is attacked at its root and limited. Hence the calm, confident serenity given by a

virtuous disposition and a good conscience, which comes out still more clearly after each good deed, as it confirms the basis of that mood to us. The egoist feels surrounded by alien and hostile appearances, and all his hope rests on his own welfare. The good person lives among friendly appearances; the welfare of each is his own. Knowledge of the human lot in general may keep his mood from becoming cheerful, but lasting knowledge of his own essence in all living things gives his mood a certain evenness and serenity. Concern spread over countless appearances cannot produce the anxiety of concern concentrated on *one*. The chances affecting individuals collectively balance out, whereas those affecting one individual bring fortune or misfortune.

Others have laid down moral principles as commands to virtue and laws that must be obeyed. I cannot do that, as I have said, since I have no “ought” or law to present to the eternally free will. Yet within my account something analogous to such a project is the purely theoretical truth of which this whole exposition may be seen as an elaboration: the will is the in-itself of every appearance and, as such, is free of the forms of appearance and therefore of multiplicity. In relation to action I know no worthier way to express it than the already mentioned Vedic formula, *Tat twam asi!*—“This is you!” Whoever can say this to himself about every being he meets, with clear knowledge and firm, heartfelt conviction, has thereby the assurance of every virtue and blessedness and is on the direct road to redemption.

Before I go further and show, as the last part of my account, how love—which we have found originates in seeing through the *principium individuationis*—leads to redemption, that is, to the complete surrender of the will to live and of all willing, and how another, less gentle but more common road takes people to the same end, I must state and explain a paradox. I do so because it is true and belongs to the completeness of the thought I am presenting: “All love (ἀγάπη, *caritas*—charity) is compassion.”

Notes

Notes

1. The Church would say that these are mere *opera operata* (works performed), which avail nothing unless grace grants the faith that leads to rebirth. More on this below. ↩
2. The human right to use animals' lives and powers rests on this: suffering grows in proportion as consciousness becomes clearer. The pain an animal undergoes through death or

labor is therefore still less than the pain a human would suffer merely by having to do without the animal's flesh or strength. Thus humans may carry affirmation of their own existence to the point of denying an animal's existence, and the will to live as a whole bears less suffering than under the opposite arrangement. This also sets the degree to which people may use animals' powers without injustice, a limit often exceeded, especially with beasts of burden and hunting dogs. Animal protection societies should principally direct their work against this. In my view, the right does not extend to vivisection, particularly of higher animals. An insect, on the other hand, does not suffer as much through death as a human does from its sting. The Hindus do not see this. ↩

§. 67.

We have seen how justice arose from seeing through the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation) to a lesser degree, and genuine goodness of disposition to a greater degree. The latter showed itself as pure, that is, unselfish, love toward others. Where it becomes complete, it places another individual and his fate wholly on a level with oneself and one's own fate. It can never go further, for there is no reason to prefer another individual to oneself. Yet concern for the welfare or lives of a great many others may outweigh concern for the welfare of a single individual. In such a case a character that has attained the highest goodness and perfect nobility will wholly sacrifice his own welfare and life for many others. Thus died Codrus, Leonidas, Regulus, Decius Mus, and Arnold von Winkelried. So does anyone who willingly and knowingly goes to certain death for his people or his country. This level also includes anyone who willingly accepts suffering and death to defend what rightly belongs to and benefits humanity as a whole—important general truths and the removal of great errors. Thus Socrates died; thus Giordano Bruno and many other champions of truth found death at the stake at the hands of priests.

With regard to the paradox stated above, I must now recall that we found suffering essential to life as a whole and inseparable from it. We saw that every wish springs from a need, a lack, a suffering, and that every satisfaction therefore removes a pain rather than bringing a positive happiness. Pleasures falsely promise desire that they are a positive good; in truth they are negative, merely the end of an ill. Whatever goodness, love, and nobility do for others can therefore only relieve their suffering. The only thing that can move them to good deeds and acts of love is *knowledge of another's suffering*, understood immediately from one's own and put on an equal footing with it. Pure love (ἀγάπη, *caritas*) is consequently compassion by its very nature, whether it relieves great suffering or a small suffering such as any unsatisfied wish.

In direct opposition to *Kant*, who recognizes something as truly good or virtuous only if it arises from abstract reflection, particularly from the concept of duty and the categorical imperative, and calls felt compassion weakness rather than virtue, I say: a mere concept is as unfruitful for genuine virtue as for genuine art. Every true and pure love is compassion, and every love that is not compassion is self-love. Self-love is ἔρως (*eros*); compassion is ἀγάπη (*agape*). The two are often mixed. Even genuine friendship is always a mixture of

self-love and compassion. The former lies in pleasure at the friend's presence, whose individuality corresponds to our own, and almost always makes up the larger part; compassion appears in sincere concern for his welfare and distress and in unselfish sacrifices for his sake. Even Spinoza says, *Benevolentia nihil aliud est, quam cupiditas ex commiseratione orta* (*Ethics*, III, proposition 27, corollary 3, scholium; "Benevolence is nothing other than desire arising from compassion"). To confirm our paradoxical claim, notice that the tone and words of the language and endearments of pure love exactly coincide with those of compassion. Incidentally, the same Italian word, *pietà*, denotes compassion and pure love.

This is also the place to discuss one of the most striking peculiarities of human nature, *weeping*, which, like laughter, is among the expressions distinguishing humans from animals. Weeping is by no means a direct expression of pain: people weep over very few pains. In my view, one never even weeps directly over a pain one feels, but only over its recurrence in reflection. One passes from the felt pain, even when bodily, to a mere representation of it. One then finds one's own state so deserving of pity that one is firmly and sincerely convinced one would help if someone else were suffering it, out of compassion and love. Yet one is oneself the object of one's sincere compassion: with the most helpful disposition, one is the person needing help. One feels that one suffers more than one could bear to see another suffer. In this strangely interwoven mood, immediately felt suffering comes back to perception only by a double detour. It is imagined as someone else's, shared as such through compassion, and suddenly perceived again as immediately one's own. Nature then gives itself relief through the peculiar physical convulsion of weeping.

Weeping is thus *compassion for oneself*, or compassion turned back on its starting point. It requires a capacity for love and compassion as well as imagination. Hard-hearted people and people without imagination therefore seldom weep. Weeping is even always taken as a sign of some goodness of character, and disarms anger, because we feel that someone who can still weep must also be capable of love, that is, compassion for others. Compassion enters in precisely the way described into the mood that leads to tears. Petrarch's description of the rise of his own tears, expressing his feeling simply and truthfully, exactly fits this account:

*I vo pensando: e nel pensar m' assalo
Una pietà sì forte di me stesso,*

*Che mi conduce spesso,
Ad alto lagrimar, ch' i non soleva.*^[1]

Our account is also confirmed by the fact that children who have suffered pain usually begin to weep only when someone pities them. They weep not over the pain but over the representation of it. When another person's suffering moves us to tears, we vividly put ourselves in the sufferer's place in imagination. Or we see in that person's fate the lot of all humanity, above all our own. By a long detour we thus still weep over ourselves and feel compassion for ourselves. This also seems a principal reason for the universal and therefore natural weeping at deaths. The mourner is not weeping for his loss; he would be ashamed of such egoistic tears, whereas he is sometimes ashamed of *not* weeping. At first he does weep over the deceased person's fate. Yet he also weeps when death, after long, severe, incurable suffering, was a welcome release for that person. What principally moves him is compassion for the lot of humanity as a whole, condemned to finitude: every life, however full of striving and often of deeds, must go out and become nothing. In humanity's lot he sees above all his own, all the more strongly the closer the deceased was to him, and most of all when it was his father. Even if old age and illness had made the father's life a torment and his helplessness a heavy burden to the son, the son still weeps intensely at his death, for the reason given.^[2]

Notes

Notes

1. "As I walk deep in thought, such strong *compassion for myself* comes over me that I often have to weep aloud, though I was not formerly given to it." ↩
2. See chapter 47 of the second volume. It hardly needs saying that the ethics sketched in §§61–67 has received a fuller and more finished treatment in my prize essay *On the Basis of Morality*. ↩

§. 68.

After this digression on the identity of pure love and compassion, whose turning back toward one's own person has weeping as its sign, I take up again our account of the ethical significance of action. I shall now show how, from the same source as all goodness, love, virtue, and nobility, there finally emerges what I call denial of the will to live.

We saw earlier that hatred and malice depend on egoism, and that egoism rests on cognition's captivity to the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation). We then found the origin and nature of justice and, beyond it, of love and nobility, even at their highest degrees, in seeing through that principle. This alone removes the distinction between oneself and other individuals and makes possible, and explains, a completely good disposition reaching the most unselfish love and most generous self-sacrifice for others.

When this insight into the *principium individuationis*, this immediate cognition of the will's identity in all its appearances, is present with great clarity, it has a still further effect on the will. Maya's veil may have lifted so far from a person's eyes that he no longer makes the egoistic distinction between himself and others, but takes as much part in their sufferings as in his own. He is helpful in the highest degree and is even prepared to sacrifice his own person when that will save several others. Since such a person recognizes himself, his innermost and true self, in all beings, he must also regard the endless sufferings of everything living as his own and make the whole world's pain his own. No suffering is foreign to him. The torments of others that he sees and can so seldom relieve, those he hears of indirectly, even those he knows only as possible, affect him like his own. His concern is no longer the changing welfare and distress of his own person, as it is for someone still captive to egoism. Having seen through the *principium individuationis*, he finds everything equally close. He knows the whole, apprehends its essence, and finds it caught in ceaseless passing away, vain striving, inner conflict, and constant suffering. Wherever he looks he sees suffering humanity and suffering animals and a vanishing world. All this is now as close to him as his own person is to the egoist.

How could he, knowing the world in this way, continue to affirm this life by constant acts of will and thereby bind himself ever more firmly to it and embrace it more tightly? The person still captive to egoism and the *principium*

individuationis knows only individual things and their relation to himself; these become ever renewed *motives* for his willing. But knowledge of the whole and of the essence of things in themselves, as just described, becomes a *quietive* of every kind of willing. The will now turns away from life. It shudders at life's pleasures, recognizing in them its affirmation. The person reaches voluntary renunciation, resignation, true composure, and complete freedom from willing. For the rest of us still surrounded by Maya's veil, our own keenly felt suffering or another's vividly recognized suffering may at times bring us close to knowing life's emptiness and bitterness. We may wish to break the sting of desire through complete and permanent renunciation, shut suffering out, purify ourselves, and become holy. Yet appearance's illusion soon entangles us again, and its motives set the will in motion anew. We cannot tear ourselves free. The allure of hope, the flattery of the present, the sweetness of enjoyment, and the well-being that falls to our person amid a suffering world ruled by chance and error draw us back to life and fasten its bonds afresh. Thus Jesus says: "It is easier for a ship's cable to pass through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God."

Imagine life as a circular track of glowing coals with a few cool spots, which we must run around without cease. The person captive to illusion takes comfort in the cool spot on which he now stands or sees close ahead, and keeps running. The person who sees through the *principium individuationis* and knows the essence of things in themselves and thereby the whole is no longer open to that consolation: he sees himself at every point at once and steps off the track. His will turns. It no longer affirms its own nature mirrored in appearance but denies it. The phenomenon revealing this is the passage from virtue to *asceticism*. It no longer satisfies him to love others as himself and do as much for them as for himself. He becomes repelled by the being expressed in his own appearance, the will to live, the core and essence of the world he now knows to be wretched. He therefore disowns this being, which appears in him and is already expressed by his body. His conduct now contradicts his appearance openly. Although he is essentially nothing but an appearance of the will, he ceases to will anything, takes care not to attach his will to anything, and seeks to establish the greatest indifference to everything within himself. His healthy, strong body expresses the sexual drive through its genitals, yet he denies the will and contradicts his body: he refuses sexual satisfaction under every condition.

Voluntary and complete chastity is the first step in asceticism, or denial of the will to live. It thereby denies affirmation of the will beyond the individual's

life and signals that with this body's life the will whose appearance it is also comes to an end. Nature, always truthful and candid, declares that if this maxim were universal, the human race would die out. From what was said in the second book about the connection among all appearances of the will, I believe we may assume that with its highest appearance the weaker reflection of it, animal life, would fall away too, just as partial shadows disappear with full light. With the complete abolition of cognition, the rest of the world would then vanish into nothing of itself, for without a subject there is no object. I would even relate this to a passage in the Vedas: "As hungry children in this world crowd around their mother, so all beings await the holy sacrifice" (*Asiatic Researches*, vol. 8, Colebrooke, "On the Vedas," excerpt from the *Sama Veda*; also in Colebrooke's *Miscellaneous Essays*, vol. 1, p. 88). Sacrifice here means resignation generally. The rest of nature awaits redemption from the human being, who is both priest and sacrifice.

Remarkably, the admirable and unfathomably deep Angelus Silesius expressed the same thought in a little verse titled "Man Brings Everything to God":

"Human! All things love you; around you they crowd and press;
All run toward you so that they may come to God."

An even greater mystic, Meister Eckhart, whose marvelous writings have at last become available in Franz Pfeiffer's edition, says on p. 459, wholly in the present sense: "I confirm this with Christ, when he says: When I am lifted up from the earth, I will draw all things to me (John 12:32). Thus the good person should carry all things up to God, to their first origin. The masters confirm that all creatures are made for the sake of man. See in every creature how one serves another: the ox the grass, the fish the water, the bird the air, the animal the forest. In this way all creatures serve the good person: the good person carries one creature within another to God." He means that a person may use animals in this life in return for redeeming them in and with himself. I even think that the difficult passage Romans 8:21–24 can be interpreted in this sense.

Buddhism too has expressions of this thought. For example, when the Buddha, still a bodhisattva, has his horse saddled for the last time, to flee his father's residence for the wilderness, he says to it: "For a long time you have been caught in life and death. Now you shall cease to bear and pull. Carry me away just this once, O Kanthaka, and when I have attained the law [become

Buddha], I shall not forget you” (*Foe Koue Ki*, translated by Abel Rémusat, p. 233).

Asceticism then shows itself in voluntary, deliberate poverty. This does not arise merely *per accidens* (incidentally), through giving away possessions to relieve another's suffering; it is now an end in itself. It serves as continual mortification of the will, so that the satisfaction of wishes and life's sweetness will not stir the will afresh when self-knowledge has inspired revulsion against it. The person who has reached this point still feels, as an animate body and concrete appearance of will, a disposition to every kind of willing. Yet he deliberately suppresses it, forcing himself to do none of what he wants and, on the contrary, to do what he does not want, even if there is no further purpose than mortifying the will. Since he denies the will appearing in his own person, he does not resist when someone else does the same, that is, commits an injustice against him. Every suffering that comes to him from outside, by chance or another's malice, every loss, disgrace, or insult, is therefore welcome. He receives it joyfully as a chance to assure himself that he no longer affirms the will but gladly takes the side of every enemy of the appearance of will that is his own person. He therefore bears such disgrace and suffering with inexhaustible patience and gentleness, returns good for evil without display, and allows neither anger nor desire to reignite within him.

As he mortifies the will itself, he also mortifies its visible objectivity, the body. He feeds it sparingly, lest its lush flourishing revive and more strongly excite the will, of which it is merely expression and mirror. He turns to fasting, even to mortification and self-torment, so that continual deprivation and suffering may increasingly break and kill the will he recognizes and detests as the source of his own and the world's suffering existence. When death finally comes and dissolves this appearance of will, the will's essence has already long since died through free self-denial, except for the weak remnant appearing as animation of this body. Death is therefore welcomed joyfully as a longed-for redemption. With it, it is not merely appearance that ends, as it does for others; the essence itself is abolished, having had only a weak existence left in and through this appearance.^[1] Its last frail bond now breaks. For a person who ends in this way, the world too has ended.

What I have described here with a weak tongue and only in general terms is no philosophical tale I invented today. It was the enviable life of many saints and noble souls among Christians, still more among Hindus and Buddhists, and among other believers too. However different the dogmas impressed on their

reason, the inner, immediate, intuitive cognition from which alone all virtue and holiness can arise expressed itself in the same way through their conduct. Here again we see the great distinction between intuitive and abstract cognition, so important throughout this work and so little noticed before. A wide gulf separates the two, which only philosophy can bridge in regard to knowledge of the world's essence. In intuition, or *in concreto* (in the concrete), everyone is aware of all philosophical truths; bringing them into abstract knowledge and reflection is the philosopher's task, and nothing more is asked or possible.

Perhaps, then, the inner essence of holiness, self-denial, mortification of one's own will, and asceticism is expressed here for the first time abstractly and without myth as *denial of the will to live*, occurring when complete knowledge of the will's own essence becomes a quietive of all willing. But all those saints and ascetics knew it immediately and expressed it through action. Sharing the same inner cognition, they used very different language according to the dogmas they had adopted. An Indian, a Christian, and a Lamaist saint must each give a very different account of his own conduct, but this is wholly indifferent to the matter. A saint may hold the most absurd superstition or, conversely, be a philosopher; either is equally possible. His conduct alone certifies him as a saint, for morally it springs not from abstract cognition but from immediate, intuitive cognition of the world and its essence. He interprets it through some dogma only to satisfy his reason. A saint no more needs to be a philosopher than a philosopher needs to be a saint, just as a perfectly beautiful person need not be a great sculptor, nor a great sculptor beautiful. In general, it is a strange demand that a moral philosopher recommend only the virtues he possesses himself. To repeat the whole essence of the world clearly and generally in abstract concepts, and to lay it before reason as a reflected image in concepts that endure and remain ready to hand: this, and nothing else, is philosophy. I recall the passage from Francis Bacon quoted in the first book.

Yet my description of denial of the will to live and of a noble soul's conduct, of a resigned saint voluntarily doing penance, is only abstract and general and therefore cold. Since the cognition from which denial of the will arises is intuitive, not abstract, its complete expression is found not in abstract concepts but solely in deeds and a life's conduct. To understand more fully what philosophy calls denial of the will to live, we must become acquainted with examples in experience and reality. We shall not find them in daily experience, of course: *nam omnia praeclara tam difficilia quam rara sunt* ("all excellent things are as difficult as they are rare"), as Spinoza says so well. Unless a

particularly fortunate fate makes us eyewitnesses, we must turn to the lives of such people. Even the little of Indian literature known so far in translation shows it rich in accounts of the lives of saints and penitents, called *samanas*, *sannyasis*, and so on. The familiar, though not entirely commendable, *Mythologie des Indous par Mad. de Polier* (*Mythology of the Hindus by Madame de Polier*) contains many excellent examples, especially in chapter 13 of volume 2.

There is no lack of Christian examples either. Read the generally poorly written biographies of people called saintly souls, Pietists, Quietists, devout enthusiasts, and the like. Collections have been made at various times, such as Tersteegen's *Lives of Holy Souls*, Reiz's *History of the Reborn*, and in our day a collection by Kanne which, among much that is poor, includes some good material, particularly the life of Beata Sturmin. The life of Saint Francis of Assisi, a true personification of asceticism and model of all mendicant monks, belongs especially here. His younger contemporary Saint Bonaventure, also famous as a scholastic, wrote his life, recently republished as *Vita S. Francisci a S. Bonaventura concinnata* (*Life of Saint Francis compiled by Saint Bonaventure*, Soest, 1847). Shortly before that a careful, extensive biography using all the sources had appeared in France: Chavin de Mallan's *Histoire de S. François d'Assise* (*History of Saint Francis of Assisi*, 1845). As an Eastern parallel to these monastic writings we have Spence Hardy's very readable *Eastern Monachism: An Account of the Order of Mendicants Founded by Gotama Buddha* (1850). It shows us the same matter in different clothing and also how little it matters whether its religion is theistic or atheistic.

Above all, as a particular and very detailed factual illustration of my concepts, I recommend Madame Guyon's autobiography. It must delight every person of better character to know this noble and great soul, whose memory always fills me with reverence, and to do justice to the excellence of her disposition while overlooking the superstition of her reason. The book will always be held in low repute by ordinary minds, the majority, since each person can appreciate only what is at least somewhat akin to him and for which he has at least a weak disposition. This holds in ethics as in intellectual matters. One might even count the familiar French biography of Spinoza as an example, if one uses as its key the splendid opening of his otherwise very inadequate *De emendatione intellectus* (*On the Improvement of the Understanding*). I also recommend that passage as the most effective means I know of calming a storm of passions. Finally, even the great Goethe, for all his Greek spirit, did not

consider it beneath him to show us this fairest side of humanity in poetry's clarifying mirror. In the "Confessions of a Beautiful Soul" he gave an idealized account of Fräulein Klettenberg's life, later supplying historical information in his autobiography. He also told the life of Saint Philip Neri twice.

World history must always be silent about people whose lives best and most fully illustrate this important point of our inquiry. Its subject is quite another matter, indeed the opposite: the affirmation and appearance of the will to live in countless individuals, not its denial and surrender. At the highest point of its objectivation the will's division against itself emerges there with complete clarity. History displays now an individual's superiority through cunning, now the strength of a crowd through sheer numbers, now the power of chance personified as fate, and always the futility and emptiness of the whole striving. We, however, are philosophers seeking the ethical significance of acts rather than following the thread of appearances in time. Taking that significance as our sole measure of importance, we should not be deterred by the permanent majority of commonness and banality from acknowledging that the world's greatest, most important, and most significant appearance is not the conqueror of the world but the one who overcomes the world. It is the quiet, unnoticed life of someone in whom a cognition dawns that leads him to surrender and deny the will to live, which fills everything and drives and strives in everything. Only here, in him alone, does the will's freedom appear, and his action becomes the direct opposite of ordinary action. For a philosopher, the lives of holy, self-denying people are consequently far more instructive and important in this respect than even Plutarch and Livy, though generally badly written and mingled with superstition and nonsense, because of the significance of their subject.

To know more closely and completely what we call denial of the will to live in the general, abstract terms of our exposition, it helps greatly to consider ethical instructions given in this spirit by people filled with it. They also show how old our view is, even if its purely philosophical expression is new. Christianity lies nearest to us. Its ethics is wholly in the spirit indicated and leads not only to the highest degrees of love of humanity but also to renunciation. The latter is already plainly present as a seed in the apostles' writings, though it developed fully and was expressly stated only later. The apostles prescribe love of one's neighbor equal to self-love, beneficence, the return of love and good deeds for hatred, patience, gentleness, endurance of all injuries without resistance, restraint in food to suppress desire, and, if one can,

complete resistance to sexual desire. Here we already see the first stages of asceticism, or denial of the will proper. The latter expression means exactly what the Gospels call denying oneself and taking up the cross (Matthew 16:24–25; Mark 8:34–35; Luke 9:23–24, 14:26–27, 33). This tendency developed further and gave rise to penitents, anchorites, and monasticism. Its origin was pure and holy, but for that very reason wholly unsuited to most people, so that its later products could only be hypocrisy and abomination: *abusus optimi pessimus* (“the abuse of the best is the worst”).

As Christianity developed further, that ascetic seed came into full bloom in the writings of Christian saints and mystics. Alongside the purest love they preached complete resignation, voluntary and total poverty, true composure, perfect indifference to worldly things, dying to one's own will and rebirth in God, complete forgetting of one's own person, and immersion in the contemplation of God. A full account appears in Fénelon's *Explication des maximes des Saints sur la vie intérieure* (*Explanation of the Maxims of the Saints on the Inner Life*). Nowhere, perhaps, is the spirit of Christianity in this development expressed as fully and powerfully as in the German mystics, Meister Eckhart and the justly celebrated *German Theology*. In the preface he wrote for it, Luther says that apart from the Bible and Augustine he learned more from this book about God, Christ, and humanity than from any other. We received its authentic and uncorrupted text, however, only in Pfeiffer's Stuttgart edition of 1851. Its precepts and teaching are the fullest exposition, born of deep conviction, of what I have described as denial of the will to live. One should come to know it more closely there before pronouncing on it with Jewish-Protestant self-assurance. Tauler's *Following the Poor Life of Christ* and his *Medulla animae* (*Marrow of the Soul*) are written in the same excellent spirit, though not quite equal to it. In my view, the teaching of these genuine Christian mystics stands to that of the New Testament as distilled spirits stand to wine. Or what the New Testament lets us see through veil and mist stands before us in their works uncovered, clear and distinct. Finally, one might regard the New Testament as the first initiation and the mystics as the second: *σμικρὰ καὶ μεγάλα μυστήρια* (“the lesser and the greater mysteries”).

What we have called denial of the will to live is developed still further, expressed in more ways and pictured more vividly in ancient Sanskrit works than was possible in the Christian Church and the Western world. This ethical view of life could perhaps take a further and more definite form there chiefly because it was not constrained by an alien element, as Christianity was by

Jewish doctrine. Christianity's sublime founder necessarily had to accommodate himself to and join with that doctrine, partly consciously and perhaps partly without knowing it. Christianity thus consists of two very different elements. I would call the purely ethical one especially, even exclusively, Christian, and distinguish it from the Jewish dogmatism it found already in place. It has often been feared, especially now, that this excellent and healing religion could fall into complete decay. If so, I would seek the cause only in its composition from two originally alien elements joined by the course of history. Their differing affinity for and reaction to the advancing spirit of the age could produce a separation and dissolution. Even then, however, its purely ethical part would remain intact, for it is indestructible.

In Hindu ethics, as far as we know its literature so far, we find this view expressed most powerfully and variously in the Vedas, Puranas, poems, myths, legends of saints, maxims, and rules of life.^[2] It prescribes love of one's neighbor with complete surrender of self-love; love reaching beyond the human race to everything living; beneficence even to the point of giving away one's hard-won daily earnings; boundless patience toward every offender; returning every evil, however grave, with good and love; willing and cheerful endurance of disgrace; abstention from animal food; complete chastity and renunciation of all sensual pleasure for anyone striving for holiness proper; surrender of all property; leaving every home and all relatives; and deep, complete solitude spent in silent contemplation, voluntary penance, and terrible, slow self-torment. The aim is complete mortification of the will, sometimes carried to voluntary death by starvation, facing crocodiles, throwing oneself from a sacred Himalayan peak, being buried alive, or flinging oneself beneath the wheels of the enormous chariot bearing idols amid singing, jubilation, and dancing by *bayaderes*. These precepts originated more than four thousand years ago. Though this people has declined in many respects, individuals still follow them now even to the furthest extremes.^[3] Something practiced for so long among so many millions despite requiring the gravest sacrifices cannot be an arbitrary fancy; it must be grounded in human nature.

More than this, the accord between the life of a Christian penitent or saint and that of an Indian is astonishing. Their dogmas, customs, and surroundings differ fundamentally, yet their striving and inner lives are the same, as are their precepts. Tauler, for instance, speaks of the complete poverty one should seek: to relinquish everything that could yield any worldly comfort or satisfaction, because it all gives the will fresh nourishment when the goal is its complete

extinction. As an Indian counterpart, Fo's precepts finally instruct the sannyasi, who must own nothing and have no home, not even to lie under the same tree too often, lest he acquire a fondness or attachment to it. Christian mystics and teachers of Vedanta agree, too, that external works and religious practices become superfluous for someone who has reached perfection. Such agreement across such different times and peoples is factual evidence that it expresses not a perversity or madness of disposition, as shallow optimists like to claim, but a side of human nature that is essential and appears rarely only because of its excellence.

I have now named sources from which the appearances of denial of the will to live can be learned directly from life. This is in a sense the most important point of our whole inquiry. Yet I have presented it only very generally. It is better to refer readers to those who speak from immediate experience than to swell this book needlessly by repeating their accounts less effectively.

I will add only a little to characterize their state in general. We saw earlier that the evil person, through the vehemence of his willing, suffers constant, consuming inner torment, and that when every object of willing is exhausted he finally cools the fierce thirst of self-will at the sight of another's suffering. By contrast, someone in whom denial of the will to live has dawned is full of inner joy and true heavenly peace, however poor, joyless, and deprived his condition looks from outside. This is not the restless drive to live or exuberant joy that requires severe suffering before or after it, such as marks a pleasure-seeking life. It is an unshakable peace, deep calm, and inward serenity. When we see or imagine this condition, we cannot look at it without the greatest longing. We recognize it at once as the only right state, infinitely outweighing all others, and our better spirit calls us toward it with a great *sapere aude* ("dare to be wise"). We then feel that every fulfilment of desire wrested from the world resembles alms that keep a beggar alive today only so he can go hungry again tomorrow. Resignation, by contrast, resembles an inherited estate that forever relieves its owner of care.

Recall from the third book that much of aesthetic pleasure in beauty consists in our entering pure contemplation and being freed for a moment from all willing, desires, and cares. We seem to lose ourselves. We are no longer individuals cognizing for the sake of constant willing, correlates of individual things that become motives for us, but pure, eternal subjects of cognition free of will, correlates of the Idea. We know that these moments, in which we rise as though from the heavy air of earth, freed from the fierce urge of will, are the

most blessed we experience. From this we can infer how blessed the life of someone must be whose will is calmed not momentarily, as in enjoyment of beauty, but forever, indeed wholly extinguished except for the last glowing spark that maintains the body and will go out with it. Such a person, having finally overcome his own nature after many bitter struggles, remains only as a purely knowing being, an unclouded mirror of the world. Nothing can frighten or move him now, for he has cut the thousand threads of willing that held us to the world and pull us to and fro in desire, fear, envy, and anger amid constant pain. Calmly and smilingly he looks back on the phantoms of this world that once stirred and tormented him. They now lie as indifferently before him as chess pieces after a game or, in the morning, discarded carnival costumes whose shapes teased and troubled us during the night. Life and its forms hover before him only as a passing appearance, like a light morning dream to someone half awake, through which reality already shows and which can no longer deceive. Like that dream they finally vanish without a violent transition.

These reflections help us understand the sense in which Madame Guyon often says near the end of her autobiography: “Everything is indifferent to me: I *can* want nothing more; often I do not know whether I exist or not.” To express how, when the will has died, the death of the body—only its appearance, whose disappearance therefore loses all meaning—can no longer be bitter and is instead most welcome, let me quote the words of this holy penitent, though they are not elegantly phrased: *Midi de la gloire; jour où il n’y a plus de nuit; vie qui ne craint plus la mort, dans la mort même: parceque la mort a vaincu la mort, et que celui qui a souffert la première mort, ne gouterá plus la seconde mort* (“Midday of glory; day in which there is no more night; life which no longer fears death, even in death: for death has conquered death, and one who has suffered the first death shall no longer taste the second death”) (*Vie de Mad. de Guion*, vol. 2, p. 13).

We must not suppose, however, that once cognition has become a quietive and denial of the will to live has occurred, it can no longer waver and can be rested upon like an acquired possession. It must be won anew through constant struggle. The body is the will itself, only in the form of objectivity, or as appearance in the world as representation. As long as it lives, the entire will to live remains present as a possibility, always striving to become actual and blaze up again with all its heat. In the lives of saints the peace and blessedness described are therefore only the flower of continual conquest of the will; their soil is unending struggle with the will to live. No one can have lasting peace on

earth. Their inner histories are full of struggles of the soul, temptations, and abandonment by grace—that mode of cognition which renders all motives ineffective, quiets every act of willing as a universal quietive, gives the deepest peace, and opens the gate of freedom.

We accordingly see people who have once reached denial of the will striving with all their strength to remain there. They force themselves into every kind of renunciation, lead a hard, penitential life, and seek out what they find unpleasant, all to subdue the will that continually rises again. Knowing already the value of redemption, they anxiously guard the salvation they have won. They feel scruples of conscience at every innocent pleasure or tiny stirring of vanity, which dies last even here: the most indestructible, energetic, and foolish of human inclinations. By *asceticism*, a word I have often used, I mean in the narrower sense this *deliberate* breaking of the will: refusing what is pleasant, seeking what is unpleasant, choosing a life of penance and self-mortification, to keep the will subdued.

People who have reached denial of the will practice such asceticism to remain in that condition. But suffering imposed by fate is a second path (*δεύτερος πλοῦς*, “second voyage”^[4]) to denial. Indeed, we may assume most people reach it only this way. Suffering *felt by oneself*, rather than merely recognized, most often brings complete resignation, often only near death. For only a few is cognition alone sufficient: seeing through the *principium individuationis*, it first produces the most perfect goodness of disposition and universal love of humanity, then makes them recognize all the world's suffering as their own, until denial of the will follows. Even for someone approaching this point, the tolerable state of his own person, the flattery of the moment, the lure of hope, and the ever available satisfaction of the will—pleasure—almost always obstruct denial and continually tempt him to affirm again. These lures have therefore been personified as devils. Generally the will must be broken by the greatest personal suffering before it denies itself.

We then see someone driven through every degree of increasing distress, resisting fiercely, to the brink of despair. Suddenly he turns inward, knows himself and the world, changes his whole being, and rises above himself and all suffering. As though purified and sanctified by it, he willingly renounces everything he had previously willed most fiercely, in unassailable calm, blessedness, and elevation, and gladly receives death. This is the silver gleam of denial of the will to live, or redemption, suddenly emerging from suffering's purifying flame. Even very evil people are sometimes purified through deepest

pain to this degree: they become others, wholly transformed. Their previous misdeeds therefore no longer trouble their conscience, though they willingly atone for them with death and welcome the ending of the appearance of the will now alien and repulsive to them. In the story of Gretchen's sufferings in his immortal *Faust*, Goethe has given us a clearer and more vivid portrayal of denial of the will through profound misfortune and despair of rescue than any other I know in poetry. Gretchen perfectly exemplifies this second path, which leads to denial not, like the first, by cognition alone of a whole world's suffering willingly taken as one's own, but through immense personal pain actually felt. Many tragedies bring their fiercely willing heroes at the end to such complete resignation, where will to live and its appearance usually end together. Yet no work I know presents the essential transformation as clearly and without distractions as this passage of *Faust*.

In actual life we often see such a transformation among unfortunate people who must drain the greatest measure of suffering. All hope has been taken from them and, in full possession of their minds, they face a shameful, violent, often agonizing death on the scaffold. We should not assume their characters differ from most people's as much as their fate suggests; circumstances largely account for it. Nevertheless they are guilty and evil to a considerable degree. Many of them, once hope is wholly gone, change in the way described. They now show genuine goodness and purity of disposition and a real abhorrence of even the slightest evil or unkind act. They forgive their enemies, even those through whom they have suffered innocently—not merely in words or from hypocritical fear of judges in the underworld, but sincerely and wholeheartedly—and desire no revenge. At last even their suffering and death become dear to them, for denial of the will to live has occurred. They often refuse an offered rescue and die willingly, calmly, and blessedly.

In their excess of pain the ultimate secret of life has been revealed: the evil deed and the suffering, suffering and hatred, the tormented and the tormentor, however different they appear to cognition following the principle of sufficient reason, are one in themselves. They are appearances of the one will to live, which objectivates its conflict with itself through the *principium individuationis*. They have known both sides, evil doing and suffering, in full measure. At last recognizing their identity, they reject both together and deny the will to live. As I said, it makes no difference through which myths and dogmas they account to their reason for this immediate, intuitive cognition and their transformation.

Matthias Claudius was surely a witness to such a change of heart when he wrote the remarkable essay “Conversion Story of ***” in *Wandsbecker Bote* (part 1, p. 115). It ends: “A person's way of thinking can pass from one point on a circle to its opposite, and back again to the former point, if circumstances trace out the arc for him. Such changes are not in themselves anything great or interesting in a human being. But that *remarkable, comprehensive, transcendental change*, when the whole circle is torn irreparably apart and every law of psychology becomes vain and empty, when the coat of skins is taken off or at least turned inside out and it is as though scales fall from a person's eyes—that is something for which anyone at all conscious of the breath in his nostrils would leave father and mother, if he could hear and learn something certain about it.”

Neither closeness to death nor hopelessness is absolutely necessary for such purification by suffering. Without them, great misfortune and pain may force on a person knowledge of the will to live's conflict with itself and the emptiness of all striving. Thus people who led very eventful lives driven by passion—kings, heroes, adventurers—have often changed suddenly, taken to resignation and penance, and become hermits or monks. All genuine conversion stories belong here. One is that of Ramon Llull. A beautiful woman he had long courted finally summoned him to her room, and he expected all his wishes to be fulfilled. Instead she opened her bodice and showed him her breast, horribly eaten away by cancer. From that moment, as though he had seen into hell, he converted, left the court of the king of Majorca, and went into the wilderness to do penance.^[5] The conversion of the Abbé Rancé, briefly recounted in chapter 48 of the second volume, is very similar. Both were prompted by an abrupt passage from pleasure to life's horrors. This helps explain the striking fact that the most pleasure-loving, cheerful, sensual, and light-minded nation of Europe, the French, gave rise to by far the strictest monastic order, the Trappists. After its decline, Rancé restored it. Despite revolutions, changes in the Church, and the spread of unbelief, it has maintained its purity and fearsome austerity to this day.

Yet cognition of the kind described, concerning the character of this existence, can vanish along with the event that prompted it. The will to live and the former character then return. We see the passionate Benvenuto Cellini changed in this way once in prison and once during a serious illness, only to fall back into his old condition when the suffering ends. In general, denial of the will no more follows suffering with the necessity of an effect following a cause.

The will remains free. This is the one point where its freedom enters appearance directly, hence the force of Claudius's amazement at the "transcendental change." For any suffering one can conceive a will still more vehement and thus unconquered. Plato accordingly tells us in the *Phaedo* of people who continue feasting, drinking, and enjoying sex up to the moment of execution, affirming life into death. In Cardinal Beaufort, Shakespeare sets before us the terrible end of a villain who dies in despair: neither suffering nor death can break a will fierce enough for the utmost wickedness.^[6]

The fiercer the will, the more glaring the appearance of its conflict and thus the greater the suffering. A world that was the appearance of a much fiercer will to live than the present one would contain correspondingly greater suffering. It would be a *hell*.

All suffering has a potential sanctifying power insofar as it mortifies the will and calls for resignation. This explains why great misfortune and deep pain command a certain reverence in themselves. But the sufferer becomes wholly venerable to us only when he looks over his life as a chain of sufferings, or mourns a great incurable pain, without dwelling on the particular circumstances that plunged his own life into sorrow or on that single great misfortune. Up to that point his cognition still follows the principle of sufficient reason and clings to an individual appearance: he still wants life, just not under the conditions allotted him. He becomes truly venerable when his view rises from the particular to the universal, and he sees his own suffering merely as an example of the whole. Becoming a genius in ethical matters, he takes one case for thousands. Life as a whole, apprehended as essentially suffering, then brings him to resignation. This is why the princess in Goethe's *Torquato Tasso* is venerable when she speaks of how her own life and those of her loved ones have always been sad and joyless, while looking entirely to the universal.

We always imagine a very noble character with a tinge of quiet sorrow. This is nothing like constant annoyance at daily adversity, which would be an ignoble trait and give reason to fear an evil disposition. It is an awareness, born of cognition, of the emptiness of all goods and the suffering of all life, not merely one's own. Yet personal suffering, especially one great experience, may first awaken this cognition. A single unattainable wish brought Petrarch to the resigned sorrow over all life that speaks so movingly from his works. The Daphne he pursued had to escape his grasp and leave him the immortal laurel instead. When fate breaks the will to some degree through such a great, irrevocable refusal, hardly anything more is willed, and character becomes

gentle, sorrowful, noble, and resigned. Finally, when grief has no particular object but spreads over life as a whole, it becomes a kind of inward turning, a withdrawal and gradual vanishing of the will. It gently but deeply undermines even the will's visible form, the body. The person feels his bonds loosening and softly anticipates death, which announces itself as dissolution of body and will together. A secret joy therefore accompanies this grief, the feeling I believe the most melancholy of peoples calls *the joy of grief*.

There is also the danger here of *sentimentality*, both in life and in poetic depictions of it. If one continually mourns and complains without rising to resignation and taking courage, one loses earth and heaven alike and is left with watery sentiment. Suffering becomes a venerable path to redemption only when it takes the form of pure cognition and thereby, as a *quietive of the will*, brings true resignation. In this respect, when we see anyone deeply unfortunate, we feel a certain respect akin to that compelled by virtue and nobility, and our own good fortune seems a reproach. We cannot help regarding every suffering, our own or another's, as at least a possible approach to virtue and holiness, and pleasures and worldly satisfactions as a movement away from them. This goes so far that someone enduring great bodily or mental suffering, or even doing exhausting physical labor by the sweat of his brow, visibly spent but patient and without complaint, strikes us, if we watch him intently, as a sick person undergoing a painful cure. He bears the pain willingly and even with satisfaction, knowing that the more he suffers, the more of the disease is destroyed and that his present pain measures his healing.

From everything said so far, denial of the will to live, called complete resignation or holiness, always arises from a quietive of the will: cognition of its inner conflict and essential emptiness as expressed in the suffering of all living things. The two paths differ in what prompts this cognition. On one, it is suffering merely and purely *known*, freely taken on by seeing through the *principium individuationis*. On the other, it is suffering immediately *felt oneself*. True salvation, redemption from life and suffering, is inconceivable without complete denial of the will. Until then each person is nothing other than that will itself. Its appearance is a vanishing existence, a striving always empty and frustrated, and the world full of suffering that we have described. All belong to it irrevocably and alike. For we found that life is always assured to the will to live; its only real form is the present, from which the will can never escape, however much birth and death rule in appearance. Indian myth expresses this by saying, "They are reborn."

The great ethical difference among characters means that the evil person is infinitely far from cognition leading to denial of the will. All the torments that appear *possible* in life are thus *actual* for him in truth. Even his possibly happy present state is only an appearance mediated by the *principium individuationis*, Maya's illusion, the beggar's happy dream. The suffering he inflicts on others in the fierceness and fury of his will's urge measures the suffering whose personal experience would be unable to break his will and lead it finally to denial. Conversely, every true and pure love, indeed every freely chosen justice, arises from seeing through the *principium individuationis*. When that insight arrives in full force, it brings complete sanctification and redemption. Their appearance is the state of resignation described above, accompanied by unshakable peace and the highest joy in death.^[7]

Notes

Notes

1. An ancient Sanskrit philosophical work, the *Sankhya Karika*, expresses this idea in a fine simile: "Yet the soul remains clothed with the body for a while, as the potter's wheel continues to turn after the vessel is finished through the force of its earlier impulse. Only when the enlightened soul separates from the body and nature ceases for it does complete redemption occur." Colebrooke, "On the Philosophy of the Hindus," *Miscellaneous Essays*, vol. 1, p. 259; likewise Horace Wilson's *Sankhya Karika*, §67, p. 184. ↩

2. See, for example, *Oupnek'hat*, edited by Anquetil-Duperron, vol. 2, nos. 138, 144, 145, 146; *Mythologie des Indous par Mad. de Polier*, vol. 2, chapters 13–17; Klaproth's *Asiatisches Magazin*, vol. 1, "On the Religion of Fo" and the *Bhagavad Gita*, or "Conversations between Krishna and Arjuna," and vol. 2, *Moha-Mudgava; Institutes of Hindu Law, or the Ordinances of Menu*, translated from Sanskrit by William Jones, German translation by Hüttner (1797), especially chapters 6 and 12; and many passages in *Asiatic Researches*. (Indian literature available in Europe has grown so much in the last forty years that an update of this note from the first edition would take several pages.) ↩

3. During the Jagannath procession in June 1840, eleven Hindus threw themselves beneath the chariot and died immediately (letter from an East Indian landowner in *The Times*, December 30, 1840). ↩

4. On *δεύτερος πλοῦς* ("second voyage"), see Stobaeus, *Florilegium*, vol. 2, p. 374. ↩

5. Brucker, *Historia critica philosophiae*, vol. 4, part 1, p. 10. ↩

6. *Henry VI, Part 2*, act 3, scene 3. ↩

7. See chapter 48 of the second volume. ↩

§. 69.

Nothing differs more from denial of the will to live, which has now been adequately explained within the limits of our approach, than *suicide*, the actual abolition of one of the will's individual appearances. Denial is the one act of the will's freedom that enters appearance and thus, as Claudius calls it, the transcendental change. Far from being denial of the will, suicide is a phenomenon of its strong affirmation. For denial consists in abhorring life's pleasures, not its sufferings. The person who kills himself wants life; he is merely dissatisfied with the conditions on which it has come to him. He therefore gives up not the will to live but only life, by destroying an individual appearance. He wants life, the unhindered existence and affirmation of the body, but the entanglement of circumstances prevents it and causes him great suffering. The will to live finds itself so constrained in this one appearance that it cannot unfold its striving. It accordingly decides in keeping with its nature in itself, outside the forms of the principle of sufficient reason and thus indifferent to any particular appearance. It remains untouched by all arising and passing away and is the inner life of everything.

The same firm inward certainty that lets us all live without constant dread of death—the certainty that the will can never lack its appearance—also supports the suicidal act. The will to live thus appears as much in self-killing (Shiva) as in the satisfaction of self-preservation (Vishnu) and the pleasure of procreation (Brahma). This is the inner meaning of the *unity* of the *Trimurti*, which every person wholly is, though in time he displays first one and then another of its three heads. Suicide stands to denial of the will as an individual thing stands to an Idea: the person who kills himself denies only the individual, not the species. We found above that life is always assured to the will to live and suffering is essential to life. Suicide is the voluntary destruction of one appearance while the thing in itself remains undisturbed, as a rainbow stands fast though the drops that support it for moments change rapidly. It is therefore a futile and foolish act.

Moreover, it is Maya's masterpiece, the most blatant expression of the will to live's conflict with itself. We recognized that conflict in the lowest appearances of will, in the constant struggle among expressions of natural forces and among organic individuals for matter, time, and space. We saw it emerge ever more terribly at higher grades of the will's objectivation. Finally, at the highest grade,

the human Idea, it reaches the point where not only individuals presenting the same Idea destroy one another, but the very same individual declares war on himself. He wills life so fiercely and assails its hindrance, suffering, so forcefully that he destroys himself. The individual will abolishes the body, its own visibility, by an act of will rather than let suffering break the will. Precisely because the person who kills himself cannot cease willing, he ceases living. The will here affirms itself by abolishing its appearance, since it can no longer affirm itself otherwise.

Yet the suffering he thus evades could have mortified the will and led him to denial and redemption. In this respect he resembles a sick person who refuses to complete a painful operation already begun that could cure him thoroughly, preferring to keep the disease. Suffering approaches and opens the possibility of denying the will, but he wards it off by destroying the will's appearance, the body, so that the will remains unbroken. This is why almost all philosophical and religious ethical systems condemn suicide, though they can give only oddly sophistical reasons. If someone has ever refrained from suicide from a purely moral impulse, the innermost meaning of that self-conquest, whatever concepts his reason used for it, was this: "I will not evade suffering, so that it can help abolish the will to live whose appearance is so wretched. It can strengthen the knowledge of the world's true nature already dawning on me until that knowledge finally quiets my will and redeems me forever."

It is well known that from time to time a parent kills children he dearly loves and then himself. Conscience, religion, and every inherited concept tell the father that murder is the gravest crime, yet he commits it in the hour of his own death, without any egoistic motive for doing so. This can be explained only because the individual's will immediately recognizes itself in the children. Captive, however, to the illusion that appearance is the essence in itself and deeply struck by knowledge of the misery of all life, he thinks he can abolish the essence along with its appearance. He thus wants to rescue himself and the children in whom he sees himself living again from existence and its misery. An exactly analogous error would be to imagine that one could achieve through preventing conception what voluntary chastity achieves, or even to hasten a newborn's death in view of life's inevitable suffering instead of doing everything to secure the life of each being pressing into it.

For if the will to live exists, no force can break it as the one metaphysical reality, the thing in itself. Force can only destroy its appearance here and now. The will itself can be abolished only through *cognition*. Thus the sole path to

salvation is to allow the will to appear unhindered so that in that appearance it can *know* its own essence. Only as a result of such knowledge can the will abolish itself and end the suffering inseparable from its appearance. Physical violence—the destruction of an embryo, the killing of a newborn, or suicide—cannot do this. Nature leads the will into the light precisely because only in the light can it find redemption. Nature's purposes must therefore be advanced in every way once the will to live, her inner essence, has made its decision.

A special kind of voluntary death, perhaps not yet sufficiently established, seems wholly different from ordinary suicide: death by starvation freely chosen in the highest degree of asceticism. Its occurrence has always been attended by much religious enthusiasm and even superstition, obscuring it. It seems possible, however, for complete denial of the will to reach a degree where even the will needed to preserve the body's vegetative life by taking nourishment falls away. Far from arising from the will to live, a completely resigned ascetic ceases living only because he has ceased willing altogether. No manner of death other than hunger is readily conceivable here, unless it arose from some particular superstition. An intention to shorten the torment would already be a degree of affirmation of the will. The dogmas filling such a penitent's reason present him with the illusion that a higher being commanded the fasting to which his inward inclination drives him.

Older examples appear in the *Breslau Collection of Natural and Medical Histories*, September 1799, p. 363 ff.; Bayle's *Nouvelles de la république des lettres* (*News of the Republic of Letters*), February 1685, p. 189 ff.; Zimmermann's *On Solitude*, vol. 1, p. 182; and a report by Houttuyn in the *Histoire de l'académie des sciences* (*History of the Academy of Sciences*) for 1764, reprinted in the *Collection for Practical Physicians*, vol. 1, p. 69. Later reports appear in Hufeland's *Journal for Practical Medicine*, vol. 10, p. 181, and vol. 48, p. 95; Nasse's *Journal for Psychiatric Physicians*, 1819, issue 3, p. 460; and the *Edinburgh Medical and Surgical Journal*, 1809, vol. 5, p. 319. All the newspapers reported in 1833 that the English historian Dr. Lingard had voluntarily starved himself to death in Dover that January; later accounts said it was not he but a relative. These reports generally call the people insane, and it is now impossible to establish how far that was true. But I will reproduce a more recent report, if only to preserve one of the rare examples of this striking and extraordinary phenomenon of human nature. It at least appears to belong in this

category and would otherwise be hard to explain. The report appeared in the *Nürnberger Korrespondent* of July 29, 1813:

From Bern it is reported that a hut has been discovered in a thick wood near Thurnen. It contained the body of a man dead and decomposing for about a month, dressed in clothes that gave little indication of his station. Two very fine shirts lay nearby. The most important object was a Bible with blank pages bound in, some written on by the dead man. He records the day of his departure from home, though not his place of origin, and then says he was driven by the spirit of God into a wilderness to pray and fast. He had already fasted for seven days on his journey, then eaten again. After settling there he began to fast once more, for a certain number of days. Each day is then marked with a stroke. There are five strokes, after which the pilgrim presumably died. A letter addressed to a pastor concerning a sermon he had heard from him was also found, but it too lacked an address.

There may be many intermediate degrees and mixtures between voluntary death arising from the extreme of asceticism and ordinary suicide arising from despair. These are hard to explain, but the human mind has depths, darknesses, and intricacies that are exceedingly difficult to illuminate and disentangle.

§. 70.

Someone might think our account of what I call denial of the will, now complete, incompatible with the earlier explanation of the necessity governing motivation just as it governs every other form of the principle of sufficient reason. According to that account, motives, like all causes, are merely occasions on which character unfolds its nature and reveals it with the necessity of a natural law. We therefore absolutely denied freedom as *liberum arbitrium indifferentiae* (an indifferent freedom of choice). Far from revoking that denial, I recall it here. True freedom, independence of the principle of sufficient reason, belongs only to the will as thing in itself, not to its appearance, whose essential form everywhere is that principle, the element of necessity. There is only one case in which this freedom can become immediately visible in appearance: when it brings what appears to an end. Yet the mere appearance—the animate body as a link in the chain of causes—continues in time, which contains appearances alone. The will manifesting itself through this appearance therefore contradicts it, denying what it expresses. In such a case the genitals, the visible expression of sexual desire, exist and are healthy, yet no sexual satisfaction is willed, even inwardly. The whole body is the visible expression of the will to live, yet motives corresponding to that will no longer work. Indeed, dissolution of the body, the end of the individual and thus the greatest hindrance of the natural will, is welcomed and desired.

The apparent contradiction between our claim that motives necessarily determine the will in accordance with character and our claim that the will can be completely abolished, leaving motives powerless, is therefore only philosophy's reflective repetition of that *real* contradiction. It arises when the freedom of the will in itself, which knows no necessity, directly intervenes in the necessity of its appearance. The key to reconciling the claims is that the condition in which character is withdrawn from the power of motives does not come immediately from the will, but from a changed mode of cognition. So long as cognition remains captive to the *principium individuationis* (principle of individuation) and follows the principle of sufficient reason unreservedly, motives have irresistible force. But when one sees through the *principium individuationis* and immediately knows the Ideas and even the essence of things in themselves as the same will in everything, that knowledge becomes a universal quietive of willing. Individual motives then lose their effect, because the mode of cognition corresponding to them has retreated and been eclipsed by

an entirely different one. Character can therefore never change in part. In individual cases it must carry out, with the consistency of a natural law, the will of which it is an appearance as a whole. Yet that whole, character itself, can be abolished completely through the change in cognition just described. Claudius called this the “comprehensive, transcendental change” and marveled at it. It is aptly called *rebirth* in the Christian Church, and the cognition from which it springs was called the *action of grace*. We speak of character's complete abolition rather than a change in it. This is why people whose characters differed widely before it occurred show great similarity of conduct afterward, though each still *speaks* very differently according to his concepts and dogmas.

In this sense the old philosophical doctrine of free will, forever disputed and forever affirmed, is not groundless. Nor is the Church's doctrine of grace and rebirth without meaning. Unexpectedly, the two now coincide, and we can understand the sense in which the excellent Malebranche could rightly say, *La liberté est un mystère* (“Freedom is a mystery”). What Christian mystics call the *action of grace* and *rebirth* is for us the only immediate expression of the *freedom of the will*. It occurs only when the will, having come to know its essence in itself, receives from that knowledge a *quietive* and is thereby withdrawn from the effect of *motives*. These belong to another mode of cognition, whose objects are appearances alone. The possibility of freedom expressing itself in this way is humanity's greatest advantage, forever denied to animals. It requires reason's reflective awareness, which enables a survey of life as a whole independently of the present impression. An animal has no possibility of freedom. Indeed, it cannot even make a genuine, considered choice after a full conflict among motives, which would need to be abstract representations. A hungry wolf sinks its teeth into its prey with the same necessity as a stone falls to the ground, without any possibility of knowing that it is both the creature torn apart and the one doing the tearing. *Necessity is the realm of nature; freedom is the realm of grace.*

As we have seen, this *self-abolition of the will* arises from cognition. Cognition and insight as such are independent of deliberate choice. Denial of willing, the entrance into freedom, therefore cannot be forced by a resolution. It springs from the innermost relation of cognition to willing in a person, arriving suddenly, as though from outside. That is precisely why the Church called it the *action of grace*. Yet just as the Church makes its operation depend on receiving grace, the quietive's effect is ultimately an act of freedom by the will. After this action of grace, the person's whole being is changed and turned about from its

foundations. He wants none of what he formerly wanted so fiercely; a new person, as it were, takes the old one's place. The Church therefore called the result *rebirth*. What it calls the *natural person*, denying him every capacity for good, is the will to live itself. That will must be denied if redemption from an existence such as ours is to be attained. Something else lies behind our existence, accessible to us only when we shake off the world.

Christian doctrine does not consider individuals according to the principle of sufficient reason, but the Idea of humanity in its unity. It therefore symbolizes *nature*, the *affirmation of the will to live*, in Adam. His sin inherited by us, that is, our unity with him in the Idea, represented in time through the bond of procreation, makes us all partake of suffering and eternal death. In contrast it symbolizes *grace*, *denial of the will*, and *redemption* in God become human. Free of all sinfulness, that is, of all will to live, he cannot have arisen, as we have, from the strongest affirmation of the will, nor have a body that is through and through concrete will, an appearance of will. Born of a pure virgin, he has only an apparent body. This last is the doctrine of the Docetists, certain Church Fathers who were very consistent on this point. Apelles especially taught it, opposed by Tertullian and his followers. Even Augustine, however, comments on Romans 8:3, *Deus filium suum misit in similitudinem carnis peccati* ("God sent his son in the likeness of sinful flesh"): *Non enim caro peccati erat, quae non de carnali delectatione nata erat: sed tamen inerat ei similitudo carnis peccati, quia mortalis caro erat* ("It was not sinful flesh, since it was not born of carnal pleasure; yet it had the likeness of sinful flesh, since it was mortal flesh") (*Liber 83 quaestionum*, question 66). In his *Opus imperfectum*, I, 47, Augustine also teaches that original sin is both sin and punishment. It is present even in newborns, though it manifests only when they grow up. Its origin must nevertheless be traced to the will of the sinner. That sinner was Adam, but we all existed in him: Adam became unhappy, and in him we all became unhappy.

In fact, the doctrines of original sin, the affirmation of the will, and redemption, its denial, are the great truth at Christianity's core. Most of the rest is clothing, covering, or accessory. Jesus Christ should accordingly always be understood generally as the symbol or personification of denial of the will to live, rather than as an individual, whether on the basis of his mythical story in the Gospels or of the probable historical reality behind it. Neither account will readily satisfy completely. They serve only as vehicles of that general understanding for the people, who always demand something factual. The fact

that Christianity has lately forgotten its true meaning and declined into shallow optimism is not our concern here.

Another original evangelical Christian teaching was defended by Augustine, with the Church leaders' agreement, against the platitudes of the Pelagians. *Luther* made cleansing it of errors and restoring it the chief aim of his efforts, as he expressly says in *De servo arbitrio* (*On the Bondage of the Will*). It teaches that the *will is not free*, but originally subject to an inclination to evil; its works are therefore always sinful and defective, never adequate to justice. Consequently salvation comes not from works at all but from faith alone, and even this faith arises not from deliberate choice and free will but comes to us through the *action of grace*, without our doing, as though from outside. Not only the doctrines already mentioned but this last genuinely evangelical doctrine is among those now rejected as absurd, or concealed, by a crude and shallow view. Despite Augustine and Luther, that view favors the Pelagians' homely common sense, today's rationalism. It declares obsolete precisely the profound doctrines most distinctive and essential to Christianity in the strict sense, while retaining only the doctrine from Judaism, attached to Christianity by historical circumstance,^[1] and making that its chief concern.

We, however, recognize in the doctrine just described a truth wholly agreeing with the result of our inquiry. Genuine virtue and holiness of disposition arise first not from considered choice, or works, but from *cognition*, or faith, just as we derived them from our central thought. If works arising from motives and deliberate resolutions led to salvation, virtue would always be merely a prudent, methodical, far-sighted egoism, however one put it. The faith to which the Christian Church promises salvation says that through the first human's fall we all partake of sin and are given over to death and ruin, and that all can be redeemed only through grace and the divine mediator's assumption of our immense guilt, wholly without merit on our part as persons. What can arise from a person's intentional action determined by motives—works—can never justify us. By its very nature it cannot, precisely because it is *intentional* action prompted by motives, an *opus operatum* (a work performed).

This faith thus says, first, that our condition is originally and essentially without salvation and we need *redemption* from it. Second, we ourselves essentially belong to evil and are so firmly bound to it that our works according to law and precept, that is, according to motives, can never satisfy justice or redeem us. Redemption can be won only through faith, a changed mode of cognition, and even that faith can come only through grace, as though from

outside. This means that salvation is something entirely foreign to our person and points to the need for that very person's denial and surrender. Works, obedience to law as such, can never justify, since they are always action on motives. *Luther* demands in *De libertate Christiana* (*On Christian Liberty*) that, once faith has arrived, good works arise from it of themselves as its signs and fruits. They must not claim merit, justification, or reward for themselves, but occur wholly freely and without payment. Similarly we derived from an increasingly clear insight through the *principium individuationis* first freely chosen justice, then love up to the complete abolition of egoism, and finally resignation or denial of the will.

I have drawn on these Christian doctrines, foreign as they are in themselves to philosophy, only to show that the ethics arising from and closely agreeing with all parts of our inquiry, however new and unheard of its expression might be, is by no means new in substance. It fully agrees with Christianity's most characteristic doctrines and was already essentially contained in them. It agrees just as closely with the teachings and ethical precepts of India's sacred books, expressed in entirely different forms. Recalling Church doctrine also explained and clarified the apparent contradiction between the necessity of every expression of character when motives are presented, the realm of nature, and the freedom of the will in itself to deny itself and abolish character together with all the necessity of motives grounded in it, the realm of grace.

Notes

Notes

1. How true this is becomes clear from the fact that all the contradictions and incomprehensibilities contained in the Christian dogmatics systematized consistently by Augustine, which led to the opposite Pelagian shallowness, disappear as soon as we set aside the fundamental Jewish dogma and recognize that the human being is the work of his own will, not of another's. Everything then becomes clear and correct at once. No freedom is needed in *operari* (acting), for it lies in *esse* (being), where sin too lies as original sin; the action of grace, however, is our own. Under today's rationalist view, many doctrines in Augustinian dogmatics based on the New Testament, such as predestination, appear wholly untenable, even offensive. Their rejection discards what is truly Christian and returns to crude Judaism. Yet the error in calculation, the original defect in Christian dogmatics, lies where no one looks: in precisely the premise removed from scrutiny as certain. Once it is set aside, the whole dogmatics is rational. For that dogma spoils theology as it spoils every other science. Studying Augustine's theology in *De civitate Dei* (*The City of God*), especially book 14, is like trying to make an object stand when its center of gravity lies outside it: turn and place it as one likes, and it keeps toppling over. Despite all Augustine's efforts and sophistry, the guilt of the world and its torments likewise keep falling back on the God who made everything, made all things in all, and knew how they would turn out. I have already shown in my prize essay on freedom of the will (chapter 4, pp. 66–68 of the first [and second] edition) that Augustine himself noticed the difficulty and stumbled over it. The conflict between God's goodness and the world's misery, as well as that between free will and God's foreknowledge, was likewise the inexhaustible subject of a nearly century-long controversy among the Cartesians, Malebranche, Leibniz, Bayle, Clarke, Arnauld, and others. The one dogma all sides held fixed was God's existence and attributes. They turned in circles without end, trying to reconcile these things, to solve an equation that never works out: its remainder appears first here, then there, after being concealed elsewhere. No one thinks to seek the source of the difficulty in the fundamental premise itself, although it is obvious. Only Bayle gives a hint that he notices it. ↩

§. 71.

As I finish this outline of ethics, and with it the whole development of the single thought I set out to communicate, I have no wish to hide an objection to this last part. Rather, I will show that it lies in the nature of the matter and cannot possibly be removed. Our inquiry has ended by bringing before us, in complete holiness, the denial and surrender of all willing and thereby redemption from a world whose whole existence appeared to us as suffering. Yet precisely this now seems to be a passage into empty *nothingness*.

First, the concept of *nothingness* is essentially relative. It refers only to some particular thing that it negates. Some, especially Kant, have ascribed this property only to the *nihil privativum* (relative nothing), represented by a minus in opposition to a plus, which could become plus from the opposite standpoint. They set against it the *nihil negativum* (absolute nothing), which would be nothing in every relation, giving as an example a logical contradiction that cancels itself. On closer examination, however, no absolute nothing, no *nihil negativum* in the strict sense, is even conceivable. Viewed from a higher standpoint or placed under a wider concept, every such nothing is again only a *nihil privativum*. A nothing is nothing only in a relation to something else and therefore presupposes that other thing. Even a logical contradiction is only relatively nothing. It is not a thought of reason, but neither is it absolute nothing. It is a combination of words and an example of what cannot be thought, needed in logic to demonstrate the laws of thought. When we seek such an example for that purpose, we grasp the nonsense as the positive thing sought and pass over sense as the negative. Every *nihil negativum*, or absolute nothing, thus appears as a mere *nihil privativum*, or relative nothing, when subordinated to a higher concept. It can exchange signs with what it negates, so that the other becomes the negation and it becomes the positive. This agrees with Plato's result in the difficult dialectical inquiry into nothing in the *Sophist* (pp. 277–287, Bipont edition; *Sophist* 258e): Τὴν τοῦ ἑτέρου φύσιν ἀποδείξαντες οὕσαν τε, καὶ κατακεκερματισμένην ἐπὶ πάντα τὰ ὄντα πρὸς ἄλληλα, τὸ πρὸς τὸ ὄν ἕκαστον μῦριον αὐτῆς ἀντιτιθέμενον, ἐτολμήσαμεν εἰπεῖν, ὥς αὐτὸ τοῦτό ἐστιν ὄντως τὸ μὴ ὄν. (*Cum enim ostenderemus, alterius ipsius naturam esse, perque omnia entia divisam atque dispersam invicem; tunc partem ejus oppositam ei, quod cujusque ens est, esse ipsum revera non ens asseruimus.* “Having shown that the nature of the other exists and is divided and

dispersed among all beings in relation to one another, we ventured to say that the part opposed to each being is truly non-being.”)

What is generally taken as positive, what we call *being* and whose negation the concept *nothingness* expresses in its broadest sense, is the world as representation. I have shown it to be the objectivity of the will, its mirror. This will and this world are also ourselves. Representation as such belongs to the world as one of its sides. Its form is space and time, so everything that exists from this standpoint must exist somewhere and sometime. Denial, abolition, and reversal of the will are also the abolition and disappearance of the world, its mirror. When we no longer see the will in that mirror, we ask in vain where it has gone. We lament that it has vanished into nothing, because it no longer has any where or when.

If the opposite standpoint were possible for us, it would reverse the signs, showing what exists for us as nothing and that nothing as what exists. But so long as we are ourselves the will to live, we can know and name the latter only negatively. The old saying of Empedocles, that like is known only by like, deprives us here of all cognition. Conversely, it ultimately grounds the possibility of everything we actually know: the world as representation, or the will's objectivity. For the world is the will's self-knowledge.

If one still insisted on somehow obtaining positive knowledge of what philosophy can express only negatively as denial of the will, we could only point to the state experienced by those who have reached complete denial. It has been called ecstasy, rapture, illumination, union with God, and so on. Yet it cannot properly be called cognition, since it no longer has the form of subject and object. Besides, it is accessible only through one's own experience, which cannot be communicated further.

We, however, must remain wholly at the standpoint of philosophy and be content here with negative cognition, satisfied to have reached the last boundary of positive cognition. We have known the world's essence in itself as will and all its appearances as the will's objectivity, tracing it from the unknowing urge of obscure natural forces to the most fully conscious human action. We do not shrink from the consequence: with the will's free denial and surrender, all those appearances are abolished. The ceaseless pressure and activity without goal or rest on every level of objectivity, in and through which the world exists, is abolished. So is the multiplicity of its successive forms; with the will, its whole appearance is abolished. Finally the general forms of that appearance, time and

space, and its most fundamental form, subject and object, are abolished too. No will: no representation, no world.

Only nothingness certainly remains before us. But what resists this dissolution into nothingness is our nature, and that is precisely the will to live. We are that will, as our world is. Our strong aversion to nothingness is simply another expression of how strongly we will life, and that we are nothing but this will and know nothing but it. Yet if we turn from our own poverty and captivity to those who overcame the world, in whom the will, reaching full self-knowledge, found itself in everything and then freely denied itself, and who now only await the disappearance of its last trace along with the body it animates, we see something else. In place of restless pressure and striving, the continual movement from desire to fear and joy to pain, the hope never satisfied and never dying that makes up the willing person's dream of life, there is the peace beyond all reason, the complete calm of a sea without wind in the mind, deep repose, unshakable confidence and serenity. Their mere reflection on a face, as Raphael and Correggio portrayed it, is a complete and certain gospel: cognition alone remains; the will has disappeared. We look on this state with deep and painful longing, and in contrast the misery and hopelessness of our own stands revealed. Nevertheless, this is the only contemplation that can console us enduringly when we have recognized incurable suffering and endless misery as essential to the world, the will's appearance, yet see that world dissolve when the will is abolished and are left before empty nothingness.

By contemplating the lives and conduct of saints—whom we are seldom fortunate enough to meet in our own experience, but whose recorded histories and works of art bearing the stamp of inward truth set before our eyes—we can thus dispel the dark impression of the nothingness hovering as the final goal beyond all virtue and holiness, which we fear like children fear the dark. We do this instead of evading it, as the Indians do through myths and words without meaning such as absorption into *Brahman* or the Buddhists' *Nirvana*. We acknowledge freely: what remains after the complete abolition of the will is indeed nothing for everyone still full of will. But conversely, for those in whom the will has turned and denied itself, this world of ours, so very real, with all its suns and Milky Ways, is—nothing.^[1]

Notes

Notes

1. This is also the Buddhists' *Prajñāpāramitā*, “beyond all cognition”: the point where subject and object no longer exist. (See J. J. Schmidt, *On the Mahayana and Prajñāpāramitā*.) ↩

Appendix.

Critique of Kantian Philosophy.

*C'est le privilège du vrai génie, et surtout du génie qui
ouvre une carrière, de faire impunément de grandes fautes.*

—Voltaire

“It is the privilege of true genius, especially a genius who opens a new path, to make great mistakes with impunity.”

It is much easier to point out the faults and errors in a great mind's work than to give a clear and complete account of its value. Faults are individual and finite and can therefore be surveyed fully. The mark that genius imprints on its works, however, is that their excellence is unfathomable and inexhaustible. They thus become the ageless teachers of century after century. The completed masterpiece of a truly great mind always has a profound and far-reaching effect on humanity as a whole. No one can calculate the distant centuries and lands its illuminating influence may reach. It always does so because, however cultivated and rich the age in which it arose, genius rises above the ground in which it is rooted like a palm tree.

Such a deep and widespread effect cannot arrive suddenly, because the distance between genius and ordinary humanity is so great. The knowledge a single person draws directly from life and the world in one lifetime, gains and prepares for others, cannot immediately become humanity's possession; humanity lacks even as much power to receive as he has to give. Even after fighting off unworthy opponents who threaten an immortal work's life at its birth and would suffocate humanity's benefit in the bud, like the serpent at Hercules' cradle, that knowledge must travel the roundabout paths of countless false interpretations and crooked applications. It must survive attempts to combine it with old errors and live in struggle until a new, unbiased generation grows up to meet it. Gradually, through a thousand derived channels, that generation partly receives the source's content in its youth, assimilates it little by little, and shares in the benefit the great mind was meant to bring humanity. So slow is the education of humanity, the weak and obstinate pupil of genius. Kant's teaching too will reveal its full force and importance only with time, when the spirit of the age, gradually remade by that teaching and changed in its most important depths, bears living witness to the power of his giant mind. I do

not mean presumptuously to anticipate this and play the thankless role of Calchas and Cassandra. Let me merely, for the reasons given, treat Kant's works as still very new. Many now consider them outdated, lay them aside as finished, or say they have "moved beyond" them. Emboldened by this, others simply ignore them and brazenly continue philosophizing about God and the soul on the premises of old realist dogmatism and scholasticism. That is as though modern chemistry were to accept the teachings of alchemists. Kant's works need no weak praise of mine. They will praise their author forever and live on earth, perhaps not in their letter, but in their spirit.

Looking at the immediate outcome of his teaching—the attempts and events in philosophy since then—one may indeed find confirmation of Goethe's disheartening observation: "As the water displaced by a ship closes up again immediately behind it, so error, when superior minds have pushed it aside and made room for themselves, very quickly closes up again by nature behind them" (*Poetry and Truth*, part 3, p. 521). Yet this period was only an episode among the fortunes of every new and great insight, and it is now plainly nearing its end: the soap bubble blown up for so long is finally bursting. People are beginning to realize generally that serious philosophy still stands where Kant left it. At any rate, I acknowledge no philosophical achievement between him and me, and so attach myself directly to him.

My purpose in this appendix is really only to justify the doctrine set out in my work insofar as it differs from, and in many places contradicts, Kantian philosophy. Such a discussion is necessary. Though the content of my train of thought differs greatly from Kant's, it is plainly under his influence throughout, necessarily presupposes him, and starts from him. Next to the impression of the intuitive world, I acknowledge that I owe the best in my own development to Kant's works, the Hindus' sacred writings, and Plato. I can justify my disagreements with Kant only by showing error and exposing faults in the points concerned. I must therefore be thoroughly polemical against him in this appendix, earnestly and with all my strength. Only in this way can the error clinging to his teaching be rubbed away so that its truth shines more brightly and stands more securely.

No one should expect my deeply felt reverence for Kant to extend to his weaknesses and mistakes or to require such careful gentleness in uncovering them that circumlocution makes my account weak and dull. Such gentleness is needed toward someone living, since human weakness finds even the fairest correction of an error hard to bear without soothing and flattery. A teacher of

centuries and benefactor of humanity deserves at least to have his human weakness spared pain. But someone dead has shed that weakness. His merit is established; time will increasingly cleanse it of exaggeration and disparagement. His errors must be separated from it, made harmless, and then forgotten. In this polemic, then, I have only Kant's faults and weaknesses in view and stand against them. I wage a relentless war of elimination on them, intent on exposing them in the clearest light, rather than covering them gently, to remove them the more surely. For the reasons already stated, I am conscious of no injustice or ingratitude to Kant in doing this. Yet to remove any appearance of malice in others' eyes, I shall first show my heartfelt respect and gratitude by briefly stating what I take to be his chief merit. I shall do so from general standpoints, so that I need not yet touch on the points where I must later contradict him.

Kant's greatest merit is the distinction between appearance and the thing in itself, based on the demonstration that the *intellect* always stands between things and us, so that we cannot know them as they may be in themselves. *Locke* led him onto this path (see *Prolegomena to Any Future Metaphysics*, §13, note 2). *Locke* had shown that things' secondary qualities—sound, smell, color, hardness, softness, smoothness, and the like—depend on affections of the senses and do not belong to the objective body, the thing in itself. To that he ascribed only primary qualities, presupposing merely space and impenetrability: extension, shape, solidity, number, and mobility. But *Locke's* readily discovered distinction, which stays on the surface of things, was only a youthful prelude to Kant's. Starting from a far higher standpoint, Kant declared that everything *Locke* had allowed as *qualitates primariae* (primary qualities), properties of the thing in itself, likewise belongs only to its appearance in our faculty of apprehension. Precisely because space, time, and causality, the conditions of that faculty, are known by us *a priori*, this is so. *Locke* thus subtracted from the thing in itself the contribution of the sense organs to its appearance. Kant went on to subtract the contribution of the brain's functions, though he did not call them that. The distinction between appearance and thing in itself thereby gained infinitely greater importance and far deeper meaning. For this Kant had to make the great separation between our cognition *a priori* and *a posteriori*. Before him it had never been made with proper rigor, completeness, and clarity of awareness. It became the chief subject of his profound inquiries.

We should note immediately that Kant's philosophy has a threefold relation to his predecessors: first, it confirms and extends *Locke*, as just shown; second, it corrects and uses *Hume*, most clearly stated in the preface to the *Prolegomena*, the finest and most accessible of Kant's chief works and read far too little despite how greatly it eases the study of his philosophy; third, it is decidedly polemical and destructive toward the Leibniz-Wolff philosophy. One should know all three teachings before studying Kant. If, as I have said, the distinction between appearance and thing in itself—the complete difference between ideal and real—is the fundamental feature of Kant's philosophy, the shortly subsequent assertion of their absolute identity sadly confirms Goethe's saying quoted earlier. All it rested on was the empty boast of intellectual intuition and so was merely a return to the crudity of the ordinary view, disguised by a grand manner, bombast, and gibberish. It became the fitting starting point for the still coarser nonsense of the dull and spiritless *Hegel*.

Kant's grounded distinction between appearance and thing in itself surpassed everything before it in profundity and circumspection and had consequences of immense reach. Discovered independently, in a wholly new way, from a new side and along a new path, it presented the very truth Plato tirelessly repeated, generally in these words: this world appearing to the senses has no true being but only ceaseless becoming; it is and is not, and our apprehension of it is not so much knowledge as illusion. Plato expresses this truth mythically in the most important passage of all his works, the opening of book seven of the *Republic*, mentioned in my third book. People chained in a dark cave see neither genuine original light nor real things, only the meager light of the cave's fire and the shadows of real things passing behind their backs before it. Yet they take the shadows for reality and regard discerning the order in which these shadows succeed one another as true wisdom. The same truth, presented quite differently, is a chief teaching of the Vedas and Puranas: the doctrine of Maya. By Maya they mean nothing other than what Kant calls appearance in contrast to the thing in itself. Maya's work is the visible world we inhabit, a conjured enchantment, a fleeting appearance without essence in itself, comparable to an optical illusion or a dream, a veil surrounding human consciousness. It is equally false and equally true to say of it that it is and that it is not.

Kant not only expressed the same doctrine in an entirely new and original way, but made it a demonstrated and indisputable truth through the calmest and most sober exposition. Plato and the Indians had based their claims on a general intuition of the world, presenting them as direct expressions of their

consciousness, more mythically and poetically than philosophically and clearly. In this respect they stand to Kant as the Pythagoreans Hicetas, Philolaus, and Aristarchus, who asserted that the earth moves around a stationary sun, stand to Copernicus. A clear understanding and calm, considered account of this dreamlike character of the whole world is the real foundation and soul of Kant's philosophy, its greatest merit. He achieved it by taking apart the whole machinery of our faculty of cognition, through which the phantasmagoria of the objective world arises, and showing it piece by piece with admirable care and skill. All earlier Western philosophy seems unspeakably crude beside his, having missed this truth and therefore spoken as though in a dream. Kant suddenly awakened it, which is why the last sleepers, including Mendelssohn, called him the all-destroyer.

He showed that the laws ruling existence—that is, experience in general—with unbreakable necessity cannot be used to derive and explain *existence itself*. Their validity is only relative: it begins only after existence, the world of experience, has already been posited and is present. These laws therefore cannot guide us when we try to explain the existence of the world and ourselves. All previous Western philosophers had imagined that the laws connecting appearances to one another—time, space, causality, and inference, all of which I sum up under the principle of sufficient reason—were absolute and unconditioned, *aeternae veritates* (eternal truths). They thought the world itself existed only in consequence of and in accordance with them, and the whole riddle of the world could therefore be solved by following them. The assumptions made for this purpose, criticized by Kant under the name Ideas of reason, only served to raise mere appearance, Maya's work and Plato's shadow world, to the sole and highest reality. They put it in place of the inmost, true essence of things and made real knowledge of that essence impossible: in short, they put the dreamers to sleep still more soundly. Kant showed that these laws, and consequently the world itself, are conditioned by the subject's mode of cognition. Thus, however far we inquire and infer under their guidance, we advance not a step in the chief matter, knowledge of the world's essence in itself and apart from representation. We merely move like a squirrel in a wheel. The dogmatists might be compared to people who think that if they walk straight ahead long enough they will reach the end of the world. Kant circumnavigated it and showed that because it is round, horizontal motion cannot carry us beyond it, though vertical motion may perhaps do so. We may also say his

doctrine teaches us to seek the world's end and beginning within, not outside, ourselves.

All this rests on the fundamental distinction between dogmatic and *critical*, or *transcendental*, philosophy. Someone wanting a clear, concrete example can briefly read Leibniz's essay *De rerum originatione radicali* (*On the Ultimate Origin of Things*), first published in Erdmann's edition of Leibniz's philosophical works, vol. 1, p. 147, as a specimen of dogmatic philosophy. It demonstrates the world's origin and excellent character *a priori* in a thoroughly realist, dogmatic manner, using the ontological and cosmological proofs and resting on the *veritates aeternae* (eternal truths). It admits in passing that experience shows the exact opposite of this demonstrated excellence of the world, then tells experience that it knows nothing and should hold its tongue when *a priori* philosophy has spoken. *Critical philosophy* appeared with Kant as an opponent of this whole method. It takes as its problem the very eternal truths forming the foundation of every such dogmatic construction, investigates their origin, and finds it in the human head. They arise from forms peculiar to that head, which it carries within itself to apprehend an objective world. Here, then, in the brain, lies the quarry supplying the material for that proud dogmatic building. To reach this result critical philosophy had to *go beyond* the eternal truths on which all earlier dogmatism relied, taking them themselves as objects of inquiry. This made it *transcendental* philosophy. It further follows that the objective world as we know it does not belong to the nature of things in themselves, but is merely their *appearance*, conditioned by those forms that lie *a priori* in the human intellect, that is, the brain. Consequently it can contain nothing but appearances.

Kant did not arrive at the knowledge that appearance is the world as representation and the thing in itself is will. He did show that the appearing world is conditioned as much by the subject as by the object. Isolating the most general forms of its appearance, or representation, he demonstrated that we can know and survey their whole lawfulness from the subject's side as well as from the object's. They are the boundary shared by both subject and object. He concluded that following this boundary takes us into the interior of neither subject nor object, and so can never reveal the world's essence, the thing in itself.

He did not derive the thing in itself correctly, as I shall soon show, but through an inconsistency that exposed this main part of his teaching to repeated and irresistible attacks. He did not directly recognize the will as the thing in

itself. Yet he took a great step toward this pioneering discovery when he presented the undeniable moral significance of human action as wholly distinct from, independent of, and inexplicable by the laws of appearance, something immediately touching the thing in itself. This is the second chief aspect of his merit.

A third merit is the complete overthrow of scholastic philosophy. Here I use that name broadly for the whole period from the Church Father Augustine to just before Kant. As Tennemann rightly says, scholasticism's principal feature was the guardianship of philosophy by the prevailing state religion. Philosophy was left chiefly to prove and embellish the principal dogmas prescribed by that religion. The scholastics proper, down to Suárez, admit this openly; later philosophers do so more unconsciously or at least without admitting it. Scholastic philosophy is often said to end about a century before Descartes, who supposedly began an entirely new era of free inquiry independent of every positive religious doctrine. But this cannot truly be attributed to Descartes and his successors,^[2] only an appearance of it or at best an aspiration. Descartes was an exceptionally gifted mind and, considering his age, achieved very much. Set that consideration aside, however, and judge him by the liberation of thought from all fetters and beginning of independent, unbiased inquiry for which he is praised. His skepticism lacks real seriousness and is therefore abandoned so quickly and poorly. He makes a show of throwing off all the fetters of opinions instilled early and belonging to his nation and age, but does so only briefly and in appearance, to take them up immediately and hold them more tightly. The same is true of all his successors up to Kant. Goethe's verse aptly describes such a free thinker:

“He seems to me, with all respect to your grace,
Like one of the long-legged cicadas,
Always flying and leaping as it flies—
Then singing its old little song in the grass.”

Kant had reason to appear as though he meant to do only that. But the supposed leap, permitted because everyone already knew it would lead back into the grass, this time became a flight. Those below were left watching and could no longer catch him.

Kant dared to show from his teaching that all those dogmas supposedly proved so often could not be proved. He dealt speculative theology and its companion, rational psychology, a deathblow. Since then they have vanished

from German philosophy. One should not be misled if the words are retained here and there after the things are abandoned, or if some wretched professor of philosophy keeps his master's displeasure in view and lets truth take care of itself. Only someone who notices the harmful influence of those concepts on natural science and philosophy in even the best seventeenth- and eighteenth-century writers can appreciate the greatness of Kant's merit here. The change since Kant in the tone and metaphysical background of German scientific works is striking. Before him they read as English works still do.

This merit is connected with the fact that all earlier philosophy, ancient, medieval, and modern, had been governed by *realism*: unreflectingly following the laws of appearance, raising them to eternal truths and thereby raising fleeting appearance to the world's true essence, without reflection ever disturbing the delusion. *Berkeley*, like *Malebranche* before him, saw its one-sidedness and falsity but could not overturn it because his attack was limited to *one* point. It was left to *Kant* to establish in European philosophy the fundamental idealist view that is essentially even the religious view throughout the non-Islamic parts of Asia. Before Kant we were *in* time; now time is in us, and so forth.

Realist philosophy had also treated ethics according to laws of appearance, regarded as absolute and valid even for the thing in itself. Ethics was therefore based at one time on a doctrine of happiness, at another on the will of the world's creator, finally on the concept of perfection. By itself this concept is wholly empty. It denotes a mere relation that takes meaning only from the things to which it is applied. "To be perfect" means no more than "to correspond to some given concept presupposed here." That concept must therefore be stated first. Without it, perfection is an unnamed number and says nothing by itself. If one silently presupposes the concept of "humanity" and sets the striving for perfect humanity as a moral principle, one says only, "People should be as they should be," and is no wiser. "Perfect" is almost synonymous with "complete": all the predicates contained in the concept of a kind are actually present in the particular case or individual. Used by itself *in abstracto* (in the abstract), "perfection" is therefore an empty word, as is talk of "the most perfect being" and the like. It is all mere verbal show. Nevertheless, in the previous century the concepts of perfection and imperfection became common currency, indeed the pivot of almost all moralizing and even theology. Everyone spoke of them until their abuse became a real nuisance. Even the best writers of the age, Lessing for example, were pitifully entangled in perfections

and imperfections and struggled with them. Yet every thinking mind must at least have dimly felt that the concept has no positive content, indicating only a relation in the abstract like an algebraic symbol. As I have said, Kant separated the undeniable, great ethical significance of actions wholly from appearance and its laws and showed it to concern immediately the thing in itself, the world's inmost essence. Time, space, and everything filling them and ordered within them by the causal law, by contrast, are to be seen as a transient, insubstantial dream.

These brief remarks do not exhaust the matter, but they may suffice as testimony to my recognition of Kant's great merits, offered here for my satisfaction and because fairness calls for recalling them to everyone who follows my unreserved exposure of his faults, to which I now turn.

History alone suggests that Kant's great achievements must have been accompanied by great faults. He brought about the greatest revolution in philosophy, ending a scholasticism that, in the broad sense given above, had lasted fourteen centuries, and began a genuinely new, third world epoch of philosophy. Yet the immediate result of his appearance was almost wholly negative, not positive. He established no complete new system to which his followers could hold for a time. Everyone sensed that something very great had happened, but no one knew exactly what. They realized earlier philosophy had been a fruitless dream from which the new age awoke, but did not know what to hold to now. A great void and need arose. Public attention, even beyond specialists, was aroused. Prompted by this rather than by any inner drive and sense of power, which would show itself even in the least favorable age, as it did with Spinoza, men of no special talent made various weak, absurd, and sometimes mad attempts. The newly aroused public still paid attention and listened for a long time with a patience found only in Germany.

Something similar must once have happened in nature when a great revolution changed the whole face of the earth, sea and land exchanged places, and a new creation could begin. Nature took a long time to bring forth a new series of lasting forms, each in harmony with itself and the others. Strange, monstrous organisms arose, discordant within and among themselves, that could not endure. Their surviving remains recall the wavering experiments of a nature remaking itself. We all know that Kant caused a similar crisis in philosophy, an age of monstrous births. It suggests that his merit was incomplete, burdened with great defects, negative and one-sided. We shall now trace those defects.

First let us clearly state and examine the fundamental thought behind the whole *Critique of Pure Reason*. Kant adopted the standpoint of his predecessors, the dogmatic philosophers, and began with these assumptions: (1) Metaphysics is a science of what lies beyond all possible experience. (2) It can never be found through principles drawn from experience (*Prolegomena*, §1); only what we know *before* all experience, and so independently *of* it, can reach beyond possible experience. (3) Some such principles are indeed found in our reason and are called cognitions of pure reason. To this point Kant agrees with his predecessors; here he parts from them. They say, “These principles, or cognitions of pure reason, express the absolute possibility of things, *aeternae veritates* (eternal truths), sources of ontology. They stand above the world order as fate stood above the ancient gods.” Kant says instead that they are merely forms of our intellect, laws not of the existence of things but of our representations of them. They hold only for our apprehension of things and therefore cannot reach beyond possible experience, the aim assumed in (1). The very *a priori* character of these forms of cognition can rest only on their subjective origin. It forever cuts us off from knowledge of things' essence in itself and confines us to a world of mere appearances. We cannot know things as they may be in themselves even *a posteriori*, much less *a priori*. Metaphysics is consequently impossible, and the critique of pure reason takes its place. Kant's victory over the old dogmatism is complete. Every later dogmatic attempt has therefore had to take paths different from the earlier ones. In line with this critique's stated purpose, I shall now lead to the justification of my own.

Careful examination of that argument shows that its very first basic assumption is a *petitio principii* (begging of the question). It is the claim, especially clearly stated in *Prolegomena*, §1, that “The source of metaphysics must absolutely not be empirical; its principles and fundamental concepts must never be taken from experience, whether inward or outward.” No ground for this cardinal claim is given except an etymological argument from the word *metaphysics*. But this is how matters actually stand. The world and our own existence necessarily present themselves as a riddle. Without further argument, Kant assumes that its solution cannot emerge from a thorough understanding of the world itself, but must be sought in something wholly different from the world—for that is what “beyond all possible experience” means. He excludes from the solution anything of which we can have *immediate* knowledge, meaning possible inner or outer experience. He insists that it be sought only in

what we can reach indirectly, by inference from general *a priori* propositions. After excluding the chief source of all knowledge and closing the direct path to truth, we need not wonder that dogmatic attempts failed and Kant could prove they had to fail. Metaphysics and *a priori* knowledge had been assumed identical from the outset. But it first needed to be proved that the material for solving the riddle of the world could not possibly lie in the world itself, and could be sought only outside it in something accessible solely by following the forms known to us *a priori*.

Until that is proved, we have no reason to close off the richest sources of knowledge, inner and outer experience, for the most important and difficult of all tasks and work only with forms empty of content. I say, then, that solving the world's riddle must arise from understanding the world itself. The task of metaphysics is not to fly beyond the experience in which the world stands, but to understand it from the ground up, for inner and outer experience are indeed the principal source of all knowledge. The riddle can be solved only by connecting outward with inward experience at the proper point and in the proper way, joining two very different sources of cognition. Even then it is possible only within limits inseparable from our finite nature. We may arrive at a correct understanding of the world itself without a final account of its existence that removes every further problem. Thus *est quaedam prodire tenus* ("one may advance to a certain point"): my path lies between the claim to omniscience of earlier dogmatism and the despair of Kant's critique. Yet the important truths Kant discovered and used to overthrow earlier metaphysical systems furnished my own with data and material. Compare what I said of my method in chapter 17 of the second volume. So much for Kant's basic thought; now let us look at its execution and details.

Kant's style throughout bears the stamp of a superior mind, genuine and firm originality, and quite extraordinary power of thought. Perhaps its character can best be called *brilliant dryness*. Through it he grasps concepts firmly, singles them out with great assurance, and tosses them back and forth with the greatest freedom, to the reader's amazement. I find the same brilliant dryness in Aristotle's style, though his is much simpler. Nevertheless Kant's exposition is often unclear, indefinite, inadequate, and sometimes obscure. Part of this obscurity is excused by the subject's difficulty and the depth of his thoughts. But a person who is himself wholly clear and knows exactly what he thinks and intends will never write obscurely or set up wavering, indefinite concepts. He will not collect elaborate, difficult foreign expressions to name them and use

those continuously afterward, as Kant borrowed words and formulas from earlier, even scholastic, philosophy and combined them for his purposes. An example is “transcendental synthetic unity of apperception”; in general he writes “unity of synthesis” when “combination” would suffice. Such a writer will not keep explaining afresh what he has explained already, as Kant does with the understanding, the categories, experience, and other chief concepts. Nor will he repeat himself endlessly while leaving the same obscure spots in each new presentation of a thought given a hundred times. He will state his view clearly, thoroughly, and fully once, and let it stand. As Descartes says in his fifth letter, *Quo enim melius rem aliquam concipimus, eo magis determinati sumus ad eam unico modo exprimendam* (“The better we conceive something, the more determined we are to express it in one way”). The greatest harm of Kant's occasionally obscure exposition was that it served as an *exemplar vitiis imitabile* (a model imitable in its faults), indeed was misread as dangerous authorization. The public had been forced to see that obscurity is not always nonsense; nonsense immediately hid behind obscurity. *Fichte* first seized and exploited this new privilege. *Schelling* at least matched him, and an army of hungry scribblers without spirit or honesty soon outdid both. The greatest effrontery in serving up sheer nonsense and cobbling together empty, deranged tangles of words, previously heard only in madhouses, finally appeared in *Hegel*. It became the instrument of the crudest mass mystification ever, with a success that posterity will find fabulous and remember as a monument of German foolishness. Meanwhile *Jean Paul* wrote in vain his fine section “Higher Appreciation of Philosophical Madness at the Lectern and Poetic Madness on the Stage” (*Aesthetic After-School*). Earlier still, *Goethe* had said, also in vain:

“Thus people chatter and teach undisturbed;
Who wants to bother with fools?
Usually, when someone hears only words,
He thinks there must be some thought behind them.”

But let us return to *Kant*. One cannot deny that he wholly lacks the grand simplicity of antiquity, its naïveté, *ingénuité*, and *candeur* (guileless candor). His philosophy is unlike Greek architecture, which offers large, simple relations immediately visible at a glance. Rather, it strongly recalls Gothic architecture. A peculiar feature of Kant's mind is his strange delight in *symmetry*. He loves colorful multiplicity so that he can order it and repeat the order in subordinate divisions, again and again, just as in Gothic churches. Sometimes he carries this

to the point of play, doing clear violence to truth for the sake of that inclination. He treats truth like old-fashioned formal gardeners treated nature, making symmetrical avenues, squares and triangles, trees cut into pyramids and spheres, and hedges twisted into regular curves. I shall document this with facts.

After treating space and time separately, he dispatches the whole intuitive world that fills them, in which we live and exist, with the empty words “the empirical content of intuition is *given* to us.” With *one* leap he then reaches the *logical foundation of his whole philosophy: the table of judgments*. From it he deduces exactly twelve categories arranged symmetrically under four headings. They later become a dreadful Procrustean bed into which he forces everything in the world and everything occurring within us. He shuns no violence or sophistry to repeat the table's symmetry everywhere. The first thing derived symmetrically from it is the pure physiological table of general principles of natural science: axioms of intuition, anticipations of perception, analogies of experience, and postulates of empirical thought in general. The first two principles are simple; each of the latter two symmetrically sends out three offshoots. The bare categories are what he calls *concepts*; these principles of natural science are *judgments*. Following his highest guide to wisdom, symmetry, it is now the turn of *inferences* to prove fruitful, once more symmetrically and in step. The application of categories to sensibility gave rise to experience, with its *a priori* principles, for the *understanding*. In the same way the application of *inferences* to categories, carried out by *reason* according to its supposed principle of seeking the unconditioned, gives rise to the *Ideas* of reason. The three categories of relation yield the only three possible kinds of major premises for inferences; these consequently fall into three types. Each is like an egg from which reason hatches an Idea: from the categorical type, the Idea of the *soul*; from the hypothetical, the Idea of the *world*; and from the disjunctive, the Idea of *God*. In the middle Idea, that of the world, the category table's symmetry is repeated again: its four headings produce four theses, each paired symmetrically with an antithesis.

We admire the genuinely acute combinations that produced this elegant structure, though we shall later examine it thoroughly in its foundations and parts. First, however, some observations are needed.

It is astonishing how Kant proceeds without pausing to reflect, following his symmetry and ordering everything by it, without ever considering any object so treated on its own terms. Let me explain. He considers intuitive cognition only in mathematics, neglects completely the rest of intuitive cognition, where the

world lies before us, and holds only to abstract thought. Yet abstract thought derives all its meaning and worth from the intuitive world, which is infinitely more significant, general, and rich in content than the abstract part of our cognition. Indeed, he nowhere clearly distinguishes intuitive from abstract cognition. This is a central point and, as we shall see, involved him in irreconcilable self-contradictions. After dispatching the whole sensory world with the empty “it is given,” he makes the logical table of judgments his foundation. But again he never pauses to reflect on what lies before him. The forms of judgments are *words* and *combinations of words*. He should first have asked what they signify immediately, and would have found that they signify *concepts*. Next he should have asked what *concepts* are. The answer would have revealed their relation to intuitive representations in which the world exists, and intuition would have been distinguished from reflection. He would then have had to ask not only how pure, merely formal *a priori* intuition, but also how its content, empirical intuition, comes to consciousness. He would have seen what part the *understanding* plays in this, and so what the understanding generally is and what *reason*, which he proposes to critique, really is.

It is striking that he never defines reason properly and adequately even once. He only gives incomplete and incorrect explanations in passing as each context requires, contrary to the rule of Descartes cited above.^[3] For example, in the *Critique of Pure Reason*, p. 11; fifth edition p. 24, reason is the faculty of *a priori principles*. At p. 299; fifth edition p. 356, it is again the faculty of *principles*, contrasted with the understanding as the faculty of *rules*. One would expect a vast difference between principles and rules if each warrants its own faculty of cognition. Yet the distinction is merely this: what is known *a priori* from pure intuition or through the forms of the understanding is a *rule*, while only what comes *a priori* from mere concepts is a principle. I shall return to this arbitrary, untenable distinction in discussing the Dialectic. At p. 330; fifth edition p. 386, reason is the faculty of inference, while he often says judging alone belongs to the understanding (p. 69; fifth edition p. 94). This amounts to saying that judging is the understanding's business when a judgment's ground is empirical, transcendental, or metalogical (see my essay on the principle of sufficient reason, §§31–33), but when the ground is logical, as in an inference, a wholly separate and much superior faculty, reason, acts. Worse, at p. 303; fifth edition p. 360, Kant says immediate consequences of a proposition belong to the understanding and only those requiring an intervening concept to reason.

Thus from “All humans are mortal,” “Some mortals are humans” follows through the understanding alone, but “All scholars are mortal” requires a quite different, much superior faculty, reason. How could a great thinker advance such a claim? At p. 553; fifth edition p. 581, reason suddenly becomes the abiding condition of all voluntary actions. At p. 614; fifth edition p. 642, it consists in our capacity to give an account of our assertions. At pp. 643–644; fifth edition pp. 671–672, it combines the concepts of the understanding into Ideas as the understanding combines the manifold of objects into concepts. At p. 646; fifth edition p. 674, it is simply the faculty of deriving the particular from the general.

The *understanding* is likewise redefined repeatedly. At seven places in the *Critique of Pure Reason*: p. 51; fifth edition p. 75, it is the faculty of producing representations itself. At p. 69; fifth edition p. 94, it is the faculty of judging, that is, thinking or cognizing through concepts. At p. 137 of the fifth edition it is, in general, the faculty of cognitions. At p. 132; fifth edition p. 171, it is the faculty of rules. At p. 158; fifth edition p. 197, Kant says that “it is not only the faculty of rules but the source of principles according to which everything stands under rules,” although he had contrasted it with reason because only the latter was the faculty of principles. At p. 160; fifth edition p. 199, the understanding is the faculty of concepts; at p. 302; fifth edition p. 359, the faculty of unifying appearances by means of rules.

I need not defend my fixed, sharp, definite, simple definitions of these two faculties, always agreeing with how people of every nation and age use the words, against such confused and groundless remarks, though they come from Kant. I have cited them only to support my charge that Kant followed his symmetrical logical system without thinking adequately about the subject he treated.

Had Kant seriously asked how two different faculties of cognition, one distinguishing human beings from other animals, disclose themselves, and what every nation's and philosopher's usage means by reason and understanding, he would never have divided reason into theoretical and practical without better authority than the scholastics' *intellectus theoreticus* and *practicus*, used in quite another sense, or made practical reason the source of virtuous action. Likewise, before carefully separating concepts of the understanding, by which he means partly his categories and partly all general concepts, from concepts of reason, his so-called Ideas, and making both the material of a philosophy largely about their validity, use, and origin, he should first have investigated

what a *concept* is in general. That indispensable inquiry was unfortunately omitted, greatly contributing to the disastrous confusion of intuitive and abstract cognition I shall soon show. The same lack of reflection that led him to pass over “What is intuition? What is reflection? What is a concept? What is reason? What is understanding?” also led him to pass over equally necessary questions: What do I mean by an *object* distinguished from a *representation*? What are existence, object, subject, truth, appearance, and error? He proceeds without stopping or looking around, following his logical scheme and symmetry. The table of judgments is supposed to be the key to all wisdom.

I identified Kant's chief merit above as distinguishing appearance from thing in itself, declaring the whole visible world appearance, and denying that its laws hold beyond appearance. Oddly, he did not derive appearance's merely relative existence from the simple, obvious, undeniable truth “*No object without a subject.*” At the root he could have shown that an object exists only in relation to a subject and is therefore dependent on and conditioned by it: mere appearance, not something existing in itself and unconditionally. Berkeley had already made that important proposition the foundation of his philosophy and thereby won an immortal name, though he himself drew neither the proper consequences nor sufficient understanding or attention. Kant is unfair to his merit. In my first edition I explained Kant's avoidance of Berkeley's proposition as an evident fear of decisive idealism, though I found idealism plainly expressed in many passages of the *Critique of Pure Reason*. I therefore accused Kant of contradicting himself. The charge was justified so long as one knew, as I then did, only its second and five subsequent editions. Later I read Kant's great work in its now rare first edition and, to my delight, found that all these contradictions disappeared. Though Kant does not use “no object without a subject,” he declares as decisively as Berkeley and I that the external world in space and time is merely the representation of a cognizing subject. On p. 383, for example, he says plainly: “If I take away the thinking subject, the entire corporeal world must fall away, being nothing but appearance in our subject's sensibility and a kind of its representations.”

But Kant removed the entire passage on pp. 348–392, where he had so beautifully and clearly expounded his resolute idealism, from the second edition, replacing it with many statements opposed to it. The text of the *Critique of Pure Reason* circulating from 1787 to 1838 was thus mutilated and corrupted, a self-contradictory book whose meaning no one could fully grasp. I gave the details and my conjectures about the reasons and weaknesses that

could have moved Kant to disfigure his immortal work in a letter to Professor Rosenkranz. He included the principal part in his preface to volume two of his edition of Kant's complete works, to which I refer readers. Following my representations, Rosenkranz restored the *Critique of Pure Reason* to its original form in 1838 by printing the *first* edition of 1781 in that volume. He thus earned an invaluable merit in philosophy, perhaps rescuing the most important work of German literature from oblivion; it must never be forgotten. No one should imagine that he knows the *Critique of Pure Reason* or has a clear conception of Kant's teaching if he has read only the second or a later edition. That is impossible: he has read only a mutilated, corrupted, in a sense inauthentic text. It is my duty to say so decisively as a warning to everyone.

But Kant's way of introducing the *thing in itself* undeniably contradicts the resolutely idealist fundamental view so clearly stated in the first edition of the *Critique of Pure Reason*. This was doubtless the main reason he removed the major idealist passage from the second edition and declared himself outright against Berkeley's idealism. He thereby introduced inconsistencies without remedying the work's chief defect: his manner of introducing the *thing in itself*. G. E. Schulze explained its invalidity at length in *Aenesidemus*, and it was soon recognized as the untenable point in Kant's system. The issue is easily clarified. Though he conceals it in various ways, Kant bases the assumption of the thing in itself on an inference under the causal law: empirical intuition, or more properly the *sensation* in our sense organs from which intuition begins, must have an external cause. Yet by his own correct discovery the law of causality is known to us *a priori*, a function of our intellect and therefore *subjective* in origin. The sensory sensation to which we apply it is itself undeniably *subjective*. Even the space into which we place the sensation's cause as an object through this application is an *a priori*, and therefore *subjective*, form of our intellect. The entire empirical intuition thus remains on *subjective* ground throughout, a mere process within us. Nothing wholly different from and independent of it can be brought in as a *thing in itself* or shown to be a necessary presupposition. Empirical intuition is and remains our mere representation: the world as representation. We can reach its essence in itself only by the wholly different path I have taken, bringing in self-consciousness, which discloses the will as the in-itself of our own appearance. The thing in itself then differs *toto genere* (in kind altogether) from representation and its elements, as I have explained.

This serious defect in Kant's system, demonstrated early on, illustrates the fine Indian proverb "No lotus without a stalk." The faulty derivation of the thing in itself is the stalk. But only the manner of derivation is faulty, not the recognition that the given appearance has a thing in itself. *Fichte* misunderstood the criticism as denying the latter, possible only because he was concerned not with truth but with attracting attention for personal ends. Bold and thoughtless enough to deny the thing in itself altogether, he constructed a system supposedly deriving *a priori* from the subject not merely the formal element of representation, as Kant did, but also its material, its entire content. He rightly counted on the public's poor judgment and foolishness. It accepted bad sophisms, mere hocus-pocus, and nonsensical chatter as proofs, enabling him to turn its attention from Kant to himself and set German philosophy on the path Schelling continued and that ended in Hegel's absurd sham wisdom.

I return now to the great Kantian fault mentioned above: he did not properly distinguish intuitive from abstract cognition. This produced a disastrous confusion that we must examine more closely. Had he sharply separated intuitive representations from concepts thought only *in abstracto*, he would have kept the two distinct and always known which he was dealing with. Sadly he did not, though the charge has not yet been made and may come as a surprise. His constantly mentioned "object of experience," the proper object of the categories, is neither intuitive representation nor abstract concept. It differs from both while somehow being both, and is an absolute absurdity. Incredible as it seems, he lacked either the thoughtfulness or the willingness to make clear to himself and others whether his "object of experience," meaning the cognition produced by applying the categories, was an intuitive representation in space and time, my first class of representations, or merely an abstract concept. Strange though it is, some intermediate thing constantly floats before his mind. This brings about the unfortunate confusion I must now expose, for which I need to survey the Doctrine of Elements as a whole.

The *Transcendental Aesthetic* is such an extraordinarily meritorious work that it alone could immortalize Kant's name. Its proofs are so convincing that I count its propositions among unshakable truths. They are doubtless among the most consequential, and thus are one of the rarest things in the world: a real, great discovery in metaphysics. His rigorously established fact that we are conscious of some knowledge *a priori* permits no other explanation than that it comprises forms of our intellect. This is less an explanation than simply a clear statement of the fact. *A priori* means only "not acquired through experience,

therefore not brought into us from outside.” What is present in the intellect without coming from outside belongs originally to it: it is its own nature. If what is thus within it determines the general way all objects must appear to it, we have said that these are the forms of its cognition, the fixed way it carries out its function. “*A priori* knowledge” and “forms inherent in the intellect” are thus essentially two expressions of the same matter, virtually synonyms.

I know of nothing I would remove from the Transcendental Aesthetic, then, though I would add something. In particular, Kant did not carry his thought to its end by discarding the whole Euclidean method of demonstration after saying at p. 87; fifth edition p. 120, that all geometrical knowledge has immediate evidence from intuition. Remarkably, even his sharpest opponent, G. E. Schulze (*Critique of Theoretical Philosophy*, II, p. 241), concluded that Kant's doctrine would call for a treatment of geometry quite unlike the usual one. He thought this an indirect proof against Kant, while in fact he was unwittingly making war on the Euclidean method. I refer readers to §15 of the first book of the present work.

After the Transcendental Aesthetic's detailed account of the general *forms* of intuition, one expects some explanation of its *content*: how *empirical* intuition enters our consciousness and how we come to know this world so real and important to us. Kant's whole teaching offers nothing more than the repeated, empty phrase “The empirical element of intuition is *given* from outside.” He therefore leaps straight from the *pure forms of intuition* to *thinking*, to Transcendental Logic. At its very beginning (*Critique of Pure Reason*, p. 50; fifth edition p. 74), where he cannot avoid touching the material content of empirical intuition, he takes his first false step, the *πρῶτον ψεῦδος* (first falsehood). “Our cognition,” he says, “has two sources: receptivity to impressions and spontaneity of concepts. The first is the capacity to receive representations; the second is that of knowing an object through these representations. Through the first an *object* is given to us; through the second it is thought.” This is false. On that account the *impression*, for which alone we are merely receptive, which comes from outside and alone is properly “*given*,” would already be a *representation*, even an *object*. But it is nothing more than a mere sensation in the sense organ. Only by applying the *understanding*, that is, the law of causality, and the intuitive forms of space and time does our *intellect* turn this mere *sensation* into a *representation*. It then stands as an *object* in space and time. The representation and object can be distinguished only if one

asks about the thing in itself; otherwise they are identical. I explained this process fully in my essay on the principle of sufficient reason, §21.

The understanding and intuitive cognition have completed their work at this point; they require neither concepts nor thought. Animals too therefore have such representations. If concepts and thought are added, a spontaneity may indeed be ascribed to them, but *intuitive* cognition has been left behind entirely. An entirely different class of representations enters consciousness: non-intuitive, abstract concepts. This is the activity of *reason*, which nevertheless draws the whole content of its thought solely from the earlier intuition and its comparison with other intuitions and concepts. Kant instead brings thought into intuition and lays the groundwork for the disastrous blending of intuitive and abstract cognition that I am criticizing. He makes intuition in itself without understanding, purely sensory and wholly passive, and has an object apprehended only through thinking, a category of understanding. Thus he brings *thinking into intuition*. Yet the object of *thought* is in turn an individual real object. Thought loses its essential generality and abstraction and receives individual things rather than general concepts as its objects; thus he brings *intuition into thinking*. From this springs the confusion described, and the consequences of this first false step run through his whole theory of cognition. Throughout, intuitive and abstract representations are fused into something midway between them, which he presents as the object known through the understanding and its categories, calling this cognition *experience*. It is difficult to believe Kant had anything fully definite or clear in mind as this object of understanding. I shall prove it through the immense contradiction running through Transcendental Logic, the true source of its obscurity.

In the *Critique of Pure Reason*, pp. 67–69; fifth edition pp. 92–94; pp. 89–90; fifth edition pp. 122–123; and again in the fifth edition at pp. 135, 139, and 153, Kant repeatedly insists that the understanding is not a faculty of intuition. Its cognition is not intuitive but discursive. The understanding is the faculty of judging (p. 69; fifth edition p. 94), and a judgment is mediated cognition, a representation of a representation (p. 68; fifth edition p. 93). It is the faculty of thinking, and thinking is cognition through concepts (p. 69; fifth edition p. 94). The categories of the understanding are in no way the conditions under which objects are given in intuition (p. 89; fifth edition p. 122), and intuition has no need of the functions of thought (p. 91; fifth edition p. 123). Our understanding can only think, not intuit (fifth edition pp. 135, 139). Likewise the *Prolegomena*, §20, assigns intuition, perception, *perceptio*, to the

senses alone and judging to the understanding alone; §22 says that the senses' task is to intuit and the understanding's to think, that is, judge. Finally, in the *Critique of Practical Reason*, fourth edition p. 247; Rosenkranz edition p. 281, the understanding is discursive: its representations are thoughts, not intuitions. These are all Kant's own words.

It follows from these statements that the intuitive world would exist for us even without an understanding, entering our heads in an utterly inexplicable way. Kant often marks this with the peculiar phrase that intuition is *given*, without ever explaining that vague metaphor further.

But his entire remaining account of the understanding, its categories, and the possibility of experience in Transcendental Logic flagrantly contradicts those statements. In the *Critique of Pure Reason*, p. 79; fifth edition p. 105, the understanding brings unity into the manifold of *intuition* through its categories, and pure concepts of the understanding relate *a priori* to objects of *intuition*. At p. 94; fifth edition p. 126, categories are conditions of experience, whether of the *intuition* or of the thought found within it. At fifth edition p. 127, the understanding creates experience; at p. 128, categories determine the *intuition* of objects. At p. 130, everything we represent as connected in the object, surely something intuitive rather than an abstraction, is first connected by an act of understanding. At p. 135, the understanding is newly defined as the faculty of combining *a priori* and bringing the manifold of given representations under the unity of apperception. But in all ordinary usage, apperception is not thinking a concept; it is *intuition*. At p. 136 we even find a supreme principle for the possibility of all intuition in relation to the understanding. At p. 143 a heading says all sensory intuition is conditioned by the categories. There the *logical function of judgments* also brings the manifold of given *intuitions* under apperception in general, and the manifold of a given intuition necessarily falls under the categories. At p. 144, the understanding brings unity into *intuition* by the categories. At p. 145, the understanding's thinking is oddly explained as synthesizing, combining, and ordering the manifold of *intuition*. At p. 161, experience is possible only through the categories and consists in connecting *perceptions*, which surely are intuitions. At p. 159, the categories are *a priori* cognitions of objects of *intuition* in general.

Here and at fifth edition pp. 163 and 165, Kant also presents a major doctrine: *the understanding first makes nature possible*, prescribing *a priori* laws for it, so that it conforms to the understanding's lawfulness. But nature is surely something intuited, not an abstraction; the understanding must therefore

be a faculty of intuition. At p. 168, concepts of the understanding are called the principles of the possibility of experience, which is the determination of appearances in space and time generally; appearances surely exist in intuition. Finally, at pp. 189–211; fifth edition pp. 232–265, comes the long proof, whose error I explained fully in my essay on the principle of sufficient reason, §23, that objective succession and coexistence of objects of experience are not sensibly perceived but brought into nature solely by the understanding, which first makes nature possible. Yet nature, the succession of events, and the coexistence of states are surely all intuitive, not merely abstractly thought.

I challenge anyone who shares my reverence for Kant to reconcile these contradictions and show that he thought anything definite and clear when he spoke of the object of experience and its determination by the understanding and its twelve functions. I am convinced the contradiction running through the whole Transcendental Logic is the real reason for its great obscurity. Kant dimly knew of it and struggled inwardly with it, yet would not or could not bring it to clear awareness. He thus veiled it from himself and others and evaded it by all sorts of indirect paths. Perhaps that is why he made the faculty of cognition into such a strange, complicated machine with so many wheels: twelve categories; transcendental synthesis by imagination, by inner sense, and by the transcendental unity of apperception; the schematism of pure concepts of the understanding; and so on. For all this apparatus, no attempt is even made to explain intuition of the outer world, surely the principal thing in our knowledge. The demand is repeatedly put off with the same poor, empty metaphor: “Empirical intuition is given to us.” On p. 145 of the fifth edition we learn further that it is given *by the object*, which must therefore differ from intuition.

If we try to discover Kant's inmost thought, which he did not state clearly himself, we find that such an object, distinct from *intuition* but by no means a *concept*, really is for him the proper object of the understanding. The strange assumption of this unrepresentable object is supposed first to turn intuition into experience. I think its ultimate source is an old, ingrained prejudice in Kant, beyond the reach of inquiry: the assumption of an *absolute object*, an object in itself, even without a subject. It is not the *intuited object*. Through a concept it is added in thought to intuition as something corresponding to it. Only now is intuition experience, acquiring worth and truth through reference to a concept, exactly opposite to my account, on which a concept gains worth and truth only from intuition. Adding this directly unrepresentable object to intuition is then the categories' proper function. “Only through intuition is the object given,

which is subsequently thought according to the category” (*Critique of Pure Reason*, first edition, p. 399). A passage in the fifth edition, p. 125, makes this especially clear: “Now the question is whether *a priori* concepts also precede, as conditions under which alone something may be *thought* as an *object* in general, though *not intuited*.” He answers yes. Here the source of the error and of the confusion enveloping it is plain.

An *object* as such exists only for and in *intuition*, whether through the senses or, in its absence, imagination. What is thought is always a general, non-intuitive *concept*, perhaps the concept of an object in general. Thought relates to *objects* only indirectly, through concepts; objects themselves always are and remain *intuitive*. Thought does not serve to confer reality on intuitions; they have whatever empirical reality they can have of themselves. It serves to gather their common features and results so we can preserve and handle them more easily. Kant instead assigns objects themselves to *thought*, making experience and the objective world dependent on the *understanding* while refusing to make it a faculty of *intuition*. In this respect he does distinguish intuiting from thinking, yet makes individual things partly objects of intuition and partly of thought. In fact they are only the former. Our empirical intuition is already *objective* because it begins from causal connection. Its immediate objects are things, not representations distinct from them. Individual things as such are intuited through the senses and understanding; imagination immediately supplements the *one-sided* impression on the senses. Once we pass to *thinking*, by contrast, we leave individual things and deal with general, non-intuitive concepts, though we may later apply the results to individual things. Holding to this distinction, we see that intuitive things do not first gain reality and become experience through thought applying twelve categories. Empirical reality, and thus experience, is already given in intuition itself. Yet intuition can occur only by applying cognition of causal connection, the understanding's sole function, to sensory sensation. Intuition is therefore genuinely intellectual, precisely what Kant denies.

The Kantian assumption criticized here is particularly clear not only in the cited passage but at the start of §36 of the *Critique of Judgment* and in the note to the first definition of “Phenomenology” in the *Metaphysical Foundations of Natural Science*. It is stated most plainly, with a naïveté Kant least dared at this delicate point, in the work of a Kantian, Kiesewetter's *Outline of General Logic*, third edition, part 1, p. 434 of the exposition, and part 2, §§52–53 of the exposition, as well as in Tiefttrunk's *Theory of Thought in Pure German*. The

unthinking students of a thinker become magnifying glasses for his faults. Kant treaded softly throughout his account of the category doctrine he had once decided on; his students speak boldly, exposing its falsity.

On this account, Kant's object of the categories is not the thing in itself, but is its nearest relative. It is the *object in itself*, an object needing no subject: an individual thing but not in space and time, since it is not intuitive; an object of thought but not an abstract concept. Kant thus really distinguishes three things: (1) representation; (2) the object of representation; and (3) the thing in itself. The first belongs to sensibility, which for him includes sensation and the pure intuitive forms of space and time. The second belongs to the understanding, which *adds it in thought* through twelve categories. The third lies beyond everything knowable. See pp. 108–109 of the first edition of the *Critique of Pure Reason* for evidence. Yet the distinction between a representation and its object is groundless. Berkeley had already proved this, and it follows from my whole account in the first book, especially chapter 1 of the supplements, and even from Kant's own fully idealist fundamental view in the first edition. If one did not count the object of representation as representation and identify them, one would have to place it with the thing in itself. Ultimately it depends on what one means by “object.” In any case, clear reflection finds only representation and thing in itself. The unwarranted insertion of this hybrid, the object of representation, is the source of Kant's errors. Remove it and his doctrine of categories as *a priori* concepts also falls. They are not supposed to contribute anything to intuition or apply to the thing in itself; through them we are supposed only to think those “objects of representations” and thereby turn representation into experience.

Every empirical intuition, however, already is experience. Every intuition beginning with sensory sensation is empirical. The understanding relates that sensation to its cause by its sole function, *a priori* cognition of the causal law. The cause thus appears in space and time, forms of pure intuition, as an object of experience, a material object persisting through time in space, yet even as such always remaining representation, just as space and time do. If we wish to go beyond this representation, we face the question of the thing in itself, the theme of my whole work and indeed of all metaphysics. Connected with Kant's error is the fault criticized earlier: he offers no theory of how empirical intuition arises. He simply takes it as *given*, identifying it with mere sensory sensation, to which he adds the intuitive forms of space and time, both included under sensibility. Yet those materials alone do not yield an objective representation.

That strictly requires relating sensation to its cause, applying the causal law, and therefore the understanding. Without this, sensation remains subjective and places no object in space, even if space is supplied. But for Kant the understanding must not be used in intuition; it was only supposed to *think*, so that he could remain within Transcendental Logic. This connects with another of his faults: he left to me the only valid proof of the correctly recognized *a priori* nature of the causal law, namely the proof from the very possibility of objective empirical intuition. Instead he gave a plainly false proof, as I showed in my essay on the principle of sufficient reason, §23.

It is clear that Kant's "object of representation" (2) is assembled from what he took partly from representation (1) and partly from the thing in itself (3). If experience truly arose only when our understanding applied twelve different functions and used as many *a priori* concepts to *think* objects previously merely intuited, each real thing would have many determinations. Given *a priori*, like space and time, they could not be thought away and would belong essentially to a thing's existence, yet could not be derived from the properties of space and time. Only one such determination exists: causality. Materiality rests on it, since matter's essence lies in acting and is causality through and through (see volume 2, chapter 4). Materiality alone distinguishes a real thing from an image of fantasy, which is still a representation. As persisting, matter gives a thing persistence through time in its material, while forms change according to causality. Everything else in a thing is either a determination of space or time or an empirical property, all ultimately referring to its efficacy and therefore to more specific determinations of causality. Causality already enters empirical intuition as a condition. Intuition is thus the understanding's work; it makes intuition possible and contributes nothing further to experience or its possibility beyond the causal law. Except for what I have specified, the old ontologies contain only relations among things or to our reflection, and a gathered *farrago* (jumble).

The very exposition of the category doctrine is a sign that it lacks foundation. What a contrast between the Transcendental *Aesthetic* and Transcendental *Analytic*! *There* we find clarity, definiteness, assurance, firm conviction openly expressed and communicated without fail. All is bright; no dark corners are left. Kant knows what he wants and knows he is right. *Here* all is dark, confused, indefinite, wavering, uncertain; the exposition is anxious, full of excuses and appeals to what will come later or has supposedly been held back. The entire second and third sections of the deduction of pure concepts of understanding

were changed completely in the second edition because Kant himself was dissatisfied. They differ wholly from the first but have not become clearer. One really sees him struggling against the truth to maintain a doctrine he had settled on. In the *Transcendental Aesthetic*, he actually proves all his propositions from undeniable facts of consciousness. In the *Transcendental Analytic*, examination reveals only assertions that this is and must be so. Here as everywhere the exposition bears the character of the thinking from which it came: style is the physiognomy of the mind.

It is also worth noting that almost whenever Kant wants to illustrate a claim he chooses the category of causality. His claim then turns out right, precisely because the causal law is the real and sole form of the understanding; the other eleven categories are blind windows. The deduction of the categories is simpler and more direct in the first edition than in the second. He tries to show how the understanding, thinking through categories after intuition is given by sensibility, produces experience. He repeats “recognition,” “reproduction,” “association,” “apprehension,” and “transcendental unity of apperception” to exhaustion without attaining clarity. Most strikingly, in this explanation he never once touches the point that must occur to everyone first: relating sensory sensation to its external cause. If he rejected that relation, he should have said so explicitly, but he does not. He slips around it, followed by all the Kantians. The hidden motive is that he reserves causal connection under the name “ground of appearance” for his false derivation of the thing in itself. Moreover, relating sensation to its cause would make intuition intellectual, which he cannot admit. He also seems to have feared that accepting a causal connection between sensation and object would turn the latter immediately into the thing in itself and introduce Locke's empiricism. But reflection removes this difficulty by reminding us that the causal law is subjective in origin, as sensation itself is, and that our own body insofar as it appears in space already belongs to representations. His fear of Berkeley's idealism prevented Kant from conceding it.

Kant repeatedly calls “combining the manifold of intuition” the understanding's essential operation through its twelve categories. Yet he never properly explains this or shows what the manifold of intuition is before the understanding combines it. Time and space, with its three dimensions, are *continua*: their parts are originally connected, not separate. They are the universal forms of our intuition. Everything appearing or given in them thus already appears as a continuum, its parts connected from the start and needing

no added combination of a manifold. Perhaps one interprets the supposed combination as relating the various sensory impressions of an object to one object: for example, intuiting a bell, I recognize that what affects my eyes as yellow, my hands as smooth and hard, and my ears as sounding is one body. But this follows from *a priori* knowledge of causal connection, the real and sole function of the understanding. The diverse effects on my sense organs direct me to one common cause, the character of the body before me. Despite the variety and number of effects, my understanding apprehends the unity of the cause as one object that becomes intuitive through precisely that process.

In the fine summary of his teaching in the *Critique of Pure Reason*, pp. 719–726; fifth edition pp. 747–754, Kant explains the categories perhaps more clearly than anywhere: as “the mere rule for synthesizing what perception has given *a posteriori*.” He seems to have something in mind like angles giving a rule for putting lines together when constructing a triangle; that image best illustrates what he says of the categories' function. The preface to *Metaphysical Foundations of Natural Science* contains a long note likewise explaining the categories. They “differ in nothing from the formal acts of understanding in judging,” it says, except that in judgments subject and predicate may exchange places. It defines judgment as “an act through which given representations first become cognitions of an object.” Animals, being unable to judge, must then know no objects at all. For Kant generally, there are only concepts of *objects*, not intuitions. I say instead: objects exist first for intuition, and concepts are always abstractions from it. Abstract thought must therefore conform exactly to the world present in intuition, since reference to that world alone gives concepts content. We should assume no other *a priori* form for concepts than the faculty of reflection generally. Its nature is the formation of concepts, abstract, non-intuitive representations, the sole function of *reason*, as shown in the first book. I therefore demand that we throw eleven categories out the window and retain only causality, recognizing that its activity is already a condition of empirical intuition. Intuition is thus not merely sensory but intellectual. The object so intuited, the object of experience, is one with representation; only the thing in itself remains to be distinguished from it.

Repeated study of the *Critique of Pure Reason* at different ages has led me to a conviction about the origin of Transcendental Logic that I share because it greatly helps one understand it. The discovery based on objective apprehension and the highest human reflection is solely the insight that we know time and space *a priori*. Delighted by this fortunate find, Kant wanted to follow the vein

further, guided by his love of architectural symmetry. He had found pure *a priori* intuition underlying *empirical intuition* as its condition. He therefore supposed that certain *pure concepts* must likewise underlie *empirically acquired concepts* as presuppositions in our faculty of cognition, and that actual empirical thinking must first be made possible by pure *a priori* thinking. This pure thinking would have no objects of its own, but would take them from intuition. As the *Transcendental Aesthetic* demonstrated an *a priori* foundation for mathematics, there should be one for logic, so that a *Transcendental Logic* formed a symmetrical counterpart to the Aesthetic. From this point Kant was no longer unbiased, no longer simply inquiring into and observing what is in consciousness. A presupposition guided him and he pursued an aim: to find what he had presupposed so that an analogous, symmetrical Transcendental Logic could be built as a second story on the happily discovered Aesthetic. He turned to the table of judgments and constructed from it, as best he could, the *table of categories*, a doctrine of twelve pure *a priori* concepts. They were supposed to be conditions of our *thinking* the same *things* whose *intuition* is conditioned by the two *a priori* forms of sensibility. A *pure understanding* now corresponded symmetrically to *pure sensibility*.

Then another thought offered him a way of making the account more plausible through the *schematism* of pure concepts of the understanding. This most clearly betrays the course of his procedure, of which he himself was unaware. Seeking an *a priori* analogue for every empirical function of cognition, he noticed that our empirical intuiting and our empirical thinking in abstract, non-intuitive concepts are often, though not always, mediated. Occasionally we try to return from abstract thought to intuition, but only as a test: we want to assure ourselves that our abstract thought has not moved too far from intuition's firm ground, gone astray, or become empty words, rather as someone walking in the dark reaches now and then for the wall that guides him. Tentatively and momentarily, we return to intuition by summoning in imagination an intuition corresponding to the concept occupying us. It can never fully match the concept, but serves only as its temporary *representative*. I explained this in my essay *On the Principle of Sufficient Reason*, §28. Kant calls such a fleeting phantom, in contrast to a complete imaginative image, a *schema*, a kind of monogram of imagination. He then asserts an analogous intermediate *a priori schema of pure concepts of the understanding* between the faculty of *a priori* intuition of pure sensibility and the *a priori* thinking of pure understanding, the categories. He describes them one by one as monograms of

pure *a priori* imagination, assigning each to its category in the strange “chapter on the schematism of pure concepts of understanding.” Famous for its obscurity, it has never made anyone wiser. Seen from my standpoint, its darkness clears, but its deliberately contrived character and Kant's prior determination to find something serving analogy and architectural symmetry become even more conspicuous here than anywhere, almost to the point of comedy.

In assuming schemas of pure, *contentless a priori* concepts corresponding to the empirical schemas that represent actual concepts in imagination, he overlooks that the purpose of schemas is wholly absent here. In empirical, actual thinking, schemas serve only a concept's *material content*. Since empirical concepts were abstracted from intuition, we help and orient ourselves in abstract thought by glancing back at the intuition from which they came, assuring ourselves that the thought still has real content. This necessarily presupposes that the concepts arose from intuition. It is merely a look back at their material content, an aid to our weakness. But *a priori* concepts have no content yet and cannot admit of such a look back. They did not arise from intuition but approach it from within to receive content for the first time. I dwell on this because it illuminates the hidden course of Kant's philosophizing. After the fortunate discovery of the two *a priori* forms of intuition, he sought by analogy an *a priori* counterpart to every feature of our empirical cognition. With the schemas, he extended this even to a merely psychological fact. The apparent depth and difficulty of the exposition conceal from the reader that its content remains a wholly arbitrary and unproved assumption. Someone who finally penetrates its meaning is easily tempted to mistake this hard-won understanding for conviction that the doctrine is true.

Had Kant instead proceeded without prejudice, purely observing as he did in discovering *a priori* intuitions, he would have found that when pure intuition of space and time becomes empirical, two things are added: sensation on one side and cognition of causality on the other. The latter transforms mere sensation into objective empirical intuition. For just this reason it is not borrowed or learned from intuition but exists *a priori* as the form and function of pure understanding, its sole function, though so consequential that all our empirical knowledge rests on it. It is often said that refuting an error is complete only when one has shown how it arose psychologically. I believe I have done so here for Kant's doctrine of categories and their schemas.

Having introduced such grave errors into the first simple outlines of a theory of representation, Kant was led to many complicated assumptions. One is the synthetic unity of apperception, a very strange thing strangely presented: “The *I think* must be able to accompany all my representations.” Must—be able to: this is a problematic-apodictic proposition, one that takes with one hand what it gives with the other. What does this precariously balanced claim mean? That all representation is thinking? No. That would be disastrous: there would be nothing but abstract concepts, least of all a pure intuition free from reflection and will, like contemplation of beauty, the deepest apprehension of things' true essence, their Platonic Ideas. Animals too would then either have to think or lack representations entirely. Or does the claim mean “no object without subject”? If so, it says it very badly and comes too late. Taking Kant's statements together, his synthetic unity of apperception seems to be the extensionless center of the sphere of all our representations, toward which their radii converge. It is what I call the subject of cognition, the correlate of every representation. I also described and discussed it fully in chapter 22 of the second volume as the focal point toward which the rays of brain activity converge. I refer there to avoid repetition.

It follows from my critique above that I reject the whole doctrine of the categories and count it among the groundless assumptions with which Kant encumbered his theory of cognition. I showed contradictions in Transcendental Logic arising from the mixture of intuitive and abstract cognition and the lack of any clear, definite conception of understanding and reason. Kant's works offered only disconnected, inconsistent, meager, and incorrect remarks about those two faculties. I have given definite, clear accounts of them in the first book and its supplements, and more fully in *On the Principle of Sufficient Reason*, §§21, 26, and 34. They follow plainly from examining our cognition's nature and agree fully with the meanings of these faculties expressed, if not clearly formulated, in ordinary speech and writing across peoples and ages. Exposing the faults in Kant's account has largely defended my own against it. But the table of judgments underlying Kant's theory of thought, indeed his whole philosophy, is by and large correct in itself. I must therefore show how these general forms of judgment arise from our faculty of cognition and reconcile them with my account. In the discussion I shall always use “understanding” and “reason” in the sense of my own explanations, which I presume the reader knows.

An essential difference between Kant's method and mine is that he begins from mediated, reflective cognition and I from immediate, intuitive cognition. He resembles someone measuring a tower's height from its shadow, while I apply the measuring rod directly. Philosophy is for him a science *from* concepts; for me it is a science *in* concepts, drawn from intuitive cognition, the sole source of evidence, and fixed in general concepts. He skips over the whole varied, meaningful intuitive world surrounding us and holds to forms of abstract thought. An unstated premise underlies this: reflection is a copy of all intuition, so everything essential in intuition must be expressible in reflection, and in compressed forms and outlines easily surveyed. The essential laws of abstract cognition would then put into our hands all the strings moving the colorful puppet show of the intuitive world before our eyes. Had Kant at least stated this highest methodological principle clearly and followed it consistently, he would have had to keep intuitive and abstract cognition distinct, sparing us insoluble contradictions and confusion. But the way he carried out his task shows that the principle was only very dimly before his mind. Only after thorough study of his philosophy can one infer it.

The method and guiding maxim just described have much to recommend them and are a brilliant idea. The nature of every science is to bring the endless variety of intuitive appearances under comparatively few abstract concepts, arranging from them a system by which we gain full cognitive command of those appearances, explain what has happened, and predict what will happen. The sciences divide among themselves the broad domain of appearances according to their varied particular kinds. It was a bold and fortunate thought to isolate what is essential to concepts as such, apart from their content, and to learn from these forms of all thinking what must be essential to all intuitive cognition and thus to the world as appearance generally. Because the necessary forms of thinking would be found *a priori*, their origin would be subjective, serving Kant's purposes. Before going further, however, he needed to investigate how reflection relates to intuitive cognition, which presupposes that the two be carefully distinguished. How exactly does it reproduce and represent intuition? Does it do so faithfully, or does it alter and partly obscure intuition by taking it into its own forms? Is abstract, reflective cognition's form determined more by intuitive cognition's form or by the fixed character belonging to reflection itself? Very different things in intuitive cognition may become indistinguishable when brought into reflection; conversely, distinctions noticed

in reflective cognition may arise only there, without corresponding differences in intuition.

Such an inquiry would have shown that intuitive cognition changes on entering reflection almost as much as food changes on entering an animal body, whose own forms and mixtures determine the result and whose composition no longer reveals the food's original character. Or, since that says a little too much, it would at least have shown that reflection is not to intuition as an image in water is to the objects reflected. It is more nearly their shadow, reproducing only some outer contours while uniting very different things in one shape and presenting unlike things with the same outline. We could never confidently and completely reconstruct the forms of things from such a shadow.

All reflective cognition, or reason, has one chief form, the abstract concept. It belongs to reason itself and has no necessary direct relation to the intuitive world, which exists without it for animals and could be quite different while still fitting the same form of reflection. Combining concepts into judgments has certain fixed, lawful forms. Found through induction, these make up the table of judgments. Most can be derived from reflective cognition itself, directly from reason, particularly insofar as they arise through the four laws of thought, which I call metalogical truths, and the *dictum de omni et nullo* ("what is affirmed or denied of all is affirmed or denied of each"). Some forms are grounded instead in intuitive cognition, and thus in the understanding. Yet they do not indicate a corresponding plurality of forms of understanding: they all derive from its one function, immediate cognition of cause and effect. Others arise from the meeting and connection of reflective with intuitive cognition, more properly from taking the latter into the former. I shall examine the features of judgment one by one and trace each to these sources. It will follow that no deduction of categories from them remains possible, and that the categories are as groundless in assumption as their presentation is confused and self-contradictory.

1. Quantity. The so-called *quantity* of judgments springs from concepts as such. It is grounded solely in reason, without any direct connection to understanding or intuitive cognition. As explained in the first book, concepts essentially have an extension or sphere: a wider, less definite one contains a narrower, more definite one, which can be separated out. One may do so by marking it merely as some indefinite part of the wider concept, or by isolating it definitely and completely under a special name. In the first case the judgment is particular; in the second universal. The same part of the sphere of "tree," for example, can be isolated in either way: "Some trees bear gallnuts," or "All oaks

bear gallnuts.” The operations differ very little, and their very possibility depends on the language's richness. Yet Kant calls the difference two fundamentally distinct acts, functions, or categories of pure understanding, determining experience *a priori*.

Finally one may use a concept to reach a definite individual intuitive representation from which, along with many others, that concept was abstracted. This is done by a singular judgment, marking the boundary of abstract and intuitive cognition and leading directly to the latter: “This tree here bears gallnuts.” Kant made even that a separate category. After everything said above, no further argument is needed here.

2. Quality. The *quality* of judgments likewise lies wholly within reason and is no copy of, or clue to, a law of the understanding that makes intuition possible. As also explained in the first book, the nature of abstract concepts, the essence of reason itself grasped objectively, permits their spheres to be joined and separated. The general laws of identity and contradiction presuppose this possibility. I call their truth *metalogical* because they spring purely from reason and admit no further explanation. They require what has been joined to remain joined and what has been separated to remain separate: what is posited cannot simultaneously be cancelled. They therefore presuppose the possibility of joining and separating conceptual spheres, that is, of judging. In its *form*, this activity lies solely in reason. Unlike the *content* of judgments, the form is not brought across from intuitive cognition in the understanding. No correlate or analogue for it is to be sought there. Once intuition has arisen through and for the understanding, it stands complete, subject to neither doubt nor error and knowing neither affirmation nor negation. It presents itself directly, rather than depending, as abstract rational cognition does, for worth and content on reference to something outside itself according to the principle of sufficient reason of knowing. Intuition is therefore sheer reality; negation is foreign to it and can only be added by reflection, remaining within abstract thought.

Kant adds infinite judgments to affirmative and negative ones, borrowing a whim of the old scholastics. An ingenious gap-filler needing no discussion, it is one of the many blind windows he installed for the sake of symmetrical architecture.

3. Relation. Under the very broad heading of relation Kant brings together three quite different features of judgments. To find their origins we must consider each separately.

(a) Hypothetical judgment. In general, a *hypothetical judgment* abstractly expresses the most general form of all our knowledge, the principle of sufficient reason. I showed in my essay of 1813 on that principle that it has four quite different meanings, each arising from a different faculty of cognition and concerning a different class of representations. Thus hypothetical judgment as a general form of thought cannot originate solely, as Kant wishes, in the understanding and its category of causality. On my account, the causal law is the one form of cognition of pure understanding, and only one form of the principle of sufficient reason encompassing all pure or *a priori* cognition. Each meaning of the principle is expressed in hypothetical judgment. Here we see clearly how cognitions quite different in origin and significance can nonetheless appear, when reason thinks them *in abstracto*, in the same form of connection among concepts and judgments. In that form they can no longer be distinguished; we have to leave abstraction and return to intuition to distinguish them. Kant's method of trying to discover the elements and inner workings of intuitive cognition from the standpoint of abstract cognition was therefore entirely mistaken. In a sense my whole introductory essay *On the Principle of Sufficient Reason* thoroughly examines the meaning of hypothetical judgment, so I shall not dwell on it here.

(b) Categorical judgment. The form of the *categorical judgment* is simply the form of judgment in its strictest sense. Strictly, to judge means only to think the joining or incompatibility of conceptual spheres. Hypothetical and disjunctive connections are not, in fact, distinct forms of judgment. They apply only to judgments already made, within which concepts remain connected categorically; the new forms link judgments to one another, the hypothetical expressing dependence and the disjunctive incompatibility. Mere concepts have only *one* kind of relation to one another, expressed by categorical judgment. More exact determinations, or kinds, of that relation are the overlap and complete separation of conceptual spheres, affirmation and negation. Kant makes these separate categories under another heading, *quality*. Overlap and separation in turn differ according to whether spheres overlap wholly or partly, a distinction forming the *quantity* of judgments. Kant makes yet another separate category heading from this. He thus separated closely related, even identical matters—readily surveyed variations of the sole possible relations among mere concepts—while uniting quite different matters under the heading of relation.

Categorical judgments have the laws of thought of identity and contradiction as their metalogical principle. The *ground* for joining conceptual spheres, which gives the judgment consisting in that union its *truth*, may nevertheless be of very different kinds. Its truth may accordingly be logical, empirical, metaphysical, or metalogical, as explained in my introductory essay, §§30–33, without need of repetition here. Thus immediate cognitions of the most diverse sorts can all present themselves *in abstracto* as a connection of the spheres of two concepts, subject and predicate. No one function of understanding can be posited as producing and corresponding to all of them. For example, “The water boils,” “The sine measures the angle,” “The will decides,” “Occupation distracts,” and “The distinction is difficult” express very different relations in the same logical form. This again confirms the mistake of starting from abstract cognition to analyze immediate intuitive cognition.

A categorical judgment does arise from cognition of the understanding in my sense when it expresses causality. This applies even to judgments naming a physical quality. To say “This body is heavy, hard, liquid, green, acidic, alkaline, organic,” and so on always names its action or effect, a cognition possible only through pure understanding. Yet physical qualities and quite different matters, such as the subordination of very abstract concepts, are both expressed *in abstracto* by subject and predicate. People therefore transferred those merely conceptual relations back to intuitive cognition, thinking that subject and predicate in a judgment must have special intuitive correlates, substance and accident. I shall show below that “substance” has no true content other than “matter,” and that accidents are simply modes of action. Supposed cognition of substance and accident thus remains pure understanding's cognition of cause and effect. I discussed how the representation of matter arises in §4 of the first book and more accessibly at the end of §21, p. 77, of *On the Principle of Sufficient Reason*. We shall examine it further in discussing the principle of substance's persistence.

(c) Disjunctive judgment. *Disjunctive judgments* arise from the law of thought of the excluded middle, a metalogical truth. They thus belong wholly to pure reason and do not originate in understanding. Deriving the category of community or *reciprocal interaction* from them is a glaring example of the violence Kant sometimes does to truth merely to indulge architectural symmetry. G. E. Schulze in his *Critique of Theoretical Philosophy* and Berg in his *Epicritique of Philosophy*, among others, have rightly criticized this derivation and shown it invalid on several grounds. What real analogy is there

between leaving a concept's determination open among mutually exclusive predicates and thinking reciprocal interaction? The two are actually opposites. In a disjunctive judgment, positing one member of the division necessarily abolishes the other. In reciprocal interaction, positing one thing is supposedly a necessary positing of the other and conversely. The real logical analogue of reciprocal interaction is surely the *circulus vitiosus* (vicious circle), where what is grounded becomes the ground in turn, just as reciprocal interaction supposedly does. As logic rejects the vicious circle, metaphysics should ban reciprocal interaction. I intend seriously to show that no reciprocal interaction exists in the proper sense. However popular the term is because it is so vague, close inspection reveals it as empty, false, and void.

First recall what causality is in general, consulting my introductory essay, §20; my prize essay on freedom of the will, chapter 3, p. 27 ff. [2nd ed., p. 26 ff.]; and chapter 4 of our second volume. Causality is the law by which emerging *states* of matter determine their places in time. It concerns states, strictly *changes*, not matter as such or persistence without change. *Matter* itself does not stand under the causal law: it neither comes to be nor passes away. Neither does the whole *thing*, as people commonly say; only *states* of matter do. The causal law likewise has nothing to do with *persistence*: where nothing *changes*, there is no *acting* and no causality, only an enduring state at rest. When such a state changes, either the new state persists or it immediately produces a third state. The necessity with which this happens is the causal law, a form of the principle of sufficient reason. It cannot be explained further, for the principle of sufficient reason is the principle of every explanation and necessity. It is clear that cause and effect are necessarily and closely tied to *succession in time*. State A is a cause and state B an effect only insofar as A precedes B and their succession is necessary rather than accidental, not merely a following but a following-from.

Reciprocal interaction, however, means that each is both cause and effect of the other. That would make each both earlier and later: a contradiction. Nor can we assume both *states* exist at once and necessarily together. If they necessarily belong together and coexist, they make only *one* state whose persistence requires all its determinations to remain present. We are then speaking not of change and causality but only of duration and rest. If *one* determination of the whole state changes, the resulting new state may not endure; it causes changes in the other determinations of the first state, producing another, third state. All

this occurs under the simple causal law and establishes no new law of reciprocal interaction.

I also assert flatly that *reciprocal interaction* cannot be supported by a single example. Whatever is offered is either a state at rest, to which causality, meaningful only for changes, does not apply at all, or an alternating succession of states of the same kind conditioning one another, fully explained by simple causality. Balanced scales with equal weights provide the first sort. Nothing acts here because nothing changes. It is a state of rest. Weight strives, equally distributed as in every body supported at its center of gravity, but cannot display its force in an effect. Removing *one* weight gives a second state that immediately causes a third, the other pan's descent. This follows the simple law of cause and effect and needs neither a special category of understanding nor even a special name.

A continuing fire illustrates the second sort. Oxygen's combination with combustible matter causes heat, which in turn causes that chemical combination to occur anew. This is simply a chain of causes and effects whose links alternate between states bearing the *same names*: burning A produces free heat B; this produces new burning C, another effect of the same kind as cause A but not individually identical with it; C produces new heat D, identical with effect B only conceptually, by name, not in reality; and so on. Humboldt's account of deserts (*Views of Nature*, second edition, vol. 2, p. 79) gives an appealing example of what ordinary speech calls reciprocal interaction. Sandy deserts receive no rain, while the forested mountains bordering them do. The cause is not the mountains attracting clouds. A rising column of heated air from the sand prevents vapor droplets from condensing and drives clouds upward. Above the mountains the upward air current is weaker; clouds sink and precipitation occurs in cooler air. Lack of rain and lack of vegetation in the desert thus stand in so-called reciprocal interaction: no rain falls because the hot sandy surface radiates more heat, and the desert fails to become a steppe or grassy plain because rain does not fall. Plainly this is again a succession of causes and effects bearing the same names, not something essentially different from simple causality. The same holds of a pendulum's swing and even of an organism's self-preservation: each state produces a new one of the same kind as the state that produced it, though individually new. In the organism the matter is more complex. The chain has links of many kinds rather than two, and a link of the same kind returns only after several others have intervened. Yet we still see

only the one simple causal law giving order to a succession of states, nothing to be grasped by a new and special faculty of understanding.

Perhaps someone would cite the equality of action and reaction as an instance of reciprocal interaction. But that rests on what I have insisted on and explained in *On the Principle of Sufficient Reason*: cause and effect are not two bodies but two successive states of bodies. Each state includes all the bodies involved. The effect, the newly arising state after an impact, for example, extends to both bodies proportionately. The striking body changes as much as the struck body, each in proportion to its mass and speed. If one chooses to call this reciprocal interaction, then absolutely every effect is reciprocal interaction; no new concept or function of understanding is introduced, only a redundant synonym for causality. Kant himself carelessly says just this in *Metaphysical Foundations of Natural Science*, where the proof of the fourth proposition of mechanics begins: “All external action in the world is reciprocal interaction.” How, then, can simple causality and reciprocal interaction have separate *a priori* functions in the understanding? How can real succession be possible and knowable only by one and coexistence only by the other? If every action is reciprocal interaction, succession and simultaneity would be the same, and everything in the world simultaneous. Were there genuine reciprocal interaction, a *perpetuum mobile* (perpetual motion machine) would be possible, even *a priori* certain. The claim that it is impossible rests instead on the *a priori* conviction that no genuine reciprocal interaction or form of understanding for it exists.

Aristotle too denies reciprocal interaction in the strict sense. He observes that two things can be causes of one another only if “cause” has a different meaning for each: one may act on the other as an aim, the other on the first as a cause of motion. In both *Physics*, II, chapter 3, and *Metaphysics*, V, chapter 2, he says: “Ἔστι δέ τινα καὶ ἀλλήλων αἰτία· οἷον τὸ πονεῖν αἴτιον τῆς εὐεξίας, καὶ αὕτη τοῦ πονεῖν· ἀλλ’ οὐ τὸν αὐτὸν τρόπον, ἀλλὰ τὸ μὲν ὡς τέλος, τὸ δὲ ὡς ἀρχὴ κινήσεως. (*Sunt praeterea quae sibi sunt mutuo causae, ut exercitium bonae habitudinis, et haec exercitii: at non eodem modo, sed haec ut finis, illud ut principium motus.* “Some things are mutually causes, as exercise causes good condition and good condition causes exercise, but not in the same way: one as an end, the other as a source of motion.”) Had he accepted reciprocal interaction proper, he would have listed it there, since he is enumerating all possible kinds of causes in both places. In *Posterior Analytics*, II, chapter 11, he speaks of a cycle of causes and effects but not reciprocal interaction.

4. Modality. The categories of *modality* have one advantage over all the others: what each expresses really does correspond to the form of judgment from which it is derived. That is scarcely so for the other categories, mostly extracted from judgment forms by the most arbitrary force. It is perfectly true that the concepts possible, actual, and necessary occasion the problematic, assertoric, and apodictic forms of judgment. It is not true that they are special, original forms of understanding's cognition that admit no further derivation. Rather, they spring from the one original form of all cognition known to us *a priori*, the principle of sufficient reason. Knowledge of *necessity* comes directly from it; chance, possibility, impossibility, and actuality arise only when reflection is applied to necessity. None springs from a single mental faculty, the understanding. They arise instead from the encounter of abstract and intuitive cognition, as will now become clear.

I maintain that to be necessary and to follow from a given ground are convertible concepts, wholly identical. We can know, indeed think, something as necessary only insofar as we regard it as following from a given ground. Necessity contains absolutely nothing beyond dependence, being posited by another, and inevitably following from it. The concept thus arises and exists solely through application of the principle of sufficient reason. According to that principle's different forms, there is physical necessity, an effect following a cause; logical necessity, through a ground of knowing in analytic judgments and inferences; mathematical necessity, through the ground of being in space and time; and practical necessity. By the last I do not mean determination by a supposed categorical imperative, but an act necessarily occurring from the empirical character when motives are presented. Everything necessary is so only relatively, on the presupposition of the ground from which it follows; *absolute necessity* is therefore a contradiction. For more, see §49 of my essay on the principle of sufficient reason.

The contradictory opposite of necessity, its negation, is *contingency*. This concept has negative content: nothing more than the absence of the connection expressed by the principle of sufficient reason. The contingent is therefore always relative, contingent in relation to something that is *not* its ground. Every object, of whatever kind, and every event in the actual world, is at once necessary and contingent: *necessary* in relation to its cause and *contingent* in relation to everything else. Its contact in time and space with everything else is merely a meeting without a necessary connection; hence the words *chance*, σύμπτωμα, and *contingens* (what happens to come together). An absolutely

contingent thing is no more conceivable than an absolutely necessary one. It would be an object bearing no relation of consequence to ground with any other object. That it cannot be represented is precisely the negative content of the principle of sufficient reason. One would have to abolish that principle to think an absolutely contingent thing; then “contingent” itself would lose all meaning, since it has meaning only in relation to the principle: it says two objects are not related as ground and consequence.

In nature as intuitive representation, everything that happens is necessary, since it follows from its cause. Consider that event in relation to something else that did not cause it, and we call it contingent; this is already abstract reflection. Now abstract from both causal relation and necessity or contingency in considering a natural object. The remaining kind of cognition is covered by *actuality*: one considers only the *effect*, without looking for the cause in relation to which it would be called *necessary* or for other things in relation to which it would be *contingent*. Ultimately this rests on the fact that a judgment's modality indicates less an objective feature of things than the relation of our cognition to them. Everything in nature arises from a cause, so everything *actual* is also *necessary*, but only insofar as it exists at *this time* and *this place*: causal determination extends no further. Leaving intuitive nature for abstract thought, we can reflect on all natural laws, some known *a priori*, some only *a posteriori*. The abstract representation contains everything existing in nature at *any* place and time, while abstracting from every specific place and time. Reflection thus takes us into the broad realm of *possibility*. What has no place even there is *impossible*. Possibility and impossibility plainly exist only for reflection and abstract rational cognition, not for intuition. Nevertheless intuition's pure forms provide reason with the means of determining possible and impossible. Depending on whether the natural laws from which we proceed are known *a priori* or *a posteriori*, possibility or impossibility is metaphysical or merely physical.

This account needs no proof beyond knowledge of the principle of sufficient reason and the development of the concepts necessary, actual, and possible. It shows how entirely groundless Kant's assumption of three distinct functions of understanding for those concepts is; again no misgiving checked his architectural symmetry.

There is a further, very serious error. Following earlier philosophy, Kant confuses necessity and contingency. Earlier philosophy abused abstraction in this way. Plainly, when a ground is posited, what follows cannot fail to occur

and is therefore necessary. But it fixed on this last feature alone and said: necessary is what cannot be otherwise, or whose opposite is impossible. It forgot the ground and root of necessity and overlooked the resulting relativity of all necessity. Thus it invented the utterly unthinkable *absolutely necessary*: something whose existence would be as unavoidable as a consequence following its ground, yet would not itself follow from any ground or depend on anything. The last addition is an absurd request contradicting the principle of sufficient reason. Starting from this fiction, philosophy then called precisely everything posited by a ground *contingent*, in direct opposition to the truth. It compared the relativity of its necessity with that entirely invented, self-contradictory *absolute* necessity.^[4] Kant retains and offers this fundamentally mistaken definition of contingency in the *Critique of Pure Reason*, fifth edition pp. 289–291, 243, 301, 419, 447, 486, and 488. He even plainly contradicts himself at p. 301: “Everything contingent has a cause,” while adding, “Contingent is what can fail to exist.” Yet if something has a cause, it cannot fail to exist; it is necessary.

The source of the mistaken definition of necessary and contingent is already in Aristotle, *De generatione et corruptione*, II, chapters 9 and 11. He defines the necessary as what cannot fail to exist and opposes it to what cannot exist. Between them lies what may exist or not exist, that is, what comes to be and passes away, which he calls contingent. As explained above, this definition, like many of Aristotle's, stops at abstract concepts without returning to concrete intuition, the source that must always check them. “Something whose nonexistence is impossible” can perhaps be thought *in abstracto*, but when we seek an instance in concrete reality or intuition, we find nothing even potentially corresponding to it except the consequence of a given ground. Its necessity is relative and conditional.

I add a few more remarks here on these concepts of modality. Since all necessity rests on the principle of sufficient reason and is therefore relative, every *apodictic* judgment is originally and in its ultimate meaning *hypothetical*. It becomes *categorical* only when an *assertoric* minor premise is added, that is, in the conclusion. If the minor premise remains undecided and this uncertainty is expressed, the result is a *problematic* judgment.

What is apodictic generally, as a rule or law of nature, is only problematic in an individual case, since the condition bringing the case under the rule must first occur. Conversely, what is necessary, or apodictic, in an individual case—every particular change necessarily produced by its cause—is only

problematic when stated generally. The cause that occurred affected only this case, whereas an apodictic and always hypothetical judgment states general laws, not individual cases directly. This follows because possibility exists only in reflection for reason, actuality in intuition for understanding, and necessity for both. Indeed, the distinction among necessary, actual, and possible exists strictly only *in abstracto*, in concepts. In the real world all three coincide. Everything that happens happens *necessarily* because it follows from causes that in turn have causes. All events in the world, large and small, form a strict chain of necessary occurrences. Thus everything actual is necessary, and in reality there is no difference between actuality and necessity. Nor is there a difference between actuality and possibility. What did not happen, and so did not become actual, was not possible either. Its necessary causes did not occur, and could not have occurred within the great causal chain. It was impossible. Every event, then, is either necessary or impossible.

This applies only to the empirically real world, the complex of individual things taken as wholly individual. If we use reason to consider things generally and apprehend them *in abstracto*, necessity, actuality, and possibility separate again. We recognize everything compatible with the *a priori* laws of our intellect as possible generally, and what accords with empirical natural laws as possible in this world, even if it never occurs. Thus we clearly distinguish possible from actual. Although the actual is always necessary in itself, it is recognized as such only by someone who knows its cause. Apart from the cause, it is called contingent. This account also unlocks the *contentio* (dispute) περὶ δυνατόν (“about possibilities”) between Diodorus the Megarian and Chrysippus the Stoic recounted in Cicero's *De fato*. Diodorus says: “Only what becomes actual was possible; everything actual is also necessary.” Chrysippus says: “Much that never becomes actual is possible, for only what is necessary becomes actual.”^[‡] We can explain it as follows. Actuality is the conclusion of an inference whose premises furnish possibility. Both the major and minor premises are needed; together they yield full possibility. The major offers merely theoretical, general possibility *in abstracto*. It does not yet make anything possible in the sense of capable of becoming actual. The minor supplies that by placing the individual case under the rule. The case thereby becomes actual at once. For example:

Major: All houses, including mine, can burn down.

Minor: My house catches fire.

Conclusion: My house burns down.

Every general proposition, every major premise, determines things with respect to actuality only under a presupposition and hence hypothetically: a house's capacity to burn down presupposes its catching fire. The minor provides this presupposition. The major always loads the cannon; only when the minor brings the fuse does the shot, the conclusion, follow. This holds throughout for the relation of possibility to actuality. Since the conclusion stating actuality always follows *necessarily*, everything actual is necessary. The same follows from the meaning of necessity: being a consequence of a given ground. The ground of something actual is a cause; therefore all actuality is necessary. We see possible, actual, and necessary coincide. The last presupposes the first two, but they also presuppose the last. Our intellect's limitation by time keeps them apart: time mediates between possibility and actuality. Knowing all the causes of an individual event reveals its necessity completely. But the meeting of these different, independent causes seems *contingent* to us. Their independence of one another is precisely the concept of contingency. Yet each cause is in turn the necessary result of *its* cause in a beginningless chain. Contingency thus proves to be a merely subjective appearance arising from the limited horizon of our understanding, as subjective as the horizon of sight where sky touches earth.

Necessity, identical with following from a given ground, must appear in a distinct way in each form of the principle of sufficient reason, with an opposite in possibility and impossibility. That opposite arises only when reason applies abstract consideration to the object. Thus the four kinds of necessity mentioned above have four matching kinds of impossibility: physical, logical, mathematical, and practical. If we remain wholly within abstract concepts, possibility attaches to the broader concept and necessity to the narrower: "An animal *can* be a bird, fish, amphibian," and so on; "a nightingale *must* be a bird, a bird an animal, an animal an organism, an organism a body." This is because logical necessity, expressed by syllogism, proceeds from general to particular, never conversely. In intuitive nature, the first class of representations, everything is necessary under the causal law. Reflection alone can also regard it as contingent by comparing it with things that did not cause it, or as simply actual by ignoring every causal connection. Only this class of representations properly admits the concept *actual*, as the word's derivation from causality indicates. In the third class, pure mathematical intuition, there is only necessity so long as one remains within it. Possibility arises only by relating it to

reflective concepts: “A triangle *can* be right-, obtuse-, or equiangular; it *must* have three angles equal to two right angles.” Here too we reach the *possible* only by passing from intuition to abstraction.

This account presupposes familiarity with my essay on the principle of sufficient reason and the first book of this work. It should leave no doubt about the true, very different origins of the forms of judgment in the table, or about the invalidity and complete groundlessness of positing twelve separate functions of understanding to explain them. Some simple observations already expose the latter. It takes great love of symmetry and faith in it as a guide to assume, for example, that an affirmative, a categorical, and an assertoric judgment are so fundamentally different that each warrants its own function of understanding.

Kant himself betrays awareness that his category doctrine cannot be sustained. In the third chapter of the *Analytic of Principles*, “Phenomena and Noumena,” he omitted several long passages from the first edition—pp. 241, 242, 244–246, and 248–253—in the second, because they disclosed its weakness too openly. On p. 241, for example, he says he did not define the individual categories because he could not, even if he wanted to: they are incapable of definition. He had forgotten his earlier claim on p. 82 of the same edition: “I deliberately refrain from defining the categories, though I might possess the definitions.” That was, if I may say so, bluster. He left the latter passage standing. All the passages prudently removed reveal that the categories admit of no clear conception and the whole doctrine stands on weak legs.

The table of categories is supposed to guide every metaphysical, indeed every scientific inquiry (*Prolegomena*, §39). It is the foundation of Kant's whole philosophy and the pattern of symmetry everywhere carried through it, as shown above. It became a true Procrustean bed into which he forces every possible consideration, by a violence I shall now examine further. What, then, did the *imitatores, servum pecus* (“imitators, a servile herd”) do? We have seen. The violence consists in setting aside and forgetting the meanings of the words naming the headings, forms of judgment, and categories, and clinging only to the words themselves. Some come from Aristotle's *Prior Analytics*, I, 23, *περὶ ποιότητος καὶ ποσότητος τῶν τοῦ συλλογισμοῦ ὄρων* (*de qualitate et quantitate terminorum syllogismi*; “on the quality and quantity of the terms of a syllogism”). But the names are arbitrary. The extension of concepts could have been called something other than *quantity*, although this term fits its subject better than the other category titles. *Quality* was plainly chosen through habit of

pairing it with quantity, though it is an arbitrary name for affirmation and negation.

In every inquiry Kant undertakes, however, he puts any quantity in space and time, and any possible physical, moral, or other quality of things under those category headings. These matters share nothing with the headings for forms of judgment and thought but accidental, arbitrary names. One must remember all the respect owed Kant to avoid expressing anger at this procedure in harsh words. The pure physiological table of general principles of natural science gives the first example. What in the world has the quantity of judgments to do with the extensive magnitude of every intuition, or the quality of judgments with every sensation's degree? The former rests instead on space as the form of our outer intuition. The latter is merely an empirical and wholly subjective observation drawn from examining our sense organs. Again, in the table foundational to rational psychology (*Critique of Pure Reason*, p. 344; fifth edition p. 402), the soul's *simplicity* appears under quality. Yet simplicity is a quantitative property without any connection to affirmation or negation in judgment. Quantity was already filled by the *unity* of the soul, which is included in simplicity. Modality is then forced in absurdly: the soul stands in relation to *possible* objects. But relation belongs under relation, already occupied by substance. The four cosmological Ideas supplying the antinomies are likewise forced under the category headings. I shall discuss them in examining the antinomies. The table of *categories of freedom* in the *Critique of Practical Reason* gives still more glaring examples, as does the first book of the *Critique of Judgment*, which treats judgments of taste under the four category headings. Finally, the *Metaphysical Foundations of Natural Science* is entirely cut to the category table. This may be the principal cause of the false elements mixed here and there with that important work's true and excellent parts. Look at the end of its first chapter, where unity, plurality, and totality of the directions of lines supposedly correspond to categories named after the quantity of judgments.

The principle of the *persistence of substance* is derived from the category of subsistence and inherence. Yet we know that category only from the form of categorical judgments, the joining of two concepts as subject and predicate. How violently this great metaphysical principle is made to depend on a simple, purely logical form! It is only *pro forma* (for form's sake) and for symmetry. The proof Kant gives for it ignores its supposed origin in the understanding and category and proceeds from pure intuition of time. But this proof too is wholly wrong. It is false that mere time contains *simultaneity* and *duration*. These

notions first arise from uniting space with time, as I showed in *On the Principle of Sufficient Reason*, §18, and more fully in §4 of this work; both discussions are needed to understand what follows. It is false that time itself *remains* amid all change. It is precisely what flows; a persisting time is a contradiction. Kant's proof is untenable despite his sophisms, indeed he plainly contradicts himself. At p. 177; fifth edition p. 219, he wrongly makes *coexistence* a mode of time; at p. 183; fifth edition p. 226, he rightly says, "*Coexistence* is not a mode of time, since no parts of time coexist, but all follow one another." In truth, coexistence involves space as much as time. If two things coexist without being one, space distinguishes them. If two states of *one* thing coexist, such as a hot iron's glow and heat, they are simultaneous effects of *one* thing and presuppose matter and therefore space. Strictly, coexistence is a negative determination saying only that two things or states are not distinguished by time; their difference must be sought elsewhere.

Our knowledge of substance's persistence, that is, matter's, must indeed rest on *a priori* insight. It is beyond doubt and cannot be drawn from experience. I derive it from the fact that the principle of all arising and passing away, the causal law known to us *a priori*, concerns only *changes*, successive *states* of matter, and so is limited to form, leaving *matter* untouched. Matter thus stands in our consciousness as the basis of all things, neither arising nor passing away, always having been and always remaining. A deeper ground for substance's persistence, drawn from analyzing our intuitive representation of the empirical world, appears in §4 of my first book. There I show that *matter* consists in the complete *union of space and time*. This union is possible only through representation of causality and therefore only for the understanding, the subjective correlate of causality. Matter is consequently known only as acting, entirely as causality; its being and acting are one, as the word *actuality* itself suggests. The intimate union of space and time, causality, matter, and actuality are thus one, whose subjective correlate is understanding. Matter must carry the conflicting properties of the two factors from which it arises. The representation of causality resolves their contradiction and makes their coexistence intelligible to the understanding, through and for which alone matter exists and whose whole faculty is knowing cause and effect. For it, time's impermanent flow appears in matter as changing accidents and unites with space's rigid immobility, appearing as the persistence of substance. If substance vanished as accidents do, appearance would be torn away from space and belong to time alone; the world of experience would dissolve through matter's annihilation.

The principle that substance persists, acknowledged by everyone as certain *a priori*, must be derived from the part *space* plays in matter and all appearances of actuality. Space opposes time and knows no change in itself apart from their union. It cannot be derived from time alone, to which Kant absurdly ascribed *persistence* for this purpose.

I demonstrated at length in *On the Principle of Sufficient Reason*, §23, the error of the next proof, which tries to derive the causal law's *a priori* necessity from mere temporal succession, and refer to it here.^[5] The same holds for his proof of reciprocal interaction, whose concept I have already shown to be empty. Enough has likewise been said about modality and the principles Kant next derives from it.

There are many more details in the Transcendental Analytic I could refute, but I fear tiring the reader and leave them to his own thought. Kant's chief fault, discussed above, keeps confronting us throughout the *Critique of Pure Reason*: his utter failure to distinguish abstract, discursive cognition from intuition. It spreads a constant obscurity over his whole theory of cognition. The reader never knows exactly what is being discussed and must guess rather than understand, trying each statement alternately as referring to thought or intuition and left perpetually uncertain. This astonishing lack of reflection on intuitive and abstract representation brings Kant, in the chapter "On Distinguishing All Objects into Phenomena and Noumena," to the monstrous claim I shall discuss: without thinking and abstract concepts there is no cognition of an object at all; intuition is not thought and so is not cognition, but only an affection of sensibility, mere sensation. Worse, intuition without a concept is wholly empty, while a concept without intuition is still something (p. 253; fifth edition p. 309). That is the direct opposite of the truth. Concepts receive all meaning and content only through relation to intuitive representations. They are abstracted from intuition by dropping what is inessential, so without it they are empty and void. Intuitions, on the other hand, have immediate and immense significance in themselves, for in them the thing in itself objectivates itself. They represent and express themselves rather than borrowing their content, as concepts do. The principle of sufficient reason governs them only as the causal law, determining their position in space and time. It does not condition their content and significance as it does for concepts, where it operates as the ground of knowing.

Oddly, Kant seems here to want to distinguish intuitive and abstract representations properly. He faults Leibniz for treating everything as abstract representation and Locke for treating everything as intuitive. Yet he reaches no

distinction. Even if Locke and Leibniz committed those errors, Kant committed a third containing both, so mixing intuition and abstraction that a monstrous hybrid resulted, something inconceivable that could only confuse, stupefy, and set his students quarreling.

Thought and intuition do separate more than anywhere else in the chapter “On Distinguishing All Objects into Phenomena and Noumena,” but in a fundamentally false way. At p. 253; fifth edition p. 309, Kant says: “If I remove all thinking (through categories) from an empirical cognition, no cognition of an object remains. For mere intuition thinks nothing, and the fact that this affection of sensibility is in me does not establish any relation between such representations and any object.” This one sentence contains all Kant's errors in miniature. It shows that he misconceived the relation among sensation, intuition, and thought. He identifies intuition, whose form is supposedly three-dimensional space, with mere subjective sensation in a sense organ, and allows cognition of an object to enter only through thinking distinct from intuition. I say instead that objects are first given in intuition, not thought, and all cognition of *objects* is originally and in itself intuitive. But intuition is by no means mere sensation; understanding already acts within it. *Thinking*, added only for humans and not animals, is merely abstraction from intuition. It supplies no fundamentally new cognition and first posits no objects absent before. It changes only the form of cognition already gained through intuition, making it abstract, conceptual, and no longer intuitive. This loss makes combination possible and immensely widens cognition's uses. The *material* of our thought is nothing other than our intuitions, not something thought adds that intuition lacked. The material of everything occurring in thought must therefore be traceable in intuition, or thought is empty. Thought may work and reshape it in many ways, but it must be possible to recover it and return thought to it, just as a piece of gold can be recovered whole and metallic from every dissolution, oxidation, sublimation, and compound. That would be impossible if thinking itself added something, still more the chief thing, to the object.

The entire following chapter on the Amphiboly is a critique of Leibniz's philosophy and is on the whole right. Yet its whole arrangement serves architectural symmetry. To create an analogy with Aristotle's *Organon*, Kant sets up a transcendental Topic: every concept must be considered in four respects before one can decide which faculty of cognition it belongs to. These four respects are arbitrary; ten others could be added with equal right. But four matches the category headings, under which Leibniz's chief teachings are

distributed as best they can be. The critique also turns what were only *Leibniz's* false abstractions into supposedly natural errors of reason. Rather than learning from his great contemporaries Spinoza and Locke, Leibniz preferred to present his own strange inventions. At the end of the *Amphiboly of Reflection*, Kant says a mode of intuition wholly different from ours might exist yet admit application of our categories. The objects of this supposed intuition would be *noumena*, things we can only *think*. But since we lack the intuition that would give that thought meaning, and its very existence is doubtful, the object of the thought remains an entirely indefinite possibility.

I have cited passages showing Kant's profound self-contradiction in presenting the categories sometimes as conditions of intuitive representation, sometimes as functions of merely abstract thought. Here they appear only in the second role, as though he intended them to have only discursive thought. If that truly was his meaning, at the start of *Transcendental Logic*, before elaborating its various functions, he should have characterized thought generally and distinguished it from intuition, showing what cognition mere intuition gives and what thought adds. We would then have known what he meant—or rather, he would have spoken quite differently, first of intuition and then of thought. As it is he always treats some impossible intermediate thing. He would not have left the great gap between *Transcendental Aesthetic* and *Logic*. After presenting intuition's mere form, he dismisses its content, all empirical perception, with “it is *given*,” never asking whether and how it arises *with or without understanding*. He jumps to abstract thinking, and not even to thinking generally but straight to particular forms of it, saying nothing about what thinking or a concept is, the relation of abstract and discursive to concrete and intuitive cognition, the difference between human and animal cognition, or the nature of reason.

The very distinction Kant overlooked between abstract and intuitive cognition is what ancient philosophers marked by *φαινόμενα* and *νοούμενα* (phenomena and noumena).^[6] Its opposition and incommensurability occupied them in the Eleatics' teachings, Plato's Ideas, the Megarians' dialectic, and later the scholastics' dispute between nominalism and realism, whose slowly developing seed was already in the opposite tendencies of Plato and Aristotle. Kant, quite inexcusably neglecting the subject for which these terms had already been taken, seizes them as though unowned and uses them for his things in themselves and appearances.

Having rejected Kant's doctrine of categories as he rejected Aristotle's, I would suggest a third route to what they sought. Both were surely looking for the most general concepts under which even the most diverse things must be subsumed, through which everything existing is thought. Kant therefore took them as the *forms* of all thought.

Grammar stands to logic as clothing stands to the body. Might not these highest concepts, the bass line of reason underlying every more specific thought and without whose use no thinking can occur, ultimately lie in concepts so extremely general, or transcendental, that they are expressed not by particular words but by entire classes of words? Every word already carries one of them. Their sign would thus be found in grammar, not a dictionary. Might they be the distinctions by which a word is a noun, adjective, verb, adverb, pronoun, preposition, or other particle: the *partes orationis* (parts of speech)? These plainly mark the forms all thinking first takes and moves within. They are therefore essential forms and basic components of every language. We cannot imagine a language without at least nouns, adjectives, and verbs. Beneath these fundamental forms we would place forms of thought expressed by their inflections, declension and conjugation. Whether articles and pronouns help express them matters little. Let us examine this more closely and ask anew: What are the forms of thought?

1. Thought consists throughout of judgments; judgments are the threads of its entire fabric. Thought cannot move without a verb, and every use of a verb is a judgment.

2. Every judgment recognizes a relation between subject and predicate, separating or joining them with various restrictions. It joins them when they are truly identical, possible only with interchangeable concepts. In a universal affirmative it recognizes that one is always thought within the other, though not conversely; in a particular affirmative, that one is sometimes thought within the other. Negative propositions follow the reverse course. Every judgment must therefore have subject, predicate, and an affirmative or negative copula, though not always separately expressed by words. One word often contains predicate and copula, as in "Caius ages"; sometimes one word contains all three, as in *concurritur* ("the armies engage"). Thus the forms of thought cannot be sought directly in words or even parts of speech. The same judgment can be expressed by different words and even different parts of speech in different languages or in one language, while remaining the same thought and form. A thought could not be the same if its own form differed. The verbal construction may vary

while thought and its form stay the same: words are merely its outer clothing, while thought is inseparable from its form. Grammar thus explains only how thought's forms are clothed. Parts of speech may be derived from original forms of thought independent of every language. Their purpose is to express those forms and all their variations. They are thought's tool and garment, which must fit its structure closely enough for it to be recognized beneath them.

3. These real, original, unchanging forms of thought are indeed those in Kant's *logical table of judgments*, except that it includes blind windows for symmetry and the category table, which must all be removed, and is wrongly ordered. An arrangement would be:

(a) Quality: affirmation or negation, joining or separating concepts. These are two forms and attach to the copula.

(b) Quantity: the subject concept is taken wholly or partly: universality or particularity. Individual subjects belong to universality; "Socrates" means "all Socrates." Thus there are only two forms. Quantity attaches to the subject.

(c) Modality: this really has three forms. It determines quality as necessary, actual, or contingent and therefore also attaches to the copula.

These three forms of thought arise from the laws of thought of contradiction and identity. The principle of sufficient reason and the law of excluded middle, however, yield:

(d) Relation: this arises only when we judge judgments already made. It can indicate that one judgment depends on another, or on several, joining them in a *hypothetical* proposition. Or it can indicate that judgments exclude one another, separating them in a *disjunctive* proposition. It attaches to the copula, which joins or separates completed judgments here.

The *parts of speech* and grammatical forms express the three elements of judgment—subject, predicate, copula—and their possible relations, the forms of thought just listed, with their finer determinations and variations. Nouns, adjectives, and verbs are therefore essential building blocks of language generally and must occur in every language. One could, however, imagine a language where adjective and verb were always fused, as they sometimes are in all languages. Provisionally, nouns, articles, and pronouns serve to express the *subject*; adjectives, adverbs, and prepositions the *predicate*; and verbs the *copula*, though verbs other than "to be" also contain the predicate.

Philosophical grammar should teach the exact mechanism for expressing the forms of thought, as logic teaches operations with the forms themselves.

Note. To warn against a wrong turn and clarify what I have said, I mention S. Stern's *Provisional Foundation for a Philosophy of Language* (1835), a wholly unsuccessful attempt to construct the categories from grammatical forms. Stern confuses thought completely with intuition and therefore tries to derive supposed categories of intuition, rather than thought, from grammar, relating grammatical forms directly to *intuition*. His great error is to suppose *language* relates immediately to *intuition*. It relates immediately only to *thought* as such, to *abstract concepts*, and through them first to intuition. But their relation to intuition brings about a complete change of form. What exists in intuition, including relations arising from time and space, can certainly become an object of thought, and linguistic forms must express it, but only *in abstracto*, as concepts. Concepts are always thought's immediate material; logical forms relate only to them, never *directly* to intuition. Intuition determines a proposition's material truth, never its formal truth, which depends solely on logical rules.

I return to Kant and come to the *Transcendental Dialectic*. He begins by defining *reason*, the faculty that is to play the leading role, while sensibility and understanding have occupied the stage until now. Among his various definitions of reason already discussed, I mentioned the one here: "the faculty of principles." He now teaches that all the *a priori* cognitions considered so far, making pure mathematics and pure natural science possible, provide only *rules*, not *principles*. They arise from intuitions and forms of cognition rather than from mere *concepts*, which is required to count as a principle. A principle would thus have to be cognition *from mere concepts* and yet *synthetic*. This is absolutely impossible. Only *analytic* propositions can arise from mere concepts. If concepts are to be joined synthetically and yet *a priori*, a third thing must mediate the joining: pure intuition of the formal possibility of experience, as empirical intuition mediates synthetic *a posteriori* judgments. No synthetic *a priori* proposition can therefore arise from mere concepts. Generally we know *a priori* only the principle of sufficient reason in its different forms. No other synthetic *a priori* judgments are possible than those arising from what supplies content to that principle.

At last Kant offers a supposed principle of reason meeting his demand, but only *one* from which he then derives consequences. It is the proposition set out by Christian Wolff in *Cosmologia*, section 1, chapter 2, §93, and *Ontologia*,

§178. Earlier, in the *Amphiboly*, Kant had treated mere Leibnizian doctrines as natural, necessary errors of reason and critiqued them accordingly. He now does the same with Wolff's doctrines. He presents the principle still veiled by obscurity, vagueness, and fragmentation (pp. 307 and 322; fifth edition pp. 361 and 379). Stated plainly, it is: "If the conditioned is given, the totality of its conditions, and thus the *unconditioned* that alone completes that totality, must also be given." Its seeming truth is most vivid if we imagine conditions and conditioned things as links in a hanging chain whose upper end is unseen and might extend without end. Because the chain hangs rather than falls, *one* link at the top must be first and somehow attached. More briefly, reason would like an attachment point for the chain of causes receding into infinity. That would be convenient. But we must test the proposition itself, not an image.

It is indeed synthetic; only the concept of a condition follows analytically from the conditioned. But it has no truth either *a priori* or *a posteriori*. It steals an appearance of truth in a subtle way I shall expose. We know the principle of sufficient reason immediately and *a priori* in its four forms. All abstract expressions of it are derived from and thus less immediate than those cognitions, and its consequences still less immediate. As I explained above, *abstract* cognition often unites very different *intuitive* cognitions in *one* form or concept, so that they can no longer be distinguished. It stands to intuitive cognition as a shadow stands to real objects, reducing their great variety to *one* common outline. The supposed principle of reason exploits this shadow. To draw from the principle of sufficient reason an unconditioned that directly contradicts it, the proposition wisely leaves behind immediate intuitive knowledge of the principle's content in its distinct forms. It uses only the abstract concepts drawn from them, whose worth and significance come solely from those forms, and smuggles an unconditioned into their broad scope.

A dialectical presentation makes the procedure plain: "If a conditioned thing exists, its condition must be given, and given wholly, so completely: the totality of its conditions. If those form a series, the whole series must be given, including its first beginning, the unconditioned." Already it is false that a conditioned thing's conditions as such can form a *series*. The totality of conditions for any conditioned thing must be contained in its *nearest* ground, from which it follows immediately and which is *sufficient* only for that reason. For instance, all the determinations of the causal state must come together before the effect occurs. A series, such as a chain of causes, arises only when we take what was just a condition and consider it anew as a conditioned thing.

The whole operation then begins again, and the principle of sufficient reason raises its demand afresh. There can never be a proper successive *series* of conditions existing merely as conditions for one final conditioned thing. Rather, it is always an alternating series of conditioned things and conditions. At every link already passed, the chain has been broken and the principle's demand completely met. It starts again only when the condition becomes something conditioned. The principle of *sufficient* reason thus requires only the completeness of the *nearest condition*, never the completeness of a *series*.

The concept "complete condition" leaves open whether its conditions are simultaneous or successive. Choosing succession creates a demand for a complete series of successive conditions. Only by arbitrary abstraction can a series of causes and effects be treated as a series of mere causes existing for the final effect and required as its *sufficient* ground. More careful consideration, descending from abstraction's vague generality to specific reality, finds instead that the demand for a *sufficient* ground concerns the completeness of the *nearest* cause, not a series. The principle's demand expires completely in each given sufficient ground. It arises again as soon as that ground is considered as an effect, but it never immediately demands a series of grounds. Remaining among abstract concepts erases these distinctions. Then a chain alternating causes and effects, or logical grounds and consequences, is passed off as a chain consisting solely of causes or grounds for the final effect. The *completeness of conditions* that makes one ground *sufficient* is presented as completeness of that supposed *series* of grounds existing only for a final consequence. The abstract principle of reason can then boldly demand the unconditioned.

We need no critique of reason through antinomies and their solutions to expose this demand, only a critique of reason in my sense: examine how abstract relates to immediate intuitive cognition by descending from abstraction's vague generality to intuition's firm specificity. We then find that reason's nature is by no means to demand an unconditioned. Reflecting fully, reason itself must recognize that an unconditioned is an absurdity. As a faculty of cognition, it can deal only with objects. Every object for a subject is necessarily and irrevocably subject to the principle of sufficient reason, both *a parte ante* (with respect to what precedes) and *a parte post* (with respect to what follows). The principle is so inherent in consciousness that we cannot represent any objective thing of which no further "why?" can be asked, no absolute absolute confronting us like a board. Some people may find it convenient to stop somewhere and posit such an absolute at will, but their grand

manner cannot overcome this unshakable *a priori* certainty. The whole talk of “the absolute,” almost the sole subject of philosophies attempted since Kant, is the cosmological proof *incognito*. After Kant tried and outlawed it, it cannot show itself in its true form. It wears disguises: at times noble, cloaked in intellectual intuition or pure thought; at others a suspicious vagrant, half begging and half extorting what it gets in more modest philosophies. If these gentlemen insist on an absolute, I will give them one that fits all their demands far better than their imagined phantoms: matter. It has neither origin nor end, and is thus truly independent, *quod per se est et per se concipitur* (“what is in and conceived through itself”). Everything emerges from its womb and returns there. What more can one ask of an absolute? Rather, to those whom no critique of reason has reached, we should cry:

“Are you not like women who forever
Return to their first word again,
Though reason has been spoken for hours?”

That going back to an unconditioned cause, a first beginning, is not inherent in reason is also established by fact. The oldest religions of our race, still followed by the greatest number of people on earth, Brahmanism and Buddhism, know and admit no such assumptions. They carry the chain of mutually conditioned appearances back without end. I refer to my note below on the first antinomy and to Upham's *Doctrine of Buddhism*, p. 9, or any authentic account of Asian religions. Judaism should not be identified with reason.

Kant insists his supposed principle of reason has only subjective necessity, not objective validity. Yet he derives even that through a shallow sophism (p. 307; fifth edition p. 364). We try, as long as possible, to subsume every known truth under a more general one; he takes this as already a pursuit of the unconditioned, which we supposedly presuppose. In truth this search is simply a proper use of reason, the faculty of abstract, general cognition distinguishing reflective, speaking, thinking humans from animals enslaved by the present. We simplify and improve our knowledge by surveying it. Reason's use consists in knowing the particular through the general, the case through a rule, and that rule through a still more general one, seeking the broadest standpoints. Such a survey makes knowledge much easier and better and accounts for the great difference between animal and human lives and, again, between the lives of educated and uneducated people.

The chain of *grounds of knowing*, found only in abstraction and reason, does indeed end at something unprovable: a representation no longer conditioned under this form of the principle of sufficient reason, the directly intuitive *a priori* or *a posteriori* ground of the highest proposition in an inferential chain. In *On the Principle of Sufficient Reason*, §50, I showed that here the chain of grounds of knowing actually passes over into grounds of becoming or being. One can use this to prove an unconditioned under the causal law, even merely as a demand, only by failing to distinguish the forms of that principle and confusing them all under the abstract name. Kant even tries to justify the confusion with a pun on *universalitas* and *universitas* (p. 322; fifth edition p. 379). It is thus fundamentally false that our search for higher grounds of knowing, for general truths, arises from assuming an object unconditioned in its existence or has anything in common with that assumption. How could reason essentially presuppose something it must recognize as absurd when it reflects? The concept of an unconditioned has no other source than the laziness of someone wanting to end others' and his own further questions, without justification.

Kant denies objective validity to this alleged principle of reason, yet makes it a subjectively necessary presupposition. This creates an irresolvable division within our cognition that soon becomes plainer. He develops the principle by his favored architecturally symmetrical method (p. 322; fifth edition p. 379). The three categories of relation yield three kinds of inferences, each guiding a search for a particular unconditioned. These are therefore three: soul, world regarded as an object in itself and a closed totality, and God. Kant ignores an immediate, major contradiction because it threatens the symmetry. Two of the supposedly unconditioned things, soul and world, are themselves conditioned by the third, God, as their producing cause. They therefore share with God not the relevant property of being unconditioned, but only that of being inferred from principles of experience beyond its possible scope.

Setting that aside, the three supposedly necessary products of every reason turn out to be the three main subjects around which philosophy under Christianity's influence revolved from the scholastics to Christian Wolff. Those concepts are familiar and accessible to our reason after centuries of such philosophy, but that does not show that without revelation they would arise in every reason as products of its own nature. Establishing this would require historical inquiry. Did ancient and non-European peoples, especially those of India, and many early Greek philosophers actually reach these concepts? Or do

we kindly but falsely attribute them to those peoples, as the Greeks found their own gods everywhere? Is it wrong to translate Hindu *Brahman* and Chinese *Tian* as “God”? Perhaps theism proper occurs only in Judaism and the two religions descended from it. Their adherents therefore group all other religions' followers under “pagans,” incidentally an extremely foolish and crude term that should at least be barred from scholarly writing. It throws Brahmins, Buddhists, Egyptians, Greeks, Romans, Germans, Gauls, Iroquois, Patagonians, Caribs, Tahitians, Australians, and others into one sack. Priests may find the term fitting; scholarship should show it the door at once and send it to settle in Oxford. Buddhism in particular, the religion with the most followers on earth, certainly contains no theism and indeed abhors it.

As for Plato, I believe he owed the theism that periodically came over him to the Jews. *Numenius* therefore called him *Moses graecisans* (“Moses speaking Greek”; see Clement of Alexandria, *Stromata*, I, chapter 22; Eusebius, *Praeparatio Evangelica*, XIII, 12; and Suidas under *Numenius*): Τί γάρ ἐστι Πλάτων, ἢ Μωσῆς ἀττικίζων; (“What is Plato but Moses speaking Attic Greek?”). He accused Plato of stealing (ἀποσυλήσας) his doctrines of God and creation from the Mosaic writings. Clement repeatedly returns to Plato's having known and used Moses, for instance in *Stromata*, I, 25; V, chapter 14, §90; *Paedagogus*, II, 10 and III, 11. In *Cohortatio ad gentes*, chapter 6, after scolding and mocking all Greek philosophers like a Capuchin friar in the previous chapter for not being Jews, he praises Plato alone and bursts into rejoicing: just as Plato learned geometry from the Egyptians, astronomy from the Babylonians, magic from the Thracians, and much from the Assyrians, so he learned theism from the Jews. Οἶδά σου τοὺς διδασκάλους, κἂν ἀποκρύπτειν ἐθέλῃς ... δόξαν τὴν τοῦ θεοῦ παρ’ αὐτῶν ὠφελήσῃ τῶν Ἑβραίων (*tuos magistros novi, licet eos celare velis, — — — illa de Deo sententia suppeditata tibi est ab Hebraeis*; “I know your teachers, even if you wish to hide them ... that view about God was supplied to you by the Hebrews”). A touching scene of recognition! I find a curious confirmation in the following. According to Plutarch (*Marius*), and more clearly Lactantius (I, 3, 19), Plato thanked nature that he had become a human and not an animal, a man and not a woman, a Greek and not a barbarian. Isaac Euchel's *Prayers of the Jews*, translated from Hebrew, second edition, 1799, p. 7, includes a morning prayer thanking and praising God that the speaker was born a Jew, not a pagan, free, not a slave, and a man, not a woman.

Such historical inquiry would have spared Kant his awkward position. He makes the three concepts spring necessarily from reason's nature, yet shows they cannot be sustained or grounded by reason. He thereby makes reason itself a sophist: "These are sophistications not of man, but of pure reason itself, from which even the wisest cannot free himself. Perhaps with much effort he can avoid the error, but never escape the illusion that continually vexes and mocks him" (p. 339; fifth edition p. 397). Kant's "Ideas of reason" would then resemble the focal point where rays reflected by a concave mirror meet a few inches before it. By an unavoidable process of understanding, an object seems to appear there though it has no reality.

The name *Ideas* is especially unfortunate for these three supposedly necessary products of pure theoretical reason. Kant took it from Plato, who used it for imperishable forms imperfectly visible in countless individual, transient things through multiplication in time and space. Plato's Ideas are thus entirely intuitive, as the word he chose plainly indicates; it might be translated "visible forms" or "things seen." Kant appropriated it for what lies so far beyond all possible intuition that even abstract thought can only half reach it. For twenty-two centuries after Plato introduced "Idea," it kept his meaning. Ancient philosophers, scholastics, Church Fathers, and medieval theologians all used it in that Platonic sense, as the Latin *exemplar* (model), as Suárez expressly notes in his twenty-fifth disputation, section 1. Later English and French writers abused the word because their languages were poor, but that carries no weight. Kant's misuse introduces a new meaning on the frail connection that his Ideas, like Plato's and every possible chimera, are not objects of experience. It is indefensible. The abuse of a few years cannot outweigh centuries of usage. I have therefore always used "Idea" in its original Platonic sense.

The refutation of *rational psychology* is much fuller and more thorough in the first edition of the *Critique of Pure Reason* than in the second and later ones, so the first must be used here. On the whole this refutation has great merit and contains much truth. Yet I am convinced Kant derives the concept of soul as a necessary result of applying the demand for the unconditioned to *substance*, the first category of relation, through that paralogism solely for the sake of symmetry. He thus claims the idea of a soul arises in every speculative reason in this way. If it truly came from assuming a final subject of all a thing's predicates, we would necessarily assume a soul in every lifeless thing as in a human being, since each demands a final subject of its predicates. In general Kant uses an inadmissible expression when he speaks of something able to exist

only as subject and never as predicate (*Critique of Pure Reason*, p. 323; fifth edition p. 412; *Prolegomena*, §§4 and 47), though Aristotle's *Metaphysics*, IV, chapter 8, already offers a precedent. Nothing exists *as subject and predicate*: these belong exclusively to logic and name relations among abstract concepts. Their supposed intuitive-world counterparts are substance and accident. But we need not seek far for something that always exists as substance, never as accident: matter is immediately before us. It is the substance of every thing's properties, which are its accidents. If we retain Kant's criticized expression, matter is the last subject of all predicates of every empirically given thing: what remains after subtracting all properties of every kind. This applies to humans, animals, plants, and stones. So obvious is it that overlooking it requires a determined wish not to see. I shall soon show that matter really is the prototype of substance.

Subject and predicate stand to substance and accident as the logical principle of sufficient reason stands to causality in nature. Confusing or identifying the one pair is as wrong as confusing the other. Kant pushes the confusion to its utmost in *Prolegomena*, §46, to derive the concept of soul from the final subject of all predicates and the form of the categorical inference. To expose the sophistry, one need only remember that subject and predicate are purely logical determinations concerning only abstract concepts in their relation within a judgment. Substance and accident belong instead to the intuitive world and its apprehension by the understanding, where they occur only as identical with matter and form or quality. More on this presently.

The real opposition that prompted belief in two fundamentally different substances, body and soul, is that of objective and subjective. When someone apprehends himself objectively through external intuition, he finds a being extended in space and wholly corporeal. Apprehending himself in mere self-consciousness, purely subjectively, he finds only a willing and representing being, free of all intuitive forms and therefore of bodily properties. He then forms the concept of soul, like all the transcendent concepts Kant calls Ideas, by applying the principle of sufficient reason, the form of every object, to what is not an object: here, the subject of knowing and willing. He treats knowing, thinking, and willing as effects and seeks their cause. Unable to take the body as that cause, he posits one wholly distinct from it. This is how the first and the last dogmatists alike prove a soul's existence: Plato already in the *Phaedrus*, and Wolff much later. Thinking and willing are taken as effects pointing to it as cause. Only after thus making a cause corresponding to the effect into a thing

does the school develop and prove an immaterial, simple, indestructible being from the concept of *substance*. But it had first fashioned that concept specifically for this purpose by a noteworthy trick.

The first class of representations, the intuitively real world, includes representation of matter. The causal law ruling it determines changes of states, which presuppose something persisting whose changes they are. Discussing substance's persistence above, I referred to earlier passages showing how matter arises as a representation. In the understanding, through and for which alone matter exists, time and space are intimately joined by causality, its sole form of cognition. Space's contribution appears as the persistence of *matter*, time's as the change of its *states*. Pure matter can only be thought *in abstracto*, not intuited, since in intuition it always already has form and quality. *Substance* is another abstraction from *matter*, a higher *genus*, formed by keeping only persistence while thinking away matter's other essential properties: extension, impenetrability, divisibility, and so forth. Like any higher genus, substance *contains less in itself* than matter. But unlike a proper higher genus it does not *contain more under it*. It comprises no lower genera alongside matter, which remains its one genuine species, the sole example giving it real content. The usual purpose of forming a higher genus by abstraction, to think several species differing in secondary features under one concept, is absent. The abstraction was thus either idle and pointless or served a hidden aim. The aim appears when a second species, an immaterial, simple, indestructible substance called soul, is placed beside genuine matter under the concept "substance."

The concept was smuggled in by first forming the higher genus *substance* unlawfully and illogically. Reason properly forms a higher genus only by placing several species concepts side by side and comparing them. It drops their differences and keeps their common features, arriving at a broader, less detailed genus. Species must therefore precede genus. Here the reverse occurred. Only *matter* existed before the genus *substance*. The latter was made from it idly, without occasion or justification, by arbitrarily dropping all determinations but one. Only afterward was a second, spurious species placed alongside matter. Forming it required simply expressly negating what had been silently removed in forming the genus: extension, impenetrability, and divisibility. "Substance" was thus formed solely as a vehicle to smuggle in "immaterial substance." Far from being a category or necessary function of understanding, it is highly dispensable. Its only true content is already in "matter"; besides this it holds a great void that can be filled only by the smuggled-in species "immaterial

substance,” the very reason it was formed. Strictly it should be rejected entirely and “matter” substituted everywhere.

The categories were a Procrustean bed for every possible thing; the three forms of inference serve the same role for the three so-called Ideas. The soul was forced to find its origin in categorical inference. Now dogmatic ideas of the world as a whole, taken as an object in itself enclosed between the smallest, the atom, and the largest, limits of the world in time and space, must arise from hypothetical inference. This requires less force in itself. Hypothetical judgment has its form from the principle of sufficient reason; all these so-called Ideas, not only the cosmological ones, do indeed arise from the unreflective, unqualified application of that principle followed by arbitrary abandonment of it. Following it, one seeks one object's dependence on another without end until a tired imagination creates an end to the journey. One overlooks that every object, the whole series, and the principle of sufficient reason itself are far more directly and profoundly dependent on the knowing subject. That principle applies only to the subject's objects, its representations, determining merely their positions in space and time. Since the form of cognition from which Kant derives only the cosmological Ideas, the principle of sufficient reason, actually gives rise to all rationalizing hypostases, no sophism is needed on this occasion. Considerably more is needed, however, to classify those Ideas under the four category headings.

1. The cosmological Ideas concerning time and space, the world's limits in both, are boldly assigned to *quantity*. Their only link is the chance use in logic of “quantity,” a metaphorical name that could easily have been replaced, for the extension of the subject concept in a judgment. Kant's love of symmetry is enough to exploit this fortunate name and attach transcendent doctrines of the world's extent to it.

2. Still more boldly he attaches transcendent Ideas about matter to *quality*, that is, affirmation or negation in judgment, without even an accidental likeness of names. Matter's mechanical, rather than chemical, divisibility concerns precisely its *quantity*, not its quality. Moreover, the whole Idea of divisibility does not belong among consequences of the principle of sufficient reason, though all cosmological Ideas are supposed to spring from it as the content of hypothetical judgment. Kant assumes that the relation of parts to whole is that of condition to conditioned, a relation under the principle of sufficient reason. This is subtle but groundless sophistry. The relation rests rather on the law of contradiction. Neither whole nor parts arise from one another as ground and

consequence. Both necessarily belong together because they are one; their separation is only an arbitrary act. If parts are thought away, the whole is also thought away, and conversely, under the law of contradiction. It is not that parts as *ground* condition the whole as *consequence*, driving us to seek ultimate parts under the principle of sufficient reason in order to understand the whole from them. Such difficulties are no match for the love of symmetry.

3. The Idea of a first cause of the world would properly belong under *relation*. Kant must save it for the fourth heading, modality, otherwise left empty. He forces it there by having the first cause turn the contingent—on his definition, directly opposite to truth, every consequence of its ground—into the necessary. The concept of *freedom* thus enters as the third Idea for symmetry's sake, but it really is simply the Idea of the world's cause, the one Idea that fits here at all, as the note on the thesis of the third antinomy plainly says. The third and fourth antinomies are essentially tautological.

I maintain that the entire Antinomy is sham combat. Only the *antitheses* are actually grounded in the forms of our cognition or, stated objectively, in the necessary and most general laws of nature known with *a priori* certainty. Their proofs alone proceed from objective grounds. The *theses* and their proofs have only a subjective basis. They rest wholly on the weakness of the reasoning individual, whose imagination tires of an infinite regress and brings it to an end by arbitrary assumptions made as plausible as possible. His judgment is further paralyzed by prejudices firmly instilled early in life. The proof of each thesis is therefore a sophism, whereas each antithesis follows inevitably from reason applying the *a priori* laws of the world as representation. Only with much effort and art could Kant keep the theses on their feet and make them appear to attack a foe endowed with original strength. His constant first device is not to show the *nervus argumentationis* (core of the argument) by isolating it as plainly as possible, as someone confident of the truth would do. Instead he buries it on both sides in a flood of lengthy, superfluous sentences.

These theses and antitheses recall the δίκαιος and ἄδικος λόγος (“just” and “unjust” arguments) that Socrates makes debate in Aristophanes' *Clouds*. But the likeness is only formal, not one of content, however much those who attach moral significance to this most speculative issue of theoretical philosophy would like to take the thesis as the just and the antithesis as the unjust argument. I will not accommodate such narrow, perverse minds. Giving the honor to truth rather than to them, I shall expose Kant's proofs of the theses as sophisms and show that those of the antitheses are honest, correct, and grounded objectively. I

presume the reader has Kant's Antinomy before him throughout this examination.

If the proof of the thesis in the first antinomy were accepted, it would prove too much. It applies to time itself as well as to change within time, and would thus prove that time began, which is absurd. The sophism is that a series of states *without a beginning*, the original topic, suddenly becomes a series *without an end*, and Kant proves only the undisputed claim that an endless series cannot be completed, while every present is the end of the past. We can *think* an end to a beginningless series without compromising its lack of a beginning, just as we can think a beginning to an endless series. Kant offers nothing against the antithesis's sound argument that changes in the world necessarily presuppose an infinite sequence of prior changes. We can conceive that the causal chain might someday stop absolutely, but not that it could begin absolutely.^[7]

For the world's spatial limits, the thesis proves that if the world is called a *given whole* it must have limits. The inference is correct, but its premise is exactly what required proof and is left unproved. Totality presupposes limits and limits presuppose totality, and both are assumed arbitrarily here. The antithesis's proof on this point is less satisfactory than on the first, because causality supplies necessary determinations with respect to time, not space. It gives us *a priori* certainty that filled time cannot border on earlier empty time and no change can be first, but not that filled space cannot have empty space beside it. On that issue no *a priori* decision is possible in the same way. Still, conceiving a spatially bounded world is difficult because space itself is necessarily infinite. A finite world within it, however large, becomes infinitely small by comparison, a disproportion imagination cannot overcome. It must think the world as either infinitely large or infinitely small. Ancient philosophers recognized this: Μητρόδωρος ὁ καθηγητῆς Ἐπικούρου, φησὶν ἄτοπον εἶναι ἐν μεγάλῳ πεδίῳ ἓνα στάχυν γεννηθῆναι, καὶ ἓνα κόσμον ἐν τῷ ἀπείρῳ (*Metrodorus, caput scholae Epicuri, absurdum ait, in magno campo spicam unam produci, et unum in infinitum mundum*; “Metrodorus, head of Epicurus's school, says it is absurd for a single ear of grain to grow in a vast field or for there to be only one world in the infinite”) (Stobaeus, *Eclogae*, I, chapter 23). Many therefore taught, as the next passage reports, ἀπείρους κόσμους ἐν τῷ ἀπείρῳ (*infinitos mundos in infinito*; “infinite worlds in the infinite”). This is also the sense of Kant's argument for the antithesis, distorted by scholastic and contorted presentation. The same argument could be used against the world's temporal limits if causality did not provide a much better

one. A spatially limited world also prompts the unanswerable question why the filled portion should be privileged over the infinite space left empty. Giordano Bruno gives a detailed and very readable discussion on both sides of the world's finitude in the fifth dialogue of *Del infinito, universo e mondi* (*On the Infinite, the Universe and Worlds*). Kant himself seriously affirms the world's spatial infinity on objective grounds in *Universal Natural History and Theory of the Heavens*, part 2, chapter 7. Aristotle agrees in *Physics*, III, chapter 4; this and the following chapters repay reading in connection with the antinomy.

The thesis in the second antinomy immediately begs the question, and not subtly: “Every composite substance consists of simple parts.” Once composition has been assumed arbitrarily, proving simple parts is easy. But the claim that “all matter is composed” is precisely what needs proof and receives none. What opposes simple is not composite, but extended, having parts, divisible. Here it is silently assumed that parts existed before the whole and were brought together to make it; “composite” says just that. But we cannot assert it any more than its opposite. Divisibility means only that a whole can be divided into parts, not that it arose by assembling them. It asserts parts *a parte post* (afterward), whereas composition asserts them *a parte ante* (beforehand). Parts and whole are not essentially related in time; they condition each other and are simultaneous, since what is extended spatially exists only with both. Kant's note on the thesis, that space should be called a *totum* (whole) rather than a *compositum* (composite), holds just as much for matter, which is only space made perceptible. Matter's infinite divisibility, maintained by the antithesis, follows *a priori* and undeniably from the infinite divisibility of the space it fills. Nothing stands against this proposition. Kant himself presents it as objective truth at p. 513; fifth edition p. 541, where he speaks seriously in his own name rather than as spokesman for the ἄδικος λόγος (unjust argument). In *Metaphysical Foundations of Natural Science*, p. 108 of the first edition, “matter is infinitely divisible” also heads the proof of the first proposition of mechanics as established truth, having appeared and been proved earlier as the fourth proposition of dynamics. Here, however, Kant spoils the proof of the antithesis with exceedingly confused exposition and a flood of useless words, cunningly preventing its evident truth from too thoroughly eclipsing the thesis's sophisms. Atoms are no necessary thought of reason, merely a hypothesis to explain differences in specific weight. Kant himself showed in the Dynamics of his *Metaphysical Foundations* how these could be explained differently, indeed better and more simply than by atomism. Priestley had done so before him in

On Matter and Spirit, section 1; Aristotle already has the basic idea in *Physics*, IV, 9.

The argument for the third thesis is a very subtle sophism, Kant's supposed principle of pure reason itself, undiluted and unchanged. It tries to prove a finite series of causes from the claim that a cause, to be *sufficient*, must include the full sum of conditions producing the subsequent state, the effect. Into this completeness of determinations existing *together* in the causal state, it slips the completeness of the causal series through which that state itself became actual. Since completeness supposedly requires closure and therefore finitude, it infers a first, unconditioned cause closing the series. The trick is obvious. To understand state A as a sufficient cause of B, I assume it contains all the required determinations whose conjunction inevitably produces B. This fully satisfies my demand that A be a *sufficient* cause. How A itself became actual is a different question, with no immediate connection to the first. In the new inquiry I no longer treat A as a cause, but as an effect needing another state related to it as it was to B. Nowhere does this require a finite causal series or first beginning, just as the present moment does not presuppose a beginning of time. An idle speculator adds that assumption. To say it lies in calling a cause a *sufficient ground* is a false smuggling-in, as I showed in examining Kant's principle of reason, identical with this thesis. To illustrate the false thesis, Kant even offers his rising from a chair as an unconditioned beginning, as if he could rise without a motive any more than a ball could roll without a cause. I need hardly use Lucan, the Eleatics, and others, much less the Hindus, to show the weakness of his appeal to ancient philosophers, prompted by a sense of weakness. As in the earlier antinomies, nothing can be objected to the antithesis's proof.

As noted, the fourth antinomy is essentially a repetition of the third. Its thesis has substantially the same proof. The claim that every conditioned thing presupposes a complete *series* of conditions ending in an unconditioned is a *petitio principii* (begging of the question) to be denied outright. A conditioned thing presupposes only its condition. Asking whether that condition is conditioned opens a new inquiry not immediately contained in the first.

The Antinomy has a certain plausibility. Remarkably, however, no part of Kant's philosophy has met so little opposition or won so much approval as this highly paradoxical doctrine. Nearly every philosophical party and textbook has accepted, repeated, and even developed it, while almost all his other teachings have been challenged. There have even been odd thinkers who rejected the

Transcendental Aesthetic. The Antinomy's unanimous welcome may be due to the inward pleasure some take in contemplating a point where understanding is supposed to stop because it encounters something that both is and is not. They seem to see before them the sixth trick performed by the conjurer Philadelphus on Lichtenberg's bill.

Kant's subsequent *Critical Resolution* of the cosmological dispute, when we examine its true meaning, is not what he claims: that both sides start from false assumptions, so that in the first two disputes both are wrong and in the last two both are right. It actually confirms the antitheses by clarifying their claims.

First, Kant wrongly maintains that both parties start from the premise that the conditioned brings with it the complete, closed *series* of its conditions. Only the *thesis* bases itself on this proposition, Kant's pure principle of reason. The antithesis expressly denies it at every point and maintains the opposite. Kant further accuses both parties of assuming the world exists in itself, independently of being known and of the forms of cognition. Once again, only the thesis assumes this. The antithesis depends so little on it that the two are incompatible. It directly contradicts the concept of an infinite series to be wholly given. Such a series essentially exists only in relation to traversing it, not independently of that process. Assuming definite limits, on the other hand, assumes a whole existing in itself and independently of measuring it. Only the thesis thus wrongly assumes a world-whole existing in itself before all cognition, to which cognition is merely added. From the beginning the antithesis contests this assumption: the endlessness it attributes to series under the principle of sufficient reason exists only insofar as the regress is performed, not independently. As an object generally presupposes a subject, an object determined as an *endless* chain of conditions necessarily presupposes in the subject its corresponding mode of cognition: *continually following* the chain's links. This is precisely Kant's repeatedly stated solution: "The infinity of the world's magnitude exists only *through* the regress, not *before* it." His solution actually decides for the antithesis, which already contains that truth, and is wholly incompatible with the thesis.

Had the antithesis asserted that the world consists of infinite series of grounds and consequences yet exists independently of representation and its regressive series, in itself as a given whole, it would contradict both the thesis and itself. An infinite thing can never be *wholly* given; an *endless* series exists only as it is traversed without end; something without limits cannot make a whole. Only the thesis makes the assumption Kant says misled both parties.

Aristotle already taught that an infinite thing cannot exist *actu* (actually, as a completed given), only *potentia* (potentially): Οὐκ ἔστιν ἐνεργεία εἶναι τὸ ἄπειρον — — — — ἀλλ’ ἀδύνατον τὸ ἐντελεχείᾳ ὄν ἄπειρον (*infinitum non potest esse actu ... sed impossibile, actu esse infinitum*; “The infinite cannot exist as an actual thing ... it is impossible for an infinite thing to be actual”) (*Metaphysics*, K, 10). Again: κατ’ ἐνέργειαν μὲν γὰρ οὐδέν ἐστιν ἄπειρον, δυνάμει δὲ ἐπὶ τὴν διαίρεσιν (*nihil enim actu infinitum est, sed potentia tantum, nempe divisione ipsa*; “Nothing infinite exists actually, but only potentially, in division itself”) (*On Generation and Corruption*, I, 3). He develops this at length in *Physics*, III, 5–6, virtually giving the right solution to all the antinomies. He states them in his concise way, says “an arbitrator (διατητοῦ) is needed,” and resolves them: the infinite in the world's space, time, and divisibility exists never *before* regress or progress, only *in* it. The truth is therefore already contained in the rightly understood concept of the infinite. We misunderstand ourselves if we think any sort of infinite is something objectively present and finished, independent of the regress.

Indeed, beginning with Kant's own supposed resolution produces the antithesis directly. If the world is no unconditioned whole, existing not in itself but only in representation, and if its series of grounds and consequences exist not *before* but only *through* our regress through them, then those series cannot be definite and finite. Definite limits would have to exist independently of the representation subsequently added. All series must therefore be endless, incapable of exhaustion by any representation.

At p. 506; fifth edition p. 534, Kant tries to infer the transcendental ideality of appearance from both parties' being wrong. He begins, “If the world is a whole existing in itself, it is either finite or infinite.” This is false: a whole existing in itself cannot possibly be infinite. One could instead infer ideality from the infinity of worldly series as follows. If series of grounds and consequences in the world are wholly endless, the world cannot be a given whole independent of representation. Such a whole always presupposes definite limits, while infinite series presuppose an endless regress. The supposed infinity of series must therefore be determined by the form of ground and consequence, which is determined by the subject's mode of cognition. The world as known thus exists only in the subject's representation.

I cannot say whether Kant knew that his Critical Resolution actually favored the antithesis. It depends on whether what Schelling aptly called Kant's system

of accommodation went so far, or whether his mind had unconsciously accommodated itself to the influence of his age and surroundings.

The resolution of the third antinomy, whose subject is freedom, deserves special attention. Remarkably for us, it is here, with the Idea of *freedom*, that Kant must speak more fully of the *thing in itself*, until now in the background. This is readily intelligible after we have recognized the thing in itself as *will*. Here Kant's philosophy points toward mine, or mine grows from it as from a trunk. Attentive reading of the *Critique of Pure Reason*, pp. 536–537; fifth edition pp. 564–565, will show this. Compare the introduction to the *Critique of Judgment*, pp. XVIII–XIX of the third edition or p. 13 of Rosenkranz's, which even says: "The concept of freedom can represent in its object [surely the will] a thing in itself, though not in intuition; by contrast, the concept of nature can represent its object in intuition, though not as a thing in itself." Above all, read §53 of the *Prolegomena* on the solution of the antinomies and ask sincerely whether everything there does not sound like a riddle to which my doctrine provides the answer. Kant did not think his matter through to the end; I have carried it out. I accordingly extended to all appearances, which differ from the human one only in degree, Kant's statement about human appearance: its essence in itself is absolutely free, that is, a will. The fertility of this insight joined to his teaching on the ideality of space, time, and causality is clear from my work.

Kant nowhere devotes a distinct analysis or clear derivation to the thing in itself. Whenever he needs it, he immediately draws it in by inferring that appearance, the visible world, must have a ground or intelligible cause that is not appearance and thus belongs to no possible experience. He does this after insisting repeatedly that the categories, including causality, apply only within possible experience. They are merely forms of understanding used to spell out sensory appearances and have no meaning beyond them. He strictly forbids applying them to what lies beyond experience and rightly explains and overthrows all earlier dogmatism as a breach of that rule. Kant's incredible inconsistency was quickly noticed by his earliest opponents, who used it in attacks his philosophy could not resist. We do indeed apply the causal law wholly *a priori*, before any experience, to changes sensed in our organs. But for that reason it is subjective in origin, just like the sensations themselves, and cannot lead to the thing in itself.

The truth is that representation can never take us beyond representation. It is a closed whole, with no thread in its own means leading to the essence of the

thing in itself, which differs from it *toto genere* (in kind altogether). Were we beings that only represented, the path to the thing in itself would be entirely closed. Only the other side of our own being can disclose the other side of things' essence in itself. That is the path I took. Kant's inference to the thing in itself, though forbidden by his own rule, gains some appearance of justification in this way. He does not simply and absolutely make object depend on subject, and subject on object, as truth requires. He makes only the *manner of the object's appearance* depend on the subject's cognitive forms, which can therefore be conscious *a priori*. What is known only *a posteriori*, in contrast, he already takes as an immediate effect of the thing in itself, becoming appearance only on passing through those *a priori* forms. This may explain why he missed that being an object at all belongs to appearance's form and is conditioned by being a subject at all, just as the object's manner of appearing is conditioned by the subject's cognitive forms. If a thing in itself is assumed, it cannot be an object either, as he always presupposes. It must lie in a realm wholly different *toto genere* from representation, knowing and being known, and can least of all be inferred under laws linking objects to one another.

Kant's proof of the thing in itself met the same fate as his proof that the causal law is *a priori*. Both doctrines are true, but their proofs are false: correct conclusions from false premises. I have retained both while grounding them quite differently and securely.

I have neither smuggled in nor inferred the thing in itself by laws that exclude it, since those laws already belong to its appearance; nor have I reached it by any roundabout route. Rather, I have pointed it out immediately where it immediately lies: in the will, which reveals itself to everyone directly as the in-itself of his own appearance.

It is also from this immediate knowledge of one's own will that the concept of *freedom* arises in human consciousness. For the will as creator of the world, as thing in itself, is indeed free from the principle of sufficient reason and thus from all necessity: it is wholly independent, free, even omnipotent. Strictly speaking, however, this is true only of the will in itself, not of its appearances, the individuals, who, precisely through the will itself, are already unalterably determined as its appearances in time. Ordinary consciousness, not clarified by philosophy, at once confuses the will with its appearance and attributes to the latter what belongs only to the former. Thus arises the illusion of the individual's unconditional freedom. For just this reason Spinoza rightly says that even a thrown stone, if it had consciousness, would believe it was flying of

its own free will. For the in-itself of the stone too is indeed the one free will; but here, as in all its appearances, where it appears as a stone it is already entirely determined. Enough has already been said about all this in the main body of this work.

Kant, failing to recognize or notice this immediate origin of the concept of freedom in every human consciousness, instead places its origin, at p. 533; V, 561, in a very subtle speculation. According to him, the unconditioned, toward which reason is always supposed to strive, occasions the hypostatization of the concept of freedom; and it is only on this transcendent idea of freedom that the practical concept of it is supposed to rest. In the *Critique of Practical Reason*, § 6, and at p. 185 of the fourth edition, p. 235 of Rosenkranz's edition, however, he derives this latter concept differently again, from the categorical imperative's presupposition of it. On this account the speculative idea would be merely the first origin of the concept of freedom, while here it would first acquire its proper meaning and application. Neither account is right. The illusion that the individual is perfectly free in each of his actions is most vividly held by the most uncultivated person, who has never reflected; it is therefore founded on no speculation, though it is often carried into speculation. Those free of this illusion are only philosophers, and indeed the most profound philosophers, as well as the most thoughtful and enlightened writers of the Church.

In view of all that has been said, the true origin of the concept of freedom is in no essential respect an inference, whether from the speculative idea of an unconditioned cause or from the categorical imperative's presupposition of it. It springs directly from consciousness, in which everyone immediately knows himself as *will*: as that which, being a thing in itself, does not have the principle of sufficient reason as its form, and which itself depends on nothing, while everything else depends on it. Yet, lacking philosophical criticism and reflection, he does not at the same time distinguish himself, as an appearance of this will already entered into time and determined—one might say a force of will—from the will to life itself. Hence, instead of recognizing his whole existence as an act of his freedom, he looks for that freedom in his individual actions. On this point I refer to my prize essay on the freedom of the will.

If Kant had merely inferred the thing in itself, as he claims here and apparently did on earlier occasions, and had done so with the great inconsistency of an inference he himself absolutely forbade, what a strange coincidence it would be that here, where for the first time he approaches the thing in itself more closely and illuminates it, he at once recognizes in it the

will: the free will that manifests itself in the world only through temporal appearances! I therefore actually assume, although it cannot be proved, that whenever Kant spoke of the thing in itself, in the darkest depths of his mind he was already thinking, indistinctly, of the will. Some evidence for this is given in the preface to the second edition of the *Critique of Pure Reason*, pp. XXVII–XXVIII, or p. 677 of the supplements in Rosenkranz's edition.

Moreover, it is this intended solution of the supposed third conflict that gives Kant the opportunity to express beautifully the deepest thoughts of his entire philosophy. He does so throughout the “Sixth Section of the Antinomy of Pure Reason,” but above all in the exposition of the contrast between empirical and intelligible character, pp. 534–550; V, 562–578, which I count among the finest things ever said by a human being. (A parallel passage in the *Critique of Practical Reason*, pp. 169–179 of the fourth edition, or pp. 224–231 of Rosenkranz's edition, should be read as a supplementary explanation.) It is all the more regrettable, then, that these thoughts do not stand in the right place. In part, they were not reached by the path the exposition describes, and should therefore be derived differently; in part, they do not fulfill the purpose for which they appear here, namely the solution of the supposed antinomy. From the appearance Kant infers its intelligible ground, the thing in itself, by the inconsistent application of the category of causality beyond all appearance that I have already criticized at length. For this case he presents the human will as the thing in itself—calling it *reason*, quite unjustifiably and in an inexcusable violation of ordinary usage—and appeals to an unconditional ought, the categorical imperative, which he simply postulates.

Instead, the plain and open procedure would have been to start directly from the will and show it to be the in-itself of our own appearance, known without any mediation. One could then give that account of empirical and intelligible character, showing how all actions, though necessitated by motives, are nevertheless necessarily and unconditionally attributed, both by their agent and by another who judges them, to that agent alone, as depending solely on him, so that guilt and merit are assigned to him accordingly. This was the only direct path to knowledge of what is not appearance and hence cannot be discovered according to the laws of appearance, but is what reveals itself, becomes knowable, and objectifies itself through appearance: the will to life. By analogy alone, it should then have been presented as the in-itself of every appearance. But Kant could then certainly not have said (p. 546; V, 574) that in inanimate, and even in animal, nature no faculty can be thought of except as conditioned

by the senses. In Kant's language this really means that explanation by the law of causality exhausts even the innermost essence of those appearances; thus, quite inconsistently, the thing in itself disappears in their case. Kant's placing of the thing in itself in the wrong position, and the circuitous derivation that follows from it, have also falsified the whole concept. For when the will, or thing in itself, is reached through a search for an unconditioned cause, it enters into the relation of cause to effect with appearance. But this relation obtains only *within* appearance and therefore already presupposes it. It cannot join appearance itself to what lies outside it and differs from it *toto genere* (in kind altogether).

Furthermore, the announced aim of solving the third antinomy is not achieved by deciding that both sides are right, each in a different sense. For neither thesis nor antithesis speaks of the thing in itself: both speak throughout of appearance, the objective world, the world as representation. It is of this, and nothing else, that the thesis seeks to prove, by the sophism already exposed, that it contains unconditioned causes; and of this same world the antithesis rightly denies it. The entire account of the transcendental freedom of the will, insofar as it is a thing in itself, offered here in defense of the thesis is therefore, however excellent in itself, quite literally a μετάβασις εἰς ἄλλο γένος (a shift to another kind of subject). The transcendental freedom of the will described here is by no means the unconditioned causality of a cause asserted by the thesis. A cause must essentially be an appearance, not something lying beyond all appearance and differing from it *toto genere* (in kind altogether).

When cause and effect are under discussion, the relation of the will to its appearance—or of intelligible to empirical character—must never be introduced, as it is here, for it is entirely different from the causal relation. Nevertheless this solution of the antinomy also says, correctly, that the empirical character of a human being, like that of every other cause in nature, is unalterably determined and that actions consequently issue from it of necessity in accordance with external influences. Thus, despite all transcendental freedom—that is, the independence of the will in itself from the laws connecting its appearances—no human being has the power to begin a series of actions of himself, although this is precisely what the thesis asserted. Freedom, then, has no causality either. Only the will is free, and it lies outside nature or appearance, which is merely its objectivation; it does not stand in a causal relation to appearance. That relation is first found within appearance, and so already presupposes it: it cannot include appearance itself and join it to what is

expressly not appearance. The world itself can be explained only from the will, since it is the will itself insofar as it appears, and not by causality. But *in the world* causality is the sole principle of explanation, and everything happens solely according to laws of nature. Right is therefore entirely on the side of the antithesis, which keeps to the subject under discussion and uses the principle of explanation valid for it; it needs no defense. The thesis, by contrast, can be defended only by moving away from the question: first by leaping to something altogether different from what was asked about, and then by carrying over to it a principle of explanation that cannot be applied there.

The fourth conflict, as I have said, is in its innermost meaning a repetition of the third. In its solution Kant develops still further the untenability of the thesis. Yet he gives no reason for its truth or for its supposed compatibility with the antithesis, just as he can offer nothing against the antithesis. He introduces the assumption of the thesis almost as a plea, although he himself calls it (p. 562; V, 590) an arbitrary presupposition whose object might well be impossible in itself. He merely makes a quite feeble attempt to find some safe corner for it against the antithesis's overwhelming force, so as to avoid revealing the emptiness of the whole claim, once he has grown attached to it, that human reason necessarily falls into antinomy.

Next comes the chapter on the transcendental ideal, which suddenly transports us back into the rigid scholasticism of the Middle Ages. One seems to hear Anselm of Canterbury himself. The *ens realissimum* (most real being), the sum of all realities and the content of all affirmative propositions, appears with the claim to be a necessary thought of reason! For my part, I must confess that such a thought is impossible for my reason and that the words meant to express it give me no definite idea.

I do not doubt, moreover, that Kant was driven to this strange chapter, so unworthy of him, solely by his fondness for architectural symmetry. The three main objects of scholastic philosophy—which, as I have said, can in the broader sense be taken to extend up to Kant—soul, world, and God, were to be derived from the three possible major premises of syllogisms. Yet plainly they arose, and can arise, solely through an unconditional application of the principle of sufficient reason. Once the soul had been forced into the categorical judgment and the hypothetical judgment had been used for the world, nothing remained for the third idea but the disjunctive major premise. Fortunately there was some earlier material to hand: the scholastics' *ens realissimum*, together with the ontological proof of God's existence, outlined by Anselm of Canterbury and

then perfected by Descartes. Kant gladly made use of it, perhaps also recalling a Latin work of his youth. But the sacrifice he makes to his love of architectural symmetry in this chapter is exceedingly great. In defiance of all truth, the grotesque notion—one must call it that—of a sum of all possible realities is made an essential and necessary thought of reason. To derive it Kant takes up the false claim that our knowledge of individual things arises by progressively narrowing general concepts, and hence also a most general concept containing all reality *within itself*. In this he contradicts his own teaching as much as the truth. Our knowledge proceeds in just the opposite way, extending from the individual to the universal. Every general concept arises by abstraction from actual individual things known in intuition. Abstraction can proceed up to the most general concept, which then comprises everything *under* it but almost nothing *within* it. Kant has thus turned the procedure of our cognitive faculty upside down. He might even be accused of having provided an occasion for a philosophical charlatanry made famous in our own day: instead of recognizing concepts as thoughts abstracted from things, it makes concepts primary and sees in things only concrete concepts. In this way it puts an inverted world on the market as a philosophical farce, which naturally was bound to win great applause.

Even if we assume that every reason must, or at least can, arrive at the concept of God without revelation, it clearly does so only by following the thread of causality; this is so evident that it needs no proof. Thus Christian Wolff too says (*Cosmologia generalis*, preface, p. 1): *Sane in theologia naturali existentiam Numinis e principiis cosmologicis demonstramus. Contingentia universi et ordinis naturae, una cum impossibilitate casus, sunt scala, per quam a mundo hoc a adspectabili Deum ascenditur* (“Indeed, in natural theology we demonstrate the existence of the Deity from cosmological principles. The contingency of the universe and of the order of nature, together with the impossibility of chance, are the ladder by which one ascends from this visible world to God”). Before him Leibniz said of the law of causality: *Sans ce grand principe nous ne pourrions jamais prouver l'existence de Dieu* (“Without this great principle we could never prove the existence of God”; *Théodicée*, § 44). Likewise, in his controversy with Clarke, § 126: *J'ose dire que sans ce grand principe on ne saurait venir à la preuve de l'existence de Dieu* (“I venture to say that without this great principle one could not arrive at a proof of God's existence”). By contrast, the thought developed in this chapter is so far from being essential and necessary to reason that it must be regarded as a real

masterpiece among the monstrous productions of an age driven by strange circumstances onto the strangest wrong paths and into the strangest errors, as the scholastic age was: an age without parallel in world history, which can never recur. It is true that scholasticism, when fully developed, based its chief proof of God's existence on the concept of the *ens realissimum*, using the other proofs only as accessories. But that is merely a method of teaching and proves nothing about the origin of theology in the human mind. Kant has mistaken the procedure of scholasticism for that of reason, as he has done on other occasions too. If the idea of God really arose, according to essential laws of reason, from the disjunctive syllogism in the form of an idea of the most real being, it would have occurred among the philosophers of antiquity as well. Yet there is no trace of the *ens realissimum* in any ancient philosopher. Some do indeed teach a maker of the world, but only as a shaper of matter that existed independently of him, a δημιουργός (demiurge); and they infer him solely according to the law of causality. Sextus Empiricus (*Adversus mathematicos*, IX, § 88) does report an argument of *Cleanthes* which some have taken for the ontological proof. It is no such thing, but merely an inference by analogy: experience teaches that on earth *one* being is always more excellent than another and that the human being, as the most excellent, completes the series, though still with many defects. There must therefore be a still more excellent being and finally one most excellent of all, κράτιστον, ἄριστον ("strongest, best"); and that would be God.

As for the extensive refutation of speculative theology that now follows, I have only this brief observation. Like the entire critique of the three so-called ideas of reason—that is, the whole Dialectic of Pure Reason—it is in a sense the goal and purpose of the entire work. Yet this polemical part lacks the wholly general, lasting, and purely philosophical interest of the preceding doctrinal part, the Aesthetic and Analytic. It is more bound to its time and place, because it relates specifically to the chief features of the philosophy prevailing in Europe up to Kant. His complete overthrow of that philosophy through this polemic nevertheless remains to his immortal credit. He eliminated theism from philosophy, which, as a science and not a doctrine of faith, can give a place only to what is either empirically given or established by sound proofs. Naturally I mean philosophy genuinely and seriously pursued, directed toward truth and nothing else, not the sham philosophy of the universities. In that philosophy speculative theology still plays the leading role, as before; and the soul still appears without ceremony as if it were a familiar person. For it is a philosophy endowed with salaries, fees, and even the titles of court councillor. Looking

proudly down from its heights, it has failed to notice people like me for forty years, and would gladly be rid of old *Kant* and his critiques too, so that it could loudly celebrate Leibniz once more. It should further be noted that, just as Kant admittedly was led to his teaching that the concept of causality is *a priori* by *Hume's* skepticism about that concept, Kant's critique of all speculative theology may likewise have been prompted by *Hume's* critique of all popular theology in his very readable *Natural History of Religion* and *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*. Kant may even have intended in a way to complete Hume's work. The former of Hume's writings is really a critique of popular theology: it seeks to expose its wretchedness while respectfully pointing instead to rational or speculative theology as the genuine article. Kant now exposes the groundlessness of the latter, while leaving popular theology untouched and even presenting it in an ennobled form as a faith supported by moral feeling. Later the philosophical dabblers distorted this into things supposedly heard by reason, consciousness of God, or intellectual intuitions of the supersensible or the deity, and the like. Kant, however, in pulling down venerable old errors and knowing the danger involved, had merely wanted to prop them up for the time being with a few weak supports from moral theology, so that the collapse would not fall on him and he could have time to get away.

As for the execution of the argument, no critique of reason was needed to refute the *ontological* proof of God's existence. Even without presupposing the Aesthetic and Analytic, it is easy to show clearly that this proof is nothing but a subtle play with concepts, devoid of all power to convince. Aristotle's *Organon* already contains a chapter that suffices so completely to refute the ontological proof that it might have been written for the purpose: chapter seven of the second book of the *Posterior Analytics*. Among other things, it expressly says: τὸ δὲ εἶναι οὐκ οὐσία οὐδενί ("being is the essence of nothing"); that is, *existentia nunquam ad essentiam rei pertinet* ("existence never belongs to the essence of a thing").

The refutation of the *cosmological* proof applies the teaching of the Critique presented up to that point to a particular case, and calls for no objection. The *physico-theological* proof is a mere expansion of the cosmological proof, which it presupposes; its detailed refutation comes only in the *Critique of Judgment*. On this matter I refer my reader to the section "Comparative Anatomy" in my work *On the Will in Nature*.

As I have said, in his critique of these proofs *Kant* is concerned solely with speculative theology and confines himself to the schools. If, however, he had

also considered life and popular theology, he would have had to add to the three proofs a fourth, the one that actually works on the great mass of people. In Kant's technical language the most fitting name for it might be the *ceraunological* proof. It rests on people's sense of needing help, of their powerlessness and dependence in the face of immensely superior, inscrutable, and usually threatening forces of nature. Added to this is their natural tendency to personify everything and, finally, the hope of achieving something through prayers and flattery, or even gifts. In every human undertaking there is something beyond our power and outside our calculation. The wish to win it over is the origin of the gods. *Primus in orbe Deos fecit timor* ("Fear first made gods in the world") is an old and true saying of Petronius. It is chiefly this proof that *Hume*, who appears throughout as Kant's forerunner, criticizes in the writings mentioned above. But those whom Kant has put in lasting difficulty by his critique of speculative theology are the professors of philosophy. Paid by Christian governments, they cannot abandon the central article of faith.^[8] How do these gentlemen manage? They simply assert that God's existence is self-evident. So! After the ancient world performed miracles to prove it at the cost of its conscience, and the modern world deployed ontological, cosmological, and physico-theological proofs at the cost of its understanding, for these gentlemen it is self-evident. And from this self-evident God they then explain the world: that is their philosophy.

Until *Kant*, a genuine dilemma stood between materialism and theism: either blind chance or an intelligence ordering things from outside according to purposes and concepts must have brought the world about; *neque dabatur tertium* ("and there was no third alternative"). Hence atheism and materialism were the same thing. Hence, too, the doubt whether an atheist could really exist: a person who could actually credit blind chance with nature's extraordinarily purposive arrangement, especially in organic nature. See, for example, Bacon's *Essays, or Counsels Civil and Moral*, essay 16, "Of Atheism." The opinion of the great mass and of the English—who in such matters belong entirely to the great mass, the *mob*—is still the same, even among their most celebrated scholars. One need only look at R. Owen's *Ostéologie comparée* (1855), preface, pp. 11–12, where he still confronts the old dilemma between Democritus and Epicurus on one side and an *intelligence* on the other, in which *la connaissance d'un être tel que l'homme a existé avant que l'homme fût son apparition* ("knowledge of a being such as man existed before man appeared"). All purposiveness must have proceeded from an *intelligence*: it has never even

occurred to him to doubt this. Indeed, in the lecture delivered at the *Académie des sciences* on 5 September 1853, a somewhat different version of this preface, he said with childlike naïveté: *la téléologie, ou la théologie scientifique* (“teleology, or scientific theology”; *Comptes rendus*, September 1853). To him they are immediately one and the same! If something in nature is purposive, then it is the work of intention, deliberation, intelligence. Of course, why should an Englishman or the *Académie des sciences* care about the *Critique of Judgment*, let alone my book *On the Will in Nature*? These gentlemen do not look that far down. Those *illustres confrères* (“illustrious colleagues”) despise metaphysics and *philosophie allemande* (“German philosophy”): they adhere to the philosophy of the distaff. Yet the validity of that disjunctive major premise, that dilemma between materialism and theism, rests on the assumption that the world before us is the world of things in themselves, and thus that there is no order of things other than the empirical one. Once Kant had made the world and its order mere appearance, whose laws rest chiefly on the forms of our intellect, the existence and essence of things and of the world no longer had to be explained by analogy with changes we perceive or bring about in the world. Nor did what we apprehend as means and end have to have arisen through knowledge of that kind. Thus Kant, by his important distinction between appearance and thing in itself, deprived theism of its foundation while opening the way to quite different and more profound explanations of existence.

In the chapter on the ultimate aims of the natural dialectic of reason, it is claimed that the three transcendent ideas are valuable as regulative principles for the advance of our knowledge of nature. But Kant can hardly have meant this seriously. Every natural scientist will at least be certain of the opposite: that such assumptions obstruct and stifle all investigation of nature. As one test, consider whether the assumption of a soul as an immaterial, simple, thinking substance would have helped or, rather, greatly hindered the truths so beautifully set out by *Cabanis* and the discoveries of *Flourens*, *Marshall Hall*, and *Charles Bell*. Indeed, Kant himself says (*Prolegomena*, § 44) that “the ideas of reason run counter to and hinder the maxims of reason's knowledge of nature.”

It is certainly among Frederick the Great's merits that under his rule Kant could develop his thought and publish the *Critique of Pure Reason*. A salaried professor would hardly have dared do such a thing under any other government. Kant had to promise the great king's successor that he would write no more.

I might regard myself as excused from criticizing the ethical part of Kant's philosophy here, since twenty-two years after the present critique I provided a fuller and more thorough one in *The Two Fundamental Problems of Ethics*. Nevertheless, what is retained here from the first edition could not have been omitted, if only for completeness, and can serve as a suitable prelude to that later and much more thorough critique, to which I accordingly refer the reader for the main argument.

In keeping with his love of architectural symmetry, theoretical reason had to have a *pendant* (counterpart). The scholastics' *intellectus practicus* (practical intellect), itself descended from Aristotle's νοῦς πρακτικός (practical intellect; *De anima*, III, 10, and *Politics*, VII, ch. 14: μὲν γὰρ πρακτικός ἐστι λόγος, ὁ δὲ θεωρητικός, “one kind of reason is practical, the other theoretical”), supplied the name. Here, however, it denotes something quite different: not reason directed toward technique, as it did there. Practical reason now appears as the source and origin of the undeniable ethical significance of human action and of all virtue, all nobility of character, and every attainable degree of holiness. All this would therefore come from *reason* alone and require nothing but reason. To act rationally and to act virtuously, nobly, or holily would be one and the same thing; to act selfishly, maliciously, or viciously would merely be to act irrationally. Yet all ages, peoples, and languages have always distinguished the two and regarded them as entirely different things. So does everyone who knows nothing of the language of the modern school—that is, the whole world except a small group of German scholars. All of these people understand a virtuous way of life and a rational course of life as two quite different things. To call the exalted founder of the Christian religion, whose life is offered to us as the model of all virtue, the *most rational* of human beings would be considered a most unworthy, perhaps even blasphemous expression. Almost the same would be true of saying that his precepts contain merely the best instructions for a thoroughly *rational life*. Again, everyone rightly reveres the person who, following those precepts, does not think ahead of himself and his own future needs, but always relieves the greater present need of others without further concern, and even gives away all his possessions to the poor before going, stripped of every resource, to preach to others the virtue he himself has practiced. But who dares praise this as the height of *rationality*? And, finally, who praises as an exceptionally *rational* deed Arnold von Winkelried's supreme nobility in gathering the enemy's spears against his own body to secure victory and rescue for his countrymen? By contrast, suppose we see a man who from

his youth takes exceptional care to secure the means of a life free from worry, support for his wife and children, a good name, and public honor and distinction. He does not let himself be diverted by the lure of present pleasures, the thrill of defying the arrogance of the powerful, the wish to avenge insults or undeserved humiliations, the attraction of useless aesthetic or philosophical pursuits, or travel to countries worth seeing. None of this makes him lose sight of his aim; with great consistency he works for it alone. Who would deny that such a philistine is extraordinarily *rational*, even if he has allowed himself some discreditable but risk-free means? More than this: suppose a villain, through calculating cunning and a carefully thought-out plan, helps himself to riches, honors, even thrones and crowns. Then with the finest guile he entangles neighboring states, subdues them one by one, and becomes a conqueror of the world. He is never distracted by considerations of justice or humanity but relentlessly tramples and crushes whatever opposes his plan. Without pity he plunges millions into every kind of misery and millions into bloodshed and death, yet rewards his followers and helpers royally and always protects them, forgetting nothing, until he achieves his aim. Who does not see that such a man must have proceeded with consummate rationality? The plans required a powerful understanding, but their execution required perfect command of *reason*, indeed *practical reason* in the strictest sense. Or are the counsels that the clever, consistent, reflective, and farsighted Machiavelli gives his prince perhaps *irrational*?^[9]

Just as malice is perfectly compatible with reason, and indeed becomes truly terrible in combination with it, nobility of character is sometimes found together with irrationality. The action of Coriolanus may be counted as such a case. After years spent exerting all his powers to take revenge on the Romans, he finally has his opportunity, yet allows the pleas of the Senate and the tears of his mother and wife to soften him. He gives up the revenge so long and laboriously prepared, and even draws the just anger of the Volsci upon himself, dying for the very Romans whose ingratitude he knows and had worked so hard to punish. For completeness, let me add that reason can also be combined with a lack of understanding. This happens when one chooses a foolish maxim but follows it consistently. An example was Princess Isabella, daughter of Philip II, who vowed not to put on a clean shirt until Ostend was conquered and kept her word for three years. All vows belong here in general: they originate in a failure to understand the law of causality, that is, in a lack of understanding. Even so,

fulfilling them is rational once one has been so limited in understanding as to make them.

In keeping with these examples, writers appearing shortly before *Kant* set conscience, the seat of moral impulses, against reason. Thus *Rousseau* says in book four of *Émile: La raison nous trompe, mais la conscience ne trompe jamais* (“Reason deceives us, but conscience never deceives”); and a little later: *il est impossible d'expliquer par les conséquences de notre nature le principe immédiat de la conscience indépendant de la raison même* (“It is impossible to explain through the consequences of our nature the immediate principle of conscience, independent even of reason”). Later still: *Mes sentimens naturels parlaient pour l'intérêt commun, ma raison rapportait tout à moi. — — On a beau vouloir établir la vertu par la raison seule, quelle solide base peut-on lui donner?* (“My natural feelings spoke for the common interest; my reason referred everything to myself. However much one wishes to establish virtue by reason alone, what solid basis can one give it?”). In the *Reveries of the Solitary Walker*, fourth walk, he says: *Dans toutes les questions de morale difficiles je me suis toujours bien trouvé de les résoudre par le dictamen de la conscience, plutôt que par les lumières de la raison* (“In all difficult moral questions I have always done well to settle them by the dictate of conscience rather than the lights of reason”). Indeed, *Aristotle* expressly says (*Magna Moralia*, I, 5) that the virtues have their seat in the ἀλόγῳ μορίῳ τῆς ψυχῆς, *in parte irrationali animi* (“irrational part of the soul”), not in the λόγον ἔχοντι, *in parte rationali* (“rational part”). Accordingly *Stobaeus*, speaking of the Peripatetics (*Eclogae*, II, ch. 7), says: Τὴν ἠθικὴν ἀρετὴν ὑπολαμβάνουσι περὶ τὸ ἄλογον μέρος γίνεσθαι τῆς ψυχῆς, ἐπειδὴ διμερὴ πρὸς τὴν παρούσαν θεωρίαν ὑπέθεντο τὴν ψυχὴν, τὸ μὲν λογικὸν ἔχουσιν, τὸ δ’ ἄλογον. Καὶ περὶ μὲν τὸ λογικὸν τὴν καλοκαγαθίαν γίνεσθαι, καὶ τὴν φρόνησιν, καὶ τὴν ἀγχίνοιαν, καὶ σοφίαν, καὶ εὐμάθειαν, καὶ μνήμην, καὶ τὰς ὁμοίους· περὶ δὲ τὸ ἄλογον, σωφροσύνην, καὶ δικαιοσύνην, καὶ ἀνδρείαν, καὶ τὰς ἄλλας τὰς ἠθικὰς καλουμένας ἀρετάς.^[†] (In Latin: *Ethicam virtutem circa partem, animae ratione carentem versari putant, cum duplicem, ad hanc disquisitionem, animam ponant, ratione praeditam, et ea carentem. In parte vero ratione praedita collocant ingenuitatem, prudentiam, perspicacitatem, sapientiam, docilitatem, memoriam et reliqua; in parte vero ratione destituta temperantiam, justitiam, fortitudinem, et reliquas virtutes, quas ethicas vocant.* “They hold that ethical virtue belongs to the part of the soul without reason, since for this inquiry they posit a soul with two parts, one endowed with reason and one without it. In the rational part they

place nobility, prudence, quickness of insight, wisdom, teachability, memory, and the like; in the part without reason, temperance, justice, courage, and the other virtues called ethical.”) And *Cicero* argues at length (*De natura deorum*, III, chs. 26–31) that reason is the necessary means and instrument of every crime.

I have defined *reason* as the *faculty of concepts*. This distinctive class of general representations, which are not intuitive but are symbolized and fixed only by words, distinguishes human beings from animals and gives them mastery over the earth. The animal is the slave of the present. It knows no motives but those immediately given through the senses and, when they appear, is drawn to or repelled by them as necessarily as iron by a magnet. In human beings, by contrast, the gift of reason gives rise to reflection. It lets them look backward and forward, easily survey their own lives and the course of the world as a whole, become independent of the present, and act deliberately, according to a plan and with forethought, for evil as well as for good. Whatever a person does, however, he does with complete self-consciousness: he knows exactly how his will decides, what he chooses in each case, and what other choice was objectively possible. From his self-conscious willing he comes to know himself and sees himself reflected in his deeds. In all these relations to human action, reason may be called *practical*. It is theoretical only when the objects with which it deals bear no relation to the thinker's actions and have merely theoretical interest, of which very few people are capable. What in this sense is called *practical reason* is fairly well expressed by the Latin *prudentia* (prudence), which according to *Cicero* (*De natura deorum*, II, 22) is a contraction of *providentia* (foresight). *Ratio* (reason), by contrast, when used of a mental power, usually means theoretical reason proper, although the ancients did not observe the distinction strictly. In almost everyone reason has an almost exclusively practical direction. But if even this is abandoned, thought loses command over action; then one says, *scio meliora, proboque, deteriora sequor* (“I know and approve the better, but follow the worse”), or *le matin je fais des projets, et le soir je fais des sottises* (“in the morning I make plans, and in the evening I do foolish things”). When a person allows his actions to be guided by the impression of the present rather than by his thought, almost as an animal does, he is called *irrational*. This does not impute moral wickedness to him. What he really lacks is not reason but its application to his actions; one might say that his reason is merely theoretical, not practical. He may still be an excellent person, like someone who cannot see an unfortunate person without

helping him, even at a sacrifice, yet leaves his debts unpaid. Such an irrational character is quite incapable of great crimes, because the planning, dissimulation, and self-control always needed for them are beyond him. He is also unlikely, however, to achieve a very high degree of virtue. However strongly disposed toward good he may be by nature, the occasional vicious and malicious impulses to which everyone is subject are bound to arise. Unless reason operates practically, opposing them with unchanging maxims and firm resolutions, those impulses must become actions.

Finally, *reason* shows itself as *practical* in the strictest sense in truly rational characters, whom ordinary life therefore calls practical philosophers. They are distinguished by extraordinary calm in unpleasant as well as pleasant events, an even temper, and steady adherence to decisions once made. What prevails in them is reason: knowledge that is more abstract than intuitive and therefore enables them, through concepts, to survey life generally and as a whole. It has taught them once and for all the deceptiveness of momentary impressions, the impermanence of all things, the brevity of life, the emptiness of pleasures, the changes of fortune, and the great and small tricks of chance. Nothing therefore comes unexpectedly to them. What they know *in abstracto* (in the abstract) does not surprise or disconcert them when they encounter it in reality and in particular cases. Less rational characters, by contrast, are so strongly affected by the present, the intuitive, and the actual that cold and colorless concepts recede entirely into the background of consciousness. Forgetting resolutions and maxims, they are at the mercy of feelings and passions of every kind. At the end of the first book I already explained that, in my view, Stoic ethics was originally nothing but instruction in a genuinely rational life in this sense. Horace repeatedly commends such a life in many places. His *Nil admirari* (“Be astonished at nothing”) belongs here, as does the Delphic Μηδὲν ἄγαν (“Nothing in excess”). To translate *Nil admirari* as “Admire nothing” is quite wrong. Horace's saying concerns practice more than theory. Its actual meaning is: “Do not value anything unconditionally; become infatuated with nothing; do not believe that possessing anything can confer happiness. Every inexpressible craving for an object is only a teasing chimera, which can be dispelled just as well, and much more easily, by clearer knowledge than by gaining possession.” Cicero too uses *admirari* in this sense in *De divinatione*, II, 2. What Horace means, then, is the ἀθαμβία and ἀκαταπληξία, also ἀθασμασία (“freedom from alarm, from being overwhelmed, and from astonishment”), which Democritus already praised as the highest good (see Clement of Alexandria, *Stromata*, II,

21, and compare Strabo, I, pp. 98 and 105). Virtue and vice are not really at issue in a life rational in this way. But this practical use of reason brings into play the genuine advantage humans have over animals, and only in this respect does it make sense and become permissible to speak of human dignity.

In all the cases described, and in all conceivable cases, the distinction between rational and irrational action comes down to whether the motives are abstract concepts or intuitive representations. My account of reason therefore agrees exactly with the usage of all ages and peoples. No one should regard such usage as accidental or arbitrary: it has arisen from the distinction among mental faculties of which everyone is aware and in accordance with which everyone speaks, though without raising that awareness to the clarity of an abstract definition. Our ancestors did not make words without attaching definite meanings to them, as if setting them aside for philosophers centuries later to decide what they should mean. They used them to designate quite definite concepts. Words are therefore no longer ownerless; to assign them meanings altogether different from those they have previously had is to misuse them and introduce a license under which everyone could use every word in any sense he pleased, producing boundless confusion. *Locke* has already shown at length that most disagreements in philosophy arise from the misuse of words. For illustration, one need only glance at the disgraceful abuse that today's thoughtless philosophical dabblers make of such words as substance, consciousness, and truth. The statements and explanations of philosophers in every age, apart from the very latest, agree with my account of reason no less than do the prevailing views of this human advantage among all peoples. See what Plato calls the λόγιμον or λογιστικὸν τῆς ψυχῆς (“the reasoning part of the soul”) in the fourth book of the *Republic* and countless other passages; what Cicero says in *De natura deorum*, III, 26–31; and what Leibniz and Locke say in the passages on this point cited in the first book. There would be no end to quotations if one wished to show how all philosophers before Kant spoke of reason broadly in my sense, even if they did not explain its nature with complete precision and clarity by reducing it to a single point. What was understood by reason shortly before Kant appeared can be seen in two essays by Sulzer in the first volume of his miscellaneous philosophical writings: “Analysis of the Concept of Reason” and “On the Reciprocal Influence of Reason and Language.” Read, by contrast, how reason has been discussed in recent times under the influence of Kant's error, which subsequently grew like an avalanche, and one has to conclude that all the sages of antiquity, and indeed

all philosophers before Kant, had no reason at all. For the immediate perceptions, intuitions, apprehensions, and premonitions of reason now discovered were as foreign to them as the sixth sense of bats is to us. For my part, I must confess that, in my limited capacity, I can conceive and imagine a reason that immediately perceives, apprehends, or intellectually intuits the supersensible, the absolute, and the long stories said to happen to it, only as I can imagine the sixth sense of bats. Still, one must credit the invention—or discovery—of a reason that immediately perceives whatever one likes with being an incomparable *expédient* (expedient) for extricating oneself and one's cherished fixed ideas in the easiest possible way, in spite of every *Kant* and his critiques of reason. The invention, and the reception it has found, do honor to the age.

Although the essential nature of *reason* (τὸ λόγιμον, ἡ φρόνησις, *ratio*, *raison*, *reason*—roughly, the rational faculty or prudence) has thus been recognized correctly in general by philosophers of all ages, though not defined sharply enough or reduced to a single point, they have been less clear about the nature of the *understanding* (νοῦς, διάνοια, *intellectus*, *esprit*, *intellect*, *understanding*—terms for intellect or understanding). They therefore often mix it with reason and consequently fail to give a perfectly clear, pure, and simple explanation of reason itself. Among Christian philosophers the concept of reason acquired an entirely foreign secondary meaning through its opposition to revelation. Starting from this, many rightly maintained that knowledge of the obligation to virtue is possible through reason alone, that is, without revelation. This consideration certainly influenced even Kant's account and choice of words. Yet that contrast has a positive, historical significance; it is therefore foreign to philosophy, which must be kept free of it.

One might have expected Kant, in his critiques of theoretical and practical reason, to begin with an account of the nature of reason in general and, having thus defined the *genus* (kind), proceed to explain its two *species* (forms). He should have shown how one and the same reason manifests itself in two such different ways while retaining its chief character and so proving itself the same faculty. Nothing of this is to be found. I have already shown how inadequate, wavering, and discordant are the explanations he gives here and there in passing, in the *Critique of Pure Reason*, of the faculty he is criticizing. *Practical* reason makes an unannounced appearance in that Critique and subsequently stands in the critique devoted to it as an established fact, without further accounting for it. Neither the usage of all ages and peoples, which is

trampled underfoot, nor the definitions of the greatest earlier philosophers are allowed a voice. Taken together, individual passages suggest that Kant's view is this: knowledge of *a priori* principles is the essential character of reason. Since knowledge of the ethical significance of action is not of empirical origin, it too is an *a priori* principle and therefore stems from reason, which in this respect is *practical*. I have already said enough about the falsity of that definition of reason. Even setting this aside, how superficial and groundless it is to use the single feature of independence from experience to unite the most heterogeneous things, overlooking the fundamental, immeasurable distance between them in every other respect. For suppose, though I do not grant it, that knowledge of the ethical significance of action arose from an imperative within us, an unconditional *ought*. How fundamentally different such an imperative would be from those universal *forms of knowledge* that Kant shows in the *Critique of Pure Reason* to be known to us *a priori*, and by awareness of which we can state in advance an unconditional *must*, valid for every experience possible to us. The difference between this *must*, the necessary form of every object already determined in the subject, and the *ought* of morality is as vast as it is obvious. The fact that both share the character of nonempirical knowledge might serve as a witty comparison, but cannot furnish a philosophical warrant for identifying their origins.

The birthplace of this child of practical reason, the *absolute ought* or categorical imperative, is, moreover, not the *Critique of Practical Reason* but already the *Critique of Pure Reason*, p. 802; V, 830. The birth is difficult and succeeds only with the obstetric forceps of a *therefore* boldly, even shamelessly, placed between two utterly unrelated propositions to connect them as ground and consequence. Kant begins with the proposition that we are determined by abstract as well as intuitive motives, putting it as follows: "Not only what stimulates, that is, immediately affects the senses, determines human choice. We have a faculty of overcoming impressions on our sensuous faculty of desire through representations of what is useful or harmful even in a more distant way. These reflections on what is desirable, that is, good and useful, with regard to our condition as a whole rest on reason." (Perfectly right: if only he always spoke so rationally about reason!) "*Therefore* reason also gives laws which are imperatives, that is, objective laws of freedom, and say what ought to happen, although perhaps it never does." And so, with no further credentials, the categorical imperative leaps into the world to rule it with its unconditional *ought*: a scepter of wooden iron. For the concept of *ought* essentially and in

every case includes reference to a threatened punishment or promised reward as a necessary condition. This cannot be separated from it without abolishing the concept itself and stripping it of all meaning. An *unconditional ought* is therefore a *contradictio in adjecto* (contradiction in terms). This error had to be criticized, closely related though it is to Kant's great achievement in ethics. That achievement is that he freed ethics from all principles of the empirical world, especially from every direct or indirect doctrine of happiness, and showed in a strict sense that the realm of virtue is not of this world. His achievement is all the greater because the ancient philosophers—except Plato alone, namely the Peripatetics, Stoics, and Epicureans—used very different devices to make virtue and happiness either depend on each other according to the principle of sufficient reason or identical according to the principle of contradiction. The same reproach applies to every modern philosopher up to Kant. His achievement here is therefore very great. Justice requires us to add, however, that his exposition and execution often fail to match the tendency and spirit of his ethics, as we shall see at once. Nor, even so, was he the first to cleanse virtue of every principle of happiness. Plato had already taught explicitly, especially in the *Republic*, whose chief purpose is precisely this, that virtue must be chosen for its own sake alone, even if misfortune and disgrace were inevitably joined to it. Christianity, still more, preaches a wholly disinterested virtue, practiced without payment out of love of God, and not even for reward in an afterlife, since works do not justify, but only faith, which virtue accompanies as its mere sign and so enters wholly without payment and of itself. Read Luther's *De libertate Christiana* (*On the Freedom of a Christian*). I shall not even count the Indians, whose sacred books everywhere portray the hope of reward for one's works as the path of darkness, which can never lead to salvation. Kant's doctrine of virtue is nevertheless not so pure; or rather, its exposition has fallen far behind its spirit and even into inconsistency. In his *highest* good, discussed later, virtue is married to happiness. The originally unconditional ought subsequently postulates a condition for itself, really to rid itself of the internal contradiction with which it cannot live. Happiness in the highest good is indeed not supposed actually to be the motive for virtue. Yet there it stands like a secret clause whose presence turns all the rest into a merely apparent agreement. It is not exactly the reward of virtue, but it is a voluntary gift toward which virtue, after finishing its work, furtively holds out its hand. One can see this in the *Critique of Practical Reason* (pp. 223–266 of the fourth edition, or pp. 264–295 of Rosenkranz's edition). His entire moral theology has the same tendency, and through it morality really destroys itself. For, I repeat,

every virtue practiced for any kind of reward rests on a shrewd, systematic, farsighted egoism.

The content of the absolute ought, the basic law of practical reason, is the celebrated maxim: "Act so that the maxim of your will could always at the same time hold as a principle of universal legislation." This principle gives someone seeking a rule for his own will the task of finding one for the wills of *everyone*. The question then is how to find it. To discover the rule for my conduct I am evidently meant to consider not myself alone but the entire aggregate of individuals. The welfare of everyone without distinction, rather than my own, then becomes my aim. But that aim remains welfare. I find that everyone can be equally well off only if each person sets the egoism of others as a limit to his own. It certainly follows that I should harm no one, because if this principle is accepted universally I too will not be harmed. But that is the only reason why I, as someone who does not yet have a moral principle but is seeking one, can wish for this to be a universal law. Plainly, then, the desire for welfare, that is, egoism, remains the source of this ethical principle. It would be excellent as a basis for political theory; it is unfit as a basis for ethics. For to establish, as this moral principle requires, a rule for the wills of everyone, the person seeking it necessarily needs a rule of his own; otherwise everything would be indifferent to him. That rule can only be his own egoism, since only this is affected by the conduct of others. Only through and with reference to it can he care about others' actions and have any will regarding them. Kant very naïvely reveals this himself at p. 123 of the *Critique of Practical Reason* (p. 192 of Rosenkranz's edition), where he describes the search for a maxim of the will: "If everyone viewed the distress of others with complete indifference, and *you too belonged* to such an order of things, would you consent to it?" *Quam temere in nosmet legem sancimus iniquam* ("How rashly we decree an unjust law against ourselves!") would be the rule governing the consent in question. Likewise in the *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals*, p. 56 of the third edition, p. 50 of Rosenkranz's: "A will that resolved to assist no one in need would contradict itself, since cases might occur in which *it needed the love and sympathy of others*," and so on. This ethical principle is therefore, seen in the light, merely an indirect and veiled expression of the old, simple rule *quod tibi fieri non vis, alteri ne feceris* ("Do not do to another what you do not wish done to yourself"). It refers first and immediately to passivity, to *suffering*, and only through this to *doing*. As I have said, it would therefore be quite usable as a guide to founding the *state*, which seeks to prevent *the suffering of wrong* and

to secure the greatest possible sum of welfare for all. But in ethics, where the subject of inquiry is *doing as doing* and its immediate significance for the *agent*, not its consequence as suffering or its relation to others, that consideration is altogether inadmissible. At bottom it leads back to a principle of happiness and thus to egoism.

We therefore cannot share Kant's delight that his ethical principle is not material—that is, it sets no object as motive—but merely formal, so that it corresponds symmetrically to the formal laws made known by the *Critique of Pure Reason*. Admittedly, instead of a law it is only a formula for finding one. But we already had this formula, more briefly and clearly, in *quod tibi fieri non vis, alteri ne feceris* (“Do not do to another what you do not wish done to yourself”). Moreover, analyzing it shows that concern for one's own happiness alone gives it content. It can therefore serve only rational egoism, to which every legal constitution also owes its origin.

Another defect, often criticized because it offends everyone's feelings and mocked by Schiller in an epigram, is Kant's pedantic stipulation that, to be truly good and meritorious, an act must be performed solely out of respect for the known law and the concept of duty, according to a maxim of which reason is conscious *in abstracto* (in the abstract). It must not be performed from inclination, felt goodwill toward others, tender sympathy, compassion, or warmth of heart. These, according to the *Critique of Practical Reason* (p. 213; Rosenkranz's edition, p. 257), are even highly troublesome to right-minded people because they confuse their carefully considered maxims. Rather, the action must be done reluctantly and with self-compulsion. Remember that the hope of reward is nevertheless supposed to play no part, and judge how absurd the demand is. More than that, it directly opposes the genuine spirit of virtue. Not the deed, but doing it gladly—the love from which it springs, without which it is a dead work—makes it meritorious. Christianity therefore rightly teaches that all outward works are worthless unless they spring from that genuine disposition consisting in a true willingness and pure love. It is not the works performed (*opera operata*), but faith, the genuine disposition granted only by the Holy Spirit and not produced by a free, deliberate will that keeps only the law in view, that brings salvation and redemption. Kant's requirement that every virtuous action occur from pure, considered respect for the law and according to its abstract maxims, coldly and without, indeed against, every inclination, is exactly like claiming that every genuine work of art must arise from the well-considered application of aesthetic rules. One claim is as perverse

as the other. The question already discussed by Plato and Seneca, whether virtue can be taught, must be answered no. We must finally resolve to understand what also gave rise to the Christian doctrine of election by grace: in its main substance and inward core, virtue is in a sense innate, like genius. Just as all professors of aesthetics working together cannot endow anyone with the capacity for works of genius, that is, genuine works of art, so all professors of ethics and preachers of virtue cannot transform an ignoble character into a virtuous and noble one. That impossibility is far more obvious than the impossibility of turning lead into gold. The search for an ethics and a supreme principle of it that would have practical influence and really transform and improve humankind is exactly like the search for the philosopher's stone. The possibility of a complete change of a person's disposition, or rebirth, through intuitive rather than abstract knowledge (ethics)—the work of grace—is discussed at length at the end of our fourth book. Indeed, the contents of that book spare me the need to dwell on this any longer.

Finally, Kant also shows that he has by no means penetrated the real meaning of the ethical content of actions through his doctrine of the highest good as the necessary union of virtue and happiness, with virtue amounting to worthiness for happiness. Here he is already subject to the logical objection that the concept of worthiness, which supplies the standard, itself presupposes an ethics as its standard and therefore should not have been the starting point. Our fourth book has shown that all genuine virtue, once it reaches its highest degree, leads at last to complete renunciation, in which all willing ends. Happiness, by contrast, is satisfied willing. The two are therefore fundamentally incompatible. Anyone convinced by my account needs no further explanation of how wholly mistaken Kant's view of the highest good is. Independently of my positive account, I have no further negative criticism to offer here.

Kant's love of architectural symmetry appears again in the *Critique of Practical Reason*: he gives it the same arrangement as the *Critique of Pure Reason*, even repeating the same titles and forms with evident arbitrariness, especially apparent in the table of the categories of freedom.

The *Doctrine of Right* is among Kant's latest works and is so weak that, although I reject it entirely, I consider a polemic against it unnecessary. As though it were the product of an ordinary mortal rather than the work of this great man, it must die a natural death from its own weakness. I therefore forgo the negative procedure with respect to the doctrine of right and refer to the positive account: the brief outlines of it set out in our fourth book. I shall make

only a few general observations here. The errors I criticized in my discussion of the *Critique of Pure Reason* as accompanying Kant everywhere are present in the doctrine of right to such an extent that one often thinks one is reading a satirical parody of Kant's manner, or at least hearing one of his followers. There are two principal errors. First, he wishes—and many have since wished—to separate the doctrine of right sharply from ethics, while also refusing to make it dependent on positive legislation, that is, arbitrary coercion. He would have the concept of right stand on its own, pure and *a priori*. But this is impossible. Apart from its ethical significance and its physical relation to others, and thus to external coercion, action admits no third point of view whatsoever. Accordingly, when he says, “A duty of right is one that *can* be enforced,” this *can* must be understood either physically or ethically. If physically, all right is positive and arbitrary, and, conversely, every arbitrary power that can impose itself is right. If ethically, we are back in the domain of ethics. Thus Kant's concept of right hangs between heaven and earth with no ground on which to stand. In my account it belongs to ethics. Second, his definition of the concept of right is entirely negative and therefore inadequate:^[10] “Right is what is compatible with the coexistence of the freedoms of individuals alongside one another according to a universal law.” Freedom here means empirical, that is, physical freedom, not moral freedom of the will. It means the absence of hindrance and is therefore a mere negation; coexistence has exactly the same character. We are left with negations throughout and obtain no positive concept, nor do we even learn what the matter is about unless we already know from elsewhere. As the exposition continues, the most perverse views emerge: that in the state of nature, outside the state, there is no right to property at all—which really means that all right is positive and makes natural right depend on positive right when the reverse should be the case; his account of rightful acquisition through taking possession; the ethical obligation to establish a civil constitution; the basis of criminal law; and so on. As I have said, none of these seems worth a separate refutation. Meanwhile these errors of Kant's have done much harm, confusing and obscuring truths long recognized and stated, and prompting strange theories and a great deal of writing and controversy. This cannot last, of course, and already we see truth and sound reason clearing a path again. An especially good example of the latter, in contrast to so many distorted theories, is I. C. F. Meister's *Natural Right*, although I do not therefore consider it a model of complete perfection.

After what has been said, I can also be very brief about the *Critique of Judgment*. It is remarkable that Kant, to whom art probably remained quite foreign, who seems to have had little receptivity to beauty, who probably never had a chance to see an important work of art, and who appears not even to have known of Goethe—his gigantic counterpart, the only figure in his century and nation who could be placed beside him—nevertheless made a great and lasting contribution to the philosophical consideration of art and beauty. His contribution lies in this: despite the many reflections on beauty and art, the matter had previously been considered almost always from an empirical standpoint. On the basis of facts, people investigated what quality distinguished an object called *beautiful* from other objects of its kind. They first arrived at quite specific propositions, then at more general ones. They sought to separate genuine artistic beauty from spurious beauty and discover marks of authenticity that could in turn serve as rules. What pleases as beautiful, what does not, what should therefore be imitated or sought and what avoided, what rules could be laid down, at least negatively—in short, what means produce aesthetic pleasure, or what conditions for it lie *in the object*: these had been almost the only themes of reflection on art. Aristotle took this path, and we still find Home, Burke, Winckelmann, Lessing, Herder, and others on it in more recent times. The generality of the aesthetic principles discovered did eventually lead back toward the subject. It became clear that, if the effect in the subject were properly known, one could then also determine *a priori* its cause in the object, and only thus could the inquiry attain the certainty of a science. This sometimes prompted psychological discussions. Alexander Baumgarten in particular sought to establish a general aesthetics of all beauty, starting with the concept of perfection in sensuous, and thus intuitive, knowledge. Yet with the introduction of this concept he immediately finished with the subjective aspect and moved to the objective and the practical aspect related to it. Kant, by contrast, was the one to investigate seriously and deeply *the very feeling* because of which we call its object *beautiful*, seeking, if possible, to find its components and conditions in our minds. His inquiry therefore took an entirely subjective direction. This was plainly the right path: to explain a phenomenon given in its effects and determine the nature of its cause thoroughly, one must first know those effects precisely. Kant's contribution here, however, scarcely extends beyond indicating the right path and offering a preliminary example of approximately how to follow it. What he actually gave cannot be regarded as objective truth and real gain. He indicated the method of the inquiry and cleared the way, but missed the goal.

In the Critique of Aesthetic Judgment, the first thing we notice is that Kant retained the method peculiar to his whole philosophy, which I discussed at length above. I mean his starting from abstract knowledge to fathom intuitive knowledge, as though the former were a *camera obscura* (dark chamber) in which to catch and survey the latter. In the *Critique of Pure Reason* the forms of judgment were supposed to teach him about our knowledge of the whole intuitive world. Likewise, in this Critique of Aesthetic Judgment he starts not from beauty itself, from immediate intuitive beauty, but from the *judgment* about beauty, the unfortunately named judgment of taste. This is his problem. What particularly catches his attention is that such a judgment plainly reports an occurrence in the subject but claims a general validity as though it concerned a property of the object. That struck him, not beauty itself. He proceeds only from what others say, from the judgment about beauty, not from beauty itself. He seems almost to know it only by hearsay, not directly. A very intelligent blind person might likewise construct a theory of colors from detailed reports heard about them. Indeed, we can regard Kant's philosophical claims about beauty almost only in this light. Then we find his theory very ingenious, and there are occasionally apt and true general observations. But his actual solution to the problem is so inadmissible, so far beneath the dignity of its subject, that it cannot occur to us to take it for objective truth. I therefore consider myself excused from refuting it and refer once more to the positive part of my work.

As for the form of his whole book, we should note that it arose from the idea of finding the key to the problem of beauty in the concept of *purposiveness*. The idea is duly deduced—which, as Kant's successors have taught us, is never hard to do. Hence the bizarre combination of knowledge of beauty with knowledge of the purposiveness of natural bodies under *one* cognitive faculty, called *judgment*, and the treatment of these two heterogeneous subjects in a single book. These three cognitive powers—reason, judgment, and understanding—then provide material for various exercises in architectural symmetry. A taste for these is visible throughout the book: in the forced adaptation of its whole arrangement to that of the *Critique of Pure Reason*, and especially in the far-fetched antinomy of aesthetic judgment. One might also charge Kant with gross inconsistency. After repeatedly saying in the *Critique of Pure Reason* that the understanding is the faculty of judgment, and making the forms of its judgments the cornerstone of all philosophy, he now introduces a wholly separate faculty of judgment, entirely distinct from the understanding. What I call judgment, by contrast—the ability to carry intuitive knowledge over

into abstract knowledge and then apply the latter correctly back to the former—is explained in the positive part of this work.

By far the finest thing in the Critique of Aesthetic Judgment is the theory of the sublime. It succeeds incomparably better than the theory of beauty. It offers not only the general method of inquiry, as that theory does, but takes a step along the right path. Though it does not provide the actual solution, it comes very close.

In the Critique of *Teleological* Judgment, the simplicity of the subject perhaps reveals more clearly than anywhere else Kant's strange talent for turning an idea this way and that, and stating it in many different ways, until it becomes a book. The whole book intends just this: although organized bodies necessarily appear to us as if composed according to a concept of their purpose that preceded them, this does not entitle us to assume that they objectively arose in this way. Our intellect receives things from outside and indirectly. It never knows their inner nature, through which they arise and continue to exist, but only their outer side. It can therefore make sense of a certain characteristic peculiar to organic products of nature only by analogy with works deliberately made by human beings, whose character is determined by a purpose and a concept of that purpose. This analogy suffices to make the agreement of their parts with the whole intelligible to us and even to guide our investigation of them. But it must on no account be made the real explanatory ground of the origin and existence of such bodies. The necessity of conceiving them in this way has a subjective origin. That, approximately, is how I would summarize Kant's teaching on this matter. He had already presented the essentials of it in the *Critique of Pure Reason*, pp. 692–702; V, 720–730. Yet in recognizing *this* truth too we find *David Hume* as Kant's distinguished predecessor. He had already sharply disputed the assumption in part two of his *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*. The main difference between Hume's critique and Kant's is that Hume criticizes the assumption as one based on experience, while Kant criticizes it as an *a priori* assumption. Both are right, and their accounts complement one another. Indeed, the essentials of Kant's teaching here are already expressed in Simplicius's commentary on Aristotle's *Physics*: ἡ δὲ πλάνη γέγονεν αὐτοῖς ἀπὸ τοῦ ἡγεῖσθαι, πάντα τὰ ἕνεκά του γινόμενα κατὰ προαίρεσιν γενέσθαι καὶ λογισμὸν, τὰ δὲ φύσει μὴ οὕτως ὁρᾶν γινόμενα. (Latin: *Error iis ortus est ex eo, quod credebant, omnia, quae propter finem aliquem fierent, ex proposito et ratiocinio fieri, dum videbant, naturae opera non ita fieri.* “Their error arose from supposing that everything done for some

end was done by choice and reasoning, while they saw that the works of nature did not come about in this way"; *Scholia in Aristotelem*, Berlin edition, p. 354.) Kant is entirely right about the matter. Once it had been shown that the concept of effect and cause cannot be applied to nature as a whole, in respect of its existence, it was also necessary to show that, in respect of its constitution, nature cannot be conceived as the effect of a cause guided by motives or concepts of purpose. Consider the great plausibility of the physico-theological proof, which even *Voltaire* took to be irrefutable. It was of the greatest importance to show that the subjective element in our apprehension—to which Kant had assigned space, time, and causality—extends also to our judgment of natural bodies. Thus the compulsion we feel to think of them as premeditated and produced according to concepts of purpose, on a path *where their representation preceded their existence*, has as subjective an origin as the intuition of space, which presents itself so objectively. It may therefore not be passed off as objective truth. Apart from its tiresome length and repetition, Kant's exposition of the matter is excellent. He rightly maintains that we shall never succeed in explaining the nature of organic bodies by merely mechanical causes, by which he means the unintended and lawful operation of all general forces of nature. Yet I find a gap here. He denies the possibility of such an explanation only with regard to the purposiveness and apparent design of *organic* bodies. But even where these are absent, we find that explanatory grounds cannot be carried from *one* domain of nature into another. As soon as we enter a new domain, the earlier grounds leave us, and new fundamental laws appear that we cannot hope to explain by those of the earlier domain. In the strictly mechanical domain, for instance, the laws of gravity, cohesion, rigidity, fluidity, and elasticity prevail. In themselves, setting aside my explanation of all natural forces as lower grades of the will's objectivation, they stand as manifestations of forces not further explicable. They themselves provide the principles of every further explanation there, which consists simply in reducing things to them. But when we leave this domain for the phenomena of chemistry, electricity, magnetism, or crystallization, those principles are wholly unusable. Those laws no longer apply, other forces overpower them, and the phenomena proceed in direct opposition to them according to new fundamental laws. Like the former, these are original and inexplicable: they cannot be reduced to more general laws. All the laws of strict mechanics, for example, will never explain even the dissolution of salt in water, let alone more complex chemical phenomena. I discussed all this at greater length in the second book of this work. An inquiry of this kind would, I think, have been very useful in the

Critique of Teleological Judgment and would have shed much light on what it says. It would especially have served Kant's excellent suggestion that a deeper knowledge of the being in itself whose appearances are the things of nature would find one and the same ultimate principle in both the mechanical, lawful operation of nature and its apparently purposeful operation, a principle that could explain them both. By presenting the will as the real thing in itself I hope to have supplied such a principle. Accordingly, in our second book and its supplements, and especially in my work *On the Will in Nature*, insight into the inner essence of the apparent purposiveness and the harmony and concord of nature as a whole has perhaps become clearer and deeper. I have therefore nothing more to say about it here.

A reader interested in this critique of Kant's philosophy should also read its supplement in the second essay of the first volume of my *Parerga and Paralipomena*, under the title "Some Further Explanations of Kantian Philosophy." My writings, few though they are, were composed not all at once but successively over a long life and at wide intervals. One should therefore not expect everything I have said about a subject to be gathered in one place.

Notes

Notes

2. Bruno and Spinoza must be wholly excepted here. Each stands alone, belonging neither to his century nor to his part of the world: one was repaid with death, the other with persecution and abuse. Their impoverished lives and deaths in the West resemble those of a tropical plant in Europe. Their true spiritual home was on the banks of the sacred Ganges, where they would have lived calmly and honorably among kindred minds. In the following verses, with which he opens *Della causa, principio et uno* (*On Cause, Principle, and Unity*), the book for which he was sent to the stake, Bruno expresses clearly and beautifully how alone he felt in his century. They also show a foreboding of his fate, which made him hesitate to put forward his thought until the drive, so strong in noble minds, to communicate what they have recognized as true overcame him:

Ad partum properare tuum, mens aegra, quid obstat;

Seclo haec indigno sint tribuenda licet?

Umbrarum fluctu terras mergente, cacumen

Adtolle in clarum, noster Olympe, Jovem.

“Troubled mind, what prevents you from hastening to bring forth your offspring, though it must be given to an unworthy age? While a flood of shadows submerges the earth, lift your summit, our Olympos, toward bright Jupiter.”

Anyone who reads this principal work of his, as well as his other Italian writings, once so rare and now available to everyone in a German edition, will agree with me that among all philosophers he alone comes close to Plato in combining a strong poetic power and inclination with philosophy and in showing it especially in dramatic form. Imagine the sensitive, spiritual, thinking being who confronts us in this work in the hands of savage, furious priests as his judges and executioners, and be grateful for the age that brought a brighter and gentler century, so that the posterity whose curse was to fall upon those devilish fanatics has already become their own contemporaries. ↩

3. Let me note here that I cite the *Critique of Pure Reason* throughout by the page numbers of the first edition, since these numbers are given throughout Rosenkranz's edition of the collected works. I also add, preceded by “V,” the page number of the fifth edition. All editions from the second onward have the same text as the fifth and presumably the same pagination. ↩

4. See Christian Wolff, *Rational Thoughts on God, the World, and the Soul*, §§ 577–579. Strangely, he calls contingent only what is necessary according to the principle of sufficient reason of becoming, that is, what happens from causes. He nevertheless recognizes as necessary what follows from the other forms of that principle: for instance, what follows from the *essentia* (essence or definition), including analytic judgments, and also mathematical truths. His reason is that only the law of causality yields endless series, while the other kinds of grounds yield finite ones. This is by no means true, however, of the forms of the principle of sufficient reason in pure space and time, but applies only to the logical ground of knowledge. Yet he took mathematical necessity to rest on such a ground. Compare my essay *On the Fourfold Root of the Principle of Sufficient Reason*, § 50. ↩

5. Anyone may compare my refutation of Kant's proof with the earlier attacks on it by *Feder, On Time, Space, and Causality*, § 28, and G. E. *Schulze, Critique of Theoretical Philosophy*, vol. 2, pp. 422–442. ↩

6. See Sextus Empiricus, *Outlines of Pyrrhonism*, book I, ch. 13: νοούμενα φαινόμενοις ἀντετίθη Ἀναξαγόρας (*intelligibilia apparentibus opposuit Anaxagoras*; “Anaxagoras opposed intelligible things to appearances”). ↩

7. That the assumption of a temporal limit to the world is by no means a necessary thought of reason can even be demonstrated historically. Hindus do not teach such a limit even in popular religion, still less in the Vedas. Instead, they try to express mythically the infinity of this appearing world, this insubstantial and essenceless web of Maya, through a monstrous chronology. At the same time they ingeniously emphasize the relativity of all lengths of time in the following myth (*Polier, Mythologie des Indous*, vol. 2, p. 585). The four ages, in the last of which we live, together comprise 4,820,000 years. Each day of Brahma the creator contains 1,000 such periods of four ages, and each of his nights another 1,000. His year has 365 days and the same number of nights. He lives, constantly creating, for 100 of his years; and when he dies, a new Brahma is born at once, and so on from eternity to eternity. The same relativity of time is expressed in the particular myth retold from the Puranas in Polier's work, vol. 2, p. 594: a raja spends only a few moments visiting Vishnu in his heaven, but on returning to earth finds that several million years have passed and a new age has begun, for every day of Vishnu equals 100 repetitions of the four ages. ↩

8. Kant said: “It is a very absurd thing to expect enlightenment from reason while prescribing to it beforehand which side it must necessarily take” (*Critique of Pure Reason*, p. 747; V, 775). By contrast, here is the naïve pronouncement of a philosophy professor in our own time: “If a philosophy denies the reality of the fundamental ideas of Christianity, then it is either false or, *even if true, still useless*”—*scilicet* (“that is”), useless to professors of philosophy. The late Professor Bachmann was the man who, in the *Jena Literary Gazette* of July 1840, no. 126, indiscreetly let slip the maxim of all his colleagues. It is characteristic of university philosophy that here truth, if it will not behave and conform, is unceremoniously shown the door: “March, Truth! We have no *use* for you. Do we owe you anything? Do you pay us? Then march!” ↩

9. Incidentally, Machiavelli's problem was how a prince could maintain himself *unconditionally* on the throne despite enemies at home and abroad. His problem was therefore in no way the ethical question whether a prince, as a human being, ought to want this; it was purely the political question of how, *if* he wants it, he can carry it out. He gives the solution as one writes a manual for chess, where it would be foolish to miss an answer to the question whether it is morally advisable to play chess at all. Accusing Machiavelli of immorality in his book is as fitting as accusing a fencing master of failing to begin his instruction with a moral lecture against murder and manslaughter. ↩

10. Although the concept of right is really negative, as the opposite of wrong, which is the positive starting point, the explanation of these concepts still must not be wholly negative. ↩

† Editorial note: this quotation retains Schopenhauer's historical wording. The published witness has grammatical variants, including “τὰς ὁμοίους”; these have not been silently

replaced by a conjectured critical text. Broken letters, missing “θεωρίαν,” and the dropped final “ἄρετάς” in the extraction have been restored. ↩

‡ Editorial note: the extraction omits δυνατῶν (“possibilities”) after περί and reads “becomes possible” at the end of Chrysippus’s statement. This edition restores the Greek phrase and reads “becomes actual” following the published Haldane–Kemp witness, consistent with the argument that follows. ↩